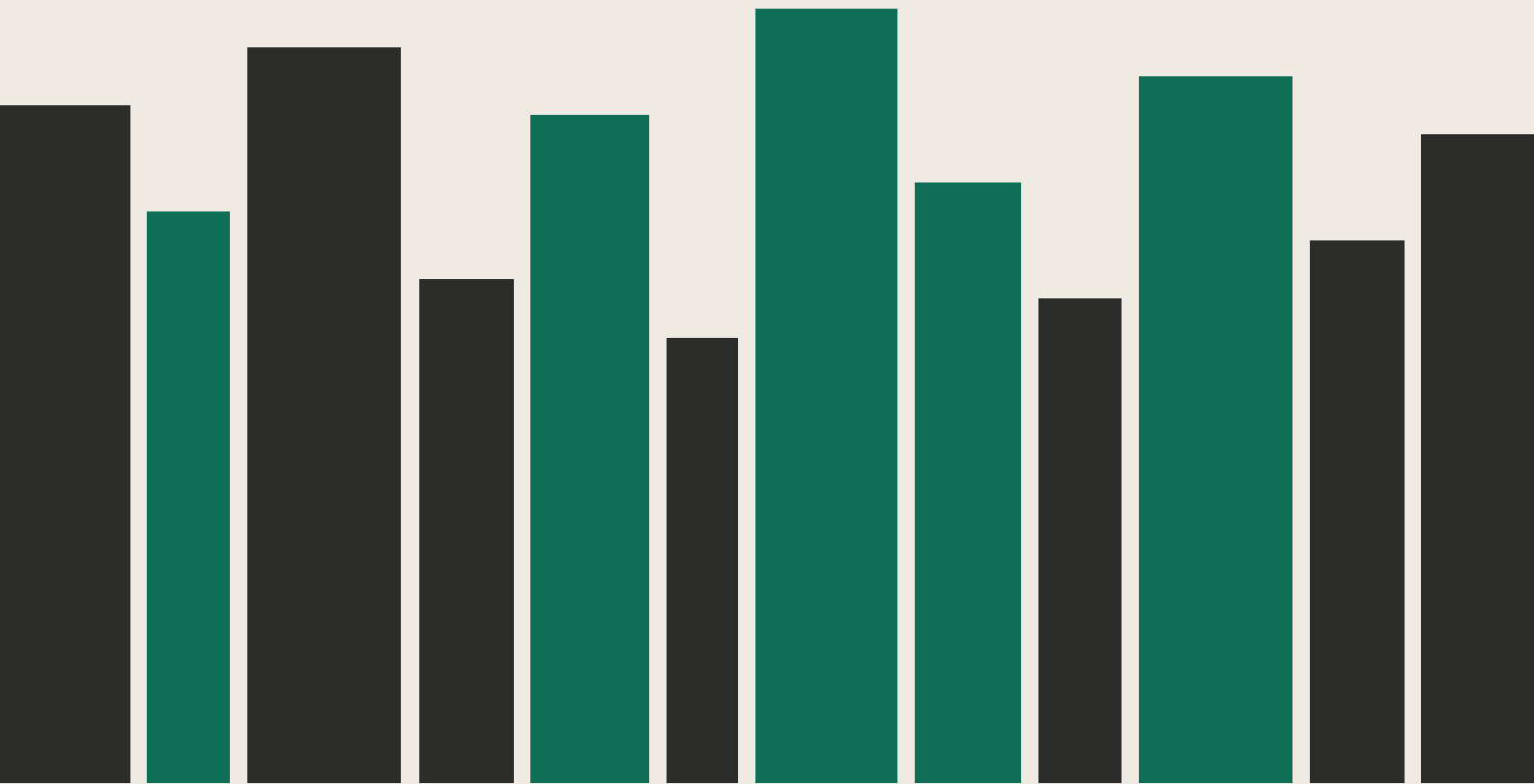




PRELIMINARY EDITION

Church Planting Bibliography

Annotated Reading Lists
for Students

Christian Selvaratnam

This version was produced on **25 September 2026**.
See inside for how to obtain the latest edition.

Church Planting Bibliography: Annotated Reading Lists for Students

Compiled by Christian Selvaratnam.

This reference book brings together curated reading lists, introductory material and annotations to help students and those preparing for ministry find their way into the growing literature on church planting. It has been developed primarily for students studying church planting at theological colleges, seminaries and ministry training programmes, but is also intended to be useful to anyone seeking to explore the subject.

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This is the preliminary edition. Further titles, reading lists and annotations will be added and revised in future editions.

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The book is available for purchase in print and electronic editions. A free electronic edition is available to theological colleges, seminaries and ministry training programmes for use by their students and staff. Institutions wishing to receive a copy should email christian.selvaratnam@sthild.org. The electronic edition is provided for educational use within the institution and may not be redistributed, sold or made publicly available without permission.

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About this Book

The Church is planted like Paradise in this world.

Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* (c. AD 180)

Church Planting Bibliography

This is a reference book: a collection of annotated reading lists, and a guide to the literature on church planting. It began as a supplementary reading list for my own students to use alongside assigned and recommended reading for a module, so that they could see quickly which books were worth consulting on a particular topic. It has since grown into something more comprehensive, and I now offer it also to those who teach the subject, to recommend to their students and to list among the readings for a module or programme.

The reading lists come in two main sections. The first covers the core subjects of the discipline — the topics any student or teacher of church planting will need, and the lists you would expect to find. The second is more eclectic: reading lists on subjects adjacent to church planting, which have either caught my interest in teaching it or been taken up by my research students. After these come a guide to other places to look, a glossary of key church planting terms, biographical notes on some of the key figures in the field, and a complete index of authors. Most of the entries are books, but there are also chapters, papers, articles and other recommended resources.

Some readers will come to church planting out of interest alone, and they will find plenty here. My own greatest reward, though, is in working with emerging practitioner-theologians: people who combine first-hand experience of planting with serious theological learning and reflection. I want to learn church planting from theologians who have planted, and from planters who have done their theology. That combination is what I most enjoy teaching, and these reading lists exist mainly with such readers in mind.

Church planting as a field of study

Church planting as an area of study is growing in significance in the West, not only because it shows how new churches reach new people in new ways, but also because it illuminates the nature of ministry itself in a season when the Western church is post-Christendom and increasingly ministering to a pre-Christian society.

The study of church planting has no hard boundary, and it can be taught from rather different starting points. Some treat it as an applied subdiscipline of missiology; others approach it primarily through ecclesiology. In my view it sits best at the intersection of missiology and ecclesiology, though the field also draws on church growth and church renewal, pioneering ministry, leadership and movements, among other things. I also find that students make fruitful connections further afield — with liturgy, anthropology or education, for instance — drawing on these as resources, or turning back on them the questions that church planting raises. An area this diffuse needs mapping. There is no single shelf in the library to go to, and some of the most useful writing is found where you would not think to look; hence a guide like this.

'Church planting' is the term in general use today, but it is not the only one, and readers will meet others in the literature. *Plantatio ecclesiae* is the oldest: a technical term since Gisbertus Voetius in the 1650s, though its currency today owes more to twentieth-century Catholic missiology and *Ad Gentes* (1965). 'Church extension' belongs to the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries and to the denominational societies that built new churches for growing populations; 'new church development' and 'church starting' are its North American successors. 'Church multiplication' describes not the founding of one church but the reproduction of many, and leads into the language of movements ('church planting movements', 'disciple-making movements'), which the literature of the past twenty years has taken up with enthusiasm. Within the Church of England, 'fresh expressions of church', 'pioneer ministry' and 'new worshipping communities' or 'new Christian communities' each describe part of the same thing. Most recent of all is 'the mixed ecology of church', a term I explore in *Exploring the Mixed Ecology: How Different Churches Belong Together* (Grove Books, 2026).

The study of church planting draws on four main kinds of material. The first is Scripture itself, together with the biblical scholarship that supports its reading; here the Acts of the Apostles holds pride of place. The second is the wider theological disciplines — missiology and ecclesiology above all, but also church history and systematic and doctrinal theology. The third is practical theology, the discipline that reflects on the practices of the church in order to understand the theology those practices carry, and to bring theory and practice closer together. It works characteristically with empirical research — often ethnographic — usually borrowing its methods from the social sciences. This feeds the other dimension of practical theology, namely applied theology: how theological thinking shapes the practice of ministry. The fourth is theological reflection on practice: the planter's own account of what is happening, thought through theologically. At its best this work is quasi-ethnographic: it attends closely to what is actually happening in a particular place before drawing any conclusions from it. That is itself a practice, with a literature and a method of its own.

My involvement in church planting

I have been involved in church planting as a practitioner for more than thirty years. I came to faith forty years ago alongside friends who were themselves part of recent church plants. So I learned from the start to see planting not as unusual but as normal — indeed as central to what the church is: ever renewing, ever revitalising, always attentive to its mission in society.

Church planting is a specialism, but it ought to be a more ordinary part of the church's life than it currently is. It is easily treated as a task for the few, set to one side of the church's main work. I have come to see it as something close to the church's normal condition — all the more so now, as the church rediscovers its mission to a changing society and its need to reach the whole range of people who live in our communities. The church exists because it was sent, and a sent church multiplies; the New Testament knows no other pattern. Every Christian congregation was once a plant. To plant, then, is not to add something to the church's life but to express what the church is: a gift received and passed on, an overflow of the life of God into new places and among new people. I have made that case at greater length in *Why Plant Churches? Theological and Practical Reasons* (Grove Books, 2023).

Church planting was the focus of my doctoral studies at Asbury Theological Seminary, where I studied the pedagogical methods of the medieval English craft guilds as an apprenticeship model for training church planters; that research became *The Craft of Church Planting: Exploring the Lost Wisdom of Apprenticeship* (SCM Press, 2022). Since 2019 I have led the teaching of the Church Planting Track and other church planting programmes at St Hild Theological College in Yorkshire, where I am Dean of

Church Planting and founder of the St Hild Centre for Church Planting. At Asbury I am an Adjunct Professor and Director of Studies for a Doctor of Ministry programme in the UK and Europe.

Over the past twenty-five years I have led two church plants myself, and have sent, supported or supervised several others. In addition to my teaching work, I serve on a number of boards related to mission, church renewal, planting and education in the UK, Europe and North America.

An emerging area of interest for me is intercultural church planting. Churches draw on the communities around them, and as those communities become more diverse, so do the congregations that serve them. For church planting the question is unavoidable: a new church must reach the people who actually live in its neighbourhood, and established churches are finding their own life reshaped in the same way. Remarkably little theological or practical thinking has been done on this, and it is a current focus of my research.

How to use this document

The reading lists come in two main sections. The first covers the core subjects of church planting, each as a short reading list in its own right. How the book works should be obvious. The lists are named after the topics students actually write on, and a glance at the contents page should be enough to find the right one. Each list opens with a short introduction and is divided into sections, whose headings indicate the focus of the resources beneath them and the use to which they are best put. Every resource carries an annotation on what it is and where it is useful, together with a note of the other lists in which it also appears, for those following a theme across the book. Where a resource belongs to more than one subject, its entry is reproduced in full under each, so there is no need to turn back and forth. The second, Wider Reading, gathers books on subjects adjacent to church planting which past students have explored. The reading lists are followed by a guide to other places to look: centres and programmes resourcing church planting, and other church planting libraries and collections. Then come a glossary of key church planting terms, cross-referenced back to the reading lists and to particular books, and short biographies of some of the key church planting authors, to introduce the voices behind the literature. Finally, a complete index of lead authors and co-authors, so that students can see what else a given author has contributed.

The reading lists bring together literature of several kinds, and each is useful in a different way. Some works offer substantial theological treatments of a subject; these are the ones to read for depth, clarity and critical understanding. Others are primers and overviews: they map the subject, introduce the key ideas and authors, and are often the place to begin. Some present empirical or historical research, with evidence and analysis that show what is happening in practice or how particular ideas and movements have developed. Others are practical — 'how-to' guides, ministry manuals, case studies and personal accounts — and offer real wisdom and insight into experience, though they are less often critically assessed, may present only one perspective, and should be used with corresponding care. Personal testimony is evidence of what someone experienced; it does not by itself establish that an approach is theologically sound or that it will produce the same results elsewhere. 'It worked for me, so it must be true' is not a theological argument.

A reading list is a starting point, not a substitute for research. Finding your own reading is part of learning the subject. One of my aims in providing these lists is to help you begin well: to take you quickly to the books that will serve your study or assignment, and to spare you the time you would otherwise spend on those that will not. Use them to get your bearings, and then go looking. Search the

shelves of a library in the appropriate section, or search its catalogue online. Above all, read bibliographies. Start with the best books you have on your topic: the bibliography at the back of each shows what its author read and relied on. Then turn to the journals. Books tend to be general and articles focused, so the bibliography of a key article on your topic will show you who is writing on exactly that question, including emerging voices. Do this with three or four good sources and a pattern emerges: the authors and publications that appear again and again are the ones the field takes seriously, and they are where your own reading should go next. On every topic here there are far more good books than I have been able to name, and I will inevitably have missed some that matter. Everyone who uses this book will need to go beyond it. That is part of becoming a good student: starting from what your tutor gives you, and then learning to guide your own reading and thinking.

How it was produced

For as long as I have taught church planting I have kept lists of recommended resources, put together for whoever happened to need them; more recently I have compiled them formally for the modules and programmes I teach, and this document gathers them into one place. The material comes from the bibliographies I have used in my teaching, from what students have cited in their assignments and research, and from my own reading and the recommendations of others.

Some of the annotations are mine, as are some of the header notes that introduce each reading list; these were carried over from an earlier edition, and a few were supplied by colleagues for that original document. For this new publication, others have been created using AI tools that I designed. Some of those tools work from my own teaching notes, built up over more than twenty-five years, checking what they draft against published sources. Others gather several published reviews of a resource and draft an annotation from them according to a framework I have set. Each of these I have checked before inclusion. Any errors remain mine.

The production of this document is managed with Claude Code, using a set of custom Python scripts and a file-based database that holds a record for each entry. That makes it straightforward to add resources, to have citation details checked for accuracy and duplication, and to generate the cross-references. Claude Code then assembles the whole from those same records, and typesets and publishes it using WeasyPrint. Compiling a revision is therefore a matter of minutes rather than an afternoon's work. Without AI tools, creating and maintaining a document of this length would not be a realistic undertaking. The cover image was generated with Claude Design.

Its limitations

Inevitably, a collection like this reflects the bias of its editor. I have not included books I do not recommend, but not every recommendation carries the same weight. Some resources I know well and commend personally; others I have not read myself, and pass on more provisionally on the judgement of colleagues or of published reviews. The annotations should be read with that variation in mind. The selection is also weighted towards England, where I mostly teach. There is a substantial body of writing from North America; the titles I judge to be the best are included, but a great many are not — some by deliberate selection, others simply because I am not aware of them — and North American readers will know of resources I have not listed.

The literature has weaknesses of its own, which these lists cannot help but inherit. Three stand out. The first is confessional: most of the writing on church planting comes from Protestant and evangelical

perspectives, and there is a good deal less from the other traditions. Church planting is practised across the major traditions of the church — Catholic and Orthodox, Protestant and Pentecostal — and each has a distinctive contribution to make to our understanding of it. Many of the historic examples of church planting belong to Catholic contexts and are best read through Catholic eyes, and much of the most rapid planting in the world today takes place within Pentecostal and charismatic movements, for whom planting is a principal means of growth. Comparatively little of the Catholic, Orthodox or Pentecostal experience finds its way into print, so most of what a student can read is Protestant. That is worth bearing in mind.

The second is geographical: beyond England, North America and, to a lesser degree, Europe, there is simply less literature to be had. My friends in the Global South are often working in the situations that see the most rapid growth, or in the hardest and most costly ones, and they tell me plainly that they have no time to write books for Westerners. The practitioner in me understands that entirely. I remain on the lookout, all the same, for writing by authors from contexts outside the Western bubble.

The third is that most authors on church planting are men. Some of my students have explored the reasons for this and what might redress the balance. Men are significantly more likely to hold paid roles associated with church planting, teaching roles among them, while women are more likely to serve as volunteers, including as self-supporting church leaders. Almost all of those currently teaching church planting are men, and since teaching and writing feed one another, the imbalance is reproduced in what gets published.

Corrections and additions

A publication of this kind is never finished. This edition, last updated on 25 September 2026, brings together 811 resources in 80 reading lists. It also has a glossary of 113 church planting terms and profiles of 42 key authors. I revise them at the end of any term in which I teach the subject, partly because students reliably introduce me to new resources.

Please help me to keep these reading lists up to date, and to make them the best they can be. If you know of a resource I have not listed, or spot a mistake or an omission, I would be very glad to hear from you at christian.selvaratnam@sthild.org.

Revd Canon Dr **Christian Selvaratnam**
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Church Planting Resources by Subject

Getting Started

Key Theological and Scholarly Works

This list is defined by a kind of reading rather than a subject: the more scholarly books on church planting, which argue from Scripture, doctrine, history or research and engage the scholarship around them, and which support theological thinking and critical engagement in an essay or a dissertation, alongside the topical books in the subject lists. Those under Related Fields are recommended although they are not directly about church planting. Manuals are gathered in Practical Guides, and first surveys in Introductions and Overviews, which shares some comprehensive texts with this list.

Much of the writing on church planting is North American, Protestant and evangelical, and more often pragmatic than critical, and several recent books here are presented by their publishers as supplying the theological reflection it has lacked. The principal disagreement is over how church and mission relate in planting. Valentine grounds the practice in a biblical theology of the mission of God; Hull argues against *Mission-Shaped Church* that it makes the church the goal of mission rather than its agent. Paas presses a further question for a secular Europe: whether planting can be justified by the growth it promises, or only on other grounds.

The books are grouped as Standard Texts, Theology of Church Planting, Critical Studies and Related Fields.

STANDARD TEXTS

Keller, Timothy. *Center Church: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas; Presbyterian and Reformed; Introductions and Overviews

A comprehensive overview of church planting theology and theory, set out as what Keller calls a theological vision for ministry in the city, by the founding pastor of Redeemer Presbyterian Church in New York and founding president of City to City. Its first part shows how the gospel drives planting and renews church and planter; the second, on the city, has a careful section on contextualisation and substantial sections on the place of the city in any planting strategy. It is long and demanding, but deeply thoughtful, and an excellent framework for urban planting.

Murray, Stuart. *Church Planting: Laying Foundations*. Carlisle: Paternoster Press, 1998.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

Murray's most comprehensive book on planting, written from an Anabaptist perspective by a theologian and practitioner of planting. It looks at the common objections to planting, then at planting in theology, in the New Testament and in history, before asking what planting does to the church. He is sensitive to the post-Christendom context of Britain and the West and argues for an approach to planting that reflects it; sometimes critical of contemporary planting, he is never less than stimulating. The opening chapter, on the critics, and the chapter setting out a theological framework bear most directly on the case for planting.

Ott, Craig, and Gene Wilson. *Global Church Planting: Biblical Principles and Best Practices for Multiplication*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2011.

An excellent overview of church planting from a missionary perspective, readable but intelligent, written for missionaries and needing some translation for a Western setting. James Park's review finds that its theology could go deeper, though it goes further than most; Clay Harris's, that it leaves the form a church takes to anthropology more than to Scripture. It is particularly good on leadership development, with real emphasis on indigenous leaders, the subject of chapter 17; Part I, with its good chapters on church planting in the Bible, bears most directly on the theology of planting.

THEOLOGY OF CHURCH PLANTING

Cockayne, Joshua, ed. *Participation and Church Planting: Perspectives from Scripture, Doctrine and Practice*. Durham Studies in Church Planting and Theology. London: SCM Press, 2026.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

An edited collection from a conference, in the Durham Studies in Church Planting and Theology, reading church planting through participation in the life of Christ by the Spirit, which its description sets against the pragmatism with which planting is sometimes associated. Its distinct contributions come from Scripture, doctrine and practice, among them Alan Torrance on the Trinity and Pete Ward against ecclesiocentrism. It shows scholars engaging critically with church planting, and would suit a student working at an advanced level.

Foulger, Will, and Joshua Cockayne, eds. *New Churches: A Theology*. London: SCM Press, 2024.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Anglican; Ecclesial Minimum

An edited collection of theological essays on starting new churches, written from the British scene by contributors from evangelical and Anglo-Catholic traditions alike. In its first part, on new churches and the *missio Dei*, Mark Collinson asks whether church planters believe in the *missio Dei* at all, Joshua Cockayne writes on community and the Triune God, and Beth Honey sets out an ethics of planting in conversation with Aquinas. Christian Selvaratnam's chapter, on planting as a craft learned by apprenticeship, is listed under Formation and Training.

Valentine, John. *Is Church Planting Legitimate? Some Theological Reflections*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2022.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Anglican

A paper of 43 pages written for CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, in February 2022 and posted on its site that August. Valentine sets out the scale of planting in Britain and the objections it has drawn, that it is schismatic, exclusively evangelical, un-Anglican or without an ecclesiology, and answers them from the biblical linking of church and mission, Bosch's 'church-in-mission' and a plea for provisionality on both sides. He argues for an ecclesiology that is fully missiological and a missiology that is fully ecclesial, open to essentialist and functionalist accounts of the church alike. His *Jesus, the Church and the Mission of God* develops the argument at book length.

Valentine, John. *Jesus, the Church and the Mission of God: A Biblical Theology of Church Planting*. London: Apollos, 2023.

A 500-page study in the biblical theology of church planting: the why and the how of starting new churches and renewing old ones, drawn first from the biblical material and then worked out theologically. Its publisher presents it as the sustained biblical reflection that a literature led by practitioners has lacked, and it is the only biblical theology of planting here. Valentine writes from within Anglican planting, as a planter and a trainer of planters. The later, theological part would be a useful place to look for the argument in doctrinal terms.

CRITICAL STUDIES

Crider, Erin. *Planting the Word: Missional Ecclesiology in Twenty-First-Century America*. Waco, TX: Baylor University Press, 2025.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A monograph in practical theology asking what American church planting movements since the mid-20th century reveal about the ecclesiology beneath them. Crider traces their shared conviction that every church is called to participate in the *missio Dei* through contextualised proclamation, and argues that planters, while spreading missional ministry, unintentionally weakened the functional ecclesiology of many congregations through their practice of pastoral roles, worship and demographic targeting. She writes as a director of church planting at an evangelical seminary. The chapter on the theology at work in the practice of American planting movements, and the chapter on the theological interpretation of the church, bear most directly on her case about functional ecclesiology.

Hull, John M. *Mission-Shaped Church: A Theological Response*. London: SCM Press, 2006.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesiology; Ecclesial Minimum; Church of England Papers and Reports

A book-length theological critique of *Mission-Shaped Church*, arguing that the report never consistently distinguishes the Kingdom of God from the church, and so turns a mission directed towards the world into a strategy for the church's own growth. Drawing on Barth, Hull treats the church as the fruit and agent of mission rather than its goal, and presses the report on its treatment of poverty, its neglect of consumerism and religious plurality, and its Anglican horizon. He writes as a supporter of fresh expressions, if a cautious one.

James, Christopher B. *Church Planting in Post-Christian Soil: Theology and Practice*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2018.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A mixed-method study of the churches founded in Seattle between 2001 and 2014, joining survey and interview data to theological assessment. James sorts most of them into four models — the Great Commission Team, the Household of the Spirit, the New Community and the Neighborhood Incarnation — and assesses each theologically with help from Avery Dulles, the move from sociology into theology that Justin Cober-Lake's review singles out. James Butler's review in *Anvil* doubts how far the findings travel to Britain, where the scale and the funding differ.

Paas, Stefan, and Alrik Vos. 'Church Planting and Church Growth in Western Europe: An Analysis'. *International Bulletin of Mission Research* 40, no. 3 (2016): 243–52.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Europe; Church Growth

An article testing, with data, whether planting churches grows the church numerically or only moves Christians between congregations. Paas and Vos compare older and younger churches in three small Reformed denominations in the Netherlands and find the younger ones gained about four times as many converts and five times as many returnees, which they credit to location, outreach and entrepreneurial leadership rather than to planting as such. Among the studies of biological, transfer and conversion growth it is one of the few to test the connection to planting empirically.

Paas, Stefan. *Church Planting in the Secular West: Learning from the European Experience*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2016.

ALSO IN Europe; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

This is an important but uncomfortable book. Paas is a church planter and also a scholar critical of much contemporary planting, and he sorts the motives for planting in Europe into three — confessional, growth and innovation — testing each theologically and against the European evidence, with little confidence that planting produces growth in a secular setting. It is also a history of planting in Europe, particularly useful for understanding the origins of the church there and why its more Catholic wings have theological objections to evangelical planting. The last chapter, 'In Defense of Church Planting in Europe', is particularly good.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Charts'. In *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism: Currents, Contours, Charts*, 25–38. Abingdon: Routledge, 2017.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Anglican; Ecclesiology

The opening chapter of Martyn Percy's book *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism* (2017), which sets the question of growth and management first in an account of where Anglicanism is heading. The chapter takes its title and subject from his 2014 article in *Modern Believing*, 'Some Comments' becoming 'Some Charts', and stands beside it as the later setting of the same question, within a book-length argument rather than a journal's comment.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Comments'. *Modern Believing* 55, no. 3 (2014): 257–70.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Anglican; Ecclesiology

A short article in *Modern Believing* commenting on growth and management in the Church of England, by an Anglican theologian. Percy's writing before and after it, in 2013 against treating the church as an organisation that must grow to survive and in 2021 against a proposal for 10,000 new lay-led churches, places him among the critics of the church growth school.

RELATED FIELDS

Bosch, David J. *Transforming Mission: Paradigm Shifts in Theology of Mission*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1991.

ALSO IN Missiology; Theory of Change

The classic textbook on mission: how mission has been understood from the New Testament through the historical paradigms of the church to the present, followed by the elements of an emerging ecumenical paradigm. It does not address church planting directly, but its analysis of church, mission and kingdom helps planters to think through their practice theologically. The sections on the developments in missionary thinking in the mid-20th century are particularly helpful: chapter 11 and the first two sections of chapter 12, whose 13 elements include mission as the church-with-others and as *missio Dei*. The twentieth-anniversary edition of 2011 adds a concluding chapter by Darrell Guder and Martin Reppenhausen.

Goodhew, David, ed. *Towards a Theology of Church Growth*. Farnham: Ashgate, 2015.

ALSO IN Church Growth

An edited collection, from a Durham conference of 2013, arguing that numerical growth is a proper theological concern for the church and not merely a sociological one. It moves from introductory questions through the Bible, doctrine and history, with C. Kevin Rowe on the ecclesiology of Acts and Graham Tomlin on a pneumatological doctrine of mission; no chapter treats church planting itself. Rod Green's review in *Fulcrum* judges the collection uneven and singles out the chapters by Alister McGrath and Martin Warner as the weaker.

Jongeneel, J. A. B. 'The Missiology of Gisbertus Voetius: The First Comprehensive Protestant Theology of Missions'. *Calvin Theological Journal* 26, no. 1 (1991): 47-79.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article arguing, as its subtitle states, that Gisbertus Voetius (1589-1676), the Dutch Reformed theologian, produced the first comprehensive Protestant theology of missions, within Reformed scholasticism and well before the missionary-society movement. It gives this bibliography an early systematic account of mission theology, distinct from the practical and biblical treatments most other entries offer.

Ott, Craig, ed. *The Mission of the Church: Five Views in Conversation*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology; Ecclesiology

An edited volume that puts one question — what is the mission of the church? — to five scholars from different Christian traditions, each stating a position and then responding to the other four. Stephen Bevans argues a Roman Catholic 'prophetic dialogue' approach and Darrell Guder a 'multicultural and translational approach', the latter filed separately in this bibliography as a chapter in its own right. Written for seminarians and church leaders, and designed for classroom use.

Practical Guides

This list is defined by a kind of book rather than a subject: books written to help with the work of starting a church. Most are guides for the planter, the team or the sending church; alongside them are books on the planter as pastor, on the team and on the planter's marriage and family, and first-hand accounts of plants and replants. The case for planting is argued in Introductions and Overviews, and the scholarship is gathered in Key Theological and Scholarly Works.

Most of the guides are North American. This list also takes in guides to renewing a congregation that already exists, which bring the same practice to an established church.

The guides divide over what kind of work planting is. Stetzer and Im treat it as a process to be learned and managed, with models to choose between and systems to put in place. Knight answers that planting is pastoral work, and sets his book against the entrepreneurial mindset that his publisher says planters often adopt; reviewing Stetzer and Im, he found a church-growth undercurrent in their book. The books written from failure come at the question from the other end, from what happens when a plant struggles.

The books follow a planter's path. After Start Here come Manuals and Handbooks; Planters, Teams and Families; Planting in a Particular Setting; Simple and Multiplying Churches; What Goes Wrong; and Revitalising an Existing Church.

Stetzer, Ed. 'Why Lay People Can (and Should) Plant Churches'. *The Exchange*, Christianity Today, April 2018.

ALSO IN Bivocational and Covocational Ministry

A short online article arguing that planting need not wait for ordained and salaried leaders: in Stetzer's words, 'Building and growing a church depends on competency, not certification.' It puts to North American churches the case Roland Allen made a century earlier for a voluntary ministry, and would be a quick way in for a lay team wondering whether it may start a church at all.

START HERE

Murray, Stuart. *Planting Churches: A Framework for Practitioners*. Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2008.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A practical guide by a British Anabaptist, organised round six questions, from why to what, and written, in Murray's words, for practitioners 'and for those who deploy and support them'. Phil Whittall, reviewing it for *Christianity*, finds the treatment theoretical and wishes for more worked examples.

Payne, J. D. *Discovering Church Planting: An Introduction to the Whats, Whys, and Hows of Global Church Planting*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009.

ALSO IN Baptist; Introductions and Overviews; Global and Cross-Cultural

An introductory overview, written from the perspective of a North American Baptist. Its four sections run from the theology of planting to contemporary issues, and draw on history, with the Moravians, the Methodists and the Baptists among its examples. It is set out as a first textbook: each chapter carries summaries, review questions and short articles on practical issues in planting.

Stetzer, Ed, and Daniel Im. *Planting Missional Churches: Your Guide to Starting Churches That Multiply*. 2nd ed. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A textbook for planting in North America, rewritten for this second edition with Daniel Im and, by the authors' account, more than half new. Of its five sections, Section 2 sets several models side by side, from simple churches to multisite, and Section 3 works through a launch, from focus group to finances and a meeting place. Nathan Knight, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds little on membership, discipline and shepherding.

Thorpe, Ric. *How to Plant a Church: A Guide to Planting and Leading Healthy New Worshipping Communities*. London: CCX, 2024.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Anglican

A guide for anyone starting a new worshipping community, adapted from the Plant course and written while Thorpe was Bishop of Islington, with a Church of England-wide brief for planting. It runs from vision and resources to leading a team and launching and multiplying a plant. Stephen Skuce, reviewing it for the Methodist Church in Ireland, reads it as one Anglican model, in which a resource church sends members, staff and a budget to a plant, but finds its principles broadly transferable.

MANUALS AND HANDBOOKS

General guides to starting a church; manuals for a particular setting, and for simple and multiplying churches, have subheadings of their own.

Becker, Paul, Jim Carpenter and Mark Williams. *The New Dynamic Church Planting Handbook*. Dynamic Church Planting International, 2013. <https://dcpi-website.s3.us-west-2.amazonaws.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/07/04165741/The-New-Dynamic-Church-Planting-Handbook.pdf>.

A handbook from Dynamic Church Planting International, built on the 12 biblical principles on which DCPI bases all its training, and covering how to organise a team, plan a launch and take the decisions along the way. It is written in part for leaders in restricted-access regions who cannot attend DCPI's training in person.

Bevins, Winfield. *Church-Planting Revolution: A Guidebook for Explorers, Planters, and Their Teams*. Franklin, TN: Seedbed Publishing, 2017.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

An introduction to church planting in which practical chapters alternate with case studies from both the UK and North America. It is addressed to those still exploring whether to plant as well as to planters and their teams.

Bevins, Winfield. *Plant: A Sower's Guide to Church Planting*. Franklin, TN: Seedbed Publishing, 2016.

A short book on planting by the founding pastor of the Church of the Outer Banks in North Carolina, then canon for church planting in the Anglican Diocese of the Carolinas. His *Church-Planting Revolution* followed from the same publisher in 2017.

Beynon, Graham. *Planting for the Gospel: A Hands-On Guide to Church Planting*. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2011.

A guide in two halves by a British pastor who had led plants in Cambridge and Leicester. The first sets out the models a plant can follow and the principles and practicalities of starting one; the second gives 31 case studies from the UK and the US, grouped by model. That grouping makes it a useful place to look for examples of a particular kind of plant.

Christopherson, Jeff, and Mac Lake. *Kingdom First: Starting Churches That Shape Movements*. Nashville, TN: B&H Books, 2015.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A planting manual that puts one question, drawn from Matthew 6:33, to each stage of the work: whether a plant's aim is the kingdom of God or the church itself. Of its eight parts, the first takes the planter's character and context, and the last, on multiplying churches, bears most directly on a church that means to plant others.

Clifton, Clint. *Church Planting Thresholds: A Gospel-Centered Guide*. Lulu Publishing Services, 2016.

ALSO IN Baptist

A guide by a planter who worked for the Southern Baptist North American Mission Board, organised as a series of thresholds: milestones a plant is to cross in order. It covers ground from team leadership and personal integrity to doctrine, eldership and spiritual warfare, and adds 20 appendices to the main text.

Jones, Peyton. *Church Plantology: The Art and Science of Planting Churches*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2021.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A textbook that assesses current planting methods and proposes a model drawn from Paul's apostolic practice, in 20 chapters paired into 10 sections. Jones writes as a practitioner and trainer, the founder of NewBreed Training, and his topics run from the planter's character to multiplication networks. Bernard Mukwavi, reviewing it for the Northwest Institute for Ministry Education Research, notes its emphasis on rapid multiplication.

Jones, Peyton. *Rediscovering Church Planting: 10 Principles That Work Anytime, Anywhere, with Anyone*. NewBreed Training, [2023]. <https://newbreedtraining.com/resources/books/>.

A guide of 22 pages, issued by NewBreed Training as an ebook, in which Jones sets out 10 'church plantology principles', each a practice he finds at once in scripture, church history and global missionary practice, the test that also governs his *Church Plantology*. It opens by contrasting 'church starting', which begins with money, a venue and marketing, with planting that begins in prayer, sowing and discipleship and reaps a church as its harvest, and closes with an invitation to NewBreed's training cohort. It gives the framework of the longer book without its argument and detail, and would suit a planter deciding whether to read it.

Keller, Timothy, and J. Allen Thompson. *Redeemer Church Planting Manual*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2002.

ALSO IN Presbyterian and Reformed

A manual for planting a church in a city, which sets out a step-by-step approach and tells the story of Redeemer Presbyterian Church, New York, throughout. Founders Ministries, in its annotated bibliography for planters, judges its practical instruction useful outside urban settings too.

Malphurs, Aubrey. *Planting Growing Churches for the 21st Century: A Comprehensive Guide for New Churches and Those Desiring Renewal*. 3rd ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2004.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A guide in three parts, the third of which sets out a process for planting, from values, mission and vision statements to gathering and growing a people. The third edition adds material on healthy change and the postmodern setting. John Joseph, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds it leaning on business principles at the expense of biblical foundations.

Malphurs, Aubrey. *The Nuts and Bolts of Church Planting: A Guide for Starting Any Kind of Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2011.

A guide that sets out, step by step, a process for planting not tied to any one model, beginning with the planter's values, mission and vision. Sixteen appendices, among them a spiritual gifts survey and sample vision statements, supply working material. It is a shorter book than Malphurs's *Planting Growing Churches for the 21st Century*.

Moore, Ralph. *21 Questions to Ask before Starting a New Church*. Exponential, 2025. <https://exponential.org/product/21-questions-to-ask-before-starting-a-new-church/>.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters

A discernment guide of 21 questions for someone weighing whether and how to start a new church, by the same author and in the same Hope Chapel and Exponential context as the shorter *How Nearly Anyone Can Start a Microchurch*. It states its wager on the church that will prevail in one sentence on page 9: it will be 'more relational, less of a spectacle, and more focused on equipping members for ministry'. Unlike the thesis-based planter-profile studies found elsewhere in this bibliography, its questions are for the prospective planter to put to themselves, before rather than during the work of starting.

Moore, Ralph. *Starting a New Church: The Church Planter's Guide to Success*. Ventura, CA: Regal Books, 2002.

A guide from the Hope Chapel movement. It argues that planting is the way to reach each new generation, since new churches attend to its needs and present biblical truth in the culture that reaches it, and then turns to the practice of starting one.

Murray, Stuart. *Planting Churches in the 21st Century: A Guide for Those Who Want Fresh Perspectives and New Ideas for Creating Congregations*. Harrisonburg, VA: Herald Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A practical guide written for planters, seminary students and churches considering a plant, organised round the questions who, what, why, where, when and how, with 'what next' added. Fay Puddicombe, reviewing it in 2015, describes a book full of practical lists, of kinds of plant, qualities in a planter, team-building and stages of development, with discussion questions for each chapter. It carries the same statement of purpose as Murray's *Planting Churches: A Framework for Practitioners* (2008) and shares its questions.

Murray, Stuart. *Planting Churches: A Framework for Practitioners*. Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2008.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Orthodox Presbyterian Church, Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension. *Planting an Orthodox Presbyterian Church*. Willow Grove, PA: Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension, 2002. <https://opc.org/chm/chplant/>.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Presbyterian and Reformed

A denominational manual from the Orthodox Presbyterian Church's Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension, written by its general secretary, Ross W. Graham, and approved by the Committee in December 2001. It sets out the church's own process for planting: how a core group becomes a mission work under an overseeing session and an organising pastor, and is in turn organised as a particular church. Written for organising pastors, overseeing elders and presbytery home missions committees, it describes the procedures of one Presbyterian and Reformed polity rather than a general method, and reads as a tradition's own working document.

Payne, J. D. *Discovering Church Planting: An Introduction to the Whats, Whys, and Hows of Global Church Planting*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Redford, Jack. *Planting New Churches*. Nashville, TN: Broadman Press, 1978.

ALSO IN Baptist

A Southern Baptist manual setting out nine numbered steps by which a sponsoring church starts a new one, through a mission fellowship and a mission chapel to a constituted church. Three chapters on the mission pastor follow the steps.

Schaller, Lyle E. *44 Questions for Church Planters*. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1991.

A book by a congregational consultant who worked across denominations, asking why new churches should be started and how the decline in new church development might be reversed. Ralph Mayhew, in the reading list he kept while preparing to plant, could not find a clear set of forty-four questions in it.

Shenk, David W., and Ervin R. Stutzman. *Creating Communities of the Kingdom: New Testament Models of Church Planting*. Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1988.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Acts of the Apostles

A book on planting that works through Acts, by two Mennonite church leaders, weaving practical applications from theology, anthropology, sociology, psychology and communication theory into the biblical commentary. Of its 13 chapters, those on gospel and culture and on leadership and accountability bear most directly on a team preparing to plant. Its questions for review, study and discussion would suit a group.

Stetzer, Ed, and Daniel Im. *Planting Missional Churches: Your Guide to Starting Churches That Multiply*. 2nd ed. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2016.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Tang, Len, and Charles E. Cotherman, eds. *Sent to Flourish: A Guide to Planting and Multiplying Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2019.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Formation and Training; Women in Church Planting

An edited volume from Fuller Theological Seminary's church planting programme, which its editors rest on three foundations: a biblical theology of planting, the spiritual formation of the planter, and intercultural competencies. The editors write of the need to form 'a new generation of women and men from a multitude of cultural backgrounds' as planters.

Thorpe, Ric. *How to Plant a Church: A Guide to Planting and Leading Healthy New Worshipping Communities*. London: CCX, 2024.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

PLANTERS, TEAMS AND FAMILIES

Books about the people who do the work: the planter, the team, the coach and the planter's household.

Bloye, Brian, and Amy Bloye. *It's Personal: Surviving and Thriving on the Journey of Church Planting*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Resilience and Burnout

A book written for planting couples by a husband and wife who started West Ridge Church in Georgia in 1997, on the personal side of planting: the marriage, the children and the balance of family and ministry, along with criticism, friendship and spiritual warfare. Each chapter carries interviews with other planting couples. Hoover's *The Church Planting Wife*, listed under Practical Guides, is by contrast written for the wife.

Hoover, Christine. *The Church Planting Wife: Help and Hope for Her Heart*. Chicago: Moody Publishers, 2013.

A book for the wives of church planters, by one who planted Charlottesville Community Church in Virginia with her husband in 2008. It takes up the questions the role raises: her own job description, being a wise help to her husband, making friends in the church and the community, and handling discouragement and wounds. Each chapter closes with an interview with another planter's wife.

Knight, Nathan. *Planting by Pastoring: A Vision for Starting a Healthy Church*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2023.

ALSO IN Pastoral Ministry

A book in the 9Marks Building Healthy Churches series, arguing that a church plant is a church and a planter a pastor, so that a plant's health is measured by pastoring that produces faith, fruit and a flourishing community, not by size or speed. Knight, who planted and leads Restoration Church in Washington DC, sets this against the entrepreneurial mindset that, in its publisher's words, planters often adopt, in chapters mostly titled as contrasts, such as 'Pastors, Not Entrepreneurs' and 'The Team, Not the Man'.

Nicholson, Steve, and Jeff Bailey. *Coaching Church Planters: A Manual for Church Planters and Those Who Coach Them*. Association of Vineyard Churches USA, 2001.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; New Churches and Networks; Coaching

A coaching manual from the Association of Vineyard Churches USA, addressed at once to the planter and to the coach. The manual comes out of Vineyard planting practice. It emphasises the planter's pursuit of intimacy with God, with Jesus's life as the model, and includes a guide for small groups.

Payne, J. D. *The Barnabas Factors: Eight Essential Practices of Church Planting Team Members*. Missional Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Teams and Culture

A book for the members of a planting team, taking Barnabas as their model and giving each chapter to one of eight practices, 'walks with the Lord' first among them. It includes a guide by which leaders can assess prospective team members against the eight.

Robinson, Gareth. *Stones and Ripples: 10 Principles for Pioneers and Church Planters*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2021.

ALSO IN Pioneering

A book setting out 10 principles from Robinson's four-year study of whether any principles of planting hold across very different contexts. In his image, five are stones, characteristics of the leader's own life with Jesus, prayer among them; five are ripples, steps that carry an initiative outward, multiplication among them. It is written from Church of England practice.

PLANTING IN A PARTICULAR SETTING

Guides for one kind of place, from the city to the village, or for one church tradition.

Ambrose, Gill, Helen Bent, Nick Edmonds and Sandra Millar. *How Village Churches Thrive: A Practical Guide*. Edited by Robert Atwell. London: Church House Publishing, 2021.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns

A basic introduction to good practice for village churches, from the Diocese of Exeter's Growing the Rural Church project. Robert Atwell, then Bishop of Exeter, described its aim as helping those who lead a village church, lay or ordained, to focus on 'ten basic things' for its renewal. Each of its 10 chapters takes one area of practice, such as welcome or the churchyard. Unlike Griggs's *Small Town Jesus* and Morrow's *Small Town Mission*, on mission in American small towns, it is written for the existing English village church.

Carter, Matt, and Darrin Patrick. *For the City: Proclaiming and Living Out the Gospel*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2011.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A book in two parts by two American planters. In the first each tells how he started his church: Carter's Austin Stone Community Church in Austin, Texas, and Patrick's The Journey in St Louis. In the second they write on topics such as contextualisation and suffering, using their own failures as warnings. Its concern is a church that exists for its city rather than for its own survival. Where Keller's *Planting a Church in the City* states principles, this works from two planters' experience.

Griggs, Donnie. *Small Town Jesus: Taking the Gospel Mission Seriously in Seemingly Unimportant Places*. Morehead City, NC: Everyday Truth, 2016.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns

A book arguing that small towns deserve the same missionary attention as cities, in two halves: the theological, sociological and philosophical case, then practical guidance. Griggs writes from planting in a coastal town in North Carolina. It is written for pastors, planters and ministry students generally, not only those already in small towns. Morrow's *Small Town Mission* addresses church members; Ambrose and others' *How Village Churches Thrive*, the existing English village church.

Horsley, Graham. *Planting New Congregations: A Practical Guide for Methodists*. London: Methodist Church Home Mission, 1994.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan

A booklet for Methodists on starting new congregations, published by the Methodist Church's Home Mission division in 1994, the year the Church of England's report *Breaking New Ground* appeared.

Keller, Timothy, and J. Allen Thompson. *Redeemer Church Planting Manual*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2002.

ANNOTATED under Manuals and Handbooks

Keller, Timothy. *Planting a Church in the City*. Manuals and Papers AR 18. New York: Redeemer Presbyterian Church, 2010. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/planting-a-church-in-the-city/>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas; Presbyterian and Reformed

A short paper, first published in *The Movement Newsletter* in 2004, setting out five principles for starting a church, from locating, which means living among the people to be reached, to launching, from the top down or the bottom up. Its publisher introduces them as principles common to any church plant. Keller's *Center Church* (2012) treats ministry in the city at book length.

Male, David. *How to Pioneer (Even If You Haven't a Clue)*. London: Church House Publishing, 2016.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Pioneering

A practical guide for beginners in pioneering new Christian communities. Male wrote it while advising the Church of England on pioneer development. It covers listening to a local context and discerning its needs, building a team, starting and discipleship.

Morrow, Aaron. *Small Town Mission: A Guide for Mission-Driven Communities*. GCD Books, 2016.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns

A practical guide to gospel-centred mission in small towns, written for lay people in ordinary jobs and for small-town congregations, on the premise that mission must be a priority locally as well as globally and in cities. Morrow wrote out of ministry in small-town Wisconsin. Where Griggs's *Small Town Jesus* makes the case to pastors and planters, this is addressed to church members; Ambrose and others' *How Village Churches Thrive* is for the English village church.

Redford, Jack. *Planting New Churches*. Nashville, TN: Broadman Press, 1978.

ANNOTATED under Manuals and Handbooks

SIMPLE AND MULTIPLYING CHURCHES

Manuals for small and simple forms of church and for planting that multiplies; the movements themselves are studied in Church Planting Movements.

Comiskey, Joel. *Planting Churches That Reproduce: Starting a Network of Simple Churches*. Moreno Valley, CA: CCS Publishing, 2016.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; Church Planting Strategy

A manual for planting simple churches that can keep reproducing into a network, drawn from Comiskey's three church plants and his work as a cell-church coach. Its first part defines a simple church by four marks: at least three members, God-appointed leadership, the lordship of Christ, and baptism and communion. Later parts turn to the planter's preparation and to strategies for cell-driven and house churches. Where Dale's *Getting Started* keeps to the house church, it covers both forms.

Connelly, Ben. *Sent Churches, Sending Churches: How Every Church Can Plant Churches and Send Missionaries for the Gospel and through the Gospel*. Exponential, 2026. <https://exponential.org/product/sent-churches-sending-churches/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A practical guide for a single congregation, rather than for a network as in Ferguson and O'Connell's *Together*, to becoming a church that plants churches and sends missionaries, argued from the biblical case of the church at Antioch. It offers biblical theology alongside exercises for congregations to work through, and states that a church can begin sending in its second year with as few as 20 engaged members. Where Walkemeyer's *The River Church* narrates one congregation's own turn to a multiplying culture, this book supplies the exercises for doing that work.

Dale, Felicity. *Getting Started: A Practical Guide to House Church Planting*. Austin, TX: House2House, 2003.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A practical guide to starting a simple church in a home, combining biblical material and case studies, on the premise that any believer can start one. Dale, a co-founder of House2House, planted churches in London in the British house-church movement before moving to Texas in 1987. It is addressed to ordinary believers, where Comiskey's *Planting Churches That Reproduce* plans networks of cell-based churches and Patterson and Scoggins's *Church Multiplication Guide* trains leaders.

Patterson, George, and Richard Scoggins. *Church Multiplication Guide: Helping Churches to Reproduce Locally and Abroad*. Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1993.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A guide to multiplying churches from Patterson's 20 years in Honduras, where he moved from training pastors in a residential Bible institute to training leaders by extension where they lived. It teaches his obedience-oriented education, a curriculum built on the commands of Christ rather than on doctrine as a subject, and expects each church to start daughter churches. A revised and enlarged edition is subtitled *The Miracle of Church Reproduction*.

Shank, Nathan, and Kari Shank. *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth: Starting and Releasing Healthy Churches*. 2014 edition. <https://churchplantingmovements.com/four-fields/>.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; Asia and the Middle East

A training manual organised around four fields drawn from the parable of the growing seed (Mark 4:26–29), from entering a community to forming a church. Nathan and Kari Shank compiled it from the experience of church planters in South Asia, where they worked in Northeast India. It is a common framework for planting: e3 Partners, NoPlaceLeft and East-West Ministries teach it by name, and an evaluation for the mission agency ABWE (2022) finds the method pervasive among sending organisations, while questioning its biblical basis, which rests largely on that one parable.

Woodward, J. R., and Dan White Jr. *The Church as Movement: Starting and Sustaining Missional-Incarnational Communities*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A field manual, with exercises and tools, for church-planting teams and discipleship groups, built from the training of the V3 Movement, which both authors help lead. It is organised around eight competencies for starting and sustaining missional-incarnational communities, among them polycentric leadership and incarnational practices. Where Shank's *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth* maps the stages of the work, this sets out the competencies a planting team develops.

WHAT GOES WRONG

Arment, Ben. *Church in the Making: What Makes or Breaks a New Church Before It Starts*. Nashville, TN: B&H Books, 2010.

A book arguing that whether a plant succeeds is largely settled before it opens, by a former church planter. Arment names three conditions: good ground, a community's spiritual receptivity; rolling rocks, the people, funds and resources God is already bringing together; and deep roots, leaders able to align them and sustain the church's mission. He argues that persevering through every difficulty is often mislabelled faithfulness, and the book bears most directly on the decision whether and where to plant.

Bennardo, Tom. *The Honest Guide to Church Planting: What No One Ever Tells You about Planting and Leading a New Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2019.

A book on the struggles and failures of planting rather than its method, addressed to planters in the middle of them by a co-director of the Synergy Church Planting Network. It warns against over-organisation and gimmicks to draw attendance, takes up rapid growth and encourages long-term pastoral friendships. Simon Murphy, reviewing it for Redeemer City to City, reads it as written for an American planter with a core team in place, offering practical counsel rather than a ministry philosophy grounded in scripture.

Driscoll, Mark. *Confessions of a Reformission Rev.: Hard Lessons from an Emerging Missional Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2006.

An account of the founding and growth of Mars Hill Church, Seattle, by its founding pastor, organised by the church's size at each stage, from fewer than 45 people to several thousand. Driscoll resigned from Mars Hill in 2014 amid serious concerns about his leadership, and the church dissolved soon after.

Griffith, Jim, and Bill Easum. *Ten Most Common Mistakes Made by New Church Starts*. St Louis, MO: Chalice Press, 2008.

A book naming the 10 mistakes that, in its authors' experience of planting and of coaching and consulting with planters, account for most failures among new churches, among them premature launch, evangelism that stops after the launch, and fear of talking about money until it is too late. Each comes with examples and guidance, with special sections for coaches and supervisors. Steel's *Wise Church Planting*, by contrast, draws its pitfalls from research into 80 struggling or failed plants.

McKinley, Mike. *Church Planting Is for Wimps: How God Uses Messed-Up People to Plant Ordinary Churches That Do Extraordinary Things*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

ALSO IN Baptist; Revitalisation and Replanting

An account of the revitalisation of Guilford Baptist Church in northern Virginia, a dying congregation, told under a planting title in the 9Marks series. McKinley argues that a pastor's faithful preaching, evangelism and training of leaders matter more than the size of his church, and is candid about his own fears and early mistakes. Written for pastors and seminarians weighing a plant and for those struggling in a young congregation; the chapter 'How to Ruin Everything' concerns ego, pride, fear and strain on marriage and family.

Steel, Dan. *Wise Church Planting: Twelve Pitfalls to Avoid in Starting New Churches*. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2024.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A book on 12 pitfalls, drawn from research into 80 church plants that struggled or failed, by a pastor in Oxford who had worked in market research. It groups the struggles under external opposition, character, practical barriers, disunity and lack of support, and works through them with stories, scripture and self-examination. Several pitfalls concern the leader, among them choosing workers for gifts rather than godliness, isolation, and burn-out from an unsustainable early pace, and these bear most directly on leading a plant.

REVITALISING AN EXISTING CHURCH

The fuller literature on replanting a dying church is in Revitalisation and Replanting.

Clifton, Mark. *Reclaiming Glory: Revitalizing Dying Churches*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2016.

ALSO IN Baptist; Revitalisation and Replanting

A book arguing that a dying congregation should be revitalised or replanted rather than abandoned, since a dying church does not glorify God, written from the North American Mission Board's work of replanting. It joins that conviction to practical strategy, for pastors weighing whether to lead a struggling church. An updated edition, subtitled *Creating a Gospel Legacy throughout North America* (2023), adds further experiences and strategies.

DeVine, Mark, and Darrin Patrick. *Replant: How a Dying Church Can Grow Again*. Colorado Springs, CO: David C Cook, 2014.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting

A book telling, as narrative rather than as principles, how First Calvary Baptist Church in Kansas City, a dying congregation, handed its ministry and assets to The Journey in St Louis, which planted Redeemer Fellowship there. DeVine, a seminary professor, narrates most of it, with shorter contributions from Patrick, The Journey's founding pastor. An appendix takes up the theological meaning of church buildings and the dangers of open business meetings.

Farrant, Suzi, and Darren Philip. *Being an Intergenerational Church: Practices to Bring the Generations Back Together*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book arguing that age-segregated models of ministry with children, young people and families are not working, and setting out practices by which an existing congregation can bring the generations together in mutual serving, sharing and learning. Commissioned by the Church of Scotland from two of its national staff, it grows out of their dissertations on Bonhoeffer and is organised around eight practices, among them hospitality and testimony. Written for pastors, parents, children's ministers and youth workers.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *On This Rock: Simple Lessons and Achievable Habits for Church Growth*. FirestartersUK, 2023.

ALSO IN Baptist; Church Growth; Missional Spirituality

A booklet setting out seven habits held in common by British Baptist churches seeing conversion growth, from small plants to larger established congregations, drawn from the Firestarters Network's conversations. Among them are intensity of prayer and fasting, and reorganising more often than you think. Each chapter grounds one habit in scripture, tells the story of a church that has practised it and closes with questions and next steps. Written for the leaders of existing churches to work through together.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *Scattered Not Small: Empowering Ordinary Churches to Become Disciple-Making Communities*. Firestarters Network Resources, 2024.

ALSO IN Baptist; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Revitalisation and Replanting

The sequel to *On This Rock*: a guide to moving a church from a traditional model to a scattered, decentralised one, and to starting a church that way. Remsberg is minister of Beacon Church, Stafford, and the authors draw on practitioners in other churches. It takes up the questions leaders raised with them, among them who provides leadership and what the minister's job becomes, with a discussion section in each chapter.

Henard, Bill. *Can These Bones Live? A Practical Guide to Church Revitalization*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2015.

ALSO IN Baptist; Revitalisation and Replanting

A guide for plateaued or declining churches, by a Southern Baptist pastor. It works through 11 causes of decline, diagnosing each and giving a process for addressing it, and closes with a 'Change Matrix' for implementation. Henard holds that revitalisation rests on preaching and the work of the Spirit rather than on method, and expects it to take seven to 10 years.

Huntley, Ron, and James Mallon. *Unlocking Your Parish: Making Disciples, Raising Up Leaders with Alpha*. Frederick, MD: The Word Among Us Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Alpha Course and Church Planting; Parish Church

A book on Alpha as the means of renewing a Catholic parish, drawn from Saint Benedict Parish in Halifax, Nova Scotia, where Huntley served on the senior leadership team alongside Mallon. A practical outworking of Mallon's *Divine Renovation*, it argues that evangelisation shapes the whole culture of a parish, from outreach to sacramental life, and takes up the logistical questions that arise after a first or second course. Written for parishes considering Alpha as well as those already running it.

Jackson, Bob. *Leading One Church at a Time: From Multi-Church Ministers to Focal Ministers*. Leadership 34. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2018.

ALSO IN Parish Church; Church Growth

A Grove booklet arguing that a shrinking clergy should lead one church each, not several, replacing the multi-parish incumbent with a 'focal minister' – paid or unpaid, lay or ordained – set at the centre of a single congregation. Where Jackson's earlier, data-led studies ask what drives numerical growth, this is a short policy argument for restructuring ministry itself, citing early evidence from the Diocese of St Davids. Written for diocesan and deanery leaders reviewing multi-parish arrangements; the term itself is defined on page 3.

McKinley, Mike. *Church Planting Is for Wimps: How God Uses Messed-Up People to Plant Ordinary Churches That Do Extraordinary Things*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

ANNOTATED under What Goes Wrong

Warren, Robert. *The Healthy Churches' Handbook: A Process for Revitalizing Your Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Church Growth; Anglican; Parish Church

A handbook setting out seven marks of a healthy church, each a contrast, such as energised by faith rather than just keeping things going, with a process by which a congregation reviews itself against them, from a detailed review to a single evening. It treats health in qualitative terms rather than as numerical growth. The Diocese of Southwark uses the marks to frame visits to every parish by its bishops and archdeacons. The chapter 'The angel of the church' concerns a congregation's character, buildings, setting and story.

Church Planting Strategy

See also the lists on Practical Guides, on Church Planting Movements, and on Vision and Strategy.

This reading list is on church planting strategy: planning above the single plant, where a network, diocese or denomination decides where churches are to be planted, how many, in what form and from which sending churches, and how the whole is to be resourced and sustained. Practical Guides holds the planter's handbook for one church; Church Planting Movements holds the literature of one strategy that became a genre; the general books on vision and strategy for any organisation are in Wider Reading. This list holds the books and reports that treat planting as a system: what a church or a network must put in place to plant repeatedly, and what dioceses and denominations have actually decided.

Its writers divide over where strategy should come from. At one pole is the system deliberately built and measured: Ed Stetzer, Jeff Christopherson and Daniel Yang benchmark North American planting networks and find most of them built to choose planters rather than to make churches that go on to plant, and the Lausanne network's paper takes up the saturation strategy first promoted in the 1980s and makes the case for it now. At the other is strategy read from theology and context: Timothy Keller makes a 'theological vision' the link between doctrine and the decisions a church takes in its own place, and Ric Thorpe sets out the resource church strategy from within the Church of England, where a bishop's authorisation and a place in diocesan strategy define it. Will Foulger's research on eleven dioceses shows what the English strategies have produced, mostly within the parish system and rarely called church planting, and Bob Jackson holds that a diocese, not only a parish, can grow again.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Choosing a Model, Systems and Networks, and Dioceses and Denominations.

START HERE

Keller, Timothy. 'Introduction: Center Church Theological Vision'. In *Center Church: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*, 13-26. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012. https://timothykeller.squarespace.com/s/CenterChurch_Intro.pdf.

Students have found this introductory chapter helpful in its own right as a thinking piece about church mission strategy. Keller introduces the concept of a 'theological vision' as the link between Christian doctrine and the practical life and ministry of a church. He argues that churches need to move beyond both an emphasis on measurable success and an understanding of faithfulness that pays little attention to outcomes, proposing 'fruitfulness' as a more helpful biblical category. A theological vision is a faithful restatement of the gospel with implications for life, ministry and mission in a particular cultural and historical context. Keller explores how this vision relates to both the unchanging truths of Christian doctrine and the contextual decisions involved in preaching, worship, evangelism, discipleship and mission. He then outlines the three elements of his own theological vision for Redeemer Presbyterian Church — gospel, city and movement — which provide the organising framework for the rest of the book.

Stetzer, Ed, Jeff Christopherson, and Daniel Yang. *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems: With Particular Attention to Church Planting Churches*. Wheaton, IL: Send Institute and New Churches, 2018. <https://www.sendinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/SI-2018-BPCPS.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; Selecting and Assessing Planters

Benchmarking research on North American planting networks, asking what the churches that reproduce well do differently. Of the 130 organisations that answered, nearly half had taken multiplication language into their mission or vision statements and 73 per cent trained for it, but 74 per cent reported that fewer than a quarter of their churches were actually planting; and the average organisation still optimises for selecting planters rather than for growing churches that plant. American throughout, and concerned with how a planting system is put together rather than how it should feel.

Thorpe, Ric. *Resource Churches: A Story of Church Planting and Revitalisation Across the Nation*. London: CCX, 2021.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Revitalisation and Replanting; Anglican

The account of the resource church strategy from inside it, by the bishop who held the Church of England's national brief for planting when it was written. Biblical, theological and historical roots first, then the practicalities of launching and growing one, with stories from planters and a reflection from each of their bishops. Its definition, as Shepherd reports it, turns on a bishop's authorisation, a place in diocesan strategy, resourcing to plant and revitalise, a leadership pipeline, and resourcing for wider mission. Thorpe intends it to apply beyond Anglicanism.

CHOOSING A MODEL

Jackson, Bob. *What Makes Churches Grow? Vision and Practice in Effective Mission*. London: Church House Publishing, 2015.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A book on what makes Church of England congregations grow, which counts depth of faith and strength of ministry as growth alongside numbers. It joins strategy to prayer: its central part sets out strategies, from lay leadership to church planting and fresh expressions, on the principle that 'it is those who intend to grow the church who tend to grow the church', and its last part holds that strategy alone cannot produce growth. A congregation planning for growth might begin with the central part.

Kewley, Daniel, and Sven Östring. 'Can Church Planting Movements Emerge in the West? Case Studies of Three Church Planting Strategies in Western Australia.' *Journal of Adventist Mission Studies* 8, no. 1 (2012): 25–43.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

An article in the *Journal of Adventist Mission Studies* asking whether church planting movements, a category developed in the majority world, can take hold in a secular Western setting, and testing the question against three church-planting strategies in Western Australia. Among the studies of movements in particular places it is the one Australian case, and the only entry here from the Adventist literature.

Porter, Matthew. *Overflow: Learning from the Inspirational Resource Church of Antioch in the Book of Acts*. Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2020.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Acts of the Apostles

A book reading the church at Antioch in Acts 11 and 13 as a resource church, with 'not just a local but a regional vision'; Porter names seven such churches in the New Testament, Antioch his main case. He wrote it as vicar of St Michael le Belfrey in York, and draws characteristics, structures and strategies from Antioch for churches now. Each chapter closes with questions for reflection and group discussion.

SYSTEMS AND NETWORKS

Millar, Caroline, and Laura Treneer. *National Church Planting Network Scoping Research*. Chalk Lab for the National Church Planting Network Steering Group, 2022. <https://cte.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/03/NCPN-Scoping-Project-Chalk-Lab-Feb-2022.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A scoping report commissioned by the steering group of the National Church Planting Network, supported by the Church of England, Churches Together in England, the Evangelical Alliance and City to City UK, and written by Caroline Millar and Laura Treneer of the consultancy Chalk Lab. It synthesises 19 interviews in autumn 2021 with those leading national planting strategies for denominations and networks, from the Church of England to New Frontiers and the RCCG, under plans, process, funding, place, people and partnership, and reflects on collaboration and the network's role. It finds a national picture hard to draw, given differing theologies, vocabularies and metrics, beside a shared wish for more churches. An executive summary is published with it.

Comiskey, Joel. *Planting Churches That Reproduce: Starting a Network of Simple Churches*. Moreno Valley, CA: CCS Publishing, 2016.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; Practical Guides

A manual for planting simple churches that can keep reproducing into a network, drawn from Comiskey's three church plants and his work as a cell-church coach. Its first part defines a simple church by four marks: at least three members, God-appointed leadership, the lordship of Christ, and baptism and communion. Later parts turn to the planter's preparation and to strategies for cell-driven and house churches. Where Dale's *Getting Started* keeps to the house church, it covers both forms.

Ferguson, Dave, and Jon Ferguson. *Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2010.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A book setting out the reproducing plan behind Community Christian Church in Chicago, begun by five friends and told in four stages: movements start with one, then reproducing tribes of ten to a hundred, communities of a hundred to a thousand, and movements of tens of thousands. The anchor book of the Exponential series. Josh Manley, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds its scriptural grounding thin, which is the standing complaint against this end of the literature.

Lausanne Church Planting Issue Network. *Saturation Church Planting: A Call to Collaboration*. Edited by Juan Wagenveld. Lausanne Occasional Paper 79. Lausanne Movement, 2024. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/saturation-church-planting-a-call-to-collaboration>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement; Church Planting Movements

A Lausanne report tracing the DAWN saturation approach that Jim Montgomery and others promoted through the 1980s and 1990s, and arguing for its continuation in new forms. It grew out of a gathering of 250 leaders from 65 countries at Batam, Indonesia, in February 2024, convened with GACX, the Global Church Planting Network and Vision 5:9, and carries contributions from Chuck Van Engen, Murray Moerman, Raphael Anzenberger, Todd Benkert, Matt Fretwell and Ron Anderson, with a final review by Craig Van Gelder.

Send Network. *Church Planting Pipeline: Moving Beyond Addition*. Alpharetta, GA: North American Mission Board, 2017.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Formation and Training

A short booklet from Send Network, the North American Mission Board's church-planting arm, issued in August 2017 with a foreword by Jeff Christopherson, then its vice-president. It presents the Pipeline as a local church's own system for finding and forming planters: a pre-assessment, then three levels of 10 competencies each, up to three years of modules, on the argument that planting by addition, one recruited planter at a time, never becomes a movement. Among books on churches that send, it is the one that describes a denomination's ready-made programme, and would suit a church wanting to see what such a pathway contains.

Stetzer, Ed, Jeff Christopherson, and Daniel Yang. *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems: With Particular Attention to Church Planting Churches*. Wheaton, IL: Send Institute and New Churches, 2018. <https://www.sendinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/SI-2018-BPCPS.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. *Viral Churches: Helping Church Planters Become Movement Makers*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2010.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A book drawing on research commissioned by Leadership Network on what distinguishes churches that multiply from those that merely grow. Its definition of a multiplication movement requires half of each new church's attenders to be new converts. Richard Rymarz, reviewing it for *Catholic Books Review*, finds its research detail thin and points elsewhere for a more systematic and critical treatment.

DIOCESES AND DENOMINATIONS

Millar, Caroline, and Laura Treneer. *National Church Planting Network Scoping Research*. Chalk Lab for the National Church Planting Network Steering Group, 2022. <https://cte.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/03/NCPN-Scoping-Project-Chalk-Lab-Feb-2022.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Systems and Networks

Church Multiplication: Growing the Church Exponentially. Special issue, *Enrichment Journal* 14, no. 4 (Fall 2009).

ALSO IN Pentecostal

A collection of articles filling the fall 2009 issue of the Assemblies of God's quarterly for ministers, 160 pages given to church multiplication as the denomination set up its Church Multiplication Network. They run from George Wood on Acts 19 and David Olson on why multiplication decides a denomination's survival, through Ed Stetzer on planting systems, Nelson Searcy on launching large, Dave Ferguson on multisite and Neil Cole on organic church, to Bob Roberts on 'glocal' planting and Steven Pike on the network itself. Together they show one Pentecostal denomination gathering the wider movement's voices for its own planters. Stetzer's article also has an entry of its own.

Church of Scotland Faith Action Programme Leadership Team. *Report of the Faith Action Programme Leadership Team*. Reports to the General Assembly 2026. Church of Scotland, 2026. https://www.churchofscotland.org.uk/__data/assets/pdf_file/0006/154653/Faith-Action-Programme-Leadership-Team1.pdf.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Resource Churches; Presbyterian and Reformed

A report to the Church of Scotland's General Assembly of May 2026, which asked the Assembly to note the progress of plans for a resource church in the Presbytery of Glasgow. It defines a resource church as a hub for mission, planting, revitalisation and developing leaders, proposes siting one near universities to reach students and young adults, and affirms three levels of planting: local, presbytery and national. It also records that the planting strategy the 2025 Assembly asked for is not ready, central staff having been cut.

Foulger, Will. *New Things: A Theological Investigation into the Work of Starting New Churches across 11 Dioceses in the Church of England*. Durham: Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research, 2024. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+New+Things+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Resource Churches

A report built on interviews with a representative of each of 11 dioceses, with their strategy documents and funding bids, on what the Church of England has been starting and what it calls it. Around 900 new things across the 11, 89 per cent of them inside the parish system rather than standing alone, and 40 of them newly designated resource churches. None of the 11 dioceses used the language of 'church plant'. Foulger reads the descriptors as an ecclesiology already shaping practice, and calls the starting of new things essentially an evangelically driven project.

Jackson, Bob. *The Road to Growth: Towards a Thriving Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2005.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church Growth

The fuller and more strategic sequel to *Hope for the Church*, drawn from Jackson's consultancy with churches and dioceses. It argues that decline can be reversed in parishes, dioceses and the Church of England as a whole, and gives two of its four parts to strategies for deploying people and money to support growth.

Methodist Church in Britain. *New Places for New People (NPNP) Guide*. Version 1. Methodist Church, 2021. <https://media.methodist.org.uk/media/documents/new-places-for-new-people-nnpn-guide.pdf>.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan

The Methodist Church in Britain's practical guide, first issued in August 2021, to starting New Places for New People: new Christian communities for those not yet part of an existing church, one of the commitments of its God for All strategy. Written by the Connexion's pioneering and Church at the Margins officers for districts, circuits and local churches, it sets out a Methodist theological foundation and core practices, and names five priority settings, among them new housing, students and families. It is the current British Methodist policy on planting; the chapters on discerning where to locate a project and on financial sustainability would be useful places to look.

Thorpe, Ric. *Resource Churches: A Story of Church Planting and Revitalisation Across the Nation*. London: CCX, 2021.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Introductions and Overviews

This list is defined by a reader rather than a subject: someone coming to church planting who wants a map of the field, its theology, history and practice together, before a manual or the scholarship. Most of the manuals are gathered in Practical Guides and the scholarly treatments in Key Theological and Scholarly Works, and a comprehensive textbook can belong in more than one.

This list reaches back behind the current literature: to the nineteenth-century missionary argument that new churches should support, govern and propagate themselves, and, in England, to the planting of the 1980s and 1990s, whose history some of its books tell.

The introductions agree that new churches are needed and divide over what they are for. Keller and Payne treat planting chiefly as evangelism: Keller's case is that new churches reach new people more effectively than existing ones, and Payne's definition makes church planting a form of evangelism. Murray, writing for a post-Christendom Britain, and Moynagh, arguing for contextual churches, ask what shape a church should take and treat planting as a way of finding it. Paas asks what authorises the practice at all. A second argument, over whether churches should multiply or put down roots in one place, runs through the books on the shape of church.

After Start Here, the books are grouped as General Introductions, The Theology of Planting, Where the Conversation Came From, Rethinking the Shape of Church, and Stories and Cases.

START HERE

Moynagh, Michael, with Philip Harrold. *Church for Every Context: An Introduction to Theology and Practice*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church

A textbook arguing for what Moynagh calls contextual churches, drawing on the literature and practice of both church planting and fresh expressions; its publisher describes it as the first textbook to reflect the learning from fresh expressions of church. It runs from ecclesiology to how a new community is sustained and supported, and at over 500 pages would suit use by section.

Murray, Stuart. *Church Planting: Laying Foundations*. Carlisle: Paternoster Press, 1998.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works

Murray's most comprehensive book on planting, written from an Anabaptist perspective by a theologian and practitioner of planting. It looks at the common objections to planting, then at planting in theology, in the New Testament and in history, before asking what planting does to the church. He is sensitive to the post-Christendom context of Britain and the West and argues for an approach to planting that reflects it; sometimes critical of contemporary planting, he is never less than stimulating. The opening chapter, on the critics, and the chapter setting out a theological framework bear most directly on the case for planting.

Payne, J. D. *Discovering Church Planting: An Introduction to the Whats, Whys, and Hows of Global Church Planting*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009.

ALSO IN Baptist; Practical Guides; Global and Cross-Cultural

An introductory overview, written from the perspective of a North American Baptist. Its four sections run from the theology of planting to contemporary issues, and draw on history, with the Moravians, the Methodists and the Baptists among its examples. It is set out as a first textbook: each chapter carries summaries, review questions and short articles on practical issues in planting.

Stetzer, Ed, and Daniel Im. *Planting Missional Churches: Your Guide to Starting Churches That Multiply*. 2nd ed. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A textbook for planting in North America, rewritten for this second edition with Daniel Im and, by the authors' account, more than half new. Of its five sections, Section 2 sets several models side by side, from simple churches to multisite, and Section 3 works through a launch, from focus group to finances and a meeting place. Nathan Knight, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds little on membership, discipline and shepherding.

GENERAL INTRODUCTIONS

Bevins, Winfield. *Church-Planting Revolution: A Guidebook for Explorers, Planters, and Their Teams*. Franklin, TN: Seedbed Publishing, 2017.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

An introduction to church planting in which practical chapters alternate with case studies from both the UK and North America. It is addressed to those still exploring whether to plant as well as to planters and their teams.

Goodhew, David, Andrew Roberts, and Michael Volland. *Fresh! An Introduction to Fresh Expressions of Church and Pioneer Ministry*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Fresh Expressions of Church

A textbook introduction to fresh expressions of church and to pioneer ministry, presented as one field rather than two, co-written by David Goodhew, Andrew Roberts and Michael Volland. It draws a theological rationale for both from scripture and the wider Christian tradition, tests it against contemporary British culture and against the criticisms fresh expressions have attracted, and follows this with practical guidance for starting and sustaining a fresh expression or a pioneer post over the long term.

Hesselgrave, David J. *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: A Guide for Home and Foreign Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1980.

ALSO IN Missiology; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural; Acts of the Apostles

A missiologist's guide to planting across cultures, organised round a 10-stage Pauline Cycle drawn from Acts 13–16, which runs from missionaries commissioned to sending churches convened. A second edition, retitled *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: North America and Beyond*, followed in 2000.

Jones, Peyton. *Church Plantology: The Art and Science of Planting Churches*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2021.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A textbook that assesses current planting methods and proposes a model drawn from Paul's apostolic practice, in 20 chapters paired into 10 sections. Jones writes as a practitioner and trainer, the founder of NewBreed Training, and his topics run from the planter's character to multiplication networks. Bernard Mukwavi, reviewing it for the Northwest Institute for Ministry Education Research, notes its emphasis on rapid multiplication.

Keller, Timothy. *Center Church: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Cities and Urban Areas; Presbyterian and Reformed

A comprehensive overview of church planting theology and theory, set out as what Keller calls a theological vision for ministry in the city, by the founding pastor of Redeemer Presbyterian Church in New York and founding president of City to City. Its first part shows how the gospel drives planting and renews church and planter; the second, on the city, has a careful section on contextualisation and substantial sections on the place of the city in any planting strategy. It is long and demanding, but deeply thoughtful, and an excellent framework for urban planting.

Malphurs, Aubrey. *Planting Growing Churches for the 21st Century: A Comprehensive Guide for New Churches and Those Desiring Renewal*. 3rd ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2004.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A guide in three parts, the third of which sets out a process for planting, from values, mission and vision statements to gathering and growing a people. The third edition adds material on healthy change and the postmodern setting. John Joseph, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds it leaning on business principles at the expense of biblical foundations.

Murray, Stuart. *Church Planting: Laying Foundations*. Carlisle: Paternoster Press, 1998.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Murray, Stuart. *Planting Churches in the 21st Century: A Guide for Those Who Want Fresh Perspectives and New Ideas for Creating Congregations*. Harrisonburg, VA: Herald Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A practical guide written for planters, seminary students and churches considering a plant, organised round the questions who, what, why, where, when and how, with 'what next' added. Fay Puddicombe, reviewing it in 2015, describes a book full of practical lists, of kinds of plant, qualities in a planter, team-building and stages of development, with discussion questions for each chapter. It carries the same statement of purpose as Murray's *Planting Churches: A Framework for Practitioners* (2008) and shares its questions.

Murray, Stuart. *Planting Churches: A Framework for Practitioners*. Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2008.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A practical guide by a British Anabaptist, organised round six questions, from why to what, and written, in Murray's words, for practitioners 'and for those who deploy and support them'. Phil Whittall, reviewing it for *Christianity*, finds the treatment theoretical and wishes for more worked examples.

Payne, J. D. *Apostolic Church Planting: Birthing New Churches from New Believers*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A short book for planting teams, arguing from Acts that church plants begin with sharing the gospel and grow out of making disciples. Its 12 chapters run from defining planting to ethical guidelines for a plant, each closing with practical steps and principles, and its methods are meant to be carried out by ordinary team members, not only by charismatic leaders. Phillip J. Long, reviewing it, reads it as a follow-up to Payne's *Discovering Church Planting*.

Payne, J. D. *Discovering Church Planting: An Introduction to the Whats, Whys, and Hows of Global Church Planting*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Robinson, Martin. *Planting Mission-Shaped Churches Today*. Oxford: Monarch Books, 2006.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Missiology

A book on planting new churches in the West, illustrated with dozens of examples, by a Churches of Christ minister who had led a plant in inner-city Birmingham. It is a different book from *Planting Tomorrow's Churches Today* (1992), the handbook Robinson wrote with Stuart Christine.

Shenk, David W., and Ervin R. Stutzman. *Creating Communities of the Kingdom: New Testament Models of Church Planting*. Scottdale, PA: Herald Press, 1988.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Acts of the Apostles

A book on planting that works through Acts, by two Mennonite church leaders, weaving practical applications from theology, anthropology, sociology, psychology and communication theory into the biblical commentary. Of its 13 chapters, those on gospel and culture and on leadership and accountability bear most directly on a team preparing to plant. Its questions for review, study and discussion would suit a group.

Stetzer, Ed, and Daniel Im. *Planting Missional Churches: Your Guide to Starting Churches That Multiply*. 2nd ed. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2016.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Tang, Len, and Charles E. Cotherman, eds. *Sent to Flourish: A Guide to Planting and Multiplying Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2019.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Formation and Training; Women in Church Planting

An edited volume from Fuller Theological Seminary's church planting programme, which its editors rest on three foundations: a biblical theology of planting, the spiritual formation of the planter, and intercultural competencies. The editors write of the need to form 'a new generation of women and men from a multitude of cultural backgrounds' as planters.

Timmis, Steve, ed. *Multiplying Churches: Reaching Today's Communities Through Church Planting*. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2000.

A collection making the theological case for planting rather than setting out a procedure for it, addressed, in the description of its 2016 reissue, to church leaders struggling with internal problems, for whom planting 'does not appear on the agenda'. The reissue carries the subtitle *Exploring God's Mission Strategy*. Its editor, Steve Timmis, was removed as chief executive of Acts 29 in 2020 over concerns about his leadership.

Wagner, C. Peter. *Church Planting for a Greater Harvest: A Comprehensive Guide*. [1990.] Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2010.

A book on planting as evangelism by Fuller Theological Seminary's professor of church growth, setting down his 'How to Plant a Church' seminar and the 10 years of research and teaching behind it. It argues that planting, neglected as a method of evangelism for 40 years, is needed because 'no single church can meet every person's needs'.

THE THEOLOGY OF PLANTING

Ashford, Bruce Riley, ed. *Theology and Practice of Mission: God, the Church, and the Nations*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2011.

ALSO IN Baptist; Missiology

An edited volume setting out a biblical-theological framework for the church's mission to the nations, written by pastors, professors and missionaries and published by B&H Academic, the Southern Baptist imprint. It begins from God's mission, traced through creation, fall, redemption and restoration, and places church planting within the church's wider mission, beside preaching and witness in every area of culture. J. D. Payne's chapter in the second part, 'Mission and Church Planting', bears most directly on planting.

Cockayne, Joshua, and Scott Harrower. *Exploring a Theology for Church Planting: Learning from Bede as Evangelist, Prophet, Scribe*. Church Multiplication 1. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2024.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission

A booklet, the first in Grove's Church Multiplication series, arguing that church planting, at times treated by advocates and critics alike as a purely pragmatic task, needs a clear theological basis. Cockayne and Harrower offer Bede as one source for it, since he held a commitment to mission and church growth together with scholarly study of the world, the past and Scripture. Where Smith's *Church Planting by the Book* argues from Acts, it looks for its theology in the early English church.

Cockayne, Joshua. 'Church Planting, Community and the Triune God of Grace'. In *New Churches: A Theology*, edited by Will Foulger and Joshua Cockayne, 62-72. London: SCM Press, 2024.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A chapter in the missiological first part of *New Churches: A Theology*, taking its title and its argument from James B. Torrance's lectures *Worship, Community, and the Triune God of Grace*. Cockayne holds that much talk of planting is, in Torrance's phrase, 'practically unitarian', treating planters as the primary agents, and argues instead that planting is participation in the ongoing work of the Trinity, so that the planter's first task is not strategy but discernment of where Christ is already building his church.

Cunnington, Ralph. 'Editorial'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 1-3. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-editorial/>.

A short editorial article introducing an issue of *Foundations* given to church planting, by the journal's editor, Ralph Cunnington, who had helped to plant a church in central Manchester in 2014. It argues that planting is a principle, because the gospel demands it, as well as a strategy.

Hyde, Daniel R., and Shane Lems, eds. *Planting, Watering, Growing: Planting Confessionally Reformed Churches in the 21st Century*. Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2011.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Presbyterian and Reformed

An edited volume of 21 essays on planting confessionally Reformed churches, most by pastors of the United Reformed Churches in North America with experience of planting. Stephen Doe's review for the Orthodox Presbyterian Church notes that its handling of the oversight of new mission work follows United Reformed practice. Its first part, on the biblical and confessional foundations, with Brian Vos's 'The Fruitful Grain of Wheat' and Wes Bredenhof's 'The Reformed Confessions and Missions', bears most directly on the theology of planting.

Keller, Timothy. 'Why Plant Churches?' New York: Redeemer City to City, 2002. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/why-plant-churches/>.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A brief paper addressing the common objections to planting: that there are already many churches and they are not full, and that plants merely take Christians from elsewhere. Keller argues that new churches are the most effective way of reaching new people in new places, and that planting causes existing churches to grow too. Selvaratnam's Grove booklet of the same title is a slightly longer and more up-to-date equivalent.

Keller, Timothy. *Center Church Europe: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Edited by Stefan Paas. Amsterdam: Buijten en Schipperheijn, 2014.

ALSO IN Europe

A volume that sets responses from theologians working in Europe around Keller's *Center Church*, edited by Stefan Paas and published in English in the Netherlands. Keller's case for ministry that is gospel-centred, city-centred and movement-centred, drawn from his years in New York, is answered by writers including Leonardo De Chirico, Michael Herbst and Martin Reppenhausen, and a postscript from the European Evangelical Alliance reports on church developments across Europe.

Moynagh, Michael. *Church in Life: Innovation, Mission and Ecclesiology*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesiology; Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesial Minimum

A monograph modelling how new Christian communities come into being, drawing on complexity theory and entrepreneurship studies alongside theology. Where Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* (2012) makes the case for contextual churches, this book gives an account of how they emerge, analysing and systematising the innovation skills that pioneers of fresh expressions use by instinct. Its closing section, 'Perspectives on Method', bears most directly on how innovating teams work.

Paas, Stefan. 'Church Renewal by Church Planting: The Significance of Church Planting for the Future of Christianity in Europe'. *Theology Today* 68, no. 4 (January 2012): 467-77. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0040573611424326>.

ALSO IN Europe; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A journal article by a Dutch missiologist who has planted churches, on what planting means for the future of Christianity in Europe. Where Keller's 'Why Plant Churches?' argues for new churches as a way of reaching new people, Paas's title presents planting as the means of the church's renewal. His *Church Planting in the Secular West* (2016) returns to planting in Europe at book length.

Paas, Stefan. 'Why Church Planting in Europe? On Authorizing a Common Evangelical Practice'.

Posted by the author, n.d. <https://www.academia.edu/30912620/>

[Why_Church_Planting_in_Europe_On_Authorizing_a_Common_Evangelical_Practice_%CE%B1](https://www.academia.edu/30912620/Why_Church_Planting_in_Europe_On_Authorizing_a_Common_Evangelical_Practice_%CE%B1).

ALSO IN Europe; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A paper asking what authorises church planting in Europe, which its subtitle calls 'a common evangelical practice'. Where Paas's 'Church Renewal by Church Planting' presents planting as a means of renewing the church, this paper asks on what grounds the practice rests at all.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *Why Plant Churches? Theological and Practical Reasons*. Mission and Evangelism 142. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2023.

A short book arguing that church planting, often reduced to a task of mission, has wider theological and practical reasons, and setting out the benefits it brings to the wider Church.

Smith, E. Elbert. *Church Planting by the Book*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A study of the nine church plants in Acts, from Jerusalem to Ephesus, taken chapter by chapter for what they have in common, what is particular to each and how Scripture applies to planting now. Smith writes from 30 years with the Southern Baptist International Mission Board, where he planted churches. Argued from the text rather than set out as a manual, it draws out prayer, the Spirit's empowering, multiplication and the training of leaders.

Timmis, Steve, ed. *Multiplying Churches: Reaching Today's Communities Through Church Planting*. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2000.

ANNOTATED under General Introductions

WHERE THE CONVERSATION CAME FROM

Histories of church planting in England, alongside the earlier books whose ideas the present discussion takes up.

Frost, Michael, and Alan Hirsch. *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2003.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets; Missiology; Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Innovation and Creativity; Theory of Change

A book arguing that the attractional church shaped by Christendom cannot reach the post-Christendom West. Frost and Hirsch build on the Gospel and Our Culture Network's account of the missional church, which drew on Lesslie Newbigin, adding three shifts of their own: to incarnational ecclesiology, messianic spirituality and apostolic leadership. They set a centred-set church, defined by nearness to Jesus, against a bounded-set one. Chapter 11, 'Imagination and the Leadership Task', treats imagination as part of a leader's work. A revised edition followed from Baker in 2013.

Lings, George, and Stuart Murray. *Church Planting in the UK Since 2000: Reviewing the First Decade*. Evangelism 99. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2012.

A short Grove booklet, the successor to *Church Planting: Past, Present and Future* by the same authors, reviewing the decade from 2000 to 2011. Lings and Murray report on how new churches, Christian communities and forms of church developed after the planting of the 1990s, and set out the lessons, prospects and challenges. The pair together make a brief history of English church planting from the 1980s to 2011.

Lings, George, and Stuart Murray. *Church Planting: Past, Present and Future*. Evangelism 61. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2003.

A short Grove booklet on the history of church planting in England in the 1980s and 1990s, when many denominations committed themselves to planting as a way forward for church growth and set targets that proved unrealistic; it weighs the successes and the lessons learned. Both authors wrote from inside the movement: Lings led Church Army's research unit, and Murray had directed church planting and evangelism at Spurgeon's College. Its 2012 successor, *Church Planting in the UK Since 2000*, carries the story into the following decade.

Lings, George. 'The History of Fresh Expressions of Church and Church Planting in the Church of England'. In *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*, edited by David Goodhew, 161-78. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Fresh Expressions of Church; Anglican

A chapter tracing church planting in the Church of England from the 1960s to fresh expressions of church, by the head of Church Army's research unit. Lings sets out six movements that prepared the ground, among them charismatic renewal and church growth theory, gives figures for plants by period, and presents fresh expressions as a new departure rather than a return to the daughter church.

Nevius, John L. *The Planting and Development of Missionary Churches*. Shanghai: Presbyterian Press, 1886.

ALSO IN Missiology; Asia and the Middle East; Victorian Three Selves; Presbyterian and Reformed

A primary text of the 19th-century missionary movement, first written in 1885 as articles for the *Chinese Recorder* and published as a book in 1886. Against paying local evangelists and pastors from mission funds, Nevius argues for churches that are self-supporting, self-governing and self-propagating, whose members keep their own occupations and call pastors when they can support them. The source of what came to be called the Nevius method, it was adopted by Presbyterian missionaries in Korea; the *Biographical Dictionary of Chinese Christianity* records that it and Nevius's *Methods of Mission Work* became required reading for most Presbyterian missionaries to China and Korea for over 50 years. The 1899 New York printing is digitised by the Internet Archive.

RETHINKING THE SHAPE OF CHURCH

Books on what a church should be and how it should be ordered for mission, rather than on how to start one.

Fitch, David E., and Geoffrey Holsclaw. *Prodigal Christianity: Ten Signposts into the Missional Frontier*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2013.

ALSO IN Missiology

A theological account of the missional church, set out as 10 signposts on doctrine, practice and ethics. Anabaptist in its theology, it presents itself as a way beyond both Emergent and Neo-Reformed evangelicalism. The chapters on practice, among them those on proclamation and the church, bear most directly on the shape a congregation takes.

Greear, J. D. *Gaining by Losing: Why the Future Belongs to Churches That Send*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2015.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A pastor's case for a church ordered around sending its members and leaders out, drawn from the practice of the Summit Church in Raleigh-Durham, North Carolina. Shane Lems, reviewing on the Reformed Reader blog, doubts that methods formed in a church of well over a thousand people transfer to smaller ones. The 'sending plumb lines' of the second part, and the appendices on missions and church planting, bear most directly on a church preparing to send out a plant.

Keller, Timothy. *Serving a Movement: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A volume republishing the third part of Keller's *Center Church*, on the church's mission and how churches become movements, with responses from Tim Chester, Daniel Montgomery and Mike Cosper, and Alan Hirsch, and a reply from Keller. The responses are what it adds: Chester questions the idea that a church earns 'the right to be heard' through service, and Hirsch recasts movement through the fivefold ministry of Ephesians 4. The section on movement dynamics bears most directly on multiplying churches.

Moynagh, Michael, with Philip Harrold. *Church for Every Context: An Introduction to Theology and Practice*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Myers, Joseph R. *Organic Community: Creating a Place Where People Naturally Connect*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2007.

A book arguing that community cannot be programmed, with nine tools for shaping the conditions in which it forms instead of drawing up master plans. Written, Myers says, for leaders of organisations of all kinds, from a small-group and church perspective. Its treatment of measurement, putting stories of change in place of numbers, bears most directly on how a church judges its progress.

Myers, Joseph R. *The Search to Belong: Rethinking Intimacy, Community and Small Groups*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2003.

A book on belonging, built on Edward T. Hall's four spaces: public, social, personal and intimate. Myers, writing for church leaders, argues that each is a real form of belonging, and that churches go wrong in treating intimacy as the goal and pressing everyone into small groups. His later *Organic Community* turns from the kinds of belonging to the conditions in which community forms.

Rainer, Thom S., and Eric Geiger. *Simple Church: Returning to God's Process for Making Disciples*. Nashville, TN: B&H Books, 2006.

A study of how American churches make disciples, drawn from survey research: growing churches scored higher than stagnant ones on a simple process built on clarity, movement, alignment and focus. Graham Shearer, reviewing for 9Marks, accepts the statistics but asks whether simplicity causes growth or only accompanies it, and faults the book for arguing from data rather than Scripture. The chapter on focus, on cutting programmes outside the process, would suit a new church deciding what not to start.

Sparks, Paul, Tim Soerens and Dwight J. Friesen. *The New Parish: How Neighborhood Churches Are Transforming Mission, Discipleship and Community*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Parish Church

An argument for the parish as a way of life rather than a legal boundary, set in American neighbourhoods: parish means 'all the relationships (including the land) where the local church lives out its faith together', and a neighbourhood's churches share in it. Faithful presence is its central practice. Part Three, on practice, bears most directly on a church settling into a neighbourhood.

Stanley, Andy. *Deep and Wide: Creating Churches Unchurched People Love to Attend*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Growth

An account of North Point Community Church's model by its founder, arguing that a church can be deep for believers and wide enough to draw outsiders, where most drift into serving insiders. The opening chapters, on North Point's beginnings as a plant amid his father's divorce and a church split, bear most directly on planting; the section 'Going Wide' sets out how the church reaches outsiders.

White, Dan, Jr. *Subterranean: Why the Future of the Church Is Rootedness*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2015.

ALSO IN Parish Church

An argument for congregations that stay rooted in one neighbourhood over the long term, against strategies that measure a church by its numbers, by a co-planter of Axiom Church, a network of neighbourhood communities in Syracuse, New York. It shares the case for staying in one place with Sparks, Soerens and Friesen's *The New Parish*. The first chapter, on what White calls 'the numbers leash', sets out the critique.

STORIES AND CASES

Bevins, Winfield, ed. *Global Voices: Stories of Church Planting from Around the World*. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2019.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural

A collection of eight case studies of church planting, from Jerusalem, India, Canada, England, Colombia, China, Kenya and New Zealand, edited by the director of Asbury Theological Seminary's church planting initiative. Selvaratnam's chapter, 'Reclaiming the Missing Generation', tells of G2, the plant he led in York.

Branson, Mark Lau, and Nicholas Warnes. *Starting Missional Churches: Life with God in the Neighborhood*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2014.

Case studies of seven American church plants, each chapter built around at least one interview with the pastor who started it, compiled by a pastor and a professor associated with Fuller Theological Seminary. The book frames them with the challenges common to starting a church and a five-stage account of missional change, from awareness to commitment. Where Tim Matthews's *Love Church* follows a single plant, Branson and Warnes set seven side by side.

Hope in Hard Places: Real Church Planting Stories from Around the World to Encourage You in God's Mission. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2022.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

A collection of case studies of church plants around the world, one to each chapter, published by Asbury Theological Seminary from the Global Church Planting Summit it co-hosted in 2021. Each case is offered as evidence that every context needs new local churches. Winfield Bevins's *Global Voices* is an earlier collection of planters' stories from the same seminary.

Matthews, Tim. *Love Church: Join the Adventure of Hope*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 2018.

ALSO IN Anglican

A memoir of planting St Swithun's, Bournemouth, with a team from Holy Trinity Brompton in 2014, after repeated attempts in London had come to nothing. Matthews sets the setbacks and strain beside the growth, and argues that prayer and relationships count for more than strategy or budgets. A narrative rather than a method or a study, written for planters and for anyone concerned with the health of the church in the UK.

Van de Poll, Evert, and Joanne Appleton, eds. *Church Planting in Europe: Connecting to Society, Learning from Experience*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Europe

An edited volume from the Mission in Europe Symposium held in Belgium in 2014, on planting churches in European societies shaped by secularisation, new spiritualities and a Christian heritage. Most of it is reflection and analysis; the case studies, three chapters, come last. A review on the Kouyanet blog finds Pentecostal and black majority churches thinly covered. Ron Anderson's chapter, 'Creative Church Planting Involving Lay People', bears most directly on lay leadership in planting.

Biblical and Theological Foundations

Acts of the Apostles

The Acts of the Apostles is Luke's account of how the first churches were founded, and the principal text for understanding church planting in the early church: most of the arguments in this bibliography reach back to it sooner or later. This list gathers readings of Acts, and of Paul's mission as Acts and his letters present it, for what they show about how churches begin and how that account is used now. The wider biblical theology of mission is in Missiology, and the New Testament's teaching on the church in Ecclesiology.

The modern argument starts with Roland Allen's *Missionary Methods* in 1912, which set Paul's practice in Acts against the methods of Western missions: Paul, on Allen's reading, planted churches quickly, trusted the Holy Spirit and handed them to local leaders, whereas the missions of Allen's day kept control.

The literature divides over whether Acts gives a pattern to follow. Allen, and much of the practical literature since, finds in Paul's practice a method to carry into the present. Schnabel finds steady goals but methods that changed with circumstance. Behind that question lies another, still open: what kind of book Acts is, and whether Luke wrote chiefly to record what happened or to shape how his readers would take part in mission. A commentary would be particularly helpful in weighing either question: those in this list work through Acts passage by passage, so that an episode the planting books draw on can be read in its place in Luke's narrative before a pattern is taken from it.

The entries are grouped as Start Here, Commentaries, Reading the Text, Paul's Mission, Churches in Acts and Planting from Acts Today.

START HERE

Allen, Roland. *Missionary Methods: St Paul's or Ours? A Study of the Church in the Four Provinces*. London: Robert Scott, 1912. <https://archive.org/details/missionarymethod00alle>.

ALSO IN Missiology; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Victorian Three Selves; Global and Cross-Cultural

A prophetic book from an early 20th-century missionary to China: its ideas were initially misunderstood and gained ground after Allen's death in 1947. Working from the Acts of the Apostles, he sketches how Paul reached whole regions by planting churches quickly, relying on the Holy Spirit and the training of local leaders rather than on missionary control. Much of the later literature argues either from it or with it; Caleb Greggson, in a 9Marks review, finds Allen's approach insufficient without firmer scriptural grounding but holds that readers must engage with him.

McGinnis, Daniel. *The Church's Mission in the Book of Acts: Called and Equipped for Action*. Biblical 112. Cambridge: Grove Books.

A Grove booklet by a church planter whose doctoral research was on Acts and the church's mission. Where Allen's *Missionary Methods* reads Acts for Paul's practice, the booklet reads it for Luke's purpose in writing, in relation to his Gospel, and draws out five themes for mission today. McGinnis's monograph *Missional Acts* is a separate study with its own fourfold scheme.

COMMENTARIES

There are many good commentaries on Acts, and reading it with one is the surest way in. Those here have proved useful in teaching, especially for the planting story: a place to start, not a verdict on the rest.

Fernando, Ajith. *Acts*. NIV Application Commentary. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1998.

A commentary in the NIV Application Commentary, by the teaching director, long the national director, of Youth for Christ in Sri Lanka. As throughout the series, the comment on each passage falls into Original Meaning, Bridging Contexts and Contemporary Significance, which keeps what the text meant apart from how it applies. The Bridging Contexts sections, which weigh what in a passage is timeless, would be a useful place to look on whether a practice in Acts is a pattern to follow.

González, Justo L. *Acts: The Gospel of the Spirit*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2001.

A commentary first published in Spanish as *Hechos* (1992) and reworked in English by its author, a Cuban American church historian. González reads Acts as the story of a Spirit who enables believers to live 'as citizens of that other kingdom' among the kingdoms of this world. Of the commentaries here it is the one written from a Hispanic vantage, and it draws from Acts what the Spirit's work means for wealth and poverty, for power, and for allegiance to church and state, rather than a method for mission.

Keener, Craig S. *Acts*. New Cambridge Bible Commentary. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2020.

A one-volume commentary by the author of the four-volume exegetical commentary on Acts, reading the book in its ancient setting for students and preachers. Keener holds that Luke 'encourages his audience to expect continuing preaching, church planting, signs and wonders, persecution, and the growth of the Way', which makes it a natural companion to this list's planting books.

McGinnis, Daniel. *Missional Acts: Rhetorical Narrative in the Acts of the Apostles*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2022.

ALSO IN Missiology

A monograph reading Acts through ancient rhetorical convention, on the argument that Luke tells its stories to strengthen his readers' missional commitment and practice rather than merely to record events. McGinnis sorts the material under four heads on an analogy with the body: missional stimuli, structures, strategies and suffering, the last treated as integral to mission. On whether Paul worked to a strategy, he finds that he did: Paul is Luke's archetypal missionary, and his strategy carries lessons for ministry that transforms whole regions.

Peterson, David G. *The Acts of the Apostles*. Pillar New Testament Commentary. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans; Nottingham: Apollos, 2009.

A commentary in the Pillar New Testament Commentary, written for preachers and students. It joins narrative criticism to theological analysis and attends throughout to mission, following Luke's emphasis on the word of the gospel as what brings people of different nationalities and backgrounds to faith. Peterson comments closely on evangelistic encounters such as the disciples at Ephesus (Acts 19:1–7) and the Areopagus speech (Acts 17:16–34), which he relates to addressing a secular culture. William W. Klein, reviewing it in the *Denver Journal*, finds its Reformed reading of election and baptism passes over some alternative views.

Schnabel, Eckhard J. *Acts*. Zondervan Exegetical Commentary on the New Testament. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

A commentary on the Greek text that takes the mission of the church and the expansion of early Christianity as its themes, following each passage from its structure to its theology and application. Schnabel's *Paul the Missionary*, his study of Paul's missionary practice, is also in this list.

Witherington, Ben, III. *The Acts of the Apostles: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998.

A socio-rhetorical commentary reading Acts as ancient historiography and attending to the social world of its churches, with how the church grew and developed among its major themes. Its length and detail suit a student who wants the evidence behind the claims that planting books make about Acts.

READING THE TEXT

Studies of Acts as a whole, its genre, purpose and theology, rather than comment passage by passage.

McGinnis, Daniel. *Missional Acts: Rhetorical Narrative in the Acts of the Apostles*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2022.

ANNOTATED under Commentaries

McGinnis, Daniel. *The Church's Mission in the Book of Acts: Called and Equipped for Action*. Biblical 112. Cambridge: Grove Books.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Padilla, Osvaldo. *The Acts of the Apostles: Interpretation, History and Theology*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2016.

A single-volume study of Acts for students, treating authorship, genre, historicity and theology together. Padilla classes Acts as an ancient historical monograph and Luke as a theological historian; where McGinnis's *Missional Acts* reads the narrative as rhetoric meant to strengthen missional commitment, Padilla reads it as history and theology at once. Craig L. Blomberg and Phillip J. Long, reviewing it, both single out the chapter reading the speeches against Thucydides and Polybius, and Long notes that it does not address Acts as a pattern for Christian mission.

Walton, Steve. 'The Acts of the Apostles as the Mission of God'. Public lecture, Redcliffe College, 15 May 2012. Posted by Laidlaw College. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LS82NndVF2I>.

A public lecture given at Redcliffe College in May 2012, whose announcement asked of the action plans widely used in mission, 'are they right? Who really drives mission?' By the announcement's account, Walton answers from Acts that God, not human planning, drives the mission, reading it in the light of *missio Dei*, the idea that Christians join a mission God is already carrying out. That answer runs against Allen's *Missionary Methods* and Hesselgrave's *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally*, which draw a pattern for planting from Paul's practice. The recording is posted by Laidlaw College, not by Redcliffe or Walton.

PAUL'S MISSION

Flemming, Dean. *Contextualization in the New Testament: Patterns for Theology and Mission*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2005.

ALSO IN Missiology

A study of contextualisation, the expressing of the gospel in forms fitted to each new cultural, religious and historical setting, as a practice found in the New Testament itself rather than a modern missiological invention. Fleming, a New Testament scholar and former missionary, traces it through Acts, Paul's letters, the Gospels and Revelation, and draws lessons for plural and globalised settings today. Where Schnabel's *Paul the Missionary* asks what Paul's goals and methods were, Fleming asks how the gospel took a different shape in different settings.

Pollock, John. *The Apostle: A Life of Paul*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1969.

ALSO IN Missiology

A popular narrative biography of Paul, from Stephen's martyrdom to Paul's execution, that harmonises Acts and the letters into one connected life. Where Wright's *Paul: A Biography* tests Acts against the letters, Pollock takes it as a reliable historical frame and does not ask whether it describes Paul's practice or prescribes it. Reviewers divide on his portrait of Paul: Kirkus, reviewing the first edition, called it 'dated hagiography' drawn from Acts by conjecture, while crediting its synthesis of his teaching from the letters; Tim Challies, in 2016, found it largely free of speculation.

Schnabel, Eckhard J. *Paul the Missionary: Realities, Strategies and Methods*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2008.

ALSO IN Missiology; Modality and Sodality

A study of Paul's missionary work, condensed largely from Schnabel's two-volume *Early Christian Mission* (2004), reading the New Testament for the goals Paul had and the methods he used. Schnabel finds the goals consistent and the methods situational, credits Paul's success to God's power rather than to strategy, and disputes Roland Allen's claim that Paul worked by provinces rather than cities. Robert Plummer calls it 'the new Roland Allen', stronger in biblical-theological method but without Allen's immediate application. Chapters 4 and 5, on goals and methods, bear most directly on whether Paul's practice gives a pattern to follow.

Wright, Tom. *Paul: A Biography*. London: SPCK, 2018.

ALSO IN Missiology

A biography for general readers, reconstructing Paul's life and thought within the Jewish, Greek and Roman world. Wright uses Acts critically, as one strand of evidence beside the letters, and at points goes beyond it, arguing for an imprisonment in Ephesus that Acts does not mention. Reviewers note that the narrative is shaped by his advocacy of the New Perspective on Paul. A chronological table at the end sets the letters against the events in Acts.

CHURCHES IN ACTS

Cooper, Michael T. *Ephesiology: A Study of the Ephesian Movement*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2020.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Church Planting Movements

A study of the church at Ephesus as a church planting movement, reading Acts 19 with Ephesians, 1 and 2 Timothy and Revelation 2–3; Cooper counts two-fifths of the New Testament as bearing on the city. He coins 'ephesiology' for a discipline drawing on missiology, ecclesiology and archaeology, and finds in these texts a reproducible pattern in five stages, from launching a movement to sustaining it. Appendices supply a 'Movement Action Plan' and 'Maturity Matrices' for practitioners.

Porter, Matthew. *Overflow: Learning from the Inspirational Resource Church of Antioch in the Book of Acts*. Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2020.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Church Planting Strategy

A book reading the church at Antioch in Acts 11 and 13 as a resource church, with 'not just a local but a regional vision'; Porter names seven such churches in the New Testament, Antioch his main case. He wrote it as vicar of St Michael le Belfrey in York, and draws characteristics, structures and strategies from Antioch for churches now. Each chapter closes with questions for reflection and group discussion.

Smith, E. Elbert. *Church Planting by the Book*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A study of the nine church plants in Acts, from Jerusalem to Ephesus, taken chapter by chapter for what they have in common, what is particular to each and how Scripture applies to planting now. Smith writes from 30 years with the Southern Baptist International Mission Board, where he planted churches. Argued from the text rather than set out as a manual, it draws out prayer, the Spirit's empowering, multiplication and the training of leaders.

PLANTING FROM ACTS TODAY

Allen, Roland. *Missionary Methods: St Paul's or Ours? A Study of the Church in the Four Provinces*. London: Robert Scott, 1912. <https://archive.org/details/missionarymethod00alle>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Allen, Roland. *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church and the Causes Which Hinder It*. London: World Dominion Press, 1927.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Global and Cross-Cultural; Victorian Three Selves; Modality and Sodality

A companion volume to Allen's *Missionary Methods* (1912), arguing that the church grows through the unorganised witness of ordinary members explaining the gospel they have found for themselves, and that the control missions keep over the churches they found is what hinders it. Its introduction starts from his missionary experience in China, and its instances come from Acts, among them Acts 11:19–21 and Paul's churches at Lystra and Thessalonica, left to govern, support and propagate themselves once planted. A review for Reaching and Teaching International Ministries calls the model 'reductionistic', judging that in resisting years of formal education for national pastors Allen gives up even basic theological discernment.

Cole, Neil. *Journeys to Significance: Charting a Leadership Course from the Life of Paul*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2011.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A study of Paul in the Acts of the Apostles and of how he changed his church planting methodology over time, traced through six phases of his formation as a leader, from Sovereign Foundations to the Fourth Journey and Beyond. Each phase pairs biblical observation with practical leadership application. Cole founded a church planting movement, Church Multiplication Associates. It would suit a reader inclined to treat Acts as a fixed template rather than a developing practice.

Hesselgrave, David J. *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: A Guide for Home and Foreign Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1980.

ALSO IN Missiology; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Introductions and Overviews; Global and Cross-Cultural

A missiologist's guide to planting across cultures, organised round a 10-stage Pauline Cycle drawn from Acts 13–16, which runs from missionaries commissioned to sending churches convened. A second edition, retitled *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: North America and Beyond*, followed in 2000.

Moore, Carolyn. 'At the Intersection of Acts and Galatians: New Strategies for Women Church Planters'. DMin thesis, Asbury Theological Seminary, 2018. <https://place.asburyseminary.edu/ecommonsatsdissertations/1229/>.

ALSO IN Women in Church Planting; Leadership in Church Planting

A Doctor of Ministry thesis on how women plant churches, by the founding pastor of Mosaic Church in Evans, Georgia, drawing on her 20 years in ministry to name the barriers women planters meet and ways past them. Its title pairs Acts with Galatians; in 'Biblical Women and the Spread of the Gospel', an essay for the Wesleyan Covenant Association, Moore reads Lydia in Acts 16 as evidence of women's early leadership and weighs restrictive passages through Galatians 3:28. American and Wesleyan in setting, and written for practitioners.

Ollerton, David. *Ministry on the Move: New Testament Patterns of Apostles and Apostolic Teams for Supporting Church Plants and Existing Churches*. Newid Books, 2008. <https://www.cgwww.org/books/p/fbqdy5hn1zjs26vhj6i0oiibeqyxrm>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A book on who supports a new church once it exists, and by what authority. Ollerton finds in Acts and Paul's letters two kinds of ministry, 'ministry on the spot' from local elders and 'ministry on the move' from apostolic teams, and traces the pattern through Welsh church history from the early Celtic church to today. He wrote from Cardiff as founder-chairman of Waleswide, a church planting network across Wales. It bears on oversight rather than on planting itself.

Payne, J. D. *Apostolic Church Planting: Birthing New Churches from New Believers*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A short book for planting teams, arguing from Acts that church plants begin with sharing the gospel and grow out of making disciples. Its 12 chapters run from defining planting to ethical guidelines for a plant, each closing with practical steps and principles, and its methods are meant to be carried out by ordinary team members, not only by charismatic leaders. Phillip J. Long, reviewing it, reads it as a follow-up to Payne's *Discovering Church Planting*.

Porter, Matthew. *Overflow: Learning from the Inspirational Resource Church of Antioch in the Book of Acts*. Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2020.

ANNOTATED under Churches in Acts

Shenk, David W., and Ervin R. Stutzman. *Creating Communities of the Kingdom: New Testament Models of Church Planting*. Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1988.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Practical Guides

A book on planting that works through Acts, by two Mennonite church leaders, weaving practical applications from theology, anthropology, sociology, psychology and communication theory into the biblical commentary. Of its 13 chapters, those on gospel and culture and on leadership and accountability bear most directly on a team preparing to plant. Its questions for review, study and discussion would suit a group.

Smith, E. Elbert. *Church Planting by the Book*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

ANNOTATED under Churches in Acts

Missiology

Missiology is the study of the church's mission: its theology, history and practice. A church plant is a missionary act, so this is the discipline church planting sits inside, and many of a planter's questions — who a church is for, what may change when the gospel crosses a culture, when a gathering becomes a church — are among its own. This list gathers the theology, history and practice of mission as a whole, and the places where they are joined to planting; several of mission's practices and settings, evangelism and the post-Christian West among them, also have lists of their own.

The discipline took academic form with the first chairs of mission studies in the nineteenth century. Since the 1950s it has been shaped by the idea of *missio Dei*, that mission is God's before it is the church's, which Georg Vicedom's *The Mission of God* spread through the discipline.

The principal disagreement is over what mission is, and so where planting stands within it. At one pole, the church's mission is evangelism and social responsibility held together in one task: the integral mission René Padilla argued for at the Lausanne Congress of 1974. At the other, the church's mission is chiefly evangelism and the multiplying of churches, as in Donald McGavran's theory of church growth, whose homogeneous unit principle Padilla charged with building a strategy on a sociological observation and seeking biblical warrant afterwards.

Two changes in the discipline's setting run through the books: Christianity's centre of gravity has moved to the global South and East, a shift Andrew Walls was among the first to describe and whose future course is argued over; and the West has come to be seen as a mission field in its own right, the case Lesslie Newbigin made in *Foolishness to the Greeks*.

This list runs from Start Here through The Biblical Basis of Mission, What Mission Is, The Missionary Movement in History, Crossing Cultures and World Christianity to Mission in Britain and Europe, Missional Church, Justice and Public Life, and Mission and Church Planting.

START HERE

Bosch, David J. *Transforming Mission: Paradigm Shifts in Theology of Mission*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1991.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Theory of Change

The classic textbook on mission: how mission has been understood from the New Testament through the historical paradigms of the church to the present, followed by the elements of an emerging ecumenical paradigm. It does not address church planting directly, but its analysis of church, mission and kingdom helps planters to think through their practice theologically. The sections on the developments in missionary thinking in the mid-20th century are particularly helpful: chapter 11 and the first two sections of chapter 12, whose 13 elements include mission as the church-with-others and as *missio Dei*. The twentieth-anniversary edition of 2011 adds a concluding chapter by Darrell Guder and Martin Reppenhagen.

Kirk, J. Andrew. *What Is Mission? Theological Explorations*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1999.

An introduction to the theology of mission whose central part takes seven themes, among them justice and religious pluralism. Kirk defines mission as 'what the Christian community is sent to do, beginning right where it is located'. Each chapter closes with study questions for a class or group. Andrew S. Ames Fuller, reviewing it in 2019, reads it as moving past the 20th-century division between ecumenical and evangelical approaches, but finds that it 'reads less like a basic introduction', and succeeds better as 'a provocation to theological reflection'.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Open Secret: Sketches for a Missionary Theology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans; London: SPCK, 1978.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book written from lectures Newbigin gave at Selly Oak to people preparing for missionary service. It argues that mission belongs to the church's identity, and gives a trinitarian account of it as proclaiming the kingdom of the Father, sharing the life of the Son and bearing the witness of the Spirit; the closing chapters take up justice, church growth and dialogue with other faiths. The 1995 revision adds a preface and an index under a new subtitle, *An Introduction to the Theology of Mission*.

Walls, Andrew F. *The Missionary Movement in Christian History: Studies in the Transmission of Faith*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books; Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1996.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Global and Cross-Cultural

A collection of historical essays and lectures written between 1971 and 1994, arguing that Christianity crosses cultures by translation, and that its centre of gravity moves from one region to another, each era's periphery becoming the next era's heartland. 'The Gospel as the Prisoner and Liberator of Culture' is the essay usually credited with the indigenising principle, by which the faith is at home in every culture, and the pilgrim principle, by which it is at home in none. Chapter 18, 'Missionary Societies and the Fortunate Subversion of the Church', argues that the mission societies did what the churches could not.

Wright, Christopher J. H. *The Mission of God: Unlocking the Bible's Grand Narrative*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2006.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A study in biblical theology arguing that the whole Bible is generated by God's mission and is about it, so that mission is the key to reading Scripture rather than one theme among others. It is scholarly and long; the third of its four parts, on the people of mission, bears most directly on the church. Its weight falls on the Old Testament: Michael Sweeney (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2010) judges the lighter treatment of the New deliberate, while Mike Gilbert-Smith (9Marks, 2010) finds that it understates the New Testament's discontinuity with the Old. A revised second edition (2025) adds chapters on holistic mission and on election and supersessionism.

THE BIBLICAL BASIS OF MISSION

Flemming, Dean. *Contextualization in the New Testament: Patterns for Theology and Mission*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2005.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A study of contextualisation, the expressing of the gospel in forms fitted to each new cultural, religious and historical setting, as a practice found in the New Testament itself rather than a modern missiological invention. Flemming, a New Testament scholar and former missionary, traces it through Acts, Paul's letters, the Gospels and Revelation, and draws lessons for plural and globalised settings today. Where Schnabel's *Paul the Missionary* asks what Paul's goals and methods were, Flemming asks how the gospel took a different shape in different settings.

McGinnis, Daniel. *Missional Acts: Rhetorical Narrative in the Acts of the Apostles*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2022.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A monograph reading Acts through ancient rhetorical convention, on the argument that Luke tells its stories to strengthen his readers' missional commitment and practice rather than merely to record events. McGinnis sorts the material under four heads on an analogy with the body: missional stimuli, structures, strategies and suffering, the last treated as integral to mission. On whether Paul worked to a strategy, he finds that he did: Paul is Luke's archetypal missionary, and his strategy carries lessons for ministry that transforms whole regions.

Piper, John. *Let the Nations Be Glad! The Supremacy of God in Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1993.

A book arguing that 'missions exists because worship doesn't': worship is both the goal of mission and its fuel. Piper describes it as mainly biblical reflection rather than methodological application, written for lay readers, pastors, missionaries and seminary classes alike. Chapters 4 and 5 argue against inclusivism that saving faith must consciously rest on Christ, and read 'the nations' as people groups. Robin Weekes (9Marks, 2010) finds the local church's place in mission under-treated: 'the word "church" does not appear in the book's index'. The second edition (2003) adds a chapter on worship, and the third (2010) a new introduction.

Pollock, John. *The Apostle: A Life of Paul*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1969.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A popular narrative biography of Paul, from Stephen's martyrdom to Paul's execution, that harmonises Acts and the letters into one connected life. Where Wright's *Paul: A Biography* tests Acts against the letters, Pollock takes it as a reliable historical frame and does not ask whether it describes Paul's practice or prescribes it. Reviewers divide on his portrait of Paul: Kirkus, reviewing the first edition, called it 'dated hagiography' drawn from Acts by conjecture, while crediting its synthesis of his teaching from the letters; Tim Challies, in 2016, found it largely free of speculation.

Schnabel, Eckhard J. *Paul the Missionary: Realities, Strategies and Methods*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2008.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Acts of the Apostles

A study of Paul's missionary work, condensed largely from Schnabel's two-volume *Early Christian Mission* (2004), reading the New Testament for the goals Paul had and the methods he used. Schnabel finds the goals consistent and the methods situational, credits Paul's success to God's power rather than to strategy, and disputes Roland Allen's claim that Paul worked by provinces rather than cities. Robert Plummer calls it 'the new Roland Allen', stronger in biblical-theological method but without Allen's immediate application. Chapters 4 and 5, on goals and methods, bear most directly on whether Paul's practice gives a pattern to follow.

Wright, Christopher J. H. *The Mission of God's People: A Biblical Theology of the Church's Mission*. Biblical Theology for Life. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2010.

The first volume in Zondervan's Biblical Theology for Life series, written for pastors, teachers and lay readers: a biblical theology of the church's mission, working out for the church's practice the case made in Wright's longer *The Mission of God* (2006). It widens mission beyond cross-cultural 'missions' to such callings as care for creation and blessing the nations. Bobby Jamieson (9Marks, 2010) objects that Wright declines to give evangelism priority within the church's mission.

Wright, Christopher J. H. *The Mission of God: Unlocking the Bible's Grand Narrative*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2006.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Wright, Tom. *Paul: A Biography*. London: SPCK, 2018.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A biography for general readers, reconstructing Paul's life and thought within the Jewish, Greek and Roman world. Wright uses Acts critically, as one strand of evidence beside the letters, and at points goes beyond it, arguing for an imprisonment in Ephesus that Acts does not mention. Reviewers note that the narrative is shaped by his advocacy of the New Perspective on Paul. A chronological table at the end sets the letters against the events in Acts.

Wright, Tom. *Surprised by Hope*. London: SPCK, 2007.

A book for general readers, companion to Wright's scholarly *The Resurrection of the Son of God* (2003), arguing that the New Testament hope is bodily resurrection into a renewed heaven and earth, not souls going to heaven, and that what Christians believe about life after death shapes what they believe about life before it. Part III, 'Hope in Practice', holds justice, beauty and evangelism together rather than setting saving souls against doing good. Reviewers divide over that move: Barry Seagren (*Evangelicals Now*, 2008) values the book for grounding justice and environmental concern in Christian hope, while Kim Riddlebarger (*Modern Reformation*, 2010) calls Part III 'boorish moralizing'.

WHAT MISSION IS

Second Vatican Council. *Ad Gentes: Decree on the Mission Activity of the Church*. Rome, 7 December 1965.

https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_decree_19651207_ad-gentes_en.html.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Ecclesiology; Church Planting Movements

A document of the Second Vatican Council, its decree on the church's missionary activity, promulgated by Pope Paul VI on 7 December 1965: the first time an ecumenical council treated the missions as a subject in their own right. It grounds mission in the sending of the Son and the Spirit, so that the church is 'missionary by her very nature'. Chapter 2, on witness, preaching and the forming of a Christian community, and chapter 3, on the particular churches, their laity and their theological adaptation, bear most directly on planting.

Baker, Jonny, and Cathy Ross. *Imagining Mission with John V. Taylor*. London: SCM Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Pioneering

A book by two teachers on the Church Mission Society's pioneer training that thinks with John V. Taylor about church, mission and society now, rather than writing his history. It is drawn from the travel diaries and monthly newsletters Taylor wrote as the Society's General Secretary from 1963 to 1974, and works with his 'immersion, imagination and improvisation'; each chapter closes with practical questions.

Bevans, Stephen B., and Roger P. Schroeder. *Constants in Context: A Theology of Mission for Today*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2004.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic

A book on the theology of mission by two Catholic missiologists, and a companion piece to Bosch's *Transforming Mission*: like Bosch, it moves from key biblical texts to the approaches to mission taken across church history, and reviewers set the two side by side, Steve Hayes reading it as doing for Catholic missiology what Bosch did for Protestant. Ecumenical in range, it draws on Catholic, Protestant, Orthodox and Pentecostal approaches. It does not deal directly with church planting, though it gives planters a theological framework; Warrick Farah finds that its contextual emphasis undervalues conversion and church planting in unreached areas. Part III sets out the authors' own proposal, mission as 'prophetic dialogue'.

Francis, Pope. *Evangelii Gaudium: The Joy of the Gospel; Apostolic Exhortation on the Proclamation of the Gospel in Today's World*. London: Catholic Truth Society, 2013.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic

A papal document, the apostolic exhortation Francis signed on 24 November 2013. It calls for a church that goes out rather than stays enclosed, one 'bruised, hurting and dirty because it has been out on the streets' (§49), and gives a chapter to the social dimension of evangelisation. *Ad Gentes* (1965) called the church missionary by its very nature; this document asks for its 'missionary transformation'. Kirsteen Kim (*International Review of Mission*, 2015) finds in it and the World Council of Churches' *Together towards Life* (2013) a shared, holistic understanding of mission. Chapter 1, on that transformation, bears most directly on planting.

Hirsch, Alan, and Mark Nelson. *Reframation: Seeing God, People, and Mission Through Reenchanted Frames*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2019.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity

A book calling Christians to 'reframe and reenchanted' a worldview that Hirsch and Nelson find 'starved of imagination, wary of paradox, and devoid of mystery', to help them articulate the gospel for contemporary culture. It argues from poetry, literature, the arts, philosophy and popular culture alongside Scripture, and is a work of re-enchantment rather than of method. The first chapter, 'Moving the Moon', sets out its diagnosis, 'the great reduction': truth broken into parts, each mistaken for the whole.

Kirk, J. Andrew. *What Is Mission? Theological Explorations*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1999.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Kraemer, Hendrik. *The Christian Message in a Non-Christian World*. London: Edinburgh House Press, 1938. <https://archive.org/details/in.ernet.dli.2015.1168>.

A book commissioned by the International Missionary Council as the preparatory study for its conference at Tambaram, Madras, in December 1938, and written against William Hocking's *Rethinking Missions*, the report of the American Laymen's Inquiry, which had argued for a more cooperative stance towards other faiths. Drawing on Barth, Kraemer's 'biblical realism' sets divine revelation in fundamental discontinuity with human religion, the position later called exclusivism. Ramachandra's *The Recovery of Mission* (1996) makes a later evangelical case against pluralism, from Asia.

McGavran, Donald A. *Understanding Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle; Church Growth; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

The fuller statement of the church growth theory Donald McGavran first argued in *The Bridges of God* (1955), resting on J. Waskom Pickett's research into the Indian mass movements. It is the source of the much-quoted sentence about people becoming Christians without crossing racial, linguistic or class barriers, and the book the debate over church growth and the homogeneous unit principle is about. The revised edition of 1980 adds three chapters on the principle; the third, of 1990, revised by C. Peter Wagner, turns church growth from a chief purpose of mission into the chief one.

Niles, Daniel Thambyrajah. *Upon the Earth: The Mission of God and the Missionary Enterprise of the Churches*. London: Lutterworth Press, 1962.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Ecclesiology

A study of the relation between God's mission, the Church and the missionary enterprise, written from the perspective of a Christian leader from Sri Lanka. It is not a book about church planting, and its concern is theological rather than practical: an ecclesiology of mission in which the Church's existence is bound up with God's missionary purpose. Harold Lindsell (*Christianity Today*, 1963) reads it as implying universal salvation, that all people are already 'in Christ' whether they know it or not.

Ott, Craig, ed. *The Mission of the Church: Five Views in Conversation*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

An edited volume that puts one question — what is the mission of the church? — to five scholars from different Christian traditions, each stating a position and then responding to the other four. Stephen Bevans argues a Roman Catholic 'prophetic dialogue' approach and Darrell Guder a 'multicultural and translational approach', the latter filed separately in this bibliography as a chapter in its own right. Written for seminarians and church leaders, and designed for classroom use.

Padilla, C. René. *Mission Between the Times: Essays on the Kingdom*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1985.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Latin America

A collection of essays by the Latin American evangelical who argued at Lausanne in 1974 for integral mission (*misión integral*): evangelism and social responsibility as one task. It is the source of the underlying objection to church growth theory, of which McGavran's three kinds of growth (biological, transfer and conversion) are part: that it begins with sociological observation and looks for biblical warrant afterwards. Its essay 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle' answers McGavran's *Understanding Church Growth* directly and would make a useful pair with it; the Langham revision (2010), where the essay is chapter 8, adds one on integral mission's later history.

Peters, George W. *A Biblical Theology of Missions*. Chicago: Moody Press, 1972.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

An evangelical treatment of mission, written while Peters headed the missions department at Dallas Theological Seminary. It holds that God is a missionary God, and its publisher names the centrality of the local church among its concerns. Peter Hamm (*Direction*, 1977) finds its distinction between the cultural and the spiritual mandate possibly too sharp, and its treatment of other religions meagre. For the relation between the church and mission structures, the section on the church and missions in Part II would be a useful place to look.

Ramachandra, Vinoth. *The Recovery of Mission: Beyond the Pluralist Paradigm*. Carlisle: Paternoster, 1996.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Global and Cross-Cultural

An evangelical critique, written from Sri Lanka, of religious pluralism as a theological programme, made through three Asian exponents, Stanley Samartha, Aloysius Pieris and Raimundo Panikkar, with a chapter on each. Drawing on Lesslie Newbigin's account of mission, Ramachandra argues from biblical, patristic and contemporary theology for the decisiveness of what God has done in Christ. It closes with proposals, addressed to pluralists and conservative Christians alike, for communicating the gospel in a multifaith world.

Spencer, Stephen. *Types of Christian Mission: An Introduction*. London: SCM Press, 2025.

An introductory textbook on contemporary missiology, setting out its challenges, debates and contexts for students, by the Anglican Communion Office's Director for Theology and Implementation in theological education. Published in 2025, it is the most recent of the introductions to mission in this part of the list.

Stott, John, and Christopher J. H. Wright. *Christian Mission in the Modern World*. Updated ed. Downers Grove, IL: IVP, 2015.

An updated edition of Stott's book of 1975, drawn from his address to the Lausanne Congress on World Evangelization (1974) and his Chavasse Lectures in Oxford (1975). Stott's five chapters each define one term, from mission to conversion; Christopher Wright adds a chapter after each, reflecting on developments since the 1970s and at points differing from Stott. The book holds evangelism and social action together as partners in mission, and George P. Wood reads it as giving evangelism priority. Reviewing the earlier text, Wood finds that it treats mission as a matter for individual Christians rather than for the church as its agent.

Tippett, Alan R. *Verdict Theology in Missionary Theory*. Lincoln, IL: Lincoln Christian College Press, 1969.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves

A book of addresses prepared for a missionary week at Lincoln Christian College in 1969. Tippett argues that the three selves of Venn and Anderson are not enough, and proposes six: self-image, self-functioning, self-determining, self-supporting, self-propagating and self-giving. They came 16 years before Hiebert made the case for a fourth self, self-theologising, in *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries* (1985), so his was not the first attempt to say what the three had left out. The enlarged second edition (William Carey Library, 1973) includes a discussion of functional substitutes, the Christian forms that take over the social functions of customs converts give up.

Van Engen, Charles. *God's Missionary People: Rethinking the Purpose of the Local Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1991.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A study of the local congregation as the primary agent of mission and not its support base: in Van Engen's words, 'by very nature a missionary people – founded *by* mission and existing *for* mission'. He argues from Ephesians and from the church's history before turning to the congregation's purpose, goals, members, leaders and administration; Arthur Glasser's foreword presents the local church as a neglected key to missiological reflection. A 2007 review on the blog *Exagorazo* finds that it stays 'at the vision level' rather than giving detailed practical advice.

Vicedom, Georg F. *The Mission of God: An Introduction to a Theology of Mission*. Translated by Gilbert A. Thiele and Dennis Hilgendorf. St Louis, MO: Concordia, 1965.

A translation of *Missio Dei* (1958), in which a German Lutheran missiologist grounds mission in God's own sending: mission is not one activity of the church among others but constitutive of it, and the church, 'placed completely on the side of God' and 'fully directed to the world', is the instrument through which God's mission is carried out. The St Andrews Encyclopaedia of Theology dates the currency of *missio Dei* in missiology from this book, which developed theologically the language taken up at the International Missionary Council's Willingen conference (1952), though Vicedom did not coin the term.

THE MISSIONARY MOVEMENT IN HISTORY

Allen, Roland. *Missionary Methods: St Paul's or Ours? A Study of the Church in the Four Provinces*. London: Robert Scott, 1912. <https://archive.org/details/missionarymethod00alle>.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Victorian Three Selves; Global and Cross-Cultural

A prophetic book from an early 20th-century missionary to China: its ideas were initially misunderstood and gained ground after Allen's death in 1947. Working from the Acts of the Apostles, he sketches how Paul reached whole regions by planting churches quickly, relying on the Holy Spirit and the training of local leaders rather than on missionary control. Much of the later literature argues either from it or with it; Caleb Greggson, in a 9Marks review, finds Allen's approach insufficient without firmer scriptural grounding but holds that readers must engage with him.

Anderson, Rufus. *To Advance the Gospel: Selections from the Writings of Rufus Anderson*. Edited by R. Pierce Beaver. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1967.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves

A collection of the writings of Rufus Anderson, secretary and chief policymaker of the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions from 1832 to 1866, and the American half of the pair who set out the three selves. His concern is the same as Henry Venn's, and reached independently: that a mission which does not plan its own ending is not building a church but a dependency. Where he differs is in a sharper separation of the gospel from civilisation, which he held would follow the gospel rather than be an aim of mission.

Bede. *Ecclesiastical History of the English People*. Completed 731. Translated by Leo Sherley-Price, revised by R. E. Latham, with an introduction and notes by D. H. Farmer. London: Penguin Classics, 1990. Also free online in A. M. Sellar's older translation at <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/38326/38326-h/38326-h.html>.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Church Planting Movements

A primary text, completed by Bede at Jarrow in 731 and dedicated to King Ceolwulf of Northumbria, and the principal source for how England was evangelised. It is organised around the conversion of successive kingdoms and their rulers, and says little about missionary work among ordinary people. Book I includes Augustine's mission from Rome, and Book III Aidan's mission from Iona and the Synod of Whitby (664), which settled the dispute between Roman and Irish practice, chiefly over the date of Easter; the two books would be a good starting point for comparing the missions.

Evans, Eifion. 'Calvin's Influence on Mission'. *Foundations*, no. 48 (May 2002): 4-15. https://www.affinity.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/08/48_04.pdf.

ALSO IN Presbyterian and Reformed

An article by the Welsh Presbyterian minister and church historian Eifion Evans, answering the view that Calvin had no interest in mission. Much of it concerns Geneva's training of pastors and their sending into France, where, in Ronald Wallace's words, Calvin regarded each small group of believers as 'the nucleus of a congregation'. It relies on Philip Hughes for a count of 88 men named in the register of Geneva's Company of Pastors as sent out between 1555 and 1562.

Finney, John. *Recovering the Past: Celtic and Roman Mission*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1996.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Evangelism

A book setting the Celtic mission to England from Iona and Lindisfarne beside Augustine's mission from Rome: a comparative account of the two missions Bede narrates, reaching back to Patrick and Pelagius. Finney wrote it as bishop of Pontefract, after serving as the Church of England's officer for the Decade of Evangelism.

Jongeneel, J. A. B. 'The Missiology of Gisbertus Voetius: The First Comprehensive Protestant Theology of Missions'. *Calvin Theological Journal* 26, no. 1 (1991): 47-79.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works

An article arguing, as its subtitle states, that Gisbertus Voetius (1589-1676), the Dutch Reformed theologian, produced the first comprehensive Protestant theology of missions, within Reformed scholasticism and well before the missionary-society movement. It gives this bibliography an early systematic account of mission theology, distinct from the practical and biblical treatments most other entries offer.

McGavran, Donald A. *Understanding Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970.

ANNOTATED under What Mission Is

Neill, Stephen. *A History of Christian Missions*. Pelican History of the Church 6. Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, 1964.

A one-volume narrative history of Christian missions from the New Testament to the early 1960s, by a former Anglican bishop in south India. It traces the expansion period by period, attending to how alliances of church and state produced superficial conversions and to the establishment of indigenous churches, and is a history rather than a theology of mission. The second edition (1986) was revised by Owen Chadwick, who by one account wrote its final two chapters; G. Wright Doyle, reviewing it, notes that it predates most of the southward shift of Christianity's centre of gravity.

Nevius, John L. *The Planting and Development of Missionary Churches*. Shanghai: Presbyterian Press, 1886.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Asia and the Middle East; Victorian Three Selves; Presbyterian and Reformed

A primary text of the 19th-century missionary movement, first written in 1885 as articles for the *Chinese Recorder* and published as a book in 1886. Against paying local evangelists and pastors from mission funds, Nevius argues for churches that are self-supporting, self-governing and self-propagating, whose members keep their own occupations and call pastors when they can support them. The source of what came to be called the Nevius method, it was adopted by Presbyterian missionaries in Korea; the *Biographical Dictionary of Chinese Christianity* records that it and Nevius's *Methods of Mission Work* became required reading for most Presbyterian missionaries to China and Korea for over 50 years. The 1899 New York printing is digitised by the Internet Archive.

Sanneh, Lamin. *Whose Religion Is Christianity? The Gospel beyond the West*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Africa

A short book in question-and-answer form, in which Lamin Sanneh, a Gambian-born historian and convert from Islam, puts to himself some 115 questions a sceptical Western reader might ask about Christianity's growth beyond the West. His answer is translation: Christianity has no revealed language, and rendering the scriptures in a vernacular dignifies the culture receiving them, so that translation, rather than Western missionary agency, is the deeper cause of the faith's spread. It restates in shorter form the argument of his *Translating the Message* (1989).

Venn, Henry. *To Apply the Gospel: Selections from the Writings of Henry Venn*. Edited by Max Warren. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1971.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves

A collection of the writings of Henry Venn, honorary secretary of the Church Missionary Society from 1841, edited and introduced by Max Warren, the society's general secretary from 1942 to 1963. It is the way into Venn's own words: the minutes and papers in which the three selves are set out, and in which 'the euthanasia of a mission' appears.

Wagner, C. Peter, ed. *Church/Mission Tensions Today*. Chicago: Moody Press, 1972.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

An edited volume from the Green Lake conference of 1971, where North American mission agencies were being asked whether they existed because congregations had failed in their responsibility, or by design; this volume is where the question was put. Its 12 chapters, by mission executives who took part, include Jack Shepherd's on the nature of the church and Winter's contribution to the argument, 'The Planting of Younger Missions', and show the dispute behind the two-structure thesis in concrete terms. Hans Kasdorf (*Direction*, 1973) notes that no contributor is from a non-Western church, and that the volume defines mission too narrowly, as evangelism.

Walls, Andrew F. *The Missionary Movement in Christian History: Studies in the Transmission of Faith*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books; Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1996.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Winter, Ralph D. 'Protestant Mission Societies: The American Experience'. *Missiology: An International Review* 7, no. 2 (1979): 139-78. <https://rdwrc.wciu.edu/wp-content/uploads/2023/07/Protestant-Mission-Societies-by-RDW-1979.pdf>.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

An article making the historical case for the two structures at greater length: Protestant mission societies set against Catholic religious orders, and the provocation, borrowed from the historian Kenneth Scott Latourette, that Methodist circuit riders effectively kept Catholic vows. A useful place to look if the 1974 essay's compression leaves the argument looking thinner than it is.

Winter, Ralph D. 'The Anatomy of the Christian Mission'. *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* 5, no. 1 (1969): 74-89.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

An article, Winter's first published treatment of church and mission structures, written before he had the modality and sodality vocabulary of 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission' (1974). Useful for showing that the terms were a later formalisation of an argument he was already making about mission agencies in North America.

Winter, Ralph D. 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission'. *Missiology* 2, no. 1 (January 1974): 121-39. <https://doi.org/10.1177/009182967400200109>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Modality and Sodality

An article, first given as an address to the All-Asia Mission Consultation in Seoul in 1973, tracing two structures from the New Testament through medieval monasticism to the Protestant mission societies: the modality, the congregation to which everyone belongs, and the sodality, the mission band or order that people join for a purpose. Winter argues that both are 'legitimate and necessary' parts of the church, and that non-Western churches need sodalities of their own. Mark Vanderwerf (*Global Missiology*, 2011) surveys the objections to it.

CROSSING CULTURES

Crider, Caleb, Larry McCrary, Rodney Calfee and Wade Stephens. *Tradecraft: For the Church on Mission*. Portland, OR: Urban Loft Publishers, 2013.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

A manual of missionary skills for ordinary Christians, adapting the cross-cultural tools once reserved for full-time missionaries. It is written for Western churches that have accepted the 'why' of mission but are unsure of the 'how', and teaches nine skills, from mapping a place and exegeting its culture to contextualisation and protecting indigeneity.

Donovan, Vincent J. *Christianity Rediscovered: An Epistle from the Masai*. Notre Dame, IN: Fides/Claretian, 1978.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Pioneering; Africa; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book of narrative and reflection by an American Catholic missionary priest who, influenced by Roland Allen, gave up the school-based method in northern Tanzania and took the gospel directly to the Maasai. It asks what the gospel is when stripped of the Western forms that usually carry it. Samuel K. Elolia (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) contests its conclusion that missionaries are no longer needed, pointing to the growth of Christianity in Africa. The Orbis 25th anniversary edition (2003) adds essays by Lamin Sanneh and Eugene Hillman.

Hesselgrave, David J. *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: A Guide for Home and Foreign Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1980.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Introductions and Overviews; Global and Cross-Cultural; Acts of the Apostles

A missiologist's guide to planting across cultures, organised round a 10-stage Pauline Cycle drawn from Acts 13–16, which runs from missionaries commissioned to sending churches convened. A second edition, retitled *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: North America and Beyond*, followed in 2000.

Hiebert, Paul G. 'Critical Contextualization'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 11, no. 3 (1987): 104-12.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

An article proposing 'critical contextualization': a four-step method — studying the culture, exegeting Scripture, evaluating the practice critically against it, then shaping a new Christian practice — that steers between rejecting local custom outright and accepting it uncritically. Distinct from Hiebert's 1978 article on bounded and centred sets, it gives the method his 1985 and 1994 books, both already in this bibliography, apply and develop further.

Hiebert, Paul G. 'Critical Contextualization'. *Missiology: An International Review* 12, no. 3 (1984): 287–96.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

The article in which Hiebert first proposed critical contextualization, asking what people should do with their past customs when they become Christians. He surveys how missions have answered, from rejecting old customs outright to accepting them wholesale at the risk of syncretism, and sets out a third way, in which a community weighs its own practices against Scripture, with the steps in outline. His 1987 article of the same title is the fuller statement, adding a history of missionary practice and giving the method its four named steps.

Hiebert, Paul G. *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1985.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves; Global and Cross-Cultural

An introduction to anthropology for missionaries, arguing that the gospel must be incarnated in each culture while transforming it. The section 'The Fourth Self' makes the case for self-theologising: theological dependence is the deepest dependence of all, and a church which receives its theology ready-made has not yet been handed over. Rochelle Cathcart Scheuermann (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) faults its functionalist anthropology for treating cultures as bounded entities. Hiebert's article 'Critical Contextualization' (*International Bulletin of Missionary Research*, 1987) supplies the method that keeps the fourth self from collapsing into syncretism.

Kraft, Charles H. *Anthropology for Christian Witness*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1996.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural

A basic introduction to the study of anthropology for those planning careers in mission or cross-cultural ministry. Drawn from what Kraft taught at Fuller's School of World Mission, it covers theories of culture and society, the anthropological schools, kinship and cross-cultural communication. Hiebert's *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries*, by contrast, gives whole sections to the missionary's culture shock and bicultural identity.

Moon, W. Jay, and W. Bud Simon. *Effective Intercultural Evangelism: Good News in a Diverse World*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2021.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Evangelism

A book on evangelism across four worldviews: guilt and justice, shame and honour, fear and power, indifference and belonging. 'Intercultural' in its title means across these worldviews, not within the multi-ethnic congregation. Moon and Simon argue that the guilt-and-justice framing most Western presentations assume is one starting point among several, and often not the one in front of the speaker; the fourth worldview addresses secular younger generations in North America. Each chapter includes exercises for groups or individuals.

Moon, W. Jay. *Missional Imagination: Preparation for Kingdom Innovation*. American Society of Missiology Series. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book arguing that Christian ministry has been shaped by a 'dominant social paradigm' that separates sacred from secular, private from public and transcendent from immanent, and that missional imagination, a way of seeing and acting that refuses those separations, is where innovation in mission begins. Drawing on Moon's missionary work in Ghana and congregational ministry in the United States, it sets out practices for discipleship and mission as well as for evangelism, the subject of Moon and Simon's *Effective Intercultural Evangelism*.

WORLD CHRISTIANITY

Bediako, Kwame. *Christianity in Africa: The Renewal of a Non-Western Religion*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press; Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1995.

ALSO IN Africa

A monograph by a Ghanaian theologian arguing that African Christianity is not a foreign religion needing to be Africanised but a renewal of the faith on African terms, continuous with Africa's pre-Christian religious past. Bediako rejects the choice between Christian and African that earlier African theologians accepted, and traces the question through Edward Blyden in the 19th century and the neo-traditional Afrikania movement. He studied under Andrew Walls, and a Reformed Theological Seminary missions course sets part of the book beside Walls on the transmission of faith across cultures.

Chan, Simon. *Grassroots Asian Theology: Thinking the Faith from the Ground Up*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2014.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Pentecostal

An argument by a Singaporean Pentecostal theologian that Asian theology has been dominated by an academic elite and should be read instead from what ordinary Asian Christians believe and practise. Like Tennent's *Theology in the Context of World Christianity* it follows the doctrinal loci, but fills them from popular and Pentecostal faith: honour and shame for sin and salvation, the family as a model for the Trinity and the church. Alexander Chow, reviewing it, finds the line between elite and grassroots drawn too cleanly, and Ruth Benedict's 'shame culture' thesis used uncritically.

Escobar, Samuel. *The New Global Mission: The Gospel from Everywhere to Everyone*. Christian Doctrine in Global Perspective. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2003.

ALSO IN Latin America; Global and Cross-Cultural

A short book by a Peruvian Baptist arguing that mission is no longer a Western enterprise but the task of a global church, now growing faster in Latin America, Africa and parts of Asia than in the West. Escobar sat on the drafting committee of the Lausanne Covenant (1974) and is credited, with René Padilla, with shaping integral mission; the book faults the paternalism of Western mission agencies. Three of its chapters follow the Trinity: the Father as sender, Christ as the model missionary, the Spirit as director of mission.

Jenkins, Philip. *The Next Christendom: The Coming of Global Christianity*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2002.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

A historian's account, for a general readership, of Christianity's centre of gravity moving to Africa, Latin America and Asia, where the typical Christian is now 'a woman living in a village in Nigeria or in a Brazilian favela' and the churches are more supernaturalist, morally conservative and Pentecostal than the North's. Walls's *The Missionary Movement in Christian History* traces that shift through history; Jenkins gives it in numbers, projected to 2050. D. G. Hart (*Modern Reformation*) argues that growth by conversion makes those projections much less predictable than Jenkins assumes. Revised editions followed in 2007 and 2011.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Multicultural Kingdom: Ethnic Diversity, Mission and the Church*. London: SCM Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Africa

A book by a Malawian missiologist based in Britain, arguing that the church is by nature a multicultural mosaic, an image he takes from his mother, while British churches of different ethnic heritage often share a building but not a service. His *Sent Forth* (2014) studies African mission to the West; this book addresses British churches and argues for a multicultural missiology. Its final section asks how a church's membership, leadership and worship should reflect that diversity. Walter McConnell (*Mission Round Table*, 2023) finds that its history of mission starts at William Carey and that some of its statistics are inaccurate.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Sent Forth: African Missionary Work in the West*. American Society of Missiology Series 51. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Africa; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book by a Malawian scholar and pastor arguing that African Christianity has carried a missionary impulse since the early church and now brings it to the West. Its organising idea is the 'blessed reflex': that the continuing evangelisation of the world will need, and profit from, the energies of African churches, so that mission now runs towards the West as well as from it. Written for scholars, pastors and congregational leaders, and for African Christians engaged in mission in Western contexts.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Mission-Shaped Church in a Multicultural World*. Mission and Evangelism 118. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2017.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural

A Grove booklet arguing that growing ethnic diversity in British Christianity will make race a central question for mission this century, and urging majority-culture congregations to build real relationships with the immigrant and majority-world Christians already worshipping among them. *Sent Forth* (2014) studies African mission to the West at large, and *Multicultural Kingdom* (2020) sets out a fuller multicultural missiology for Britain; this booklet compresses a similar argument into a short, parish-level statement, written for a general church readership rather than students.

Padilla, C. René. *Mission Between the Times: Essays on the Kingdom*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1985.

ANNOTATED under What Mission Is

Tennent, Timothy C. *Theology in the Context of World Christianity: How the Global Church Is Influencing the Way We Think about and Discuss Theology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2007.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

A textbook of systematic theology, with chapter bibliographies and a glossary, that pairs doctrines with non-Western contexts, setting the Western, chiefly evangelical, treatment beside majority-world readings and arguing that the faith is theologically as well as culturally translatable. J. Scott Horrell (*DTS Voice*) finds those readings filtered through Tennent's own lens rather than quoted from the theologians themselves. Chapter 5, on African Christology, which Joseph Greer singles out for its range of majority-world voices, would be a good place to start.

MISSION IN BRITAIN AND EUROPE

Davison, Andrew, Anna Matthews, Alison Milbank, Philip North, Gemma Simmonds, Ric Thorpe and Rowan Williams. *God's Church in the World: The Gift of Catholic Mission*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Parish Church

A collection on Catholic mission and evangelism whose contributors include Alison Milbank, co-author with Andrew Davison of *For the Parish* (2010), a critique of fresh expressions, and Ric Thorpe, a leading figure in the Church of England's resource church strategy as Bishop of Islington. It brings writers from opposite sides of that church's argument over planting into one volume.

Fraser, Liam Jerrold. *Mission in Contemporary Scotland*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2021.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A study of Christian mission in Scotland by Liam Jerrold Fraser, then minister of St Michael's, Linlithgow. Its publisher presents it as 'practical guidance to church leaders engaged in Fresh Expressions and church planting in a Scottish context'; the reviewer in *Life and Work* read it as 'a two-way dialogue' rather than a guide to method.

Morisy, Ann. *Journeying Out: A New Approach to Christian Mission*. London: Continuum, 2006.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

A book arguing that the community work British churches took on as the welfare state contracted is part of their mission, not a preliminary to it, and that they should offer the chance of spiritual transformation as well as material help. Morisy writes as a community theologian, working across sociology and theology. It first appeared in 2004.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *Foolishness to the Greeks: The Gospel and Western Culture*. London: SPCK, 1986.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A book expanded from Newbigin's Warfield Lectures at Princeton Theological Seminary in March 1984. It asks what a missionary encounter between the gospel and modern Western culture would require, and treats the West as a mission field needing the cross-cultural care that missionaries bring to any other culture.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*. London: SPCK, 1989.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Theory of Change

A book on the gospel and Western culture by a missionary theologian who returned from long service in India to the English Midlands and found it the more challenging environment. Newbigin argues that splitting facts from values leaves Christian claims counted as private preference, and concludes that the local congregation is the ultimate hermeneutic of the gospel; chapter 18, 'The Congregation as Hermeneutic of the Gospel', would be a good place to meet the idea inside its own argument.

Newbiggin, Lesslie. *Truth to Tell: The Gospel as Public Truth*. London: SPCK, 1991.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

Three lectures, given as the 1990 Osterhaven Lectures at Western Theological Seminary in Holland, Michigan, arguing that the gospel is a claim to true knowledge with a place in public life, not a private preference or a set of values. Newbiggin draws on Michael Polanyi to argue against relativism and fundamentalism alike. The book is the shorter form of the argument of *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society* (1989).

Paas, Stefan. *Pilgrims and Priests: Christian Mission in a Post-Christian Society*. London: SCM Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A book, written from the Netherlands, on what a small Christian community is for in a society where it will not become large. Paas argues that the Western church should stop expecting Christendom to return and read its situation through Israel's exile and 1 Peter, with two images: Christians as pilgrims, strangers without institutional power, and as priests, mediating between God and their culture. He sets aside church growth, revival and transformation models as rooted in Christendom; Benjamin Espinoza (*Evangelical Missions Quarterly*, 2020) notes the cost, an expectation of a few converts rather than rapid growth.

Robinson, Martin. *Planting Mission-Shaped Churches Today*. Oxford: Monarch Books, 2006.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Fresh Expressions of Church

A book on planting new churches in the West, illustrated with dozens of examples, by a Churches of Christ minister who had led a plant in inner-city Birmingham. It is a different book from *Planting Tomorrow's Churches Today* (1992), the handbook Robinson wrote with Stuart Christine.

Snow, Martyn, ed. *Anglican Evangelists: Identifying and Training a New Generation*. London: SPCK, 2019.

ALSO IN Anglican; Evangelism; Formation and Training

An edited collection by 13 contributors from different traditions in the Church of England, published for the twentieth anniversary of the Archbishops' College of Evangelists and its relaunch. It sets aside evangelistic method for the calling and gifts of the evangelist, asking what an evangelist is and how the church should recognise and train one, so that evangelists can equip all Christians for witness.

Wakefield, Gavin, and Nigel Rooms, eds. *Northern Gospel, Northern Church: Reflections on Identity and Mission*. Durham: Sacristy Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

An edited collection asking whether there is a distinctively northern way of proclaiming the gospel, and whether the North of England is coherent enough, culturally and theologically, to warrant ministry shaped to the region when the gospel's claim is universal. Its 16 contributors, practitioners and academics, write from settings as different as housing estates and cathedrals.

Wakefield, Gavin. 'Mission in the Spirit: Revivalist and Celtic Strands of Mission'. *Anvil* 18, no. 1 (2001): 7-19. https://biblicalstudies.org.uk/pdf/anvil/18-1_007.pdf.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission

An article comparing the theologies of mission of two Anglican charismatics, Mark Stibbe and Ray Simpson, which turn out to have almost nothing in common. Stibbe's is revivalist, driven by a burden for the lost and an implicitly penal account of the atonement; Simpson's is Celtic, motivated by love for God and creation. Wakefield tests both against the Five Marks of Mission and finds each underpowered on the origin of mission in God.

Warren, Robert. *Being Human, Being Church: Spirituality and Mission in the Local Church*. London: Marshall Pickering, 1995.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Anglican; Missional Spirituality

A book arguing that the inherited church's structure casts the congregation as clients of a provider and so keeps its members passive, and that a local church becomes missionary through its spirituality and shared life. Warren compares the emerging church he anticipates with the Celtic church of the past.

Warren, Robert. *Building Missionary Congregations: Towards a Post-Modern Way of Being Church*. Board of Mission Occasional Paper 4. London: Church House Publishing, 1995.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Church of England Papers and Reports; Anglican

A Board of Mission occasional paper by the Church of England's National Officer for Evangelism, on how the church could move from a pastoral to a missionary mode, arguing that this needs to be the main focus of the second half of the Decade of Evangelism. *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004) cites its account of church life as worship, community and mission, which Warren drew as three overlapping circles, and traces 'emerging church' to this paper and to his *Being Human, Being Church* (1995).

Waddell, David. 'The Evolution of Missionary Congregations'. *International Review of Mission* 66, no. 264 (October 1977): 366-72.

ALSO IN Parish Church

An article in the World Council of Churches' *International Review of Mission* by the Church of England priest who founded the Urban Church Project. Unlike his *Let My People Grow!* (1974) and *Divide and Conquer* (1975), which the project published, it appeared in an international journal of mission.

MISSIONAL CHURCH

The missional church conversation, North American and Australian in the main; its British counterpart is under Mission in Britain and Europe.

Bolger, Ryan K., ed. *The Gospel after Christendom: New Voices, New Cultures, New Expressions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Fresh Expressions of Church; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

An edited volume that widens the largely Anglo-American scope of Gibbs and Bolger's *Emerging Churches* (2005) to churches that have grown up after Christendom on several continents. Bolger put questions about the shifts facing the Western church to 137 scholar-practitioners and built the book from the 76 who replied, in five parts, with contributors commenting on one another's chapters in text boxes. Reviewing it, Kevin Book-Satterlee finds themes repeated, especially in the European material.

Burger, Coenie, Frederick Marais and Danie Mouton, eds. *Cultivating Missional Change: The Future of Missional Churches and Missional Theology*. Wellington, South Africa: Bible Media Biblecor, 2017.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Africa

An edited volume of papers from a conference at Stellenbosch University in January 2015, taking stock of the missional church conversation since Darrell Guder and others' *Missional Church* (1998) and arguing that 'missional' is too central a term to abandon. South African contributors, among them the editors and Jerry Pillay, write beside Guder, Patrick Keifert, Stefan Paas and Graham Cray, on subjects from biblical studies and ecclesiology to liturgy and theological education. For planting, Cray's chapter on discernment would be a useful place to look.

Cray, Graham. 'Discernment: The Key to Planting Missional Churches'. In *Cultivating Missional Change: The Future of Missional Churches and Missional Theology*, edited by Coenie Burger, Frederick Marais and Danie Mouton. Wellington, South Africa: Bible Media Biblecor, 2017.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A chapter by Graham Cray, Archbishops' Missioner and Team Leader of Fresh Expressions from 2009 to 2014, written for the 2015 Stellenbosch conference on the future of missional churches and missional theology. It is a contribution from the English fresh expressions movement to a conversation about the missional church convened in South Africa.

Fitch, David E., and Geoffrey Holsclaw. *Prodigal Christianity: Ten Signposts into the Missional Frontier*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2013.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A theological account of the missional church, set out as 10 signposts on doctrine, practice and ethics. Anabaptist in its theology, it presents itself as a way beyond both Emergent and Neo-Reformed evangelicalism. The chapters on practice, among them those on proclamation and the church, bear most directly on the shape a congregation takes.

Frost, Michael, and Alan Hirsch. *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2003.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Introductions and Overviews; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets; Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Innovation and Creativity; Theory of Change

A book arguing that the attractional church shaped by Christendom cannot reach the post-Christendom West. Frost and Hirsch build on the Gospel and Our Culture Network's account of the missional church, which drew on Lesslie Newbigin, adding three shifts of their own: to incarnational ecclesiology, messianic spirituality and apostolic leadership. They set a centred-set church, defined by nearness to Jesus, against a bounded-set one. Chapter 11, 'Imagination and the Leadership Task', treats imagination as part of a leader's work. A revised edition followed from Baker in 2013.

Frost, Michael. *Surprise the World! The Five Habits of Highly Missional People*. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2016.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Missional Spirituality

A book setting out five weekly habits under the acronym BELLS (Bless, Eat, Listen, Learn, Sent), on the argument that Christians have replaced habits that surprise the world with habits that mimic it. Frost, writing from Australia, offers them as a discipline for individuals or small groups rather than a technique of evangelism. Frost and Hirsch's *The Shaping of Things to Come* argued for a change in the church's shape; this book turns to the habits of its members. The closing chapter, on small groups for discipleship, nurture and accountability, bears on practising them together.

Guder, Darrell L. 'A Multicultural and Translational Approach'. In *The Mission of the Church: Five Views in Conversation*, edited by Craig Ott, 21-39. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A chapter in Craig Ott's edited volume *The Mission of the Church: Five Views in Conversation* (2016), catalogued separately in this bibliography. Guder, co-editor of *Missional Church* (1998), argues that the church's mission is to be a multicultural community translating the gospel into every culture it enters.

Hirsch, Alan. *The Forgotten Ways: Reactivating Apostolic Movements*. 2nd ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Theory of Change; Leadership in Church Planting

A book asking why some Christian movements grew exponentially, and calling what they share Apostolic Genius: six elements of 'mDNA', one of them 'APEST culture', which Hirsch and Catchim's *The Permanent Revolution* develops. Hirsch calls it 'not a how-to book'. The preface new to this edition concedes that few Western churches show all six elements, and argues that a handful of exemplary churches would be enough to change the paradigm.

Hunter, George G., III. *The Celtic Way of Evangelism: How Christianity Can Reach the West . . . Again*. 10th anniversary ed. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Evangelism

A book arguing that the Celtic evangelisation of Ireland and Britain, from Patrick in the fifth century to Aidan in the seventh, reached a 'barbarian' culture more effectively than the Roman model. The table in chapter 4 sets the two side by side: the Roman model moves from presentation to decision to fellowship, the Celtic from fellowship to ministry and conversation to belief. Hunter, an American, writes for the church across the West, and chapters 7 and 8 apply the Celtic model to reaching its secular society.

Nelson, Gary V. *Borderland Churches: A Congregation's Introduction to Missional Living*. St Louis, MO: Chalice Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A book on leading congregations into missional change, by the General Secretary of Canadian Baptist Ministries, writing from Canada. It takes the borderland, church life lived beyond its own walls, as its image, and covers the changing challenges of mission in the West and how to identify and overcome the blockages in congregations as they try to meet them. Chapter 4, on leadership for change, is particularly good: Robert Cornwall's review singles out its four leadership roles for a congregation moving into mission — apprentice, pastor, missionary and theologian.

Roxburgh, Alan J. *Missional Map-Making: Skills for Leading in Times of Transition*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2010.

A book of cultural analysis for mission, with a critique of the church's current theological practices of mission, concluding with steps for a church to assess its context, develop its identity and some core practices. Roxburgh argues that the maps church leaders inherited from modernity, strategic planning among them, no longer describe a changed culture; Part One (chapters 1 to 7) makes that diagnosis before the three chapters of steps. Written for congregational leaders.

Roxburgh, Alan J. *Missional: Joining God in the Neighborhood*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2011.

A book arguing that a church should stop asking how being missional can help it grow, and instead enter its neighbourhood to discern what the Spirit is already doing there, taking its practices from Luke 10's sending of the seventy. Roxburgh's *Missional Map-Making* ends with partnerships between a congregation and its neighbourhood; this book starts from the neighbourhood. Written for local churches, and closing with practical steps; its chapter on the history of the missional conversation would be a useful starting point for a reader new to it.

JUSTICE AND PUBLIC LIFE

Corbett, Steve, and Brian Fikkert. *When Helping Hurts: How to Alleviate Poverty Without Hurting the Poor . . . and Yourself*. Chicago: Moody Publishers, 2009.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

A book by two Christian economists arguing that much church work with the poor does harm because it misdiagnoses poverty, which is broken relationship with God, self, others and creation as well as material lack. Its central distinction is between relief, rehabilitation and development, and it names applying relief where rehabilitation or development is needed as one of the biggest mistakes North American churches make. The framework is applied to short-term mission and microfinance. Theresa Davidson (*Christian Scholar's Review*, 2010) finds that its emphasis on individual development leaves the systemic and legislative causes of poverty unaddressed.

Ekblad, Bob. *A New Christian Manifesto: Pledging Allegiance to the Kingdom of God*. Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

A book reading the Lord's Prayer as resistance to the earthly powers and allegiances that keep God's kingdom from coming. Ekblad writes out of Tierra Nueva, the ministry in Washington's Skagit Valley whose two cornerstones are chaplaincy in the county jail and advocacy for migrant farm workers. He argues that people at the margins are the most receptive to becoming agents of the kingdom's transformation, not only its objects, and calls the church to break down the barriers that separate it from them.

Howson, Chris. *A Just Church: 21st Century Liberation Theology in Action*. London: Continuum, 2011.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Fresh Expressions of Church

A book, by its priest, on a fresh expression in the centre of Bradford that took liberation theology as its working method: radical forms of worship, experimental forms of community, and non-violent direct action, including resistance to the detention of asylum seekers. Howson sets out an action–reflection cycle of education, action, reflection and sustaining, offered to help other Christians develop a contextual theology of their own.

Keller, Timothy. 'A Biblical Critique of Secular Justice and Critical Theory'. *Life in the Gospel*, 2020.

<https://quarterly.gospelinlife.com/a-biblical-critique-of-secular-justice-and-critical-theory/>.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

An article in Gospel in Life's 2020 series on justice and race, setting four secular theories of justice — libertarian, liberal, utilitarian and postmodern — against a biblical account in five parts. Keller argues that each theory captures some of biblical justice and none all of it, and that critical theory contradicts itself by treating all morality as socially constructed except its own.

Offutt, Stephen, F. David Bronkema, Krisanne Vaillancourt Murphy, Robb Davis and Gregg Okesson. *Advocating for Justice: An Evangelical Vision for Transforming Systems and Structures*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

A book by five authors arguing that evangelical compassion has concentrated on relief and neglected advocacy aimed at the systems and structures that produce poverty and injustice. It sets out the nature of social justice concerns, the theological foundations for advocacy and contemporary approaches to practising it.

Okesson, Gregg. *A Public Missiology: How Local Churches Witness to a Complex World*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2020.

A book arguing that the local congregation, not the agency or the campaign, is the primary means of public witness, and that witness becomes thick as Christians move between church and neighbourhood, workplace and civic life, rather than thin and confined to individual conversion. It rests on three ethnographic case studies, from Kenya, Montreal and Nashville. Mark Barneche (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2021) faults its use of the immanent Trinity as a pattern for human behaviour. Okesson also co-wrote *Advocating for Justice* (2016) with Stephen Offutt and three others.

MISSION AND CHURCH PLANTING

Ashford, Bruce Riley, ed. *Theology and Practice of Mission: God, the Church, and the Nations*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2011.

ALSO IN Baptist; Introductions and Overviews

An edited volume setting out a biblical-theological framework for the church's mission to the nations, written by pastors, professors and missionaries and published by B&H Academic, the Southern Baptist imprint. It begins from God's mission, traced through creation, fall, redemption and restoration, and places church planting within the church's wider mission, beside preaching and witness in every area of culture. J. D. Payne's chapter in the second part, 'Mission and Church Planting', bears most directly on planting.

Dent, Don. *The Ongoing Role of Apostles in Missions: The Forgotten Foundation*. Bloomington, IN: WestBow Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A book by a Southern Baptist missiologist arguing that apostles, now usually called missionaries, are God's gift for the initial planting of the church among every people, to the end of the age. It began as Dent's doctoral thesis (DMiss, Malaysia Baptist Theological Seminary, 2009), and the case rests on the New Testament's use of *apostolos*, the subject of chapter 2, and on the ministry patterns of the early missionary apostles. A review for the Immanuel Network objects that it sets apostolic teams outside the authority of established churches.

Hesselgrave, David J. *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: A Guide for Home and Foreign Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1980.

ANNOTATED under Crossing Cultures

McClintic, Douglas C. 'Assessing Missional Leaders: Evaluating the Effectiveness and Placement of Missional Church Planters'. Doctoral thesis, Bakke Graduate University, 2007.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters

A doctoral thesis proposing a way of assessing church planters for a postmodern and increasingly complex urban context, around four categories: calling, character, competence and chemistry. McClintic grounds it in biblical and theological foundations for church multiplication movements, and documents an assessment system devised and run in southern California from 2004 to 2006, with a training manual for assessment consultants. It is concerned with where planters are placed as well as with who is selected.

Payne, J. D. 'Mission and Church Planting'. In *Theology and Practice of Mission: God, the Church, and the Nations*, edited by Bruce Riley Ashford, 203-10. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2011.

A chapter relating church planting to mission, in the part of Ashford's volume on the church's mission. In his earlier writing Payne defines biblical church planting as 'evangelism resulting in congregationalization' and argues that a strategy should be 'simple and reproducible', which sets planting within evangelism. His *Discovering Church Planting* (2009) is a book-length introduction to planting.

Porterbrook Learning. *Missional Church and Church Planting*. Local Groups ed. Sheffield: Porterbrook Network, 2011.

ALSO IN Formation and Training

A course book from Porterbrook Learning, the Sheffield-based training programme run through local groups rather than a seminary, in the edition it printed through Lulu in October 2011. Its nine units move from ecclesiology to the practice of church planting, and it names no individual author. Written for a group working through it together, it stands as a British network's own course material rather than a treatise, and shows how one such network taught church planting.

Robinson, Martin. *Planting Mission-Shaped Churches Today*. Oxford: Monarch Books, 2006.

ANNOTATED under Mission in Britain and Europe

Evangelism

Evangelism is the sharing of the gospel with people outside the faith, so that they come to trust Christ and to belong to his church. Definitions differ in where they put the weight: on proclaiming the message, on the whole process by which a person comes to faith, or on bringing people into God's kingdom and the church's common life. This list gathers the theology of evangelism, research into how people come to faith, and ways of doing it, as they bear on a new church; mission as a whole is the subject of Missiology, and formation after conversion of Discipleship.

What's Gone Wrong with the Harvest? (1975) introduced the model of stages discussed in the Engel Scale list, and John Finney's survey of adults in England on the way to a public profession of faith, *Finding Faith Today* (1992), found the process gradual for most of them, and encouraged methods of evangelism that allow for it.

The literature divides over whether evangelism is first a message proclaimed or the life of a community over time. For J. I. Packer, evangelism is the preaching of the gospel, measured by the message delivered. For Bryan Stone, it belongs to the shared life of a congregation, whose character is itself the church's witness.

This list runs from Start Here through The Theology of Evangelism to Ways of Doing It.

START HERE

Green, Michael. *Evangelism through the Local Church*. London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1990.

A handbook arguing that the local church, rather than the campaign or the outside agency, is the best means of communicating the gospel, and setting out how a congregation can take on the work itself. Green joins biblical and theological grounding to method, from missions to discovery and enquiry groups, with a part on apologetics for a secular audience and appendices on planning outreach. A summary on the Life and Leadership site finds some of its methods dated.

Stone, Bryan. *Evangelism after Christendom: The Theology and Practice of Christian Witness*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A theological study treating evangelism as a practice in Alasdair MacIntyre's sense, belonging to the whole church, rather than a technique for producing converts. Stone holds that the church does not need an evangelistic strategy because it is one: its embodied life is its witness. He grounds the case in Israel, Jesus and the apostles, then traces how Constantine and modernity undermined it. Reviewers find it dense and academic; James Krabill, in the *Conrad Grebel Review*, also judges the case overstated, given how many other ways people have been drawn to faith.

THE THEOLOGY OF EVANGELISM

Engel and Norton's model and Finney's survey of conversion are filed here beside the theology.

Abraham, William J. *The Logic of Evangelism*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989.

A theological study defining evangelism as 'primary initiation into the kingdom of God', against the rival definitions of evangelism as proclamation and as church growth. For Abraham evangelism is not a single act but a set of activities aimed at initiating people into the kingdom for the first time; preaching counts only as part of that initiation, which takes in community, spiritual gifts and the disciplines of his Wesleyan tradition. Gailyn Van Rhee, in the *Journal of Applied Missiology*, finds that he writes more as a theorist, with little illustration from evangelistic practice.

Booth, Catherine. *Papers on Aggressive Christianity*. London: S. W. Partridge, 1880. <https://archive.org/details/papersonaggressi00boot>.

ALSO IN Salvation Army

A collection of addresses Catherine Booth delivered from February 1880, published the same year under the title page's *Papers on Aggressive Christianity* and known by the cover title *Aggressive Christianity*. Where her husband's book gives the social scheme, she gives the theology behind sending Salvationists to those the churches did not reach: conversion as something pursued rather than awaited. The opening address, from which the collection takes its title, states the case most directly. Later reprints carry the fuller title *Aggressive Christianity: Practical Sermons*.

Engel, James F., and H. Wilbert Norton. *What's Gone Wrong with the Harvest? A Communication Strategy for the Church and World Evangelism*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1975.

ALSO IN Engel Scale

A book applying communication theory to evangelism, and the source usually given for the Engel Scale. Engel and Norton argue that churches often fail to produce spiritual results because they put programmes before effective communication, and propose a strategy of understanding the audience, adapting the message and measuring its effect. The scale sets out coming to faith as a sequence of stages, from no knowledge of the gospel to commitment and, in some versions, beyond it into growth as a believer; sources number the stages differently.

Finney, John. *Emerging Evangelism*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2004.

ALSO IN Engel Scale

A book on the thinking and practice of mission in a society where the churches' influence is declining. It came after Finney's survey of how adults come to faith, *Finding Faith Today* (1992), and his comparison of the Celtic and Roman missions to England, *Recovering the Past* (1996).

Finney, John. *Finding Faith Today: How Does It Happen?* Swindon: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1992.

ALSO IN Engel Scale; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A report of research into how adults in England come to faith, drawn from 511 questionnaires completed in Anglican, Roman Catholic, Free Church and New Church congregations. Finney found that for most it was a gradual process, taking about four years on average, though the share who recalled a definite time of not believing ranged from over three-quarters in New Churches to about a third in the United Reformed Church. Respondents were about two-thirds women and almost all white. The survey is reported in more detail in Pam Hanley's *Finding Faith Today: The Technical Report* (1992).

Finney, John. *Recovering the Past: Celtic and Roman Mission*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1996.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Missiology

A book setting the Celtic mission to England from Iona and Lindisfarne beside Augustine's mission from Rome: a comparative account of the two missions Bede narrates, reaching back to Patrick and Pelagius. Finney wrote it as bishop of Pontefract, after serving as the Church of England's officer for the Decade of Evangelism.

Niles, Daniel Thambyrajah. *An Evangelizing Church*. Geneva: World's Student Christian Federation, 1953.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Ecclesiology

A theological essay of 15 pages rather than a book, and an early statement of Niles's understanding of what the Church is for, published in 1953, the year he became executive secretary for evangelism at the World Council of Churches. Rather than treating evangelism as one activity among many, he asks what it means for the Church itself to be an evangelising community, which makes it useful for thinking about the relation between evangelism, Christian community and the formation of new believers. The question it raises, what kind of Church is capable of evangelising, goes deeper for planting than asking which methods work.

Packer, J. I. *Evangelism and the Sovereignty of God*. London: Inter-Varsity Fellowship, 1961.

A short book arguing that belief in God's sovereignty, rightly understood, sustains evangelism rather than inhibiting it. Packer treats divine sovereignty and human responsibility as an antinomy: two truths that appear to contradict each other, to be held together rather than reconciled. He defines evangelism as preaching the gospel, to be judged by the message delivered rather than by its results.

Snow, Martyn, ed. *Anglican Evangelists: Identifying and Training a New Generation*. London: SPCK, 2019.

ALSO IN Anglican; Formation and Training; Missiology

An edited collection by 13 contributors from different traditions in the Church of England, published for the twentieth anniversary of the Archbishops' College of Evangelists and its relaunch. It sets aside evangelistic method for the calling and gifts of the evangelist, asking what an evangelist is and how the church should recognise and train one, so that evangelists can equip all Christians for witness.

Stone, Bryan. *Evangelism after Christendom: The Theology and Practice of Christian Witness*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2007.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Tomlin, Graham. *The Provocative Church*. London: SPCK, 2002.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book arguing that evangelism depends on a church whose life gives people something to be curious about, a step he argues most churches pass over. Tomlin treats evangelism as a corporate activity, drawing on gifts spread through the whole church rather than on the specialist evangelist. He wrote it in 2002 while teaching historical theology and evangelism at Wycliffe Hall, Oxford; the third and fourth editions (2013, 2014) add a study guide. It would be useful to a new church deciding what it wants to be visible for.

WAYS OF DOING IT

Coleman, Robert E. *The Master Plan of Evangelism*. Westwood, NJ: Fleming H. Revell, 1963.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Discipleship

A short book deriving a method of evangelism from Jesus's training of his disciples, in eight principles, from selection to reproduction. Coleman argues that Jesus invested in a few rather than the crowd, and reads the Great Commission's main verb as 'make disciples', grounding the last principle: those trained train others. Nik Lingle (9Marks, 2013) notes that it rules out treating the point of decision as the main goal; Jared Longshore (Founders Ministries) finds that it underplays the local church's part in discipleship.

Green, Michael. *Evangelism in the Early Church*. Rev. ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2004.

A historical study of how the first Christians evangelised the Roman world, from the New Testament to the middle of the third century, first published in 1970. Green treats the evangelising of Jews and of Gentiles as different settings, weighs the strengths and weaknesses of the early church's motives, methods and strategy, and holds that its practice has lessons for evangelism now, if adapted. His handbook for congregations, *Evangelism through the Local Church*, followed in 1990.

Green, Michael. *Evangelism through the Local Church*. London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1990.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Harney, Kevin G. *Organic Outreach for Ordinary People: Sharing the Good News Naturally*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2009.

A book for Christians who fear telling others about their faith, arguing that sharing it should grow out of ordinary life as a set of biblical practices rather than a script or programme. Its three parts run from love as motivation to presenting the gospel, which comes last, with study questions for small groups; the 2018 revision keeps that structure.

Hollinghurst, Steve. *Mission-Shaped Evangelism: The Gospel in Contemporary Culture*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2010.

ALSO IN [Fresh Expressions of Church](#)

A book on sharing the gospel once Christendom's assumptions no longer hold, from Church Army's Sheffield Centre, where Hollinghurst was researcher in evangelism. Asking whether God speaks through culture as well as through the Christian tradition, it listens to each in turn: to contemporary culture, including the rise of new spiritualities, then to how the church met earlier cultural shifts from the ancient pagan world onwards. Part Three turns to practice, with evangelism in supermarkets, at festivals and online.

Hunter, George G., III. *The Celtic Way of Evangelism: How Christianity Can Reach the West . . . Again*. 10th anniversary ed. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2010.

ALSO IN [Celtic and Early British Mission](#); [Missiology](#)

A book arguing that the Celtic evangelisation of Ireland and Britain, from Patrick in the fifth century to Aidan in the seventh, reached a 'barbarian' culture more effectively than the Roman model. The table in chapter 4 sets the two side by side: the Roman model moves from presentation to decision to fellowship, the Celtic from fellowship to ministry and conversation to belief. Hunter, an American, writes for the church across the West, and chapters 7 and 8 apply the Celtic model to reaching its secular society.

King, Kevin, and Christine Daniels. *Living Out Loud: Letting Your Love for God Flow into Your Everyday Language*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale Momentum, 2024.

A book on making God so much a part of daily life that talking about him becomes part of ordinary conversation. Its publisher calls it not a strategy for sharing the gospel but a matter of being 'comfortable in your own spiritual skin', and its practical material covers recognising people who are spiritually open. It is concerned with beginning to talk about faith, and offers no apologetic answers.

Moon, W. Jay, and W. Bud Simon. *Effective Intercultural Evangelism: Good News in a Diverse World*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2021.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Missiology

A book on evangelism across four worldviews: guilt and justice, shame and honour, fear and power, indifference and belonging. 'Intercultural' in its title means across these worldviews, not within the multi-ethnic congregation. Moon and Simon argue that the guilt-and-justice framing most Western presentations assume is one starting point among several, and often not the one in front of the speaker; the fourth worldview addresses secular younger generations in North America. Each chapter includes exercises for groups or individuals.

Pippert, Rebecca Manley. *Out of the Saltshaker and into the World: Evangelism as a Way of Life*. Rev. ed. Downers Grove, IL: IVP, 1999.

A book on relational evangelism, first published in 1979. Pippert argues for following Jesus's own approach, meeting people where they are and talking about faith in conversation rather than imposing it, and sets out three conversational models, among them 'investigate, stimulate, relate'.

Sjogren, Steve. *Conspiracy of Kindness: A Unique Approach to Sharing the Love of Jesus*. Rev. ed. Bloomington, MN: Bethany House, 2008.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

A book setting out servant evangelism, Sjogren's term for small, free acts of practical kindness offered with no obligation attached, such as cleaning a business's toilets unasked. His formula is deeds of love plus words of love plus adequate time: doing the message precedes telling it, to earn a hearing for the gospel rather than to replace speaking it. The examples come from Vineyard Community Church, Cincinnati, which Sjogren founded in 1985. Life and Leadership's summary judges the approach best suited to informally structured churches. First published by Vine Books in 1993; the edition cited is the revised one of 2008.

Sumpter, Tim. *Freshly Expressed Church: Lessons from Fresh Expressions for the Wider Church*. Evangelism 109. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2015.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

A Grove booklet in the Evangelism series, addressed not to those starting a fresh expression but to the established congregations around them. It argues that existing churches have much to learn from the missional values and methods of fresh expressions, and sets out how a congregation might examine and renew its own evangelism in response. Where most writing on the mixed ecology argues for holding parish and fresh expression together, this booklet asks what the one learns from the other.

Watson, David. *I Believe in Evangelism*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1976.

A book written while Watson was rector of St Michael-le-Belfrey, York, from within charismatic renewal in the Church of England. It uses the definition of evangelism in *Towards the Conversion of England* (1945), which ends in serving Christ 'in the fellowship of his Church', and considers spiritual gifts, the social dimension, church structures, modern communications and the arts as means of evangelism.

White, James Emery. *The Rise of the Nones: Understanding and Reaching the Religiously Unaffiliated*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A book by James Emery White, founding pastor of a Charlotte megachurch, arguing that the fastest-growing category on American religious surveys is not atheism but apathy: 'apatheists' indifferent rather than hostile to belief. Its first half profiles this group; its second proposes reaching them through a 'Cause to Community to Christ' strategy, distinguishing real conversion growth from the transfer growth of churches merely recycling existing Christians. Where Davis's *The Great Dechurching* tracks departure from American churches, White's subject is those never much attached to one; one reviewer questions whether his pragmatic methods risk reinforcing consumerism.

Ecclesiology

Ecclesiology is the doctrine of the church: what it is, what marks it out, who belongs to it and how it is ordered. The Nicene Creed calls the church one, holy, catholic and apostolic, and the Reformers located it where the word is rightly preached and the sacraments duly administered. This list is concerned with the church's nature and order rather than with its worship or with mission as a whole, and so it also takes in mission bands and movements, whose standing as church is disputed, and the health of congregations.

Avery Dulles's *Models of the Church* (1974) set out the main ways the church is pictured, as institution, communion, sacrament, herald and servant. Lesslie Newbigin's *The Household of God* (1953) had already set mission at the heart of what the church is, and *Missional Church* (1998), edited by Darrell Guder, gave that conviction the name under which it spread.

The principal disagreement is over what makes a church a church. On one account, put by Jonathan Leeman among others, a church is constituted by its marks, word, sacrament and discipline, and by its ordered life; on another, found in Newbigin and in Craig Van Gelder, by God's mission, as a community created by the Spirit and sent. For planting, the question becomes when a new gathering is a church, and on whose authority: Joshua Cockayne's survey of who presides at communion in new worshipping communities puts it in sacramental terms, and Michael Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* makes the theological case for contextual churches.

This list runs from Start Here through Systematic Accounts, Traditions Describing Themselves, The Church for the Sake of the World, Renewal and Mission Structures and New Churches and Their Ecclesiology to Health, Culture and Failure.

START HERE

Dulles, Avery. *Models of the Church*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1974.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic

A study of the church through five models: institution, mystical communion, sacrament, herald and servant. Dulles, a Jesuit, weighs the strengths and limitations of each rather than ranking them, and holds that none is sufficient alone, so that a balanced theology keeps what each model affirms. The expanded edition adds a sixth, the church as a community of disciples.

Kärkkäinen, Veli-Matti. *An Introduction to Ecclesiology: Historical, Global, and Interreligious Perspectives*. Rev. and exp. ed. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2021.

A textbook survey of ecclesiology in four parts, among them one on Latin American, African and Asian ecclesiologies and, new in this revised edition, one comparing the church with other religions. Where Dulles's *Models of the Church* sorts accounts of the church into types, Kärkkäinen surveys them tradition by tradition. Amos Yong (2004) found the first edition accessible and suited to classroom use; Wilburn Stancil (2021), who taught it to seminarians, expects the revision to be as useful to theological students.

Minear, Paul S. *Images of the Church in the New Testament*. Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1960.

A survey of 96 images for the church, among them the vine, the flock, the temple and the bride. It presses readers who build a doctrine of the church on one or two familiar images, such as the body of Christ or the people of God, to reckon with the New Testament's wider range, and closes with a chapter relating the images to one another. An index of the images, by chapter and page, makes it usable for reference as well as for reading through.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Household of God: Lectures on the Nature of the Church*. London: SCM Press, 1953.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum

The Kerr Lectures for 1952, given at Trinity College, Glasgow. Newbigin sets out the Protestant, Catholic and Pentecostal answers to what the church is, and argues for a missionary and eschatological understanding of the church. John Howard Yoder (1958) accepted that the church is essentially missionary but disputed that the idea was new, holding that the Anabaptists had insisted on it centuries earlier. Of Newbigin's books, the one where his ecclesiology is set out most directly.

Van Gelder, Craig. *The Essence of the Church: A Community Created by the Spirit*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2000.

A book on the church's nature, arguing that what the church is must be settled before what it does and how it organises itself. Van Gelder writes against starting from successful contemporary models: the church is not another human organisation but the Spirit's creation, and in his missional account it is the sign, foretaste and instrument of God's reign. The book keeps that order, turning to the church's ministry and organisation only after its nature.

SYSTEMATIC ACCOUNTS

Allison, Gregg R. *Sojourners and Strangers: The Doctrine of the Church*. Foundations of Evangelical Theology. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2012.

ALSO IN Baptist

A six-part account of the church, written from a Reformed Baptist position, which moves from the church's identity and growth to its government, then its ordinances, then its ministries. Chapter 9, setting out Allison's model of church governance, includes an excursus on multisite churches. Glenn Kreider (DTS Voice, 2013) commends it as a textbook for ecclesiology courses, especially in the Free Church tradition, finding it charitable to other views and clear in defending its own.

Avis, Paul, ed. *The Oxford Handbook of Ecclesiology*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018.

An edited reference work for the scholarly study of the church as it is found in the Bible, in Christian history and today, with chapters by specialists from across the major traditions, where Clowney's *The Church* and Allison's *Sojourners and Strangers* each argue from one. Avis's introduction summarises his own understanding of ecclesiology; his *The Identity of Anglicanism* (2008) is his account of Anglican ecclesiology.

Bannerman, James. *The Church of Christ: A Treatise on the Nature, Powers, Ordinances, Discipline and Government of the Christian Church*. Edinburgh: T. and T. Clark, 1868.

ALSO IN [Presbyterian and Reformed](#)

A treatise in two volumes by a Free Church of Scotland minister, edited after his death in 1868 from his lectures at New College, Edinburgh. It argues the Presbyterian position in comparison with other confessional traditions, with sustained treatment of church power and of church and state. Presbyterian reviewers still recommend it, Jeff Kingswood (2015) because churches face the issues earlier generations grappled with; Matt Cover finds some of its controversies harder for a modern reader to follow.

Clowney, Edmund P. *The Church*. Contours of Christian Theology. Leicester: Inter-Varsity Press, 1995.

ALSO IN [Presbyterian and Reformed](#)

A treatment of the doctrine of the church in 18 chapters, from a Reformed and Presbyterian standpoint. Clowney grounds the church in the Trinity and sets its task as worship, nurture and mission. Ben Robin (9Marks, 2024), writing as a Baptist, disagrees on three points, arguing for believer's baptism, stronger congregational authority and a membership restricted to believers, which he judges better suited to the church's missional identity. Chapters 8 and 14, on the marks of the church and on its structure, would be useful places to begin.

Coutts, Jon. *The Marks of a Church: Shaped by the Main Things*. Pastoral 155. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2018.

ALSO IN [Ecclesial Minimum](#)

A Grove booklet asking what, if anything, a church needs in order to be a church, and answering with a restatement of the Reformation's classic marks of a church - not word and sacrament alone, but a third mark of 'mutual discipleship' in place of church discipline. Coutts argues that a congregation shaped by hearing the word together, by baptism and communion, and by mutual discipleship in reconciliation has what it needs to witness to Christ. Short and accessible; it would be a good starting point for the question this list is organised around.

Dever, Mark. *The Church: The Gospel Made Visible*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2012.

ALSO IN [Baptist](#)

A primer on the doctrine of the church for readers who hold Scripture alone a sufficient authority for its life, grown from Dever's chapter in *A Theology for the Church* (2007). It sets what the Bible says beside what the church has believed, and its last part moves from a Protestant through a gathered and a congregational ecclesiology to a Baptist one. Nathan Finn (2012) reads it as an introduction to Baptist ecclesiology and points readers who want fuller coverage to John Hammett and Gregg Allison.

Dulles, Avery. *Models of the Church*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1974.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Kärkkäinen, Veli-Matti. *An Introduction to Ecclesiology: Historical, Global, and Interreligious Perspectives*. Rev. and exp. ed. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2021.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Leeman, Jonathan. *Don't Fire Your Church Members: The Case for Congregationalism*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN [Baptist](#)

An argument for congregational government from the office of the ordinary member: Christ gives every member an office, with final responsibility for guarding 'the what and the who of the gospel', and elders are to equip members for it rather than sideline them. Where Leeman's *The Church and the Surprising Offense of God's Love* (2010) grounds membership and discipline in God's love, this book grounds the member's authority in that office. An appendix answers criticisms of congregationalism.

Leeman, Jonathan. *The Church and the Surprising Offense of God's Love: Reintroducing the Doctrines of Church Membership and Discipline*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

ALSO IN Baptist

A theological argument for church membership and discipline from the nature of God's love, which Leeman holds is holy and so draws boundaries: the church's careful exercise of authority guards the gospel and marks off a people. Tim Chester (9Marks, 2011) singles out the chapter on the nature of love, but finds that the practical chapters lean on membership lists and covenants rather than on baptism and the Lord's Supper as the markers of who belongs.

Verduin, Leonard. *The Reformers and Their Stepchildren*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1964.

A history of the dissenters the mainstream Reformers opposed, told through the names of abuse they were given, each of its eight chapters titled by one. Verduin, a minister of the Christian Reformed Church, argues that the Reformers kept the union of church and state begun under Constantine, which he calls sacralism, and that the dissenters who refused it pioneered the separation of the two. It gives the history behind the believers' church, a church gathered apart from the state.

Volf, Miroslav. *After Our Likeness: The Church as the Image of the Trinity*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum

A study in trinitarian ecclesiology, written to show that Free Church order, the church as a gathered community of believers, is theologically legitimate. Volf starts from John Smyth, the first Baptist, and argues in sustained dialogue with Joseph Ratzinger and John Zizioulas, seeking to give person and community their due against individualism in Protestant ecclesiology. Like Jonathan Leeman's *Don't Fire Your Church Members* (2016), it defends congregational order, but from the Trinity rather than from the office of the member.

Waters, Guy Prentiss. *How Jesus Runs the Church*. Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R Publishing, 2011.

A short account of Presbyterian polity, in chapters on the church's government, power, offices and courts, argued from Scripture with reference to the Westminster Confession. Its thread is that Christ alone holds authority in the church, so that polity is a question of his rule rather than of preference. It is written for church members: Gregory Reynolds (*Ordained Servant*, 2014) taught it to an adult Sunday school class over 12 weeks. James Bannerman's two-volume *The Church of Christ* (1868) argues the Presbyterian case at far greater length.

Watkins, Clare. *Disclosing Church: An Ecclesiology Learned from Conversations in Practice*. Explorations in Practical, Pastoral and Empirical Theology. Abingdon: Routledge, 2020.

A book of systematic ecclesiology built out of empirical research rather than from doctrine alone. Watkins reports the Action Research: Church and Society project, run between 2006 and 2011 at Heythrop College and the Oxford Centre for Ecclesiology and Practical Theology, and asks what the conversations it recorded disclose about the church. It follows *Talking About God in Practice* (2010), which set out the method, theological action research, and its four voices of theology. It is the one account in this list whose doctrine of the church is generated from practice.

TRADITIONS DESCRIBING THEMSELVES

Accounts of the church from within particular traditions, and from conversations between them; some bear on what the church is only through a tradition's history or worship.

Second Vatican Council. *Ad Gentes: Decree on the Mission Activity of the Church*. Rome, 7 December 1965.

https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_decree_19651207_ad-gentes_en.html.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Missiology; Church Planting Movements

A document of the Second Vatican Council, its decree on the church's missionary activity, promulgated by Pope Paul VI on 7 December 1965: the first time an ecumenical council treated the missions as a subject in their own right. It grounds mission in the sending of the Son and the Spirit, so that the church is 'missionary by her very nature'. Chapter 2, on witness, preaching and the forming of a Christian community, and chapter 3, on the particular churches, their laity and their theological adaptation, bear most directly on planting.

Avis, Paul. *The Identity of Anglicanism: Essentials of Anglican Ecclesiology*. London: T&T Clark, 2008.

ALSO IN Anglican

A book on Anglican identity, which Avis locates in Anglicanism's understanding of the church and of authority, set out as both catholic and reformed. It treats the origins of Anglican ecclesiology, the diversity and coherence of the Anglican Communion, baptism and the Eucharist, the ordination of women, ecumenical engagement, and the conflicts within the Communion in the early 21st century.

Burgess, Stanley M., ed. *Christian Peoples of the Spirit: A Documentary History of Pentecostal Spirituality from the Early Church to the Present*. New York: New York University Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Pentecostal

A documentary history of charismatic gifts, worship and experience from the early church to the present: primary texts, from Tertullian and Antony of the Desert to the Shakers and Sundar Singh, with writings by their critics, each briefly introduced. Arranged in four periods, ancient, medieval, early modern and contemporary, it argues that modern Pentecostalism, usually dated from Azusa Street in 1906, has precedents in every age of the church.

Carter, David. *Love Bade Me Welcome: A British Methodist Perspective on the Church*. Exploring Methodism. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2002.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan

A history and account of British Methodist ecclesiology from the Wesleys to the present, setting classical Wesleyan thought beside Methodism's other strands and within wider ecumenical discussion. Carter writes as an ecumenist, for churches in dialogue with Methodists as well as for Methodists; the back cover calls it the first book on its subject since 1964, and the *Dictionary of Methodism in Britain and Ireland* cites it on connexionalism. The opening chapters treat the Wesleys, the first Methodists and classical Wesleyan ecclesiology.

Dever, Mark, and Jonathan Leeman, eds. *Baptist Foundations: Church Government for an Anti-Institutional Age*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2015.

ALSO IN Baptist

An edited volume arguing that right polity for a church is congregational, with elders and deacons, regenerate membership, church discipline and a Baptist practice of the ordinances. Its 11 contributors, the editors among them, work through each historically, exegetically and theologically before applying it. Lifeway Research (2015) finds the chapters on membership, by John Hammett, useful even to pastors who reject that polity; Jonathan Leeman's closing chapters give a congregational account of unity, holiness and apostolicity, and of the independence and interdependence of churches.

Green, Chris E. W. *Toward a Pentecostal Theology of the Lord's Supper: Foretasting the Kingdom*. Cleveland, TN: CPT Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Pentecostal; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

A monograph, the published form of Green's Bangor doctoral thesis, on the Lord's Supper in Pentecostal theology. From early Pentecostal periodicals of both the Wesleyan-Holiness and Finished Work streams it retrieves a high view of the sacraments, then reads three biblical texts to argue that Christ is 'really, personally, and bodily present' in the Supper through the Spirit. Jason Goroncy (2013) finds its untranslated Latin and Greek a barrier for some readers.

Hammett, John S. *Biblical Foundations for Baptist Churches: A Contemporary Ecclesiology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Academic, 2005.

ALSO IN Baptist

A book of Baptist ecclesiology written for pastors, students and lay leaders, each chapter with study questions and suggestions for further reading. Hammett moves from the nature and marks of the church to regenerate church membership, which he argues is the distinguishing Baptist mark, then makes the case for congregational polity and treats elders, deacons, the ordinances and newer models of church. The second edition (2019) adds a chapter on church membership and revises the chapters on polity and on church models, among them multisite churches.

Hilborn, David, and Simo Frestadius, eds. *Anglicans and Pentecostals in Dialogue*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2023.

ALSO IN Pentecostal; Anglican

An edited volume in which Anglican and Pentecostal writers take the same subjects in paired chapters: first each tradition's approach to ecumenism, then sacraments, ministry, ecclesiology, pneumatology and mission, with accounts of ecumenical work at local, national and international level, mostly in Britain. Hilborn's own chapter compares the two traditions on ordination, and Ric Thorpe's, on Anglicans, church growth and church planting, sits in the section on mission and church growth. Amy White (*The Melbourne Anglican*, 2024) finds that some chapters recount their own tradition's history without engaging the other.

Hyde, Daniel R., and Shane Lems, eds. *Planting, Watering, Growing: Planting Confessionally Reformed Churches in the 21st Century*. Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2011.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Presbyterian and Reformed

An edited volume of 21 essays on planting confessionally Reformed churches, most by pastors of the United Reformed Churches in North America with experience of planting. Stephen Doe's review for the Orthodox Presbyterian Church notes that its handling of the oversight of new mission work follows United Reformed practice. Its first part, on the biblical and confessional foundations, with Brian Vos's 'The Fruitful Grain of Wheat' and Wes Bredenhof's 'The Reformed Confessions and Missions', bears most directly on the theology of planting.

Needham, Phil. *Community in Mission: A Salvationist Ecclesiology*. London: The Salvation Army, 1987.

ALSO IN Salvation Army

A monograph written from inside the Salvation Army on what a corps is ecclesiologically, prompted, on its own account, by a first century 'too busily involved in its evangelistic mission' to ask what its own nature was within the church universal. It takes up, from within the tradition, the question of whether the Army is a church, making the case for the corps's own ecclesial standing, where Taylor's later study takes the same question up at greater length and more critically. Assumes some familiarity with Salvationist practice and vocabulary.

Orthodox Presbyterian Church, Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension. *Planting an Orthodox Presbyterian Church*. Willow Grove, PA: Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension, 2002. <https://opc.org/chm/chplant/>.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Presbyterian and Reformed

A denominational manual from the Orthodox Presbyterian Church's Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension, written by its general secretary, Ross W. Graham, and approved by the Committee in December 2001. It sets out the church's own process for planting: how a core group becomes a mission work under an overseeing session and an organising pastor, and is in turn organised as a particular church. Written for organising pastors, overseeing elders and presbytery home missions committees, it describes the procedures of one Presbyterian and Reformed polity rather than a general method, and reads as a tradition's own working document.

Ott, Craig, ed. *The Mission of the Church: Five Views in Conversation*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

An edited volume that puts one question — what is the mission of the church? — to five scholars from different Christian traditions, each stating a position and then responding to the other four. Stephen Bevans argues a Roman Catholic 'prophetic dialogue' approach and Darrell Guder a 'multicultural and translational approach', the latter filed separately in this bibliography as a chapter in its own right. Written for seminarians and church leaders, and designed for classroom use.

Paas, Stefan, and Hans Schaeffer. 'Reconstructing Reformed Identity: Experiences from Church Planting in the Netherlands'. *Journal of Reformed Theology* 8, no. 4 (2014): 382-407. <https://doi.org/10.1163/15697312-00804004>.

ALSO IN Europe; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Presbyterian and Reformed

A journal article, written for a specialist theological readership, by Stefan Paas, a missiologist, and Hans Schaeffer, a practical theologian whose research concerns changing forms of the church and practical ecclesiology. Its subject is Reformed identity, taken up through experiences of church planting in the Netherlands.

Peters, Greg. *The Monkhood of All Believers: The Monastic Foundation of Christian Spirituality*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2018.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book arguing that baptism makes every Christian a monk in the original sense of single-mindedness towards God. Peters holds that the vowed monasticism of the fourth century onwards modified an earlier and more universal monastic life, rooted in baptism and the priesthood of all believers, and draws on early monks, Russian Orthodox thinkers, the Reformers and Anglican writers. Ed Smither (2018) notes that it does not address parish or mission contexts. The chapter on the priesthood of all believers bears most directly on the doctrine of the church.

Robeck, Cecil M., Jr., and Amos Yong, eds. *The Cambridge Companion to Pentecostalism*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Pentecostal

An edited volume introducing Pentecostalism to students and specialists through its history, its regions and the academic disciplines. No chapter takes ecclesiology as its subject; for the doctrine of the church, the chapters on Pentecostal theology, by Mark Cartledge, and on Pentecostalism and ecumenism, by Wolfgang Vondey, would be a useful place to look. Martin Mittelstadt (2014) notes that none of its chapter authors is a woman and no chapter treats gender.

Smith, Gordon T. *Evangelical, Sacramental and Pentecostal: Why the Church Should Be All Three*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2017.

ALSO IN Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

A short book arguing that the church should be evangelical, sacramental and pentecostal at once, because word, sacrament and the Spirit's presence are three dimensions of one grace rather than rival emphases, drawing on John 15:4, Luke–Acts, Calvin and Wesley. It is addressed to evangelicals: Robert Cornwall (2017) commends it to them as a remedy for the sterility of a church centred on the word alone.

Taylor, David. *Like a Mighty Army? The Salvation Army, the Church, and the Churches*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick, 2014.

ALSO IN Salvation Army

A monograph-length study of whether the Salvation Army is a church, and of its relations with the churches ecumenically, substantially longer than Needham's 1987 treatment of the same question from within the tradition. It examines the Army's position as a founding member of the World Council of Churches alongside its long reluctance to call itself a church outright, pursuing that question at greater length than Needham and from a more ecumenical vantage. Assumes some acquaintance with ecumenical theology.

THE CHURCH FOR THE SAKE OF THE WORLD

Burger, Coenie, Frederick Marais and Danie Mouton, eds. *Cultivating Missional Change: The Future of Missional Churches and Missional Theology*. Wellington, South Africa: Bible Media Biblecor, 2017.

ALSO IN Missiology; Africa

An edited volume of papers from a conference at Stellenbosch University in January 2015, taking stock of the missional church conversation since Darrell Guder and others' *Missional Church* (1998) and arguing that 'missional' is too central a term to abandon. South African contributors, among them the editors and Jerry Pillay, write beside Guder, Patrick Keifert, Stefan Paas and Graham Cray, on subjects from biblical studies and ecclesiology to liturgy and theological education. For planting, Cray's chapter on discernment would be a useful place to look.

Guder, Darrell L. 'A Multicultural and Translational Approach'. In *The Mission of the Church: Five Views in Conversation*, edited by Craig Ott, 21-39. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology

A chapter in Craig Ott's edited volume *The Mission of the Church: Five Views in Conversation* (2016), catalogued separately in this bibliography. Guder, co-editor of *Missional Church* (1998), argues that the church's mission is to be a multicultural community translating the gospel into every culture it enters.

Guder, Darrell L., ed. *Missional Church: A Vision for the Sending of the Church in North America*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998.

ALSO IN Theory of Change

An edited volume by six members of the Gospel and Our Culture Network, asking what a theology of the church would look like that took seriously that North America is now a mission field. Steven Hovater notes that it gives no examples from actual congregations. George Hunsberger's chapter on the church as called and sent bears most directly on what the church is, and Alan Roxburgh's on missional leadership on how a church changes.

Kreider, Alan, Eleanor Kreider and Paulus Widjaja. *A Culture of Peace: God's Vision for the Church*. Intercourse, PA: Good Books, 2005.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality

A book by Alan and Eleanor Kreider, who co-directed the London Mennonite Centre and helped found the Anabaptist Network, with the Indonesian Paulus Widjaja, prompted by his judgement that the church in Indonesia must address reconciliation with Muslims. It treats peace as part of the culture a church should have, within the congregation, at work and between the church and the world, and argues that peacemaking rests on 'reflexes', habits formed before conflict arrives rather than skills improvised once it has.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Household of God: Lectures on the Nature of the Church*. London: SCM Press, 1953.

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Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Open Secret: Sketches for a Missionary Theology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans; London: SPCK, 1978.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book written from lectures Newbigin gave at Selly Oak to people preparing for missionary service. It argues that mission belongs to the church's identity, and gives a trinitarian account of it as proclaiming the kingdom of the Father, sharing the life of the Son and bearing the witness of the Spirit; the closing chapters take up justice, church growth and dialogue with other faiths. The 1995 revision adds a preface and an index under a new subtitle, *An Introduction to the Theology of Mission*.

Niles, Daniel Thambyrajah. *An Evangelizing Church*. Geneva: World's Student Christian Federation, 1953.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Evangelism

A theological essay of 15 pages rather than a book, and an early statement of Niles's understanding of what the Church is for, published in 1953, the year he became executive secretary for evangelism at the World Council of Churches. Rather than treating evangelism as one activity among many, he asks what it means for the Church itself to be an evangelising community, which makes it useful for thinking about the relation between evangelism, Christian community and the formation of new believers. The question it raises, what kind of Church is capable of evangelising, goes deeper for planting than asking which methods work.

Niles, Daniel Thambyrajah. *Upon the Earth: The Mission of God and the Missionary Enterprise of the Churches*. London: Lutterworth Press, 1962.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Missiology

A study of the relation between God's mission, the Church and the missionary enterprise, written from the perspective of a Christian leader from Sri Lanka. It is not a book about church planting, and its concern is theological rather than practical: an ecclesiology of mission in which the Church's existence is bound up with God's missionary purpose. Harold Lindsell (*Christianity Today*, 1963) reads it as implying universal salvation, that all people are already 'in Christ' whether they know it or not.

Padilla, C. René. 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 6, no. 1 (January 1982): 23-30.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle; Latin America

An article arguing that the homogeneous unit principle has no biblical foundation, since a church which will not cross the barriers Christ has abolished has misunderstood what it is. Padilla works from Ephesians and from the Gentile mission in Acts, judging a mission strategy by the church's unity, and writes as a Latin American evangelical from inside evangelical mission rather than against it; he took part in the 1977 Pasadena consultation on the principle. The article is reprinted in his *Mission Between the Times* (1985).

Van Engen, Charles. *God's Missionary People: Rethinking the Purpose of the Local Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1991.

ALSO IN Missiology

A study of the local congregation as the primary agent of mission and not its support base: in Van Engen's words, 'by very nature a missionary people – founded *by* mission and existing *for* mission'. He argues from Ephesians and from the church's history before turning to the congregation's purpose, goals, members, leaders and administration; Arthur Glasser's foreword presents the local church as a neglected key to missiological reflection. A 2007 review on the blog *Exagorazo* finds that it stays 'at the vision level' rather than giving detailed practical advice.

Van Gelder, Craig. *The Essence of the Church: A Community Created by the Spirit*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2000.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Warren, Robert. *Being Human, Being Church: Spirituality and Mission in the Local Church*. London: Marshall Pickering, 1995.

ALSO IN Missiology; Anglican; Missional Spirituality

A book arguing that the inherited church's structure casts the congregation as clients of a provider and so keeps its members passive, and that a local church becomes missionary through its spirituality and shared life. Warren compares the emerging church he anticipates with the Celtic church of the past.

Warren, Robert. *Building Missionary Congregations: Towards a Post-Modern Way of Being Church*. Board of Mission Occasional Paper 4. London: Church House Publishing, 1995.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Anglican; Missiology

A Board of Mission occasional paper by the Church of England's National Officer for Evangelism, on how the church could move from a pastoral to a missionary mode, arguing that this needs to be the main focus of the second half of the Decade of Evangelism. *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004) cites its account of church life as worship, community and mission, which Warren drew as three overlapping circles, and traces 'emerging church' to this paper and to his *Being Human, Being Church* (1995).

Wright, Christopher J. H. *The Mission of God: Unlocking the Bible's Grand Narrative*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2006.

ALSO IN Missiology

A study in biblical theology arguing that the whole Bible is generated by God's mission and is about it, so that mission is the key to reading Scripture rather than one theme among others. It is scholarly and long; the third of its four parts, on the people of mission, bears most directly on the church. Its weight falls on the Old Testament: Michael Sweeney (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2010) judges the lighter treatment of the New deliberate, while Mike Gilbert-Smith (9Marks, 2010) finds that it understates the New Testament's discontinuity with the Old. A revised second edition (2025) adds chapters on holistic mission and on election and supersessionism.

RENEWAL AND MISSION STRUCTURES

Work on renewing a church's structures, and on mission bands and movements whose relation to the congregation is disputed.

Chester, Tim, and Steve Timmis. *Everyday Church: Mission by Being Good Neighbours*. Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; New Churches and Networks

A book reading 1 Peter for a church on the margins after Christendom, and a sequel to Chester and Timmis's *Total Church*. The argument is that mission belongs to ordinary members, in the relationships and routines of daily life, rather than to a leader or a programme. Inter-Varsity Press withdrew both books from sale in 2020, *Christianity Today* reported, after Steve Timmis's removal from Acts 29, judging that the close church community they advocate 'lacked sufficient safeguards against abusive control'.

Chester, Tim, and Steve Timmis. *Total Church: A Radical Reshaping Around Gospel and Community*. Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2007.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

A book built on two principles: the gospel as content, which makes a church word-centred and mission-centred, and community as context, sharing life among Christians and offering belonging to those outside. Chester and Timmis make the biblical case, then apply it in 11 chapters, from church planting to work with children, as a middle path between the emerging church and conservative evangelicalism. Inter-Varsity Press withdrew it from sale in 2020, after Steve Timmis's removal from Acts 29, judging that the community it advocates 'lacked sufficient safeguards against abusive control'.

Cooper, Michael T. *Ephesiology: A Study of the Ephesian Movement*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2020.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles; Church Planting Movements

A study of the church at Ephesus as a church planting movement, reading Acts 19 with Ephesians, 1 and 2 Timothy and Revelation 2–3; Cooper counts two-fifths of the New Testament as bearing on the city. He coins 'ephesiology' for a discipline drawing on missiology, ecclesiology and archaeology, and finds in these texts a reproducible pattern in five stages, from launching a movement to sustaining it. Appendices supply a 'Movement Action Plan' and 'Maturity Matrices' for practitioners.

Costas, Orlando E. *The Church and Its Mission: A Shattering Critique from the Third World*. Wheaton, IL: Tyndale House, 1974.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Latin America

A book published the same year as Ralph Winter's essay 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission' and answering it directly: there is no New Testament warrant for mission apart from the church, the two-structure model damages the historic and universal character of the church, and mission sodalities, the specialised bodies that send Christians in mission, ought to be church sodalities. It also evaluates the church growth movement at length. A contemporary objection, from a Latin American writing to North Americans about their own arrangements; *Christianity Today* (1975) found that Costas 'recognizes the strength and bares the weaknesses of North American missiology'.

Hirsch, Alan. *5Q: Reactivating the Original Intelligence and Capacity of the Body of Christ*. 100 Movements, 2017.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting

A book on the fivefold typology of ministry in Ephesians 4, apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd and teacher (APEST), presented not as five offices to fill but as the church's DNA: traced through God's nature, creation and culture, embodied fully in Jesus, and what makes a community a church. Its first part, 'Mapping the Genome of the Body of Christ', sets out the theology, and the second turns to practice. Chris Schoon (*Englewood Review of Books*, 2017) judges that it claims too much for APEST as a lens on all of these at once.

Metcalf, Sam. *Beyond the Local Church: How Apostolic Movements Can Change the World*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Church Planting Movements

A book developing Ralph Winter's two structures, the congregation (modality) and the mission band (sodality): the fullest book-length development of Winter, and a tendentious one. Metcalf attempts a biblical case, arguing that sodalities are a legitimate expression of the church rather than a pragmatic device, and essential to the Great Commission. Ken Caruthers (9Marks, 2016), while granting that sodalities 'have done amazing work', finds that Metcalf treats biblical descriptions as prescriptions and ends with a low view of the congregation. Valuable precisely because it shows where the logic runs when it is pushed.

Moore, Philip. 'Defending Specificity on Doctrinal Distinctives for a Church-Planting Network: Why Reformed Soteriology and Complementarianism Are Important'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 26-40. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-2-defending-specificity-on-doctrinal-distinctives-for-a-church-planting-network/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; New Churches and Networks; Presbyterian and Reformed

An article defending a church-planting network's requirement of more than gospel agreement from the churches it takes on. Moore, writing within Acts 29, argues for Reformed soteriology and complementarianism on three grounds: biblical fidelity, pastoral practice and method, and the trust that working together in a network needs.

Petersen, Jim. *Church Without Walls: Moving Beyond Traditional Boundaries*. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 1992.

A book by a Navigators leader who helped begin their work in Brazil in 1963, challenging the habit of equating the church with the place where believers meet. As the first Christians had to separate Jesus from the religious apparatus of Judaism to reach all nations, Petersen asks whether the church now needs to separate him from its own. He disputes that the local church is God's primary means of fulfilling the Great Commission, and calls the division between local and parachurch structures the result of 'our narrow understanding of the church', a view friendlier to parachurch bodies than Costas's in *The Church and Its Mission*. A longer edition appeared in 2018.

Snyder, Howard A. *Liberating the Church: The Ecology of Church and Kingdom*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1983.

A book on church and kingdom, which Snyder treats as an ecology, beginning from justice, liberation and God's economy. Its second part sets out four models of the church, as sacrament, community, servant and witness; its last has chapters on lay ministry, women's leadership and the role of the poor. It shares its subject with *The Community of the King* (1977), while *The Problem of Wineskins* (1975) is on the church's structures.

Snyder, Howard A. *Signs of the Spirit: How God Reshapes the Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1989.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Early Methodist Church Planting

A study of four renewal movements, the Montanists, the Pietists, the Moravians and the early Methodists, read for what recurs across them, including judgement on the institutional church, non-traditional leadership, lay ministry and evangelistic vitality. From these Snyder builds a theology of renewal, and he closes with a renewal strategy for the local church. The chapters on the Methodist revolution and on the dynamics of renewal movements bear most directly on early Methodism and on what renewal movements share.

Snyder, Howard A. *The Community of the King*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1977.

A book asking whether the church brings the kingdom, and answering that the church is the agent through which God's kingdom breaks into history, a charismatic community rather than an organisation or institution. Evangelism, social action and worship, Snyder argues, take their meaning from that kingdom mission and lose their biblical proportion when separated from it, and the church's structures should free its members to use their gifts for it. A revised edition appeared in 2004.

Snyder, Howard A. *The Problem of Wineskins: Church Structure in a Technological Age*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1975.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

A book on church structure, built on the image of Luke 5: the wine is the gospel, which does not change, and the wineskins are the structures made to hold it, which are culturally conditioned and must be renewed or the wine is lost. Snyder argues that most institutional church structure has little biblical warrant, and that the church's primary structure should be the small group, meeting alongside large-group worship, rather than the congregation. Reissued as *Radical Renewal: The Problem of Wineskins Today* (1996; 2015).

NEW CHURCHES AND THEIR ECCLESIOLOGY

Cockayne, Joshua, ed. *Participation and Church Planting: Perspectives from Scripture, Doctrine and Practice*. Durham Studies in Church Planting and Theology. London: SCM Press, 2026.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works

An edited collection from a conference, in the Durham Studies in Church Planting and Theology, reading church planting through participation in the life of Christ by the Spirit, which its description sets against the pragmatism with which planting is sometimes associated. Its distinct contributions come from Scripture, doctrine and practice, among them Alan Torrance on the Trinity and Pete Ward against ecclesiocentrism. It shows scholars engaging critically with church planting, and would suit a student working at an advanced level.

Cockayne, Joshua. 'Church Planting, Community and the Triune God of Grace'. In *New Churches: A Theology*, edited by Will Foulger and Joshua Cockayne, 62-72. London: SCM Press, 2024.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A chapter in the missiological first part of *New Churches: A Theology*, taking its title and its argument from James B. Torrance's lectures *Worship, Community, and the Triune God of Grace*. Cockayne holds that much talk of planting is, in Torrance's phrase, 'practically unitarian', treating planters as the primary agents, and argues instead that planting is participation in the ongoing work of the Trinity, so that the planter's first task is not strategy but discernment of where Christ is already building his church.

Cockayne, Joshua. *The Communion Dilemma: The Challenges of Leading Eucharistic New Things*. Durham: Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Communion+Dilemma+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments; Ecclesial Minimum

A report surveying the leaders of 63 new communities in 20 Church of England dioceses, and by its own account the only current data on their eucharistic practice. Cockayne sets out three responses — not celebrating, celebrating with authorised liturgy and an ordained president, or celebrating without authorisation — and concludes that 'the communion dilemma is a loser's game', urging that liturgical reform be joined to the Church's aim of 10,000 new worshipping communities. Only nine of the 63 never celebrated communion.

Cray, Graham, Ian Mobsby and Aaron Kennedy, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: New Monasticism as Fresh Expression of Church*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Missional Spirituality; Rule of Life

An edited volume in which leaders of traditional religious communities and of new monastic ones write from their own communities on how an older form of religious life is shaping a new form of church. It was edited from within Fresh Expressions, which Graham Cray then led, and its subtitle states its claim: that new monasticism, which *Mission-Shaped Church* named among the new forms of church, is a fresh expression of church. The chapters are testimony and reflection rather than a single argument. Gladys Ganiel's review commends Shane Claiborne's 'Marks of a New Monasticism' for its vision of living alongside disadvantaged communities.

Crider, Erin. *Planting the Word: Missional Ecclesiology in Twenty-First-Century America*. Waco, TX: Baylor University Press, 2025.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works

A monograph in practical theology asking what American church planting movements since the mid-20th century reveal about the ecclesiology beneath them. Crider traces their shared conviction that every church is called to participate in the *missio Dei* through contextualised proclamation, and argues that planters, while spreading missional ministry, unintentionally weakened the functional ecclesiology of many congregations through their practice of pastoral roles, worship and demographic targeting. She writes as a director of church planting at an evangelical seminary. The chapter on the theology at work in the practice of American planting movements, and the chapter on the theological interpretation of the church, bear most directly on her case about functional ecclesiology.

Dunlop, Andrew. 'Catholicity and Connection: An Ecclesiological Framework for the Mixed Ecology Discerned through Research in an Anglican Team Ministry'. PhD thesis, University of Roehampton, 2025. <https://pure.roehampton.ac.uk/portal/en/studentTheses/catholicity-and-connection>.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Rural and Market Towns; Parish Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A doctoral thesis that builds an ecclesiological framework for the mixed ecology from theological action research with the Lordsbridge Team of Churches, an Anglican team ministry of 11 village parishes west of Cambridge. Its question is what holds a mixed ecology of inherited congregations and fresh expressions together, and Dunlop answers with five 'instincts': missio-ecclesiology, in line with Rowan Williams's theology; a missional understanding of pastoral care; interconnection between communities; catholicity, which values ecclesiastical diversity; and a Christ-centredness that unifies the whole.

Dunlop, Andrew. *Out of Nothing: A Cross-Shaped Approach to Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2018.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A monograph narrating Dunlop's own attempt to plant a fresh expression, reviewing the ecclesiological models and atonement theologies that might ground its evaluation before proposing his own, the 'Cross-Shaped approach'. Where his later thesis, *Catholicity and Connection* (2025), draws on fieldwork across a team ministry's mixed ecology, this earlier book stays with a single plant and its pioneer's own theological reasoning. A *Church Times* review found the closing chapter, turning from theology to ask what the plant's growth amounted to, more useful than what precedes it.

Foulger, Will, and Joshua Cockayne, eds. *New Churches: A Theology*. London: SCM Press, 2024.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Anglican; Ecclesial Minimum

An edited collection of theological essays on starting new churches, written from the British scene by contributors from evangelical and Anglo-Catholic traditions alike. In its first part, on new churches and the *missio Dei*, Mark Collinson asks whether church planters believe in the *missio Dei* at all, Joshua Cockayne writes on community and the Triune God, and Beth Honey sets out an ethics of planting in conversation with Aquinas. Christian Selvaratnam's chapter, on planting as a craft learned by apprenticeship, is listed under Formation and Training.

Gibbs, Eddie, and Ryan K. Bolger. *Emerging Churches: Creating Christian Community in Postmodern Cultures*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2005.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A study of emerging churches in the United States and the United Kingdom, built on interviews with about 50 of their leaders over three years, from which Gibbs and Bolger draw nine practices held in common, three of which, identifying with Jesus among them, they treat as core. The authors offer interpretation rather than theological critique, working, in Xochitl Alvizo's phrase, 'more like sociologists', so the book describes the practice of new churches rather than arguing an ecclesiology. A chapter is given to each practice, and an appendix sets out the research method with the leaders' own words.

Hull, John M. *Mission-Shaped Church: A Theological Response*. London: SCM Press, 2006.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesial Minimum; Church of England Papers and Reports

A book-length theological critique of *Mission-Shaped Church*, arguing that the report never consistently distinguishes the Kingdom of God from the church, and so turns a mission directed towards the world into a strategy for the church's own growth. Drawing on Barth, Hull treats the church as the fruit and agent of mission rather than its goal, and presses the report on its treatment of poverty, its neglect of consumerism and religious plurality, and its Anglican horizon. He writes as a supporter of fresh expressions, if a cautious one.

Hyde, Daniel R., and Shane Lems, eds. *Planting, Watering, Growing: Planting Confessionally Reformed Churches in the 21st Century*. Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2011.

ANNOTATED under Traditions Describing Themselves

Moynagh, Michael, with Philip Harrold. *Church for Every Context: An Introduction to Theology and Practice*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church

A textbook arguing for what Moynagh calls contextual churches, drawing on the literature and practice of both church planting and fresh expressions; its publisher describes it as the first textbook to reflect the learning from fresh expressions of church. It runs from ecclesiology to how a new community is sustained and supported, and at over 500 pages would suit use by section.

Moynagh, Michael. *Church in Life: Innovation, Mission and Ecclesiology*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Introductions and Overviews; Modality and Sodality; Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesial Minimum

A monograph modelling how new Christian communities come into being, drawing on complexity theory and entrepreneurship studies alongside theology. Where Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* (2012) makes the case for contextual churches, this book gives an account of how they emerge, analysing and systematising the innovation skills that pioneers of fresh expressions use by instinct. Its closing section, 'Perspectives on Method', bears most directly on how innovating teams work.

Paas, Stefan, and Hans Schaeffer. 'Reconstructing Reformed Identity: Experiences from Church Planting in the Netherlands'. *Journal of Reformed Theology* 8, no. 4 (2014): 382-407. <https://doi.org/10.1163/15697312-00804004>.

ANNOTATED under Traditions Describing Themselves

Paterson, Andy. 'Multi-Site Church'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 61-75. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-4-multi-site-church/>.

ALSO IN Multi-site Church; New Churches and Networks

An article asking of one structure, multi-site church, whether it is an end in itself, a dangerous distortion or a pragmatic tool, written while Paterson was mission director of the Fellowship of Independent Evangelical Churches. He allows it a use in planting and in reviving dying congregations, but argues that *ekklesia* means a literal assembly in one place, and that a site whose leader is not its preacher separates leading from preaching. A site, he concludes, must in time be freed 'to become a fully autonomous, self-governing church in its own right'.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *Exploring the Mixed Ecology: How Different Churches Belong Together*. Church Multiplication 3. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Anglican; Ecclesial Minimum

A booklet exploring the biblical and theological underpinnings of 'mixed ecology', the term the Church of England adopted in 2021 for established congregations and newer forms of church held together in one body, and tracing how it grew from the 'mixed economy' of *Mission-shaped Church* (2004). It reads the idea through the body of Christ in 1 Corinthians 12 and the household of God, and sets out the challenges an ecological ecclesiology raises for those who lead within it. Selvaratnam was on the working group that wrote the Church of England's Vision and Strategy for the 2020s, which adopted the term.

Shenk, Wilbert R., and David Parker. *The Realities of the Changing Expressions of the Church*. Lausanne Occasional Paper 43. Issue Group 14, 2004 Forum for World Evangelization, Pattaya. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 2005. https://lausanne.org/wp-content/uploads/2007/06/LOP43_IG14.pdf.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement; Fresh Expressions of Church

A committee report on its issue group's brief: the different patterns of church planting aimed at different sections of a community, and how effective each is at reaching the unreached. It works from cases in Africa, Asia, Europe, Latin America and North America, and on new varieties of church that had emerged over the preceding 30 years. Its theological reflection argues that these raise questions the classic notes of the church do not fully cover, and cautions both against dismissing new forms and against granting older ones a monopoly on truth. The closest thing Lausanne has to a theological treatment of new and emerging forms of church, and, with its cases, a useful paper for students.

Steele, Hannah. *New World, New Church? The Theology of the Emerging Church Movement*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A critical theological assessment of the emerging church movement, developed from Hannah Steele's doctoral research at King's College London under Alister McGrath, who contributes the foreword. It sets out the thinking of leading figures in the movement, Brian McLaren and Rob Bell among them, around the question of whether its drive for accessibility comes at the expense of Christian orthodoxy. Steele affirms what she judges good and insightful in the emerging church while offering a critical evaluation of its theological revisions.

Valentine, John. *Is Church Planting Legitimate? Some Theological Reflections*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2022.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Anglican

A paper of 43 pages written for CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, in February 2022 and posted on its site that August. Valentine sets out the scale of planting in Britain and the objections it has drawn, that it is schismatic, exclusively evangelical, un-Anglican or without an ecclesiology, and answers them from the biblical linking of church and mission, Bosch's 'church-in-mission' and a plea for provisionality on both sides. He argues for an ecclesiology that is fully missiological and a missiology that is fully ecclesial, open to essentialist and functionalist accounts of the church alike. His *Jesus, the Church and the Mission of God* develops the argument at book length.

Walker, Andrew. *Restoring the Kingdom: The Radical Christianity of the House Church Movement*. 4th ed. Guildford: Eagle, 1998.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

A history of the British house church movement from the mid-1960s to the mid-1980s, by a sociologist who studied it as it grew. Walker divides the movement into two wings, R1 and R2, labels that passed into wider use, and argues that Restorationism, despite insisting it was no new denomination, is sociologically a sect moving toward one. Where Kay describes the later networks as a settled new way of being church, this is the founding study of a movement still taking shape. The fourth edition, cited here, extends the account with new chapters beyond the 1985 first edition.

HEALTH, CULTURE AND FAILURE

Bretherton, Roger, and R. I. M. Dunbar. 'Dunbar's Number Goes to Church: The Social Brain Hypothesis as a Third Strand in the Study of Church Growth'. *Archive for the Psychology of Religion* 42, no. 1 (2020): 63-76. <https://ora.ox.ac.uk/objects/uuid:447ef235-8ef6-4ee6-b91a-68a6a3d9316b>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A journal article proposing Robin Dunbar's social brain hypothesis, which ties the size of human social groups to the size of the brain, as a third strand in the study of church growth beside the Church Growth Movement and social science. It derives five predictions and tests each against the church growth literature: among them, that engagement falls as a congregation grows, that a congregation led by one person is limited to about 150, and that growth beyond that forces reorganisation and tension. The section on transitions in group size bears most directly on a church growing past 150.

Chester, Tim, and Steve Timmis. *Everyday Church: Mission by Being Good Neighbours*. Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2011.

ANNOTATED under Renewal and Mission Structures

Chester, Tim, and Steve Timmis. *Total Church: A Radical Reshaping Around Gospel and Community*. Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2007.

ANNOTATED under Renewal and Mission Structures

Croft, Brian. *Biblical Church Revitalization: Solutions for Dying and Divided Churches*. Practical Shepherding. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2016.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting

A book on bringing dying and divided churches back to life, in the Practical Shepherding series, written while Croft was pastor of a Baptist church in Louisville, Kentucky. In an article for Southern Equip (10 March 2016), Croft makes the church's health rather than its numbers the goal of revitalisation, and sets a biblical approach against both the pragmatist's 'clever gimmicks and appealing programs' and the purist's legalism.

Dever, Mark. *Nine Marks of a Healthy Church*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2000.

ALSO IN Baptist

A book proposing nine marks by which to judge a church's health rather than its size, expository preaching the first of them. Tim Challies, expecting a polemic against the church growth movement, found instead a positive case for 'being church rather than doing church'. Dever's doctrinal account of the church is *The Church* (2012). The 2004 expanded edition keeps the nine; the fourth (2021) merges four of them into two and adds two, missions among them.

Farrant, Suzi, and Darren Philip. *Being an Intergenerational Church: Practices to Bring the Generations Back Together*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A book arguing that age-segregated models of ministry with children, young people and families are not working, and setting out practices by which an existing congregation can bring the generations together in mutual serving, sharing and learning. Commissioned by the Church of Scotland from two of its national staff, it grows out of their dissertations on Bonhoeffer and is organised around eight practices, among them hospitality and testimony. Written for pastors, parents, children's ministers and youth workers.

McKnight, Scot, and Laura Barringer. *A Church Called Tov: Forming a Goodness Culture That Resists Abuses of Power and Promotes Healing*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale Momentum, 2020.

ALSO IN Power and Its Abuse; Teams and Culture

A book on church culture rather than policy, whose introduction begins with the unravelling of Willow Creek after the allegations against its founding pastor, Bill Hybels, in 2018. McKnight, a New Testament scholar, and Barringer argue that goodness, *tov* in Hebrew, has to be formed in a church deliberately, because celebrity and self-protection will otherwise shape its culture. Mary Stahl (CBE International) found it useful for spotting warning signs in a healthy church and for putting 'words to feelings' in a toxic one. Part 1, on how a church's culture forms and deforms, bears most directly on what goes wrong.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Charts'. In *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism: Currents, Contours, Charts*, 25–38. Abingdon: Routledge, 2017.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Anglican; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

The opening chapter of Martyn Percy's book *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism* (2017), which sets the question of growth and management first in an account of where Anglicanism is heading. The chapter takes its title and subject from his 2014 article in *Modern Believing*, 'Some Comments' becoming 'Some Charts', and stands beside it as the later setting of the same question, within a book-length argument rather than a journal's comment.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Comments'. *Modern Believing* 55, no. 3 (2014): 257–70.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Anglican; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

A short article in *Modern Believing* commenting on growth and management in the Church of England, by an Anglican theologian. Percy's writing before and after it, in 2013 against treating the church as an organisation that must grow to survive and in 2021 against a proposal for 10,000 new lay-led churches, places him among the critics of the church growth school.

Pohl, Christine D. *Living into Community: Cultivating Practices That Sustain Us*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2011.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book on four practices that sustain a community — gratitude, promise-keeping, truthfulness and hospitality — set against the betrayal, deception, grumbling, envy and exclusion that damage one. Gratitude, promising and truthfulness each have three chapters, on the practice, its complications and what weakens or strengthens it; hospitality, the subject of Pohl's *Making Room*, has one chapter drawing the practices together. Written from Christian social ethics for communities and families, it includes discussion questions.

Tomlin, Graham. *The Provocative Church*. London: SPCK, 2002.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A book arguing that evangelism depends on a church whose life gives people something to be curious about, a step he argues most churches pass over. Tomlin treats evangelism as a corporate activity, drawing on gifts spread through the whole church rather than on the specialist evangelist. He wrote it in 2002 while teaching historical theology and evangelism at Wycliffe Hall, Oxford; the third and fourth editions (2013, 2014) add a study guide. It would be useful to a new church deciding what it wants to be visible for.

Post-Christendom and the Secular West

Christendom was the long era in which the church stood at the centre of Western society and its story was widely known; post-Christendom is the condition of the West as that era comes to an end. 'Secular', in this list's title, carries Charles Taylor's sense in *A Secular Age*: not only that fewer people believe, or that the state stands apart from religion, but that belief has become, even for believers, one possibility among others. This reading list gathers accounts of that change and of what it asks of the church: how to read the culture, how to stand towards it and how to plant in it. Its subject is a condition of the West rather than a region, or mission as a whole, which the lists on Europe and Missiology take.

Lesslie Newbigin asked whether the West could itself be converted. The principal disagreement is over what the church may hope for. At one pole, Timothy Keller's *How to Reach the West Again* calls for a new missionary encounter with the West. At the other, Stefan Paas holds that the dominant models of missional ecclesiology, Newbigin's question among them, still depend on a vision of a Christianised world, and his *Pilgrims and Priests* asks the church to accept a minority's place. For planting, the open question, pressed by Paas's *Church Planting in the Secular West*, is whether new churches bring growth in a secular society at all.

This list runs from Start Here through Diagnosing the Culture and Responding to the Culture to Planting After Christendom.

START HERE

Murray, Stuart. *Post-Christendom: Church and Mission in a Strange New World*. 2nd ed. London: SCM Press, 2018.

A book tracing how the Christendom system formed and what it has left in Western church life, and asking what mission and church become when the church is one minority among many in a culture it no longer dominates. It opened the After Christendom series, and Murray writes from the Anabaptist tradition, which Alun Brookfield, reviewing it in *Ministry Today* (2004), finds presented in an unnecessarily favourable light. Paternoster first published it in 2004; this second edition adds a new preface.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *Foolishness to the Greeks: The Gospel and Western Culture*. London: SPCK, 1986.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book expanded from Newbigin's Warfield Lectures at Princeton Theological Seminary in March 1984. It asks what a missionary encounter between the gospel and modern Western culture would require, and treats the West as a mission field needing the cross-cultural care that missionaries bring to any other culture.

Paas, Stefan. *Church Planting in the Secular West: Learning from the European Experience*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2016.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Europe

This is an important but uncomfortable book. Paas is a church planter and also a scholar critical of much contemporary planting, and he sorts the motives for planting in Europe into three — confessional, growth and innovation — testing each theologically and against the European evidence, with little confidence that planting produces growth in a secular setting. It is also a history of planting in Europe, particularly useful for understanding the origins of the church there and why its more Catholic wings have theological objections to evangelical planting. The last chapter, 'In Defense of Church Planting in Europe', is particularly good.

DIAGNOSING THE CULTURE

Bullivant, Stephen. *Europe's Young Adults and Religion: Findings from the European Social Survey (2014–16) to Inform the 2018 Synod of Bishops*. Twickenham: Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society, St Mary's University, 2018. <https://research.stmarys.ac.uk/id/eprint/2280/1/Europes%20Young%20Adults%20and%20Religions%20-%20report%20compressed.pdf>.

ALSO IN Europe

A research report by Stephen Bullivant for the Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society, produced with the Institut Catholique de Paris to inform the 2018 Synod of Bishops. Drawing on the European Social Survey of 2014 to 2016, it sets out religious affiliation and practice for 16 to 29 year olds across 22 European countries, and finds: Catholics are 82 per cent of young Poles and 10 per cent of young Britons, while 70 per cent of young adults in the UK and 64 per cent in France identify with no religion. Where Bullivant's 'No Religion' Population of Britain stays within the UK, this report sets British figures beside the rest of Europe.

Bullivant, Stephen. *The 'No Religion' Population of Britain: Recent Data from the British Social Attitudes Survey (2015) and the European Social Survey (2014)*. Catholic Research Forum Reports 3. Twickenham: Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society, St Mary's University, 2017. <https://research.stmarys.ac.uk/id/eprint/1525/1/FINAL%20NO%20RELIGION%20REPORT%20-%20embargo%2014%20May.pdf>.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church Growth

A research report by Stephen Bullivant, the third in the Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society's Catholic Research Forum Reports series, drawing on the British Social Attitudes Survey (2015) and the European Social Survey (2014). It finds that 48.6 per cent of Britain's population now identify with no religion, and that the main driver is 'nonversion' rather than lifelong non-affiliation: for every person raised with no religion who becomes a Christian, 26 raised Christian now call themselves 'Nones'. Issued by a Catholic research centre at St Mary's University, Twickenham; a numbered, survey-based diagnosis beside the more general accounts of secularisation elsewhere in this list.

Davie, Grace. *Religion in Britain: A Persistent Paradox*. 2nd ed. Chichester: Wiley-Blackwell, 2015.

A sociological account of religion in 21st-century Britain, the retitled and substantially rewritten second edition of *Religion in Britain since 1945: Believing without Belonging* (1994), whose title phrase described religious identity outlasting churchgoing. Davie asks why Britain has grown more secular while religion is more present in public debate, and adds the idea of 'vicarious religion', in which an active minority believes and practises on behalf of a majority who approve without taking part. Its evidence is British, where Davis's *The Great Dechurching* is American.

Davis, Jim, and Michael Graham, with Ryan P. Burge. *The Great Dechurching: Who's Leaving, Why Are They Going, and What Will It Take to Bring Them Back?* Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2023.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report of a survey of American adults who have stopped going to church, analysed by the political scientists Ryan Burge and Paul Djupe. The authors find that about 40 million adults who once attended monthly now attend less than once a year, which they call the largest and fastest religious shift in the country's history. Most are 'casually dechurched', leaving after a move or a change in family life; about 10 million left after conflict or abuse. The evidence is American throughout. The later chapters, on how congregations might respond, would be the place for a planter to look.

Drane, John. *The McDonaldization of the Church: Spirituality, Creativity and the Future of the Church*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2000.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Theory of Change

A book applying George Ritzer's sociological thesis, that modern institutions are organised around efficiency, calculability, predictability and control, to the church. Drane argues that churches adopted this rationalised machinery, pre-packaged worship included, just as the wider culture was losing patience with it. Unusually among critics of consumer culture, he treats the postmodern turn as an opportunity and looks for renewal in creativity. A sequel, *After McDonaldization*, followed in 2008.

Francis, Leslie J., and Philip J. Richter. *Gone for Good?: Church-Leaving and Returning in the Twenty-First Century*. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church Growth

A monograph by Leslie J. Francis and Philip Richter, drawn from interviews and questionnaires with people who had left churches across British denominations, and a sequel to their *Gone but Not Forgotten* (1998). It sorts what leavers gave as reasons into 15 themes, from disillusionment and being let down by the church to problems with worship, leadership and belief, and asks which leavers are the more likely to return. Its evidence bears on the biological and transfer sides of British church growth rather than on new church plants, which this list treats separately under For Planting Specifically.

Hayward, John. 'Church of England 2001–2019'. Church Growth Modelling, 2022. <https://churchmodel.org.uk/church-growth-models/limited-enthusiasm/demographics-2/church-of-england-2001-2019/>.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A page on John Hayward's own site, Church Growth Modelling, applying his 'Limited Enthusiasm Model with Reversion' to the Church of England's attendance statistics for 2001 to 2019, and concluding that 88 per cent of the model's optimisations point to extinction, forecast for 2062. Hayward, a mathematician, brings a quantitative method beside Goodhew's survey-based *Church Growth in Britain*. Written in 2022 and maintained on the author's own site.

Hayward, John. 'Growth, Decline and Extinction of UK Churches'. Church Growth Modelling, 15 May 2022. <https://churchmodel.org.uk/2022/05/15/growth-decline-and-extinction-of-uk-churches/>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A web article by John Hayward, published on his own site, Church Growth Modelling, on 15 May 2022 and reprinted less than a week later by Anglican Ink. It applies his Limited Enthusiasm Model across the whole range of UK denominations rather than the Church of England alone, giving each an 'R number' modelled on epidemiological reproduction: below one, conversions fail to outpace losses and the church heads for extinction. Most historic UK denominations fall below one; only three, FIEC, Newfrontiers and the Elim Pentecostal Church, are above it. Complements Hayward's single-denomination model for the Church of England and Goodhew's survey-based *Church Growth in Britain*.

Keller, Timothy. 'A Biblical Critique of Secular Justice and Critical Theory'. *Life in the Gospel*, 2020. <https://quarterly.gospelinlife.com/a-biblical-critique-of-secular-justice-and-critical-theory/>.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article in Gospel in Life's 2020 series on justice and race, setting four secular theories of justice — libertarian, liberal, utilitarian and postmodern — against a biblical account in five parts. Keller argues that each theory captures some of biblical justice and none all of it, and that critical theory contradicts itself by treating all morality as socially constructed except its own.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*. London: SPCK, 1989.

ALSO IN Missiology; Theory of Change

A book on the gospel and Western culture by a missionary theologian who returned from long service in India to the English Midlands and found it the more challenging environment. Newbigin argues that splitting facts from values leaves Christian claims counted as private preference, and concludes that the local congregation is the ultimate hermeneutic of the gospel; chapter 18, 'The Congregation as Hermeneutic of the Gospel', would be a good place to meet the idea inside its own argument.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *Truth to Tell: The Gospel as Public Truth*. London: SPCK, 1991.

ALSO IN Missiology

Three lectures, given as the 1990 Osterhaven Lectures at Western Theological Seminary in Holland, Michigan, arguing that the gospel is a claim to true knowledge with a place in public life, not a private preference or a set of values. Newbigin draws on Michael Polanyi to argue against relativism and fundamentalism alike. The book is the shorter form of the argument of *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society* (1989).

Smith, James K. A. *How (Not) to Be Secular: Reading Charles Taylor*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2014.

A guide to Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* (2007) that condenses its 900 pages to about a sixth of their length. Smith follows Taylor in finding belief and unbelief each pressed by the other, rather than faith simply lost. It describes that condition rather than arguing a case, as Sam Keyes's review for *bethinking.org* observes; the chapter on 'the malaise of immanence' sets out what belief now feels like.

Taylor, Charles. *A Secular Age*. Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2007.

A philosophical history of belief in the West since the Reformation. Taylor traces the coming of a secular age, through Deism to modern humanism, to moral narratives developed within Christianity rather than to the rise of science. Robert Bellah, reviewing it for *The Immanent Frame* (2007), holds that its account of the conditions of belief recasts the whole debate about secularism.

White, James Emery. *The Rise of the Nones: Understanding and Reaching the Religiously Unaffiliated*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A book by James Emery White, founding pastor of a Charlotte megachurch, arguing that the fastest-growing category on American religious surveys is not atheism but apathy: 'apatheists' indifferent rather than hostile to belief. Its first half profiles this group; its second proposes reaching them through a 'Cause to Community to Christ' strategy, distinguishing real conversion growth from the transfer growth of churches merely recycling existing Christians. Where Davis's *The Great Dechurching* tracks departure from American churches, White's subject is those never much attached to one; one reviewer questions whether his pragmatic methods risk reinforcing consumerism.

RESPONDING TO THE CULTURE

Dreher, Rod. *The Benedict Option: A Strategy for Christians in a Post-Christian Nation*. New York: Sentinel, 2017.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book of cultural polemic that borrows Benedict's name from a sentence at the end of Alasdair MacIntyre's *After Virtue*; it is not a study of the Rule. Dreher argues that Christians in the West should rely less on politics than on building resilient local communities, churches, schools and neighbourhoods, on a loosely Benedictine discipline. Its withdrawal strategy sits awkwardly with any missional reading, and R. R. Reno (*First Things*, 2017) faults its 'rhetoric of crisis'. It would serve students wanting to understand an argument they may meet in their own congregations better than those wanting to learn about Benedict.

Frost, Michael. *Exiles: Living Missionally in a Post-Christian Culture*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2006.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality

A book arguing that Western Christians should see themselves as exiles under an empire no longer Christian, and take up the practices of biblical exiles. Frost wrote it without Hirsch. The second of its four parts, on authenticity, community, hospitality and work, bears most directly on a church's common life.

Keller, Timothy. *How to Reach the West Again: Six Essential Elements of a Missionary Encounter*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2020.

A booklet arguing that, with churches closing across the United States, Canada, Australia and Europe, Western Christians need a new missionary encounter with their own culture, modelled on the early church, that makes the gospel both credible and attractive. It sets out six elements of that encounter, among them a counter-catechesis for a digital age and a social agenda that defies the usual political categories.

Paas, Stefan. *Pilgrims and Priests: Christian Mission in a Post-Christian Society*. London: SCM Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book, written from the Netherlands, on what a small Christian community is for in a society where it will not become large. Paas argues that the Western church should stop expecting Christendom to return and read its situation through Israel's exile and 1 Peter, with two images: Christians as pilgrims, strangers without institutional power, and as priests, mediating between God and their culture. He sets aside church growth, revival and transformation models as rooted in Christendom; Benjamin Espinoza (*Evangelical Missions Quarterly*, 2020) notes the cost, an expectation of a few converts rather than rapid growth.

Stone, Bryan. *Evangelism after Christendom: The Theology and Practice of Christian Witness*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A theological study treating evangelism as a practice in Alasdair MacIntyre's sense, belonging to the whole church, rather than a technique for producing converts. Stone holds that the church does not need an evangelistic strategy because it is one: its embodied life is its witness. He grounds the case in Israel, Jesus and the apostles, then traces how Constantine and modernity undermined it. Reviewers find it dense and academic; James Krabill, in the *Conrad Grebel Review*, also judges the case overstated, given how many other ways people have been drawn to faith.

PLANTING AFTER CHRISTENDOM

Bolger, Ryan K., ed. *The Gospel after Christendom: New Voices, New Cultures, New Expressions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Fresh Expressions of Church; Missiology

An edited volume that widens the largely Anglo-American scope of Gibbs and Bolger's *Emerging Churches* (2005) to churches that have grown up after Christendom on several continents. Bolger put questions about the shifts facing the Western church to 137 scholar-practitioners and built the book from the 76 who replied, in five parts, with contributors commenting on one another's chapters in text boxes. Reviewing it, Kevin Book-Satterlee finds themes repeated, especially in the European material.

Frost, Michael, and Alan Hirsch. *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2003.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Introductions and Overviews; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets; Missiology; Innovation and Creativity; Theory of Change

A book arguing that the attractional church shaped by Christendom cannot reach the post-Christendom West. Frost and Hirsch build on the Gospel and Our Culture Network's account of the missional church, which drew on Lesslie Newbigin, adding three shifts of their own: to incarnational ecclesiology, messianic spirituality and apostolic leadership. They set a centred-set church, defined by nearness to Jesus, against a bounded-set one. Chapter 11, 'Imagination and the Leadership Task', treats imagination as part of a leader's work. A revised edition followed from Baker in 2013.

James, Christopher B. *Church Planting in Post-Christian Soil: Theology and Practice*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2018.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

A mixed-method study of the churches founded in Seattle between 2001 and 2014, joining survey and interview data to theological assessment. James sorts most of them into four models — the Great Commission Team, the Household of the Spirit, the New Community and the Neighborhood Incarnation — and assesses each theologically with help from Avery Dulles, the move from sociology into theology that Justin Cober-Lake's review singles out. James Butler's review in *Anvil* doubts how far the findings travel to Britain, where the scale and the funding differ.

Paas, Stefan. 'Church Renewal by Church Planting: The Significance of Church Planting for the Future of Christianity in Europe'. *Theology Today* 68, no. 4 (January 2012): 467-77. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0040573611424326>.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Europe

A journal article by a Dutch missiologist who has planted churches, on what planting means for the future of Christianity in Europe. Where Keller's 'Why Plant Churches?' argues for new churches as a way of reaching new people, Paas's title presents planting as the means of the church's renewal. His *Church Planting in the Secular West* (2016) returns to planting in Europe at book length.

Paas, Stefan. 'Why Church Planting in Europe? On Authorizing a Common Evangelical Practice'.

Posted by the author, n.d. <https://www.academia.edu/30912620/>

[Why_Church_Planting_in_Europe_On_Authorizing_a_Common_Evangelical_Practice_%CE%B1.](#)

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Europe

A paper asking what authorises church planting in Europe, which its subtitle calls 'a common evangelical practice'. Where Paas's 'Church Renewal by Church Planting' presents planting as a means of renewing the church, this paper asks on what grounds the practice rests at all.

Paas, Stefan. *Church Planting in the Secular West: Learning from the European Experience*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2016.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Paas, Stefan. *New Churches in the Old World: Exploring the Theology of Church Planting in Post-Christendom Europe*. Church Multiplication 2. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2025.

ALSO IN Europe

A Grove booklet of 28 pages, the second in the Church Multiplication series, on the theology of church planting in Europe after Christendom. Paas looks at the experience of planting in the far and the recent past, and asks how far it offers strategies for the present, theologically and in practice.

Pioneering

Pioneers, in the Church of England's definition, are people 'called by God, who are the first to see and creatively respond to the Holy Spirit's initiatives with those outside the church'. Pioneering is that first response: beginning something new, with people the existing churches do not reach, before it has a settled form. This reading list is concerned with the pioneer as a person and a vocation, with how churches receive and deploy pioneers, and with accounts of the work itself; the new forms of church that pioneers begin are the subject of the list on Fresh Expressions of Church, and the theory of modality and sodality has a list of its own.

The Church of England's report of 2004 on church planting and fresh expressions proposed an ordained pioneer ministry. The definition is the Church of England's, but this list also includes earlier work, and work from other churches and countries, on the same kind of vocation.

The main fault line is how far the term reaches. George Lings, calling the settled church of parish and diocese modality and the mobile, deployable church of orders and mission societies sodality, reserves 'pioneer' for 'originators of fresh entities'; Tina Hodgett and Paul Bradbury extend it along a spectrum from leaders who replicate an existing church to activists who do not set out to plant one. The open question is where pioneers belong in relation to the institution: Lings reports Beth Keith's research as finding those sent into settled contexts 'frustrated by the system'.

This list runs from Start Here through The Pioneer Vocation to Pioneering in Practice.

START HERE

Goodhew, David, Andrew Roberts, and Michael Volland. *Fresh! An Introduction to Fresh Expressions of Church and Pioneer Ministry*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Fresh Expressions of Church

A textbook introduction to fresh expressions of church and to pioneer ministry, presented as one field rather than two, co-written by David Goodhew, Andrew Roberts and Michael Volland. It draws a theological rationale for both from scripture and the wider Christian tradition, tests it against contemporary British culture and against the criticisms fresh expressions have attracted, and follows this with practical guidance for starting and sustaining a fresh expression or a pioneer post over the long term.

Keith, Beth. 'To Pluck Up and Pull Down, to Build and to Plant'. In *The Pioneer Gift: Explorations in Mission*, edited by Cathy Ross and Jonny Baker, 117-40. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

A chapter reporting Keith's research on Church of England pioneers placed in modal, sodal and mixed contexts, and so the empirical counterpart to Lings's paper on modality and sodality. It reports poor outcomes for pioneers placed modally, research that Lings's paper cites. It would be a source to cite where the argument needs to rest on evidence rather than on temperament.

Listening to the Voice of the Pioneer. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2025.

<https://ccx.org.uk/content/pioneer-research/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A report from CCX, produced with the London Pioneer School and marking 20 years since *Mission-Shaped Church*, on what pioneers say of their own experience of the work. It sets out seven findings, with actions the wider Church might take in response.

Male, David. *How to Pioneer (Even If You Haven't a Clue)*. London: Church House Publishing, 2016.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Practical Guides

A practical guide for beginners in pioneering new Christian communities. Male wrote it while advising the Church of England on pioneer development. It covers listening to a local context and discerning its needs, building a team, starting and discipleship.

THE PIONEER VOCATION

Baker, Jonny, and Cathy Ross. *Imagining Mission with John V. Taylor*. London: SCM Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Missiology

A book by two teachers on the Church Mission Society's pioneer training that thinks with John V. Taylor about church, mission and society now, rather than writing his history. It is drawn from the travel diaries and monthly newsletters Taylor wrote as the Society's General Secretary from 1963 to 1974, and works with his 'immersion, imagination and improvisation'; each chapter closes with practical questions.

Croft, Steven J. L. *Ministry in Three Dimensions: Ordination and Leadership in the Local Church*. 2nd ed. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2008.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Leadership in Church Planting; Pastoral Ministry

A study of ordained ministry built around three New Testament words for it — diakonia, presbyteros and episcopo — treated as dimensions present in every ordained ministry rather than as separate orders, each minister needing to find their own balance of the three. Croft's case is that recovering this pattern matters because the inherited model of ministry no longer sustains a more mobile, declining society, and that secular management models are a false trail. First published in 1999, while Croft was Warden of Cranmer Hall, Durham, this 2008 edition adds some 90 pages and a final chapter, written once he had become Archbishops' Missioner and Team Leader of Fresh Expressions, connecting diakonia to the forming of new contextual communities.

Donovan, Vincent J. *Christianity Rediscovered: An Epistle from the Masai*. Notre Dame, IN: Fides/Claretian, 1978.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Missiology; Africa; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book of narrative and reflection by an American Catholic missionary priest who, influenced by Roland Allen, gave up the school-based method in northern Tanzania and took the gospel directly to the Maasai. It asks what the gospel is when stripped of the Western forms that usually carry it. Samuel K. Elolia (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) contests its conclusion that missionaries are no longer needed, pointing to the growth of Christianity in Africa. The Orbis 25th anniversary edition (2003) adds essays by Lamin Sanneh and Eugene Hillman.

Hodgett, Tina, and Paul Bradbury. 'Pioneering Mission Is... a Spectrum'. *Anvil* 34, no. 1 (2018).

<https://churchmissionsociety.org/anvil/pioneering-mission-is-a-spectrum-tina-hodgett-and-paul-bradbury-anvil-vol-34-issue-1/>.

An article setting pioneers along a spectrum of cultural distance: church replicators, pioneer adaptors, pioneer innovators working 'beyond the edges of the church's structures', and pioneer activists who shape communities without necessarily planting a church. The authors argue that an innovator working slowly and incarnationally is as valid as the resource church leader up the road, and that the church should protect such vocations for a time that may run to a generation or more. Hodgett wrote from the Diocese of Bath and Wells, Bradbury from a regional hub of the Church of England's pioneer network.

Keith, Beth. 'To Pluck Up and Pull Down, to Build and to Plant'. In *The Pioneer Gift: Explorations in Mission*, edited by Cathy Ross and Jonny Baker, 117-40. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2014.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Lings, George. *Why Modality and Sodality Thinking Is Vital to Understand Future Church*. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, n.d. [2013?]. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/george-lings---why-modality-and-sodality.pdf>.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Fresh Expressions of Church

A short report applying modality and sodality to the Church of England. Lings holds the two as a spectrum rather than a binary, argues that sodality pioneers what modality then sustains, and warns against deploying sodal people in modal roles: there is, he writes, 'little point in breeding tigers if you intend to keep them chained up in dog kennels'. Eight pages.

Male, Dave. *Pioneering Leadership: Disturbing the Status Quo?* Leadership 14. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2013.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A Grove booklet in the Leadership series, shorter than Male's other two titles in this list and addressed to church leaders generally rather than to pioneers themselves. Opening from a predicted 90 per cent fall in Anglican worship attendance by 2057, it helps a leader decide whether pioneering has any place in their own ministry, and sets out a spectrum of pioneering leadership styles rather than one model. Where *How to Pioneer* (2016) gives the practical steps once that decision is made and *Pioneers 4 Life* (2011) sustains those already committed to it, this booklet sits at the discernment stage before either.

Male, David, ed. *Pioneers 4 Life: Explorations in Theology and Wisdom for Pioneering Leaders*. Abingdon: BRF, 2011.

An edited collection arising from the Breakout Pioneers Conference, held each year from 2006 for lay and ordained pioneers across the denominations, which sets essays beside first-hand stories from pioneer leaders. George Lings's chapter asks what makes a pioneer; Beth Keith's is on pioneers and learning. Male edited it while tutor in pioneer mission training at Ridley Hall and Westcott House, Cambridge.

Robinson, Gareth. *Stones and Ripples: 10 Principles for Pioneers and Church Planters*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2021.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A book setting out 10 principles from Robinson's four-year study of whether any principles of planting hold across very different contexts. In his image, five are stones, characteristics of the leader's own life with Jesus, prayer among them; five are ripples, steps that carry an initiative outward, multiplication among them. It is written from Church of England practice.

Ross, Cathy, and Jonny Baker, eds. *Pioneering Spirituality: Resources for Reflection and Practice*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality

An edited collection on the spiritual life that sustains pioneer ministry, on the premise that prayer and contemplation lie at the heart of work that can look merely active. Its contributors consider the spirituality already present in British culture, and how practices from the Eucharist to pilgrimage might be offered to people outside the church. It followed *The Pioneer Gift* (2014), from the same editors.

Ross, Cathy, and Jonny Baker, eds. *The Pioneer Gift: Explorations in Mission*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2014.

An edited collection of essays by pioneer practitioners and theologians on the theology and practice of ordained pioneer ministry in the Church of England, the Methodist Church and further afield, among them Beth Keith's chapter 'To Pluck Up and Pull Down, to Build and to Plant'.

PIONEERING IN PRACTICE

Benesh, Sean. *The Bikeable Church: A Bicyclist's Guide to Church Planting*. Portland, OR: Urban Loft Publishers, 2015.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A short book, written from Portland, Oregon, on church planting in a city organised around the bicycle rather than the car: bike culture, cycling infrastructure and proximity as forces on where and how a church is planted. By its publisher's own account it rests on 'stories, antics, and slightly questionable research', and it is written for cyclists and ordinary planters rather than for scholars. Dan Herford, reviewing an earlier printing, credits it with naming a group, cyclists, that churches have failed to accommodate.

Dalpra, Claire. *Pioneering Pieces: An Evaluation of the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2020. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/pioneering-pieces-full-report.pdf>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Presbyterian and Reformed; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report by Claire Dalpra of Church Army's Research Unit evaluating the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project, which funded five full-time pioneer posts from 2016 to 2021: among artists in Glasgow, on a new-build estate in Bonnyrigg, with students at Stirling, in Ferguslie Park in Paisley and among Ayrshire farming communities. It gathers the reflections of those involved, post by post, then gives the author's own assessment, and asks whether these places offer enough to sustain the planting of a new ecclesial community.

Donovan, Vincent J. *Christianity Rediscovered: An Epistle from the Masai*. Notre Dame, IN: Fides/Claretian, 1978.

ANNOTATED under The Pioneer Vocation

Kilpin, Juliet. *Urban to the Core: Motives for Incarnational Mission*. Kibworth Beauchamp: Matador, 2013.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Cities and Urban Areas; Women in Church Planting

A multi-voiced book, compiled by Kilpin, of reflections from some of the hundred or so people who had joined Urban Expression teams in Britain's urban neighbourhoods, setting out the motives behind the network's first years. Kilpin, a Baptist minister, led its first team with Jim Kilpin, planting a congregation in Shadwell, east London, in 1997, and later coordinated Urban Expression in Britain. Much of the book is the team members' own account rather than hers.

Moon, W. Jay, and Fredrick J. Long. *Entrepreneurial Church Planting: Engaging Business and Mission for Marketplace Transformation*. Wilmore, KY: GlossaHouse, 2018.

ALSO IN Bivocational and Covocational Ministry; Innovation and Creativity

A book on what Moon calls 'entrepreneurial church planting', in which planters start or find businesses that double as places where a church gathers, so that the work is the site of ministry rather than a job taken to fund it. Moon, who teaches church planting at Asbury Theological Seminary, writes with Fredrick J. Long, a New Testament scholar there. Its three parts move from the approach's biblical and theoretical foundations to historical and contemporary examples and suggested starting points. Moon's free Exponential booklet, *A Missional Approach to the Marketplace* (2019), introduces the same approach more briefly.

Moon, W. Jay. *A Missional Approach to the Marketplace: An Onramp to Entrepreneurial Church Planting*.

Exponential, 2019. <https://exponential.org/product/a-missional-approach-to-the-marketplace/>.

ALSO IN Bivocational and Covocational Ministry

A 71-page booklet from Exponential, subtitled 'An Onramp to Entrepreneurial Church Planting': a shorter, free introduction by Moon to the approach he sets out at length, with Fredrick J. Long, in *Entrepreneurial Church Planting* (2018). Moon asks what it would mean for ordinary Christians to carry out their calling within the marketplace, treated as a mission field, and points to cafés, coffee shops and gyms as places to meet people who will not come to a church building.

Woofenden, Anna. *This Is God's Table: Finding Church Beyond the Walls*. Harrisonburg, VA: Herald Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Women in Church Planting

A first-hand account, written as narrative rather than method, of the Garden Church on an empty lot in San Pedro, Los Angeles, where housed and unhoused people farmed together, worshipped and shared a weekly meal. Woofenden was its founding pastor until 2017. Sam Chamelin, reviewing it in the *Englewood Review of Books* (2020), finds the work shown as communal, 'not a celebration of one person's expertise'.

Innovation and Creativity

See also the lists on Fresh Expressions of Church, on Digital and Hybrid Church, and on Pioneering.

This reading list is on how new forms of church come into being: innovation treated as a practice that can be studied and learned, the enterprise that some planters bring to it, and the imagination that others argue must change first. The new forms themselves, and the pioneers who start them, have lists of their own.

The principal axis runs between enterprise and imagination. On one side are writers who borrow from the study of innovation and business: Michael Moynagh models how new Christian communities emerge, W. Jay Moon and Fredrick Long describe planters who start businesses, and Doug Paul sets out phases through which an innovation passes. On the other are writers for whom the church's imagination must change before anything new can be built: John Drane looks to creativity to free a church that has taken on the rationalised habits of the wider culture, and Alan Hirsch and Mark Nelson call for a worldview 'starved of imagination' to be reframed and re-enriched. Moon's later book crosses the line, arguing that innovation in mission begins with imagination.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Imagination and Enterprise.

START HERE

Moynagh, Michael. *Church in Life: Innovation, Mission and Ecclesiology*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesiology; Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesial Minimum

A monograph modelling how new Christian communities come into being, drawing on complexity theory and entrepreneurship studies alongside theology. Where Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* (2012) makes the case for contextual churches, this book gives an account of how they emerge, analysing and systematising the innovation skills that pioneers of fresh expressions use by instinct. Its closing section, 'Perspectives on Method', bears most directly on how innovating teams work.

Taylor, Steve. *First Expressions: Innovation and the Mission of God*. London: SCM Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A longitudinal study, which is what makes it unusual: Taylor researched 11 emerging churches in 2001 and went back to them 11 years later, following their creativity and their conflict, their dreams and their despair. James Butler, reviewing it for *Anvil*, notes that only five of the 11 were still in existence. Four parts, 13 chapters.

IMAGINATION AND ENTERPRISE

Drane, John. *The McDonaldization of the Church: Spirituality, Creativity and the Future of the Church*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2000.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Theory of Change

A book applying George Ritzer's sociological thesis, that modern institutions are organised around efficiency, calculability, predictability and control, to the church. Drane argues that churches adopted this rationalised machinery, pre-packaged worship included, just as the wider culture was losing patience with it. Unusually among critics of consumer culture, he treats the postmodern turn as an opportunity and looks for renewal in creativity. A sequel, *After McDonaldization*, followed in 2008.

Frost, Michael, and Alan Hirsch. *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2003.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Introductions and Overviews; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets; Missiology; Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Theory of Change

A book arguing that the attractional church shaped by Christendom cannot reach the post-Christendom West. Frost and Hirsch build on the Gospel and Our Culture Network's account of the missional church, which drew on Lesslie Newbigin, adding three shifts of their own: to incarnational ecclesiology, messianic spirituality and apostolic leadership. They set a centred-set church, defined by nearness to Jesus, against a bounded-set one. Chapter 11, 'Imagination and the Leadership Task', treats imagination as part of a leader's work. A revised edition followed from Baker in 2013.

Hirsch, Alan, and Mark Nelson. *Reframation: Seeing God, People, and Mission Through Reenchanted Frames*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2019.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book calling Christians to 'reframe and reenchanted' a worldview that Hirsch and Nelson find 'starved of imagination, wary of paradox, and devoid of mystery', to help them articulate the gospel for contemporary culture. It argues from poetry, literature, the arts, philosophy and popular culture alongside Scripture, and is a work of re-enchantment rather than of method. The first chapter, 'Moving the Moon', sets out its diagnosis, 'the great reduction': truth broken into parts, each mistaken for the whole.

Moon, W. Jay, and Fredrick J. Long. *Entrepreneurial Church Planting: Engaging Business and Mission for Marketplace Transformation*. Wilmore, KY: GlossaHouse, 2018.

ALSO IN Bivocational and Covocational Ministry; Pioneering

A book on what Moon calls 'entrepreneurial church planting', in which planters start or find businesses that double as places where a church gathers, so that the work is the site of ministry rather than a job taken to fund it. Moon, who teaches church planting at Asbury Theological Seminary, writes with Fredrick J. Long, a New Testament scholar there. Its three parts move from the approach's biblical and theoretical foundations to historical and contemporary examples and suggested starting points. Moon's free Exponential booklet, *A Missional Approach to the Marketplace* (2019), introduces the same approach more briefly.

Moon, W. Jay. *Missional Imagination: Preparation for Kingdom Innovation*. American Society of Missiology Series. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Missiology; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book arguing that Christian ministry has been shaped by a 'dominant social paradigm' that separates sacred from secular, private from public and transcendent from immanent, and that missional imagination, a way of seeing and acting that refuses those separations, is where innovation in mission begins. Drawing on Moon's missionary work in Ghana and congregational ministry in the United States, it sets out practices for discipleship and mission as well as for evangelism, the subject of Moon and Simon's *Effective Intercultural Evangelism*.

Moynagh, Michael. *Church in Life: Innovation, Mission and Ecclesiology*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Paul, Doug. *Ready or Not: Kingdom Innovation for a Brave New World*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2020.

A book on innovation in the church, written at the start of the COVID-19 pandemic, which sets out five phases of what Paul calls kingdom innovation: identification, ideation, experimentation, mobilisation and multiplication. It works through story, history and cultural analysis, and Tanwin Tanoto, reviewing it for the Churches of Christ in New South Wales and the ACT (2021), calls it 'more of an idea book' than a practical one. Paul writes as an innovation strategist with Catapult.

Root, Andrew. *The Church after Innovation: Questioning Our Obsession with Work, Creativity, and Entrepreneurship*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2022.

ALSO IN Theory of Change

A theological critique of innovation and entrepreneurship as goals the church has taken over from the culture around it. Root traces this culture of innovation through the history of management, Protestantism and neoliberal economics, and in place of a better technique proposes a recovery of the mystical theology of Meister Eckhart and Johannes Tauler. Where Drane's *The McDonaldization of the Church* looks to creativity to free the church from rationalisation, Root questions the pursuit of creativity and innovation.

Van de Poll, Evert, and Joanne Appleton, eds. *Church Planting in Europe: Connecting to Society, Learning from Experience*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Europe

An edited volume from the Mission in Europe Symposium held in Belgium in 2014, on planting churches in European societies shaped by secularisation, new spiritualities and a Christian heritage. Most of it is reflection and analysis; the case studies, three chapters, come last. A review on the Kouyanet blog finds Pentecostal and black majority churches thinly covered. Ron Anderson's chapter, 'Creative Church Planting Involving Lay People', bears most directly on lay leadership in planting.

Church Growth

Church growth is the study of how and why churches grow in number, and the name of the movement that made that study a discipline. Its questions meet a new church at every stage: why some congregations grow while others decline, whether growth can be planned and whether it is the right measure of a church's health. The Church Growth Movement began with Donald McGavran, whose *Understanding Church Growth* (1970) set out its theory at Fuller Theological Seminary's School of World Mission.

This reading list is about growth in number, and so includes books from neighbouring topics that have lists of their own wherever they bear on growth: the Church Growth Movement's homogeneous unit principle, the renewal of declining congregations and the distinction between biological, transfer and conversion growth.

The principal disagreement is over whether growth is produced by strategy or follows from faithfulness and formation. For McGavran and C. Peter Wagner, the conditions under which churches grow can be studied, and what is learned can be applied; Alan Kreider's *The Patient Ferment of the Early Church* finds the early church growing through the formation of its members rather than through any strategy for growth. In Britain the question has become one of evidence: how much growth there is, where it is found and whether it changes the picture of overall decline, questions that David Goodhew's *Church Growth in Britain* and the Church of England's *From Anecdote to Evidence* (2014) both take up.

This list runs from Start Here through The Church Growth School and Its Critics, Growth in Britain and What Makes a Church Grow to Growth in Christian History.

START HERE

Church Growth Research Programme. *From Anecdote to Evidence: Findings from the Church Growth Research Programme 2011-2013*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2014. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/from_anecdote_to_evidence_-_the_report.pdf.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church of England Papers and Reports

The summary report of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme: 18 months of research, commissioned for the Archbishops' Council and the Church Commissioners, into what is statistically associated with growth and decline. The University of Essex, under David Voas, analysed attendance statistics and surveyed growing, declining and stable churches, and a strand at Ripon College Cuddesdon studied church planting. The researchers found 'no single and simple recipe for growth', though some factors, such as employing a youth worker, are associated with it. Mark Hart's critique, 'From Delusion to Reality', argues that the report overstates what the data show, and its press release more so.

Goodhew, David, ed. *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

An edited collection showing that the blanket description of decline misses significant growth in parts of the church and the country. The major essays are Goodhew's own opening chapter, John Wolffe and Bob Jackson on the Diocese of London, and George Lings on the history of church planting and fresh expressions. Where *From Anecdote to Evidence* reports commissioned statistical research, this argues largely from case studies, with one figure and two tables in the volume by the count of the review for British Religion in Numbers. Christopher Cotter, for the Religious Studies Project, reads it as evidence of growth amid overall decline rather than as disproof of decline.

McGavran, Donald A. *Understanding Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle; Missiology; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

The fuller statement of the church growth theory Donald McGavran first argued in *The Bridges of God* (1955), resting on J. Waskom Pickett's research into the Indian mass movements. It is the source of the much-quoted sentence about people becoming Christians without crossing racial, linguistic or class barriers, and the book the debate over church growth and the homogeneous unit principle is about. The revised edition of 1980 adds three chapters on the principle; the third, of 1990, revised by C. Peter Wagner, turns church growth from a chief purpose of mission into the chief one.

THE CHURCH GROWTH SCHOOL AND ITS CRITICS

Conn, Harvie M. *Theological Perspectives on Church Growth*. Nutley, NJ: Presbyterian and Reformed, 1976.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Presbyterian and Reformed

A volume bringing Reformed theology to bear on Donald McGavran's church growth theory, edited by Harvie Conn while professor of missions at Westminster Theological Seminary, and the third in Presbyterian and Reformed's series Studies in the World Church and Missions. It speaks from Reformed missiology rather than from the movement's base at Fuller. It predates the Pasadena consultation of 1977, and Gary McIntosh's 'Revisiting the Homogeneous Unit Principle' (2023) counts Conn among the principle's early critics.

Gibbs, Eddie. *I Believe in Church Growth*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1981.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A book offering a sympathetic British reception of the Church Growth Movement that is nonetheless alert to what McGavran's categories cannot measure, and a statement of the theological unease from inside the movement. Most of its reception concerns the revised edition of 1985, which Henry Schmidt (*Direction*, 1991) describes as a biblical foundation, on God's people, the church and the kingdom, and gospel and culture, followed by practical treatment of measurement, group dynamics, leadership and strategic planning.

Goodhew, David, ed. *Towards a Theology of Church Growth*. Farnham: Ashgate, 2015.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works

An edited collection, from a Durham conference of 2013, arguing that numerical growth is a proper theological concern for the church and not merely a sociological one. It moves from introductory questions through the Bible, doctrine and history, with C. Kavin Rowe on the ecclesiology of Acts and Graham Tomlin on a pneumatological doctrine of mission; no chapter treats church planting itself. Rod Green's review in *Fulcrum* judges the collection uneven and singles out the chapters by Alister McGrath and Martin Warner as the weaker.

The Pasadena Consultation: Homogeneous Unit Principle. Lausanne Occasional Paper 1. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 1978. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/lop-1>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle

The report of the Pasadena colloquium of 1977, held under the Lausanne Theology and Education Group and published as the first Lausanne Occasional Paper: 10 primary contributors, Donald McGavran and C. Peter Wagner among them, some 25 further consultants and John Stott as moderator. Proponents and critics of the homogeneous unit principle agreed that a homogeneous unit church 'can be a legitimate and authentic church' but 'can never be complete in itself, since the 'dividing wall' Christ abolished 'was enmity or hostility'. It would be a useful place to begin on the ecclesiological objection to church-growth planting strategy, before taking either side.

McGavran, Donald A. *Understanding Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

McIntosh, Gary L. 'Revisiting the Homogeneous Unit Principle: Unpacking the Historical Development of the Homogeneous Unit Principle'. *International Journal of Frontier Missiology* 40, nos. 1-2 (2023): 5-11. https://www.ijfm.org/PDFs_IJFM/40_1_2_PDFs/IJFM_40_1_2-McIntosh.pdf.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle

A journal article, adapted from a 2022 lecture, tracing how McGavran's homogeneous unit principle actually developed rather than how it is remembered. McIntosh, McGavran's biographer, writes 'with a positive view' of the principle and argues that most of what is said for and against it addresses a simplified version; his section 'Why Was McGavran Misunderstood?' rejects the reading of the principle as racist. Where the Pasadena consultation of 1977 recorded common ground between advocates and critics, this is a defence from the advocates' side.

McIntosh, Gary L., ed. *Evaluating the Church Growth Movement: Five Views*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2004.

An edited volume in Zondervan's Counterpoints series in which five contributors each state a view of the Church Growth Movement and are answered by the other four: Elmer Towns (effective evangelism), Craig Van Gelder (the gospel in our culture), Charles Van Engen (centrist), Gailyn Van Rheenen (reformist) and Howard Snyder (renewal). Three pastors close the book with reflections on its practical implications. Andy Johnson (9Marks, 2010) finds the book mildly disappointing, though he values Van Rheenen's critique on authority and Scripture.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Charts'. In *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism: Currents, Contours, Charts*, 25–38. Abingdon: Routledge, 2017.

ALSO IN Anglican; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesiology

The opening chapter of Martyn Percy's book *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism* (2017), which sets the question of growth and management first in an account of where Anglicanism is heading. The chapter takes its title and subject from his 2014 article in *Modern Believing*, 'Some Comments' becoming 'Some Charts', and stands beside it as the later setting of the same question, within a book-length argument rather than a journal's comment.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Comments'. *Modern Believing* 55, no. 3 (2014): 257–70.

ALSO IN Anglican; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesiology

A short article in *Modern Believing* commenting on growth and management in the Church of England, by an Anglican theologian. Percy's writing before and after it, in 2013 against treating the church as an organisation that must grow to survive and in 2021 against a proposal for 10,000 new lay-led churches, places him among the critics of the church growth school.

Rainer, Thom S. *The Book of Church Growth: History, Theology, and Principles*. Nashville, TN: Broadman Press, 1993.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A survey of the Church Growth Movement in three parts, among them its history, from the forerunners to 'the Wagner era', and its principles, church planting among them. It summarises McGavran's taxonomy of growth and its variants, and with suggested reading at the close of each chapter it would be a convenient single reference for teaching. Rainer writes as an advocate aiming, in his publisher's words, at 'an objective view'; Carlus Gupton expects mainline and missional readers to disagree with much of it.

Shenk, Wilbert R., ed. *Exploring Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1983.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle

An edited collection that brings Donald McGavran into one volume with missiologists from outside the Church Growth Movement, among them Orlando Costas and David Bosch, to take up what Henry Schmidt (*Direction*, 1991) calls 'the premises, principles and goals of church growth'. Shenk, a Mennonite missiologist, stood outside the movement himself, and Schmidt reads the volume as an international analysis of it.

Thomas, Geoff. 'The Church Growth Movement'. *Foundations*, no. 33 (Autumn 1994): 20-26. https://www.affinity.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/08/33_20.pdf.

An article weighing the Church Growth Movement of Donald McGavran and C. Peter Wagner, by Geoff Thomas, pastor of Alfred Place Baptist Church, Aberystwyth. On the homogeneous unit, Thomas holds that the movement should have recorded a fact rather than made it a principle; against Wagner, he uses denominational figures to argue that charismatic growth in Britain had been exaggerated. He grants the movement 'many useful lessons', if they are guided by church history, theology and the preaching of Scripture.

Van Engen, Charles. *The Growth of the True Church: An Analysis of the Ecclesiology of Church Growth Theory*. Amsterdam: Rodopi, 1981.

A doctoral dissertation from the Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam that analyses the doctrine of the church underlying Donald McGavran's church growth theory: an examination of the theory's theological assumptions rather than a guide to its practice. Its author, Charles Van Engen, later taught the theology of church growth at Fuller Theological Seminary.

Wagner, C. Peter. *Our Kind of People: The Ethical Dimensions of Church Growth in America*. Atlanta: John Knox Press, 1979.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A book-length defence of the homogeneous unit principle for American congregations, made on ethical grounds as well as strategic ones by McGavran's colleague at Fuller. Wagner argues for a pluralism that encourages distinct identities against the integrationist ideal of the melting pot; his last chapter is titled 'Overcoming Racism Through Christian Love'. *Kirkus Reviews* found the argument's broad outlines 'solidly convincing' and Wagner's sociology 'a bit amateurish'.

Wagner, C. Peter. *Strategies for Church Growth: Tools for Effective Mission and Evangelism*. Ventura, CA: Regal Books, 1987.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A strategy manual that works out the Church Growth Movement's measurement apparatus, in chapters that include the harvest principle and testing the soil. Wagner draws together the movement, the Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization and the US Center for World Mission, whose Ralph D. Winter writes the foreword, and argues that strategy is compatible with God's sovereignty and the Spirit's work. Where *Your Church Can Grow* diagnoses a congregation, this sets out tools for planning outreach.

Wagner, C. Peter. *Your Church Can Grow: Seven Vital Signs of a Healthy Church*. Glendale, CA: Regal Books, 1976.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A manual for pastors setting out seven signs of a growing congregation, among them a possibility-thinking pastor, a mobilised laity, the homogeneous unit principle and priority for evangelism. It is where McGavran's categories move from missiology into congregational practice. Ralph Elliott (*Christian Century*, 1981), who takes it as setting out the North American movement's methods and aims, objects to its authoritarian model of the pastor and to congregations segregated by the homogeneous unit principle.

Warren, Rick. *The Purpose Driven Church: Growth without Compromising Your Message and Mission*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1995.

A manual for church growth by the founding pastor of Saddleback Church in California, which builds a church's strategy on five purposes: worship, fellowship, discipleship, ministry and mission. Warren holds that 'the message must never change, but methods must change with each new generation'. In a Barna survey of 614 American senior pastors in 2004, 15 per cent named it among the three most helpful books of the previous three years. Paul Alexander, reviewing it for 9Marks, argues that separating method from message leads to 'a "whatever works best" mentality'.

GROWTH IN BRITAIN

Aisthorpe, Steve. *The Invisible Church: Learning from the Experiences of Churchless Christians*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2016.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A study of 'churchless Christians' in Scotland, people who no longer attend a congregation but still identify as Christian. Aisthorpe finds that leaving a congregation is 'more of a "wrench" than a "flit"', and that many who leave keep up informal Christian fellowship. Attendance figures do not count such believers, which bears on any measure of growth or decline made from attendance.

Brierley, Peter, ed. *UK Christian Handbook: Religious Trends*. 7 nos. London: Christian Research, 1997–2008. Continued as *UK Church Statistics*. Tonbridge: ADBC Publishers, 2011–.

A statistical series edited by Peter Brierley: seven editions of *UK Christian Handbook: Religious Trends*, continued from 2011 as *UK Church Statistics*. The series counts churches, ministers and members in the United Kingdom by denomination and by nation, with forecasts. Where Brierley's *Capital Growth* reports one census of London, the series gives national figures over a long run. Reviewing the second number of *UK Church Statistics* (2014) for British Religion in Numbers, Clive Field notes that the denominations define membership differently, so that Brierley uses attendance for some, among them the Roman Catholic Church, and would have liked this explained more fully.

Brierley, Peter. *Capital Growth: What the 2012 London Church Census Reveals*. Tonbridge: ADBC Publishers, 2013.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report of the London Church Census of 14 October 2012, commissioned by the London City Mission and carried out by Brierley Consultancy. Sunday churchgoing in Greater London rose by 16 per cent between 2005 and 2012, from 620,000 to 720,000, and places of worship by 17 per cent; the census is the source of the claim that London's churches buck the national trend. Commentary in *Thinking Anglicans* and from the Evangelical Alliance links the growth to black-majority and immigrant churches and, in part, to migration.

Bullivant, Stephen. *The 'No Religion' Population of Britain: Recent Data from the British Social Attitudes Survey (2015) and the European Social Survey (2014)*. Catholic Research Forum Reports 3. Twickenham: Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society, St Mary's University, 2017. <https://research.stmarys.ac.uk/id/eprint/1525/1/FINAL%20NO%20RELIGION%20REPORT%20-%20embargo%2014%20May.pdf>.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A research report by Stephen Bullivant, the third in the Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society's Catholic Research Forum Reports series, drawing on the British Social Attitudes Survey (2015) and the European Social Survey (2014). It finds that 48.6 per cent of Britain's population now identify with no religion, and that the main driver is 'nonversion' rather than lifelong non-affiliation: for every person raised with no religion who becomes a Christian, 26 raised Christian now call themselves 'Nones'. Issued by a Catholic research centre at St Mary's University, Twickenham; a numbered, survey-based diagnosis beside the more general accounts of secularisation elsewhere in this list.

Church Growth Research Programme. *From Anecdote to Evidence: Findings from the Church Growth Research Programme 2011-2013*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2014. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/from_anecdote_to_evidence_-_the_report.pdf.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Dadswell, David, and Cathy Ross. *Church Growth Research Project: Church Planting*. Cuddesdon: Oxford Centre for Ecclesiology and Practical Theology, Ripon College Cuddesdon, 2013. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/cgrp_church_planting_from_cgrd_website.pdf.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A report from the church-planting strand of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme, written by David Dadswell and Cathy Ross of the Oxford Centre for Ecclesiology and Practical Theology at Ripon College Cuddesdon and dated November 2013. A qualitative study built on visits to plants, it describes the models then current, from Holy Trinity Brompton and minster plants to network, cell and Anglo-Catholic ones, and reports on buildings, dioceses, leadership, finance and growth, opening with 20 recommendations. It found leaders reluctant to measure growth by numbers and little record of where growth came from, and called for a longitudinal study. It precedes the programme's summary report, *From Anecdote to Evidence*, by a year.

Gill, Robin. *The 'Empty' Church Revisited*. Aldershot: Ashgate, 2003.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A study of British churchgoing, the revised edition of Gill's *The Myth of the Empty Church* (1993), which revisits its local case studies with new data and substantially rewrites chapters 8 and 10. Gill argues that the over-provision of church buildings, rather than secularisation alone, explains much of the decline in churchgoing: a supply-side account whose subject is why churches emptied rather than where they have grown. It appeared in Ashgate's academic series Explorations in Practical, Pastoral and Empirical Theology.

Goodhew, David, and Rob Barward-Symmons. *New Churches in the North East*. Durham: Centre for Church Growth Research, 2015. <https://csmc.webspace.durham.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/sites/144/2021/04/NCNereportFINAL.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A report counting the new churches founded in North East England between 1980 and 2015: 125, with a combined usual Sunday attendance of about 12,000. Only 18 were founded by the historic denominations, and 47 have a black and minority ethnic majority. It answers the assumption that the region is simply in decline. Where Brierley's *Capital Growth* counts all churchgoing in London, this counts only new churches.

Goodhew, David, ed. *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Goodhew, David, ed. *Growth and Decline in the Anglican Communion: 1980 to the Present*. Routledge Contemporary Ecclesiology. Abingdon: Routledge, 2016.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

An edited volume from a five-year international research project based at Durham, testing the assumption that Western Anglican churches decline uniformly while non-Western ones grow. After an overview by Todd M. Johnson and Gina A. Zurlo, 12 case studies, among them Nigeria, India, Australia, the United States and England, show how differently one denomination behaves from place to place, even within a single region. Its frame is the worldwide Communion rather than Britain; the part on England bears most directly on British questions.

Goodhew, David. 'Church Growth in Britain, 1980 to the Present'. In *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*, edited by David Goodhew, 3-22. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

The opening chapter of Goodhew's *Church Growth in Britain*, in which the editor sets out the collection's argument ahead of the case studies by other contributors, treating the national statistics as needing to be 'taken with a pinch of salt'. The Evangelical Alliance's reviewer suggests that the growth it reports owes more to immigration than to any reaction against secularisation.

Goodhew, David. 'Growth and Decline in the Anglican Communion: 1980 to the Present'. In *Growth and Decline in the Anglican Communion: 1980 to the Present*, edited by David Goodhew, 3-34. Abingdon: Routledge, 2016.

The opening chapter of Goodhew's edited volume: his introduction to the project's findings on the Anglican Communion since 1980, which set decline in Britain, Canada and the United States against growth elsewhere. It would be a good starting point for setting the Church of England's decline within the worldwide Communion, before the volume's case studies.

Goodhew, David. 'The Death and Resurrection of Christianity in Contemporary Britain'. In *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*, edited by David Goodhew, 253-57. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

The closing chapter of Goodhew's *Church Growth in Britain*, drawing the volume's case studies together into the editor's conclusion. Where his opening chapter sets out the argument, this chapter gives his verdict on the evidence, which British Religion in Numbers reads as an optimistic counter to secularisation theory.

Green, Beth, Angus Ritchie and Tim Thorlby. *Church Growth in East London: A Grassroots View*. Theology for the Local Church 5. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2016. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2016-Church-Growth-in-East-London.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report of interviews held in 2014 with 13 church leaders in five east London boroughs on what they mean by church growth. Eight lead Church of England congregations and five belong to other traditions, in churches of about 40 to 900 worshippers, and the authors state that 13 interviews are not statistically representative. The report sets growth as numbers and conversion against growth centred on worship and community, and argues that numerical growth and growth in faith and discipleship 'have to go hand in hand'. Stephen Cottrell, then Bishop of Chelmsford, responds by recasting the question as one of transformation.

Hayward, John. 'Church of England 2001–2019'. Church Growth Modelling, 2022. <https://churchmodel.org.uk/church-growth-models/limited-enthusiasm/demographics-2/church-of-england-2001-2019/>.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A page on John Hayward's own site, Church Growth Modelling, applying his 'Limited Enthusiasm Model with Reversion' to the Church of England's attendance statistics for 2001 to 2019, and concluding that 88 per cent of the model's optimisations point to extinction, forecast for 2062. Hayward, a mathematician, brings a quantitative method beside Goodhew's survey-based *Church Growth in Britain*. Written in 2022 and maintained on the author's own site.

Hayward, John. 'Growth, Decline and Extinction of UK Churches'. Church Growth Modelling, 15 May 2022. <https://churchmodel.org.uk/2022/05/15/growth-decline-and-extinction-of-uk-churches/>.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A web article by John Hayward, published on his own site, Church Growth Modelling, on 15 May 2022 and reprinted less than a week later by Anglican Ink. It applies his Limited Enthusiasm Model across the whole range of UK denominations rather than the Church of England alone, giving each an 'R number' modelled on epidemiological reproduction: below one, conversions fail to outpace losses and the church heads for extinction. Most historic UK denominations fall below one; only three, FIEC, Newfrontiers and the Elim Pentecostal Church, are above it. Complements Hayward's single-denomination model for the Church of England and Goodhew's survey-based *Church Growth in Britain*.

Jackson, Bob. *Hope for the Church: Contemporary Strategies for Growth*. London: Church House Publishing, 2002.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A study applying growth analysis to Church of England attendance data, written while Jackson, an economist by training, was a member of Springboard, Archbishop George Carey's evangelism initiative. It analyses the figures diocese by diocese, identifies where the church is growing as well as the causes of decline, and proposes strategic responses, with chapters on church planting and diocesan finance.

Jackson, Bob. *Leading One Church at a Time: From Multi-Church Ministers to Focal Ministers*. Leadership 34. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2018.

ALSO IN Parish Church; Practical Guides

A Grove booklet arguing that a shrinking clergy should lead one church each, not several, replacing the multi-parish incumbent with a 'focal minister' – paid or unpaid, lay or ordained – set at the centre of a single congregation. Where Jackson's earlier, data-led studies ask what drives numerical growth, this is a short policy argument for restructuring ministry itself, citing early evidence from the Diocese of St Davids. Written for diocesan and deanery leaders reviewing multi-parish arrangements; the term itself is defined on page 3.

Jackson, Bob. *The Road to Growth: Towards a Thriving Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2005.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church Planting Strategy

The fuller and more strategic sequel to *Hope for the Church*, drawn from Jackson's consultancy with churches and dioceses. It argues that decline can be reversed in parishes, dioceses and the Church of England as a whole, and gives two of its four parts to strategies for deploying people and money to support growth.

Jackson, Bob. *What Makes Churches Grow? Vision and Practice in Effective Mission*. London: Church House Publishing, 2015.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church Planting Strategy

A book on what makes Church of England congregations grow, which counts depth of faith and strength of ministry as growth alongside numbers. It joins strategy to prayer: its central part sets out strategies, from lay leadership to church planting and fresh expressions, on the principle that 'it is those who intend to grow the church who tend to grow the church', and its last part holds that strategy alone cannot produce growth. A congregation planning for growth might begin with the central part.

Lings, George. 'The History of Fresh Expressions of Church and Church Planting in the Church of England'. In *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*, edited by David Goodhew, 161-78. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Introductions and Overviews; Anglican

A chapter tracing church planting in the Church of England from the 1960s to fresh expressions of church, by the head of Church Army's research unit. Lings sets out six movements that prepared the ground, among them charismatic renewal and church growth theory, gives figures for plants by period, and presents fresh expressions as a new departure rather than a return to the daughter church.

Thorlby, Tim. *A Time to Sow: Anglican Catholic Church Growth in London*. Research for the Local Church 9. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2017. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2017-Time-To-Sow.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Parish Church

A report by Tim Thorlby for the Centre for Theology and Community, the sequel to his *Love, Sweat and Tears* on evangelical church planting in east London. It tells the stories of seven Anglo-Catholic parishes in the dioceses of London and Southwark, most in poorer areas, that had grown over the previous five years, from both wings of that tradition, and draws from them habits of growth: welcome, accessible worship with depth, work with children, new service times, community ministry and clergy focused on growth. Its four closing challenges include the scarcity of Anglo-Catholic church planting. It documents growth in a tradition the planting literature seldom covers.

Thorpe, Ric. 'Anglicans, Church Growth, and Church Planting'. In *Anglicans and Pentecostals in Dialogue*, edited by David Hilborn and Simo Frestadius, 236-54. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Church Planting Movements

A chapter in a volume of Anglican and Pentecostal dialogue, written by Ric Thorpe as Bishop of Islington and leader of the Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication. Its first part is a history of Anglican planting from Augustine's mission of 597, on the argument that almost every church was planted when it was first created; its last traces the three waves by which Pentecostalism reached Anglicanism, from Alexander Boddy at Sunderland to John Wimber's influence on the Anglican planting centres, and sets the parish system's stability against the Pentecostal freedom from ancient structures.

Wier, Andy, and Edd Graham-Hyde. *Seeing the Shoots: A Report for the Scottish Church Planters Network*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, December 2024. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/Final-Report-Church-Planting-in-Scotland.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A survey of church planting in Scotland, commissioned by the Scottish Church Planters Network from Church Army's Research Unit: interviews with 14 denominations and networks, and 104 responses from plant leaders. Its finding is that nobody knows the number, because many bodies keep no central record, and that a conservative floor is 200 plants since 2010. Median attendance has grown from 14 at launch to 45, with a median of one faith commitment a year.

WHAT MAKES A CHURCH GROW

Bell, James, and Jill Hopkinson. *Shaping Strategies for Mission and Growth in Rural Multi-Church Groups: A Summary of Key Findings and Implications of Recent Research*. Archbishops' Council, 2017. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2017-11/shaping-strategies-for-mission-and-growth-in-rural-multi-church-groups.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Rural and Market Towns

A short report from the Church of England's Archbishops' Council, signed by James Bell, Bishop of Ripon, and Jill Hopkinson, its national rural officer, which draws together *Released for Mission* (2016), the Church Growth Research Programme's *Going Deeper* and George Lings's case for multiplying churches. It sets out six characteristics its sources associate with growth in rural multi-church groups, co-operation within and between groups among them, and names next steps for the groups and for the diocesan strategies that support them.

Bretherton, Roger, and R. I. M. Dunbar. 'Dunbar's Number Goes to Church: The Social Brain Hypothesis as a Third Strand in the Study of Church Growth'. *Archive for the Psychology of Religion* 42, no. 1 (2020): 63-76. <https://ora.ox.ac.uk/objects/uuid:447ef235-8ef6-4ee6-b91a-68a6a3d9316b>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Ecclesiology

A journal article proposing Robin Dunbar's social brain hypothesis, which ties the size of human social groups to the size of the brain, as a third strand in the study of church growth beside the Church Growth Movement and social science. It derives five predictions and tests each against the church growth literature: among them, that engagement falls as a congregation grows, that a congregation led by one person is limited to about 150, and that growth beyond that forces reorganisation and tension. The section on transitions in group size bears most directly on a church growing past 150.

Evans, Ray. *Ready, Steady, Grow: Equipping Today's Gospel Churches*. London: IVP, 2014.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A practical guide to leading a church through growth, by a pastor of four decades in Bedford. Its case is that many leaders 'have learned how to lead what they have, but they don't know how to take it forward', and it sets out, stage by stage, what changes as a congregation grows. Neil Powell's review, filed beside it in this list, argues for growth by planting further congregations rather than by growing one larger.

Francis, Leslie J., and Philip J. Richter. *Gone for Good?: Church-Leaving and Returning in the Twenty-First Century*. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A monograph by Leslie J. Francis and Philip Richter, drawn from interviews and questionnaires with people who had left churches across British denominations, and a sequel to their *Gone but Not Forgotten* (1998). It sorts what leavers gave as reasons into 15 themes, from disillusionment and being let down by the church to problems with worship, leadership and belief, and asks which leavers are the more likely to return. Its evidence bears on the biological and transfer sides of British church growth rather than on new church plants, which this list treats separately under For Planting Specifically.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *On This Rock: Simple Lessons and Achievable Habits for Church Growth*. FirestartersUK, 2023.

ALSO IN Baptist; Practical Guides; Missional Spirituality

A booklet setting out seven habits held in common by British Baptist churches seeing conversion growth, from small plants to larger established congregations, drawn from the Firestarters Network's conversations. Among them are intensity of prayer and fasting, and reorganising more often than you think. Each chapter grounds one habit in scripture, tells the story of a church that has practised it and closes with questions and next steps. Written for the leaders of existing churches to work through together.

Henard, Bill. *ReClaimed Church: How Churches Grow, Decline, and Experience Revitalization*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2018.

ALSO IN Baptist; Revitalisation and Replanting

A book that treats a congregation's growth, plateau and decline as stages of one life cycle, from birth to death, and sets out a process by which a church can return to growth: reassess, rethink, realign and reaffirm. Its third part, on the factors that determine growth or decline, bears most directly on growth; the fourth, on steps towards revitalisation, on a church already in decline. Written, in the publisher's description, for struggling churches.

Jackson, Bob. *What Makes Churches Grow? Vision and Practice in Effective Mission*. London: Church House Publishing, 2015.

ANNOTATED under Growth in Britain

Keller, Timothy. *Leadership and Church Size Dynamics: How Strategy Changes with Growth*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2010. First published in *The Movement* newsletter, 2006; reprinted as 'Process Managing Church Growth: How Strategy Changes Over Time' in *Cutting Edge*, Spring 2008. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/leadership-and-church-size-dynamics/>.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A paper on how a church's size changes its leadership, in five bands from the house church of up to 40 to the very large church of over 800. It describes what changes inside a church as it grows rather than what makes it grow. Keller argues that size culture runs deeper than tradition: churches of 100 and 1,000 may differ more than a Presbyterian and a Baptist church of the same size. Mark Dever and Jonathan Leeman (9Marks, 2024) accept that insight but question several specifics, calling the paper descriptive sociology rather than prescriptive theology.

Mallon, James. *Divine Renovation: Bringing Your Parish from Maintenance to Mission*. New London, CT: Twenty-Third Publications, 2014.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Parish Church; Revitalisation and Replanting; Theory of Change

A book by a Catholic parish priest in Halifax, Nova Scotia, drawn from the renewal he led in his own parish. It argues that a parish moves from maintenance to mission when it stops being a membership-based community and becomes an assembly of disciples who proclaim and share the good news.

Neill, Tricia. *From Vision to Action: Practical Steps for Church Growth*. New ed. London: Alpha International, 2013.

A practical guide to turning a church's vision into working practice, by the executive director of Alpha International, which tells the story of Alpha's growth at Holy Trinity Brompton in London. This edition adds a section by Ric Thorpe on forming a vision. Unlike the other books in this list, it is written from a British church.

Paas, Stefan, and Alrik Vos. 'Church Planting and Church Growth in Western Europe: An Analysis'. *International Bulletin of Mission Research* 40, no. 3 (2016): 243–52.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Europe; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

An article testing, with data, whether planting churches grows the church numerically or only moves Christians between congregations. Paas and Vos compare older and younger churches in three small Reformed denominations in the Netherlands and find the younger ones gained about four times as many converts and five times as many returnees, which they credit to location, outreach and entrepreneurial leadership rather than to planting as such. Among the studies of biological, transfer and conversion growth it is one of the few to test the connection to planting empirically.

Powell, Neil. 'Review Article: Ready, Steady, Grow'. Review of *Ready, Steady, Grow: Equipping Today's Gospel Churches*, by Ray Evans. *Foundations*, no. 67 (Autumn 2014): 99-104. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-67/issue-67-article-7-review-article-ready-steady-grow-ray-evans/>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A review article by Neil Powell, pastor of City Church Birmingham, which he co-founded in 1999, on Ray Evans's *Ready, Steady, Grow* (2014) and its case for growing larger churches. Powell does not find the argument compelling. He sets against it the practice of his own church and others in Birmingham, which 'pursue growth through multiple church-planting', and argues that congregations working together reach more people and raise up more leaders than one congregation could.

Schwarz, Christian A. *Natural Church Development: A Guide to Eight Essential Qualities of Healthy Churches*. Carol Stream, IL: ChurchSmart Resources, 1996.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

A book setting out eight quality characteristics that Schwarz found in growing churches through a survey of about 1,000 churches on six continents, among them gift-oriented ministry and holistic small groups. It argues that growth follows health, 'quality is the root and quantity is the fruit', and that a church grows only as far as its weakest quality, the 'minimum factor', allows. Ellas and Yeakley (*Journal of the American Society for Church Growth*, 1999) call its research foundation 'pseudo-science'.

Stanley, Andy. *Deep and Wide: Creating Churches Unchurched People Love to Attend*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

An account of North Point Community Church's model by its founder, arguing that a church can be deep for believers and wide enough to draw outsiders, where most drift into serving insiders. The opening chapters, on North Point's beginnings as a plant amid his father's divorce and a church split, bear most directly on planting; the section 'Going Wide' sets out how the church reaches outsiders.

Warren, Robert. *The Healthy Churches' Handbook: A Process for Revitalizing Your Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Anglican; Practical Guides; Parish Church

A handbook setting out seven marks of a healthy church, each a contrast, such as energised by faith rather than just keeping things going, with a process by which a congregation reviews itself against them, from a detailed review to a single evening. It treats health in qualitative terms rather than as numerical growth. The Diocese of Southwark uses the marks to frame visits to every parish by its bishops and archdeacons. The chapter 'The angel of the church' concerns a congregation's character, buildings, setting and story.

Wilson, Todd, and Dave Ferguson. *Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church Field Guide*. Exponential, 2015. <https://exponential.org/resource-ebooks/becomingfive/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A field guide that places a church on a five-level scale, from Level 1, marked by subtraction and survival, to Level 5, marked by multiplying, releasing and sending, with an additional chapter by Alan Hirsch. It holds that growth by addition is Level 3, beyond which most churches never go, and that a movement needs churches that multiply. The appendix describing the five levels would help a team assessing its own church.

GROWTH IN CHRISTIAN HISTORY

Adams, Kevin. *A Diary of the Revival: The Outbreak of the 1904 Welsh Awakening*. Special centenary edition. Farnham: CWR, 2004.

A compilation of Evan Roberts's own diary extracts, letters and eyewitness accounts, assembled by Kevin Adams for the centenary of the Welsh Revival of 1904 to 1905, many not previously published. It gives an account of Roberts himself before presenting the revival's outbreak through the letters and diaries of participants and speakers. Among the entries on growth in Christian history it is the one contemporary record of a revival, closer to a diary than to an analytical history.

Kreider, Alan. *The Patient Ferment of the Early Church: The Improbable Rise of Christianity in the Roman Empire*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Theory of Change

A historical study of how the church grew across the Roman Empire in its first three centuries, drawing on Tertullian, Cyprian and the *Apostolic Tradition*. Kreider finds the engine of that growth in habitus, patience and formation: a way of life shaped by catechesis that often lasted up to three years before baptism. It would be of use to anyone arguing that discipleship and numerical growth belong together.

Lovelace, Richard F. *Dynamics of Spiritual Life: An Evangelical Theology of Renewal*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1979.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality

A study of spiritual renewal drawn from the history of revival since the Reformation, weighted towards Jonathan Edwards and written from a Reformed standpoint. It sets out the preconditions of continuous renewal and its primary and secondary elements before turning to practice, in chapters such as 'The Renewal of the Local Congregation' and 'How Revivals Go Wrong'. An expanded edition of 2020 has a foreword by Timothy Keller.

Orr-Ewing, Frog. 'A Few Lessons for Church Growth and Planting New Worshipping Communities from the Victorian Anglicans'. Unpublished paper, n.d. <https://www.academia.edu/22209550/>.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

An unpublished paper of seven pages, undated and posted by the author on Academia.edu, drawing lessons for church growth and planting today from Victorian Anglican church planting. It comes out of Orr-Ewing's doctoral research on Victorian church planting in London, completed at King's College London in 2018.

Stark, Rodney. *Cities of God: The Real Story of How Christianity Became an Urban Movement and Conquered Rome*. San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 2006.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A companion to Stark's *The Rise of Christianity* (1996), narrowing that book's model of network-driven conversion specifically to the empire's cities: a hypothesis tested against data gathered from 31 major Roman urban centres, with a data appendix. Where the earlier book modelled the overall growth curve across the empire, this one argues that growth is concentrated in, and explained by, its densely networked cities. Quantitative and empire-wide rather than urban-theological, it sits closer to historical sociology than to planting practice.

Stark, Rodney. *The Rise of Christianity: A Sociologist Reconsiders History*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1996.

A sociologist's account of how Christianity grew from about 1,000 believers in AD40 to six million by 300, at roughly 40 per cent a decade, a rate Stark checks against Mormon growth between 1880 and 1980. He credits conversion through existing networks, the higher status the church offered women and better survival of epidemics through nursing. Bart Ehrman disputes its starting figure and questions its handling of the ancient sources.

Historical Examples

Celtic and Early British Mission

Celtic and early British mission is the conversion of the peoples of Britain and Ireland between the fifth century and the eighth, and the mission their churches then sent to the Continent. Its principal figures are Patrick in Ireland, Columba and the community he founded on Iona, and the monks and bishops who went out from Iona and from the mission sent from Rome to Kent in 597.

This list holds the sources and histories of that mission and what later writers have made of it; a book on evangelism or church planting is here for its use of the mission rather than for its method.

Interest in a distinctively Celtic Christianity has revived more than once since the Middle Ages, most recently among writers on mission and spirituality at the end of the twentieth century, and the principal disagreement is over whether the mission can be recovered as a model for mission now. George Hunter's *The Celtic Way of Evangelism* finds in it a pattern in which people are welcomed into a community's life before they come to believe, and commends that pattern for reaching the secular West. Ian Bradley's *Celtic Christianity: Making Myths and Chasing Dreams* and Donald Meek's *The Quest for Celtic Christianity* argue that the 'Celtic Christianity' of popular revivals owes more to the needs of later ages than to the sources.

This list runs from Start Here through The Mission Itself to What Has Been Made of It.

START HERE

Bede. *Ecclesiastical History of the English People*. Completed 731. Translated by Leo Sherley-Price, revised by R. E. Latham, with an introduction and notes by D. H. Farmer. London: Penguin Classics, 1990. Also free online in A. M. Sellar's older translation at <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/38326/38326-h/38326-h.html>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Missiology

A primary text, completed by Bede at Jarrow in 731 and dedicated to King Ceolwulf of Northumbria, and the principal source for how England was evangelised. It is organised around the conversion of successive kingdoms and their rulers, and says little about missionary work among ordinary people. Book I includes Augustine's mission from Rome, and Book III Aidan's mission from Iona and the Synod of Whitby (664), which settled the dispute between Roman and Irish practice, chiefly over the date of Easter; the two books would be a good starting point for comparing the missions.

Wakefield, Gavin. 'Myths of Celtic Christianity'. *Anvil* 23, no. 3 (2006): 191-206. https://biblicalstudies.org.uk/pdf/anvil/23-3_191.pdf.

An article in *Anvil*, an Anglican evangelical journal of theology and mission, by Gavin Wakefield, for more than 10 years the mission tutor at Cranmer Hall, Durham. It began as a paper given in September 2004 at a conference in Durham on the myth of Celtic Christianity. It would make a short first reading to set beside Bede's *Ecclesiastical History*.

THE MISSION ITSELF

Adomnán of Iona. *Life of St Columba*. Translated with an introduction and notes by Richard Sharpe. London: Penguin Classics, 1995.

A primary text, written in Latin at Iona probably between 697 and 700, a century after Columba's death, by his kinsman Adomnán, ninth abbot of the community Columba founded; it predates Bede's *Ecclesiastical History* by a generation. Arranged by theme, in three books of prophecies, miracles and visions of angels, with few dates, it shows Columba as abbot among his monks and is a source for the Picts. Sharpe, the translator, notes that Adomnán's knowledge of earlier saints' lives influenced the book's structure and language, and may in places have shaped how its stories are told.

Bede. *Ecclesiastical History of the English People*. Completed 731. Translated by Leo Sherley-Price, revised by R. E. Latham, with an introduction and notes by D. H. Farmer. London: Penguin Classics, 1990. Also free online in A. M. Sellar's older translation at <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/38326/38326-h/38326-h.html>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Columbanus. *Saint Columbanus: Selected Writings*. Edited by Alexander O'Hara. Dublin: Veritas, 2015.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book of selected writings by Columbanus, edited by Alexander O'Hara for the 1,400th anniversary of his death in 615. Columbanus, the Irish counterweight to Benedict and much sterner, worked on the Continent rather than in Britain; the book shows Irish monastic mission abroad in a missionary's own words. Peter Costello, reviewing it in *The Irish Catholic*, describes it as a brief survey 'immediately accessible to the general reader'. It would be useful for seeing that the monastic tradition was never monolithic.

Finney, John. *Recovering the Past: Celtic and Roman Mission*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1996.

ALSO IN Missiology; Evangelism

A book setting the Celtic mission to England from Iona and Lindisfarne beside Augustine's mission from Rome: a comparative account of the two missions Bede narrates, reaching back to Patrick and Pelagius. Finney wrote it as bishop of Pontefract, after serving as the Church of England's officer for the Decade of Evangelism.

Mayr-Harting, Henry. *The Coming of Christianity to Anglo-Saxon England*. 3rd ed. London: Batsford, 1991.

A study, by a medieval historian, of the conversion of the Anglo-Saxon kingdoms. It asks how Christianity was shaped in England as well as how it arrived, giving weight to the Roman and Irish traditions and to the churchmen who carried out the mission. The third edition adds a preface reconsidering the 1972 first edition's conclusions, and a chapter on Boniface carrying the account on to the eighth-century English mission to the Continent.

Patrick. *The Works of St Patrick; St Secundinus, Hymn on St Patrick*. Translated and annotated by Ludwig Bieler. Ancient Christian Writers 17. Westminster, MD: Newman Press, 1953. Also free online in McCarthy's translation, published by the Royal Irish Academy, at https://www.confessio.ie/etexts/confessio_english, where the *Letter to Coroticus* is also given.

A translation of two Latin texts by Patrick, bishop in fifth-century Ireland: the earlier *Letter to Coroticus*, excommunicating Coroticus and his soldiers, whose raid had carried off baptised converts, and the *Confessio*, written in old age, which credits God with the whole success of his mission. Where Adomnán and Bede write about other people's missions, Patrick writes of his own, of baptising many and of clergy ordained everywhere for new believers. Bieler also edited the Latin text used by the Royal Irish Academy's [confessio.ie](https://www.confessio.ie).

Wakefield, Gavin. *Holy Places, Holy People*. Oxford: Lion Hudson, 2008.

A pilgrim's guide to the Christian sites of the North East, place by place: Lindisfarne, Hexham and Heavenfield, Jarrow and Monkwearmouth, and Durham, with their saints from Aidan and Oswald to Bede. It is written, its publisher says, for pilgrims 'who want the wisdom of the past to shape their present'. Where Wakefield's two *Anvil* articles in this list write about Celtic Christianity for a theological journal, this book takes the reader to the places themselves.

WHAT HAS BEEN MADE OF IT

Bevins, Winfield. 'Think Like St. Patrick'. In 'What Is the Biggest Change Evangelical Seminaries Need to Make Right Now?' *Christianity Today*, November 2012. <https://www.christianitytoday.com/ct/2012/november/what-is-biggest-change-evangelical-seminaries-need-to-make.html>.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Leadership in Church Planting

A short opinion piece in which Winfield Bevins answers a symposium question on seminary reform by pointing to Saint Patrick and the later Celtic monastic centres at Iona and Lindisfarne, arguing that seminaries should require a church-planting internship alongside academic study. One of three proposals printed together, with Dan Kimball and Cheryl Sanders.

Bevins, Winfield. *Multiplying Disciples: What Movements Can Teach Us About Discipleship*. Exponential, 2019. <https://exponential.org/product/multiplying-disciples/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Discipleship

A booklet drawing on three disciple-making movements from church history, the Celtic, the Moravian and the Methodist, for what each can teach the church now. Where Hunter's *The Celtic Way of Evangelism* takes the Celtic mission alone as a model for evangelism, Bevins sets it beside two later movements. His *Marks of a Movement* gives early Methodism a book to itself; this booklet would be a shorter first reading across all three.

Bradley, Ian. *Celtic Christianity: Making Myths and Chasing Dreams*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 1999.

A history of the revivals of Celtic Christianity, by a church historian. Bradley gives a chapter to each of six periods, from the early Middle Ages to the present, in which writers idealised a Celtic 'golden age' to answer the religious and political needs of their own time. The present-day enthusiasm is the last of the six.

Bradley, Ian. *Following the Celtic Way: A New Assessment of Celtic Christianity*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2018.

A reassessment by Ian Bradley of his own *The Celtic Way* (1993): a new book rather than a revision, written 25 years on and closer to the original sources. It turns the same corrective as his *Celtic Christianity: Making Myths and Chasing Dreams* (1999) on Celtic spirituality's romantic image, replacing his earlier, softer account with a harder-edged one, organised by theme rather than by history. An accessible update rather than the fuller critical argument.

Cockayne, Joshua, and Scott Harrower. *Exploring a Theology for Church Planting: Learning from Bede as Evangelist, Prophet, Scribe*. Church Multiplication 1. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2024.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A booklet, the first in Grove's Church Multiplication series, arguing that church planting, at times treated by advocates and critics alike as a purely pragmatic task, needs a clear theological basis. Cockayne and Harrower offer Bede as one source for it, since he held a commitment to mission and church growth together with scholarly study of the world, the past and Scripture. Where Smith's *Church Planting by the Book* argues from Acts, it looks for its theology in the early English church.

Hunter, George G., III. *The Celtic Way of Evangelism: How Christianity Can Reach the West . . . Again*. 10th anniversary ed. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Evangelism; Missiology

A book arguing that the Celtic evangelisation of Ireland and Britain, from Patrick in the fifth century to Aidan in the seventh, reached a 'barbarian' culture more effectively than the Roman model. The table in chapter 4 sets the two side by side: the Roman model moves from presentation to decision to fellowship, the Celtic from fellowship to ministry and conversation to belief. Hunter, an American, writes for the church across the West, and chapters 7 and 8 apply the Celtic model to reaching its secular society.

Meek, Donald E. *The Quest for Celtic Christianity*. Edinburgh: Handsel Press, 2000.

A critical study of the present-day revival of Celtic Christianity by a Gaelic scholar from Tiree, testing it against scholarship on the early churches. Meek argues that the soul friend (*anamchara*), popularly an informal companion, belonged to a discipline of confession and penance, and that *peregrinatio*, monastic wandering, was strictly regulated and often served practical ends such as gathering relics. Where Bradley's *Celtic Christianity* traces six revivals across the centuries, Meek works from particular concepts and concentrates on the present one.

Wakefield, Gavin. 'Mission in the Spirit: Revivalist and Celtic Strands of Mission'. *Anvil* 18, no. 1 (2001): 7-19. https://biblicalstudies.org.uk/pdf/anvil/18-1_007.pdf.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article comparing the theologies of mission of two Anglican charismatics, Mark Stibbe and Ray Simpson, which turn out to have almost nothing in common. Stibbe's is revivalist, driven by a burden for the lost and an implicitly penal account of the atonement; Simpson's is Celtic, motivated by love for God and creation. Wakefield tests both against the Five Marks of Mission and finds each underpowered on the origin of mission in God.

Wakefield, Gavin. 'Myths of Celtic Christianity'. *Anvil* 23, no. 3 (2006): 191-206. https://biblicalstudies.org.uk/pdf/anvil/23-3_191.pdf.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Early Methodist Church Planting

This list is about how Methodism spread by gathering new societies, classes and chapels, from the first societies John Wesley formed to the reunion of the main Methodist bodies in 1932, and about what present-day writers have drawn from it.

'Early' here means the whole of that expansion, not Wesley's lifetime alone, so Primitive Methodism and the Bible Christians belong to it, and so does Francis Asbury's American Methodism. Present-day Methodist and Wesleyan writing on planting belongs to Methodist and Wesleyan, under Church Traditions; the Church of England's building of new churches in the same century is in Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension. Wesley's *General Rules* and the class meeting, read as a rule of life, are also in Rule of Life.

The books divide between those that read the movement for a pattern the church can use now and histories that explain from within how it grew. Howard Snyder's *The Radical Wesley* (1980) took Wesley's system as a model for the renewal of the church today; David Hempton's *Methodism: Empire of the Spirit* (2005) accounts for the movement's growth and decline by tensions within it. Other histories narrate how its structures emerged without taking either side.

This list runs from Start Here to Wesley and the Movement, then Classes, Bands and Societies, on the small groups and their recovery today, and Methodism in the North East of England.

START HERE

Bevins, Winfield. *Marks of a Movement: What the Church Today Can Learn from the Wesleyan Revival*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2019.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A book analysing how and why early Methodism was so effective in England and America, looking at changed lives, a reliance on the Holy Spirit, and discipleship and leadership training. It draws from the Wesleyan revival a call to the church today to make disciples, is written for pastors, church leaders and church planters, and may be useful to readers who assume movement language is a modern invention. Exponential's free ebook of the year before, *Marks of a Multiplying Movement*, shares its subtitle.

Snyder, Howard A. *The Radical Wesley and Patterns for Church Renewal*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1980.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

A study of Wesley's early Methodism as a pattern for church renewal today. Paul Mickey's review in *Christianity Today* (1981) found the key to Snyder's Wesley in his doctrine of the church, balancing inner experience, the sacraments and social witness through the classes and societies. Revised in 2014 as *The Radical Wesley: The Patterns and Practices of a Movement-Maker*.

Turner, John Munsey. *John Wesley: The Evangelical Revival and the Rise of Methodism in England*. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2002.

A study of John Wesley and the rise of Methodism in England by a Methodist minister and historian, one of the books marking the tercentenary of Wesley's birth in 2003 that Barrie Tabraham reviewed together in the *Journal of Ecclesiastical History*. Where Snyder's *The Radical Wesley* and Bevins's *Marks of a Movement* read early Methodism for what the church can learn from it now, Turner's book is a history of the movement.

WESLEY AND THE MOVEMENT

Bevins, Winfield. *Marks of a Movement: What the Church Today Can Learn from the Wesleyan Revival*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2019.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Bevins, Winfield. *Marks of a Multiplying Movement: What the Church Today Can Learn from the Wesleyan Revival*. Exponential, 2018. <https://exponential.org/resource-ebooks/marks-of-a-movement>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A free ebook from Exponential in which Winfield Bevins draws from the Wesleyan revival marks of a multiplying movement for the church today. It shares its subtitle with his *Marks of a Movement*, published by Zondervan the following year, and would be a way into that argument for a reader without the book.

Carter, David. *Love Bade Me Welcome: A British Methodist Perspective on the Church*. Exploring Methodism. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2002.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan; Ecclesiology

A history and account of British Methodist ecclesiology from the Wesleys to the present, setting classical Wesleyan thought beside Methodism's other strands and within wider ecumenical discussion. Carter writes as an ecumenist, for churches in dialogue with Methodists as well as for Methodists; the back cover calls it the first book on its subject since 1964, and the *Dictionary of Methodism in Britain and Ireland* cites it on connexionalism. The opening chapters treat the Wesleys, the first Methodists and classical Wesleyan ecclesiology.

Heitzenrater, Richard P. *Wesley and the People Called Methodists*. 2nd ed. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2013.

A history of Wesley and the Methodist movement from its roots to Wesley's death in 1791, told in six periods. Its publisher describes it as the story of the many people who contributed to Methodism's theology, organisation and mission. The second edition, of 2013, entails 'many significant revisions and emendations, based on twenty additional years of research', its preface says. Where Rack's *Reasonable Enthusiast* follows Wesley's life, this follows the movement and its people.

Hempton, David. *Methodism: Empire of the Spirit*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2005.

A history of Methodism from a society within the Church of England in the 1730s to an international movement by the 1880s. Thomas W. Simpson, reviewing it in the *Journal of the American Academy of Religion*, finds its account of growth and decline organised around tensions inherent in the movement's origins and development.

Hunter, George G., III. *The Recovery of a Contagious Methodist Movement*. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Methodist and Wesleyan

A short book arguing that Methodism began as a missional alternative to establishment Christianity and has come to resemble the establishment it once criticised. Its remedy, as Randy Willis summarises it in his review, is for North American Methodism to recover, as well as Wesley's theological vision, three directions in ministry: lay ministries, small groups and missional Christianity. Hunter treats the early movement's practice as something a present-day denomination can take up again.

Milburn, Geoffrey. *Primitive Methodism*. Exploring Methodism 5. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2002.

A history of Primitive Methodism, one of the three churches that united in 1932 to form the present Methodist Church. Its publisher describes it as covering a century or more of the connexion's life, with particular attention to Hugh Bourne and William Clowes, both working laymen. Where Patterson's *Northern Primitive Methodism* records the circuits of one district, Milburn tells the connexion's story as a whole.

Murray, Iain H. *Wesley and Men Who Followed*. Edinburgh: Banner of Truth Trust, 2003.

A book asking why Methodism gained momentum after Wesley's death rather than dwindling. Murray writes from a Reformed standpoint, and his answer is spiritual: John Hannah's review summarises the closing argument as resting a movement's success on 'a deep personal devotedness to the Bible' and 'earnest prayer'. Of its four parts, the second, on the preachers William Bramwell, Gideon Ouseley and Thomas Collins, bears most directly on the movement after Wesley's death.

Rack, Henry D. *Reasonable Enthusiast: John Wesley and the Rise of Methodism*. 3rd ed. London: Epworth Press, 2002.

A full scholarly biography of John Wesley, some 680 pages long, that follows the rise of Methodism through his life. The third edition, of 2002, is a revision of the first, of 1989.

Snyder, Howard A. *Signs of the Spirit: How God Reshapes the Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1989.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Ecclesiology

A study of four renewal movements, the Montanists, the Pietists, the Moravians and the early Methodists, read for what recurs across them, including judgement on the institutional church, non-traditional leadership, lay ministry and evangelistic vitality. From these Snyder builds a theology of renewal, and he closes with a renewal strategy for the local church. The chapters on the Methodist revolution and on the dynamics of renewal movements bear most directly on early Methodism and on what renewal movements share.

Snyder, Howard A. *The Radical Wesley and Patterns for Church Renewal*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1980.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Turner, John Munsey. *John Wesley: The Evangelical Revival and the Rise of Methodism in England*. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2002.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Wesley, John. 'The Nature, Design, and General Rules of the United Societies'. In *The Works of John Wesley, Volume 9: The Methodist Societies; History, Nature, and Design*, edited by Rupert E. Davies, 69-73. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1989.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A pamphlet of 1743 in which Wesley defines the United Societies as companies meeting to pray together, receive exhortation and watch over one another in love. It asks of those joining only a desire to flee from the wrath to come, and gives three rules, to do no harm, to do good and to attend the ordinances of God, which class leaders enforced, if need be by exclusion. It would be worth reading in the original rather than through commentators.

Wesley, John. *A Plain Account of the People Called Methodists, in a Letter to the Revd Mr Perronet*. 1749.

https://archive.org/details/bim_eighteenth-century_a-plain-account-of-the-p_wesley-john_1749.

A letter of 1749 to Vincent Perronet, Vicar of Shoreham, in which Wesley describes how the Methodist society and its organisation began. The society arose 'without any previous design' from a Thursday evening meeting for those who had come to him for advice; the classes began at Bristol as a scheme for paying off a building debt and became weekly pastoral oversight by their leaders. Where Wesley's *General Rules* (1743) state what the societies required of their members, this letter tells how they came about, and its first two sections, on the society and the classes, would be the place to begin.

Wigger, John H. *American Saint: Francis Asbury and the Methodists*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2009.

A scholarly biography of Francis Asbury, a major figure of early American Methodism. Ann Taves, reviewing it in the *American Historical Review*, calls it long overdue: Asbury had drawn less study than Jonathan Edwards, George Whitefield or Joseph Smith because his ideas, being derivative, seemed less interesting.

CLASSES, BANDS AND SOCIETIES

Henderson, D. Michael. *John Wesley's Class Meeting: A Model for Making Disciples*. Nappanee, IN: Evangel Publishing House, 1997.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Discipleship

A study of Wesley's methods of forming disciples in small groups, and of the class meeting as a model for making disciples today. Like Kevin Watson's *The Class Meeting*, it is on the small-group machinery behind the General Rules, but it describes every part of the system — society, class, band and select society — where Watson keeps to the class. Charles Yrigoyen, reviewing it in *Methodist History* (1998), notes errors of fact, among them the year of Wesley's death.

Meadows, Philip R. *House Fellowship: A Quick Guide*. Spiritual Formation for Mission 3. Inspire Movement, 2021.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan

The third of the Inspire Movement's quick guides in its Spiritual Formation for Mission series (2021), by Philip Meadows, who co-founded the movement to recover discipleship and mission in the Wesleyan spirit. After the second guide, on the fellowship band, this one turns to the house fellowship: a small community meeting in an ordinary home to eat, pray, search the scriptures and watch over one another, then scattering to share the gospel, which may renew a local church or become the foundation of a new plant.

Meadows, Philip R., and Anthony Watts. *Fellowship Band: A Quick Guide*. Spiritual Formation for Mission 2. Inspire Movement, 2019.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Missional Spirituality; Methodist and Wesleyan

A quick guide to the fellowship band — three or four friends meeting regularly for spiritual conversation — as practised in the Inspire Movement, the international and ecumenical network for mission-shaped discipleship in the Wesleyan spirit that Meadows co-founded in 2007.

Thomas, Justin. 'Using John Wesley's Methodist Society as a Model for Lay Leader Development'. Master of Theology Studies thesis, Regent University, 2022.

A 2022 master's thesis from Regent University that takes John Wesley's Methodist society as a model for developing lay leaders. It would suit a reader asking what the early Methodist structures might offer a church today in forming leaders who are not ordained.

Watson, Kevin M. *A Blueprint for Discipleship: Wesley's General Rules as a Guide for Christian Living*. Nashville, TN: Discipleship Resources, 2009.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Methodist and Wesleyan

A book for lay readers that takes the General Rules seriously as a rule of life rather than as a historical curiosity. Watson builds a pattern of discipleship on Wesley's three rules, which he renders as do no harm, do good and practise the spiritual disciplines, and on members watching over one another in love in accountable small groups. George King's review notes that the charge of legalism, which a reader may raise early, is answered only in chapter seven.

Watson, Kevin M. *The Class Meeting: Reclaiming a Forgotten (and Essential) Small Group Experience*. Franklin, TN: Seedbed, 2013.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Methodist and Wesleyan

A guide to the small-group machinery that made the General Rules workable, written for groups starting a class meeting. Watson argues that early Methodists met in small groups to talk together about their souls, not only to study the Bible, and gives a group a shared language for the work of the Holy Spirit and a structure for its meetings. It is an eight-week study, after which the group sets the book aside and carries on as a class meeting.

Wesley, John. 'The Nature, Design, and General Rules of the United Societies'. In *The Works of John Wesley, Volume 9: The Methodist Societies; History, Nature, and Design*, edited by Rupert E. Davies, 69-73. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1989.

ANNOTATED under Wesley and the Movement

Wesley, John. *A Plain Account of the People Called Methodists, in a Letter to the Revd Mr Perronet*. 1749.

https://archive.org/details/bim_eighteenth-century_a-plain-account-of-the-p_wesley-john_1749.

ANNOTATED under Wesley and the Movement

METHODISM IN THE NORTH EAST OF ENGLAND

Charlton, Evelyn M. *Methodism in the Allen Dales*. Nenthead: North Pennines Heritage Trust, 1998.

A local history of Methodism in the two Allen dales of the North Pennines. Allen Valleys Local History describes its subject as how the movement developed there and why it thrived in that locality, where Wesleyan and then Primitive Methodist chapels were established across the dales.

Heatherington, David, ed. *An Extract of the Rev Mr John Wesley's Journal: His Journeys through Weardale, May 1752 to June 1790*. Ireshopeburn: Weardale Museum, 1993.

A booklet of extracts from Wesley's *Journal* recording his journeys through Weardale between May 1752 and June 1790, published by the Weardale Museum, and so confined to one dale and to Wesley's own record.

Milburn, Geoffrey E. *The Travelling Preacher: John Wesley in the North East, 1742-1790; With Details Also of the Work of Charles Wesley and Other Early Methodist Preachers*. Sunderland: Wesley Historical Society (North East Branch), 1987.

A collection of extracts from the journals of John and Charles Wesley and other early Methodist preachers, assembled to trace the development of Methodism in the North East between 1742 and 1790. It ranges over the whole region and several preachers, where Heatherington's extract keeps to Wesley in Weardale. Reissued by the Methodist Publishing House in 2003.

Moore, Robert. *Pit-Men, Preachers and Politics: The Effects of Methodism in a Durham Mining Community*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1974.

A sociological study of four Durham mining villages between 1870 and 1926, and of the effects of Methodism on their political life. Its publisher says Moore lived in the community and reports first-hand on the villagers he talked with. For the societies themselves, the second of the two chapters on village Methodism, on the structure of the Methodist societies in the Deerness Valley, would be a useful place to look.

Patterson, William M. *Northern Primitive Methodism: A Record of the Rise and Progress of the Circuits in the Old Sunderland District*. London: E. Dalton, 1909. <https://archive.org/details/northernprimitiv00pattuoft>.

An account, published in 1909, of Primitive Methodism's growth in the old Sunderland District, taken circuit by circuit from Cleveland to Cumberland and the Scottish Borders. Its foreword calls it 'a simple statement' rather than 'scientific history', and hopes to inspire in readers the devotion of their 'spiritual ancestry'. It has been reprinted in facsimile.

Pollard, H. *John Wesley in Northumberland*. London: SPCK, 1949.

A 23-page pamphlet by Hazel Pollard on John Wesley in Northumberland, published by SPCK in 1949: an account of Wesley in the county, where Milburn's *The Travelling Preacher* prints the journals themselves.

Short, Colin C. *Durham Colliers and West Country Methodists: The Story of the Bible Christian Mission in County Durham, 1874-1910*. Kidderminster: C. C. Short, 1995.

A history of the Bible Christian mission to County Durham between 1874 and 1910, published by its author. The Bible Christians, a Methodist connexion from the West Country, sent missions to mining migrants in the north, to Cumbria in 1871 and County Durham in 1874. The *Dictionary of Methodism in Britain and Ireland* cites the book on the Durham mission.

Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

Church extension was the nineteenth- and early twentieth-century name for what is now called church planting: the founding of new churches and parishes for populations that had outgrown the parish system, and the work of the diocesan and denominational societies formed to pay for them and to build them. The heading uses the period's own term. Its span runs longer than the two reigns suggest, because the same machinery of appeals, societies and new parishes was still at work in the suburbs built between the wars, and this reading list carries the story that far. Roland Allen, who wrote into the 1930s, belongs here for a different reason: his quarrel was with the assumptions the movement was built on, although he made it about the mission field abroad. The period's own words for what it built are worth knowing: a chapel of ease, a church built within a parish for those who could not conveniently reach the parish church and remaining dependent on it; a district church, given a district carved out of a parish that could in time become a parish of its own, under the church building legislation of 1818 and after, whose commissioners had powers to divide parishes; a mission room or mission hall, the modest and sometimes temporary building that often came first; and, still in use today, a conventional district, an area with an identity of its own served short of parish status, which may be a stepping stone to a parish.

The material is of three kinds. There are lives and letters written at the time; there are modern histories of what was built and how it was paid for; and there is fieldwork in present-day plants set against Victorian practice, which is a way of asking the question rather than a way of answering it.

Two ways of reading the period run through all three. One takes it as precedent, the last occasion on which the English churches built at scale, and looks to it for lessons about planting now, which is what Bevins and Orr-Ewing set out to do. The other takes it as history to be understood in its own terms before anything is drawn from it, which is how Walford proceeds, and which tends to complicate the lessons. Allen makes a third objection: that a church planted and staffed by a paid professional class sent in from outside cannot become what the New Testament churches were, so that the method itself was what was wrong with it.

This reading list opens with *Start Here*, then *How They Did It*, and closes with Roland Allen.

START HERE

Both are recent work asking what the Victorian expansion offers planting now.

Bevins, Winfield. 'Victorian Church Planting: A Contemporary Inquiry into a Nineteenth-Century Movement'. *The Asbury Journal* 75, no. 1 (2020): 8-22. <https://place.asburyseminary.edu/asburyjournal/vol75/iss1/3>.

A journal article on Victorian church planting, which its own subtitle describes as a contemporary inquiry into a 19th-century movement. The shortest piece here, and the quickest way to see what the subject covers.

Orr-Ewing, Frog. 'Rev. Thomas Joseph Gaster: An Urban Missionary in Historical and Theological Context'. PhD thesis, King's College London, 2018. https://cte.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/01/Rev_Thomas_Joseph_Gaster_An_Urban_Missio.pdf.

ALSO IN Anglican; Parish Church

A doctoral thesis on Victorian Anglican church planting in London, built round the ministry of Thomas Joseph Gaster and the founding of All Saints Peckham. Its argument is that Gaster drew on the models of mission he had worked with in India under the Church Missionary Society and reapplied them to the growing communities of late Victorian Britain, a fusion of parish and mission that Orr-Ewing calls the new parochialism and traces well beyond this one parish. Orr-Ewing was himself vicar of All Saints Peckham from 2003. The full text is given away by Churches Together in England.

HOW THEY DID IT

Earls, Rod. *Spurgeon's Theology for Multiplying Disciples and Churches: The Story of How Spurgeon and the Metropolitan Tabernacle Followed Christ*. Foreword by Ed Stetzer. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2022.

ALSO IN Baptist

A study of the theology and practice through which Charles Spurgeon and his Metropolitan Tabernacle planted some 200 churches in and around London and trained nearly 900 ministers at his Pastors' College. It gives a 19th-century British Baptist precedent for multiplying churches from one congregation, with a foreword by Ed Stetzer, and is written for pastors and students of Spurgeon rather than as an academic history of the Tabernacle.

Fielder, Geraint. *Grace, Grit and Gumption: The Exploits of Evangelists John Pugh, Frank and Seth Joshua*. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2000.

An account of John Pugh and the brothers Frank and Seth Joshua, converts of the Welsh valleys, and of the Forward Movement they built to reach industrial Cardiff. The title comes from Pugh's advertisement for men of grace, grit and gumption, and it was the Movement's appeal for evangelists that Martyn Lloyd-Jones answered when he went to Aberavon in 1927. Pugh started 48 mission halls.

Nicholls, John. 'Evangelising Our Cities: The Abiding Challenge of Thomas Chalmers'. *Foundations*, no. 44 (May 2000): 21-29. https://www.affinity.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/08/44_21.pdf.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas; Presbyterian and Reformed

An article on Thomas Chalmers's ministry in Glasgow and Edinburgh from 1816 to 1847 as a model for evangelising the inner city, by John Nicholls of the London City Mission. It sets out Chalmers's district visiting and the Church of Scotland's Church Extension campaign of 1834, which had built 216 new churches by 1840, and asks whether the method survives Lyle Schaller's observation that social networks, not place, now decide who comes to a neighbourhood church.

Orr-Ewing, Frog. 'A Few Lessons for Church Growth and Planting New Worshipping Communities from the Victorian Anglicans'. Unpublished paper, n.d. <https://www.academia.edu/22209550/>.

ALSO IN Church Growth

An unpublished paper of seven pages, undated and posted by the author on Academia.edu, drawing lessons for church growth and planting today from Victorian Anglican church planting. It comes out of Orr-Ewing's doctoral research on Victorian church planting in London, completed at King's College London in 2018.

Orr-Ewing, Frog. 'Rev. Thomas Joseph Gaster: An Urban Missionary in Historical and Theological Context'. PhD thesis, King's College London, 2018. https://cte.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/01/Rev_Thomas_Joseph_Gaster_An_Urban_Missio.pdf.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Stephens, W. R. W. *The Life and Letters of Walter Farquhar Hook*. 2 vols. London: Richard Bentley and Son, 1878.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic

A two-volume Victorian biography of Walter Farquhar Hook, vicar of the single ancient parish of Leeds from 1837, who secured an Act of Parliament in 1844 to break it up, and under whom the schools of the town went from three to 30. Accounts of how many new parishes the Act made differ, from 14 to about 20. Stephens was Hook's son-in-law and wrote the standard *Dictionary of National Biography* entry on him as well, so the two Victorian accounts of Hook share an author. Narrative with the letters set into it, and a primary source rather than a study.

Walford, Rex. *The Growth of 'New London' in Suburban Middlesex, 1918-1945, and the Response of the Church of England*. Lampeter: Edwin Mellen Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A study of the Church of England's response as the Middlesex suburbs north of the Thames filled with new housing between 1918 and 1945. Walford tracks the church-building campaigns parish by parish, with 38 figures, 24 illustrations and 27 tables. The situation it describes, a church deciding how to follow new housing, would be familiar to anyone planting on a new estate.

Wallace, John Charles. 'Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: An Exploration in Practical Theology'. DThM thesis, Durham University, 2021. <https://etheses.durham.ac.uk/id/eprint/14378/>.

ALSO IN Anglican; Anglo-Catholic

The doctoral thesis behind the book, for readers who want the working rather than the conclusions: the six themes drawn from the fieldwork, and a literature chapter on the criticism of *Mission-Shaped Church* and the replies to it. A doctorate in theology and ministry, submitted at Durham in 2021.

Wallace, John. *Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: Can It Work?* Durham: Sacristy Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Anglo-Catholic

The book of Wallace's Durham thesis: 18 months of monthly visits to three Anglo-Catholic church plants, set beside how Victorian Anglo-Catholics started new churches, among them Richard Temple West, who founded St Mary Magdalene, Paddington. Steve Rice, reviewing it in *The Living Church*, credits the fair historical summary and the choice of little-known subjects, but finds the brevity leaves the history's nuances unexplored and the modern case studies short of answering the book's own question.

ROLAND ALLEN

Allen, Roland. *Missionary Methods: St Paul's or Ours? A Study of the Church in the Four Provinces*. London: Robert Scott, 1912. <https://archive.org/details/missionarymethod00alle>.

ALSO IN Missiology; Acts of the Apostles; Victorian Three Selves; Global and Cross-Cultural

A prophetic book from an early 20th-century missionary to China: its ideas were initially misunderstood and gained ground after Allen's death in 1947. Working from the Acts of the Apostles, he sketches how Paul reached whole regions by planting churches quickly, relying on the Holy Spirit and the training of local leaders rather than on missionary control. Much of the later literature argues either from it or with it; Caleb Greggson, in a 9Marks review, finds Allen's approach insufficient without firmer scriptural grounding but holds that readers must engage with him.

Allen, Roland. *The Case for Voluntary Clergy*. London: Eyre and Spottiswoode, 1930.

ALSO IN Bivocational and Covocational Ministry

A book arguing that the stipendiary ministry, suited to some settled churches, is a hindrance to the founding of new ones, and that the Church should ordain men who, like those Paul appointed, can maintain themselves and their families without its support. It follows an article in *The Interpreter* (1922) and *Voluntary Clergy* (SPCK, 1923) on the same subject. His voluntary clergy are men already established in life and in their own occupations, not ministers who take a second job to pay for a ministry.

Allen, Roland. *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church and the Causes Which Hinder It*. London: World Dominion Press, 1927.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Global and Cross-Cultural; Victorian Three Selves; Modality and Sodality; Acts of the Apostles

A companion volume to Allen's *Missionary Methods* (1912), arguing that the church grows through the unorganised witness of ordinary members explaining the gospel they have found for themselves, and that the control missions keep over the churches they found is what hinders it. Its introduction starts from his missionary experience in China, and its instances come from Acts, among them Acts 11:19–21 and Paul's churches at Lystra and Thessalonica, left to govern, support and propagate themselves once planted. A review for Reaching and Teaching International Ministries calls the model 'reductionistic', judging that in resisting years of formal education for national pastors Allen gives up even basic theological discernment.

Theological Topics

Ecclesial Minimum

At what point does a gathering become a church, rather than a project, a Bible study or a congregation in waiting? Church planting forces the question, because a plant is by definition a community that is not yet what it will be, and somebody has to decide when it has arrived. It is narrower than ecclesiology at large, which has a reading list of its own: what is at stake here is the threshold rather than the doctrine entire. The classic answers are creedal and confessional: the Nicene marks, one, holy, catholic and apostolic; and, more narrowly, Article VII of the Augsburg Confession of 1530 and Article XIX of the Thirty-Nine Articles, which make the church a congregation of the faithful where the word is rightly preached and the sacraments duly administered. That test is demanding, and where only an ordained minister may preside it settles who can lead as well as what counts. The fresh expressions literature has answered in a different register, through four relationships, up to God, in to one another, out to the world and of the wider body, and the English argument since has been over whether that restates the old test for a new setting or lowers it. Counting presses hardest of all, because a survey that must report how many new churches there are has to fix the threshold before it can begin. Two conversations then run in parallel and seldom cite each other, the English one conducted through fresh expressions and the global one through church planting movements. This reading list runs from Start Here through The Theological Case to The Question in the Church of England, then The Empirical Version and The Objections, and last The Global Version.

START HERE

Works of ecclesiology rather than reports on practice, taking the question of what a church is before the question of what a plant must become.

Coutts, Jon. *The Marks of a Church: Shaped by the Main Things*. Pastoral 155. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2018.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A Grove booklet asking what, if anything, a church needs in order to be a church, and answering with a restatement of the Reformation's classic marks of a church - not word and sacrament alone, but a third mark of 'mutual discipleship' in place of church discipline. Coutts argues that a congregation shaped by hearing the word together, by baptism and communion, and by mutual discipleship in reconciliation has what it needs to witness to Christ. Short and accessible; it would be a good starting point for the question this list is organised around.

Foulger, Will, and Joshua Cockayne, eds. *New Churches: A Theology*. London: SCM Press, 2024.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesiology; Anglican

An edited collection of theological essays on starting new churches, written from the British scene by contributors from evangelical and Anglo-Catholic traditions alike. In its first part, on new churches and the *missio Dei*, Mark Collinson asks whether church planters believe in the *missio Dei* at all, Joshua Cockayne writes on community and the Triune God, and Beth Honey sets out an ethics of planting in conversation with Aquinas. Christian Selvaratnam's chapter, on planting as a craft learned by apprenticeship, is listed under Formation and Training.

Moynagh, Michael, with Philip Harrold. *Church for Every Context: An Introduction to Theology and Practice*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Introductions and Overviews; Modality and Sodality; Fresh Expressions of Church

A textbook arguing for what Moynagh calls contextual churches, drawing on the literature and practice of both church planting and fresh expressions; its publisher describes it as the first textbook to reflect the learning from fresh expressions of church. It runs from ecclesiology to how a new community is sustained and supported, and at over 500 pages would suit use by section.

Moynagh, Michael. *Church in Life: Innovation, Mission and Ecclesiology*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Introductions and Overviews; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesiology; Fresh Expressions of Church

A monograph modelling how new Christian communities come into being, drawing on complexity theory and entrepreneurship studies alongside theology. Where Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* (2012) makes the case for contextual churches, this book gives an account of how they emerge, analysing and systematising the innovation skills that pioneers of fresh expressions use by instinct. Its closing section, 'Perspectives on Method', bears most directly on how innovating teams work.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Household of God: Lectures on the Nature of the Church*. London: SCM Press, 1953.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

The Kerr Lectures for 1952, given at Trinity College, Glasgow. Newbigin sets out the Protestant, Catholic and Pentecostal answers to what the church is, and argues for a missionary and eschatological understanding of the church. John Howard Yoder (1958) accepted that the church is essentially missionary but disputed that the idea was new, holding that the Anabaptists had insisted on it centuries earlier. Of Newbigin's books, the one where his ecclesiology is set out most directly.

THE THEOLOGICAL CASE

Volf, Miroslav. *After Our Likeness: The Church as the Image of the Trinity*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A study in trinitarian ecclesiology, written to show that Free Church order, the church as a gathered community of believers, is theologically legitimate. Volf starts from John Smyth, the first Baptist, and argues in sustained dialogue with Joseph Ratzinger and John Zizioulas, seeking to give person and community their due against individualism in Protestant ecclesiology. Like Jonathan Leeman's *Don't Fire Your Church Members* (2016), it defends congregational order, but from the Trinity rather than from the office of the member.

THE QUESTION IN THE CHURCH OF ENGLAND

Where the argument is actually conducted, and where it has practical consequences, for authorisation and for who may preside.

Church of England Working Party on Church Planting. *Breaking New Ground: Church Planting in the Church of England*. London: Church House Publishing, 1994.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Anglican

A report on church planting from a working party the House of Bishops set up in 1991, and the document the Church of England's later official material answers to. *Mission-Shaped Church* of 2004 differs from it on strategy rather than on diagnosis.

Church of England, General Synod. *Dioceses, Pastoral and Mission Measure 2007*. 2007 No. 1. London: Church of England, 2007. <https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukcm/2007/1/enacted>.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports

A Measure of the Church of England's General Synod, given royal assent in October 2007, amending the Pastoral Measure 1983 and standing as primary legislation rather than a report. Section 47 let a diocesan bishop, satisfied that a proposed initiative would 'promote or further the mission of the Church', endorse it by what the Measure calls 'a bishop's mission order', without requiring parish status. That section was repealed in 2012 and re-enacted, in near-identical words, as section 80 of the Mission and Pastoral Measure 2011, which now governs the order. It gave the proposals of *Breaking New Ground* and *Mission-Shaped Church* their statutory footing.

Cockayne, Joshua. *The Communion Dilemma: The Challenges of Leading Eucharistic New Things*. Durham: Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Communion+Dilemma+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Ecclesiology; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

A report surveying the leaders of 63 new communities in 20 Church of England dioceses, and by its own account the only current data on their eucharistic practice. Cockayne sets out three responses — not celebrating, celebrating with authorised liturgy and an ordained president, or celebrating without authorisation — and concludes that 'the communion dilemma is a loser's game', urging that liturgical reform be joined to the Church's aim of 10,000 new worshipping communities. Only nine of the 63 never celebrated communion.

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Modality and Sodality; Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

Croft, Steven, and Ian Mobsby, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2009. American edition, with Stephanie Spellers, New York: Seabury Books, 2010.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

An edited volume on what a mission-shaped church looks like when it is rooted in sacramental tradition rather than set against it, written by pioneers, leaders and theologians from Britain and the United States. Contributors include Rowan Williams, Brian McLaren, Stephen Cottrell, Richard Giles and Phyllis Tickle. The American edition of 2010 adds Stephanie Spellers as a third editor and a foreword by Katharine Jefferts Schori. In the argument over fresh expressions it takes the side opposite Davison and Milbank's *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions* (2010).

Croft, Steven, ed. *Mission-Shaped Questions: Defining Issues for Today's Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2008.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Fresh Expressions of Church

A collection of essays responding to *Mission-Shaped Church*. A mixed collection, but Croft's own two — opening and closing — are well worth reading: the first argues for loosening Anglican structures to make room for planting and fresh expressions, the last reflects on what it means to be church in a missionary context. John Drane's essay on what maturity looks like for emerging churches is the other one worth the time.

Foulger, Will. *Present in Every Place? The Church of England's New Churches, and the Future of the Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

A study of whether the parish system still delivers what its defenders want from it. Foulger separates the instinct that draws people to the parish, rootedness and presence in a place, from the practice that has carried it, and argues that critics of new churches assume too smooth a move from the one to the other. Drawing on the idea of place as bounded openness, he concludes that presence in place calls for complexity of church form rather than uniform coverage. Developed from his Durham thesis of 2018.

House of Bishops of the Church of England. *Church Planting and the Mission of the Church: A Statement by the House of Bishops*. HB(18)05. London: Church of England, 2018.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Anglican

An important paper from the Church of England's House of Bishops in 2018, expressing support for church planting, and laying out the broad principles of how it should be done within an Anglican context.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *Exploring the Mixed Ecology: How Different Churches Belong Together*. Church Multiplication 3. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Ecclesiology; Anglican

A booklet exploring the biblical and theological underpinnings of 'mixed ecology', the term the Church of England adopted in 2021 for established congregations and newer forms of church held together in one body, and tracing how it grew from the 'mixed economy' of *Mission-shaped Church* (2004). It reads the idea through the body of Christ in 1 Corinthians 12 and the household of God, and sets out the challenges an ecological ecclesiology raises for those who lead within it. Selvaratnam was on the working group that wrote the Church of England's Vision and Strategy for the 2020s, which adopted the term.

THE EMPIRICAL VERSION

Counting required a working definition, so Church Army had to set one; the criteria it used, and the groups it excluded, are where the question becomes concrete.

Dalpra, Claire. 'When Is Messy Church "Church"?' In *Messy Church Theology: Exploring the Significance of Messy Church for the Wider Church*, edited by George Lings, [pages?]. Abingdon: BRF, 2013.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A chapter from a member of Church Army's Research Unit asking whether Messy Church meets the tests of being a church, printed alongside a companion chapter arguing the opposing case, in the first collection to treat Messy Church's theology at length. The Research Unit's own criteria for a fresh expression, developed here for one form, are set out more fully across the wider field in Lings's *The Day of Small Things* (2016).

Lings, George, ed. *Messy Church Theology: Exploring the Significance of Messy Church for the Wider Church*. Abingdon: BRF, 2013.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

An edited collection, the first to treat Messy Church's theology at length, gathering academics and practitioners around what Messy Church contributes to the wider church. Claire Dalpra's opening chapter, filed separately, asks whether Messy Church is a church in its own right, and the next takes the opposing case. Oliver Gross's review in *Foundations* concludes that Messy Church should stay 'an outreach or ministry' of a more traditional congregation.

Lings, George. *Encountering The Day of Small Things*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2016.

<https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/encounteringthedayofsmallthings-web.pdf>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The published summary of *The Day of Small Things*, and the short way into it. For the criteria by which a gathering was counted as a church, and the argument about them, the full report is where they are set out.

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A survey of 1,109 fresh expressions in the Church of England, started between 1992 and 2014 in 21 dioceses and studied from 2012 to 2016 through interviews with their leaders. They make up on average 15 per cent of a diocese's church communities, with over 50,600 people attending, and four times as many were being started each year as in 2004. Section 2.6 sets the survey's indicators against the eight criteria of the 2012 Anglican-Methodist report, objecting that those criteria make practices rather than relationship determine what counts as a church; pages 43-44 set out whether attenders were churchd, de-churchd or non-churchd, each estimate of those new to church lower than the last.

THE OBJECTIONS

Whether the minimum has been set too low. The objections come from different directions and do not agree with each other.

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Church of England Papers and Reports

An influential critique of the fresh expressions movement, from two mainstream Anglicans who defend the parish as theologically necessary. It would be most useful to a reader already persuaded by the movement, since it contests the movement's premise from outside it. Chapter 1, on the relationship between the form of a church and its message, and chapter 3, on the place of the church in salvation, are the significant ones.

Gross, Oliver. 'Review Article: Messy Church Theology'. Review of *Messy Church Theology: Exploring the Significance of Messy Church for the Wider Church*, edited by George Lings. *Foundations*, no. 68 (Spring 2015): 102-108. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-68/issue-68-article-5-review-article-messy-church-theology/>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A review article by Oliver Gross on *Messy Church Theology* (2013), the collection edited by George Lings. Gross asks whether Messy Church is a church in its own right, testing it against three marks he draws from the New Testament: qualified leadership, a clear distinction between believers and unbelievers, and expository preaching. He concludes that it should be kept 'as an outreach or ministry of a more traditional and biblically-organised church'.

Hull, John M. *Mission-Shaped Church: A Theological Response*. London: SCM Press, 2006.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesiology; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Church of England Papers and Reports

A book-length theological critique of *Mission-Shaped Church*, arguing that the report never consistently distinguishes the Kingdom of God from the church, and so turns a mission directed towards the world into a strategy for the church's own growth. Drawing on Barth, Hull treats the church as the fruit and agent of mission rather than its goal, and presses the report on its treatment of poverty, its neglect of consumerism and religious plurality, and its Anglican horizon. He writes as a supporter of fresh expressions, if a cautious one.

THE GLOBAL VERSION

Garrison, David. *Church Planting Movements: How God Is Redeeming a Lost World*. Midlothian, VA: WIGTake Resources, 2004.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Global and Cross-Cultural

A study of church planting movements around the world and of what they have in common, such as prayer, abundant evangelism, deliberately planting churches able to plant others, local and lay leadership, and healthy churches. It expands, with case studies of more than two dozen movements, a booklet Garrison wrote for the International Mission Board in 1999, which had already defined such a movement and listed its universal elements. Ed Roberts (9Marks, 2009) records that it was once required reading for the Board's missionaries, and finds its ecclesiology thin. Its methodology depends on a low and portable definition of church, which is where it meets the argument about the ecclesial minimum.

Homogeneous Unit Principle

The homogeneous unit principle is the claim that people come to faith most readily among their own, without having to cross barriers of race, language or class, and that mission should therefore work with the social groupings it finds rather than against them. It is not the question of the multi-ethnic congregation, which has a reading list of its own; the argument here is over whether affinity may be used as a method. Donald McGavran formulated the principle out of his years as a missionary in India and taught it from 1965 at Fuller Theological Seminary, where the church growth school formed round him, and C. Peter Wagner carried it from the mission field into American congregational life. As a description of how congregations grow it is not much disputed. As a warrant for strategy it is, and the objection is ecclesiological rather than sociological: a church gathered by social affinity cannot show what the church is, on this view, because the barriers it works with are the ones Christ has abolished. C. René Padilla states that case for the critics; McGavran and Wagner answer that a church which requires people to leave their own culture before they may believe has confused the gospel with a preference of its own. Both sides met at a consultation in Pasadena in 1977 and reported together, and the argument has been conducted since on ground that report marked out. In England it is pursued without the vocabulary, through the argument over planting into networks rather than parishes. This reading list runs from Start Here to The Case Made and The Case Against, then What the Evidence Shows, and last The Argument in England.

START HERE

The Pasadena Consultation: Homogeneous Unit Principle. Lausanne Occasional Paper 1. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 1978. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/lop-1>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Church Growth

The report of the Pasadena colloquium of 1977, held under the Lausanne Theology and Education Group and published as the first Lausanne Occasional Paper: 10 primary contributors, Donald McGavran and C. Peter Wagner among them, some 25 further consultants and John Stott as moderator. Proponents and critics of the homogeneous unit principle agreed that a homogeneous unit church 'can be a legitimate and authentic church' but 'can never be complete in itself', since the 'dividing wall' Christ abolished 'was enmity or hostility'. It would be a useful place to begin on the ecclesiological objection to church-growth planting strategy, before taking either side.

McIntosh, Gary L. 'Revisiting the Homogeneous Unit Principle: Unpacking the Historical Development of the Homogeneous Unit Principle'. *International Journal of Frontier Missiology* 40, nos. 1-2 (2023): 5-11. https://www.ijfm.org/PDFs_IJFM/40_1_2_PDFs/IJFM_40_1_2-McIntosh.pdf.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A journal article, adapted from a 2022 lecture, tracing how McGavran's homogeneous unit principle actually developed rather than how it is remembered. McIntosh, McGavran's biographer, writes 'with a positive view' of the principle and argues that most of what is said for and against it addresses a simplified version; his section 'Why Was McGavran Misunderstood?' rejects the reading of the principle as racist. Where the Pasadena consultation of 1977 recorded common ground between advocates and critics, this is a defence from the advocates' side.

THE CASE MADE

The argument in the words of the people who made it.

McGavran, Donald A. *Understanding Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Missiology; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

The fuller statement of the church growth theory Donald McGavran first argued in *The Bridges of God* (1955), resting on J. Waskom Pickett's research into the Indian mass movements. It is the source of the much-quoted sentence about people becoming Christians without crossing racial, linguistic or class barriers, and the book the debate over church growth and the homogeneous unit principle is about. The revised edition of 1980 adds three chapters on the principle; the third, of 1990, revised by C. Peter Wagner, turns church growth from a chief purpose of mission into the chief one.

Wagner, C. Peter. *Our Kind of People: The Ethical Dimensions of Church Growth in America*. Atlanta: John Knox Press, 1979.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A book-length defence of the homogeneous unit principle for American congregations, made on ethical grounds as well as strategic ones by McGavran's colleague at Fuller. Wagner argues for a pluralism that encourages distinct identities against the integrationist ideal of the melting pot; his last chapter is titled 'Overcoming Racism Through Christian Love'. *Kirkus Reviews* found the argument's broad outlines 'solidly convincing' and Wagner's sociology 'a bit amateurish'.

THE CASE AGAINST

The reply came from missiologists rather than from critics outside the missionary movement.

Padilla, C. René. 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 6, no. 1 (January 1982): 23-30.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Latin America

An article arguing that the homogeneous unit principle has no biblical foundation, since a church which will not cross the barriers Christ has abolished has misunderstood what it is. Padilla works from Ephesians and from the Gentile mission in Acts, judging a mission strategy by the church's unity, and writes as a Latin American evangelical from inside evangelical mission rather than against it; he took part in the 1977 Pasadena consultation on the principle. The article is reprinted in his *Mission Between the Times* (1985).

Shenk, Wilbert R., ed. *Exploring Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1983.

ALSO IN Church Growth

An edited collection that brings Donald McGavran into one volume with missiologists from outside the Church Growth Movement, among them Orlando Costas and David Bosch, to take up what Henry Schmidt (*Direction*, 1991) calls 'the premises, principles and goals of church growth'. Shenk, a Mennonite missiologist, stood outside the movement himself, and Schmidt reads the volume as an international analysis of it.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

Neither book is about the homogeneous unit principle; both ask what racially separate and racially mixed congregations do to the people in them.

Edwards, Korie L. *The Elusive Dream: The Power of Race in Interracial Churches*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A study of interracial congregations that sets a national dataset of some 700 churches beside fieldwork in one of them, a Midwestern church Edwards calls Crosstown. Her argument is that such congregations tend to run on white cultural terms, the chapter title being 'Reproducing White Hegemony', so that a mixed congregation may hold together without the worship, the leadership or the expectations changing hands. Uncomfortable for anyone who treats mixing as the end of the question.

Emerson, Michael O., and Christian Smith. *Divided by Faith: Evangelical Religion and the Problem of Race in America*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2000.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A sociological study of white American evangelicals and race, built on a survey of 2,000 people and 200 face-to-face interviews. Emerson and Smith argue that the tools by which white evangelicals interpret the world, accountable freewill individualism among them, lead them to explain racial inequality in terms that put structural remedies out of reach, and that racially separate congregational life keeps the habit in place. It won the Society for the Scientific Study of Religion's Distinguished Book Award in 2001; Reformed evangelical critics have contested it since.

THE ARGUMENT IN ENGLAND

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Ecclesial Minimum; Church of England Papers and Reports

An influential critique of the fresh expressions movement, from two mainstream Anglicans who defend the parish as theologically necessary. It would be most useful to a reader already persuaded by the movement, since it contests the movement's premise from outside it. Chapter 1, on the relationship between the form of a church and its message, and chapter 3, on the place of the church in salvation, are the significant ones.

Modality and Sodality

The distinction between modality and sodality provides a useful framework for understanding church planting as both church building and church multiplication. Although the terminology was popularised in modern missiology by Ralph D. Winter in his 1974 essay, 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission', it draws on older Roman Catholic patterns of distinguishing between the broad, inclusive structures of the church, such as parishes and dioceses, and more selective, specialised communities, such as religious orders. Applied to church planting, modality describes the structures through which Christian community is gathered, sustained and given an enduring ecclesial form, while sodality describes the more specialised, mission-oriented structures through which Christians are mobilised to pioneer, establish and multiply new communities.

What is contested is whether the two structures are equally the church. Winter held that both are God's redemptive instruments and that the mission society needs no ecclesiastical warrant; Orlando Costas answered him in the same year that mission belongs to the church and cannot be carried on apart from it, and Harvie Conn and George Peters put the Reformed and the biblical-theological cases against a second structure of equal standing. Howard Snyder and Gerald Arbuckle take a third position, treating the renewing order as a movement within the institution rather than a partner to it. In England the argument reappears as the question of where fresh expressions sit, which George Lings, Michael Moynagh and Beth Keith take up after *Mission-Shaped Church*.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Winter's Case and The Objections, then A Body Within the Church, and closes with The Argument in England.

START HERE

None of the three argues against the distinction; they come from a Church Army researcher, a historian of mission, and the missiologist who gave it its vocabulary.

Lings, George. *Why Modality and Sodality Thinking Is Vital to Understand Future Church*. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, n.d. [2013?]. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/george-lings---why-modality-and-sodality.pdf>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Pioneering

A short report applying modality and sodality to the Church of England. Lings holds the two as a spectrum rather than a binary, argues that sodality pioneers what modality then sustains, and warns against deploying sodal people in modal roles: there is, he writes, 'little point in breeding tigers if you intend to keep them chained up in dog kennels'. Eight pages.

Walls, Andrew F. *The Missionary Movement in Christian History: Studies in the Transmission of Faith*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books; Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1996.

ALSO IN Missiology; Global and Cross-Cultural

A collection of historical essays and lectures written between 1971 and 1994, arguing that Christianity crosses cultures by translation, and that its centre of gravity moves from one region to another, each era's periphery becoming the next era's heartland. 'The Gospel as the Prisoner and Liberator of Culture' is the essay usually credited with the indigenising principle, by which the faith is at home in every culture, and the pilgrim principle, by which it is at home in none. Chapter 18, 'Missionary Societies and the Fortunate Subversion of the Church', argues that the mission societies did what the churches could not.

Winter, Ralph D. 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission'. *Missiology* 2, no. 1 (January 1974): 121-39. <https://doi.org/10.1177/009182967400200109>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Missiology

An article, first given as an address to the All-Asia Mission Consultation in Seoul in 1973, tracing two structures from the New Testament through medieval monasticism to the Protestant mission societies: the modality, the congregation to which everyone belongs, and the sodality, the mission band or order that people join for a purpose. Winter argues that both are 'legitimate and necessary' parts of the church, and that non-Western churches need sodalities of their own. Mark Vanderwerf (*Global Missiology*, 2011) surveys the objections to it.

WINTER'S CASE

Winter's four statements of the case, the conference volume where the question was first put, and the writers who have carried the argument since.

Hirsch, Alan, and Tim Catchim. *The Permanent Revolution: Apostolic Imagination and Practice for the 21st Century Church*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting; Theory of Change

A book arguing that Western churches have narrowed the fivefold ministry of Ephesians 4:11 (apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd, teacher) to shepherd and teacher, and that recovering the apostolic function keeps a church a movement rather than a settled institution. It draws on organisational theory as well as theology. Darrell Guder contributes the foreword. Andy Johnson, in the *Englewood Review of Books*, finds it 'most certainly not easily accessible'.

Metcalf, Sam. *Beyond the Local Church: How Apostolic Movements Can Change the World*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Ecclesiology

A book developing Ralph Winter's two structures, the congregation (modality) and the mission band (sodality): the fullest book-length development of Winter, and a tendentious one. Metcalf attempts a biblical case, arguing that sodalities are a legitimate expression of the church rather than a pragmatic device, and essential to the Great Commission. Ken Caruthers (9Marks, 2016), while granting that sodalities 'have done amazing work', finds that Metcalf treats biblical descriptions as prescriptions and ends with a low view of the congregation. Valuable precisely because it shows where the logic runs when it is pushed.

Wagner, C. Peter, ed. *Church/Mission Tensions Today*. Chicago: Moody Press, 1972.

ALSO IN Missiology

An edited volume from the Green Lake conference of 1971, where North American mission agencies were being asked whether they existed because congregations had failed in their responsibility, or by design; this volume is where the question was put. Its 12 chapters, by mission executives who took part, include Jack Shepherd's on the nature of the church and Winter's contribution to the argument, 'The Planting of Younger Missions', and show the dispute behind the two-structure thesis in concrete terms. Hans Kasdorf (*Direction*, 1973) notes that no contributor is from a non-Western church, and that the volume defines mission too narrowly, as evangelism.

Winter, Ralph D. 'Protestant Mission Societies: The American Experience'. *Missiology: An International Review* 7, no. 2 (1979): 139-78. <https://rdwrc.wciu.edu/wp-content/uploads/2023/07/Protestant-Mission-Societies-by-RDW-1979.pdf>.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article making the historical case for the two structures at greater length: Protestant mission societies set against Catholic religious orders, and the provocation, borrowed from the historian Kenneth Scott Latourette, that Methodist circuit riders effectively kept Catholic vows. A useful place to look if the 1974 essay's compression leaves the argument looking thinner than it is.

Winter, Ralph D. 'The Anatomy of the Christian Mission'. *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* 5, no. 1 (1969): 74-89.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article, Winter's first published treatment of church and mission structures, written before he had the modality and sodality vocabulary of 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission' (1974). Useful for showing that the terms were a later formalisation of an argument he was already making about mission agencies in North America.

Winter, Ralph D. 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission'. *Missiology* 2, no. 1 (January 1974): 121-39. <https://doi.org/10.1177/009182967400200109>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Winter, Ralph D. 'The Warp and the Woof of the Christian Movement'. In *The Warp and the Woof: Organizing for Mission*, edited by Ralph D. Winter and R. Pierce Beaver, 52-62. South Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1970.

A chapter in a volume Winter co-edited with R. Pierce Beaver, standing between his essay of 1969 and the article of 1974. For anyone tracing how the argument about mission structures was assembled, rather than for a reader who wants the argument itself.

THE OBJECTIONS

The objections run two ways: that there is no warrant in the New Testament for a mission structure outside the church, and that a two-structure church is a divided one.

Allen, Roland. *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church and the Causes Which Hinder It*. London: World Dominion Press, 1927.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Global and Cross-Cultural; Victorian Three Selves; Acts of the Apostles

A companion volume to Allen's *Missionary Methods* (1912), arguing that the church grows through the unorganised witness of ordinary members explaining the gospel they have found for themselves, and that the control missions keep over the churches they found is what hinders it. Its introduction starts from his missionary experience in China, and its instances come from Acts, among them Acts 11:19-21 and Paul's churches at Lystra and Thessalonica, left to govern, support and propagate themselves once planted. A review for Reaching and Teaching International Ministries calls the model 'reductionistic', judging that in resisting years of formal education for national pastors Allen gives up even basic theological discernment.

Conn, Harvie M. *Theological Perspectives on Church Growth*. Nutley, NJ: Presbyterian and Reformed, 1976.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Presbyterian and Reformed

A volume bringing Reformed theology to bear on Donald McGavran's church growth theory, edited by Harvie Conn while professor of missions at Westminster Theological Seminary, and the third in Presbyterian and Reformed's series Studies in the World Church and Missions. It speaks from Reformed missiology rather than from the movement's base at Fuller. It predates the Pasadena consultation of 1977, and Gary McIntosh's 'Revisiting the Homogeneous Unit Principle' (2023) counts Conn among the principle's early critics.

Costas, Orlando E. *The Church and Its Mission: A Shattering Critique from the Third World*. Wheaton, IL: Tyndale House, 1974.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Latin America

A book published the same year as Ralph Winter's essay 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission' and answering it directly: there is no New Testament warrant for mission apart from the church, the two-structure model damages the historic and universal character of the church, and mission sodalities, the specialised bodies that send Christians in mission, ought to be church sodalities. It also evaluates the church growth movement at length. A contemporary objection, from a Latin American writing to North Americans about their own arrangements; *Christianity Today* (1975) found that Costas 'recognizes the strength and bares the weaknesses of North American missiology'.

Peters, George W. *A Biblical Theology of Missions*. Chicago: Moody Press, 1972.

ALSO IN Missiology

An evangelical treatment of mission, written while Peters headed the missions department at Dallas Theological Seminary. It holds that God is a missionary God, and its publisher names the centrality of the local church among its concerns. Peter Hamm (*Direction*, 1977) finds its distinction between the cultural and the spiritual mandate possibly too sharp, and its treatment of other religions meagre. For the relation between the church and mission structures, the section on the church and missions in Part II would be a useful place to look.

Schnabel, Eckhard J. *Paul the Missionary: Realities, Strategies and Methods*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2008.

ALSO IN Missiology; Acts of the Apostles

A study of Paul's missionary work, condensed largely from Schnabel's two-volume *Early Christian Mission* (2004), reading the New Testament for the goals Paul had and the methods he used. Schnabel finds the goals consistent and the methods situational, credits Paul's success to God's power rather than to strategy, and disputes Roland Allen's claim that Paul worked by provinces rather than cities. Robert Plummer calls it 'the new Roland Allen', stronger in biblical-theological method but without Allen's immediate application. Chapters 4 and 5, on goals and methods, bear most directly on whether Paul's practice gives a pattern to follow.

A BODY WITHIN THE CHURCH

A third position: that the committed body belongs inside the church rather than beside it.

Arbuckle, Gerald A. *Refounding the Church: Dissent for Leadership*. London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1993.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

An anthropologist's account of why an institution in confusion reaches backwards, and why it discourages dissent exactly when it most needs it. Arbuckle, a Marist priest, writes about Catholic religious congregations after Vatican II and the pull to restore the model that preceded them; refounding is his word for renewal led from the margins by people the centre finds awkward. Scholarly rather than practical, and a position planters working inside an institution may recognise.

Snyder, Howard A. *The Problem of Wineskins: Church Structure in a Technological Age*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1975.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book on church structure, built on the image of Luke 5: the wine is the gospel, which does not change, and the wineskins are the structures made to hold it, which are culturally conditioned and must be renewed or the wine is lost. Snyder argues that most institutional church structure has little biblical warrant, and that the church's primary structure should be the small group, meeting alongside large-group worship, rather than the congregation. Reissued as *Radical Renewal: The Problem of Wineskins Today* (1996; 2015).

Snyder, Howard A. *The Radical Wesley and Patterns for Church Renewal*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1980.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting

A study of Wesley's early Methodism as a pattern for church renewal today. Paul Mickey's review in *Christianity Today* (1981) found the key to Snyder's Wesley in his doctrine of the church, balancing inner experience, the sacraments and social witness through the classes and societies. Revised in 2014 as *The Radical Wesley: The Patterns and Practices of a Movement-Maker*.

THE ARGUMENT IN ENGLAND

The distinction applied to the Church of England, in two reports, two textbooks and one piece of fieldwork.

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Ecclesial Minimum; Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

Keith, Beth. 'To Pluck Up and Pull Down, to Build and to Plant'. In *The Pioneer Gift: Explorations in Mission*, edited by Cathy Ross and Jonny Baker, 117-40. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Pioneering

A chapter reporting Keith's research on Church of England pioneers placed in modal, sodal and mixed contexts, and so the empirical counterpart to Lings's paper on modality and sodality. It reports poor outcomes for pioneers placed modally, research that Lings's paper cites. It would be a source to cite where the argument needs to rest on evidence rather than on temperament.

Lings, George. *Why Modality and Sodality Thinking Is Vital to Understand Future Church*. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, n.d. [2013?]. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/george-lings---why-modality-and-sodality.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Moynagh, Michael, with Philip Harrold. *Church for Every Context: An Introduction to Theology and Practice*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Introductions and Overviews; Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church

A textbook arguing for what Moynagh calls contextual churches, drawing on the literature and practice of both church planting and fresh expressions; its publisher describes it as the first textbook to reflect the learning from fresh expressions of church. It runs from ecclesiology to how a new community is sustained and supported, and at over 500 pages would suit use by section.

Moynagh, Michael. *Church in Life: Innovation, Mission and Ecclesiology*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Introductions and Overviews; Ecclesiology; Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesial Minimum

A monograph modelling how new Christian communities come into being, drawing on complexity theory and entrepreneurship studies alongside theology. Where Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* (2012) makes the case for contextual churches, this book gives an account of how they emerge, analysing and systematising the innovation skills that pioneers of fresh expressions use by instinct. Its closing section, 'Perspectives on Method', bears most directly on how innovating teams work.

Victorian Three Selves

The three-self formula holds that a mission-founded church becomes a church properly so called when it is self-governing, self-supporting and self-propagating. It was articulated independently and almost simultaneously in the 1850s and 1860s by Henry Venn, honorary secretary of the Church Missionary Society from 1841 to 1872, and by Rufus Anderson of the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions. Venn's image is the mission as scaffolding, to be dismantled once the building stands, and his phrase for the goal is 'the euthanasia of a mission'. The formula was an argument against dependency and against the conflation of Christianity with European civilisation, and it carried a considerable, if uneven, anti-paternalist charge. John Nevius, a missionary in China, worked it into a practical plan; it took hold not in China but in Korea, where the Presbyterian mission adopted it after his two weeks in Seoul in 1890. Roland Allen gave it theological depth, pressing it towards a doctrine of the Spirit's sufficiency in the local church, and Melvin Hodges carried it into Pentecostal missiology. In the twentieth century the vocabulary was appropriated by the Three-Self Patriotic Movement in China, in a state-aligned form its Victorian authors would not have recognised. Paul Hiebert proposed a fourth self, self-theologising, arguing that a church which receives its theology ready-made from elsewhere remains dependent at the deepest level. The formula had already been pressed further than three, however: Alan Tippett proposed six marks in 1969, and later writers have added self-missilogising, self-caring and self-localising, so the fourth self is the most widely adopted addition rather than the only one. This reading list runs: Start Here; Applying the Formula; The Fourth Self, and Beyond; and What Happened in Practice.

START HERE

Venn and Anderson in their own words, with one later article looking back over the formula.

Anderson, Rufus. *To Advance the Gospel: Selections from the Writings of Rufus Anderson*. Edited by R. Pierce Beaver. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1967.

ALSO IN Missiology

A collection of the writings of Rufus Anderson, secretary and chief policymaker of the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions from 1832 to 1866, and the American half of the pair who set out the three selves. His concern is the same as Henry Venn's, and reached independently: that a mission which does not plan its own ending is not building a church but a dependency. Where he differs is in a sharper separation of the gospel from civilisation, which he held would follow the gospel rather than be an aim of mission.

Shenk, Wilbert R. 'The Origins and Evolution of the Three-Selfs in Relation to China'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 14, no. 1 (January 1990): 28-35.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East

An article tracing the three-self formula, that a church should govern, support and propagate itself, from Henry Venn and Rufus Anderson, who first set it out, to what became of the words in China, and so the piece that explains why the same three words now name two different things: a 19th-century argument for handing a church over, and a 20th-century arrangement with a state.

Venn, Henry. *To Apply the Gospel: Selections from the Writings of Henry Venn*. Edited by Max Warren. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1971.

ALSO IN Missiology

A collection of the writings of Henry Venn, honorary secretary of the Church Missionary Society from 1841, edited and introduced by Max Warren, the society's general secretary from 1942 to 1963. It is the way into Venn's own words: the minutes and papers in which the three selves are set out, and in which 'the euthanasia of a mission' appears.

APPLYING THE FORMULA

What the formula became in the hands of people trying to use it on the field.

Allen, Roland. *Missionary Methods: St Paul's or Ours? A Study of the Church in the Four Provinces*. London: Robert Scott, 1912. <https://archive.org/details/missionarymethod00alle>.

ALSO IN Missiology; Acts of the Apostles; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Global and Cross-Cultural

A prophetic book from an early 20th-century missionary to China: its ideas were initially misunderstood and gained ground after Allen's death in 1947. Working from the Acts of the Apostles, he sketches how Paul reached whole regions by planting churches quickly, relying on the Holy Spirit and the training of local leaders rather than on missionary control. Much of the later literature argues either from it or with it; Caleb Greggson, in a 9Marks review, finds Allen's approach insufficient without firmer scriptural grounding but holds that readers must engage with him.

Allen, Roland. *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church and the Causes Which Hinder It*. London: World Dominion Press, 1927.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Global and Cross-Cultural; Modality and Sodality; Acts of the Apostles

A companion volume to Allen's *Missionary Methods* (1912), arguing that the church grows through the unorganised witness of ordinary members explaining the gospel they have found for themselves, and that the control missions keep over the churches they found is what hinders it. Its introduction starts from his missionary experience in China, and its instances come from Acts, among them Acts 11:19–21 and Paul's churches at Lystra and Thessalonica, left to govern, support and propagate themselves once planted. A review for Reaching and Teaching International Ministries calls the model 'reductionistic', judging that in resisting years of formal education for national pastors Allen gives up even basic theological discernment.

Hodges, Melvin L. *The Indigenous Church*. Springfield, MO: Gospel Publishing House, 1953.

ALSO IN Pentecostal; Global and Cross-Cultural

A short book written to prepare Assemblies of God missionaries, out of Hodges's own work in El Salvador and Nicaragua. It put indigenous-church principles into the hands of a Pentecostal mission agency, and went on to shape the missionary policy of the Assemblies of God and of other evangelical agencies. Roland Allen is the influence the sources name on Hodges's missiology. Reissued in 2009 together with *The Indigenous Church and the Missionary*.

Nevius, John L. *The Planting and Development of Missionary Churches*. Shanghai: Presbyterian Press, 1886.

ALSO IN Missiology; Introductions and Overviews; Asia and the Middle East; Presbyterian and Reformed

A primary text of the 19th-century missionary movement, first written in 1885 as articles for the *Chinese Recorder* and published as a book in 1886. Against paying local evangelists and pastors from mission funds, Nevius argues for churches that are self-supporting, self-governing and self-propagating, whose members keep their own occupations and call pastors when they can support them. The source of what came to be called the Nevius method, it was adopted by Presbyterian missionaries in Korea; the *Biographical Dictionary of Chinese Christianity* records that it and Nevius's *Methods of Mission Work* became required reading for most Presbyterian missionaries to China and Korea for over 50 years. The 1899 New York printing is digitised by the Internet Archive.

THE FOURTH SELF, AND BEYOND

Hiebert, Paul G. *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1985.

ALSO IN [Global and Cross-Cultural; Missiology](#)

An introduction to anthropology for missionaries, arguing that the gospel must be incarnated in each culture while transforming it. The section 'The Fourth Self' makes the case for self-theologising: theological dependence is the deepest dependence of all, and a church which receives its theology ready-made has not yet been handed over. Rochelle Cathcart Scheuermann (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) faults its functionalist anthropology for treating cultures as bounded entities. Hiebert's article 'Critical Contextualization' (*International Bulletin of Missionary Research*, 1987) supplies the method that keeps the fourth self from collapsing into syncretism.

Tippett, Alan R. *Verdict Theology in Missionary Theory*. Lincoln, IL: Lincoln Christian College Press, 1969.

ALSO IN [Missiology](#)

A book of addresses prepared for a missionary week at Lincoln Christian College in 1969. Tippett argues that the three selves of Venn and Anderson are not enough, and proposes six: self-image, self-functioning, self-determining, self-supporting, self-propagating and self-giving. They came 16 years before Hiebert made the case for a fourth self, self-theologising, in *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries* (1985), so his was not the first attempt to say what the three had left out. The enlarged second edition (William Carey Library, 1973) includes a discussion of functional substitutes, the Christian forms that take over the social functions of customs converts give up.

WHAT HAPPENED IN PRACTICE

Hanciles, Jehu J. *Euthanasia of a Mission: African Church Autonomy in a Colonial Context*. Westport, CT: Praeger, 2002.

ALSO IN [Africa](#)

A study of what became in Sierra Leone of Henry Venn's policy that a foreign mission should become an independent local church, worked out through the Church Missionary Society's Native Pastorate: Hanciles follows the mission's growth, the crises that overtook it and the rise of Ethiopianism, and shows how far colonial assumptions undercut a policy meant to end foreign control. Hanciles is himself Sierra Leonean. A corrective to reading that policy as straightforwardly anti-colonial.

Shenk, Wilbert R. 'The Origins and Evolution of the Three-Selfs in Relation to China'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 14, no. 1 (January 1990): 28-35.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Ways of Planting

Church Planting Movements

See also the list on Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting.

A church planting movement is the rapid multiplication of churches that plant churches, through several generations, without outside control and usually without outside money. David Garrison named the phenomenon, and in *A Wind in the House of Islam* gave it a threshold that can be checked: a hundred new churches, or a thousand baptisms, inside twenty years. The counting is not incidental. It is what separates the claim from the ordinary hope that a growing church will start another, and it is what the argument turns on.

The literature divides, and this reading list holds both halves. One works with a light and portable definition of the church, a small group meeting in a house or a workplace and led by a new believer, because a movement must reproduce faster than it can train; the standing objection to it is ecclesiological, that what multiplies on those terms may not be a church, and in this list it is made in the reviews cited in the annotations rather than in any book. The other half assumes a settled congregation and asks what it must give away in order to seed something: sending a team, merging with a weaker church, opening further sites, or combining with other churches across a city. Both halves argue about leadership, and mostly from Ephesians 4, on the view that a church which kept the shepherd and the teacher quietly retired the apostle, the prophet and the evangelist.

Roland Allen and Ralph Winter wrote before the vocabulary existed and set the questions it answers: whether a new church can be trusted to govern itself from the beginning, and whether mission needs a structure of its own alongside the congregation. Disciple Making Movements, which begin from disciple-making rather than from planting, have a reading list of their own, and several books appear in both.

This reading list runs: Start Here; What a Movement Is; Apostolic Ministry and Movement Leadership; Multiplying an Existing Church; Movements in Particular Places; and When Movements Fail.

START HERE

The case as its advocates put it, and the terms the rest of the list argues with.

Addison, Steve. *Movements That Change the World: Five Keys to Spreading the Gospel*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2011.

A short account of what makes a movement spread, organised round five keys, among them white-hot faith and adaptive methods, drawn from biblical, historical and contemporary cases. It comes before *The Rise and Fall of Movements*, which carries the argument through decline as well as growth. First published by Missional Press in 2009; the edition cited here adds a discussion guide.

Garrison, David. '10 Church Planting Movement FAQs'. *Mission Frontiers*, March-April 2011, 9-11.

A short article in *Mission Frontiers*, in an issue of 2011 given to church planting movements, in which Garrison answers questions put to him about them seven years after his *Church Planting Movements* (2004).

Garrison, David. *Church Planting Movements: How God Is Redeeming a Lost World*. Midlothian, VA: WIGTake Resources, 2004.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Ecclesial Minimum

A study of church planting movements around the world and of what they have in common, such as prayer, abundant evangelism, deliberately planting churches able to plant others, local and lay leadership, and healthy churches. It expands, with case studies of more than two dozen movements, a booklet Garrison wrote for the International Mission Board in 1999, which had already defined such a movement and listed its universal elements. Ed Roberts (9Marks, 2009) records that it was once required reading for the Board's missionaries, and finds its ecclesiology thin. Its methodology depends on a low and portable definition of church, which is where it meets the argument about the ecclesial minimum.

Roberts, Bob, Jr. *The Multiplying Church: The New Math for Starting New Churches*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2007.

Written for the sending church rather than the planter: why multiplication should be a normal function of a congregation, and what it costs one to send. Roberts planted NorthWood Church at Keller, Texas, and sent from it repeatedly. Useful to a church weighing whether it can afford to send.

Woodward, J. R., and Dan White Jr. *The Church as Movement: Starting and Sustaining Missional-Incarnational Communities*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A field manual, with exercises and tools, for church-planting teams and discipleship groups, built from the training of the V3 Movement, which both authors help lead. It is organised around eight competencies for starting and sustaining missional-incarnational communities, among them polycentric leadership and incarnational practices. Where Shank's *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth* maps the stages of the work, this sets out the competencies a planting team develops.

WHAT A MOVEMENT IS

The general material: what a movement is held to be, and the strategy and precedent appealed to in support of it.

Second Vatican Council. *Ad Gentes: Decree on the Mission Activity of the Church*. Rome, 7 December 1965.

https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_decree_19651207_ad-gentes_en.html.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Missiology; Ecclesiology

A document of the Second Vatican Council, its decree on the church's missionary activity, promulgated by Pope Paul VI on 7 December 1965: the first time an ecumenical council treated the missions as a subject in their own right. It grounds mission in the sending of the Son and the Spirit, so that the church is 'missionary by her very nature'. Chapter 2, on witness, preaching and the forming of a Christian community, and chapter 3, on the particular churches, their laity and their theological adaptation, bear most directly on planting.

Addison, Steve. *Movements That Change the World: Five Keys to Spreading the Gospel*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2011.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Allen, Roland. *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church and the Causes Which Hinder It*. London: World Dominion Press, 1927.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Global and Cross-Cultural; Victorian Three Selves; Modality and Sodality; Acts of the Apostles

A companion volume to Allen's *Missionary Methods* (1912), arguing that the church grows through the unorganised witness of ordinary members explaining the gospel they have found for themselves, and that the control missions keep over the churches they found is what hinders it. Its introduction starts from his missionary experience in China, and its instances come from Acts, among them Acts 11:19–21 and Paul's churches at Lystra and Thessalonica, left to govern, support and propagate themselves once planted. A review for Reaching and Teaching International Ministries calls the model 'reductionistic', judging that in resisting years of formal education for national pastors Allen gives up even basic theological discernment.

Bede. *Ecclesiastical History of the English People*. Completed 731. Translated by Leo Sherley-Price, revised by R. E. Latham, with an introduction and notes by D. H. Farmer. London: Penguin Classics, 1990. Also free online in A. M. Sellar's older translation at <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/38326/38326-h/38326-h.html>.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Missiology

A primary text, completed by Bede at Jarrow in 731 and dedicated to King Ceolwulf of Northumbria, and the principal source for how England was evangelised. It is organised around the conversion of successive kingdoms and their rulers, and says little about missionary work among ordinary people. Book I includes Augustine's mission from Rome, and Book III Aidan's mission from Iona and the Synod of Whitby (664), which settled the dispute between Roman and Irish practice, chiefly over the date of Easter; the two books would be a good starting point for comparing the missions.

Bevins, Winfield. *Multiplying Disciples: What Movements Can Teach Us About Discipleship*. Exponential, 2019. <https://exponential.org/product/multiplying-disciples/>.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Discipleship

A booklet drawing on three disciple-making movements from church history, the Celtic, the Moravian and the Methodist, for what each can teach the church now. Where Hunter's *The Celtic Way of Evangelism* takes the Celtic mission alone as a model for evangelism, Bevins sets it beside two later movements. His *Marks of a Movement* gives early Methodism a book to itself; this booklet would be a shorter first reading across all three.

Cole, Neil. *Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2005.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

Church planted where life already happens, in restaurants, bars, coffee houses and parks rather than in a hired hall people must come to, with Life Transformation Groups as the reproducible unit underneath. Kevin McFadden, reviewing it for 9Marks, judged that readers would need to set it beside books with a firmer ecclesiology.

Cooper, Michael T. *Ephesiology: A Study of the Ephesian Movement*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2020.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles; Ecclesiology

A study of the church at Ephesus as a church planting movement, reading Acts 19 with Ephesians, 1 and 2 Timothy and Revelation 2–3; Cooper counts two-fifths of the New Testament as bearing on the city. He coins 'ephesiology' for a discipline drawing on missiology, ecclesiology and archaeology, and finds in these texts a reproducible pattern in five stages, from launching a movement to sustaining it. Appendices supply a 'Movement Action Plan' and 'Maturity Matrices' for practitioners.

Farah, Warrick, ed. *Motus Dei: The Movement of God to Disciple the Nations*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2021.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A collection from a 2020 research symposium of the Motus Dei network, in five parts, among them case studies and an agenda for further research. It carries more than 30 first-hand accounts, drawn from the Global North and South alike. Evidence rather than advocacy.

Garrison, David. *Church Planting Movements*. Richmond, VA: International Mission Board, 1999. https://moredisciples.com/wp-content/uploads/2015/10/cpm_booklet_standard_english.pdf.

A booklet from the International Mission Board's Office of Overseas Operations, its preface signed by Garrison in October 1999, five years before his book of the same title. In eight short chapters it defines a church planting movement as 'a rapid and multiplicative increase of indigenous churches planting churches within a given people group or population segment', profiles movements the Board's missionaries had seen, and lists 10 universal elements, 10 common factors and 10 practical handles. Written for those missionaries, it is the primary document behind the term; the book keeps its definition and elements, with revised wording and fuller case studies.

Garrison, David. *Church Planting Movements: How God Is Redeeming a Lost World*. Midlothian, VA: WIGTake Resources, 2004.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Keller, Timothy. *Gospel-Centered City Ministry: The City to City DNA*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2023. <https://redeemercitytocity.com/dna>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A collection of 18 white papers, each with a companion video, in which Keller sets out the ideas behind Redeemer City to City's work, in five groups. Those on the city supplement *Center Church* rather than abridge it, adding urban theory that Keller says the book largely lacks. Part 18 sets out the dynamics and markers of a gospel movement.

Lausanne Church Planting Issue Network. *Saturation Church Planting: A Call to Collaboration*. Edited by Juan Wagenveld. Lausanne Occasional Paper 79. Lausanne Movement, 2024. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/saturation-church-planting-a-call-to-collaboration>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement; Church Planting Strategy

A Lausanne report tracing the DAWN saturation approach that Jim Montgomery and others promoted through the 1980s and 1990s, and arguing for its continuation in new forms. It grew out of a gathering of 250 leaders from 65 countries at Batam, Indonesia, in February 2024, convened with GACX, the Global Church Planting Network and Vision 5:9, and carries contributions from Chuck Van Engen, Murray Moerman, Raphael Anzenberger, Todd Benkert, Matt Fretwell and Ron Anderson, with a final review by Craig Van Gelder.

MacMillan, Neil. 'Building a Church-Planting Movement in a Traditional Denomination'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 41-60. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-3-building-a-church-planting-movement-in-a-traditional-denomination/>.

ALSO IN Presbyterian and Reformed

An article on the difficulty of starting a planting movement inside a denomination with settled structures and a long memory, written from the Free Church of Scotland by the planter of Cornerstone, Morningside. MacMillan names the obstacles rather than gesturing at them: planting treated as a fad, overseas mission competing for the same money, pressure to rescue dying churches instead, bureaucratic process, and too few large self-financing churches to send from. Most of them would be recognised in any established church.

Moore, Philip. 'Defending Specificity on Doctrinal Distinctives for a Church-Planting Network: Why Reformed Soteriology and Complementarianism Are Important'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 26-40. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-2-defending-specificity-on-doctrinal-distinctives-for-a-church-planting-network/>.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; New Churches and Networks; Presbyterian and Reformed

An article defending a church-planting network's requirement of more than gospel agreement from the churches it takes on. Moore, writing within Acts 29, argues for Reformed soteriology and complementarianism on three grounds: biblical fidelity, pastoral practice and method, and the trust that working together in a network needs.

Powell, Neil. 'The Nature and Necessity of Church-Planting Movements'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 4-25. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-1-the-nature-and-necessity-of-church-planting-movements/>.

An article arguing that a city is not reached by one church growing but by churches planting together. Powell is founding pastor of City Church Birmingham, co-directs 2020 Birmingham and chairs the executive of City to City Europe. It opens a *Foundations* issue largely given over to planting.

Prinz, Emanuel. *What Actually Starts Movements: Partnering with God for Kingdom Multiplication*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2025.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A study of movement catalysts resting on more than 15 years of Prinz's research, 147 movements and some 32,000 data points, asking which qualities separate catalysts who see breakthrough from those who do not. The empirical counterpart to a literature that usually argues from stories. Not to be confused with his earlier *Movement Catalysts* (2022), which studies 35 movements and is often cited in its place.

Snyder, Howard A. *Signs of the Spirit: How God Reshapes the Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1989.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting; Ecclesiology

A study of four renewal movements, the Montanists, the Pietists, the Moravians and the early Methodists, read for what recurs across them, including judgement on the institutional church, non-traditional leadership, lay ministry and evangelistic vitality. From these Snyder builds a theology of renewal, and he closes with a renewal strategy for the local church. The chapters on the Methodist revolution and on the dynamics of renewal movements bear most directly on early Methodism and on what renewal movements share.

Stetzer, Ed, Jeff Christopherson, and Daniel Yang. *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems: With Particular Attention to Church Planting Churches*. Wheaton, IL: Send Institute and New Churches, 2018. <https://www.sendinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/SI-2018-BPCPS.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Selecting and Assessing Planters; Church Planting Strategy

Benchmarking research on North American planting networks, asking what the churches that reproduce well do differently. Of the 130 organisations that answered, nearly half had taken multiplication language into their mission or vision statements and 73 per cent trained for it, but 74 per cent reported that fewer than a quarter of their churches were actually planting; and the average organisation still optimises for selecting planters rather than for growing churches that plant. American throughout, and concerned with how a planting system is put together rather than how it should feel.

Winter, Ralph D. 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission'. *Missiology* 2, no. 1 (January 1974): 121-39. <https://doi.org/10.1177/009182967400200109>.

ALSO IN Missiology; Modality and Sodality

An article, first given as an address to the All-Asia Mission Consultation in Seoul in 1973, tracing two structures from the New Testament through medieval monasticism to the Protestant mission societies: the modality, the congregation to which everyone belongs, and the sodality, the mission band or order that people join for a purpose. Winter argues that both are 'legitimate and necessary' parts of the church, and that non-Western churches need sodalities of their own. Mark Vanderwerf (*Global Missiology*, 2011) surveys the objections to it.

APOSTOLIC MINISTRY AND MOVEMENT LEADERSHIP

The argument that movements need a kind of leader the settled church has stopped producing, made from the five gifts of Ephesians 4 — apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd and teacher — and from the New Testament's apostles.

Addison, Steve. *Pioneering Movements: Leadership That Multiplies Disciples and Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A book on the leadership that multiplies disciples and churches, with scriptural, historical and contemporary examples from around the world. Chapter 6 is especially valuable for its five levels of movement leadership, from seed sower and church planter to multiplication trainer and movement catalyst. It builds on two earlier books by Addison, *What Jesus Started* and *Movements That Change the World*, the second of them in Church Planting Movements.

Cole, Neil. *Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale House, 2014.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

Cole on the same fivefold gifts Hirsch works on in 5Q, arguing that several have been quietly retired and that the church's capacity depends on all five together. It sets out to recover, reinterpret and reimagine the gifts, and is written with four collaborators who each bring one of them: Dezi Baker, Ed Waken, Phil Helfer and Paul Kaak.

Dent, Don. *The Ongoing Role of Apostles in Missions: The Forgotten Foundation*. Bloomington, IN: WestBow Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book by a Southern Baptist missiologist arguing that apostles, now usually called missionaries, are God's gift for the initial planting of the church among every people, to the end of the age. It began as Dent's doctoral thesis (DMiss, Malaysia Baptist Theological Seminary, 2009), and the case rests on the New Testament's use of *apostolos*, the subject of chapter 2, and on the ministry patterns of the early missionary apostles. A review for the Immanuel Network objects that it sets apostolic teams outside the authority of established churches.

Devenish, David. *Fathering Leaders, Motivating Mission: Restoring the Role of the Apostle in Today's Church*. Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2011.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; New Churches and Networks

A book written from inside Newfrontiers by a leader who has overseen churches across the Russian-speaking world and the 10/40 window, arguing that the New Testament apostle is best understood as a father to leaders rather than as an office. Its reviewers divide over the ecclesiology and agree on the usefulness.

Ford, Lance, Rob Wegner and Alan Hirsch. *The Starfish and the Spirit: Unleashing the Leadership Potential of Churches and Organizations*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2021.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

Brafman's starfish — the decentralised organism that regrows from any limb — applied to the church, with a foreword by Ori Brafman himself. The argument is for leaders who release rather than run, and for multiplying leaders at every level rather than only at the top. It assumes *The Starfish and the Spider*, where the metaphor is set out. Nathan Knight, reviewing it for 9Marks, argues against it from the pastoral qualifications in 1 Timothy 3, Titus 1 and 1 Peter 5.

Frost, Michael, and Alan Hirsch. *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2003.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets; Missiology; Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Innovation and Creativity; Theory of Change

A book arguing that the attractional church shaped by Christendom cannot reach the post-Christendom West. Frost and Hirsch build on the Gospel and Our Culture Network's account of the missional church, which drew on Lesslie Newbigin, adding three shifts of their own: to incarnational ecclesiology, messianic spirituality and apostolic leadership. They set a centred-set church, defined by nearness to Jesus, against a bounded-set one. Chapter 11, 'Imagination and the Leadership Task', treats imagination as part of a leader's work. A revised edition followed from Baker in 2013.

Hirsch, Alan, and Tim Catchim. *The Permanent Revolution: Apostolic Imagination and Practice for the 21st Century Church*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2012.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Modality and Sodality; Theory of Change

A book arguing that Western churches have narrowed the fivefold ministry of Ephesians 4:11 (apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd, teacher) to shepherd and teacher, and that recovering the apostolic function keeps a church a movement rather than a settled institution. It draws on organisational theory as well as theology. Darrell Guder contributes the foreword. Andy Johnson, in the *Englewood Review of Books*, finds it 'most certainly not easily accessible'.

Hirsch, Alan. *5Q: Reactivating the Original Intelligence and Capacity of the Body of Christ*. 100 Movements, 2017.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Leadership in Church Planting

A book on the fivefold typology of ministry in Ephesians 4, apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd and teacher (APEST), presented not as five offices to fill but as the church's DNA: traced through God's nature, creation and culture, embodied fully in Jesus, and what makes a community a church. Its first part, 'Mapping the Genome of the Body of Christ', sets out the theology, and the second turns to practice. Chris Schoon (*Englewood Review of Books*, 2017) judges that it claims too much for APEST as a lens on all of these at once.

Hirsch, Alan. *The Forgotten Ways: Reactivating Apostolic Movements*. 2nd ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology; Theory of Change; Leadership in Church Planting

A book asking why some Christian movements grew exponentially, and calling what they share Apostolic Genius: six elements of 'mDNA', one of them 'APEST culture', which Hirsch and Catchim's *The Permanent Revolution* develops. Hirsch calls it 'not a how-to book'. The preface new to this edition concedes that few Western churches show all six elements, and argues that a handful of exemplary churches would be enough to change the paradigm.

Jones, Peyton. *Church Zero: Raising 1st Century Churches out of the Ashes of the 21st Century Church*. Colorado Springs, CO: David C Cook, 2013.

Jones's argument in short: stop arguing about what 'apostle' means and do the work the apostles did, which is planting. Deliberately abrasive, and the shorter of his two books on the subject; he returned to it at length in *Church Plantology* (2021).

Kay, William K. *Apostolic Networks in Britain: New Ways of Being Church*. Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2007.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

A study of the British networks that grew from the house churches, Newfrontiers, Pioneer, Ichthus and Salt and Light among them. Kay traces the networks' roots from Wigglesworth's prophecy through the charismatic renewal, then analyses 12 networks through interviews and a survey of 647 leaders, describing them, in the subtitle's phrase, as 'new ways of being church' organised round apostolic figures rather than a denomination. Where Walker reads the earlier movement as a sect moving toward denominational status, this is a fuller, more sympathetic account of the networks in their settled form.

Metcalf, Sam. *Beyond the Local Church: How Apostolic Movements Can Change the World*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Ecclesiology

A book developing Ralph Winter's two structures, the congregation (modality) and the mission band (sodality): the fullest book-length development of Winter, and a tendentious one. Metcalf attempts a biblical case, arguing that sodalities are a legitimate expression of the church rather than a pragmatic device, and essential to the Great Commission. Ken Caruthers (9Marks, 2016), while granting that sodalities 'have done amazing work', finds that Metcalf treats biblical descriptions as prescriptions and ends with a low view of the congregation. Valuable precisely because it shows where the logic runs when it is pushed.

Ollerton, David. *Ministry on the Move: New Testament Patterns of Apostles and Apostolic Teams for Supporting Church Plants and Existing Churches*. Newid Books, 2008. <https://www.cgwww.org/books/p/fbqdy5hn1zjs26vhj6i0oiibeqyxrm>.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A book on who supports a new church once it exists, and by what authority. Ollerton finds in Acts and Paul's letters two kinds of ministry, 'ministry on the spot' from local elders and 'ministry on the move' from apostolic teams, and traces the pattern through Welsh church history from the early Celtic church to today. He wrote from Cardiff as founder-chairman of Waleswide, a church planting network across Wales. It bears on oversight rather than on planting itself.

MULTIPLYING AN EXISTING CHURCH

For a congregation that is not starting a movement but could seed one. Mostly though not wholly American.

Baron, Colin, Tom O'Toole and Tim Simmonds. *Multiplanting: A Vision for Growing Churches, Leaders and Mission*. Malcolm Down Publishing, 2019.

ALSO IN Multi-site Church

Twenty-five years in Manchester behind a single argument: plant smaller interconnected congregations across a city, operating as one church — together strong enough to survive, dispersed enough to reach what one large church never could. Directly useful to anyone weighing multi-site against multiplication.

Bergquist, Linda, and Michael D. Crane. *City Shaped Churches: Planting Churches in a Global Era*. Skyforest, CA: Urban Loft Publishers, 2018.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Cities and Urban Areas

A book in 23 chapters arguing that planters should not carry suburban models into cities but shape each church to its city, drawing on demographic and ethnographic research and attending to populations churches overlook, such as night workers and undocumented immigrants. The authors' own failed plant in San Francisco in the 1990s is one case. Stephen Mark Davis's review finds it 'a patchwork of collected essays' with overlapping chapters. Bergquist has worked in church planting for over 30 years; Crane helped to launch the Gospel City Network in Southeast Asia.

Christopherson, Jeff, and Mac Lake. *Kingdom First: Starting Churches That Shape Movements*. Nashville, TN: B&H Books, 2015.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A planting manual that puts one question, drawn from Matthew 6:33, to each stage of the work: whether a plant's aim is the kingdom of God or the church itself. Of its eight parts, the first takes the planter's character and context, and the last, on multiplying churches, bears most directly on a church that means to plant others.

Comiskey, Joel. *Planting Churches That Reproduce: Starting a Network of Simple Churches*. Moreno Valley, CA: CCS Publishing, 2016.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Practical Guides; Church Planting Strategy

A manual for planting simple churches that can keep reproducing into a network, drawn from Comiskey's three church plants and his work as a cell-church coach. Its first part defines a simple church by four marks: at least three members, God-appointed leadership, the lordship of Christ, and baptism and communion. Later parts turn to the planter's preparation and to strategies for cell-driven and house churches. Where Dale's *Getting Started* keeps to the house church, it covers both forms.

Connelly, Ben. *Sent Churches, Sending Churches: How Every Church Can Plant Churches and Send Missionaries for the Gospel and through the Gospel*. Exponential, 2026. <https://exponential.org/product/sent-churches-sending-churches/>.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A practical guide for a single congregation, rather than for a network as in Ferguson and O'Connell's *Together*, to becoming a church that plants churches and sends missionaries, argued from the biblical case of the church at Antioch. It offers biblical theology alongside exercises for congregations to work through, and states that a church can begin sending in its second year with as few as 20 engaged members. Where Walkemeyer's *The River Church* narrates one congregation's own turn to a multiplying culture, this book supplies the exercises for doing that work.

Ferguson, Dave, and Jon Ferguson. *Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2010.

ALSO IN Church Planting Strategy

A book setting out the reproducing plan behind Community Christian Church in Chicago, begun by five friends and told in four stages: movements start with one, then reproducing tribes of ten to a hundred, communities of a hundred to a thousand, and movements of tens of thousands. The anchor book of the Exponential series. Josh Manley, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds its scriptural grounding thin, which is the standing complaint against this end of the literature.

Ferguson, Dave, and Patrick O'Connell. *Together: The Great Collaboration*. Chicago, IL: Exponential, 2019.
<https://exponential.org/resource-ebooks/together/>.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

The argument that collaboration between churches and networks belongs beside the Great Commission and the Great Commandment as a third call, read out of John 17. Written from inside a reproducing network rather than about one: Ferguson co-founded Exponential and leads NewThing, and the examples come from churches they work with. Short and hortatory, and lighter on evidence than on conviction, which is where Gordon Showell-Rogers's review in *Christian Daily International* also lands.

Ferguson, Dave, and Warren Bird. *Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2018.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Developing Leaders

The argument that a leader's job is to make other leaders rather than to be one, with five practices and a tool for each, from multiplication thinking to kingdom building. Written out of Community Christian Church in Chicago and the Exponential network.

Galanos, Chris. *From Megachurch to Multiplication: A Church's Journey Toward Movement*. Experience Life, 2018.

ALSO IN Multi-site Church; Leadership in Church Planting

Galanos asked 12 people to join him in reaching 10,000 people in 10 years, and passed the mark in year eight, then concluded that the megachurch he had built was the wrong goal and turned it towards multiplication. The interest is in the turn: a pastor dismantling his own success in public. Published by the church itself, Experience Life in Lubbock, Texas.

Greear, J. D. *Gaining by Losing: Why the Future Belongs to Churches That Send*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2015.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A pastor's case for a church ordered around sending its members and leaders out, drawn from the practice of the Summit Church in Raleigh-Durham, North Carolina. Shane Lems, reviewing on the Reformed Reader blog, doubts that methods formed in a church of well over a thousand people transfer to smaller ones. The 'sending plumb lines' of the second part, and the appendices on missions and church planting, bear most directly on a church preparing to send out a plant.

Keller, Timothy. *Serving a Movement: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2016.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A volume republishing the third part of Keller's *Center Church*, on the church's mission and how churches become movements, with responses from Tim Chester, Daniel Montgomery and Mike Cosper, and Alan Hirsch, and a reply from Keller. The responses are what it adds: Chester questions the idea that a church earns 'the right to be heard' through service, and Hirsch recasts movement through the fivefold ministry of Ephesians 4. The section on movement dynamics bears most directly on multiplying churches.

Moore, Ralph. *How to Multiply Your Church: The Most Effective Way to Grow*. Ventura, CA: Regal Books, 2009.

On churches planting churches rather than on starting one. More than two thousand churches trace their descent from Moore's ministry at Hope Chapel, a figure Daniel Im gives; Moore planted three of them himself and was closely involved in many more. Practical, and addressed to a church already established rather than to a planter.

Nebel, Tom. *Big Dreams in Small Places: Church Planting in Smaller Communities*. St Charles, IL: ChurchSmart Resources, 2002.

ALSO IN Baptist; Rural and Market Towns

A book urging anyone who has thought of planting a church to consider a small town, which it presents as 'a huge mission field' where millions of Americans live. Nebel planted a church in Wisconsin and became the first national director of church planting for the Baptist General Conference, now Converge Worldwide.

Patterson, George, and Richard Scoggins. *Church Multiplication Guide: Helping Churches to Reproduce Locally and Abroad*. Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1993.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Practical Guides

A guide to multiplying churches from Patterson's 20 years in Honduras, where he moved from training pastors in a residential Bible institute to training leaders by extension where they lived. It teaches his obedience-oriented education, a curriculum built on the commands of Christ rather than on doctrine as a subject, and expects each church to start daughter churches. A revised and enlarged edition is subtitled *The Miracle of Church Reproduction*.

Powell, Neil, and John James. *Together for the City: How Collaborative Church Planting Leads to Citywide Movements*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

Written out of Birmingham by two pastors who built 2020 Birmingham, arguing that a city is reached not by one church but by churches planting together. Its middle part, on how, carries most of the weight: a core, a cause and a code, out of which collaboration follows rather than standing beside them.

Roberts, Bob, Jr. *The Multiplying Church: The New Math for Starting New Churches*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2007.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Schindler, Dietrich. *Shift: The Road to Level 5 Church Multiplication*. Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/shift/>.

ALSO IN Europe

A short book of 12 practical 'shifts', addressed to habits that hold a church back from multiplying, by a church planter in Germany. Todd Wilson's writing on the same site sets out Exponential's Level 5 language for multiplying churches; this book takes that vision as given and works instead at what, in practice, is stopping a church from reaching it. Written from a European rather than an American church-planting context, for leaders already established in ministry rather than those about to start.

Send Network. *Church Planting Pipeline: Moving Beyond Addition*. Alpharetta, GA: North American Mission Board, 2017.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Church Planting Strategy

A short booklet from Send Network, the North American Mission Board's church-planting arm, issued in August 2017 with a foreword by Jeff Christopherson, then its vice-president. It presents the Pipeline as a local church's own system for finding and forming planters: a pre-assessment, then three levels of 10 competencies each, up to three years of modules, on the argument that planting by addition, one recruited planter at a time, never becomes a movement. Among books on churches that send, it is the one that describes a denomination's ready-made programme, and would suit a church wanting to see what such a pathway contains.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. *Viral Churches: Helping Church Planters Become Movement Makers*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2010.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church Planting Strategy; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A book drawing on research commissioned by Leadership Network on what distinguishes churches that multiply from those that merely grow. Its definition of a multiplication movement requires half of each new church's attenders to be new converts. Richard Rymarz, reviewing it for *Catholic Books Review*, finds its research detail thin and points elsewhere for a more systematic and critical treatment.

Stevenson, Phil. *The Ripple Church: Multiply Your Ministry by Parenting New Churches*. Indianapolis, IN: Wesleyan Publishing House, 2004.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan

An advocacy book for existing churches rather than a manual for planters, on how a congregation can multiply its ministry by parenting new churches. Stevenson, later a district superintendent in the Wesleyan Church, published it with the denomination's own press.

Thorpe, Ric. 'Anglicans, Church Growth, and Church Planting'. In *Anglicans and Pentecostals in Dialogue*, edited by David Hilborn and Simo Frestadius, 236-54. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Church Growth

A chapter in a volume of Anglican and Pentecostal dialogue, written by Ric Thorpe as Bishop of Islington and leader of the Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication. Its first part is a history of Anglican planting from Augustine's mission of 597, on the argument that almost every church was planted when it was first created; its last traces the three waves by which Pentecostalism reached Anglicanism, from Alexander Boddy at Sunderland to John Wimber's influence on the Anglican planting centres, and sets the parish system's stability against the Pentecostal freedom from ancient structures.

Tomberlin, Jim, and Warren Bird. *Better Together: Making Church Mergers Work*. Expanded and updated ed. Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting

A treatment of church mergers, first published in 2012, that distinguishes the kinds (rebirth, adoption, marriage and intensive care) rather than treating merger as one thing. The expanded edition of 2020, cited here, adds church planting, multiplication and multisite.

Walkemeyer, Larry. *The River Church: Unleashing a Culture of Multiplication in Your Church*. Exponential, 2025. <https://exponential.org/product/the-river-church/>.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan; Leadership in Church Planting

Ezekiel 47 as a diagnosis: a church can become a lake, gathering and holding what comes to it, or a river, carrying it somewhere else. Walkemeyer led Light and Life in Long Beach for 30 years and now works with Exponential and the Free Methodist Church, and the book is the account of turning the one into the other.

Wilson, Todd, and Dave Ferguson. *Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church Field Guide*. Exponential, 2015. <https://exponential.org/resource-ebooks/becomingfive/>.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A field guide that places a church on a five-level scale, from Level 1, marked by subtraction and survival, to Level 5, marked by multiplying, releasing and sending, with an additional chapter by Alan Hirsch. It holds that growth by addition is Level 3, beyond which most churches never go, and that a movement needs churches that multiply. The appendix describing the five levels would help a team assessing its own church.

MOVEMENTS IN PARTICULAR PLACES

Where the claims meet cases. The evidence comes mostly, though not only, from outside the West.

Alvarez, Iosmar. *Viral Multiplication in Hispanic Churches: How to Plant and Multiply Disciple-Making Hispanic Churches in Twenty-First Century America*. Discipleship Resources, 2019.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A book on planting among Hispanic communities in the United States, built around embedding multiplication in a church's DNA from the start rather than adding it afterwards. Alvarez writes from his own planting in the United Methodist Church.

Aychi, B. R., with Dave Coles. *Living Fire: Advancing God's Kingdom in Challenging Places*. Beyond, 2024.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Global and Cross-Cultural

A systematic account of a family of disciple-making movements catalysed by Aychi, setting out 22 factors grouped as those that ignite a movement, those that accelerate it and those that sustain it. The settings are named only as challenging places among unreached peoples. More analytical than *Cabbages in the Desert*, which tells the story instead.

Bevins, Winfield. *Marks of a Movement: What the Church Today Can Learn from the Wesleyan Revival*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2019.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting

A book analysing how and why early Methodism was so effective in England and America, looking at changed lives, a reliance on the Holy Spirit, and discipleship and leadership training. It draws from the Wesleyan revival a call to the church today to make disciples, is written for pastors, church leaders and church planters, and may be useful to readers who assume movement language is a modern invention. Exponential's free ebook of the year before, *Marks of a Multiplying Movement*, shares its subtitle.

Bevins, Winfield. *Marks of a Multiplying Movement: What the Church Today Can Learn from the Wesleyan Revival*. Exponential, 2018. <https://exponential.org/resource-ebooks/marks-of-a-movement>.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting

A free ebook from Exponential in which Winfield Bevins draws from the Wesleyan revival marks of a multiplying movement for the church today. It shares its subtitle with his *Marks of a Movement*, published by Zondervan the following year, and would be a way into that argument for a reader without the book.

Coles, Dave, ed. *God on the Move: Making Disciples Among the Nations*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2025.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

Coles was an associate editor of *Motus Dei* and wrote its third chapter, and this is the same movement research written for ordinary readers and working missionaries rather than for a symposium. Too recent to have gathered reviews.

Farah, Warrick, ed. *Motus Dei: The Movement of God to Disciple the Nations*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2021.

ANNOTATED under What a Movement Is

Garrison, David. *A Wind in the House of Islam: How God Is Drawing Muslims Around the World to Faith in Jesus Christ*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2014.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Global and Cross-Cultural; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A survey of the Muslim world in which Garrison gathered the accounts of more than a thousand believers from Muslim backgrounds across a quarter of a million miles. He divides that world into nine geo-cultural 'rooms' and counts as a movement a thousand baptisms or a hundred new churches within two decades. The definition is what makes the count checkable, and where the argument about his figures begins.

Hardy, Andrew R., and Dan Yarnell. *Forming Multicultural Partnerships: Church Planting in a Divided Society*. Watford: Instant Apostle, 2015.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

Two British church planters argue for the reconciliation of a divided, multicultural society through a united multi-ethnic church, drawing on their own practice and on missiological and theological reflection. The book takes in ethnic churches and hospitality. Where Olofinjana asks what partnership between existing congregations would require, this works towards the mixed congregation itself.

Hunter, George G., III. *The Recovery of a Contagious Methodist Movement*. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan

A short book arguing that Methodism began as a missional alternative to establishment Christianity and has come to resemble the establishment it once criticised. Its remedy, as Randy Willis summarises it in his review, is for North American Methodism to recover, as well as Wesley's theological vision, three directions in ministry: lay ministries, small groups and missional Christianity. Hunter treats the early movement's practice as something a present-day denomination can take up again.

Kewley, Daniel, and Sven Östring. 'Can Church Planting Movements Emerge in the West? Case Studies of Three Church Planting Strategies in Western Australia.' *Journal of Adventist Mission Studies* 8, no. 1 (2012): 25–43.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Planting Strategy

An article in the *Journal of Adventist Mission Studies* asking whether church planting movements, a category developed in the majority world, can take hold in a secular Western setting, and testing the question against three church-planting strategies in Western Australia. Among the studies of movements in particular places it is the one Australian case, and the only entry here from the Adventist literature.

Robertson, Patrick, and David Watson, with Gregory C. Benoit. *The Father Glorified: True Stories of God's Power Through Ordinary People*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2013.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A second book of stories from Cityteam's disciple-making work, published by its missionaries as the follow-up to Jerry Trousdale's *Miraculous Movements* (2012). The publisher presents it as a way to learn, through their accounts, how best to win people to Christ. With its predecessor it gives the stories behind the method that David Watson, one of its authors, sets out with Paul Watson in *Contagious Disciple Making* (2014).

Shank, Nathan, and Kari Shank. *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth: Starting and Releasing Healthy Churches*. 2014 edition. <https://churchplantingmovements.com/four-fields/>.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Practical Guides; Asia and the Middle East

A training manual organised around four fields drawn from the parable of the growing seed (Mark 4:26–29), from entering a community to forming a church. Nathan and Kari Shank compiled it from the experience of church planters in South Asia, where they worked in Northeast India. It is a common framework for planting: e3 Partners, NoPlaceLeft and East-West Ministries teach it by name, and an evaluation for the mission agency ABWE (2022) finds the method pervasive among sending organisations, while questioning its biblical basis, which rests largely on that one parable.

Smith, Steve, and Ying Kai. *T4T: A Discipleship Re-Revolution*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2011.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Asia and the Middle East

The account of Ying Kai's Training for Trainers work in East Asia, written up by Steve Smith, and the source of the T4T method much movement thinking now assumes. The figures reported are very large: the International Mission Board gives 1.7 million baptisms and 150,000 churches over a decade. It is built in three parts as a training manual rather than as an argument. George Robinson, in *Global Missiology*, criticises its marketing tone, its pragmatism and its unclear definition of a church.

Tasse, Aila, with Dave Coles. *Cabbages in the Desert: How God Transformed a Devout Muslim and Catalyzed Disciple Making Movements Among Unreached Peoples*. Beyond, 2024.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Africa; Global and Cross-Cultural

A Muslim teenager in Marsabit, in northern Kenya, meets a Christian teacher, is converted and, in his own words, thrown out of the house, and receives the vision of cabbages growing in desert sand that gives the book its title. What followed was decades of church planting and then disciple-making movements across more than a dozen countries in East, the Horn of, and Southern Africa. Told with Dave Coles, it is a first-hand account by the African leader who catalysed the movements.

Trousdale, Jerry. *Miraculous Movements: How Hundreds of Thousands of Muslims Are Falling in Love with Jesus*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2012.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

Jerry Trousdale's book of stories from Cityteam's work among Muslims, most of them in Africa, told to show disciple-making movements at work and drawn into seven principles for making disciples who make disciples. It is the narrative companion to the Watsons' *Contagious Disciple Making*, which sets out the method, and is written for a general Christian readership. Two reviewers dispute it: Jeff Morton, broadly sympathetic, notes that its few footnotes do not substantiate the size of the movements claimed; Darren Carlson questions its obedience-based discipleship and its definition of church, and does not commend it.

Watson, David L., and Paul D. Watson. *Contagious Disciple Making: Leading Others on a Journey of Discovery*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2014.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

The method behind Cityteam's disciple-making movements, set out plainly: Discovery Bible Study, persons of peace, and obedience-based discipleship, with churches emerging from groups of new believers rather than being gathered first. It sits with two other Cityteam volumes, *Miraculous Movements* and *The Father Glorified*. Ed Roberts, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds it poorly organised and overconfident in tone.

WHEN MOVEMENTS FAIL

Accounts of what happened when a movement, or a church built on these lines, came apart.

Addison, Steve. *The Rise and Fall of Movements: A Roadmap for Leaders*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2019.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

The later companion to *Movements That Change the World*, and the more searching of the pair: a six-stage life cycle, birth, growth, maturity, decline, decay and rebirth, which asks why movements decline as well as how they begin, and what leadership each stage requires. A corrective to a literature preoccupied with beginnings. Stephen McAlpine's review finds it most useful to those already leading something established; Caleb Morell, for 9Marks, is sharply critical of its theology.

Cosper, Mike. *The Rise and Fall of Mars Hill*. Podcast series, 15 episodes. Christianity Today, 2021-22.
<https://www.christianitytoday.com/podcasts/the-rise-and-fall-of-mars-hill/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Power and Its Abuse; New Churches and Networks

The narrative history of Mars Hill Church in Seattle, which grew to 12,000 people across 12 sites and dissolved in 2014, and of Mark Driscoll, who founded it and co-founded Acts 29. Driscoll resigned in 2014 amid serious concerns about his leadership. Setting former staff and members beside historians and sociologists, Cosper makes the series about the conditions that produced Mars Hill — celebrity, and a theology of masculinity — rather than about one leader. Justin Dean, the church's former communications director, has disputed its accuracy. Driscoll's *Confessions of a Reformation Rev.* was written in 2006 from inside the church whose end this describes.

Hunter, Todd. *Autopsy Reports of Failed Churches*. Vineyard USA, 1986.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; New Churches and Networks

One of the earliest attempts to study church plants that failed rather than those that worked, written in 1986 from inside the Vineyard by Todd Hunter, then pastor of the Wheeling Vineyard in West Virginia and later the movement's national director. Nick Klinkenberg's account of it has Hunter examining 22 failed Vineyard plants and drawing out 10 common reasons for their failure, among them leader development, strategic planning and accountability. Stetzer and Bird's 2008 report on church planting in the United States summarises its conclusions: the lead planter's disposition mattered most, then the site and the training of planters and teams.

Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

See also the list on Church Planting Movements.

A disciple making movement works from the other end of church planting. Rather than gathering a congregation and then teaching it, it makes disciples of people who are not yet believers, expects them to obey what they read as they read it, and lets churches form out of the groups that result. The method has a settled shape: a small group, no teacher, a passage read together, the question of what it asks of them, and a person of peace who opens a household to it. David and Paul Watson named it, and named it deliberately — what they were seeing had first been called a church planting movement, and they preferred to name the disciple-making rather than the result. How much difference that renaming makes is disputed; some writers hold the two apart, others use the terms interchangeably.

George Patterson's obedience-oriented education, which dates from the 1970s, predates both Discovery Bible Study and the training methods built on it, and shares the same central conviction: that a new believer learns the commands of Christ in order to obey them rather than to know them. That conviction is also what the method is attacked for. The charge, made in articles rather than in any book in this list, is that asking the unconverted to obey before they believe is legalism, and reverses the order of faith and obedience.

A second subject sits beside the method: the small congregation itself. Micro-church, simple church, house church and organic church are overlapping labels with no agreed boundaries between them, and the missional community, a mid-sized group belonging to a larger church rather than a congregation in its own right, is different again. What holds the two subjects together is the question of the smallest thing that can be a church and still reproduce.

The movements are reported from outside the West, and the concession that there are few if any in the global north comes from a writer who defends the method, not from its critics; he puts it down to how individualistic Western people are. Most of the recent books in this reading list pursue the small form in the West rather than the movement, with no movement of that kind to point to.

This reading list runs: Start Here; The Method; Small and Simple Forms; and Where It Has Worked.

START HERE

Between them these three cover both of this reading list's subjects, the disciple-making method and the small congregation as a form.

Cole, Neil. *Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2005.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

Church planted where life already happens, in restaurants, bars, coffee houses and parks rather than in a hired hall people must come to, with Life Transformation Groups as the reproducible unit underneath. Kevin McFadden, reviewing it for 9Marks, judged that readers would need to set it beside books with a firmer ecclesiology.

Sanders, Brian. *Microchurches: A Smaller Way*. Tampa, FL: Underground Media, 2019.

Sanders founded the Underground Network in Tampa, and this is its working theory: the micro-church as the simplest unit of the church, where worship, community and mission coalesce as three intentional practices, and as his answer to what the irreducible elements of a church are. The first half argues the case, the second says how to start one. It follows *Underground Church* (2018), which told the network's story.

Watson, David L., and Paul D. Watson. *Contagious Disciple Making: Leading Others on a Journey of Discovery*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2014.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

The method behind Cityteam's disciple-making movements, set out plainly: Discovery Bible Study, persons of peace, and obedience-based discipleship, with churches emerging from groups of new believers rather than being gathered first. It sits with two other Cityteam volumes, *Miraculous Movements* and *The Father Glorified*. Ed Roberts, reviewing it for 9Marks, finds it poorly organised and overconfident in tone.

THE METHOD

Most set out a training pattern meant to be passed on by the person trained; the two oldest, from 1963 and 1993, were written before the vocabulary of movements existed.

Breen, Mike. *Building a Discipling Culture*. 3rd ed. Pawleys Island, SC: 3DM International, 2017.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Leadership in Church Planting

The book behind the huddle and the LifeShapes: eight diagrams — a circle of repentance and faith, a semi-circle of work and rest, a triangle of relationships, then the square, pentagon, hexagon, heptagon and octagon — each carrying one discipline to be learned and passed on. Breen developed the system while leading St Thomas' Church, Crookes, in Sheffield. This third edition adds the Five Capitals, the Three As and a new shape for the person of peace. Keith Schooley, writing on his blog in 2013, argues that the shapes are reductive and open to being used manipulatively.

Coleman, Robert E. *The Master Plan of Evangelism*. Westwood, NJ: Fleming H. Revell, 1963.

ALSO IN Evangelism; Discipleship

A short book deriving a method of evangelism from Jesus's training of his disciples, in eight principles, from selection to reproduction. Coleman argues that Jesus invested in a few rather than the crowd, and reads the Great Commission's main verb as 'make disciples', grounding the last principle: those trained train others. Nik Lingle (9Marks, 2013) notes that it rules out treating the point of decision as the main goal; Jared Longshore (Founders Ministries) finds that it underplays the local church's part in discipleship.

Moore, Ralph. *How Nearly Anyone Can Start a Microchurch: Plant a Church without Leaving Your Job*.

Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/how-nearly-anyone-can-start-a-microchurch/>.

ALSO IN Bivocational and Covocational Ministry

A short practical guide, from Ralph Moore's Hope Chapel practice, to leading a reproducing microchurch while keeping one's job and home church membership. It sets out relational practices — shared meals, ongoing questions, a stated priority of making disciples over building congregations — and addresses recurring tensions, among them members who leave or who resist multiplying. Shorter and more method-focused than Cole's *Organic Church*, and written for lay people rather than for planters weighing a vocational call, as Brisco's *Covocational Church Planting* is.

Patterson, George, and Richard Scoggins. *Church Multiplication Guide: Helping Churches to Reproduce Locally and Abroad*. Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1993.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Practical Guides

A guide to multiplying churches from Patterson's 20 years in Honduras, where he moved from training pastors in a residential Bible institute to training leaders by extension where they lived. It teaches his obedience-oriented education, a curriculum built on the commands of Christ rather than on doctrine as a subject, and expects each church to start daughter churches. A revised and enlarged edition is subtitled *The Miracle of Church Reproduction*.

Shank, Nathan, and Kari Shank. *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth: Starting and Releasing Healthy Churches*. 2014 edition. <https://churchplantingmovements.com/four-fields/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Practical Guides; Asia and the Middle East

A training manual organised around four fields drawn from the parable of the growing seed (Mark 4:26–29), from entering a community to forming a church. Nathan and Kari Shank compiled it from the experience of church planters in South Asia, where they worked in Northeast India. It is a common framework for planting: e3 Partners, NoPlaceLeft and East-West Ministries teach it by name, and an evaluation for the mission agency ABWE (2022) finds the method pervasive among sending organisations, while questioning its biblical basis, which rests largely on that one parable.

Smith, Steve, and Ying Kai. *T4T: A Discipleship Re-Revolution*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2011.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Asia and the Middle East

The account of Ying Kai's Training for Trainers work in East Asia, written up by Steve Smith, and the source of the T4T method much movement thinking now assumes. The figures reported are very large: the International Mission Board gives 1.7 million baptisms and 150,000 churches over a decade. It is built in three parts as a training manual rather than as an argument. George Robinson, in *Global Missiology*, criticises its marketing tone, its pragmatism and its unclear definition of a church.

Vanderstelt, Jeff. *One Eighty: A Return to Disciple-Making*. Exponential, 2023. <https://exponential.org/product/one-eighty/>.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

Vanderstelt's book for Exponential, organised around five shifts: from reaching to making, informing to equipping, attending to attaching, striving to thriving, and accumulating people in buildings and programmes to deploying them. He leads the Soma family of churches, and the shifts assume a church that already has programmes and buildings to redirect — a book for an existing congregation rather than for a planter starting clean.

Watson, David L., and Paul D. Watson. *Contagious Disciple Making: Leading Others on a Journey of Discovery*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2014.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

SMALL AND SIMPLE FORMS

Where The Method is about how people are trained, this is mostly about what they meet in, from a whole church in a house to a small group inside a larger congregation.

Breen, Mike, and Alex Absalom. *Launching Missional Communities: A Field Guide*. Pawleys Island, SC: 3DM International, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

Breen and Absalom's field guide to the missional community, which they define as a group of 20 to 50 people united in the name of Jesus around a common service and witness to one context. It works through how such a group is formed and run, and closes with five case studies of churches that did it. The companion to *Building a Discipling Culture*: that book develops people, this one structures the community they belong to.

Chester, Tim, and Steve Timmis. *Everyday Church: Mission by Being Good Neighbours*. Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; New Churches and Networks

A book reading 1 Peter for a church on the margins after Christendom, and a sequel to Chester and Timmis's *Total Church*. The argument is that mission belongs to ordinary members, in the relationships and routines of daily life, rather than to a leader or a programme. Inter-Varsity Press withdrew both books from sale in 2020, *Christianity Today* reported, after Steve Timmis's removal from Acts 29, judging that the close church community they advocate 'lacked sufficient safeguards against abusive control'.

Cole, Neil. *Church 3.0: Upgrades for the Future of the Church*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2010.

The sequel to *Organic Church*, and the more practical of the two: what an organic church does about heresy, money, children, worship and the ordinances. Cole's frame is that the church took on an institutional operating system around AD 300 and has not upgraded since. Foreword by Francis Chan. Geoff Chang's review for 9Marks holds that Cole never defines what makes a local church, and that taking baptism and communion out of a church's authority distorts both.

Cole, Neil. *Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2005.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Comiskey, Joel. *Planting Churches That Reproduce: Starting a Network of Simple Churches*. Moreno Valley, CA: CCS Publishing, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Practical Guides; Church Planting Strategy

A manual for planting simple churches that can keep reproducing into a network, drawn from Comiskey's three church plants and his work as a cell-church coach. Its first part defines a simple church by four marks: at least three members, God-appointed leadership, the lordship of Christ, and baptism and communion. Later parts turn to the planter's preparation and to strategies for cell-driven and house churches. Where Dale's *Getting Started* keeps to the house church, it covers both forms.

Dale, Felicity. *Getting Started: A Practical Guide to House Church Planting*. Austin, TX: House2House, 2003.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A practical guide to starting a simple church in a home, combining biblical material and case studies, on the premise that any believer can start one. Dale, a co-founder of House2House, planted churches in London in the British house-church movement before moving to Texas in 1987. It is addressed to ordinary believers, where Comiskey's *Planting Churches That Reproduce* plans networks of cell-based churches and Patterson and Scoggins's *Church Multiplication Guide* trains leaders.

Dale, Tony, Felicity Dale and George Barna. *Small Is Big! Unleashing the Big Impact of Intentionally Small Churches*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale House, 2011.

The case for churches that stay deliberately small, from Tony and Felicity Dale with George Barna: an updated and expanded version of *The Rabbit and the Elephant* (2009) rather than a reprint under a new title. Theresa C. Shell, in *Awaiting the King*, judged it more balanced than many other house-church books, but thin on their theology. Aaron Menikoff, reviewing the earlier version for 9Marks, held that it treats the word of God, the role of pastors and the church itself too lightly.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *Scattered Not Small: Empowering Ordinary Churches to Become Disciple-Making Communities*. Firestarters Network Resources, 2024.

ALSO IN Baptist; Practical Guides; Revitalisation and Replanting

The sequel to *On This Rock*: a guide to moving a church from a traditional model to a scattered, decentralised one, and to starting a church that way. Remsberg is minister of Beacon Church, Stafford, and the authors draw on practitioners in other churches. It takes up the questions leaders raised with them, among them who provides leadership and what the minister's job becomes, with a discussion section in each chapter.

Meadows, Philip R. *House Fellowship: A Quick Guide*. Spiritual Formation for Mission 3. Inspire Movement, 2021.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan

The third of the Inspire Movement's quick guides in its Spiritual Formation for Mission series (2021), by Philip Meadows, who co-founded the movement to recover discipleship and mission in the Wesleyan spirit. After the second guide, on the fellowship band, this one turns to the house fellowship: a small community meeting in an ordinary home to eat, pray, search the scriptures and watch over one another, then scattering to share the gospel, which may renew a local church or become the foundation of a new plant.

Meadows, Philip R., and Anthony Watts. *Fellowship Band: A Quick Guide*. Spiritual Formation for Mission 2. Inspire Movement, 2019.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality; Early Methodist Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan

A quick guide to the fellowship band — three or four friends meeting regularly for spiritual conversation — as practised in the Inspire Movement, the international and ecumenical network for mission-shaped discipleship in the Wesleyan spirit that Meadows co-founded in 2007.

Payne, J. D. *Missional House Churches: Reaching Our Communities with the Gospel*. Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2008.

Payne's study of North American house churches, built on interviews with more than 30 of them by web questionnaire and then telephone survey. It sets out to find what these churches were doing rather than to argue for the form. Payne taught church planting and evangelism at Southern Baptist Theological Seminary.

Sanders, Brian. *Microchurches: A Smaller Way*. Tampa, FL: Underground Media, 2019.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Wegner, Rob, and Brian Johnson. *Deeply Rooted: Planting Our Lives and Planting the Gospel*. Exponential, 2025. <https://exponential.org/product/deeply-rooted/>.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality

A short guide by two leaders of the Kansas City Underground, a network of microchurches, written as a companion to Exponential's Microchurch Next video series. It argues that gospel multiplication grows from an ordinary, rooted life — relationships and habits of everyday witness — rather than from a starting method, and addresses individual disciples rather than planters. Wegner's earlier book with Ford and Hirsch, *The Starfish and the Spirit*, addresses movement leaders; this one is written for those they lead.

WHERE IT HAS WORKED

Aychi, B. R., with Dave Coles. *Living Fire: Advancing God's Kingdom in Challenging Places*. Beyond, 2024.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Global and Cross-Cultural

A systematic account of a family of disciple-making movements catalysed by Aychi, setting out 22 factors grouped as those that ignite a movement, those that accelerate it and those that sustain it. The settings are named only as challenging places among unreached peoples. More analytical than *Cabbages in the Desert*, which tells the story instead.

Robertson, Patrick, and David Watson, with Gregory C. Benoit. *The Father Glorified: True Stories of God's Power Through Ordinary People*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2013.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A second book of stories from Cityteam's disciple-making work, published by its missionaries as the follow-up to Jerry Trousedale's *Miraculous Movements* (2012). The publisher presents it as a way to learn, through their accounts, how best to win people to Christ. With its predecessor it gives the stories behind the method that David Watson, one of its authors, sets out with Paul Watson in *Contagious Disciple Making* (2014).

Tasse, Aila, with Dave Coles. *Cabbages in the Desert: How God Transformed a Devout Muslim and Catalyzed Disciple Making Movements Among Unreached Peoples*. Beyond, 2024.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Africa; Global and Cross-Cultural

A Muslim teenager in Marsabit, in northern Kenya, meets a Christian teacher, is converted and, in his own words, thrown out of the house, and receives the vision of cabbages growing in desert sand that gives the book its title. What followed was decades of church planting and then disciple-making movements across more than a dozen countries in East, the Horn of, and Southern Africa. Told with Dave Coles, it is a first-hand account by the African leader who catalysed the movements.

Trousedale, Jerry. *Miraculous Movements: How Hundreds of Thousands of Muslims Are Falling in Love with Jesus*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

Jerry Trousedale's book of stories from Cityteam's work among Muslims, most of them in Africa, told to show disciple-making movements at work and drawn into seven principles for making disciples who make disciples. It is the narrative companion to the Watsons' *Contagious Disciple Making*, which sets out the method, and is written for a general Christian readership. Two reviewers dispute it: Jeff Morton, broadly sympathetic, notes that its few footnotes do not substantiate the size of the movements claimed; Darren Carlson questions its obedience-based discipleship and its definition of church, and does not commend it.

Fresh Expressions of Church

See also the lists on Pioneering, and on Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy.

A fresh expression of church is a new congregation started for people who belong to no existing one, and shaped by its own missionary context rather than by the church that began it. The phrase entered general use with *Mission-Shaped Church* in 2004, and echoes the promise Anglican ministers make to proclaim the faith afresh in each generation. The crisp definition usually quoted is not in that report: that wording was settled two years later. Alongside it came 'mixed economy', for a church in which parish and fresh expression are held together, which Moynagh's 'mixed ecology' has since joined; the newer institutional label, used by the recent surveys, is a new worshipping community.

Three questions run through the argument of this reading list, and they are not the same question. The first is theological: whether these are churches. It is pressed from inside the project by Hull, who writes as a supporter and asks the report to think harder, and from outside it by Davison and Milbank, who contest the premise altogether on the ground that the parish is theologically required rather than merely inherited. The second is empirical: whether fresh expressions reach people the parish does not. That one has an answer, and the movement's own research changed it. Where an earlier estimate from church leaders put two-fifths of those attending as never having belonged to a church, a survey of the attenders themselves put it at a fifth — and the report that carried both called the earlier figure flawed.

The third is whether they last, and it is the least well answered. That same report found around a tenth had closed, varying sharply by kind; Steve Taylor followed eleven of the earliest for eleven years and found about half still going. Almost all the published evidence on survival comes from one research unit, and no one has replicated it.

This reading list runs: Start Here; The Theology of a Fresh Expression; What Was Actually Started; Starting and Leading One; and Worship and Form.

START HERE

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Ecclesial Minimum; Church of England Papers and Reports

An influential critique of the fresh expressions movement, from two mainstream Anglicans who defend the parish as theologically necessary. It would be most useful to a reader already persuaded by the movement, since it contests the movement's premise from outside it. Chapter 1, on the relationship between the form of a church and its message, and chapter 3, on the place of the church in salvation, are the significant ones.

Lings, George. *Encountering The Day of Small Things*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2016.

<https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/encounteringthedayofsmallthings-web.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Ecclesial Minimum

The published summary of *The Day of Small Things*, and the short way into it. For the criteria by which a gathering was counted as a church, and the argument about them, the full report is where they are set out.

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A survey of 1,109 fresh expressions in the Church of England, started between 1992 and 2014 in 21 dioceses and studied from 2012 to 2016 through interviews with their leaders. They make up on average 15 per cent of a diocese's church communities, with over 50,600 people attending, and four times as many were being started each year as in 2004. Section 2.6 sets the survey's indicators against the eight criteria of the 2012 Anglican-Methodist report, objecting that those criteria make practices rather than relationship determine what counts as a church; pages 43-44 set out whether attenders were churchd, de-churched or non-churched, each estimate of those new to church lower than the last.

Moynagh, Michael, with Philip Harrold. *Church for Every Context: An Introduction to Theology and Practice*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Introductions and Overviews; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum

A textbook arguing for what Moynagh calls contextual churches, drawing on the literature and practice of both church planting and fresh expressions; its publisher describes it as the first textbook to reflect the learning from fresh expressions of church. It runs from ecclesiology to how a new community is sustained and supported, and at over 500 pages would suit use by section.

THE THEOLOGY OF A FRESH EXPRESSION

Advocates and critics together, from 2005 to 2024, and not all of it about whether these are churches: some is about what mission is for.

Baker, Jonny, and Cathy Ross. *Imagining Mission with John V. Taylor*. London: SCM Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Missiology; Pioneering

A book by two teachers on the Church Mission Society's pioneer training that thinks with John V. Taylor about church, mission and society now, rather than writing his history. It is drawn from the travel diaries and monthly newsletters Taylor wrote as the Society's General Secretary from 1963 to 1974, and works with his 'immersion, imagination and improvisation'; each chapter closes with practical questions.

Cray, Graham, Ian Mobsby and Aaron Kennedy, eds. *Fresh Expressions of Church and the Kingdom of God*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic

An edited volume arguing that the mission of a fresh expression is as much about social transformation — the kingdom — as about building the church. Contributors include Rowan Williams and Phyllis Tickle. The companion volume to *Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*, and one of four in the Ancient Faith, Future Mission series.

Cray, Graham. 'Discernment: The Key to Planting Missional Churches'. In *Cultivating Missional Change: The Future of Missional Churches and Missional Theology*, edited by Coenie Burger, Frederick Marais and Danie Mouton. Wellington, South Africa: Bible Media Biblecor, 2017.

ALSO IN Missiology

A chapter by Graham Cray, Archbishops' Missioner and Team Leader of Fresh Expressions from 2009 to 2014, written for the 2015 Stellenbosch conference on the future of missional churches and missional theology. It is a contribution from the English fresh expressions movement to a conversation about the missional church convened in South Africa.

Croft, Steven, and Ian Mobsby, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2009. American edition, with Stephanie Spellers, New York: Seabury Books, 2010.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Church of England Papers and Reports; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments; Ecclesial Minimum

An edited volume on what a mission-shaped church looks like when it is rooted in sacramental tradition rather than set against it, written by pioneers, leaders and theologians from Britain and the United States. Contributors include Rowan Williams, Brian McLaren, Stephen Cottrell, Richard Giles and Phyllis Tickle. The American edition of 2010 adds Stephanie Spellers as a third editor and a foreword by Katharine Jefferts Schori. In the argument over fresh expressions it takes the side opposite Davison and Milbank's *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions* (2010).

Croft, Steven, ed. *Mission-Shaped Questions: Defining Issues for Today's Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2008.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Ecclesial Minimum

A collection of essays responding to *Mission-Shaped Church*. A mixed collection, but Croft's own two — opening and closing — are well worth reading: the first argues for loosening Anglican structures to make room for planting and fresh expressions, the last reflects on what it means to be church in a missionary context. John Drane's essay on what maturity looks like for emerging churches is the other one worth the time.

Dalpra, Claire. 'When Is Messy Church "Church"?' In *Messy Church Theology: Exploring the Significance of Messy Church for the Wider Church*, edited by George Lings, [pages?]. Abingdon: BRF, 2013.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum

A chapter from a member of Church Army's Research Unit asking whether Messy Church meets the tests of being a church, printed alongside a companion chapter arguing the opposing case, in the first collection to treat Messy Church's theology at length. The Research Unit's own criteria for a fresh expression, developed here for one form, are set out more fully across the wider field in Lings's *The Day of Small Things* (2016).

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Dunlop, Andrew. *Out of Nothing: A Cross-Shaped Approach to Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2018.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A monograph narrating Dunlop's own attempt to plant a fresh expression, reviewing the ecclesiological models and atonement theologies that might ground its evaluation before proposing his own, the 'Cross-Shaped approach'. Where his later thesis, *Catholicity and Connection* (2025), draws on fieldwork across a team ministry's mixed ecology, this earlier book stays with a single plant and its pioneer's own theological reasoning. A *Church Times* review found the closing chapter, turning from theology to ask what the plant's growth amounted to, more useful than what precedes it.

Goodhew, David, Andrew Roberts, and Michael Volland. *Fresh! An Introduction to Fresh Expressions of Church and Pioneer Ministry*. London: SCM Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Introductions and Overviews

A textbook introduction to fresh expressions of church and to pioneer ministry, presented as one field rather than two, co-written by David Goodhew, Andrew Roberts and Michael Volland. It draws a theological rationale for both from scripture and the wider Christian tradition, tests it against contemporary British culture and against the criticisms fresh expressions have attracted, and follows this with practical guidance for starting and sustaining a fresh expression or a pioneer post over the long term.

Gross, Oliver. 'Review Article: Messy Church Theology'. Review of *Messy Church Theology: Exploring the Significance of Messy Church for the Wider Church*, edited by George Lings. *Foundations*, no. 68 (Spring 2015): 102-108. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-68/issue-68-article-5-review-article-messy-church-theology/>.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum

A review article by Oliver Gross on *Messy Church Theology* (2013), the collection edited by George Lings. Gross asks whether Messy Church is a church in its own right, testing it against three marks he draws from the New Testament: qualified leadership, a clear distinction between believers and unbelievers, and expository preaching. He concludes that it should be kept 'as an outreach or ministry of a more traditional and biblically-organised church'.

Hollinghurst, Steve. *Mission-Shaped Evangelism: The Gospel in Contemporary Culture*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A book on sharing the gospel once Christendom's assumptions no longer hold, from Church Army's Sheffield Centre, where Hollinghurst was researcher in evangelism. Asking whether God speaks through culture as well as through the Christian tradition, it listens to each in turn: to contemporary culture, including the rise of new spiritualities, then to how the church met earlier cultural shifts from the ancient pagan world onwards. Part Three turns to practice, with evangelism in supermarkets, at festivals and online.

Hull, John M. *Mission-Shaped Church: A Theological Response*. London: SCM Press, 2006.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesial Minimum; Church of England Papers and Reports

A book-length theological critique of *Mission-Shaped Church*, arguing that the report never consistently distinguishes the Kingdom of God from the church, and so turns a mission directed towards the world into a strategy for the church's own growth. Drawing on Barth, Hull treats the church as the fruit and agent of mission rather than its goal, and presses the report on its treatment of poverty, its neglect of consumerism and religious plurality, and its Anglican horizon. He writes as a supporter of fresh expressions, if a cautious one.

Lings, George, ed. *Messy Church Theology: Exploring the Significance of Messy Church for the Wider Church*. Abingdon: BRF, 2013.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum

An edited collection, the first to treat Messy Church's theology at length, gathering academics and practitioners around what Messy Church contributes to the wider church. Claire Dalpra's opening chapter, filed separately, asks whether Messy Church is a church in its own right, and the next takes the opposing case. Oliver Gross's review in *Foundations* concludes that Messy Church should stay 'an outreach or ministry' of a more traditional congregation.

Lings, George. *Why Modality and Sodality Thinking Is Vital to Understand Future Church*. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, n.d. [2013?]. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/george-lings---why-modality-and-sodality.pdf>.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Pioneering

A short report applying modality and sodality to the Church of England. Lings holds the two as a spectrum rather than a binary, argues that sodality pioneers what modality then sustains, and warns against deploying sodal people in modal roles: there is, he writes, 'little point in breeding tigers if you intend to keep them chained up in dog kennels'. Eight pages.

Milbank, Alison. *The Once and Future Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Resource Churches

Milbank returns to the ground of *For the Parish*, to which this is an explicit sequel, and takes on what has happened since: minster hubs, the Strategic Development Fund and the Emerging Church programme. Her quarrel is on three fronts — ecclesiology, the account of the person these assume, and their reading of secularism.

Moynagh, Michael. *Church in Life: Innovation, Mission and Ecclesiology*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Introductions and Overviews; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesiology; Ecclesial Minimum

A monograph modelling how new Christian communities come into being, drawing on complexity theory and entrepreneurship studies alongside theology. Where Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* (2012) makes the case for contextual churches, this book gives an account of how they emerge, analysing and systematising the innovation skills that pioneers of fresh expressions use by instinct. Its closing section, 'Perspectives on Method', bears most directly on how innovating teams work.

Nelstrop, Louise, and Martyn Percy, eds. *Evaluating Fresh Expressions: Explorations in Emerging Church*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports

An edited collection assessing the fresh expressions movement four years in, presented by its publisher as the successor to Hull's shorter critique. It asks what counts as a fresh expression at all, how postmodern accounts of truth and tradition bear on it, who actually attends, and what follows for clergy training and pioneer ministry. Peter Rollins contributes 'Biting the Hand That Feeds'.

Olsworth-Peter, Ed. *Mixed Ecology: Inhabiting an Integrated Church*. London: SPCK, 2024.

ALSO IN Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

The book of the policy: what it means for parishes, fresh expressions, plants and pioneer ministries to be one church rather than parallel systems, after the Archbishop of York made mixed ecology one of the Church of England's three priorities in November 2021. Olsworth-Peter was the Church of England's national adviser for pioneer development and by publication had moved to St Mellitus as director of innovation and development. He takes the argument to gathered, digital and hybrid forms together.

Shenk, Wilbert R., and David Parker. *The Realities of the Changing Expressions of the Church*. Lausanne Occasional Paper 43. Issue Group 14, 2004 Forum for World Evangelization, Pattaya. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 2005. https://lausanne.org/wp-content/uploads/2007/06/LOP43_IG14.pdf.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement; Ecclesiology

A committee report on its issue group's brief: the different patterns of church planting aimed at different sections of a community, and how effective each is at reaching the unreached. It works from cases in Africa, Asia, Europe, Latin America and North America, and on new varieties of church that had emerged over the preceding 30 years. Its theological reflection argues that these raise questions the classic notes of the church do not fully cover, and cautions both against dismissing new forms and against granting older ones a monopoly on truth. The closest thing Lausanne has to a theological treatment of new and emerging forms of church, and, with its cases, a useful paper for students.

Steele, Hannah. *New World, New Church? The Theology of the Emerging Church Movement*. London: SCM Press, 2017.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A critical theological assessment of the emerging church movement, developed from Hannah Steele's doctoral research at King's College London under Alister McGrath, who contributes the foreword. It sets out the thinking of leading figures in the movement, Brian McLaren and Rob Bell among them, around the question of whether its drive for accessibility comes at the expense of Christian orthodoxy. Steele affirms what she judges good and insightful in the emerging church while offering a critical evaluation of its theological revisions.

WHAT WAS ACTUALLY STARTED

The accounts and the counts, as against the arguments above; most date from the years when the thing was still being worked out.

Bolger, Ryan K., ed. *The Gospel after Christendom: New Voices, New Cultures, New Expressions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Missiology; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

An edited volume that widens the largely Anglo-American scope of Gibbs and Bolger's *Emerging Churches* (2005) to churches that have grown up after Christendom on several continents. Bolger put questions about the shifts facing the Western church to 137 scholar-practitioners and built the book from the 76 who replied, in five parts, with contributors commenting on one another's chapters in text boxes. Reviewing it, Kevin Book-Satterlee finds themes repeated, especially in the European material.

Church Army's Research Unit. *Church Growth Research Project: Report on Strand 3b, An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church and Church Plants Begun in the Period 1992–2012*. Sheffield: Church Army, 2013. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/church_growth_research_fresh_expressions_-_strand_3b_oct13_-_the_report.pdf.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A report from the fresh expressions strand, Strand 3b, of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme, conducted by Church Army's Research Unit under George Lings within the consortium led by Cranmer Hall, Durham, and dated October 2013. It analyses fresh expressions of Church and church plants begun between 1992 and 2012. It precedes Lings's larger survey of 21 dioceses, *The Day of Small Things* (2016), and sits beside Dadswell and Ross's companion strand on church planting, Strand 4.

Cray, Graham, Ian Mobsby and Aaron Kennedy, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: New Monasticism as Fresh Expression of Church*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality; Ecclesiology; Rule of Life

An edited volume in which leaders of traditional religious communities and of new monastic ones write from their own communities on how an older form of religious life is shaping a new form of church. It was edited from within Fresh Expressions, which Graham Cray then led, and its subtitle states its claim: that new monasticism, which *Mission-Shaped Church* named among the new forms of church, is a fresh expression of church. The chapters are testimony and reflection rather than a single argument. Gladys Ganiel's review commends Shane Claiborne's 'Marks of a New Monasticism' for its vision of living alongside disadvantaged communities.

General Synod of the Church of England. *GS 2142: A Mission-Shaped Church and Fresh Expressions 15 Years On*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2019. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/gs-2142-mission-shaped-church.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

A five-page report put to General Synod in July 2019, 15 years after *Mission-Shaped Church*. It describes fresh expressions and pioneering as a new missionary movement affecting mission practices, ecclesiology, theology, leadership, resources and structures, and carries a motion about work in 10 dioceses. It quotes the more flattering of Church Army's two estimates of who attends a fresh expression, without the caveat Church Army itself attached to it. Of the 'mixed or blended economy' it says only that it 'is important and calls for different expressions of church to recognise and resource one another through an integrated approach'.

Gibbs, Eddie, and Ryan K. Bolger. *Emerging Churches: Creating Christian Community in Postmodern Cultures*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2005.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Ecclesiology

A study of emerging churches in the United States and the United Kingdom, built on interviews with about 50 of their leaders over three years, from which Gibbs and Bolger draw nine practices held in common, three of which, identifying with Jesus among them, they treat as core. The authors offer interpretation rather than theological critique, working, in Xochitl Alvizo's phrase, 'more like sociologists', so the book describes the practice of new churches rather than arguing an ecclesiology. A chapter is given to each practice, and an appendix sets out the research method with the leaders' own words.

Howson, Chris. *A Just Church: 21st Century Liberation Theology in Action*. London: Continuum, 2011.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Missiology

A book, by its priest, on a fresh expression in the centre of Bradford that took liberation theology as its working method: radical forms of worship, experimental forms of community, and non-violent direct action, including resistance to the detention of asylum seekers. Howson sets out an action-reflection cycle of education, action, reflection and sustaining, offered to help other Christians develop a contextual theology of their own.

Jackson, Bob, and Bev Botting. *New in the North: New Worshipping Communities in the Province of York 2023*. Faith in the North, 2024. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/optimized_new_in_the_north_2023_.pdf.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A report on new worshipping communities across the northern province, drawing on the 2023 Statistics for Mission returns: 388 among 2,616 churches sampled, about one in seven, from which the authors extrapolate some 550 province-wide. It is unusually candid about what the data cannot bear — a 24 per cent attrition rate among fresh expressions, and likely under-reporting of those that have closed. Jackson is a church-growth writer and former archdeacon; Botting is a statistician.

Lings, George, ed. *Encounters on the Edge*. 56 nos. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit (The Sheffield Centre), 1999-2012. <https://churcharmy.org/our-work/research/publications/encounters-on-the-edge/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

Fifty-six quarterly booklets from the Church Army's research unit in Sheffield, running from 1999 to 2012, most of them a close study of one new church — mostly British, a few overseas — with strategic and theological commentary attached. Lings wrote or co-wrote 50 of them; six are Claire Dalpra's. Their particular value is that they were written while fresh expressions were being invented rather than afterwards.

Lings, George. 'The History of Fresh Expressions of Church and Church Planting in the Church of England'. In *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*, edited by David Goodhew, 161-78. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Introductions and Overviews; Anglican

A chapter tracing church planting in the Church of England from the 1960s to fresh expressions of church, by the head of Church Army's research unit. Lings sets out six movements that prepared the ground, among them charismatic renewal and church growth theory, gives figures for plants by period, and presents fresh expressions as a new departure rather than a return to the daughter church.

Lings, George. *Crossnet: Do Not Despise the Day of Small Things*. Encounters on the Edge 53. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, 2012. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/encounters-53.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A case study of Crossnet in Bristol, started by three couples in 2004 and down to about a dozen at the core by 2012, after some 130 people had passed through it. Number 53 of the Encounters on the Edge series. Lings ties the title's point to method: apprentice-style work with a few, one to one, achieving more than traditional approaches to the many.

Lings, George. *Encountering The Day of Small Things*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/encounteringthedayofsmallthings-web.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Taylor, Steve. *First Expressions: Innovation and the Mission of God*. London: SCM Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A longitudinal study, which is what makes it unusual: Taylor researched 11 emerging churches in 2001 and went back to them 11 years later, following their creativity and their conflict, their dreams and their despair. James Butler, reviewing it for *Anvil*, notes that only five of the 11 were still in existence. Four parts, 13 chapters.

STARTING AND LEADING ONE

Practical guidance, for the reader who is doing it rather than assessing it.

Breen, Mike, and Alex Absalom. *Launching Missional Communities: A Field Guide*. Pawleys Island, SC: 3DM International, 2010.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

Breen and Absalom's field guide to the missional community, which they define as a group of 20 to 50 people united in the name of Jesus around a common service and witness to one context. It works through how such a group is formed and run, and closes with five case studies of churches that did it. The companion to *Building a Discipling Culture*: that book develops people, this one structures the community they belong to.

Hopkins, Bob, and Freddy Hedley. *Coaching for Missional Leadership*. Sheffield: Fresh Expressions and ACPI, 2008.

ALSO IN Coaching; Formation and Training; Leadership in Church Planting

A guide to coaching and mentoring missional leaders, produced jointly by Fresh Expressions and the Anglican Church Planting Initiatives (ACPI) as a follow-on from Fresh Expressions' own training courses. Its distinctive focus, within Christian coaching generally, is coaching for those planting churches and fresh expressions specifically, rather than pastoral or life coaching more broadly. Aimed at trainers and mentors working with pioneer ministers and planters, in a British Anglican setting, rather than at a general readership.

Male, David. *How to Pioneer (Even If You Haven't a Clue)*. London: Church House Publishing, 2016.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Pioneering

A practical guide for beginners in pioneering new Christian communities. Male wrote it while advising the Church of England on pioneer development. It covers listening to a local context and discerning its needs, building a team, starting and discipleship.

Robinson, Martin. *Planting Mission-Shaped Churches Today*. Oxford: Monarch Books, 2006.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Missiology

A book on planting new churches in the West, illustrated with dozens of examples, by a Churches of Christ minister who had led a plant in inner-city Birmingham. It is a different book from *Planting Tomorrow's Churches Today* (1992), the handbook Robinson wrote with Stuart Christine.

WORSHIP AND FORM

Two subjects rather than one: the pull of old liturgy on new churches, and the church that meets both online and in person.

Bevins, Winfield. *Ever Ancient, Ever New: The Allure of Liturgy for a New Generation*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2019.

ALSO IN Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

An account of younger Christians from non-liturgical backgrounds who have moved towards creedal and sacramental worship, built on two years of fieldwork across the United States, Canada and England. It calls the communities it found neo-liturgical: Baptist, Methodist and non-denominational churches blending contemporary worship with Word and Table. Leslie Michele, reviewing it for Christians for Social Action, objects that the churches studied are all white-centred.

Bevins, Winfield. *Liturgical Mission: The Work of the People for the Life of the World*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2022.

ALSO IN Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

Bevins argues that the church's liturgical and sacramental life is itself missional, against the habit of setting worship and mission against each other, and offers the historic practices as a framework for everyday discipleship. Foreword by Justo González. The publisher addresses it both to Christians outside liturgical traditions and to those already within them.

Cockayne, Joshua. *What Does Liturgy Have to Do with Doctrine?* Doctrine 9. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2022.

ALSO IN Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

A Grove booklet arguing that the church's liturgies form those who take part in them, so that anyone who cares about doctrine has to care how it is prayed. Cockayne is director of mission and evangelism at Cranmer Hall, Durham, and co-edited *New Churches: A Theology* with Will Foulger.

Croft, Steven, and Ian Mobsby, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2009. American edition, with Stephanie Spellers, New York: Seabury Books, 2010.

ANNOTATED under The Theology of a Fresh Expression

Phillips, Peter. *Hybrid Church: Blending Online and Offline Community*. Mission and Evangelism 131. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2020.

ALSO IN Digital and Hybrid Church

A Grove booklet written during the 2020 lockdown, setting out what hybrid church is and giving three case studies of practitioners who found hybrid ways of working in the pandemic. It began, Phillips says, when he asked some digital friends to share their thoughts. He had founded Durham's Centre for Digital Theology.

White, James Emery. *Hybrid Church: Rethinking the Church for a Post-Christian Digital Age*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Reflective, 2023.

ALSO IN Digital and Hybrid Church

A book arguing that the pandemic's acceleration of cultural change calls for a permanent shift rather than a return to earlier ways: a church must bring together the physical and the digital, and be a community of faith for churchgoers and a church for the unchurched at once. Written after attendance failed to recover on reopening, from Mecklenburg Community Church in Charlotte, North Carolina, which White founded and leads. It shares its title with Phillips's much shorter Grove booklet.

Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

See also the lists in Church Planting Around the World, and Global and Cross-Cultural in particular.

A multi-ethnic church is one in which no single ethnic group predominates. The reference definition is Michael Emerson's: a congregation is multiracial when no one racial group makes up eighty per cent or more of it.

The principal argument is over whose terms a mixed congregation runs on. Korie Edwards's study of interracial churches found them ordered by white cultural norms even where white members were a minority, so that a congregation could be mixed in its membership and unchanged in its worship, its leadership and its expectations. At the other pole are the practitioners, Mark DeYmaz among them, who set out what a church must deliberately do to become multi-ethnic and to stay so.

Whether a church may rightly gather people by ethnic affinity at all is the older argument over the homogeneous unit principle, which has its own reading list. Several of its texts are filed here as well, under Whose Terms? The Argument About Homogeneity, because a mixed congregation meets the same question from the other side.

In Britain the subject is shaped by the growth of Black majority and migrant churches, so it concerns the relations between congregations of different heritage as well as the mixing within one.

This reading list runs from Start Here to Building a Multi-Ethnic Church, then Whose Terms? The Argument About Homogeneity, and last Intercultural Competence, which is a different subject: the skill of working across a culture, rather than the congregation that holds several.

START HERE

DeYmaz, Mark. *Building a Healthy Multi-Ethnic Church: Mandate, Commitments and Practices of a Diverse Congregation*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2007.

The practical case for the multi-ethnic congregation, set out as seven commitments that run from dependence on God to mobilising the church for impact. DeYmaz argues from John 17, the church at Antioch and Ephesians, then gives a third part to how the commitments were worked out at Mosaic in Little Rock, which he planted. Ben Wright's review for 9Marks, sympathetic to the aim, finds its reading of the texts too broad.

Emerson, Michael O., and Christian Smith. *Divided by Faith: Evangelical Religion and the Problem of Race in America*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2000.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle

A sociological study of white American evangelicals and race, built on a survey of 2,000 people and 200 face-to-face interviews. Emerson and Smith argue that the tools by which white evangelicals interpret the world, accountable freewill individualism among them, lead them to explain racial inequality in terms that put structural remedies out of reach, and that racially separate congregational life keeps the habit in place. It won the Society for the Scientific Study of Religion's Distinguished Book Award in 2001; Reformed evangelical critics have contested it since.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Multicultural Kingdom: Ethnic Diversity, Mission and the Church*. London: SCM Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Africa; Missiology

A book by a Malawian missiologist based in Britain, arguing that the church is by nature a multicultural mosaic, an image he takes from his mother, while British churches of different ethnic heritage often share a building but not a service. His *Sent Forth* (2014) studies African mission to the West; this book addresses British churches and argues for a multicultural missiology. Its final section asks how a church's membership, leadership and worship should reflect that diversity. Walter McConnell (*Mission Round Table*, 2023) finds that its history of mission starts at William Carey and that some of its statistics are inaccurate.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Mission-Shaped Church in a Multicultural World*. Mission and Evangelism 118. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2017.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Missiology

A Grove booklet arguing that growing ethnic diversity in British Christianity will make race a central question for mission this century, and urging majority-culture congregations to build real relationships with the immigrant and majority-world Christians already worshipping among them. *Sent Forth* (2014) studies African mission to the West at large, and *Multicultural Kingdom* (2020) sets out a fuller multicultural missiology for Britain; this booklet compresses a similar argument into a short, parish-level statement, written for a general church readership rather than students.

BUILDING A MULTI-ETHNIC CHURCH

Alvarez, Iosmar. *Viral Multiplication in Hispanic Churches: How to Plant and Multiply Disciple-Making Hispanic Churches in Twenty-First Century America*. Discipleship Resources, 2019.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A book on planting among Hispanic communities in the United States, built around embedding multiplication in a church's DNA from the start rather than adding it afterwards. Alvarez writes from his own planting in the United Methodist Church.

Bevins, Winfield, ed. *Global Voices: Stories of Church Planting from Around the World*. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2019.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Global and Cross-Cultural

A collection of eight case studies of church planting, from Jerusalem, India, Canada, England, Colombia, China, Kenya and New Zealand, edited by the director of Asbury Theological Seminary's church planting initiative. Selvaratnam's chapter, 'Reclaiming the Missing Generation', tells of G2, the plant he led in York.

DeYmaz, Mark, and Harry Li. *Leading a Healthy Multi-Ethnic Church: Seven Common Challenges and How to Overcome Them*. Leadership Network Innovation Series. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2013.

The follow-up to *Building a Healthy Multi-Ethnic Church*, addressed to a congregation that has already begun: seven challenges that surface once the vision is agreed, rather than the case for adopting it. Its publisher describes it as formerly titled *Ethnic Blends* (2010). DeYmaz and Li write from Mosaic in Little Rock.

DeYmaz, Mark, and Harry Li. *The Coming Revolution in Church Economics: Why Tithes and Offerings Are No Longer Enough, and What You Can Do about It*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2019.

ALSO IN Money and Funding; Buildings, Venues and Space; Estates and Poorer Communities

A funding argument rather than an ethnic one: tithes and offerings, DeYmaz and Li argue, are no longer enough to carry a church, which should add a nonprofit arm that can draw grants and a business arm that lets property and starts enterprises. Mosaic, in a low-income part of Little Rock, is the tested case. George Wood's review puts the objections: pastors running businesses they are not trained for, and the tax and employment law that follows.

DeYmaz, Mark. *Building a Healthy Multi-Ethnic Church: Mandate, Commitments and Practices of a Diverse Congregation*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2007.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Gray, Derwin L. *Building a Multiethnic Church: A Gospel Vision of Love, Grace, and Reconciliation in a Divided World*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2021.

Gray's case is that reconciliation between ethnic groups is a theological question before it is a social one, and that a multiethnic congregation follows from the gospel rather than from good intentions. He writes from Transformation Church in Indian Land, South Carolina, which he and his wife founded in 2010. A revision of his earlier *The High-Definition Leader*, and the theological complement to DeYmaz's more practical pair.

Hardy, Andrew R., and Dan Yarnell. *Forming Multicultural Partnerships: Church Planting in a Divided Society*. Watford: Instant Apostle, 2015.

ALSO IN [Church Planting Movements](#)

Two British church planters argue for the reconciliation of a divided, multicultural society through a united multi-ethnic church, drawing on their own practice and on missiological and theological reflection. The book takes in ethnic churches and hospitality. Where Olofinjana asks what partnership between existing congregations would require, this works towards the mixed congregation itself.

Olofinjana, Israel Oluwole. *Partnership in Mission: A Black Majority Church Perspective on Mission and Church Unity*. Watford: Instant Apostle, 2015.

ALSO IN [Baptist](#); [Africa](#)

A monograph, not one of Olofinjana's several edited collections. It asks three questions of the Black majority churches in Britain: what they are, how varied the movement is, and what partnership with the historic denominations could look like. Case studies of partnerships already working are set beside them. The vantage is a Nigerian-British Baptist minister's, writing to the historic churches rather than about them.

WHOSE TERMS? THE ARGUMENT ABOUT HOMOGENEITY

Edwards, Korie L. *The Elusive Dream: The Power of Race in Interracial Churches*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2008.

ALSO IN [Homogeneous Unit Principle](#)

A study of interracial congregations that sets a national dataset of some 700 churches beside fieldwork in one of them, a Midwestern church Edwards calls Crosstown. Her argument is that such congregations tend to run on white cultural terms, the chapter title being 'Reproducing White Hegemony', so that a mixed congregation may hold together without the worship, the leadership or the expectations changing hands. Uncomfortable for anyone who treats mixing as the end of the question.

Emerson, Michael O., and Christian Smith. *Divided by Faith: Evangelical Religion and the Problem of Race in America*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2000.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Sent Forth: African Missionary Work in the West*. American Society of Missiology Series 51. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2014.

ALSO IN [Africa](#); [Missiology](#); [Global and Cross-Cultural](#)

A book by a Malawian scholar and pastor arguing that African Christianity has carried a missionary impulse since the early church and now brings it to the West. Its organising idea is the 'blessed reflex': that the continuing evangelisation of the world will need, and profit from, the energies of African churches, so that mission now runs towards the West as well as from it. Written for scholars, pastors and congregational leaders, and for African Christians engaged in mission in Western contexts.

The Pasadena Consultation: Homogeneous Unit Principle. Lausanne Occasional Paper 1. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 1978. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/lop-1>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement; Church Growth; Homogeneous Unit Principle

The report of the Pasadena colloquium of 1977, held under the Lausanne Theology and Education Group and published as the first Lausanne Occasional Paper: 10 primary contributors, Donald McGavran and C. Peter Wagner among them, some 25 further consultants and John Stott as moderator. Proponents and critics of the homogeneous unit principle agreed that a homogeneous unit church 'can be a legitimate and authentic church' but 'can never be complete in itself', since the 'dividing wall' Christ abolished 'was enmity or hostility'. It would be a useful place to begin on the ecclesiological objection to church-growth planting strategy, before taking either side.

Wagner, C. Peter. *Our Kind of People: The Ethical Dimensions of Church Growth in America*. Atlanta: John Knox Press, 1979.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle; Church Growth

A book-length defence of the homogeneous unit principle for American congregations, made on ethical grounds as well as strategic ones by McGavran's colleague at Fuller. Wagner argues for a pluralism that encourages distinct identities against the integrationist ideal of the melting pot; his last chapter is titled 'Overcoming Racism Through Christian Love'. *Kirkus Reviews* found the argument's broad outlines 'solidly convincing' and Wagner's sociology 'a bit amateurish'.

INTERCULTURAL COMPETENCE

Hesselgrave, David J. *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: A Guide for Home and Foreign Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1980.

ALSO IN Missiology; Introductions and Overviews; Global and Cross-Cultural; Acts of the Apostles

A missiologist's guide to planting across cultures, organised round a 10-stage Pauline Cycle drawn from Acts 13–16, which runs from missionaries commissioned to sending churches convened. A second edition, retitled *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: North America and Beyond*, followed in 2000.

Kraft, Charles H. *Anthropology for Christian Witness*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1996.

ALSO IN Missiology; Global and Cross-Cultural

A basic introduction to the study of anthropology for those planning careers in mission or cross-cultural ministry. Drawn from what Kraft taught at Fuller's School of World Mission, it covers theories of culture and society, the anthropological schools, kinship and cross-cultural communication. Hiebert's *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries*, by contrast, gives whole sections to the missionary's culture shock and bicultural identity.

Moon, W. Jay. *Intercultural Discipleship: Learning from Global Approaches to Spiritual Formation*. Encountering Mission. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2017.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Formation and Training; Discipleship

A textbook on disciple-making read across cultures rather than out of one. Moon, who spent 13 years with SIM among the Builsa of northern Ghana, argues that formation happens through the genres a culture already has, from proverb and story to song, ritual and dance, and that Western discipleship has narrowed itself to the printed word and the classroom. Eleven chapters, each closing with a case study and an exercise. Useful to a planter working in any community whose habits of learning are not their own.

Snow, Martyn, with Lusa Nsenga-Ngoy, Saju Muthalaly, Jessie Tang, and Florence Gildea. *An Intercultural Church for a Multicultural World: Reflections on Gift Exchange*. London: Church House Publishing, 2024.

ALSO IN Anglican

A short collection of theological reflections by a diocesan bishop, arising from the Diocese of Leicester's own Intercultural Worshipping Communities programme, with named contributions from four colleagues in its ministry team. It organises the case for a more diverse church around gift exchange — generous giving, radical receptivity and transformative thanksgiving — rather than around demographic argument alone. Unlike a general missiological treatment, it stays close to one diocese's own practice, drawing on Snow's ministry in the UK and West Africa; Saju Muthalaly's chapter on hospitality and Jessie Tang's closing afterword on intercultural ministry would be good starting points. Written for Church of England readers considering diversity in their own parishes.

Resource Churches

See also the lists on Revitalisation and Replanting, and on Multi-site Church.

A resource church, in the Church of England's own definition of 2017, is one designated by its diocesan bishop and set within a diocesan strategy to evangelise a city or town and transform society. The first church to be identified as one was in Brighton, in 2009. Ric Thorpe, whose books give the model's own account, put the number at around 130, across 27 dioceses, on leaving his national role in 2025; Jack Shepherd has suggested there may be as many as three hundred by 2030. The term itself has no agreed definition, as Shepherd's examination of those offered since 1997 shows.

The principal argument is over whether concentrating people and money in large sending churches renews the whole Church or narrows it. The model's own reports record growth in attendance and among young people. Its critics cite the Church's review of its strategic development funding, which found far fewer new disciples than the funded projects, not all of them resource churches, had expected. A second objection is that the churches chosen come from a narrow range of traditions. Alison Milbank's objection, made in defence of the parish, is theological.

This reading list runs from *Start Here* to *What a Resource Church Is*, and then *The Evidence*.

START HERE

Shepherd, Jack. 'What's in a Name? An Examination of Current Definitions of Resource Churches'. *Journal of Anglican Studies* 22, no. 1 (2024): 81-97. <https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/journal-of-anglican-studies/article/whats-in-a-name-an-examination-of-current-definitions-of-resource-churches/2119B46236D6917266F4627AE7EB41D0>.

ALSO IN Anglican

Shepherd takes six definitions of 'resource church' in turn, from Mike Breen's of 1997 through *Mission-Shaped Church*, the Strategy and Development Unit's of 2017 and Ric Thorpe's of 2021, and separates the term from hub church, minster church, megachurch and 'resourcing church', with which it is regularly conflated. His verdict is that it remains a term in search of a precise meaning; Thorpe's is the best available but is tied to what current legislation allows. The first of three pieces on the term, and incorporated into his Manchester thesis.

Thorpe, Ric. *Resource Churches: A Story of Church Planting and Revitalisation Across the Nation*. London: CCX, 2021.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Anglican; Church Planting Strategy

The account of the resource church strategy from inside it, by the bishop who held the Church of England's national brief for planting when it was written. Biblical, theological and historical roots first, then the practicalities of launching and growing one, with stories from planters and a reflection from each of their bishops. Its definition, as Shepherd reports it, turns on a bishop's authorisation, a place in diocesan strategy, resourcing to plant and revitalise, a leadership pipeline, and resourcing for wider mission. Thorpe intends it to apply beyond Anglicanism.

WHAT A RESOURCE CHURCH IS

Definitions, the theology under them, and the case for the model and against it.

Church of Scotland Faith Action Programme Leadership Team. *Report of the Faith Action Programme Leadership Team*. Reports to the General Assembly 2026. Church of Scotland, 2026. https://www.churchofscotland.org.uk/__data/assets/pdf_file/0006/154653/Faith-Action-Programme-Leadership-Team1.pdf.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Church Planting Strategy; Presbyterian and Reformed

A report to the Church of Scotland's General Assembly of May 2026, which asked the Assembly to note the progress of plans for a resource church in the Presbytery of Glasgow. It defines a resource church as a hub for mission, planting, revitalisation and developing leaders, proposes siting one near universities to reach students and young adults, and affirms three levels of planting: local, presbytery and national. It also records that the planting strategy the 2025 Assembly asked for is not ready, central staff having been cut.

Milbank, Alison. *The Once and Future Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Fresh Expressions of Church

Milbank returns to the ground of *For the Parish*, to which this is an explicit sequel, and takes on what has happened since: minster hubs, the Strategic Development Fund and the Emerging Church programme. Her quarrel is on three fronts — ecclesiology, the account of the person these assume, and their reading of secularism.

Porter, Matthew. *Overflow: Learning from the Inspirational Resource Church of Antioch in the Book of Acts*. Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2020.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles; Church Planting Strategy

A book reading the church at Antioch in Acts 11 and 13 as a resource church, with 'not just a local but a regional vision'; Porter names seven such churches in the New Testament, Antioch his main case. He wrote it as vicar of St Michael le Belfrey in York, and draws characteristics, structures and strategies from Antioch for churches now. Each chapter closes with questions for reflection and group discussion.

Shepherd, Jack. 'A Critical Realist Account of the Theological Values of Resource Churches in the Church of England'. PhD thesis, University of Manchester, 2026. <https://research.manchester.ac.uk/en/studentTheses/a-critical-realist-account-of-the-theological-values-of-resource-/>.

ALSO IN Anglican; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets

Interviews at three resource churches with distinctive models, and six wider perspectives, read through a critical realist frame. Shepherd traces three theological lineages behind the form, a Pentecostal ecclesiology owing to Roland Allen, a pneumatological church growth owing to Wimber and Padilla, and a pneumatological missiology owing to Wright and Donovan, and finds no shared or normative understanding of liturgical tradition among them. In place of a definition by criteria he proposes a centred set of five values: centres of spirituality, processes of evangelism, contextual revitalisation, inaugurated eschatology and narrative testimony.

Shepherd, Jack. 'What's in a Name? An Examination of Current Definitions of Resource Churches'. *Journal of Anglican Studies* 22, no. 1 (2024): 81-97. <https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/journal-of-anglican-studies/article/whats-in-a-name-an-examination-of-current-definitions-of-resource-churches/2119B46236D6917266F4627AE7EB41D0>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Thorpe, Ric, Mark Powley and Ryan Gilfeather. *Resourcing the Church? Resource Churches in the Church of England*. Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, Faith in the North and the Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/CCX_012_Resourcing-the-Church-A5-Booklet_Digital.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A briefing paper on the resource church model as it stood in 2025, covering its definition, history, evidence and theology. It reports congregational growth and engagement with young people, and raises questions about the narrow range of church traditions among resource churches. Written to inform strategic planning and further theological reflection rather than to settle the argument.

Thorpe, Ric. 'Now is the Time to Plant'. Address to Multiply 2021. Video, 11 min. St Hild Centre for Church Planting, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0njy9JrFBnA>.

ALSO IN Anglican

A conference address of 11 minutes, given at Multiply in 2021 during Thorpe's years as Bishop of Islington and posted to the St Hild Centre's channel three years later: a statement of the case for planting rather than a source to cite.

Thorpe, Ric. *How to Plant a Church: A Guide to Planting and Leading Healthy New Worshipping Communities*. London: CCX, 2024.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Anglican

A guide for anyone starting a new worshipping community, adapted from the Plant course and written while Thorpe was Bishop of Islington, with a Church of England-wide brief for planting. It runs from vision and resources to leading a team and launching and multiplying a plant. Stephen Skuce, reviewing it for the Methodist Church in Ireland, reads it as one Anglican model, in which a resource church sends members, staff and a budget to a plant, but finds its principles broadly transferable.

Thorpe, Ric. *Resource Churches: A Story of Church Planting and Revitalisation Across the Nation*. London: CCX, 2021.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

THE EVIDENCE

All of it comes from a body or a person with a stake in the model.

Foulger, Will. *New Things: A Theological Investigation into the Work of Starting New Churches across 11 Dioceses in the Church of England*. Durham: Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research, 2024. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+New+Things+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Church Planting Strategy

A report built on interviews with a representative of each of 11 dioceses, with their strategy documents and funding bids, on what the Church of England has been starting and what it calls it. Around 900 new things across the 11, 89 per cent of them inside the parish system rather than standing alone, and 40 of them newly designated resource churches. None of the 11 dioceses used the language of 'church plant'. Foulger reads the descriptors as an ecclesiology already shaping practice, and calls the starting of new things essentially an evangelically driven project.

Listening to the Voice of the Resource Church Leaders: Offering a Framework for Action. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2024. <https://ccx.org.uk/content/voice-resource-church-leader/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A report commissioned by CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, with research by Alanna Harris and Wendy Brooks, drawing on interviews with 25 leaders of resource churches. It describes what they carry, the breadth of accountability in a senior role, leading amid ambiguity, scaling and transitions, the relationships that sustain them and their standing with bishop and diocese, and closes with a framework for action offered to dioceses and leaders together. Where Foulger's *New Things* surveys dioceses, this hears the leaders themselves. CCX's page carries only a summary; the report was not published for download.

Taylor, Martyn. *Market Town Resource Churches: Developing Strategies for Mission*. Mission and Evangelism 153. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns

A Grove booklet arguing that a town church can serve as a regional base for the villages around it, drawn from scripture, local history, parish experience and Taylor's Asbury doctorate. The difference from a city, on his account, is the ripples a market town sends out to its villages, and the practical difficulty is resourcing them without appearing to threaten them. Taylor has been rector of St George's, Stamford, since 2003.

Thorlby, Tim. 'City Centre Resource Churches'. Church Growth Research and Development, February 2015. http://www.churchgrowthrd.org.uk/blog/sharedinsight/city_centre_resource_churches.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A short piece of February 2015 on city-centre resource churches, written for the Church Growth Research and Development blog by Tim Thorlby, who went on to write *Love, Sweat and Tears* (2016), a study of five churches planted in east London through the Holy Trinity Brompton network.

Thorpe, Ric, Mark Powley and Ryan Gilfeather. *Resourcing the Church? Resource Churches in the Church of England*. Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, Faith in the North and the Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/CCX_012_Resourcing-the-Church-A5-Booklet_Digital.pdf.

ANNOTATED under What a Resource Church Is

Multi-site Church

See also the list on Resource Churches.

A multi-site church is one church meeting in several places under one leadership, one budget and one board: one church in many locations, in the subtitle of Surratt, Ligon and Bird's book. It is an American model in origin. The practical division within it is between sites where the sermon arrives on a screen and sites with a preacher of their own, and beyond that there is no agreed classification.

The principal argument is ecclesiological. The objection is that a church is an assembly that actually gathers and exercises authority together, so that a body which never assembles as one is not a church but several congregations under one name. Andy Paterson makes a qualified form of it in Britain, allowing the model a use for a time. The model's own account locates the church's unity in that shared leadership, budget and board.

The boundary with a resource church lies in what the second place becomes. A resource church multiplies churches, each of which becomes an entity in its own right; a multi-site church multiplies congregations and keeps them inside one church.

This reading list runs from Start Here to Choosing Multiplication, which holds two accounts of choosing many smaller congregations over one large one.

START HERE

Paterson, Andy. 'Multi-Site Church'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 61-75. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-4-multi-site-church/>.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; New Churches and Networks

An article asking of one structure, multi-site church, whether it is an end in itself, a dangerous distortion or a pragmatic tool, written while Paterson was mission director of the Fellowship of Independent Evangelical Churches. He allows it a use in planting and in reviving dying congregations, but argues that *ekklesia* means a literal assembly in one place, and that a site whose leader is not its preacher separates leading from preaching. A site, he concludes, must in time be freed 'to become a fully autonomous, self-governing church in its own right'.

Surratt, Geoff, Greg Ligon and Warren Bird. *The Multi-Site Church Revolution: Being One Church in Many Locations*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2006.

An early treatment of one church meeting in several locations, in 15 chapters covering casting the vision, carrying a church's culture to a new site, developing leaders, funding, and the technology of shared worship. Warren Bird, one of the three authors, was Leadership Network's director of research, and a sequel, *A Multi-Site Church Roadtrip*, followed in 2009.

CHOOSING MULTIPLICATION

Baron, Colin, Tom O'Toole and Tim Simmonds. *Multiplanting: A Vision for Growing Churches, Leaders and Mission*. Malcolm Down Publishing, 2019.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

Twenty-five years in Manchester behind a single argument: plant smaller interconnected congregations across a city, operating as one church — together strong enough to survive, dispersed enough to reach what one large church never could. Directly useful to anyone weighing multi-site against multiplication.

Galanos, Chris. *From Megachurch to Multiplication: A Church's Journey Toward Movement*. Experience Life, 2018.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting

Galanos asked 12 people to join him in reaching 10,000 people in 10 years, and passed the mark in year eight, then concluded that the megachurch he had built was the wrong goal and turned it towards multiplication. The interest is in the turn: a pastor dismantling his own success in public. Published by the church itself, Experience Life in Lubbock, Texas.

Digital and Hybrid Church

See also the lists on Innovation and Creativity, and on Fresh Expressions of Church.

Hybrid church, in Peter Phillips's definition, is a Christian community that meets both onsite and online, either for everything or for distinct parts of its ministry. Online church, at one end of the range, meets only online. The three books in this reading list were all written during the pandemic or after it.

The dispute is ecclesiological, and it turns on the sacraments and the body: whether a congregation that never gathers bodily is a church, and whether communion can be celebrated or received through a screen. Drew McIntyre states the objection: 'To incarnate the sacrament, even with the best of intentions, is to go against the grain of the gospel narratives.' The Church of England's bishops considered the question in January 2021, during a national pandemic, affirmed that it would be premature to make decisions on the Eucharist in a digital medium, and resolved on further theological and liturgical study.

Church in virtual reality presses the same questions further. Churches have met in virtual worlds since 2017, and when one of the platforms closed in 2023 more than twenty of them lost the place where they met.

This reading list runs from Start Here to Church in Virtual Reality.

START HERE

Phillips, Peter. *Hybrid Church: Blending Online and Offline Community*. Mission and Evangelism 131. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2020.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A Grove booklet written during the 2020 lockdown, setting out what hybrid church is and giving three case studies of practitioners who found hybrid ways of working in the pandemic. It began, Phillips says, when he asked some digital friends to share their thoughts. He had founded Durham's Centre for Digital Theology.

White, James Emery. *Hybrid Church: Rethinking the Church for a Post-Christian Digital Age*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Reflective, 2023.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A book arguing that the pandemic's acceleration of cultural change calls for a permanent shift rather than a return to earlier ways: a church must bring together the physical and the digital, and be a community of faith for churchgoers and a church for the unchurched at once. Written after attendance failed to recover on reopening, from Mecklenburg Community Church in Charlotte, North Carolina, which White founded and leads. It shares its title with Phillips's much shorter Grove booklet.

CHURCH IN VIRTUAL REALITY

Bock, Darrell L., and Jonathan J. Armstrong. *Virtual Reality Church: Pitfalls and Possibilities (Or How to Think Biblically about Church in Your Pajamas, VR Baptisms, Jesus Avatars, and Whatever Else Is Coming Next)*. Chicago, IL: Moody Publishers, 2021.

A theological treatment of church in virtual reality by a New Testament scholar and a church historian, published a year before Reed's *VR and the Metaverse Church*. Where Reed makes a practitioner's case for virtual reality as a mission field, Bock and Armstrong weigh its pitfalls as well as its possibilities, taking up questions such as baptism in VR and what an avatar is, and would suit a reader who wants the theological questions set out before the practice.

Reed, Jeff. *VR and the Metaverse Church: How God Is Moving in This Virtual, Yet Quite Real, Reality*. Leadership Network, 2022.

A book celebrating the churches that meet in virtual reality and the pioneers who lead them, by the founder of theChurch.digital, who directs Leadership Network's work on the metaverse church. Its description calls virtual reality a new mission field. Bock and Armstrong's *Virtual Reality Church*, published a year earlier, weighs the risks as well as the opportunities.

Revitalisation and Replanting

See also the lists on Resource Churches, and on Church Growth.

Revitalisation is the renewal of an existing congregation, usually one in decline. The literature describes four ways of attempting it: renewal from within, under the existing leadership or a new pastor; the replant, in which a dying congregation hands its building and assets to a new church; the graft, in which another church sends leaders, people and resources into it; and the merger. Most of it is American, and much of it assumes a polity in which a congregation decides its own future and can vote to merge or to give its building away. An English parish cannot, and in the Church of England the same ground is covered by grafts, by bishop's mission orders and by the resource church.

The principal division is between renewal from within and renewal from outside. Writers on the first, most of them Baptist pastors, such as Davis and Henard, rest revival on preaching, the pastor's character and the Spirit's work more than on any method. Writers on the second, such as DeVine and Tomberlin, treat a dying church's building and people as assets for a new work. The literature argues mostly from cases, often the authors' own churches.

This reading list runs from Start Here to Renewal from Within, then Renewal from Outside.

START HERE

Clifton, Mark. *Reclaiming Glory: Revitalizing Dying Churches*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2016.

ALSO IN Baptist; Practical Guides

A book arguing that a dying congregation should be revitalised or replanted rather than abandoned, since a dying church does not glorify God, written from the North American Mission Board's work of replanting. It joins that conviction to practical strategy, for pastors weighing whether to lead a struggling church. An updated edition, subtitled *Creating a Gospel Legacy throughout North America* (2023), adds further experiences and strategies.

Mallon, James. *Divine Renovation: Bringing Your Parish from Maintenance to Mission*. New London, CT: Twenty-Third Publications, 2014.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Church Growth; Parish Church; Theory of Change

A book by a Catholic parish priest in Halifax, Nova Scotia, drawn from the renewal he led in his own parish. It argues that a parish moves from maintenance to mission when it stops being a membership-based community and becomes an assembly of disciples who proclaim and share the good news.

Warren, Robert. *The Healthy Churches' Handbook: A Process for Revitalizing Your Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Anglican; Practical Guides; Parish Church

A handbook setting out seven marks of a healthy church, each a contrast, such as energised by faith rather than just keeping things going, with a process by which a congregation reviews itself against them, from a detailed review to a single evening. It treats health in qualitative terms rather than as numerical growth. The Diocese of Southwark uses the marks to frame visits to every parish by its bishops and archdeacons. The chapter 'The angel of the church' concerns a congregation's character, buildings, setting and story.

RENEWAL FROM WITHIN

Croft, Brian. *Biblical Church Revitalization: Solutions for Dying and Divided Churches*. Practical Shepherding. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2016.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book on bringing dying and divided churches back to life, in the Practical Shepherding series, written while Croft was pastor of a Baptist church in Louisville, Kentucky. In an article for Southern Equip (10 March 2016), Croft makes the church's health rather than its numbers the goal of revitalisation, and sets a biblical approach against both the pragmatist's 'clever gimmicks and appealing programs' and the purist's legalism.

Davis, Andrew M. *Revitalize: Biblical Keys to Helping Your Church Come Alive Again*. 9Marks. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2017.

A 9Marks book written out of the nearly 20 years Davis had then spent as pastor of First Baptist Church, Durham, North Carolina, which he joined in 1998. From the fourth chapter on, most of its chapter titles name a quality asked of the person leading the work, such as humility or patience, rather than a step in the process.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *Scattered Not Small: Empowering Ordinary Churches to Become Disciple-Making Communities*. Firestarters Network Resources, 2024.

ALSO IN Baptist; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Practical Guides

The sequel to *On This Rock*: a guide to moving a church from a traditional model to a scattered, decentralised one, and to starting a church that way. Remsberg is minister of Beacon Church, Stafford, and the authors draw on practitioners in other churches. It takes up the questions leaders raised with them, among them who provides leadership and what the minister's job becomes, with a discussion section in each chapter.

Henard, Bill. *Can These Bones Live? A Practical Guide to Church Revitalization*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2015.

ALSO IN Baptist; Practical Guides

A guide for plateaued or declining churches, by a Southern Baptist pastor. It works through 11 causes of decline, diagnosing each and giving a process for addressing it, and closes with a 'Change Matrix' for implementation. Henard holds that revitalisation rests on preaching and the work of the Spirit rather than on method, and expects it to take seven to 10 years.

Henard, Bill. *ReClaimed Church: How Churches Grow, Decline, and Experience Revitalization*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2018.

ALSO IN Baptist; Church Growth

A book that treats a congregation's growth, plateau and decline as stages of one life cycle, from birth to death, and sets out a process by which a church can return to growth: reassess, rethink, realign and reaffirm. Its third part, on the factors that determine growth or decline, bears most directly on growth; the fourth, on steps towards revitalisation, on a church already in decline. Written, in the publisher's description, for struggling churches.

McKinley, Mike. *Church Planting Is for Wimps: How God Uses Messed-Up People to Plant Ordinary Churches That Do Extraordinary Things*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

ALSO IN Baptist; Practical Guides

An account of the revitalisation of Guilford Baptist Church in northern Virginia, a dying congregation, told under a planting title in the 9Marks series. McKinley argues that a pastor's faithful preaching, evangelism and training of leaders matter more than the size of his church, and is candid about his own fears and early mistakes. Written for pastors and seminarians weighing a plant and for those struggling in a young congregation; the chapter 'How to Ruin Everything' concerns ego, pride, fear and strain on marriage and family.

RENEWAL FROM OUTSIDE

DeVine, Mark, and Darrin Patrick. *Replant: How a Dying Church Can Grow Again*. Colorado Springs, CO: David C Cook, 2014.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A book telling, as narrative rather than as principles, how First Calvary Baptist Church in Kansas City, a dying congregation, handed its ministry and assets to The Journey in St Louis, which planted Redeemer Fellowship there. DeVine, a seminary professor, narrates most of it, with shorter contributions from Patrick, The Journey's founding pastor. An appendix takes up the theological meaning of church buildings and the dangers of open business meetings.

Thorpe, Ric. *Resource Churches: A Story of Church Planting and Revitalisation Across the Nation*. London: CCX, 2021.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Anglican; Church Planting Strategy

The account of the resource church strategy from inside it, by the bishop who held the Church of England's national brief for planting when it was written. Biblical, theological and historical roots first, then the practicalities of launching and growing one, with stories from planters and a reflection from each of their bishops. Its definition, as Shepherd reports it, turns on a bishop's authorisation, a place in diocesan strategy, resourcing to plant and revitalise, a leadership pipeline, and resourcing for wider mission. Thorpe intends it to apply beyond Anglicanism.

Tomberlin, Jim, and Warren Bird. *Better Together: Making Church Mergers Work*. Expanded and updated ed. Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A treatment of church mergers, first published in 2012, that distinguishes the kinds (rebirth, adoption, marriage and intensive care) rather than treating merger as one thing. The expanded edition of 2020, cited here, adds church planting, multiplication and multisite.

Alpha Course and Church Planting

Alpha is a short course introducing the Christian faith. It began at Holy Trinity Brompton in London in the late 1970s, was developed there from 1990 under Nicky Gumbel, spread across Britain in the early 1990s and then abroad. By Alpha's own count, 2.8 million people in 158 countries took part in 2025.

This reading list is about a narrower use of it than running it as one course among a church's activities: Alpha as the means of starting a church, or of remaking one. The connection with planting runs through Holy Trinity Brompton itself, which is both Alpha's home and the centre of a network of church plants, and through people formed there. Miles Toulmin served seven years as an associate vicar at Holy Trinity Brompton before moving to Kuala Lumpur in 2014 to plant Holy Trinity Bukit Bintang. In a Roman Catholic parish in Nova Scotia the same course has been made the centre of a programme of renewal rather than of planting, under its priest, James Mallon.

One critic's objection, that the course may produce consumers of Christianity rather than disciples, bears most directly on this use.

This reading list runs from Start Here to From the Practitioners.

START HERE

Huntley, Ron, and James Mallon. *Unlocking Your Parish: Making Disciples, Raising Up Leaders with Alpha*. Frederick, MD: The Word Among Us Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Parish Church; Practical Guides

A book on Alpha as the means of renewing a Catholic parish, drawn from Saint Benedict Parish in Halifax, Nova Scotia, where Huntley served on the senior leadership team alongside Mallon. A practical outworking of Mallon's *Divine Renovation*, it argues that evangelisation shapes the whole culture of a parish, from outreach to sacramental life, and takes up the logistical questions that arise after a first or second course. Written for parishes considering Alpha as well as those already running it.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *Alpha as a Church Planting Tool*. London: Alpha International, 2017. <https://cselvaratnam.github.io/assets/documents/alpha-as-church-planting-tool.pdf>.

A short, simple booklet on the relationship between church planting and the Alpha course, by Christian Selvaratnam, who was national director of Alpha UK. Three short case studies are included.

FROM THE PRACTITIONERS

Toulmin, Miles. *Church Planting and Alpha*. Video, 2017. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W8F3ECDCfbw>.

One of two videos by Miles Toulmin, director of Alpha Asia Pacific and vicar of Holy Trinity Bukit Bintang (HTBB), a Holy Trinity Brompton plant in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia. This is the full-length talk; *The Positives of Alpha as a Planting Tool* is a section taken from it.

Toulmin, Miles. *The Positives of Alpha as a Planting Tool*. Video, 2017. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o2BRV7WADNg>.

One of two videos by Miles Toulmin, director of Alpha Asia Pacific and vicar of Holy Trinity Bukit Bintang (HTBB), a Holy Trinity Brompton plant in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia. This is a section taken from his full-length talk, *Church Planting and Alpha*.

Church Traditions

Anglican

See also the lists on Anglo-Catholic, Parish Church, Resource Churches, Fresh Expressions of Church, Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy, Church of England Papers and Reports, and Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension.

The planting of new congregations in the Church of England, which in its own words has existed in parishes, 'local geographical units with a parish church', grouped into dioceses 'each headed by a bishop'. One book in this list takes in the wider Anglican Communion.

This list holds what is particular to planting as an Anglican: how a new congregation stands to the parish it meets in, who may preside at its eucharist, what research on the Church's new congregations has found and what its planting has looked like in practice. Several books here are not about planting; they set out the Anglican identity, evangelism and congregational life that a plant inherits.

In 1991 the House of Bishops appointed a working party on planting, whose report, *Breaking New Ground*, appeared in 1994; in 2018 the House set out principles for planting in a statement of its own.

The principal question is whether planting belongs to the Anglican way of being church or cuts against it. Paul Dunthorne argued in 1997 that Anglican missiology has always been committed both to evangelism and to 'the establishment of the church as its end result', and that planting therefore has its place beside the parish system. Alison Milbank challenges, in defence of the parish, the ecclesiology behind the Church of England's recent strategies. Between them, Will Foulger finds that those who object to new churches pass too smoothly from a principle, presence in place, to one practice of it, the parish system.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Anglican Identity and Ecclesiology, Research and Reports, and Practice and Precedent.

START HERE

Foulger, Will, and Joshua Cockayne, eds. *New Churches: A Theology*. London: SCM Press, 2024.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesiology; Ecclesial Minimum

An edited collection of theological essays on starting new churches, written from the British scene by contributors from evangelical and Anglo-Catholic traditions alike. In its first part, on new churches and the *missio Dei*, Mark Collinson asks whether church planters believe in the *missio Dei* at all, Joshua Cockayne writes on community and the Triune God, and Beth Honey sets out an ethics of planting in conversation with Aquinas. Christian Selvaratnam's chapter, on planting as a craft learned by apprenticeship, is listed under Formation and Training.

House of Bishops of the Church of England. *Church Planting and the Mission of the Church: A Statement by the House of Bishops*. HB(18)05. London: Church of England, 2018.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Ecclesial Minimum

An important paper from the Church of England's House of Bishops in 2018, expressing support for church planting, and laying out the broad principles of how it should be done within an Anglican context.

Thorpe, Ric. *How to Plant a Church: A Guide to Planting and Leading Healthy New Worshipping Communities*. London: CCX, 2024.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Resource Churches

A guide for anyone starting a new worshipping community, adapted from the Plant course and written while Thorpe was Bishop of Islington, with a Church of England-wide brief for planting. It runs from vision and resources to leading a team and launching and multiplying a plant. Stephen Skuce, reviewing it for the Methodist Church in Ireland, reads it as one Anglican model, in which a resource church sends members, staff and a budget to a plant, but finds its principles broadly transferable.

ANGLICAN IDENTITY AND ECCLESIOLOGY

Avis, Paul. *The Identity of Anglicanism: Essentials of Anglican Ecclesiology*. London: T&T Clark, 2008.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book on Anglican identity, which Avis locates in Anglicanism's understanding of the church and of authority, set out as both catholic and reformed. It treats the origins of Anglican ecclesiology, the diversity and coherence of the Anglican Communion, baptism and the Eucharist, the ordination of women, ecumenical engagement, and the conflicts within the Communion in the early 21st century.

Cockayne, Joshua. *The Communion Dilemma: The Challenges of Leading Eucharistic New Things*. Durham: Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Communion+Dilemma+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Ecclesiology; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments; Ecclesial Minimum

A report surveying the leaders of 63 new communities in 20 Church of England dioceses, and by its own account the only current data on their eucharistic practice. Cockayne sets out three responses — not celebrating, celebrating with authorised liturgy and an ordained president, or celebrating without authorisation — and concludes that 'the communion dilemma is a loser's game', urging that liturgical reform be joined to the Church's aim of 10,000 new worshipping communities. Only nine of the 63 never celebrated communion.

Dunthorne, Paul. 'The Priority of the Gospel: Church Planting in the Church of England Examined in the Light of Anglican Tradition and the Ministry of the Apostle Paul'. MA dissertation, Durham University, 1997. <https://etheses.durham.ac.uk/4771/>.

An MA dissertation at Durham, written three years after *Breaking New Ground*, when planting was, in Dunthorne's words, 'a significant feature of the modern Church of England' that had 'received little theological and historical analysis'. He examines it in the light of Anglican history, at home and overseas, and of Paul's ministry. Anglican history, he suggests, gives the lead in evangelism to local, voluntary initiative, and a weakening consensus on doctrine adds to the pressure on the parish system; he concludes that planting meets 'the need for a flexible accompaniment to the parish system'.

Foulger, Will, and Joshua Cockayne, eds. *New Churches: A Theology*. London: SCM Press, 2024.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Foulger, Will. *Present in Every Place? The Church of England's New Churches, and the Future of the Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Ecclesial Minimum

A study of whether the parish system still delivers what its defenders want from it. Foulger separates the instinct that draws people to the parish, rootedness and presence in a place, from the practice that has carried it, and argues that critics of new churches assume too smooth a move from the one to the other. Drawing on the idea of place as bounded openness, he concludes that presence in place calls for complexity of church form rather than uniform coverage. Developed from his Durham thesis of 2018.

Hilborn, David, and Simo Frestadius, eds. *Anglicans and Pentecostals in Dialogue*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2023.

ALSO IN Pentecostal; Ecclesiology

An edited volume in which Anglican and Pentecostal writers take the same subjects in paired chapters: first each tradition's approach to ecumenism, then sacraments, ministry, ecclesiology, pneumatology and mission, with accounts of ecumenical work at local, national and international level, mostly in Britain. Hilborn's own chapter compares the two traditions on ordination, and Ric Thorpe's, on Anglicans, church growth and church planting, sits in the section on mission and church growth. Amy White (*The Melbourne Anglican*, 2024) finds that some chapters recount their own tradition's history without engaging the other.

Milbank, Alison. *The Once and Future Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Resource Churches; Fresh Expressions of Church

Milbank returns to the ground of *For the Parish*, to which this is an explicit sequel, and takes on what has happened since: minster hubs, the Strategic Development Fund and the Emerging Church programme. Her quarrel is on three fronts — ecclesiology, the account of the person these assume, and their reading of secularism.

Olsworth-Peter, Ed. *Mixed Ecology: Inhabiting an Integrated Church*. London: SPCK, 2024.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

The book of the policy: what it means for parishes, fresh expressions, plants and pioneer ministries to be one church rather than parallel systems, after the Archbishop of York made mixed ecology one of the Church of England's three priorities in November 2021. Olsworth-Peter was the Church of England's national adviser for pioneer development and by publication had moved to St Mellitus as director of innovation and development. He takes the argument to gathered, digital and hybrid forms together.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Charts'. In *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism: Currents, Contours, Charts*, 25–38. Abingdon: Routledge, 2017.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesiology

The opening chapter of Martyn Percy's book *The Future Shapes of Anglicanism* (2017), which sets the question of growth and management first in an account of where Anglicanism is heading. The chapter takes its title and subject from his 2014 article in *Modern Believing*, 'Some Comments' becoming 'Some Charts', and stands beside it as the later setting of the same question, within a book-length argument rather than a journal's comment.

Percy, Martyn. 'Growth and Management in the Church of England: Some Comments'. *Modern Believing* 55, no. 3 (2014): 257–70.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesiology

A short article in *Modern Believing* commenting on growth and management in the Church of England, by an Anglican theologian. Percy's writing before and after it, in 2013 against treating the church as an organisation that must grow to survive and in 2021 against a proposal for 10,000 new lay-led churches, places him among the critics of the church growth school.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *Exploring the Mixed Ecology: How Different Churches Belong Together*. Church Multiplication 3. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Ecclesiology; Ecclesial Minimum

A booklet exploring the biblical and theological underpinnings of 'mixed ecology', the term the Church of England adopted in 2021 for established congregations and newer forms of church held together in one body, and tracing how it grew from the 'mixed economy' of *Mission-shaped Church* (2004). It reads the idea through the body of Christ in 1 Corinthians 12 and the household of God, and sets out the challenges an ecological ecclesiology raises for those who lead within it. Selvaratnam was on the working group that wrote the Church of England's Vision and Strategy for the 2020s, which adopted the term.

Shepherd, Jack. 'A Critical Realist Account of the Theological Values of Resource Churches in the Church of England'. PhD thesis, University of Manchester, 2026. <https://research.manchester.ac.uk/en/studentTheses/a-critical-realist-account-of-the-theological-values-of-resource-/>.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets

Interviews at three resource churches with distinctive models, and six wider perspectives, read through a critical realist frame. Shepherd traces three theological lineages behind the form, a Pentecostal ecclesiology owing to Roland Allen, a pneumatological church growth owing to Wimber and Padilla, and a pneumatological missiology owing to Wright and Donovan, and finds no shared or normative understanding of liturgical tradition among them. In place of a definition by criteria he proposes a centred set of five values: centres of spirituality, processes of evangelism, contextual revitalisation, inaugurated eschatology and narrative testimony.

Valentine, John. *Is Church Planting Legitimate? Some Theological Reflections*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2022.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesiology

A paper of 43 pages written for CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, in February 2022 and posted on its site that August. Valentine sets out the scale of planting in Britain and the objections it has drawn, that it is schismatic, exclusively evangelical, un-Anglican or without an ecclesiology, and answers them from the biblical linking of church and mission, Bosch's 'church-in-mission' and a plea for provisionality on both sides. He argues for an ecclesiology that is fully missiological and a missiology that is fully ecclesial, open to essentialist and functionalist accounts of the church alike. His *Jesus, the Church and the Mission of God* develops the argument at book length.

Wallace, John Charles. 'Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: An Exploration in Practical Theology'. DThM thesis, Durham University, 2021. <https://etheses.durham.ac.uk/id/eprint/14378/>.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

The doctoral thesis behind the book, for readers who want the working rather than the conclusions: the six themes drawn from the fieldwork, and a literature chapter on the criticism of *Mission-Shaped Church* and the replies to it. A doctorate in theology and ministry, submitted at Durham in 2021.

Wallace, John. *Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: Can It Work?* Durham: Sacristy Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

The book of Wallace's Durham thesis: 18 months of monthly visits to three Anglo-Catholic church plants, set beside how Victorian Anglo-Catholics started new churches, among them Richard Temple West, who founded St Mary Magdalene, Paddington. Steve Rice, reviewing it in *The Living Church*, credits the fair historical summary and the choice of little-known subjects, but finds the brevity leaves the history's nuances unexplored and the modern case studies short of answering the book's own question.

RESEARCH AND REPORTS

Church Army's Research Unit. *Church Growth Research Project: Report on Strand 3b, An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church and Church Plants Begun in the Period 1992–2012*. Sheffield: Church Army, 2013. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/church_growth_research_fresh_expressions_-_strand_3b_oct13_-_the_report.pdf.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Fresh Expressions of Church

A report from the fresh expressions strand, Strand 3b, of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme, conducted by Church Army's Research Unit under George Lings within the consortium led by Cranmer Hall, Durham, and dated October 2013. It analyses fresh expressions of Church and church plants begun between 1992 and 2012. It precedes Lings's larger survey of 21 dioceses, *The Day of Small Things* (2016), and sits beside Dadswell and Ross's companion strand on church planting, Strand 4.

Cockayne, Joshua. *The Communion Dilemma: The Challenges of Leading Eucharistic New Things*. Durham: Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Communion+Dilemma+Final.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Anglican Identity and Ecclesiology

Dadswell, David, and Cathy Ross. *Church Growth Research Project: Church Planting*. Cuddesdon: Oxford Centre for Ecclesiology and Practical Theology, Ripon College Cuddesdon, 2013. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/cgrp_church_planting_from_cgrd_website.pdf.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Growth

A report from the church-planting strand of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme, written by David Dadswell and Cathy Ross of the Oxford Centre for Ecclesiology and Practical Theology at Ripon College Cuddesdon and dated November 2013. A qualitative study built on visits to plants, it describes the models then current, from Holy Trinity Brompton and minster plants to network, cell and Anglo-Catholic ones, and reports on buildings, dioceses, leadership, finance and growth, opening with 20 recommendations. It found leaders reluctant to measure growth by numbers and little record of where growth came from, and called for a longitudinal study. It precedes the programme's summary report, *From Anecdote to Evidence*, by a year.

Foulger, Will, ed. *Shaping Place: Reflections on 4 SDF Projects in Durham Diocese*. Durham: Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research, 2023. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Final+Shaping+Place+Booklet.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report from the Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research on four churches in Durham Diocese funded through the Church of England's Strategic Development Funding: St Paul's Stockton, Vine Church Wynyard, Oxclose Church and Hope For All in Pennywell. A four-person team spent November 2021 to June 2022 with one church each, attending services and activities and interviewing clergy and members. Each church has an account of its context and then of the theological themes that emerged, which the team presents as reflecting the questions it brought rather than as neutral findings. Close description of four churches, not conclusions that generalise.

Foulger, Will. *New Things: A Theological Investigation into the Work of Starting New Churches across 11 Dioceses in the Church of England*. Durham: Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research, 2024. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+New+Things+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Resource Churches; Church Planting Strategy

A report built on interviews with a representative of each of 11 dioceses, with their strategy documents and funding bids, on what the Church of England has been starting and what it calls it. Around 900 new things across the 11, 89 per cent of them inside the parish system rather than standing alone, and 40 of them newly designated resource churches. None of the 11 dioceses used the language of 'church plant'. Foulger reads the descriptors as an ecclesiology already shaping practice, and calls the starting of new things essentially an evangelically driven project.

Gaze, Sally. *Listening to the Voice of Rural Church Planters and Pioneers: A Report on What Helps Rural Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/07/Listening-to-the-Voice-of-Rural-Church-Planters-and-Pioneers-report.pdf>.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report for CCX, with Rural Missions and Rural Ministries, on starting churches in rural England, led by Sally Gaze and drawn from 36 practitioners, 18 of them interviewed: 12 from the Church of England and six from free churches. It finds rural plants relational and small by choice, often with more young people than the churches around them, and asks overseers for trust rather than control and for funding matched to small and scattered places. Gaze's theological reflection answers the view that planting belongs where the population is dense.

Goodhew, David, ed. *Growth and Decline in the Anglican Communion: 1980 to the Present*. Routledge Contemporary Ecclesiology. Abingdon: Routledge, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

An edited volume from a five-year international research project based at Durham, testing the assumption that Western Anglican churches decline uniformly while non-Western ones grow. After an overview by Todd M. Johnson and Gina A. Zurlo, 12 case studies, among them Nigeria, India, Australia, the United States and England, show how differently one denomination behaves from place to place, even within a single region. Its frame is the worldwide Communion rather than Britain; the part on England bears most directly on British questions.

Jackson, Bob, and Bev Botting. *New in the North: New Worshipping Communities in the Province of York 2023*. Faith in the North, 2024. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/optimized_new_in_the_north_2023_.pdf.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Fresh Expressions of Church

A report on new worshipping communities across the northern province, drawing on the 2023 Statistics for Mission returns: 388 among 2,616 churches sampled, about one in seven, from which the authors extrapolate some 550 province-wide. It is unusually candid about what the data cannot bear — a 24 per cent attrition rate among fresh expressions, and likely under-reporting of those that have closed. Jackson is a church-growth writer and former archdeacon; Botting is a statistician.

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A survey of 1,109 fresh expressions in the Church of England, started between 1992 and 2014 in 21 dioceses and studied from 2012 to 2016 through interviews with their leaders. They make up on average 15 per cent of a diocese's church communities, with over 50,600 people attending, and four times as many were being started each year as in 2004. Section 2.6 sets the survey's indicators against the eight criteria of the 2012 Anglican-Methodist report, objecting that those criteria make practices rather than relationship determine what counts as a church; pages 43-44 set out whether attenders were churchd, de-churchd or non-churchd, each estimate of those new to church lower than the last.

Listening to the Voice of the Lay Planters. London: Myriad and CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2022. <https://ccx.org.uk/resource/listening-lay/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Formation and Training

A report from Myriad, the Church of England's lay church-planting initiative, with CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, the first of the 'Listening to the Voice' series, its research by Alice Bruce and Wendy Brooks. It draws on interviews in late 2021 with 20 lay people from 13 dioceses who had planted a church community, and sets out 10 insights and 10 recommendations, the chief being that no systematic pathway exists to prepare and equip lay planters, and that new ones are needed at the scale of the 10,000 new communities the church envisages. Beside the series' later reports on estates and rural planters and on pioneers, it is the account of the lay ones.

Listening to the Voice of the Pioneer. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2025. <https://ccx.org.uk/content/pioneer-research/>.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report from CCX, produced with the London Pioneer School and marking 20 years since *Mission-Shaped Church*, on what pioneers say of their own experience of the work. It sets out seven findings, with actions the wider Church might take in response.

Listening to the Voice of the Resource Church Leaders: Offering a Framework for Action. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2024. <https://ccx.org.uk/content/voice-resource-church-leader/>.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report commissioned by CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, with research by Alanna Harris and Wendy Brooks, drawing on interviews with 25 leaders of resource churches. It describes what they carry, the breadth of accountability in a senior role, leading amid ambiguity, scaling and transitions, the relationships that sustain them and their standing with bishop and diocese, and closes with a framework for action offered to dioceses and leaders together. Where Foulger's *New Things* surveys dioceses, this hears the leaders themselves. CCX's page carries only a summary; the report was not published for download.

Perrin, Ruth, and Ed Olsworth-Peter. *The Mixed Ecologists: Experiences of Mixed Ecology Ministry in the Church of England*. Living Ministry Focussed Study 2. London: Church of England Ministry Council, 2021. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2021-05/focussed-study-2-the-mixed-ecologists.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Church of England Papers and Reports

A Church of England research report from the Living Ministry programme, based on interviews with 17 parish clergy about combining pioneering initiatives with inherited or gathered forms of church within a single post. It names time, team and tenacity as what a flourishing mixed ecology needs, and follows this through five themed sections: the culture that enables it, how old and new forms interact, releasing leaders, clergy wellbeing, and the effect of the Covid-19 pandemic. Mixed ecology, it notes, is now the Church of England's stated norm rather than an exception.

Rogers, Cris. *Listening to the Voice of the Estates Planters: A Report on What Helps Estates Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/Listening-to-Estates-Planters-Report-final-1.pdf>.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Selecting and Assessing Planters; Formation and Training

A report for CCX, designed and led by Cris Rogers, a Church of England priest who spent 16 years planting and leading a church on a social housing estate. It draws on 45 practitioners, about a third of them from outside the Church of England, and on 450 working-class people asked about training. Its findings favour slow, incarnational models of planting, commitment measured in years and local leadership, and a section asks what success means on an estate. On selection it concludes that the Church's system 'rewards the qualities least needed on estates and undervalues the ones most needed'.

Shepherd, Jack. 'A Critical Realist Account of the Theological Values of Resource Churches in the Church of England'. PhD thesis, University of Manchester, 2026. <https://research.manchester.ac.uk/en/studentTheses/a-critical-realist-account-of-the-theological-values-of-resource-/>.

ANNOTATED under Anglican Identity and Ecclesiology

Shepherd, Jack. 'What's in a Name? An Examination of Current Definitions of Resource Churches'. *Journal of Anglican Studies* 22, no. 1 (2024): 81-97. <https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/journal-of-anglican-studies/article/whats-in-a-name-an-examination-of-current-definitions-of-resource-churches/2119B46236D6917266F4627AE7EB41D0>.

ALSO IN Resource Churches

Shepherd takes six definitions of 'resource church' in turn, from Mike Breen's of 1997 through *Mission-Shaped Church*, the Strategy and Development Unit's of 2017 and Ric Thorpe's of 2021, and separates the term from hub church, minster church, megachurch and 'resourcing church', with which it is regularly conflated. His verdict is that it remains a term in search of a precise meaning; Thorpe's is the best available but is tied to what current legislation allows. The first of three pieces on the term, and incorporated into his Manchester thesis.

PRACTICE AND PRECEDENT

Church of England Working Party on Church Planting. *Breaking New Ground: Church Planting in the Church of England*. London: Church House Publishing, 1994.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Ecclesial Minimum

A report on church planting from a working party the House of Bishops set up in 1991, and the document the Church of England's later official material answers to. *Mission-Shaped Church* of 2004 differs from it on strategy rather than on diagnosis.

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

Dunthorne, Paul. 'The Priority of the Gospel: Church Planting in the Church of England Examined in the Light of Anglican Tradition and the Ministry of the Apostle Paul'. MA dissertation, Durham University, 1997. <https://etheses.durham.ac.uk/4771/>.

ANNOTATED under Anglican Identity and Ecclesiology

House of Bishops of the Church of England. *Church Planting and the Mission of the Church: A Statement by the House of Bishops*. HB(18)05. London: Church of England, 2018.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Lings, George. 'The History of Fresh Expressions of Church and Church Planting in the Church of England'. In *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*, edited by David Goodhew, 161-78. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Fresh Expressions of Church; Introductions and Overviews

A chapter tracing church planting in the Church of England from the 1960s to fresh expressions of church, by the head of Church Army's research unit. Lings sets out six movements that prepared the ground, among them charismatic renewal and church growth theory, gives figures for plants by period, and presents fresh expressions as a new departure rather than a return to the daughter church.

Lockley, Philip. 'Church Planting and the Parish in Durham Diocese, 1970–1990: Church Growth Controversies in Recent Historical Perspective'. *Journal of Anglican Studies* 16, no. 2 (2018): 103–27.

ALSO IN Parish Church

A journal article recovering the Church of England's first modern church planting scheme: the restructuring of parish ministry in Chester-le-Street, near Durham, in the 1970s and 1980s, with its rapid growth, its decline and an evangelical church's strained relations with its liberal bishop, David Jenkins. Lockley reads the episode as bearing on today's disputes over fresh expressions and planting, and argues that liberals and conservatives in Anglican ecclesiology need to overcome their mistrust of each other. A historical case study rather than an argument from principle, it gives the parish debate a precedent from before *Breaking New Ground* (1994).

Matthews, Tim. *Love Church: Join the Adventure of Hope*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 2018.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A memoir of planting St Swithun's, Bournemouth, with a team from Holy Trinity Brompton in 2014, after repeated attempts in London had come to nothing. Matthews sets the setbacks and strain beside the growth, and argues that prayer and relationships count for more than strategy or budgets. A narrative rather than a method or a study, written for planters and for anyone concerned with the health of the church in the UK.

Orr-Ewing, Frog. 'Rev. Thomas Joseph Gaster: An Urban Missionary in Historical and Theological Context'. PhD thesis, King's College London, 2018. https://cte.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/01/Rev_Thomas_Joseph_Gaster_An_Urban_Missio.pdf.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Parish Church

A doctoral thesis on Victorian Anglican church planting in London, built round the ministry of Thomas Joseph Gaster and the founding of All Saints Peckham. Its argument is that Gaster drew on the models of mission he had worked with in India under the Church Missionary Society and reapplied them to the growing communities of late Victorian Britain, a fusion of parish and mission that Orr-Ewing calls the new parochialism and traces well beyond this one parish. Orr-Ewing was himself vicar of All Saints Peckham from 2003. The full text is given away by Churches Together in England.

Snow, Martyn, ed. *Anglican Evangelists: Identifying and Training a New Generation*. London: SPCK, 2019.

ALSO IN Evangelism; Formation and Training; Missiology

An edited collection by 13 contributors from different traditions in the Church of England, published for the twentieth anniversary of the Archbishops' College of Evangelists and its relaunch. It sets aside evangelistic method for the calling and gifts of the evangelist, asking what an evangelist is and how the church should recognise and train one, so that evangelists can equip all Christians for witness.

Snow, Martyn, with Lusa Nsenga-Ngoy, Saju Muthalaly, Jessie Tang, and Florence Gildea. *An Intercultural Church for a Multicultural World: Reflections on Gift Exchange*. London: Church House Publishing, 2024.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A short collection of theological reflections by a diocesan bishop, arising from the Diocese of Leicester's own Intercultural Worshipping Communities programme, with named contributions from four colleagues in its ministry team. It organises the case for a more diverse church around gift exchange — generous giving, radical receptivity and transformative thanksgiving — rather than around demographic argument alone. Unlike a general missiological treatment, it stays close to one diocese's own practice, drawing on Snow's ministry in the UK and West Africa; Saju Muthalaly's chapter on hospitality and Jessie Tang's closing afterword on intercultural ministry would be good starting points. Written for Church of England readers considering diversity in their own parishes.

Thorpe, Ric. 'Anglicans, Church Growth, and Church Planting'. In *Anglicans and Pentecostals in Dialogue*, edited by David Hilborn and Simo Freestadius, 236-54. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2023.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Church Planting Movements

A chapter in a volume of Anglican and Pentecostal dialogue, written by Ric Thorpe as Bishop of Islington and leader of the Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication. Its first part is a history of Anglican planting from Augustine's mission of 597, on the argument that almost every church was planted when it was first created; its last traces the three waves by which Pentecostalism reached Anglicanism, from Alexander Boddy at Sunderland to John Wimber's influence on the Anglican planting centres, and sets the parish system's stability against the Pentecostal freedom from ancient structures.

Thorpe, Ric. 'Now is the Time to Plant'. Address to Multiply 2021. Video, 11 min. St Hild Centre for Church Planting, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0njy9JrFBnA>.

ALSO IN Resource Churches

A conference address of 11 minutes, given at Multiply in 2021 during Thorpe's years as Bishop of Islington and posted to the St Hild Centre's channel three years later: a statement of the case for planting rather than a source to cite.

Thorpe, Ric. *How to Plant a Church: A Guide to Planting and Leading Healthy New Worshipping Communities*. London: CCX, 2024.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Thorpe, Ric. *Resource Churches: A Story of Church Planting and Revitalisation Across the Nation*. London: CCX, 2021.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Revitalisation and Replanting; Church Planting Strategy

The account of the resource church strategy from inside it, by the bishop who held the Church of England's national brief for planting when it was written. Biblical, theological and historical roots first, then the practicalities of launching and growing one, with stories from planters and a reflection from each of their bishops. Its definition, as Shepherd reports it, turns on a bishop's authorisation, a place in diocesan strategy, resourcing to plant and revitalise, a leadership pipeline, and resourcing for wider mission. Thorpe intends it to apply beyond Anglicanism.

Wallace, John. *Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: Can It Work?* Durham: Sacristy Press, 2023.

ANNOTATED under Anglican Identity and Ecclesiology

Warren, Robert. *Being Human, Being Church: Spirituality and Mission in the Local Church*. London: Marshall Pickering, 1995.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Missiology; Missional Spirituality

A book arguing that the inherited church's structure casts the congregation as clients of a provider and so keeps its members passive, and that a local church becomes missionary through its spirituality and shared life. Warren compares the emerging church he anticipates with the Celtic church of the past.

Warren, Robert. *Building Missionary Congregations: Towards a Post-Modern Way of Being Church*. Board of Mission Occasional Paper 4. London: Church House Publishing, 1995.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Church of England Papers and Reports; Missiology

A Board of Mission occasional paper by the Church of England's National Officer for Evangelism, on how the church could move from a pastoral to a missionary mode, arguing that this needs to be the main focus of the second half of the Decade of Evangelism. *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004) cites its account of church life as worship, community and mission, which Warren drew as three overlapping circles, and traces 'emerging church' to this paper and to his *Being Human, Being Church* (1995).

Warren, Robert. *The Healthy Churches' Handbook: A Process for Revitalizing Your Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Church Growth; Practical Guides; Parish Church

A handbook setting out seven marks of a healthy church, each a contrast, such as energised by faith rather than just keeping things going, with a process by which a congregation reviews itself against them, from a detailed review to a single evening. It treats health in qualitative terms rather than as numerical growth. The Diocese of Southwark uses the marks to frame visits to every parish by its bishops and archdeacons. The chapter 'The angel of the church' concerns a congregation's character, buildings, setting and story.

Anglo-Catholic

See also the list on Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments.

Church planting in the Catholic tradition of the Church of England, the tradition that descends from the Oxford Movement of the 1830s. John Wallace, beginning the doctoral research behind *Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: Can It Work?* (2023), was struck by how little work had been done on the subject, and his title states the question this list turns on.

The question arises from a tension Wallace's thesis describes, between the fresh expressions programme, of which planting is one part, and the historic parish. A study of the new things begun in eleven dioceses, published in 2024, calls their starting 'essentially an evangelically driven project'.

The case that planting can be Catholic is made here in two ways. The collection edited by Steven Croft, Ian Mobsby and Stephanie Spellers, *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition* (2010), argues through its contributors' stories and reflections that sacramental practice belongs to fresh expressions rather than standing in their way. The historical case rests on the Victorian Anglo-Catholics who founded new churches. The critique of fresh expressions made in defence of the parish is Andrew Davison and Alison Milbank's, and has its own list, *Parish Church*.

This reading list runs from Start Here through A Catholic Account of Mission to The Victorian Precedent.

START HERE

Wallace, John Charles. 'Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: An Exploration in Practical Theology'. DThM thesis, Durham University, 2021. <https://etheses.durham.ac.uk/id/eprint/14378/>.

ALSO IN Anglican; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

The doctoral thesis behind the book, for readers who want the working rather than the conclusions: the six themes drawn from the fieldwork, and a literature chapter on the criticism of *Mission-Shaped Church* and the replies to it. A doctorate in theology and ministry, submitted at Durham in 2021.

Wallace, John. *Anglo-Catholic Church Planting: Can It Work?* Durham: Sacristy Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

The book of Wallace's Durham thesis: 18 months of monthly visits to three Anglo-Catholic church plants, set beside how Victorian Anglo-Catholics started new churches, among them Richard Temple West, who founded St Mary Magdalene, Paddington. Steve Rice, reviewing it in *The Living Church*, credits the fair historical summary and the choice of little-known subjects, but finds the brevity leaves the history's nuances unexplored and the modern case studies short of answering the book's own question.

A CATHOLIC ACCOUNT OF MISSION

Cray, Graham, Ian Mobsby and Aaron Kennedy, eds. *Fresh Expressions of Church and the Kingdom of God*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

An edited volume arguing that the mission of a fresh expression is as much about social transformation — the kingdom — as about building the church. Contributors include Rowan Williams and Phyllis Tickle. The companion volume to *Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*, and one of four in the Ancient Faith, Future Mission series.

Croft, Steven, and Ian Mobsby, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2009. American edition, with Stephanie Spellers, New York: Seabury Books, 2010.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments; Ecclesial Minimum

An edited volume on what a mission-shaped church looks like when it is rooted in sacramental tradition rather than set against it, written by pioneers, leaders and theologians from Britain and the United States. Contributors include Rowan Williams, Brian McLaren, Stephen Cottrell, Richard Giles and Phyllis Tickle. The American edition of 2010 adds Stephanie Spellers as a third editor and a foreword by Katharine Jefferts Schori. In the argument over fresh expressions it takes the side opposite Davison and Milbank's *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions* (2010).

Davison, Andrew, Anna Matthews, Alison Milbank, Philip North, Gemma Simmonds, Ric Thorpe and Rowan Williams. *God's Church in the World: The Gift of Catholic Mission*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Missiology; Parish Church

A collection on Catholic mission and evangelism whose contributors include Alison Milbank, co-author with Andrew Davison of *For the Parish* (2010), a critique of fresh expressions, and Ric Thorpe, a leading figure in the Church of England's resource church strategy as Bishop of Islington. It brings writers from opposite sides of that church's argument over planting into one volume.

THE VICTORIAN PRECEDENT

Nockles, Peter B. 'The Oxford Movement as Religious Revival and Resurgence'. *Studies in Church History* 44 (2008): 214-24. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0424208400003600>.

A paper by Peter Nockles, of the John Rylands Library in Manchester, in the volume of *Studies in Church History* on revival and resurgence, treating the Oxford Movement as a religious revival, a category that, he notes, 'has tended to become synonymous with Evangelicalism'. It opens with a writer of 1912 who called the Catholic Revival 'one of the most wonderful revivals in church history'. Its question is how the movement should be classified, not how its churches were founded.

Stephens, W. R. W. *The Life and Letters of Walter Farquhar Hook*. 2 vols. London: Richard Bentley and Son, 1878.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

A two-volume Victorian biography of Walter Farquhar Hook, vicar of the single ancient parish of Leeds from 1837, who secured an Act of Parliament in 1844 to break it up, and under whom the schools of the town went from three to 30. Accounts of how many new parishes the Act made differ, from 14 to about 20. Stephens was Hook's son-in-law and wrote the standard *Dictionary of National Biography* entry on him as well, so the two Victorian accounts of Hook share an author. Narrative with the letters set into it, and a primary source rather than a study.

Baptist

See also the list on Anglican.

Books whose Baptist position, setting or institution shapes what they say: British Baptist practice, Southern Baptist denominational programmes, and Baptist ecclesiology. A book by a Baptist author is not filed here for that reason alone.

Baptist churches are congregational: in Baptist ecclesiology a church is a congregation of regenerate, baptised members who govern it together. Most of the ecclesiology filed here is not about planting; it sets out what a plant is to become.

The question it raises for planting is when a new congregation becomes a church. Jonathan Leeman, answering a Gospel Coalition survey in 2016, put it that 'a "planter" is a pastor, and a "plant", once a gathering serves the Supper, is a church.' Jack Redford's Southern Baptist guide of 1978 answers differently: the new congregation becomes a church only at the ninth and last step, when it is constituted. Much of the practical literature here comes from Southern Baptist bodies, on revitalising and replanting struggling congregations as well as planting new ones, as does the research on how prospective planters are assessed.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Baptist Ecclesiology, Planting and Replanting, where the practical literature is, and Assessing Baptist Planters.

Earls, Rod. *Spurgeon's Theology for Multiplying Disciples and Churches: The Story of How Spurgeon and the Metropolitan Tabernacle Followed Christ*. Foreword by Ed Stetzer. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2022.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

A study of the theology and practice through which Charles Spurgeon and his Metropolitan Tabernacle planted some 200 churches in and around London and trained nearly 900 ministers at his Pastors' College. It gives a 19th-century British Baptist precedent for multiplying churches from one congregation, with a foreword by Ed Stetzer, and is written for pastors and students of Spurgeon rather than as an academic history of the Tabernacle.

START HERE

Hammett, John S. *Biblical Foundations for Baptist Churches: A Contemporary Ecclesiology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Academic, 2005.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book of Baptist ecclesiology written for pastors, students and lay leaders, each chapter with study questions and suggestions for further reading. Hammett moves from the nature and marks of the church to regenerate church membership, which he argues is the distinguishing Baptist mark, then makes the case for congregational polity and treats elders, deacons, the ordinances and newer models of church. The second edition (2019) adds a chapter on church membership and revises the chapters on polity and on church models, among them multisite churches.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *On This Rock: Simple Lessons and Achievable Habits for Church Growth*. FirestartersUK, 2023.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Practical Guides; Missional Spirituality

A booklet setting out seven habits held in common by British Baptist churches seeing conversion growth, from small plants to larger established congregations, drawn from the Firestarters Network's conversations. Among them are intensity of prayer and fasting, and reorganising more often than you think. Each chapter grounds one habit in scripture, tells the story of a church that has practised it and closes with questions and next steps. Written for the leaders of existing churches to work through together.

BAPTIST ECCLESIOLOGY

Allison, Gregg R. *Sojourners and Strangers: The Doctrine of the Church*. Foundations of Evangelical Theology. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2012.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A six-part account of the church, written from a Reformed Baptist position, which moves from the church's identity and growth to its government, then its ordinances, then its ministries. Chapter 9, setting out Allison's model of church governance, includes an excursus on multisite churches. Glenn Kreider (DTS Voice, 2013) commends it as a textbook for ecclesiology courses, especially in the Free Church tradition, finding it charitable to other views and clear in defending its own.

Ashford, Bruce Riley, ed. *Theology and Practice of Mission: God, the Church, and the Nations*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2011.

ALSO IN Missiology; Introductions and Overviews

An edited volume setting out a biblical-theological framework for the church's mission to the nations, written by pastors, professors and missionaries and published by B&H Academic, the Southern Baptist imprint. It begins from God's mission, traced through creation, fall, redemption and restoration, and places church planting within the church's wider mission, beside preaching and witness in every area of culture. J. D. Payne's chapter in the second part, 'Mission and Church Planting', bears most directly on planting.

Dever, Mark, and Jonathan Leeman, eds. *Baptist Foundations: Church Government for an Anti-Institutional Age*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2015.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

An edited volume arguing that right polity for a church is congregational, with elders and deacons, regenerate membership, church discipline and a Baptist practice of the ordinances. Its 11 contributors, the editors among them, work through each historically, exegetically and theologically before applying it. Lifeway Research (2015) finds the chapters on membership, by John Hammett, useful even to pastors who reject that polity; Jonathan Leeman's closing chapters give a congregational account of unity, holiness and apostolicity, and of the independence and interdependence of churches.

Dever, Mark. *Nine Marks of a Healthy Church*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2000.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book proposing nine marks by which to judge a church's health rather than its size, expositional preaching the first of them. Tim Challies, expecting a polemic against the church growth movement, found instead a positive case for 'being church rather than doing church'. Dever's doctrinal account of the church is *The Church* (2012). The 2004 expanded edition keeps the nine; the fourth (2021) merges four of them into two and adds two, missions among them.

Dever, Mark. *The Church: The Gospel Made Visible*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2012.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A primer on the doctrine of the church for readers who hold Scripture alone a sufficient authority for its life, grown from Dever's chapter in *A Theology for the Church* (2007). It sets what the Bible says beside what the church has believed, and its last part moves from a Protestant through a gathered and a congregational ecclesiology to a Baptist one. Nathan Finn (2012) reads it as an introduction to Baptist ecclesiology and points readers who want fuller coverage to John Hammett and Gregg Allison.

Hammett, John S. *Biblical Foundations for Baptist Churches: A Contemporary Ecclesiology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel Academic, 2005.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Leeman, Jonathan. *Don't Fire Your Church Members: The Case for Congregationalism*. Nashville, TN: B&H Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

An argument for congregational government from the office of the ordinary member: Christ gives every member an office, with final responsibility for guarding 'the what and the who of the gospel', and elders are to equip members for it rather than sideline them. Where Leeman's *The Church and the Surprising Offense of God's Love* (2010) grounds membership and discipline in God's love, this book grounds the member's authority in that office. An appendix answers criticisms of congregationalism.

Leeman, Jonathan. *The Church and the Surprising Offense of God's Love: Reintroducing the Doctrines of Church Membership and Discipline*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A theological argument for church membership and discipline from the nature of God's love, which Leeman holds is holy and so draws boundaries: the church's careful exercise of authority guards the gospel and marks off a people. Tim Chester (9Marks, 2011) singles out the chapter on the nature of love, but finds that the practical chapters lean on membership lists and covenants rather than on baptism and the Lord's Supper as the markers of who belongs.

PLANTING AND REPLANTING

Brisco, Brad. *Covocational Church Planting: Aligning Your Marketplace Calling and the Mission of God*. Send Network, 2018. <https://www.sendnetwork.com/book/ebook-covocational-church-planting/>.

ALSO IN Bivocational and Covocational Ministry

A book for church planters whose primary vocation is in the marketplace, written for the Send Network of the Southern Baptist Convention's North American Mission Board, where Brisco works on strategy, and reissued by Missional Press in 2021. He distinguishes the bivocational planter, who takes a second job to supplement what the church pays, from the covocational planter, for whom work and planting are 'interlinked and equal' callings, and draws on missional theology for the practices of a planter rooted in a place, among them exeging the local culture and hospitality.

Clifton, Clint. *Church Planting Thresholds: A Gospel-Centered Guide*. Lulu Publishing Services, 2016.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A guide by a planter who worked for the Southern Baptist North American Mission Board, organised as a series of thresholds: milestones a plant is to cross in order. It covers ground from team leadership and personal integrity to doctrine, eldership and spiritual warfare, and adds 20 appendices to the main text.

Clifton, Mark. *Reclaiming Glory: Revitalizing Dying Churches*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2016.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Practical Guides

A book arguing that a dying congregation should be revitalised or replanted rather than abandoned, since a dying church does not glorify God, written from the North American Mission Board's work of replanting. It joins that conviction to practical strategy, for pastors weighing whether to lead a struggling church. An updated edition, subtitled *Creating a Gospel Legacy throughout North America* (2023), adds further experiences and strategies.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *On This Rock: Simple Lessons and Achievable Habits for Church Growth*. FirestartersUK, 2023.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *Scattered Not Small: Empowering Ordinary Churches to Become Disciple-Making Communities*. Firestarters Network Resources, 2024.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Practical Guides; Revitalisation and Replanting

The sequel to *On This Rock*: a guide to moving a church from a traditional model to a scattered, decentralised one, and to starting a church that way. Remsberg is minister of Beacon Church, Stafford, and the authors draw on practitioners in other churches. It takes up the questions leaders raised with them, among them who provides leadership and what the minister's job becomes, with a discussion section in each chapter.

Henard, Bill. *Can These Bones Live? A Practical Guide to Church Revitalization*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2015.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Practical Guides

A guide for plateaued or declining churches, by a Southern Baptist pastor. It works through 11 causes of decline, diagnosing each and giving a process for addressing it, and closes with a 'Change Matrix' for implementation. Henard holds that revitalisation rests on preaching and the work of the Spirit rather than on method, and expects it to take seven to 10 years.

Henard, Bill. *ReClaimed Church: How Churches Grow, Decline, and Experience Revitalization*. Nashville, TN: B&H, 2018.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Church Growth

A book that treats a congregation's growth, plateau and decline as stages of one life cycle, from birth to death, and sets out a process by which a church can return to growth: reassess, rethink, realign and reaffirm. Its third part, on the factors that determine growth or decline, bears most directly on growth; the fourth, on steps towards revitalisation, on a church already in decline. Written, in the publisher's description, for struggling churches.

McKinley, Mike. *Church Planting Is for Wimps: How God Uses Messed-Up People to Plant Ordinary Churches That Do Extraordinary Things*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Revitalisation and Replanting

An account of the revitalisation of Guilford Baptist Church in northern Virginia, a dying congregation, told under a planting title in the 9Marks series. McKinley argues that a pastor's faithful preaching, evangelism and training of leaders matter more than the size of his church, and is candid about his own fears and early mistakes. Written for pastors and seminarians weighing a plant and for those struggling in a young congregation; the chapter 'How to Ruin Everything' concerns ego, pride, fear and strain on marriage and family.

Nebel, Tom. *Big Dreams in Small Places: Church Planting in Smaller Communities*. St Charles, IL: ChurchSmart Resources, 2002.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns; Church Planting Movements

A book urging anyone who has thought of planting a church to consider a small town, which it presents as 'a huge mission field' where millions of Americans live. Nebel planted a church in Wisconsin and became the first national director of church planting for the Baptist General Conference, now Converge Worldwide.

Olofinjana, Israel Oluwole. *Partnership in Mission: A Black Majority Church Perspective on Mission and Church Unity*. Watford: Instant Apostle, 2015.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Africa

A monograph, not one of Olofinjana's several edited collections. It asks three questions of the Black majority churches in Britain: what they are, how varied the movement is, and what partnership with the historic denominations could look like. Case studies of partnerships already working are set beside them. The vantage is a Nigerian-British Baptist minister's, writing to the historic churches rather than about them.

Payne, J. D. *Discovering Church Planting: An Introduction to the Whats, Whys, and Hows of Global Church Planting*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Introductions and Overviews; Global and Cross-Cultural

An introductory overview, written from the perspective of a North American Baptist. Its four sections run from the theology of planting to contemporary issues, and draw on history, with the Moravians, the Methodists and the Baptists among its examples. It is set out as a first textbook: each chapter carries summaries, review questions and short articles on practical issues in planting.

Redford, Jack. *Planting New Churches*. Nashville, TN: Broadman Press, 1978.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A Southern Baptist manual setting out nine numbered steps by which a sponsoring church starts a new one, through a mission fellowship and a mission chapel to a constituted church. Three chapters on the mission pastor follow the steps.

ASSESSING BAPTIST PLANTERS

Grant, Lloyd Walter. 'Theological Analysis of Church Planter Profiles'. PhD thesis, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2012.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters

A PhD thesis of 2012 at the Southern Baptist Theological Seminary giving a theological analysis of church planter profiles, the lists of qualities by which denominations and networks judge whether a candidate is fit to plant. Where Walker's later doctoral project at the same seminary evaluates one assessment instrument statistically, Grant's analysis is theological.

Walker, Jason Alexander. 'Statistical Evaluation of the North American Mission Board's Church Planter Initial Assessment Instrument and the Implications for the Broader Church Planting Community'. DMin thesis, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2023.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A DMin thesis of 2023 at the Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, giving a statistical evaluation of the Church Planter Initial Assessment, the instrument with which the North American Mission Board of the Southern Baptist Convention begins its assessment of candidates, and drawing out what the results mean for the wider church planting community.

Methodist and Wesleyan

Contemporary Methodist and Wesleyan writing on planting and multiplication, and on recovering the early movement's disciplines of discipleship, from British Methodism and from the American Methodist and Wesleyan churches. The eighteenth-century movement, and the use later made of it, is a separate matter — see the list on Early Methodist Church Planting, under Historical Examples. Several books are filed in both lists.

Methodism is connexional: in the Methodist Church's own words, Methodists belong to local churches 'but also feel part of a larger connected community, the Connexion'. A new Methodist congregation belongs to that connected body of churches, not to itself alone.

George Hunter holds that Methodism has become the kind of establishment it began by offering an alternative to. Most of the rest of this list divides between two ways forward. One recovers the early movement's disciplines of mutual accountability, the General Rules, the class meeting and the band, as Kevin Watson and Philip Meadows do; Elaine Heath and Scott Kisker propose planting neo-monastic communities in the Wesleyan tradition. The other starts and multiplies congregations, as in Phil Stevenson's case for churches that parent new ones.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Methodist Identity and Renewal and Planting in Practice, most of it American.

START HERE

Horsley, Graham. *Planting New Congregations: A Practical Guide for Methodists*. London: Methodist Church Home Mission, 1994.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A booklet for Methodists on starting new congregations, published by the Methodist Church's Home Mission division in 1994, the year the Church of England's report *Breaking New Ground* appeared.

Watson, Kevin M. *A Blueprint for Discipleship: Wesley's General Rules as a Guide for Christian Living*. Nashville, TN: Discipleship Resources, 2009.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Early Methodist Church Planting

A book for lay readers that takes the General Rules seriously as a rule of life rather than as a historical curiosity. Watson builds a pattern of discipleship on Wesley's three rules, which he renders as do no harm, do good and practise the spiritual disciplines, and on members watching over one another in love in accountable small groups. George King's review notes that the charge of legalism, which a reader may raise early, is answered only in chapter seven.

Watson, Kevin M. *The Class Meeting: Reclaiming a Forgotten (and Essential) Small Group Experience*. Franklin, TN: Seedbed, 2013.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Early Methodist Church Planting

A guide to the small-group machinery that made the General Rules workable, written for groups starting a class meeting. Watson argues that early Methodists met in small groups to talk together about their souls, not only to study the Bible, and gives a group a shared language for the work of the Holy Spirit and a structure for its meetings. It is an eight-week study, after which the group sets the book aside and carries on as a class meeting.

METHODIST IDENTITY AND RENEWAL

Carter, David. *Love Bade Me Welcome: A British Methodist Perspective on the Church*. Exploring Methodism. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2002.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting; Ecclesiology

A history and account of British Methodist ecclesiology from the Wesleys to the present, setting classical Wesleyan thought beside Methodism's other strands and within wider ecumenical discussion. Carter writes as an ecumenist, for churches in dialogue with Methodists as well as for Methodists; the back cover calls it the first book on its subject since 1964, and the *Dictionary of Methodism in Britain and Ireland* cites it on connexionalism. The opening chapters treat the Wesleys, the first Methodists and classical Wesleyan ecclesiology.

Cartwright, Michael G., and Andrew D. Kinsey. *Watching over One Another in Love: Reclaiming the Wesleyan Rule of Life for the Church's Mission*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2011.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A spiritual formation resource 'for United Methodists and other heirs of the Wesleyan tradition', in its retailers' description, by two elders of the United Methodist Church's Indiana Conference, a university teacher and a parish pastor. It connects the Wesleyan rule of life directly to the church's mission, the link its subtitle names. Where Heath and Kisker's *Longing for Spring* takes the Wesleyan tradition towards new monastic communities, this book takes up the rule itself.

Heath, Elaine A., and Scott T. Kisker. *Longing for Spring: A New Vision for Wesleyan Community*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2010.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A proposal, in its own description's words, for 'planting neo-monastic communities as a new model of the church', by Elaine Heath, a co-founder of the Missional Wisdom Foundation, and the historian of Christianity Scott Kisker. It sets new monasticism in a Wesleyan key and is addressed to the United Methodist Church in the United States. James Pedlar's review calls it 'very accessible' and notes that it avoids 'rigorous scholarship'. Chapter 5, with its concrete suggestions on rules of life and ministry appointments, would be a useful place to start.

Hunter, George G., III. *The Recovery of a Contagious Methodist Movement*. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Early Methodist Church Planting

A short book arguing that Methodism began as a missional alternative to establishment Christianity and has come to resemble the establishment it once criticised. Its remedy, as Randy Willis summarises it in his review, is for North American Methodism to recover, as well as Wesley's theological vision, three directions in ministry: lay ministries, small groups and missional Christianity. Hunter treats the early movement's practice as something a present-day denomination can take up again.

PLANTING IN PRACTICE

Horsley, Graham. *Planting New Congregations: A Practical Guide for Methodists*. London: Methodist Church Home Mission, 1994.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Hunter, George G., III. *The Recovery of a Contagious Methodist Movement*. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 2011.

ANNOTATED under Methodist Identity and Renewal

Meadows, Philip R. *House Fellowship: A Quick Guide*. Spiritual Formation for Mission 3. Inspire Movement, 2021.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Early Methodist Church Planting

The third of the Inspire Movement's quick guides in its Spiritual Formation for Mission series (2021), by Philip Meadows, who co-founded the movement to recover discipleship and mission in the Wesleyan spirit. After the second guide, on the fellowship band, this one turns to the house fellowship: a small community meeting in an ordinary home to eat, pray, search the scriptures and watch over one another, then scattering to share the gospel, which may renew a local church or become the foundation of a new plant.

Meadows, Philip R., and Anthony Watts. *Fellowship Band: A Quick Guide*. Spiritual Formation for Mission 2. Inspire Movement, 2019.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Missional Spirituality; Early Methodist Church Planting

A quick guide to the fellowship band — three or four friends meeting regularly for spiritual conversation — as practised in the Inspire Movement, the international and ecumenical network for mission-shaped discipleship in the Wesleyan spirit that Meadows co-founded in 2007.

Merritt, Andrew W. 'Maximizing Planter Potential: An Analysis of the Church Planter Assessment of the Wesleyan Church'. DMin thesis, Asbury Theological Seminary, 2024.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A DMin thesis of 2024 at Asbury Theological Seminary analysing how the Wesleyan Church assesses its church planters. Its catalogue record lists case studies, call, appointment, mentoring and evaluation among its subjects.

Methodist Church in Britain. *New Places for New People (NPNP) Guide*. Version 1. Methodist Church, 2021. <https://media.methodist.org.uk/media/documents/new-places-for-new-people-nnpn-guide.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Strategy

The Methodist Church in Britain's practical guide, first issued in August 2021, to starting New Places for New People: new Christian communities for those not yet part of an existing church, one of the commitments of its God for All strategy. Written by the Connexion's pioneering and Church at the Margins officers for districts, circuits and local churches, it sets out a Methodist theological foundation and core practices, and names five priority settings, among them new housing, students and families. It is the current British Methodist policy on planting; the chapters on discerning where to locate a project and on financial sustainability would be useful places to look.

Stevenson, Phil. *The Ripple Church: Multiply Your Ministry by Parenting New Churches*. Indianapolis, IN: Wesleyan Publishing House, 2004.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

An advocacy book for existing churches rather than a manual for planters, on how a congregation can multiply its ministry by parenting new churches. Stevenson, later a district superintendent in the Wesleyan Church, published it with the denomination's own press.

Walkemeyer, Larry. *The River Church: Unleashing a Culture of Multiplication in Your Church*. Exponential, 2025. <https://exponential.org/product/the-river-church/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting

Ezekiel 47 as a diagnosis: a church can become a lake, gathering and holding what comes to it, or a river, carrying it somewhere else. Walkemeyer led Light and Life in Long Beach for 30 years and now works with Exponential and the Free Methodist Church, and the book is the account of turning the one into the other.

Watson, Kevin M. *A Blueprint for Discipleship: Wesley's General Rules as a Guide for Christian Living*. Nashville, TN: Discipleship Resources, 2009.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Watson, Kevin M. *The Class Meeting: Reclaiming a Forgotten (and Essential) Small Group Experience*. Franklin, TN: Seedbed, 2013.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

New Churches and Networks

The new churches are the congregations and networks that grew out of the British house church movement of the 1970s and 1980s, restorationist in theology and charismatic in practice, and the newer networks that have joined them since: Newfrontiers, Vineyard, Pioneer and Ichthus on one side, and on the other Acts 29, the FIEC's planting work and Co-Mission, which are Reformed rather than charismatic but plant by the same means, through a network of churches under a shared leadership rather than a denomination. New Churches is the category the census statisticians use for the first group, and the name is used here for want of a better one, since Free Church in England names the historic nonconformist denominations.

The boundary of this list is the network as a planting body. The theology of apostolic leadership that most of these networks hold is in Church Planting Movements and in the glossary, and the Pentecostal denominations have a list of their own. The axis of debate is whether a network led by an apostle multiplies churches more readily than a denomination or only differently, which Andrew Walker's history of the movement and William Kay's study of its networks approach from opposite ends, the one as the sociology of a sect on its way to becoming a denomination, the other as the description of a new way of being church.

This list opens with The Movement and Its Networks, then Vineyard, then Acts 29 and the Reformed Networks, and closes with The Networks' Own Pages.

THE MOVEMENT AND ITS NETWORKS

Devenish, David. *Fathering Leaders, Motivating Mission: Restoring the Role of the Apostle in Today's Church*.

Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2011.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting

A book written from inside Newfrontiers by a leader who has overseen churches across the Russian-speaking world and the 10/40 window, arguing that the New Testament apostle is best understood as a father to leaders rather than as an office. Its reviewers divide over the ecclesiology and agree on the usefulness.

Kay, William K. *Apostolic Networks in Britain: New Ways of Being Church*. Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2007.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A study of the British networks that grew from the house churches, Newfrontiers, Pioneer, Ichthus and Salt and Light among them. Kay traces the networks' roots from Wigglesworth's prophecy through the charismatic renewal, then analyses 12 networks through interviews and a survey of 647 leaders, describing them, in the subtitle's phrase, as 'new ways of being church' organised round apostolic figures rather than a denomination. Where Walker reads the earlier movement as a sect moving toward denominational status, this is a fuller, more sympathetic account of the networks in their settled form.

Walker, Andrew. *Restoring the Kingdom: The Radical Christianity of the House Church Movement*. 4th ed. Guildford: Eagle, 1998.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A history of the British house church movement from the mid-1960s to the mid-1980s, by a sociologist who studied it as it grew. Walker divides the movement into two wings, R1 and R2, labels that passed into wider use, and argues that Restorationism, despite insisting it was no new denomination, is sociologically a sect moving toward one. Where Kay describes the later networks as a settled new way of being church, this is the founding study of a movement still taking shape. The fourth edition, cited here, extends the account with new chapters beyond the 1985 first edition.

VINEYARD

Hunter, Todd. *Autopsy Reports of Failed Churches*. Vineyard USA, 1986.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Planting Movements

One of the earliest attempts to study church plants that failed rather than those that worked, written in 1986 from inside the Vineyard by Todd Hunter, then pastor of the Wheeling Vineyard in West Virginia and later the movement's national director. Nick Klinkenberg's account of it has Hunter examining 22 failed Vineyard plants and drawing out 10 common reasons for their failure, among them leader development, strategic planning and accountability. Stetzer and Bird's 2008 report on church planting in the United States summarises its conclusions: the lead planter's disposition mattered most, then the site and the training of planters and teams.

Morphew, Derek. *John Wimber's Teaching on Church Planting*. Independently published, 2020.

A short book presenting John Wimber's teaching on church planting as a course, put together by Derek Morphew from the Vineyard movement's own material: Wimber's vision of new churches as the way the kingdom expands, revived, in the publisher's words, as the Vineyard 'is raising a new generation of churches'. Self-published in 2020, it is the movement's own voice on planting rather than a study of it.

Nicholson, Steve, and Jeff Bailey. *Coaching Church Planters: A Manual for Church Planters and Those Who Coach Them*. Association of Vineyard Churches USA, 2001.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Practical Guides; Coaching

A coaching manual from the Association of Vineyard Churches USA, addressed at once to the planter and to the coach. The manual comes out of Vineyard planting practice. It emphasises the planter's pursuit of intimacy with God, with Jesus's life as the model, and includes a guide for small groups.

Sjogren, Steve. *Conspiracy of Kindness: A Unique Approach to Sharing the Love of Jesus*. Rev. ed. Bloomington, MN: Bethany House, 2008.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A book setting out servant evangelism, Sjogren's term for small, free acts of practical kindness offered with no obligation attached, such as cleaning a business's toilets unasked. His formula is deeds of love plus words of love plus adequate time: doing the message precedes telling it, to earn a hearing for the gospel rather than to replace speaking it. The examples come from Vineyard Community Church, Cincinnati, which Sjogren founded in 1985. Life and Leadership's summary judges the approach best suited to informally structured churches. First published by Vine Books in 1993; the edition cited is the revised one of 2008.

ACTS 29 AND THE REFORMED NETWORKS

Chester, Tim, and Steve Timmis. *Everyday Church: Mission by Being Good Neighbours*. Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A book reading 1 Peter for a church on the margins after Christendom, and a sequel to Chester and Timmis's *Total Church*. The argument is that mission belongs to ordinary members, in the relationships and routines of daily life, rather than to a leader or a programme. Inter-Varsity Press withdrew both books from sale in 2020, *Christianity Today* reported, after Steve Timmis's removal from Acts 29, judging that the close church community they advocate 'lacked sufficient safeguards against abusive control'.

Chester, Tim, and Steve Timmis. *Total Church: A Radical Reshaping Around Gospel and Community*. Nottingham: Inter-Varsity Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book built on two principles: the gospel as content, which makes a church word-centred and mission-centred, and community as context, sharing life among Christians and offering belonging to those outside. Chester and Timmis make the biblical case, then apply it in 11 chapters, from church planting to work with children, as a middle path between the emerging church and conservative evangelicalism. Inter-Varsity Press withdrew it from sale in 2020, after Steve Timmis's removal from Acts 29, judging that the community it advocates 'lacked sufficient safeguards against abusive control'.

Cosper, Mike. *The Rise and Fall of Mars Hill*. Podcast series, 15 episodes. Christianity Today, 2021-22.

<https://www.christianitytoday.com/podcasts/the-rise-and-fall-of-mars-hill/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; Power and Its Abuse

The narrative history of Mars Hill Church in Seattle, which grew to 12,000 people across 12 sites and dissolved in 2014, and of Mark Driscoll, who founded it and co-founded Acts 29. Driscoll resigned in 2014 amid serious concerns about his leadership. Setting former staff and members beside historians and sociologists, Cosper makes the series about the conditions that produced Mars Hill — celebrity, and a theology of masculinity — rather than about one leader. Justin Dean, the church's former communications director, has disputed its accuracy. Driscoll's *Confessions of a Reformation Rev.* was written in 2006 from inside the church whose end this describes.

Moore, Philip. 'Defending Specificity on Doctrinal Distinctives for a Church-Planting Network: Why Reformed Soteriology and Complementarianism Are Important'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 26-40. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-2-defending-specificity-on-doctrinal-distinctives-for-a-church-planting-network/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Ecclesiology; Presbyterian and Reformed

An article defending a church-planting network's requirement of more than gospel agreement from the churches it takes on. Moore, writing within Acts 29, argues for Reformed soteriology and complementarianism on three grounds: biblical fidelity, pastoral practice and method, and the trust that working together in a network needs.

Paterson, Andy. 'Multi-Site Church'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 61-75. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-4-multi-site-church/>.

ALSO IN Multi-site Church; Ecclesiology

An article asking of one structure, multi-site church, whether it is an end in itself, a dangerous distortion or a pragmatic tool, written while Paterson was mission director of the Fellowship of Independent Evangelical Churches. He allows it a use in planting and in reviving dying congregations, but argues that *ekklesia* means a literal assembly in one place, and that a site whose leader is not its preacher separates leading from preaching. A site, he concludes, must in time be freed 'to become a fully autonomous, self-governing church in its own right'.

THE NETWORKS' OWN PAGES

Acts 29. <https://www.acts29.com>.

ALSO IN Other Places to Look

The website of Acts 29, a global church planting network that 'stands in the tradition of historic evangelical confessionalism', and works in six regions, from North America to Asia Pacific. Acts 29 plants churches and supports their pastors; the site carries stories, books, podcasts, videos and training material under some 40 topics.

Co-Mission. <https://co-mission.org/>.

ALSO IN Other Places to Look

The website of Co-Mission, a network of churches in London, varied in culture, that 'teach the reformed evangelical faith of the scriptures'. The network exists 'to plant churches to reach London for Christ'. The site is chiefly about the network itself, which also keeps a video channel on YouTube.

FIEC. *Church Planting*. <https://fiec.org.uk/who-we-are/what-we-do/church-planting>.

ALSO IN Other Places to Look

The church planting section of the FIEC's website; the Fellowship of Independent Evangelical Churches is a body of self-governing churches working together in Britain. It advises on three ways of planting (a small team sent to a new area, a daughter church, and the replanting of a struggling congregation), gives grants and pastoral support, and holds an annual conference for planters.

Vineyard Churches UK and Ireland. *Multiply: Resources*. <https://www.vineyardchurches.org.uk/multiply/resources/>.

ALSO IN Other Places to Look

The church planting resources of Vineyard Churches UK and Ireland, a charismatic evangelical movement that describes itself as a church planting movement with a mandate to plant churches worldwide, rooted in Jesus's proclamation and demonstration of the Kingdom of God. A free church planting manual, two podcasts, Multiply and Planted, training modules and a staged coaching pathway serve those planting within the movement.

Pentecostal

Pentecostal writing on the church, its worship and its history. Pentecostalism is a movement within evangelical Protestantism that emphasises direct personal experience of God through baptism with the Holy Spirit. It is usually dated from the Azusa Street revival in Los Angeles in 1906, and since the 1960s its beliefs about the baptism of the Spirit and spiritual gifts have been taken up in other churches through the charismatic movement.

This list holds the tradition's theology and history rather than manuals of planting. The exception is Melvin Hodges's *The Indigenous Church* (1953), written for Assemblies of God missionaries, and one of two books by which Hodges shaped the missionary policy of his own church and of other evangelical missions.

The principal question in this list is whether Pentecostal worship is sacramental. Chris Green argues from the early Pentecostal periodicals that the first Pentecostals held a high view of the Lord's Supper, and that Christ is present at it through the Spirit, against a merely memorialist reading of it. No book in this list argues the memorialist side; the collection edited by David Hilborn and Simo Frestadius sets Anglican and Pentecostal writers side by side on the sacraments.

This reading list runs from Start Here to Pentecostal Theology and Worship.

START HERE

Church Multiplication: Growing the Church Exponentially. Special issue, *Enrichment Journal* 14, no. 4 (Fall 2009).

ALSO IN Church Planting Strategy

A collection of articles filling the fall 2009 issue of the Assemblies of God's quarterly for ministers, 160 pages given to church multiplication as the denomination set up its Church Multiplication Network. They run from George Wood on Acts 19 and David Olson on why multiplication decides a denomination's survival, through Ed Stetzer on planting systems, Nelson Searcy on launching large, Dave Ferguson on multisite and Neil Cole on organic church, to Bob Roberts on 'glocal' planting and Steven Pike on the network itself. Together they show one Pentecostal denomination gathering the wider movement's voices for its own planters. Stetzer's article also has an entry of its own.

Hodges, Melvin L. *The Indigenous Church*. Springfield, MO: Gospel Publishing House, 1953.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves; Global and Cross-Cultural

A short book written to prepare Assemblies of God missionaries, out of Hodges's own work in El Salvador and Nicaragua. It put indigenous-church principles into the hands of a Pentecostal mission agency, and went on to shape the missionary policy of the Assemblies of God and of other evangelical agencies. Roland Allen is the influence the sources name on Hodges's missiology. Reissued in 2009 together with *The Indigenous Church and the Missionary*.

Robeck, Cecil M., Jr., and Amos Yong, eds. *The Cambridge Companion to Pentecostalism*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

An edited volume introducing Pentecostalism to students and specialists through its history, its regions and the academic disciplines. No chapter takes ecclesiology as its subject; for the doctrine of the church, the chapters on Pentecostal theology, by Mark Cartledge, and on Pentecostalism and ecumenism, by Wolfgang Vondey, would be a useful place to look. Martin Mittelstadt (2014) notes that none of its chapter authors is a woman and no chapter treats gender.

PENTECOSTAL THEOLOGY AND WORSHIP

Burgess, Stanley M., ed. *Christian Peoples of the Spirit: A Documentary History of Pentecostal Spirituality from the Early Church to the Present*. New York: New York University Press, 2011.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A documentary history of charismatic gifts, worship and experience from the early church to the present: primary texts, from Tertullian and Antony of the Desert to the Shakers and Sundar Singh, with writings by their critics, each briefly introduced. Arranged in four periods, ancient, medieval, early modern and contemporary, it argues that modern Pentecostalism, usually dated from Azusa Street in 1906, has precedents in every age of the church.

Chan, Simon. *Grassroots Asian Theology: Thinking the Faith from the Ground Up*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2014.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Missiology

An argument by a Singaporean Pentecostal theologian that Asian theology has been dominated by an academic elite and should be read instead from what ordinary Asian Christians believe and practise. Like Tennent's *Theology in the Context of World Christianity* it follows the doctrinal loci, but fills them from popular and Pentecostal faith: honour and shame for sin and salvation, the family as a model for the Trinity and the church. Alexander Chow, reviewing it, finds the line between elite and grassroots drawn too cleanly, and Ruth Benedict's 'shame culture' thesis used uncritically.

Green, Chris E. W. *Toward a Pentecostal Theology of the Lord's Supper: Foretasting the Kingdom*. Cleveland, TN: CPT Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

A monograph, the published form of Green's Bangor doctoral thesis, on the Lord's Supper in Pentecostal theology. From early Pentecostal periodicals of both the Wesleyan-Holiness and Finished Work streams it retrieves a high view of the sacraments, then reads three biblical texts to argue that Christ is 'really, personally, and bodily present' in the Supper through the Spirit. Jason Goroncy (2013) finds its untranslated Latin and Greek a barrier for some readers.

Hilborn, David, and Simo Frestadius, eds. *Anglicans and Pentecostals in Dialogue*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Ecclesiology

An edited volume in which Anglican and Pentecostal writers take the same subjects in paired chapters: first each tradition's approach to ecumenism, then sacraments, ministry, ecclesiology, pneumatology and mission, with accounts of ecumenical work at local, national and international level, mostly in Britain. Hilborn's own chapter compares the two traditions on ordination, and Ric Thorpe's, on Anglicans, church growth and church planting, sits in the section on mission and church growth. Amy White (*The Melbourne Anglican*, 2024) finds that some chapters recount their own tradition's history without engaging the other.

Presbyterian and Reformed

Presbyterian and Reformed churches plant with a doctrine of the church already settled: a congregation is gathered under the ministry of word and sacrament and the oversight of elders, and a new one is the mission work of a presbytery until it can call its own session. This list holds what the book has from that tradition on planting, from James Bannerman's Free Church treatise of 1868 to the Orthodox Presbyterian Church's manual and Timothy Keller's Redeemer material, together with the Church of Scotland's own recent turn to new worshipping communities. Its boundary is the tradition's own account of itself: Reformed writers who appear elsewhere in the book for their work on mission or the city are here only where the Presbyterian or Reformed order of the church is the point.

The axis of debate runs between confessional order and missionary freedom: whether a plant must be a presbytery's work under its courts from the first, as the Orthodox Presbyterian Church's manual and Hyde and Lems's contributors hold, or may begin as a network's or a resource church's initiative and be received into order later, which is the question Neil MacMillan's Free Church of Scotland experience and the Acts 29 network raise, and which Stefan Paas and Hans Schaeffer watch being answered in Dutch Reformed plants.

This list opens with Reformed Ecclesiology, then Planting in the Reformed Tradition, then The Church of Scotland and the Free Church, and closes with Networks.

REFORMED ECCLESIOLOGY

Bannerman, James. *The Church of Christ: A Treatise on the Nature, Powers, Ordinances, Discipline and Government of the Christian Church*. Edinburgh: T. and T. Clark, 1868.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A treatise in two volumes by a Free Church of Scotland minister, edited after his death in 1868 from his lectures at New College, Edinburgh. It argues the Presbyterian position in comparison with other confessional traditions, with sustained treatment of church power and of church and state. Presbyterian reviewers still recommend it, Jeff Kingswood (2015) because churches face the issues earlier generations grappled with; Matt Cover finds some of its controversies harder for a modern reader to follow.

Clowney, Edmund P. *The Church*. Contours of Christian Theology. Leicester: Inter-Varsity Press, 1995.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A treatment of the doctrine of the church in 18 chapters, from a Reformed and Presbyterian standpoint. Clowney grounds the church in the Trinity and sets its task as worship, nurture and mission. Ben Robin (9Marks, 2024), writing as a Baptist, disagrees on three points, arguing for believer's baptism, stronger congregational authority and a membership restricted to believers, which he judges better suited to the church's missional identity. Chapters 8 and 14, on the marks of the church and on its structure, would be useful places to begin.

Hyde, Daniel R., and Shane Lems, eds. *Planting, Watering, Growing: Planting Confessionally Reformed Churches in the 21st Century*. Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2011.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Introductions and Overviews

An edited volume of 21 essays on planting confessionally Reformed churches, most by pastors of the United Reformed Churches in North America with experience of planting. Stephen Doe's review for the Orthodox Presbyterian Church notes that its handling of the oversight of new mission work follows United Reformed practice. Its first part, on the biblical and confessional foundations, with Brian Vos's 'The Fruitful Grain of Wheat' and Wes Bredenhof's 'The Reformed Confessions and Missions', bears most directly on the theology of planting.

Paas, Stefan, and Hans Schaeffer. 'Reconstructing Reformed Identity: Experiences from Church Planting in the Netherlands'. *Journal of Reformed Theology* 8, no. 4 (2014): 382-407. <https://doi.org/10.1163/15697312-00804004>.

ALSO IN Europe; Ecclesiology; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A journal article, written for a specialist theological readership, by Stefan Paas, a missiologist, and Hans Schaeffer, a practical theologian whose research concerns changing forms of the church and practical ecclesiology. Its subject is Reformed identity, taken up through experiences of church planting in the Netherlands.

PLANTING IN THE REFORMED TRADITION

Conn, Harvie M. *Theological Perspectives on Church Growth*. Nutley, NJ: Presbyterian and Reformed, 1976.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Church Growth

A volume bringing Reformed theology to bear on Donald McGavran's church growth theory, edited by Harvie Conn while professor of missions at Westminster Theological Seminary, and the third in Presbyterian and Reformed's series Studies in the World Church and Missions. It speaks from Reformed missiology rather than from the movement's base at Fuller. It predates the Pasadena consultation of 1977, and Gary McIntosh's 'Revisiting the Homogeneous Unit Principle' (2023) counts Conn among the principle's early critics.

Evans, Eifion. 'Calvin's Influence on Mission'. *Foundations*, no. 48 (May 2002): 4-15. https://www.affinity.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/08/48_04.pdf.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article by the Welsh Presbyterian minister and church historian Eifion Evans, answering the view that Calvin had no interest in mission. Much of it concerns Geneva's training of pastors and their sending into France, where, in Ronald Wallace's words, Calvin regarded each small group of believers as 'the nucleus of a congregation'. It relies on Philip Hughes for a count of 88 men named in the register of Geneva's Company of Pastors as sent out between 1555 and 1562.

Keller, Timothy, and J. Allen Thompson. *Redeemer Church Planting Manual*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2002.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A manual for planting a church in a city, which sets out a step-by-step approach and tells the story of Redeemer Presbyterian Church, New York, throughout. Founders Ministries, in its annotated bibliography for planters, judges its practical instruction useful outside urban settings too.

Keller, Timothy. *Center Church: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Cities and Urban Areas; Introductions and Overviews

A comprehensive overview of church planting theology and theory, set out as what Keller calls a theological vision for ministry in the city, by the founding pastor of Redeemer Presbyterian Church in New York and founding president of City to City. Its first part shows how the gospel drives planting and renews church and planter; the second, on the city, has a careful section on contextualisation and substantial sections on the place of the city in any planting strategy. It is long and demanding, but deeply thoughtful, and an excellent framework for urban planting.

Keller, Timothy. *Planting a Church in the City*. Manuals and Papers AR 18. New York: Redeemer Presbyterian Church, 2010. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/planting-a-church-in-the-city/>.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Cities and Urban Areas

A short paper, first published in *The Movement Newsletter* in 2004, setting out five principles for starting a church, from locating, which means living among the people to be reached, to launching, from the top down or the bottom up. Its publisher introduces them as principles common to any church plant. Keller's *Center Church* (2012) treats ministry in the city at book length.

Nevius, John L. *The Planting and Development of Missionary Churches*. Shanghai: Presbyterian Press, 1886.

ALSO IN Missiology; Introductions and Overviews; Asia and the Middle East; Victorian Three Selves

A primary text of the 19th-century missionary movement, first written in 1885 as articles for the *Chinese Recorder* and published as a book in 1886. Against paying local evangelists and pastors from mission funds, Nevius argues for churches that are self-supporting, self-governing and self-propagating, whose members keep their own occupations and call pastors when they can support them. The source of what came to be called the Nevius method, it was adopted by Presbyterian missionaries in Korea; the *Biographical Dictionary of Chinese Christianity* records that it and Nevius's *Methods of Mission Work* became required reading for most Presbyterian missionaries to China and Korea for over 50 years. The 1899 New York printing is digitised by the Internet Archive.

Nicholls, John. 'Evangelising Our Cities: The Abiding Challenge of Thomas Chalmers'. *Foundations*, no. 44 (May 2000): 21-29. https://www.affinity.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/08/44_21.pdf.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

An article on Thomas Chalmers's ministry in Glasgow and Edinburgh from 1816 to 1847 as a model for evangelising the inner city, by John Nicholls of the London City Mission. It sets out Chalmers's district visiting and the Church of Scotland's Church Extension campaign of 1834, which had built 216 new churches by 1840, and asks whether the method survives Lyle Schaller's observation that social networks, not place, now decide who comes to a neighbourhood church.

Orthodox Presbyterian Church, Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension. *Planting an Orthodox Presbyterian Church*. Willow Grove, PA: Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension, 2002. <https://opc.org/chm/chplant/>.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Practical Guides

A denominational manual from the Orthodox Presbyterian Church's Committee on Home Missions and Church Extension, written by its general secretary, Ross W. Graham, and approved by the Committee in December 2001. It sets out the church's own process for planting: how a core group becomes a mission work under an overseeing session and an organising pastor, and is in turn organised as a particular church. Written for organising pastors, overseeing elders and presbytery home missions committees, it describes the procedures of one Presbyterian and Reformed polity rather than a general method, and reads as a tradition's own working document.

THE CHURCH OF SCOTLAND AND THE FREE CHURCH

Aisthorpe, Steve. *Rewilding the Church*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2020.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A book by Steve Aisthorpe, a mission development worker for the Church of Scotland, that takes rewilding, the ecological practice of letting land return to its own growth, as a picture of a church less dependent on its own strategies. It follows his study of churchless Christians, *The Invisible Church*.

Church of Scotland Faith Action Programme Leadership Team. *Report of the Faith Action Programme Leadership Team*. Reports to the General Assembly 2026. Church of Scotland, 2026. https://www.churchofscotland.org.uk/__data/assets/pdf_file/0006/154653/Faith-Action-Programme-Leadership-Team1.pdf.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Resource Churches; Church Planting Strategy

A report to the Church of Scotland's General Assembly of May 2026, which asked the Assembly to note the progress of plans for a resource church in the Presbytery of Glasgow. It defines a resource church as a hub for mission, planting, revitalisation and developing leaders, proposes siting one near universities to reach students and young adults, and affirms three levels of planting: local, presbytery and national. It also records that the planting strategy the 2025 Assembly asked for is not ready, central staff having been cut.

Dalpra, Claire. *Pioneering Pieces: An Evaluation of the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2020. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/pioneering-pieces-full-report.pdf>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Pioneering; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report by Claire Dalpra of Church Army's Research Unit evaluating the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project, which funded five full-time pioneer posts from 2016 to 2021: among artists in Glasgow, on a new-build estate in Bonnyrigg, with students at Stirling, in Ferguslie Park in Paisley and among Ayrshire farming communities. It gathers the reflections of those involved, post by post, then gives the author's own assessment, and asks whether these places offer enough to sustain the planting of a new ecclesial community.

MacMillan, Neil. 'Building a Church-Planting Movement in a Traditional Denomination'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 41-60. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-3-building-a-church-planting-movement-in-a-traditional-denomination/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

An article on the difficulty of starting a planting movement inside a denomination with settled structures and a long memory, written from the Free Church of Scotland by the planter of Cornerstone, Morningside. MacMillan names the obstacles rather than gesturing at them: planting treated as a fad, overseas mission competing for the same money, pressure to rescue dying churches instead, bureaucratic process, and too few large self-financing churches to send from. Most of them would be recognised in any established church.

NETWORKS

Moore, Philip. 'Defending Specificity on Doctrinal Distinctives for a Church-Planting Network: Why Reformed Soteriology and Complementarianism Are Important'. *Foundations*, no. 72 (Spring 2017): 26-40. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-72/issue-72-article-2-defending-specificity-on-doctrinal-distinctives-for-a-church-planting-network/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Ecclesiology; New Churches and Networks

An article defending a church-planting network's requirement of more than gospel agreement from the churches it takes on. Moore, writing within Acts 29, argues for Reformed soteriology and complementarianism on three grounds: biblical fidelity, pastoral practice and method, and the trust that working together in a network needs.

Roman Catholic

See also the list on Anglo-Catholic.

Church planting and parish renewal in the Roman Catholic tradition. The Second Vatican Council's decree on mission, *Ad Gentes* (1965), gives 'the proper purpose of this missionary activity' as 'evangelization, and the planting of the Church among those peoples and groups where it has not yet taken root' (§6), *plantatio Ecclesiae* in the Latin.

Planting in the decree's sense is the founding of a local church among a people where the church has no roots, not the starting of a congregation beside existing ones. Where the church has long been planted, Catholic practice in this list takes the form of parish renewal, in the line of James Mallon's *Divine Renovation* (2014), subtitled *Bringing Your Parish from Maintenance to Mission*.

What runs between the two senses is the question of how much of the church's inherited form the gospel needs to carry. Vincent Donovan took the gospel to the Maasai directly and asked what it is without the cultural forms the missions had brought with it; Mallon keeps the parish and changes what it is for.

This reading list opens with Start Here and then The Council and After, which holds the decree and the theology, testimony and papal teaching written since.

START HERE

Huntley, Ron, and James Mallon. *Unlocking Your Parish: Making Disciples, Raising Up Leaders with Alpha*. Frederick, MD: The Word Among Us Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Alpha Course and Church Planting; Parish Church; Practical Guides

A book on Alpha as the means of renewing a Catholic parish, drawn from Saint Benedict Parish in Halifax, Nova Scotia, where Huntley served on the senior leadership team alongside Mallon. A practical outworking of Mallon's *Divine Renovation*, it argues that evangelisation shapes the whole culture of a parish, from outreach to sacramental life, and takes up the logistical questions that arise after a first or second course. Written for parishes considering Alpha as well as those already running it.

Mallon, James. *Divine Renovation: Bringing Your Parish from Maintenance to Mission*. New London, CT: Twenty-Third Publications, 2014.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Parish Church; Revitalisation and Replanting; Theory of Change

A book by a Catholic parish priest in Halifax, Nova Scotia, drawn from the renewal he led in his own parish. It argues that a parish moves from maintenance to mission when it stops being a membership-based community and becomes an assembly of disciples who proclaim and share the good news.

THE COUNCIL AND AFTER

Second Vatican Council. *Ad Gentes: Decree on the Mission Activity of the Church*. Rome, 7 December 1965.

https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_decree_19651207_ad-gentes_en.html.

ALSO IN Missiology; Ecclesiology; Church Planting Movements

A document of the Second Vatican Council, its decree on the church's missionary activity, promulgated by Pope Paul VI on 7 December 1965: the first time an ecumenical council treated the missions as a subject in their own right. It grounds mission in the sending of the Son and the Spirit, so that the church is 'missionary by her very nature'. Chapter 2, on witness, preaching and the forming of a Christian community, and chapter 3, on the particular churches, their laity and their theological adaptation, bear most directly on planting.

Bevans, Stephen B., and Roger P. Schroeder. *Constants in Context: A Theology of Mission for Today*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2004.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book on the theology of mission by two Catholic missiologists, and a companion piece to Bosch's *Transforming Mission*: like Bosch, it moves from key biblical texts to the approaches to mission taken across church history, and reviewers set the two side by side, Steve Hayes reading it as doing for Catholic missiology what Bosch did for Protestant. Ecumenical in range, it draws on Catholic, Protestant, Orthodox and Pentecostal approaches. It does not deal directly with church planting, though it gives planters a theological framework; Warrick Farah finds that its contextual emphasis undervalues conversion and church planting in unreached areas. Part III sets out the authors' own proposal, mission as 'prophetic dialogue'.

Donovan, Vincent J. *Christianity Rediscovered: An Epistle from the Masai*. Notre Dame, IN: Fides/Claretian, 1978.

ALSO IN Missiology; Pioneering; Africa; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book of narrative and reflection by an American Catholic missionary priest who, influenced by Roland Allen, gave up the school-based method in northern Tanzania and took the gospel directly to the Maasai. It asks what the gospel is when stripped of the Western forms that usually carry it. Samuel K. Elolia (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) contests its conclusion that missionaries are no longer needed, pointing to the growth of Christianity in Africa. The Orbis 25th anniversary edition (2003) adds essays by Lamin Sanneh and Eugene Hillman.

Dulles, Avery. *Models of the Church*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1974.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A study of the church through five models: institution, mystical communion, sacrament, herald and servant. Dulles, a Jesuit, weighs the strengths and limitations of each rather than ranking them, and holds that none is sufficient alone, so that a balanced theology keeps what each model affirms. The expanded edition adds a sixth, the church as a community of disciples.

Francis, Pope. *Evangelii Gaudium: The Joy of the Gospel; Apostolic Exhortation on the Proclamation of the Gospel in Today's World*. London: Catholic Truth Society, 2013.

ALSO IN Missiology

A papal document, the apostolic exhortation Francis signed on 24 November 2013. It calls for a church that goes out rather than stays enclosed, one 'bruised, hurting and dirty because it has been out on the streets' (§49), and gives a chapter to the social dimension of evangelisation. *Ad Gentes* (1965) called the church missionary by its very nature; this document asks for its 'missionary transformation'. Kirsteen Kim (*International Review of Mission*, 2015) finds in it and the World Council of Churches' *Together towards Life* (2013) a shared, holistic understanding of mission. Chapter 1, on that transformation, bears most directly on planting.

Salvation Army

The Salvation Army began in 1865 as William Booth's mission in the East End of London and took its present name and military form in 1878. It grew out of Methodism, Booth having been a minister of the Methodist New Connexion, and it kept Methodism's holiness teaching and its habit of taking the gospel to people who would not come to church; but it never used the words church planting. What it did instead was to open fire on a town: send a small party of officers to hold open-air meetings and start a corps, under regulations that governed the work in detail. This list reads that expansion as church planting under another name and asks what it can teach.

Its boundary is the Army's growth as a body of congregations, not its social work, though Booth's scheme of 1890 is here because the two cannot be separated in his own logic. The axis of debate runs between the Army's own account of aggressive, providential expansion and the historians who ask why it stalled: Norman Murdoch holds that evangelistic growth had faltered by the mid-1880s and the Army turned to social work, where Pamela Walker shows how corps took root in working-class communities and why. Behind both stands the question whether the Army is a church at all, which Phil Needham and David Taylor take up, and which bears on whether what it did was planting.

This list opens with *The Booths and the Early Manifestos*, follows with *How the Expansion Worked*, and closes with *Whether the Army Is a Church*.

THE BOOTHS AND THE EARLY MANIFESTOS

Booth, Catherine. *Papers on Aggressive Christianity*. London: S. W. Partridge, 1880. <https://archive.org/details/papersonaggressi00boot>.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A collection of addresses Catherine Booth delivered from February 1880, published the same year under the title page's *Papers on Aggressive Christianity* and known by the cover title *Aggressive Christianity*. Where her husband's book gives the social scheme, she gives the theology behind sending Salvationists to those the churches did not reach: conversion as something pursued rather than awaited. The opening address, from which the collection takes its title, states the case most directly. Later reprints carry the fuller title *Aggressive Christianity: Practical Sermons*.

Booth, William. *In Darkest England and the Way Out*. London: International Headquarters of the Salvation Army, 1890. <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/475>.

A book by William Booth, published in 1890, arguing that the poor of Britain live in conditions as dark as inland Africa and setting out his own remedy. Part 1 states the diagnosis; Part 2, much the longer, gives the Darkest England scheme of city, farm and overseas colonies rather than a plan for planting corps. It stands among the Army's early manifestos because Booth's own logic makes social rescue and spiritual expansion one undertaking, the same aggressive impulse that sent officers into new towns.

Eason, Andrew M., and Roger J. Green, eds. *Boundless Salvation: The Shorter Writings of William Booth*. New York: Peter Lang, 2012.

A scholarly edition of William Booth's shorter writings, previously scattered across 19th-century periodicals or reprinted without proper documentation. It gathers Booth's articles and speeches under six themes. Beside the four primary texts in this list, each fixed to one moment, this draws on Booth's whole career; its 'Missions and Missionaries' section bears most directly on expansion. The editors introduce and document the source of each piece.

HOW THE EXPANSION WORKED

Eason, Andrew Mark. *Women in God's Army: Gender and Equality in the Early Salvation Army*. Waterloo, ON: Wilfrid Laurier University Press, 2003.

ALSO IN Women in Church Planting

A study of whether the early Salvation Army's promise of sexual equality in ministry matched its practice. Eason traces the gap between the founding constitution's claim that women could preach and hold any office and the gendered assignment of roles he finds in practice, underwritten by what he calls a male-defined theology. Diane Winston, reviewing it, calls the book 'a provocative counterpoint to recent Salvationist scholarship that credits the Army with providing new opportunities for women.' The chapter on the public and domestic service of female officers bears most directly on the women who did the work of planting corps.

Horridge, Glenn K. *The Salvation Army: Origins and Early Days, 1865–1900*. Godalming: Ammonite Books, 1993.

A narrative history of the Army's founding and expansion between 1865 and 1900, from William Booth's Christian Mission through the 1878 reorganisation into an army and on past the point in the mid-1880s where Murdoch locates a stalling of growth. It charts the opening and closing of corps. Published in 1993, it is the earliest of the three modern scholarly histories of the Army's origins read together in this list, supplying the narrative record of expansion that Murdoch's account of stalled growth and Walker's account of rooted corps each set out to explain.

Murdoch, Norman H. *Origins of the Salvation Army*. Knoxville, TN: University of Tennessee Press, 1994.

A revisionist history of the Salvation Army's early growth, set against the Army's own story of triumphant advance. Murdoch traces William and Catherine Booth from Wesleyan revivalism in the 1850s to the social scheme of 1890, and argues that the shift was forced rather than chosen: 'it was the Army's failure to grow as a revivalist sect... that turned it in the direction of social service.' Where Walker asks how corps took root, Murdoch asks why, by the mid-1880s, they largely stopped.

Sandall, Robert, and others. *The History of The Salvation Army*. 9 vols. London: Thomas Nelson and Sons; Hodder and Stoughton; Salvation Army, 1947–2018.

The Salvation Army's own official chronicle, nine volumes published between 1947 and 2018, opening under Robert Sandall and carried on afterwards by four further authors. It narrates the Army's expansion in an aggressive, providential register, campaign by campaign, rather than as critical history, and so stands as the primary account that later historians have tested and revised. The volumes are organised as consecutive periods rather than by territory, so a given opening is found by first locating its date and then the volume that covers it.

Walker, Pamela J. *Pulling the Devil's Kingdom Down: The Salvation Army in Victorian Britain*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 2001.

A history of the Salvation Army's first decades in Britain, from its Methodist roots in the East End through clashes with police, press and established churches. Walker treats the Army as a movement that fused early feminism, open-air preaching, holiness teaching and provocative street theatre, and asks how that combination let corps take root in working-class districts rather than merely visit them. Where Murdoch traces a stalling of growth from the mid-1880s, Walker's account stays with the years in which expansion succeeded.

Winston, Diane. *Red-Hot and Righteous: The Urban Religion of the Salvation Army*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1999.

An account of the Salvation Army after it crossed the Atlantic, tracing how the movement that began in London's East End became, within a few decades, a fixture of American cities. Winston shows the Army borrowing the idioms of commercial entertainment and popular marketing to reach the urban poor, 'a militant Protestant mission' that, in her phrase, 'established a beachhead in the modern city.' Where the rest of this list asks how the model worked in Britain, Winston asks what changed, and what did not, when it was replanted in the United States.

WHETHER THE ARMY IS A CHURCH

Hill, Harold. *Leadership in The Salvation Army: A Case Study in Clericalisation*. Milton Keynes: Paternoster, 2006.

A historical and sociological case study of how the Salvation Army's leadership, at first functional and grounded in the priesthood of all believers, came to assume the status of clergy, most visibly when 'ordination' was adopted for commissioning officers in 1978, a century after the Army's founding. Where Needham and Taylor ask whether the Army is a church in its own theological terms, Hill gives the institutional history of how it acquired a clergy, the feature that question most often turns on. Published in a series of academic monographs on Christian history rather than as theology from within the tradition.

Needham, Phil. *Community in Mission: A Salvationist Ecclesiology*. London: The Salvation Army, 1987.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A monograph written from inside the Salvation Army on what a corps is ecclesiologically, prompted, on its own account, by a first century 'too busily involved in its evangelistic mission' to ask what its own nature was within the church universal. It takes up, from within the tradition, the question of whether the Army is a church, making the case for the corps's own ecclesial standing, where Taylor's later study takes the same question up at greater length and more critically. Assumes some familiarity with Salvationist practice and vocabulary.

Taylor, David. *Like a Mighty Army? The Salvation Army, the Church, and the Churches*. Eugene, OR: Pickwick, 2014.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A monograph-length study of whether the Salvation Army is a church, and of its relations with the churches ecumenically, substantially longer than Needham's 1987 treatment of the same question from within the tradition. It examines the Army's position as a founding member of the World Council of Churches alongside its long reluctance to call itself a church outright, pursuing that question at greater length than Needham and from a more ecumenical vantage. Assumes some acquaintance with ecumenical theology.

New Churches and the Inherited Church

Parish Church

See also the lists on Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy, Fresh Expressions of Church, and Revitalisation and Replanting.

The parish is not a church tradition but a way of understanding the Church, and in the Church of England it stands in contention with the culture of church planting. In that Church's own account it has existed in parishes, 'local geographical units with a parish church', and 'each parish or group of parishes has a parish priest', who 'gives pastoral support to the people of the parish'. This reading list holds the books in which the contention is argued, with two questions that belong beside it: how a parish that already exists is renewed, and why parishes stop growing.

The word is used here in three senses: the Church of England's parish, the Roman Catholic parish that some of the books set out to renew, and, in recent American writing, the neighbourhood in which a congregation puts down roots.

The principal question is whether the parish is a theological necessity that planting and fresh expressions put at risk, or one practice of a principle that other forms of church can also serve. Andrew Davison and Alison Milbank take the first view; Will Foulger takes the second.

The question of why parishes stop growing is older than fresh expressions. In 1974 David Wasdell took a report to the Church of England's synod on what he called the 'self-limiting structure of religious congregations'.

This reading list opens with *Start Here*, then *The Case for the Parish*, *Planting Within the Parish System*, *Renewing a Parish* and *Why Parishes Stop Growing*.

START HERE

Croft, Steven, ed. *Mission-Shaped Questions: Defining Issues for Today's Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2008.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church

A collection of essays responding to *Mission-Shaped Church*. A mixed collection, but Croft's own two — opening and closing — are well worth reading: the first argues for loosening Anglican structures to make room for planting and fresh expressions, the last reflects on what it means to be church in a missionary context. John Drane's essay on what maturity looks like for emerging churches is the other one worth the time.

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Ecclesial Minimum; Church of England Papers and Reports

An influential critique of the fresh expressions movement, from two mainstream Anglicans who defend the parish as theologically necessary. It would be most useful to a reader already persuaded by the movement, since it contests the movement's premise from outside it. Chapter 1, on the relationship between the form of a church and its message, and chapter 3, on the place of the church in salvation, are the significant ones.

Foulger, Will. *Present in Every Place? The Church of England's New Churches, and the Future of the Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Ecclesial Minimum

A study of whether the parish system still delivers what its defenders want from it. Foulger separates the instinct that draws people to the parish, rootedness and presence in a place, from the practice that has carried it, and argues that critics of new churches assume too smooth a move from the one to the other. Drawing on the idea of place as bounded openness, he concludes that presence in place calls for complexity of church form rather than uniform coverage. Developed from his Durham thesis of 2018.

THE CASE FOR THE PARISH

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Milbank, Alison. *The Once and Future Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Resource Churches; Fresh Expressions of Church

Milbank returns to the ground of *For the Parish*, to which this is an explicit sequel, and takes on what has happened since: minster hubs, the Strategic Development Fund and the Emerging Church programme. Her quarrel is on three fronts — ecclesiology, the account of the person these assume, and their reading of secularism.

Sparks, Paul, Tim Soerens and Dwight J. Friesen. *The New Parish: How Neighborhood Churches Are Transforming Mission, Discipleship and Community*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

An argument for the parish as a way of life rather than a legal boundary, set in American neighbourhoods: parish means 'all the relationships (including the land) where the local church lives out its faith together', and a neighbourhood's churches share in it. Faithful presence is its central practice. Part Three, on practice, bears most directly on a church settling into a neighbourhood.

White, Dan, Jr. *Subterranean: Why the Future of the Church Is Rootedness*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2015.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

An argument for congregations that stay rooted in one neighbourhood over the long term, against strategies that measure a church by its numbers, by a co-planter of Axiom Church, a network of neighbourhood communities in Syracuse, New York. It shares the case for staying in one place with Sparks, Soerens and Friesen's *The New Parish*. The first chapter, on what White calls 'the numbers leash', sets out the critique.

PLANTING WITHIN THE PARISH SYSTEM

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

Croft, Steven, ed. *Mission-Shaped Questions: Defining Issues for Today's Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2008.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Croft, Steven, ed. *The Future of the Parish System: Shaping the Church of England for the Twenty-first Century*. London: Church House Publishing, 2006.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

A collection of essays by 12 contributors on what church planting and fresh expressions of church mean for the parish system of the Church of England; its own description gives its aim as 'to resource debate and reflection on the development of the parish system alongside and together with fresh expressions of church life'. Rowan Williams writes on a theology of church and mission built around shared encounter with Jesus, George Lings on how fresh expressions sit within an Anglican framework, and Steven Croft, the editor, on training for mission and ministry.

Davison, Andrew, Anna Matthews, Alison Milbank, Philip North, Gemma Simmonds, Ric Thorpe and Rowan Williams. *God's Church in the World: The Gift of Catholic Mission*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Missiology

A collection on Catholic mission and evangelism whose contributors include Alison Milbank, co-author with Andrew Davison of *For the Parish* (2010), a critique of fresh expressions, and Ric Thorpe, a leading figure in the Church of England's resource church strategy as Bishop of Islington. It brings writers from opposite sides of that church's argument over planting into one volume.

Dunlop, Andrew. 'Catholicity and Connection: An Ecclesiological Framework for the Mixed Ecology Discerned through Research in an Anglican Team Ministry'. PhD thesis, University of Roehampton, 2025. <https://pure.roehampton.ac.uk/portal/en/studentTheses/catholicity-and-connection>.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Rural and Market Towns; Ecclesiology; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A doctoral thesis that builds an ecclesiological framework for the mixed ecology from theological action research with the Lordsbridge Team of Churches, an Anglican team ministry of 11 village parishes west of Cambridge. Its question is what holds a mixed ecology of inherited congregations and fresh expressions together, and Dunlop answers with five 'instincts': missio-ecclesiology, in line with Rowan Williams's theology; a missional understanding of pastoral care; interconnection between communities; catholicity, which values ecclesiastical diversity; and a Christ-centredness that unifies the whole.

Foulger, Will. *Present in Every Place? The Church of England's New Churches, and the Future of the Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Lockley, Philip. 'Church Planting and the Parish in Durham Diocese, 1970–1990: Church Growth Controversies in Recent Historical Perspective'. *Journal of Anglican Studies* 16, no. 2 (2018): 103–27.

ALSO IN Anglican

A journal article recovering the Church of England's first modern church planting scheme: the restructuring of parish ministry in Chester-le-Street, near Durham, in the 1970s and 1980s, with its rapid growth, its decline and an evangelical church's strained relations with its liberal bishop, David Jenkins. Lockley reads the episode as bearing on today's disputes over fresh expressions and planting, and argues that liberals and conservatives in Anglican ecclesiology need to overcome their mistrust of each other. A historical case study rather than an argument from principle, it gives the parish debate a precedent from before *Breaking New Ground* (1994).

Orr-Ewing, Frog. 'Rev. Thomas Joseph Gaster: An Urban Missionary in Historical and Theological Context'. PhD thesis, King's College London, 2018. https://cte.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/01/Rev_Thomas_Joseph_Gaster_An_Urban_Missio.pdf.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Anglican

A doctoral thesis on Victorian Anglican church planting in London, built round the ministry of Thomas Joseph Gaster and the founding of All Saints Peckham. Its argument is that Gaster drew on the models of mission he had worked with in India under the Church Missionary Society and reapplied them to the growing communities of late Victorian Britain, a fusion of parish and mission that Orr-Ewing calls the new parochialism and traces well beyond this one parish. Orr-Ewing was himself vicar of All Saints Peckham from 2003. The full text is given away by Churches Together in England.

RENEWING A PARISH

Huntley, Ron, and James Mallon. *Unlocking Your Parish: Making Disciples, Raising Up Leaders with Alpha*. Frederick, MD: The Word Among Us Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Alpha Course and Church Planting; Practical Guides

A book on Alpha as the means of renewing a Catholic parish, drawn from Saint Benedict Parish in Halifax, Nova Scotia, where Huntley served on the senior leadership team alongside Mallon. A practical outworking of Mallon's *Divine Renovation*, it argues that evangelisation shapes the whole culture of a parish, from outreach to sacramental life, and takes up the logistical questions that arise after a first or second course. Written for parishes considering Alpha as well as those already running it.

Jackson, Bob. *Leading One Church at a Time: From Multi-Church Ministers to Focal Ministers*. Leadership 34. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2018.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Practical Guides

A Grove booklet arguing that a shrinking clergy should lead one church each, not several, replacing the multi-parish incumbent with a 'focal minister' – paid or unpaid, lay or ordained – set at the centre of a single congregation. Where Jackson's earlier, data-led studies ask what drives numerical growth, this is a short policy argument for restructuring ministry itself, citing early evidence from the Diocese of St Davids. Written for diocesan and deanery leaders reviewing multi-parish arrangements; the term itself is defined on page 3.

Mallon, James. *Divine Renovation: Bringing Your Parish from Maintenance to Mission*. New London, CT: Twenty-Third Publications, 2014.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Church Growth; Revitalisation and Replanting; Theory of Change

A book by a Catholic parish priest in Halifax, Nova Scotia, drawn from the renewal he led in his own parish. It argues that a parish moves from maintenance to mission when it stops being a membership-based community and becomes an assembly of disciples who proclaim and share the good news.

Thorlby, Tim. *A Time to Sow: Anglican Catholic Church Growth in London*. Research for the Local Church 9. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2017. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2017-Time-To-Sow.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report by Tim Thorlby for the Centre for Theology and Community, the sequel to his *Love, Sweat and Tears* on evangelical church planting in east London. It tells the stories of seven Anglo-Catholic parishes in the dioceses of London and Southwark, most in poorer areas, that had grown over the previous five years, from both wings of that tradition, and draws from them habits of growth: welcome, accessible worship with depth, work with children, new service times, community ministry and clergy focused on growth. Its four closing challenges include the scarcity of Anglo-Catholic church planting. It documents growth in a tradition the planting literature seldom covers.

Warren, Robert. *The Healthy Churches' Handbook: A Process for Revitalizing Your Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004.

ALSO IN Revitalisation and Replanting; Church Growth; Anglican; Practical Guides

A handbook setting out seven marks of a healthy church, each a contrast, such as energised by faith rather than just keeping things going, with a process by which a congregation reviews itself against them, from a detailed review to a single evening. It treats health in qualitative terms rather than as numerical growth. The Diocese of Southwark uses the marks to frame visits to every parish by its bishops and archdeacons. The chapter 'The angel of the church' concerns a congregation's character, buildings, setting and story.

WHY PARISHES STOP GROWING

Lings, George. 'Learning from the Work of David Wasdell'. Slides for the Inter-Diocesan Learning Community. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, 2015.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The slides of a talk by George Lings of Church Army's Research Unit to the Inter-Diocesan Learning Community in 2015, returning to David Wasdell's reports of 1974 and 1975. They chart Wasdell's figures, in which a church with one priest levels off at an average congregation of about 175 whatever the parish's population, set the figures for 2011 beside them, and record the response: the first report 'was noted', and Wasdell's contract for the second part was terminated. They end with questions for dioceses about fresh expressions of church.

Wasdell, David. 'The Evolution of Missionary Congregations'. *International Review of Mission* 66, no. 264 (October 1977): 366-72.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article in the World Council of Churches' *International Review of Mission* by the Church of England priest who founded the Urban Church Project. Unlike his *Let My People Grow!* (1974) and *Divide and Conquer* (1975), which the project published, it appeared in an international journal of mission.

Wasdell, David. *Divide and Conquer*. London: Urban Church Project, 1975.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Cities and Urban Areas; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The Urban Church Project's second report, dated June 1975. George Lings records that Wasdell's contract for a second part had been terminated, and calls this report 'unauthorised'. In Lings's account it argues that growth by adding members to existing congregations is 'self-defeating', because a group loses the quality of life that sustains it as it grows, and that the alternative is 'growth by multiplication' of small units. Lings sums up the two reports' conclusion as 'The Parish System is fatally flawed'.

Wasdell, David. *Let My People Grow!* London: Urban Church Project, 1974.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Cities and Urban Areas; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The first report of the Urban Church Project, which Wasdell founded and directed, taken to General Synod in November 1974. As George Lings's slides of 2015 present it, the report analyses Church of England parishes by population, attendance and 'penetration', the share of a parish attending, and argues that no redeployment of clergy can produce growth; Lings quotes from p. 7 its contrast between 'a gospel of grace available to all' and 'a structure which takes the form of a club with limited membership'.

Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

See also the lists on Fresh Expressions of Church, Parish Church and Anglican.

Two names for one arrangement: parish churches and new forms of church, among them church plants, fresh expressions and pioneer ministries, held together within one church rather than set against each other. 'Mixed economy' was coined by the Archbishop of Wales between 1999 and 2002, who found signs of hope 'in the development of a mixed economy of Church life', with 'ways of being church alongside the inherited parochial pattern'. The Church of England's report on fresh expressions of 2004 took it up, calling for 'a mixed economy of parish churches and network churches'. 'Mixed ecology' is the later term. When the Archbishop of York set out the Church of England's priorities to General Synod in November 2021, one of the three was to be 'a church where mixed ecology is the norm'.

The principal question is whether the two can be held together without loss to either. Andrew Davison and Alison Milbank hold that the parish is theologically necessary, and critique fresh expressions from that ground. On the other side, Ed Olsworth-Peter writes of parishes and new communities 'co-growing' for one another's health, and Andrew Dunlop, from research in one Cambridgeshire team ministry, proposes five shared 'instincts' that hold a mixed ecology together, catholicity among them.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Holding the Two Together and The Objection.

START HERE

Olsworth-Peter, Ed. *Mixed Ecology: Inhabiting an Integrated Church*. London: SPCK, 2024.

ALSO IN Anglican; Fresh Expressions of Church

The book of the policy: what it means for parishes, fresh expressions, plants and pioneer ministries to be one church rather than parallel systems, after the Archbishop of York made mixed ecology one of the Church of England's three priorities in November 2021. Olsworth-Peter was the Church of England's national adviser for pioneer development and by publication had moved to St Mellitus as director of innovation and development. He takes the argument to gathered, digital and hybrid forms together.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *Exploring the Mixed Ecology: How Different Churches Belong Together*. Church Multiplication 3. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Anglican; Ecclesial Minimum

A booklet exploring the biblical and theological underpinnings of 'mixed ecology', the term the Church of England adopted in 2021 for established congregations and newer forms of church held together in one body, and tracing how it grew from the 'mixed economy' of *Mission-shaped Church* (2004). It reads the idea through the body of Christ in 1 Corinthians 12 and the household of God, and sets out the challenges an ecological ecclesiology raises for those who lead within it. Selvaratnam was on the working group that wrote the Church of England's Vision and Strategy for the 2020s, which adopted the term.

HOLDING THE TWO TOGETHER

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Anglican; Parish Church

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

Croft, Steven, ed. *Mission-Shaped Questions: Defining Issues for Today's Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2008.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Parish Church; Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church

A collection of essays responding to *Mission-Shaped Church*. A mixed collection, but Croft's own two — opening and closing — are well worth reading: the first argues for loosening Anglican structures to make room for planting and fresh expressions, the last reflects on what it means to be church in a missionary context. John Drane's essay on what maturity looks like for emerging churches is the other one worth the time.

Croft, Steven, ed. *The Future of the Parish System: Shaping the Church of England for the Twenty-first Century*. London: Church House Publishing, 2006.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Parish Church

A collection of essays by 12 contributors on what church planting and fresh expressions of church mean for the parish system of the Church of England; its own description gives its aim as 'to resource debate and reflection on the development of the parish system alongside and together with fresh expressions of church life'. Rowan Williams writes on a theology of church and mission built around shared encounter with Jesus, George Lings on how fresh expressions sit within an Anglican framework, and Steven Croft, the editor, on training for mission and ministry.

Dunlop, Andrew. 'Catholicity and Connection: An Ecclesiological Framework for the Mixed Ecology Discerned through Research in an Anglican Team Ministry'. PhD thesis, University of Roehampton, 2025. <https://pure.roehampton.ac.uk/portal/en/studentTheses/catholicity-and-connection>.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns; Ecclesiology; Parish Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A doctoral thesis that builds an ecclesiological framework for the mixed ecology from theological action research with the Lordsbridge Team of Churches, an Anglican team ministry of 11 village parishes west of Cambridge. Its question is what holds a mixed ecology of inherited congregations and fresh expressions together, and Dunlop answers with five 'instincts': missio-ecclesiology, in line with Rowan Williams's theology; a missional understanding of pastoral care; interconnection between communities; catholicity, which values ecclesiastical diversity; and a Christ-centredness that unifies the whole.

Foulger, Will. *Present in Every Place? The Church of England's New Churches, and the Future of the Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Parish Church; Ecclesial Minimum

A study of whether the parish system still delivers what its defenders want from it. Foulger separates the instinct that draws people to the parish, rootedness and presence in a place, from the practice that has carried it, and argues that critics of new churches assume too smooth a move from the one to the other. Drawing on the idea of place as bounded openness, he concludes that presence in place calls for complexity of church form rather than uniform coverage. Developed from his Durham thesis of 2018.

General Synod of the Church of England. *GS 2142: A Mission-Shaped Church and Fresh Expressions 15 Years On*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2019. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/gs-2142-mission-shaped-church.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church

A five-page report put to General Synod in July 2019, 15 years after *Mission-Shaped Church*. It describes fresh expressions and pioneering as a new missionary movement affecting mission practices, ecclesiology, theology, leadership, resources and structures, and carries a motion about work in 10 dioceses. It quotes the more flattering of Church Army's two estimates of who attends a fresh expression, without the caveat Church Army itself attached to it. Of the 'mixed or blended economy' it says only that it 'is important and calls for different expressions of church to recognise and resource one another through an integrated approach'.

Olsworth-Peter, Ed. *Mixed Ecology: Inhabiting an Integrated Church*. London: SPCK, 2024.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Perrin, Ruth, and Ed Olsworth-Peter. *The Mixed Ecologists: Experiences of Mixed Ecology Ministry in the Church of England*. Living Ministry Focussed Study 2. London: Church of England Ministry Council, 2021. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2021-05/focussed-study-2-the-mixed-ecologists.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Church of England Papers and Reports

A Church of England research report from the Living Ministry programme, based on interviews with 17 parish clergy about combining pioneering initiatives with inherited or gathered forms of church within a single post. It names time, team and tenacity as what a flourishing mixed ecology needs, and follows this through five themed sections: the culture that enables it, how old and new forms interact, releasing leaders, clergy wellbeing, and the effect of the Covid-19 pandemic. Mixed ecology, it notes, is now the Church of England's stated norm rather than an exception.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *Exploring the Mixed Ecology: How Different Churches Belong Together*. Church Multiplication 3. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Sumpter, Tim. *Freshly Expressed Church: Lessons from Fresh Expressions for the Wider Church*. Evangelism 109. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2015.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A Grove booklet in the Evangelism series, addressed not to those starting a fresh expression but to the established congregations around them. It argues that existing churches have much to learn from the missional values and methods of fresh expressions, and sets out how a congregation might examine and renew its own evangelism in response. Where most writing on the mixed ecology argues for holding parish and fresh expression together, this booklet asks what the one learns from the other.

THE OBJECTION

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Parish Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Ecclesial Minimum; Church of England Papers and Reports

An influential critique of the fresh expressions movement, from two mainstream Anglicans who defend the parish as theologically necessary. It would be most useful to a reader already persuaded by the movement, since it contests the movement's premise from outside it. Chapter 1, on the relationship between the form of a church and its message, and chapter 3, on the place of the church in salvation, are the significant ones.

Milbank, Alison. *The Once and Future Parish*. London: SCM Press, 2023.

ALSO IN Anglican; Parish Church; Resource Churches; Fresh Expressions of Church

Milbank returns to the ground of *For the Parish*, to which this is an explicit sequel, and takes on what has happened since: minster hubs, the Strategic Development Fund and the Emerging Church programme. Her quarrel is on three fronts — ecclesiology, the account of the person these assume, and their reading of secularism.

Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments

See also the lists on Anglo-Catholic, Pentecostal and Ecclesiology.

Worship, its forms of public prayer and the sacraments, above all the Lord's Supper, as they bear on new churches. The books are of two kinds: studies of what new congregations do when they worship, and theology of worship and the sacraments, which includes a study of worship across the churches written in 1936 and two cases for a sacramental view from Pentecostal and evangelical writers.

Two questions run through this reading list. The first is whether a church's forms of worship are a vehicle, to be chosen for the people a new church hopes to reach, or whether they form those who use them. None of the books here argues the first view; they take the second from different starting points, among them Winfield Bevins's account of younger Christians drawn to creed and sacrament, and Joshua Cockayne's argument that doctrine cannot be separated from how it is prayed.

The second question arises in the Church of England, whose canons provide that no one shall 'consecrate and administer the holy sacrament of the Lord's Supper' who has not been ordained priest. A new community led by lay people may not, therefore, celebrate the sacrament on its own authority, and Cockayne's survey of the leaders of new communities records what they do.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Liturgy and Formation and Sacraments.

START HERE

Bevins, Winfield. *Ever Ancient, Ever New: The Allure of Liturgy for a New Generation*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2019.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

An account of younger Christians from non-liturgical backgrounds who have moved towards creedal and sacramental worship, built on two years of fieldwork across the United States, Canada and England. It calls the communities it found neo-liturgical: Baptist, Methodist and non-denominational churches blending contemporary worship with Word and Table. Leslie Michele, reviewing it for Christians for Social Action, objects that the churches studied are all white-centred.

Cockayne, Joshua. *The Communion Dilemma: The Challenges of Leading Eucharistic New Things*. Durham: Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Communion+Dilemma+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Ecclesiology; Ecclesial Minimum

A report surveying the leaders of 63 new communities in 20 Church of England dioceses, and by its own account the only current data on their eucharistic practice. Cockayne sets out three responses — not celebrating, celebrating with authorised liturgy and an ordained president, or celebrating without authorisation — and concludes that 'the communion dilemma is a loser's game', urging that liturgical reform be joined to the Church's aim of 10,000 new worshipping communities. Only nine of the 63 never celebrated communion.

LITURGY AND FORMATION

Bevins, Winfield. *Ever Ancient, Ever New: The Allure of Liturgy for a New Generation*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2019.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Bevins, Winfield. *Liturgical Mission: The Work of the People for the Life of the World*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2022.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

Bevins argues that the church's liturgical and sacramental life is itself missional, against the habit of setting worship and mission against each other, and offers the historic practices as a framework for everyday discipleship. Foreword by Justo González. The publisher addresses it both to Christians outside liturgical traditions and to those already within them.

Cockayne, Joshua. *What Does Liturgy Have to Do with Doctrine?* Doctrine 9. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2022.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A Grove booklet arguing that the church's liturgies form those who take part in them, so that anyone who cares about doctrine has to care how it is prayed. Cockayne is director of mission and evangelism at Cranmer Hall, Durham, and co-edited *New Churches: A Theology* with Will Foulger.

Croft, Steven, and Ian Mobsby, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2009. American edition, with Stephanie Spellers, New York: Seabury Books, 2010.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Church of England Papers and Reports; Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesial Minimum

An edited volume on what a mission-shaped church looks like when it is rooted in sacramental tradition rather than set against it, written by pioneers, leaders and theologians from Britain and the United States. Contributors include Rowan Williams, Brian McLaren, Stephen Cottrell, Richard Giles and Phyllis Tickle. The American edition of 2010 adds Stephanie Spellers as a third editor and a foreword by Katharine Jefferts Schori. In the argument over fresh expressions it takes the side opposite Davison and Milbank's *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions* (2010).

Underhill, Evelyn. *Worship*. London: Nisbet, 1936.

A study of Christian worship by Evelyn Underhill, written for the Library of Constructive Theology. Part I treats the nature of worship, and Part II takes its traditions in turn, from Jewish to Anglican. Joshua Cockayne lists it among the readings for his introductory course on church planting.

SACRAMENTS

Green, Chris E. W. *Toward a Pentecostal Theology of the Lord's Supper: Foretasting the Kingdom*. Cleveland, TN: CPT Press, 2012.

ALSO IN Pentecostal; Ecclesiology

A monograph, the published form of Green's Bangor doctoral thesis, on the Lord's Supper in Pentecostal theology. From early Pentecostal periodicals of both the Wesleyan-Holiness and Finished Work streams it retrieves a high view of the sacraments, then reads three biblical texts to argue that Christ is 'really, personally, and bodily present' in the Supper through the Spirit. Jason Goroncy (2013) finds its untranslated Latin and Greek a barrier for some readers.

Smith, Gordon T. *Evangelical, Sacramental and Pentecostal: Why the Church Should Be All Three*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2017.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A short book arguing that the church should be evangelical, sacramental and pentecostal at once, because word, sacrament and the Spirit's presence are three dimensions of one grace rather than rival emphases, drawing on John 15:4, Luke–Acts, Calvin and Wesley. It is addressed to evangelicals: Robert Cornwall (2017) commends it to them as a remedy for the sterility of a church centred on the word alone.

Settings

Cities and Urban Areas

See also the lists on Estates and Poorer Communities, Rural and Market Towns, and Buildings, Venues and Space.

This reading list is on the city as a setting for mission and church planting: what theology makes of the city, and how churches are planted in it. The poorest urban neighbourhoods, and above all the housing estates, have a list of their own.

The principal difference is over where to begin. Timothy Keller argues for the city from mercy as well as strategy: it is 'a refuge for people without power', and it is where culture is made, so that 'if you win the city and you ignore the countryside, you've won the culture'. In his account, Redeemer's planting across New York was possible only because it began in Manhattan, the city centre. His critics ask whom that strategy reaches, and whether an argument drawn from Manhattan holds in other cities. Others begin in the poorest neighbourhoods, moving in and staying, as Urban Expression's teams have done in Britain since 1997 and Ash Barker's family did in a Bangkok slum.

A second argument concerns how a city is reached: by one congregation growing larger, or by more congregations. The case for multiplication was made in England in the 1970s, from evidence that a congregation with one priest levels off as it grows, and it is made again from Birmingham, where churches plant together rather than build one large congregation.

A question shared by the books on planting is whether to carry a model into the city or to shape the church to it. Several warn against suburban or borrowed models and ask the planter to learn a city's cultures and districts first.

This list opens with Start Here, then A Theology of the City and Planting in a City.

START HERE

Conn, Harvie M., and Manuel Ortiz. *Urban Ministry: The Kingdom, the City and the People of God*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2001.

A book on urban ministry in six parts, two of which take church growth and planting in the city and community development among the poor. Both authors taught at Westminster Theological Seminary: Conn after 12 years in Korea, and Ortiz, who founded churches and schools in Chicago, Philadelphia and Puerto Rico. Mark Pickett's review of *Center Church* observes that 'Keller owes much to Harvie Conn', and cites this book for Keller's reading of the city in the Bible.

Keller, Timothy. *Why God Made Cities*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2013. Adapted from the sermon 'The Problem of the City', Redeemer Presbyterian Church, 7 November 1993.

A short ebook, adapted from a sermon Keller preached at Redeemer Presbyterian Church in 1993, setting out a biblical case for the city: God invented it, sin has twisted it, and he sends his people into it 'to love, to preach, to identify, and to bless'. The case is cultural as well as evangelistic, since the city is where 'the media and education and scholarship and science and the arts and business are all based'.

Kilpin, Juliet. *Urban to the Core: Motives for Incarnational Mission*. Kibworth Beauchamp: Matador, 2013.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Pioneering; Women in Church Planting

A multi-voiced book, compiled by Kilpin, of reflections from some of the hundred or so people who had joined Urban Expression teams in Britain's urban neighbourhoods, setting out the motives behind the network's first years. Kilpin, a Baptist minister, led its first team with Jim Kilpin, planting a congregation in Shadwell, east London, in 1997, and later coordinated Urban Expression in Britain. Much of the book is the team members' own account rather than hers.

A THEOLOGY OF THE CITY

Greenway, Roger S., and Timothy M. Monsma. *Cities: Missions' New Frontier*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1989.

A book on urban mission that sets out a biblical case, with Antioch as its model of urban church development, beside practical chapters on immigrant and ethnic ministry, the urban poor, street people and pastoring a city. Keller's *Why God Made Cities* quotes its account of the world to come as 'an urban world', from the printing of 2000.

Keller, Timothy. *Center Church: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Presbyterian and Reformed; Introductions and Overviews

A comprehensive overview of church planting theology and theory, set out as what Keller calls a theological vision for ministry in the city, by the founding pastor of Redeemer Presbyterian Church in New York and founding president of City to City. Its first part shows how the gospel drives planting and renews church and planter; the second, on the city, has a careful section on contextualisation and substantial sections on the place of the city in any planting strategy. It is long and demanding, but deeply thoughtful, and an excellent framework for urban planting.

Keller, Timothy. *Gospel-Centered City Ministry: The City to City DNA*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2023. <https://redeemercitytocity.com/dna>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A collection of 18 white papers, each with a companion video, in which Keller sets out the ideas behind Redeemer City to City's work, in five groups. Those on the city supplement *Center Church* rather than abridge it, adding urban theory that Keller says the book largely lacks. Part 18 sets out the dynamics and markers of a gospel movement.

Keller, Timothy. *Why God Made Cities*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2013. Adapted from the sermon 'The Problem of the City', Redeemer Presbyterian Church, 7 November 1993.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Christian Witness to Large Cities. Lausanne Occasional Paper 9. Mini-consultation on Reaching Large Cities, Consultation on World Evangelization, Pattaya, 16-27 June 1980. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 1980. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/lop-9>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement

The report of Lausanne's mini-consultation on reaching large cities, held at Pattaya in June 1980 and chaired by Raymond Bakke. Its recommendations for Latin America included a manual on 'the varied alternative church planting methods', a good indication of where the evangelical conversation about cities stood in 1980. LOP 37 superseded it as a statement, but the earlier paper is the one that set the terms: LOP 37 itself dates 'a fresh missiological movement with the large cities of the world' to Pattaya in 1980.

Pickett, Mark. 'Review Article: Constructing Theological Vision'. Review of *Center Church: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*, by Timothy Keller. *Foundations*, no. 64 (Spring 2013): 98-111. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-64/issue-64-article-5-review-article-constructing-theological-vision/>.

A review article on Timothy Keller's *Center Church* by Mark Pickett, lecturer in missiology at the Wales Evangelical School of Theology. Pickett sets out Keller's case for holding institution and movement together, but is 'not convinced' that density is a city's essence, and suspects that Manhattan's wealth and power overawe visitors from other cities into copying Redeemer. He urges readers to construct a theological vision of their own for their own place.

Rogers, Cris. *Positive Urban Theology: Finding God in the Grit and Glory of the City*. London: CCX, 2026.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

A book, 'part lived experience and part reframed theological framework' in its publisher's words, on God's presence on the housing estate, by the rector of All Hallows Bow in east London, where Rogers has served since 2010. He set out the argument of its title in a talk of 2023, 'Towards a positive urban estate theology', faulting urban theology that describes estates only by 'deprivation, poverty, hopelessness' and describing them as places of 'untapped urban leaders who speak the local language'.

Smith, Glenn. *Towards the Transformation of Our Cities/Regions*. Lausanne Occasional Paper 37. Issue Group 8, 2004 Forum for World Evangelization, Pattaya. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 2005. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/towards-transformation-citiesregions-lop-37>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement

A paper from Lausanne's 2004 Forum at Pattaya, the successor to LOP 9 and a much larger undertaking: some 30 urban practitioners from 25 cities on six continents, with case studies from Melbourne, the Philippines, Hyderabad, central Java and Seattle. Where LOP 9 spoke of evangelising large cities, this speaks of transforming them, and the two together show how far the evangelical account of the city moved in a quarter of a century.

Stark, Rodney. *Cities of God: The Real Story of How Christianity Became an Urban Movement and Conquered Rome*. San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 2006.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A companion to Stark's *The Rise of Christianity* (1996), narrowing that book's model of network-driven conversion specifically to the empire's cities: a hypothesis tested against data gathered from 31 major Roman urban centres, with a data appendix. Where the earlier book modelled the overall growth curve across the empire, this one argues that growth is concentrated in, and explained by, its densely networked cities. Quantitative and empire-wide rather than urban-theological, it sits closer to historical sociology than to planting practice.

Um, Stephen T., and Justin Buzzard. *Why Cities Matter: To God, the Culture, and the Church*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2013.

A short book, with a foreword by Timothy Keller, moving from the characteristics of cities and the Bible's view of them to contextualisation and what it calls a ministry vision for the city. Um was based in Boston and Buzzard led Garden City Church in Silicon Valley. One reviewer reads it as an attempt to make *Center Church* more accessible; another finds its last chapter almost a summary of it. Leslie Brown, in *Modern Reformation* (2013), finds it written for young, upwardly mobile professionals and passing over the working poor. In 2021, according to his church's own statement, Um resigned as pastor of Citylife Presbyterian Church in Boston after a church disciplinary process.

Villafañe, Eldin. *Seek the Peace of the City: Reflections on Urban Ministry*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995.

A book on urban ministry by an Assemblies of God minister who founded Gordon-Conwell's Center for Urban Ministerial Education in Boston and directed it from 1976 to 1990. Villafañe calls the churches not to retreat from the city, drawing on the social sciences as well as theology, and the volume includes chapters by Douglas Hall, Efrain Agosto and Bruce W. Jackson, with a foreword by Harvey Cox. It was among the books recommended in The Gospel Coalition's 2016 survey of 20 pastors on what church planters should read.

PLANTING IN A CITY

Barker, Ash. *Slum Life Rising: How to Enflesh Hope Within a New Urban World*. Melbourne: UNOH Publishing, 2012.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

A book by Ash Barker, written out of the years from 2002 in which he and his family lived in Klong Toey, Bangkok's largest slum, with Urban Neighbours of Hope, the community he had co-founded in Melbourne in 1993. Since 2014 he has lived and worked in Winson Green, in inner-city Birmingham, where Newbigin House, which he founded, has started two local congregations.

Benesh, Sean. *The Bikeable Church: A Bicyclist's Guide to Church Planting*. Portland, OR: Urban Loft Publishers, 2015.

ALSO IN Pioneering

A short book, written from Portland, Oregon, on church planting in a city organised around the bicycle rather than the car: bike culture, cycling infrastructure and proximity as forces on where and how a church is planted. By its publisher's own account it rests on 'stories, antics, and slightly questionable research', and it is written for cyclists and ordinary planters rather than for scholars. Dan Herford, reviewing an earlier printing, credits it with naming a group, cyclists, that churches have failed to accommodate.

Bergquist, Linda, and Michael D. Crane. *City Shaped Churches: Planting Churches in a Global Era*. Skyforest, CA: Urban Loft Publishers, 2018.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Church Planting Movements

A book in 23 chapters arguing that planters should not carry suburban models into cities but shape each church to its city, drawing on demographic and ethnographic research and attending to populations churches overlook, such as night workers and undocumented immigrants. The authors' own failed plant in San Francisco in the 1990s is one case. Stephen Mark Davis's review finds it 'a patchwork of collected essays' with overlapping chapters. Bergquist has worked in church planting for over 30 years; Crane helped to launch the Gospel City Network in Southeast Asia.

Carter, Matt, and Darrin Patrick. *For the City: Proclaiming and Living Out the Gospel*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2011.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A book in two parts by two American planters. In the first each tells how he started his church: Carter's Austin Stone Community Church in Austin, Texas, and Patrick's The Journey in St Louis. In the second they write on topics such as contextualisation and suffering, using their own failures as warnings. Its concern is a church that exists for its city rather than for its own survival. Where Keller's *Planting a Church in the City* states principles, this works from two planters' experience.

Davis, Stephen M. *Urban Church Planting: Journey into a World of Depravity, Density, and Diversity*. Eugene, OR: Resource Publications, 2019.

A short practitioner's account of planting in the city by an American pastor, professor and planter. Drawing on his own successes and failures, Davis prepares planters emotionally as well as practically for urban ministry, treating depravity, density and diversity as the marks of the city. Ian Williamson's review, filed beside it in this list, values its honesty but regrets the lack of a chapter on training indigenous leaders.

Evans, Ray. *Ready, Steady, Grow: Equipping Today's Gospel Churches*. London: IVP, 2014.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A practical guide to leading a church through growth, by a pastor of four decades in Bedford. Its case is that many leaders 'have learned how to lead what they have, but they don't know how to take it forward', and it sets out, stage by stage, what changes as a congregation grows. Neil Powell's review, filed beside it in this list, argues for growth by planting further congregations rather than by growing one larger.

Greenway, Roger S., and Timothy M. Monsma. *Cities: Missions' New Frontier*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1989.

ANNOTATED under A Theology of the City

Hayes, John B. *Sub-merge: Living Deep in a Shallow World; Service, Justice and Contemplation Among the World's Poor*. Ventura, CA: Regal Books, 2006.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities

A book by John Hayes, founder of InnerCHANGE, which calls itself 'a Christian order among the marginalized'. Hayes asks Christians to go beneath 'the consumer mirage of status, style, spending, and speed' and to live among the poor, taking Francis of Assisi as a model, and argues that too few do so, for too short a time, without the structures that would sustain them.

Keller, Timothy. *Planting a Church in the City*. Manuals and Papers AR 18. New York: Redeemer Presbyterian Church, 2010. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/planting-a-church-in-the-city/>.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Presbyterian and Reformed

A short paper, first published in *The Movement Newsletter* in 2004, setting out five principles for starting a church, from locating, which means living among the people to be reached, to launching, from the top down or the bottom up. Its publisher introduces them as principles common to any church plant. Keller's *Center Church* (2012) treats ministry in the city at book length.

Kilpin, Juliet. *Urban to the Core: Motives for Incarnational Mission*. Kibworth Beauchamp: Matador, 2013.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Nicholls, John. 'Evangelising Our Cities: The Abiding Challenge of Thomas Chalmers'. *Foundations*, no. 44 (May 2000): 21-29. https://www.affinity.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/08/44_21.pdf.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Presbyterian and Reformed

An article on Thomas Chalmers's ministry in Glasgow and Edinburgh from 1816 to 1847 as a model for evangelising the inner city, by John Nicholls of the London City Mission. It sets out Chalmers's district visiting and the Church of Scotland's Church Extension campaign of 1834, which had built 216 new churches by 1840, and asks whether the method survives Lyle Schaller's observation that social networks, not place, now decide who comes to a neighbourhood church.

Powell, Neil, and John James. *Together for the City: How Collaborative Church Planting Leads to Citywide Movements*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

Written out of Birmingham by two pastors who built 2020 Birmingham, arguing that a city is reached not by one church but by churches planting together. Its middle part, on how, carries most of the weight: a core, a cause and a code, out of which collaboration follows rather than standing beside them.

Powell, Neil. 'Review Article: Ready, Steady, Grow'. Review of *Ready, Steady, Grow: Equipping Today's Gospel Churches*, by Ray Evans. *Foundations*, no. 67 (Autumn 2014): 99-104. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-67/issue-67-article-7-review-article-ready-steady-grow-ray-evans/>.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A review article by Neil Powell, pastor of City Church Birmingham, which he co-founded in 1999, on Ray Evans's *Ready, Steady, Grow* (2014) and its case for growing larger churches. Powell does not find the argument compelling. He sets against it the practice of his own church and others in Birmingham, which 'pursue growth through multiple church-planting', and argues that congregations working together reach more people and raise up more leaders than one congregation could.

Rogers, Andrew. *Being Built Together: A Story of New Black Majority Churches in the London Borough of Southwark*. London: University of Roehampton, 2013. <https://www.roehampton.ac.uk/globalassets/documents/humanities/being20built20togethersb203-7-13.pdf>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Buildings, Venues and Space; Africa

A report, written by Andrew Rogers of the University of Roehampton, on the new black majority churches of the London Borough of Southwark, from a partnership with Southwark for Jesus and Churches Together in South London. It identified 252 such churches and estimates more than 240 in operation, over twice as many as all the borough's other churches, with nearly half in one postcode. Its chief practical subject is premises: congregations unable to find buildings the planning system counts as suitable for worship, some meeting in industrial units without permission.

Thompson, J. Allen. *Unique Challenges Facing Urban Church Planters*. Manuals and Papers AR 38. New York: Redeemer Presbyterian Church, 2009. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/unique-challenges-facing-urban-church-planters/>.

ALSO IN Formation and Training

A short paper, excerpted from Thompson's manual *Coaching Urban Church Planters* and written for coaches as well as planters, on the difficulties a city adds to planting, with New York as its case. It groups them under three heads, from the religious climate to the cost of living and ministry, and adds others, among them the turnover of city dwellers, which makes leaders hard to develop.

Thorlby, Tim. *Love, Sweat and Tears: Church Planting in East London*. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2016. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2016-Love-Sweat-and-Tears.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Estates and Poorer Communities; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A report on the church planting from St Paul's Shadwell in east London over the 10 years from 2005 to 2015, with the stories of the five Holy Trinity Brompton network churches involved, all in deprived parishes. The data is very useful: typical Sunday attendance across the five grew tenfold in the decade (p. 86), though four in five regular members had come from other churches. Chapter 9 is excellent on myth-busting, answering nine common criticisms of the planting from a survey of over 500 worshippers and 14 interviews.

Waddell, David. *Divide and Conquer*. London: Urban Church Project, 1975.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Parish Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The Urban Church Project's second report, dated June 1975. George Lings records that Waddell's contract for a second part had been terminated, and calls this report 'unauthorised'. In Lings's account it argues that growth by adding members to existing congregations is 'self-defeating', because a group loses the quality of life that sustains it as it grows, and that the alternative is 'growth by multiplication' of small units. Lings sums up the two reports' conclusion as 'The Parish System is fatally flawed'.

Waddell, David. *Let My People Grow!* London: Urban Church Project, 1974.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Parish Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The first report of the Urban Church Project, which Waddell founded and directed, taken to General Synod in November 1974. As George Lings's slides of 2015 present it, the report analyses Church of England parishes by population, attendance and 'penetration', the share of a parish attending, and argues that no redeployment of clergy can produce growth; Lings quotes from p. 7 its contrast between 'a gospel of grace available to all' and 'a structure which takes the form of a club with limited membership'.

Williamson, Ian. Review of *Urban Church Planting: Journey into a World of Depravity, Density and Diversity*, by Stephen Mark Davis. *Foundations*, no. 75 (Autumn 2018): 98-100. <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-75/issue-75-book-review-3/>.

A book review by Ian Williamson, who planted New Life Church in Middlesbrough, of Stephen Mark Davis's short book of 2018 on planting in cities, drawn from the author's own successes and failures. Williamson values its honesty and its refusal to glamorise the work, but objects to its promotion of bivocational ministry and to the absence of a chapter on raising up indigenous leaders. He judges that, read alongside writing by working-class Christians, it could help change the culture of recruitment, training and support for planting in the UK's 'hard places'.

Estates and Poorer Communities

See also the lists on Cities and Urban Areas, and on Money and Funding.

This reading list is on planting churches and sustaining them among the poor: on England's social housing estates above all, and in poor communities elsewhere. Beside accounts of practice it holds theology, and books on the history, housing and church structures that shape poor places. The city as a whole has a list of its own.

The principal question is who plants and leads a church on an estate. Most of the first-hand accounts here are by incomers who moved into a poor neighbourhood and stayed for many years, and the recent research on estates planting favours that slow way while arguing for leaders from the estates themselves. The other way is to send a team from a larger church into a deprived parish. An evaluation of such planting in east London tests the charge that these churches do not reflect their neighbourhoods, and finds their members whiter and wealthier than the people around them, though diverse.

A second theme runs across writers who otherwise differ: suspicion of help that treats poor people as a set of needs rather than beginning from what they already have.

This list opens with *Start Here*, then *Living and Working Among the Poor*, *Theology, Poverty and Justice*, and *Structures, Housing and Policy*.

START HERE

Corbett, Steve, and Brian Fikkert. *When Helping Hurts: How to Alleviate Poverty Without Hurting the Poor . . . and Yourself*. Chicago: Moody Publishers, 2009.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book by two Christian economists arguing that much church work with the poor does harm because it misdiagnoses poverty, which is broken relationship with God, self, others and creation as well as material lack. Its central distinction is between relief, rehabilitation and development, and it names applying relief where rehabilitation or development is needed as one of the biggest mistakes North American churches make. The framework is applied to short-term mission and microfinance. Theresa Davidson (*Christian Scholar's Review*, 2010) finds that its emphasis on individual development leaves the systemic and legislative causes of poverty unaddressed.

Kilpin, Juliet. *Urban to the Core: Motives for Incarnational Mission*. Kibworth Beauchamp: Matador, 2013.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Cities and Urban Areas; Women in Church Planting

A multi-voiced book, compiled by Kilpin, of reflections from some of the hundred or so people who had joined Urban Expression teams in Britain's urban neighbourhoods, setting out the motives behind the network's first years. Kilpin, a Baptist minister, led its first team with Jim Kilpin, planting a congregation in Shadwell, east London, in 1997, and later coordinated Urban Expression in Britain. Much of the book is the team members' own account rather than hers.

Rogers, Cris. *Listening to the Voice of the Estates Planters: A Report on What Helps Estates Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/Listening-to-Estates-Planters-Report-final-1.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Selecting and Assessing Planters; Formation and Training

A report for CCX, designed and led by Cris Rogers, a Church of England priest who spent 16 years planting and leading a church on a social housing estate. It draws on 45 practitioners, about a third of them from outside the Church of England, and on 450 working-class people asked about training. Its findings favour slow, incarnational models of planting, commitment measured in years and local leadership, and a section asks what success means on an estate. On selection it concludes that the Church's system 'rewards the qualities least needed on estates and undervalues the ones most needed'.

LIVING AND WORKING AMONG THE POOR

Barker, Ash. *Risky Compassion*. ISUM [?], 2014.

A book of stories and reflections from the Barker family's 12 years in the Klong Toey slum of Bangkok, organised around the parable of the Good Samaritan and the risks it asks of those who hear it. Roy Goble's review (2014) credits it with recovering how the parable's first hearers would have heard it.

Barker, Ash. *Slum Life Rising: How to Enflesh Hope Within a New Urban World*. Melbourne: UNOH Publishing, 2012.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A book by Ash Barker, written out of the years from 2002 in which he and his family lived in Klong Toey, Bangkok's largest slum, with Urban Neighbours of Hope, the community he had co-founded in Melbourne in 1993. Since 2014 he has lived and worked in Winson Green, in inner-city Birmingham, where Newbigin House, which he founded, has started two local congregations.

Bishop, Gary. *Darkest England and the Way Back In*. Kibworth Beauchamp: Matador, 2007.

A book framed against William Booth's *In Darkest England and the Way Out* (1890), arguing that the church has abandoned the 'Darkest England' of the poor and must find a way back in. Phil Whittall's review (2009) describes stories, biblical reflection and personal account touching broken families, drug addiction and prostitution, and quotes Bishop's charge that 'materialism and consumerism have slipped unannounced into the Christian community'.

Brown, Wallace, and Mary Brown. *Angels on the Walls: The Risk-Taking Faith That Reclaimed a Community*. Eastbourne: Kingsway, 2000.

An account by Wallace and Mary Brown of their 18 years at St Boniface, Quinton, among three large housing estates on the edge of Birmingham. It turns on the decision to take down the barbed wire and high walls around church and vicarage, and on the daily prayer, after Nehemiah, that God's angels would guard the walls instead. In the book's own description, a small, defensive fellowship became a church able to plant a new congregation in a neighbouring district.

Hayes, John B. *Sub-merge: Living Deep in a Shallow World; Service, Justice and Contemplation Among the World's Poor*. Ventura, CA: Regal Books, 2006.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A book by John Hayes, founder of InnerCHANGE, which calls itself 'a Christian order among the marginalized'. Hayes asks Christians to go beneath 'the consumer mirage of status, style, spending, and speed' and to live among the poor, taking Francis of Assisi as a model, and argues that too few do so, for too short a time, without the structures that would sustain them.

Kilpin, Juliet. *Urban to the Core: Motives for Incarnational Mission*. Kibworth Beauchamp: Matador, 2013.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Lane, Chris. *Ordinary Miracles: Mess, Meals and Meeting Jesus in Unexpected Places*. Watford: Instant Apostle, 2017.

An account of Langworthy Community Church, which Chris Lane and friends planted on the Langworthy estate in Salford, described by the publisher as 'an inner-city estate notorious for crime and deprivation', written after 18 years there. The shared meal is at the centre of the church's practice and of the book's theology: Tom Creedy's review (2018) calls it a book about 'the importance of eating together'.

Thorlby, Tim. *Love, Sweat and Tears: Church Planting in East London*. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2016. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2016-Love-Sweat-and-Tears.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Cities and Urban Areas; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A report on the church planting from St Paul's Shadwell in east London over the 10 years from 2005 to 2015, with the stories of the five Holy Trinity Brompton network churches involved, all in deprived parishes. The data is very useful: typical Sunday attendance across the five grew tenfold in the decade (p. 86), though four in five regular members had come from other churches. Chapter 9 is excellent on myth-busting, answering nine common criticisms of the planting from a survey of over 500 worshippers and 14 interviews.

Woofenden, Anna. *This Is God's Table: Finding Church Beyond the Walls*. Harrisonburg, VA: Herald Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Women in Church Planting

A first-hand account, written as narrative rather than method, of the Garden Church on an empty lot in San Pedro, Los Angeles, where housed and unhoused people farmed together, worshipped and shared a weekly meal. Woofenden was its founding pastor until 2017. Sam Chamelin, reviewing it in the *Englewood Review of Books* (2020), finds the work shown as communal, 'not a celebration of one person's expertise'.

THEOLOGY, POVERTY AND JUSTICE

Ekblad, Bob. *A New Christian Manifesto: Pledging Allegiance to the Kingdom of God*. Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book reading the Lord's Prayer as resistance to the earthly powers and allegiances that keep God's kingdom from coming. Ekblad writes out of Tierra Nueva, the ministry in Washington's Skagit Valley whose two cornerstones are chaplaincy in the county jail and advocacy for migrant farm workers. He argues that people at the margins are the most receptive to becoming agents of the kingdom's transformation, not only its objects, and calls the church to break down the barriers that separate it from them.

Howson, Chris. *A Just Church: 21st Century Liberation Theology in Action*. London: Continuum, 2011.

ALSO IN Missiology; Fresh Expressions of Church

A book, by its priest, on a fresh expression in the centre of Bradford that took liberation theology as its working method: radical forms of worship, experimental forms of community, and non-violent direct action, including resistance to the detention of asylum seekers. Howson sets out an action-reflection cycle of education, action, reflection and sustaining, offered to help other Christians develop a contextual theology of their own.

Morisy, Ann. *Journeying Out: A New Approach to Christian Mission*. London: Continuum, 2006.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book arguing that the community work British churches took on as the welfare state contracted is part of their mission, not a preliminary to it, and that they should offer the chance of spiritual transformation as well as material help. Morisy writes as a community theologian, working across sociology and theology. It first appeared in 2004.

Offutt, Stephen, F. David Bronkema, Krisanne Vaillancourt Murphy, Robb Davis and Gregg Okesson. *Advocating for Justice: An Evangelical Vision for Transforming Systems and Structures*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book by five authors arguing that evangelical compassion has concentrated on relief and neglected advocacy aimed at the systems and structures that produce poverty and injustice. It sets out the nature of social justice concerns, the theological foundations for advocacy and contemporary approaches to practising it.

Rogers, Cris. *Positive Urban Theology: Finding God in the Grit and Glory of the City*. London: CCX, 2026.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A book, 'part lived experience and part reframed theological framework' in its publisher's words, on God's presence on the housing estate, by the rector of All Hallows Bow in east London, where Rogers has served since 2010. He set out the argument of its title in a talk of 2023, 'Towards a positive urban estate theology', faulting urban theology that describes estates only by 'deprivation, poverty, hopelessness' and describing them as places of 'untapped urban leaders who speak the local language'.

Wakefield, Gavin, and Nigel Rooms, eds. *Northern Gospel, Northern Church: Reflections on Identity and Mission*. Durham: Sacristy Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology

An edited collection asking whether there is a distinctively northern way of proclaiming the gospel, and whether the North of England is coherent enough, culturally and theologically, to warrant ministry shaped to the region when the gospel's claim is universal. Its 16 contributors, practitioners and academics, write from settings as different as housing estates and cathedrals.

STRUCTURES, HOUSING AND POLICY

DeYmaz, Mark, and Harry Li. *The Coming Revolution in Church Economics: Why Tithes and Offerings Are No Longer Enough, and What You Can Do about It*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2019.

ALSO IN Money and Funding; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Buildings, Venues and Space

A funding argument rather than an ethnic one: tithes and offerings, DeYmaz and Li argue, are no longer enough to carry a church, which should add a nonprofit arm that can draw grants and a business arm that lets property and starts enterprises. Mosaic, in a low-income part of Little Rock, is the tested case. George Wood's review puts the objections: pastors running businesses they are not trained for, and the tax and employment law that follows.

Hanley, Lynsey. *Estates: An Intimate History*. London: Granta Books, 2017.

A social history of council housing in Britain, first published in 2007 and not a church book, by a writer who grew up on the Chelmsley Wood estate just outside Birmingham. Hanley traces the rise of social housing from a century ago and describes what she calls 'the wall in the head', which separates the people of the estates from the world beyond them. It is context for estates ministry rather than a guide to it.

Jolley, Andy, and Ian Jones. 'Formation for Mission in Urban Britain: The Birmingham Mission Apprentice Scheme'. *Journal of Adult Theological Education* 13, no. 1 (2016): 33-47.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

An article on the Birmingham Mission Apprentice Scheme, in which the Church of England in Birmingham employed lay apprentices for 20 hours a week to take responsibility, under their vicar's supervision, for growing one area of a parish's life. The seven parishes were all highly urbanised: three on outer estates, two multicultural inner-city parishes, and two where most people belonged to a faith other than Christianity.

Rural and Market Towns

See also the lists on Cities and Urban Areas, and on Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy.

This reading list is on planting and sustaining churches in villages, small towns and market towns. Its books come from two countries and describe different places: the American books the small town, and the English work the village and the market town, where a new church starts among parish churches that are already there.

The principal question is whether such places warrant planting. Sally Gaze states the case against in order to answer it: effort concentrated where the population is high would be 'more logical', since 'there is an obvious ceiling on growth in areas of low population', and in that view 'rural places become negligible'. Her reply is that 'the biblical worldview refuses to measure worth by numbers', and her report reads the rural planters' experience as showing that small numbers are 'a deliberate choice for depth'. The American books make a parallel case on missionary grounds: that the small town deserves the missionary attention the city receives.

The second question is how a new congregation relates to the churches already in a small place: whether it adds to their life or competes with them.

This list opens with Start Here, then Planting in Small Places.

START HERE

Bell, James, and Jill Hopkinson. *Shaping Strategies for Mission and Growth in Rural Multi-Church Groups: A Summary of Key Findings and Implications of Recent Research*. Archbishops' Council, 2017. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2017-11/shaping-strategies-for-mission-and-growth-in-rural-multi-church-groups.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Growth

A short report from the Church of England's Archbishops' Council, signed by James Bell, Bishop of Ripon, and Jill Hopkinson, its national rural officer, which draws together *Released for Mission* (2016), the Church Growth Research Programme's *Going Deeper* and George Lings's case for multiplying churches. It sets out six characteristics its sources associate with growth in rural multi-church groups, co-operation within and between groups among them, and names next steps for the groups and for the diocesan strategies that support them.

Gaze, Sally. *Listening to the Voice of Rural Church Planters and Pioneers: A Report on What Helps Rural Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/07/Listening-to-the-Voice-of-Rural-Church-Planters-and-Pioneers-report.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A report for CCX, with Rural Missions and Rural Ministries, on starting churches in rural England, led by Sally Gaze and drawn from 36 practitioners, 18 of them interviewed: 12 from the Church of England and six from free churches. It finds rural plants relational and small by choice, often with more young people than the churches around them, and asks overseers for trust rather than control and for funding matched to small and scattered places. Gaze's theological reflection answers the view that planting belongs where the population is dense.

Morrow, Aaron. *Small Town Mission: A Guide for Mission-Driven Communities*. GCD Books, 2016.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A practical guide to gospel-centred mission in small towns, written for lay people in ordinary jobs and for small-town congregations, on the premise that mission must be a priority locally as well as globally and in cities. Morrow wrote out of ministry in small-town Wisconsin. Where Griggs's *Small Town Jesus* makes the case to pastors and planters, this is addressed to church members; Ambrose and others' *How Village Churches Thrive* is for the English village church.

Taylor, Martyn. *Market Town Resource Churches: Developing Strategies for Mission*. Mission and Evangelism 153. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Resource Churches

A Grove booklet arguing that a town church can serve as a regional base for the villages around it, drawn from scripture, local history, parish experience and Taylor's Asbury doctorate. The difference from a city, on his account, is the ripples a market town sends out to its villages, and the practical difficulty is resourcing them without appearing to threaten them. Taylor has been rector of St George's, Stamford, since 2003.

PLANTING IN SMALL PLACES

Ambrose, Gill, Helen Bent, Nick Edmonds and Sandra Millar. *How Village Churches Thrive: A Practical Guide*. Edited by Robert Atwell. London: Church House Publishing, 2021.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A basic introduction to good practice for village churches, from the Diocese of Exeter's Growing the Rural Church project. Robert Atwell, then Bishop of Exeter, described its aim as helping those who lead a village church, lay or ordained, to focus on 'ten basic things' for its renewal. Each of its 10 chapters takes one area of practice, such as welcome or the churchyard. Unlike Griggs's *Small Town Jesus* and Morrow's *Small Town Mission*, on mission in American small towns, it is written for the existing English village church.

Dunlop, Andrew. 'Catholicity and Connection: An Ecclesiological Framework for the Mixed Ecology Discerned through Research in an Anglican Team Ministry'. PhD thesis, University of Roehampton, 2025. <https://pure.roehampton.ac.uk/portal/en/studentTheses/catholicity-and-connection>.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Ecclesiology; Parish Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A doctoral thesis that builds an ecclesiological framework for the mixed ecology from theological action research with the Lordsbridge Team of Churches, an Anglican team ministry of 11 village parishes west of Cambridge. Its question is what holds a mixed ecology of inherited congregations and fresh expressions together, and Dunlop answers with five 'instincts': missio-ecclesiology, in line with Rowan Williams's theology; a missional understanding of pastoral care; interconnection between communities; catholicity, which values ecclesiastical diversity; and a Christ-centredness that unifies the whole.

Griggs, Donnie. *Small Town Jesus: Taking the Gospel Mission Seriously in Seemingly Unimportant Places*. Morehead City, NC: Everyday Truth, 2016.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A book arguing that small towns deserve the same missionary attention as cities, in two halves: the theological, sociological and philosophical case, then practical guidance. Griggs writes from planting in a coastal town in North Carolina. It is written for pastors, planters and ministry students generally, not only those already in small towns. Morrow's *Small Town Mission* addresses church members; Ambrose and others' *How Village Churches Thrive*, the existing English village church.

Nebel, Tom. *Big Dreams in Small Places: Church Planting in Smaller Communities*. St Charles, IL: ChurchSmart Resources, 2002.

ALSO IN Baptist; Church Planting Movements

A book urging anyone who has thought of planting a church to consider a small town, which it presents as 'a huge mission field' where millions of Americans live. Nebel planted a church in Wisconsin and became the first national director of church planting for the Baptist General Conference, now Converge Worldwide.

Taylor, Martyn. *Market Town Resource Churches: Developing Strategies for Mission*. Mission and Evangelism 153. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Church Planting Around the World

See also the list on *Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church*.

Africa

This list holds books on Christianity and mission in Africa, and on the mission of African Christians beyond it, in Britain above all. A book is here for its subject or for where its author stands, not because its author once worked in Africa. Churches that bring several ethnic groups into one congregation are the subject of Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church. This list opens with Start Here, then African Theology and Public Life, Planting in Africa and African Christians in Britain.

START HERE

Bediako, Kwame. *Christianity in Africa: The Renewal of a Non-Western Religion*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press; Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1995.

ALSO IN Missiology

A monograph by a Ghanaian theologian arguing that African Christianity is not a foreign religion needing to be Africanised but a renewal of the faith on African terms, continuous with Africa's pre-Christian religious past. Bediako rejects the choice between Christian and African that earlier African theologians accepted, and traces the question through Edward Blyden in the 19th century and the neo-traditional Afrikania movement. He studied under Andrew Walls, and a Reformed Theological Seminary missions course sets part of the book beside Walls on the transmission of faith across cultures.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Sent Forth: African Missionary Work in the West*. American Society of Missiology Series 51. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Missiology; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book by a Malawian scholar and pastor arguing that African Christianity has carried a missionary impulse since the early church and now brings it to the West. Its organising idea is the 'blessed reflex': that the continuing evangelisation of the world will need, and profit from, the energies of African churches, so that mission now runs towards the West as well as from it. Written for scholars, pastors and congregational leaders, and for African Christians engaged in mission in Western contexts.

AFRICAN THEOLOGY AND PUBLIC LIFE

Bediako, Kwame. *Christianity in Africa: The Renewal of a Non-Western Religion*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press; Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1995.

ANNOTATED under [Start Here](#)

Burger, Coenie, Frederick Marais and Danie Mouton, eds. *Cultivating Missional Change: The Future of Missional Churches and Missional Theology*. Wellington, South Africa: Bible Media Biblecor, 2017.

ALSO IN Missiology; Ecclesiology

An edited volume of papers from a conference at Stellenbosch University in January 2015, taking stock of the missional church conversation since Darrell Guder and others' *Missional Church* (1998) and arguing that 'missional' is too central a term to abandon. South African contributors, among them the editors and Jerry Pillay, write beside Guder, Patrick Keifert, Stefan Paas and Graham Cray, on subjects from biblical studies and ecclesiology to liturgy and theological education. For planting, Cray's chapter on discernment would be a useful place to look.

Hanciles, Jehu J. *Euthanasia of a Mission: African Church Autonomy in a Colonial Context*. Westport, CT: Praeger, 2002.

ALSO IN [Victorian Three Selves](#)

A study of what became in Sierra Leone of Henry Venn's policy that a foreign mission should become an independent local church, worked out through the Church Missionary Society's Native Pastorate: Hanciles follows the mission's growth, the crises that overtook it and the rise of Ethiopianism, and shows how far colonial assumptions undercut a policy meant to end foreign control. Hanciles is himself Sierra Leonean. A corrective to reading that policy as straightforwardly anti-colonial.

Sanneh, Lamin. *Whose Religion Is Christianity? The Gospel beyond the West*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Missiology

A short book in question-and-answer form, in which Lamin Sanneh, a Gambian-born historian and convert from Islam, puts to himself some 115 questions a sceptical Western reader might ask about Christianity's growth beyond the West. His answer is translation: Christianity has no revealed language, and rendering the scriptures in a vernacular dignifies the culture receiving them, so that translation, rather than Western missionary agency, is the deeper cause of the faith's spread. It restates in shorter form the argument of his *Translating the Message* (1989).

PLANTING IN AFRICA

Donovan, Vincent J. *Christianity Rediscovered: An Epistle from the Masai*. Notre Dame, IN: Fides/Claretian, 1978.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Missiology; Pioneering; Global and Cross-Cultural

A book of narrative and reflection by an American Catholic missionary priest who, influenced by Roland Allen, gave up the school-based method in northern Tanzania and took the gospel directly to the Maasai. It asks what the gospel is when stripped of the Western forms that usually carry it. Samuel K. Elolia (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) contests its conclusion that missionaries are no longer needed, pointing to the growth of Christianity in Africa. The Orbis 25th anniversary edition (2003) adds essays by Lamin Sanneh and Eugene Hillman.

Tasse, Aila, with Dave Coles. *Cabbages in the Desert: How God Transformed a Devout Muslim and Catalyzed Disciple Making Movements Among Unreached Peoples*. Beyond, 2024.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Global and Cross-Cultural

A Muslim teenager in Marsabit, in northern Kenya, meets a Christian teacher, is converted and, in his own words, thrown out of the house, and receives the vision of cabbages growing in desert sand that gives the book its title. What followed was decades of church planting and then disciple-making movements across more than a dozen countries in East, the Horn of, and Southern Africa. Told with Dave Coles, it is a first-hand account by the African leader who catalysed the movements.

AFRICAN CHRISTIANS IN BRITAIN

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila, Fiona Tweedie and Liam Jerrold Fraser. *Churches without People, and People without Churches*. Brendan Research, 2024. <https://www.brendanresearch.com/projects/ethnic-minority-christianity-in-scotland-nature-contribution-and-challenges>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The project report of Brendan Research's study of the diaspora churches of Scotland, whose peer-reviewed paper is 'A Future with Hope'. The project's own page counts over 200 diaspora congregations and says one has been planted every eight weeks since 2000; in Clive D. Field's reading of the report, the churches that answered its survey had 7,200 members between them.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila, Liam Jerrold Fraser and Fiona Tweedie. 'A Future with Hope: Diaspora Churches in Scotland'. *Theology in Scotland* 31, no. 2 (2024): 43-59. <https://ojs.st-andrews.ac.uk/index.php/TIS/article/view/2805>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

An article, the peer-reviewed paper of Brendan Research's project on diaspora churches, reporting a survey of Scotland's diaspora and ethnic minority congregations, which it calls 'the first study of ethnic minority and diasporic congregations in Scotland'. Sixty-five congregations responded, about a third of those contacted. The lack of suitable places of worship 'emerged as a major challenge for nearly all ministries', only 28 per cent owning their building, and the authors recommend that established congregations offer shared or redundant buildings 'for free or at reduced rates'.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila. 'Rivers in the Desert: The Story of African Christianity in Britain'. *Anvil* 37, no. 3 (2021). <https://churchmissionsociety.org/anvil/rivers-in-the-desert-the-story-of-african-christianity-in-britain-sheila-akomiah-conteh-anvil-vol-37-issue-3/>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000

An article on the growth of Black Majority Churches in Britain, and of African churches in particular, which it calls 'one of the most notable developments in contemporary British Christian history'. It traces their origins, then argues for their significance under four heads, from the resacralising of sacred places to the diversifying of British theology. Written for Church Mission Society's journal of mission by a Ghanaian scholar based in Scotland, it covers Britain as a whole.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Multicultural Kingdom: Ethnic Diversity, Mission and the Church*. London: SCM Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Missiology

A book by a Malawian missiologist based in Britain, arguing that the church is by nature a multicultural mosaic, an image he takes from his mother, while British churches of different ethnic heritage often share a building but not a service. His *Sent Forth* (2014) studies African mission to the West; this book addresses British churches and argues for a multicultural missiology. Its final section asks how a church's membership, leadership and worship should reflect that diversity. Walter McConnell (*Mission Round Table*, 2023) finds that its history of mission starts at William Carey and that some of its statistics are inaccurate.

Olofinjana, Israel Oluwole. *Partnership in Mission: A Black Majority Church Perspective on Mission and Church Unity*. Watford: Instant Apostle, 2015.

ALSO IN Baptist; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A monograph, not one of Olofinjana's several edited collections. It asks three questions of the Black majority churches in Britain: what they are, how varied the movement is, and what partnership with the historic denominations could look like. Case studies of partnerships already working are set beside them. The vantage is a Nigerian-British Baptist minister's, writing to the historic churches rather than about them.

Rogers, Andrew. *Being Built Together: A Story of New Black Majority Churches in the London Borough of Southwark*. London: University of Roehampton, 2013. <https://www.roehampton.ac.uk/globalassets/documents/humanities/being20built20togethersb203-7-13.pdf>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Cities and Urban Areas; Buildings, Venues and Space

A report, written by Andrew Rogers of the University of Roehampton, on the new black majority churches of the London Borough of Southwark, from a partnership with Southwark for Jesus and Churches Together in South London. It identified 252 such churches and estimates more than 240 in operation, over twice as many as all the borough's other churches, with nearly half in one postcode. Its chief practical subject is premises: congregations unable to find buildings the planning system counts as suitable for worship, some meeting in industrial units without permission.

Asia and the Middle East

This list holds books on mission and church planting in Asia and the Middle East, among them theology and training written from the region. A book is here for its subject or for where its author stands, not because its author once worked in the region. Two related subjects have lists of their own: whether believers from Muslim and Hindu backgrounds may remain within their communities, in C1-C6 and Insider Movements, and movements that multiply churches rapidly, in Church Planting Movements. This list opens with Start Here, then Asian Theology and Mission and Planting and Multiplication.

START HERE

Chan, Simon. *Grassroots Asian Theology: Thinking the Faith from the Ground Up*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2014.

ALSO IN Missiology; Pentecostal

An argument by a Singaporean Pentecostal theologian that Asian theology has been dominated by an academic elite and should be read instead from what ordinary Asian Christians believe and practise. Like Tennent's *Theology in the Context of World Christianity* it follows the doctrinal loci, but fills them from popular and Pentecostal faith: honour and shame for sin and salvation, the family as a model for the Trinity and the church. Alexander Chow, reviewing it, finds the line between elite and grassroots drawn too cleanly, and Ruth Benedict's 'shame culture' thesis used uncritically.

Garrison, David. *A Wind in the House of Islam: How God Is Drawing Muslims Around the World to Faith in Jesus Christ*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2014.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Global and Cross-Cultural; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A survey of the Muslim world in which Garrison gathered the accounts of more than a thousand believers from Muslim backgrounds across a quarter of a million miles. He divides that world into nine geo-cultural 'rooms' and counts as a movement a thousand baptisms or a hundred new churches within two decades. The definition is what makes the count checkable, and where the argument about his figures begins.

ASIAN THEOLOGY AND MISSION

Chan, Simon. *Grassroots Asian Theology: Thinking the Faith from the Ground Up*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2014.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Hoefler, Herbert E. *Churchless Christianity: A Report of Research among Non-Baptised Believers in Christ in Rural and Urban Tamilnadu, India, with Practical and Theological Reflections*. Rev. ed. Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 2001.

ALSO IN C1-C6 and Insider Movements

A study of people from Hindu families in Tamil Nadu who follow Jesus without being baptised or joining a church, based on research Hoefler carried out in the 1980s as a Lutheran missionary in India. First published in 1991; this edition adds five chapters and a new foreword. The Hindu-context parallel to the argument over believers from Muslim backgrounds who remain in their communities, it extends that question beyond Islam.

Niles, Daniel Thambyrajah. *An Evangelizing Church*. Geneva: World's Student Christian Federation, 1953.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Evangelism

A theological essay of 15 pages rather than a book, and an early statement of Niles's understanding of what the Church is for, published in 1953, the year he became executive secretary for evangelism at the World Council of Churches. Rather than treating evangelism as one activity among many, he asks what it means for the Church itself to be an evangelising community, which makes it useful for thinking about the relation between evangelism, Christian community and the formation of new believers. The question it raises, what kind of Church is capable of evangelising, goes deeper for planting than asking which methods work.

Niles, Daniel Thambyrajah. *Upon the Earth: The Mission of God and the Missionary Enterprise of the Churches*. London: Lutterworth Press, 1962.

ALSO IN Missiology; Ecclesiology

A study of the relation between God's mission, the Church and the missionary enterprise, written from the perspective of a Christian leader from Sri Lanka. It is not a book about church planting, and its concern is theological rather than practical: an ecclesiology of mission in which the Church's existence is bound up with God's missionary purpose. Harold Lindsell (*Christianity Today*, 1963) reads it as implying universal salvation, that all people are already 'in Christ' whether they know it or not.

Parshall, Phil. *Muslim Evangelism: Contemporary Approaches to Contextualization*. Rev. ed. Waynesboro, GA: Gabriel Publications, 2003.

ALSO IN C1-C6 and Insider Movements

A book on the contextualisation of evangelism among Muslims, by a missionary who worked among them from 1962, first in Bangladesh and then in the Philippines. Parshall had argued for contextualisation for decades when, in 1998, he criticised as going too far the C5 position, in which believers in Jesus remain legally and socially Muslim; this book weighs which forms of Muslim life and worship a Christian witness may adopt without compromising the gospel.

Ramachandra, Vinoth. *The Recovery of Mission: Beyond the Pluralist Paradigm*. Carlisle: Paternoster, 1996.

ALSO IN Missiology; Global and Cross-Cultural

An evangelical critique, written from Sri Lanka, of religious pluralism as a theological programme, made through three Asian exponents, Stanley Samartha, Aloysius Pieris and Raimundo Panikkar, with a chapter on each. Drawing on Lesslie Newbigin's account of mission, Ramachandra argues from biblical, patristic and contemporary theology for the decisiveness of what God has done in Christ. It closes with proposals, addressed to pluralists and conservative Christians alike, for communicating the gospel in a multifaith world.

Shaw, Perry. *Transforming Theological Education: A Practical Handbook for Integrative Learning*. ICETE Series. Carlisle: Langham Global Library, 2014.

ALSO IN Formation and Training

A handbook applying adult learning theory to the training of church leaders, written from outside the Western academy: it arises from Shaw's years as professor of education and academic dean at the Arab Baptist Theological Seminary in Beirut. It argues for a curriculum that integrates theory and practice, in place of the classic division into biblical, dogmatic and practical theology, and for teaching that depends less on the lecture. A reorganised second edition followed in 2022.

Shenk, Wilbert R. 'The Origins and Evolution of the Three-Selfs in Relation to China'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 14, no. 1 (January 1990): 28-35.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves

An article tracing the three-self formula, that a church should govern, support and propagate itself, from Henry Venn and Rufus Anderson, who first set it out, to what became of the words in China, and so the piece that explains why the same three words now name two different things: a 19th-century argument for handing a church over, and a 20th-century arrangement with a state.

PLANTING AND MULTIPLICATION

Garrison, David. *A Wind in the House of Islam: How God Is Drawing Muslims Around the World to Faith in Jesus Christ*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2014.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Nevius, John L. *The Planting and Development of Missionary Churches*. Shanghai: Presbyterian Press, 1886.

ALSO IN Missiology; Introductions and Overviews; Victorian Three Selves; Presbyterian and Reformed

A primary text of the 19th-century missionary movement, first written in 1885 as articles for the *Chinese Recorder* and published as a book in 1886. Against paying local evangelists and pastors from mission funds, Nevius argues for churches that are self-supporting, self-governing and self-propagating, whose members keep their own occupations and call pastors when they can support them. The source of what came to be called the Nevius method, it was adopted by Presbyterian missionaries in Korea; the *Biographical Dictionary of Chinese Christianity* records that it and Nevius's *Methods of Mission Work* became required reading for most Presbyterian missionaries to China and Korea for over 50 years. The 1899 New York printing is digitised by the Internet Archive.

Parshall, Phil. *Muslim Evangelism: Contemporary Approaches to Contextualization*. Rev. ed. Waynesboro, GA: Gabriel Publications, 2003.

ANNOTATED under Asian Theology and Mission

Shank, Nathan, and Kari Shank. *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth: Starting and Releasing Healthy Churches*. 2014 edition. <https://churchplantingmovements.com/four-fields/>.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; Practical Guides

A training manual organised around four fields drawn from the parable of the growing seed (Mark 4:26–29), from entering a community to forming a church. Nathan and Kari Shank compiled it from the experience of church planters in South Asia, where they worked in Northeast India. It is a common framework for planting: e3 Partners, NoPlaceLeft and East-West Ministries teach it by name, and an evaluation for the mission agency ABWE (2022) finds the method pervasive among sending organisations, while questioning its biblical basis, which rests largely on that one parable.

Shenk, Wilbert R. 'The Origins and Evolution of the Three-Selfs in Relation to China'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 14, no. 1 (January 1990): 28-35.

ANNOTATED under Asian Theology and Mission

Smith, Steve, and Ying Kai. *T4T: A Discipleship Re-Revolution*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2011.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

The account of Ying Kai's Training for Trainers work in East Asia, written up by Steve Smith, and the source of the T4T method much movement thinking now assumes. The figures reported are very large: the International Mission Board gives 1.7 million baptisms and 150,000 churches over a decade. It is built in three parts as a training manual rather than as an argument. George Robinson, in *Global Missiology*, criticises its marketing tone, its pragmatism and its unclear definition of a church.

Europe

This list holds books on planting churches in Europe beyond Britain. A book is here for its subject or for where its author stands, not because its author once worked in Europe. Planting in Britain runs through the whole of this bibliography; Scotland has its own list, New Churches in Scotland since 2000, and the secular West as a whole is the subject of Post-Christendom and the Secular West. Most of this list is by Stefan Paas. This list opens with Start Here, then Theology of Planting in Europe and Practice Across Europe.

START HERE

Bullivant, Stephen. *Europe's Young Adults and Religion: Findings from the European Social Survey (2014–16) to Inform the 2018 Synod of Bishops*. Twickenham: Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society, St Mary's University, 2018. <https://research.stmarys.ac.uk/id/eprint/2280/1/Europes%20Young%20Adults%20and%20Religions%20-%20report%20compressed.pdf>.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A research report by Stephen Bullivant for the Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society, produced with the Institut Catholique de Paris to inform the 2018 Synod of Bishops. Drawing on the European Social Survey of 2014 to 2016, it sets out religious affiliation and practice for 16 to 29 year olds across 22 European countries, and finds: Catholics are 82 per cent of young Poles and 10 per cent of young Britons, while 70 per cent of young adults in the UK and 64 per cent in France identify with no religion. Where Bullivant's *'No Religion' Population of Britain* stays within the UK, this report sets British figures beside the rest of Europe.

Paas, Stefan. *Church Planting in the Secular West: Learning from the European Experience*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2016.

ALSO IN Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

This is an important but uncomfortable book. Paas is a church planter and also a scholar critical of much contemporary planting, and he sorts the motives for planting in Europe into three — confessional, growth and innovation — testing each theologically and against the European evidence, with little confidence that planting produces growth in a secular setting. It is also a history of planting in Europe, particularly useful for understanding the origins of the church there and why its more Catholic wings have theological objections to evangelical planting. The last chapter, 'In Defense of Church Planting in Europe', is particularly good.

Van de Poll, Evert, and Joanne Appleton, eds. *Church Planting in Europe: Connecting to Society, Learning from Experience*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Innovation and Creativity

An edited volume from the Mission in Europe Symposium held in Belgium in 2014, on planting churches in European societies shaped by secularisation, new spiritualities and a Christian heritage. Most of it is reflection and analysis; the case studies, three chapters, come last. A review on the Kouyanet blog finds Pentecostal and black majority churches thinly covered. Ron Anderson's chapter, 'Creative Church Planting Involving Lay People', bears most directly on lay leadership in planting.

THEOLOGY OF PLANTING IN EUROPE

Paas, Stefan, and Hans Schaeffer. 'Reconstructing Reformed Identity: Experiences from Church Planting in the Netherlands'. *Journal of Reformed Theology* 8, no. 4 (2014): 382-407. <https://doi.org/10.1163/15697312-00804004>.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Presbyterian and Reformed

A journal article, written for a specialist theological readership, by Stefan Paas, a missiologist, and Hans Schaeffer, a practical theologian whose research concerns changing forms of the church and practical ecclesiology. Its subject is Reformed identity, taken up through experiences of church planting in the Netherlands.

Paas, Stefan. 'Church Renewal by Church Planting: The Significance of Church Planting for the Future of Christianity in Europe'. *Theology Today* 68, no. 4 (January 2012): 467-77. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0040573611424326>.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A journal article by a Dutch missiologist who has planted churches, on what planting means for the future of Christianity in Europe. Where Keller's 'Why Plant Churches?' argues for new churches as a way of reaching new people, Paas's title presents planting as the means of the church's renewal. His *Church Planting in the Secular West* (2016) returns to planting in Europe at book length.

Paas, Stefan. 'Why Church Planting in Europe? On Authorizing a Common Evangelical Practice'. Posted by the author, n.d. https://www.academia.edu/30912620/Why_Church_Planting_in_Europe_On_Authorizing_a_Common_Evangelical_Practice_%CE%B1.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A paper asking what authorises church planting in Europe, which its subtitle calls 'a common evangelical practice'. Where Paas's 'Church Renewal by Church Planting' presents planting as a means of renewing the church, this paper asks on what grounds the practice rests at all.

Paas, Stefan. *Church Planting in the Secular West: Learning from the European Experience*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2016.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Paas, Stefan. *New Churches in the Old World: Exploring the Theology of Church Planting in Post-Christendom Europe*. Church Multiplication 2. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2025.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A Grove booklet of 28 pages, the second in the Church Multiplication series, on the theology of church planting in Europe after Christendom. Paas looks at the experience of planting in the far and the recent past, and asks how far it offers strategies for the present, theologically and in practice.

PRACTICE ACROSS EUROPE

Anderson, Ron. 'Creative Church Planting Involving Lay People'. In *Church Planting in Europe: Connecting to Society, Learning from Experience*, edited by Evert Van de Poll and Joanne Appleton, 216-26. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

A chapter on planting churches through lay people, from the volume of papers given at the Mission in Europe Symposium in Belgium in 2014, where Anderson led a workshop on lay-led church planting. He writes as a practitioner: a missionary with European Christian Mission International since 1978, who worked in Spain for more than 40 years and became the mission's consultant on church planting in Europe.

Keller, Timothy. *Center Church Europe: Doing Balanced, Gospel-Centered Ministry in Your City*. Edited by Stefan Paas. Amsterdam: Buijten en Schipperheijn, 2014.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A volume that sets responses from theologians working in Europe around Keller's *Center Church*, edited by Stefan Paas and published in English in the Netherlands. Keller's case for ministry that is gospel-centred, city-centred and movement-centred, drawn from his years in New York, is answered by writers including Leonardo De Chirico, Michael Herbst and Martin Reppenhagen, and a postscript from the European Evangelical Alliance reports on church developments across Europe.

Augland, Øivind, and Harald Giesebrecht, eds. *M4: New People, New Fellowships; From Dream to Reality*. 2 parts. Kristiansand: DAWN Norway, 2013.

ALSO IN Formation and Training

A training book in two parts from Norway's national church planting network, edited by Øivind Augland and Harald Giesebrecht with nine contributing authors, Dietrich Schindler among them, and translated from the Norwegian. M4 is a process tool for the first phase of a plant in four stages, Master, Mission, Multiplication and Movement, Part 1 taking the first two and Part 2 the second, each chapter ending in exercises 'from word to action' and learning goals, at two levels. The foreword says it grew from practical experience rather than academic study, and it is the text behind the M4 Europe process that planting teams across the continent have followed.

Paas, Stefan, and Alrik Vos. 'Church Planting and Church Growth in Western Europe: An Analysis'. *International Bulletin of Mission Research* 40, no. 3 (2016): 243–52.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Church Growth

An article testing, with data, whether planting churches grows the church numerically or only moves Christians between congregations. Paas and Vos compare older and younger churches in three small Reformed denominations in the Netherlands and find the younger ones gained about four times as many converts and five times as many returnees, which they credit to location, outreach and entrepreneurial leadership rather than to planting as such. Among the studies of biological, transfer and conversion growth it is one of the few to test the connection to planting empirically.

Schindler, Dietrich. *Shift: The Road to Level 5 Church Multiplication*. Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/shift/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A short book of 12 practical 'shifts', addressed to habits that hold a church back from multiplying, by a church planter in Germany. Todd Wilson's writing on the same site sets out Exponential's Level 5 language for multiplying churches; this book takes that vision as given and works instead at what, in practice, is stopping a church from reaching it. Written from a European rather than an American church-planting context, for leaders already established in ministry rather than those about to start.

Van de Poll, Evert, and Joanne Appleton, eds. *Church Planting in Europe: Connecting to Society, Learning from Experience*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2015.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Global and Cross-Cultural

This list holds books that treat church planting and mission across the world rather than in one region; a book about Africa, Asia and the Middle East, Europe or Latin America is also in that region's list. Crossing cultures here means a planter's move into a culture not their own, abroad or at home; churches that bring several cultures into one congregation are the subject of Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church. Crossing Cultures holds books on the anthropology and skills of that move; Mission from Everywhere, books on mission as the work of the whole church, much of it written from the majority world; Planting Across the World, accounts of planting around the world and the principles argued from them, the research on movements among them, whose fuller literature is in Church Planting Movements. This list opens with Start Here, then Crossing Cultures, Mission from Everywhere and Planting Across the World.

START HERE

Hiebert, Paul G. *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1985.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves; Missiology

An introduction to anthropology for missionaries, arguing that the gospel must be incarnated in each culture while transforming it. The section 'The Fourth Self' makes the case for self-theologising: theological dependence is the deepest dependence of all, and a church which receives its theology ready-made has not yet been handed over. Rochelle Cathcart Scheuermann (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) faults its functionalist anthropology for treating cultures as bounded entities. Hiebert's article 'Critical Contextualization' (*International Bulletin of Missionary Research*, 1987) supplies the method that keeps the fourth self from collapsing into syncretism.

Jenkins, Philip. *The Next Christendom: The Coming of Global Christianity*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2002.

ALSO IN Missiology

A historian's account, for a general readership, of Christianity's centre of gravity moving to Africa, Latin America and Asia, where the typical Christian is now 'a woman living in a village in Nigeria or in a Brazilian favela' and the churches are more supernaturalist, morally conservative and Pentecostal than the North's. Walls's *The Missionary Movement in Christian History* traces that shift through history; Jenkins gives it in numbers, projected to 2050. D. G. Hart (*Modern Reformation*) argues that growth by conversion makes those projections much less predictable than Jenkins assumes. Revised editions followed in 2007 and 2011.

Sanneh, Lamin. *Whose Religion Is Christianity? The Gospel beyond the West*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003.

ALSO IN Missiology; Africa

A short book in question-and-answer form, in which Lamin Sanneh, a Gambian-born historian and convert from Islam, puts to himself some 115 questions a sceptical Western reader might ask about Christianity's growth beyond the West. His answer is translation: Christianity has no revealed language, and rendering the scriptures in a vernacular dignifies the culture receiving them, so that translation, rather than Western missionary agency, is the deeper cause of the faith's spread. It restates in shorter form the argument of his *Translating the Message* (1989).

CROSSING CULTURES

Crider, Caleb, Larry McCrary, Rodney Calfee and Wade Stephens. *Tradecraft: For the Church on Mission*. Portland, OR: Urban Loft Publishers, 2013.

ALSO IN Missiology

A manual of missionary skills for ordinary Christians, adapting the cross-cultural tools once reserved for full-time missionaries. It is written for Western churches that have accepted the 'why' of mission but are unsure of the 'how', and teaches nine skills, from mapping a place and exegeting its culture to contextualisation and protecting indigeneity.

Donovan, Vincent J. *Christianity Rediscovered: An Epistle from the Masai*. Notre Dame, IN: Fides/Claretian, 1978.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Missiology; Pioneering; Africa

A book of narrative and reflection by an American Catholic missionary priest who, influenced by Roland Allen, gave up the school-based method in northern Tanzania and took the gospel directly to the Maasai. It asks what the gospel is when stripped of the Western forms that usually carry it. Samuel K. Elolia (*Missio Dei Journal*, 2018) contests its conclusion that missionaries are no longer needed, pointing to the growth of Christianity in Africa. The Orbis 25th anniversary edition (2003) adds essays by Lamin Sanneh and Eugene Hillman.

Hesselgrave, David J. *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: A Guide for Home and Foreign Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1980.

ALSO IN Missiology; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Introductions and Overviews; Acts of the Apostles

A missiologist's guide to planting across cultures, organised round a 10-stage Pauline Cycle drawn from Acts 13–16, which runs from missionaries commissioned to sending churches convened. A second edition, retitled *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: North America and Beyond*, followed in 2000.

Hiebert, Paul G. 'Critical Contextualization'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 11, no. 3 (1987): 104–12.

ALSO IN Missiology

An article proposing 'critical contextualization': a four-step method — studying the culture, exegeting Scripture, evaluating the practice critically against it, then shaping a new Christian practice — that steers between rejecting local custom outright and accepting it uncritically. Distinct from Hiebert's 1978 article on bounded and centred sets, it gives the method his 1985 and 1994 books, both already in this bibliography, apply and develop further.

Hiebert, Paul G. 'Critical Contextualization'. *Missiology: An International Review* 12, no. 3 (1984): 287–96.

ALSO IN Missiology

The article in which Hiebert first proposed critical contextualization, asking what people should do with their past customs when they become Christians. He surveys how missions have answered, from rejecting old customs outright to accepting them wholesale at the risk of syncretism, and sets out a third way, in which a community weighs its own practices against Scripture, with the steps in outline. His 1987 article of the same title is the fuller statement, adding a history of missionary practice and giving the method its four named steps.

Hiebert, Paul G. *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1985.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Hiebert, Paul G. *Anthropological Reflections on Missiological Issues*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1994.

ALSO IN Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets

A book bringing anthropology to bear on mission, in which Hiebert sets out his method of critical contextualisation and treats spiritual power, miracles and healing. Its chapter on the category 'Christian' develops his 1978 distinction between bounded and centred sets into a scheme that distinguishes intrinsic from extrinsic and well-formed from fuzzy sets. For a planter working in another culture, the second part's chapters on relations between missionaries and national leaders, and on training leaders, bear most directly.

Kraft, Charles H. *Anthropology for Christian Witness*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1996.

ALSO IN Missiology; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A basic introduction to the study of anthropology for those planning careers in mission or cross-cultural ministry. Drawn from what Kraft taught at Fuller's School of World Mission, it covers theories of culture and society, the anthropological schools, kinship and cross-cultural communication. Hiebert's *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries*, by contrast, gives whole sections to the missionary's culture shock and bicultural identity.

Moon, W. Jay, and W. Bud Simon. *Effective Intercultural Evangelism: Good News in a Diverse World*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2021.

ALSO IN Evangelism; Missiology

A book on evangelism across four worldviews: guilt and justice, shame and honour, fear and power, indifference and belonging. 'Intercultural' in its title means across these worldviews, not within the multi-ethnic congregation. Moon and Simon argue that the guilt-and-justice framing most Western presentations assume is one starting point among several, and often not the one in front of the speaker; the fourth worldview addresses secular younger generations in North America. Each chapter includes exercises for groups or individuals.

Moon, W. Jay. *Intercultural Discipleship: Learning from Global Approaches to Spiritual Formation*. Encountering Mission. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2017.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Formation and Training; Discipleship

A textbook on disciple-making read across cultures rather than out of one. Moon, who spent 13 years with SIM among the Builsa of northern Ghana, argues that formation happens through the genres a culture already has, from proverb and story to song, ritual and dance, and that Western discipleship has narrowed itself to the printed word and the classroom. Eleven chapters, each closing with a case study and an exercise. Useful to a planter working in any community whose habits of learning are not their own.

Moon, W. Jay. *Missional Imagination: Preparation for Kingdom Innovation*. American Society of Missiology Series. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2026.

ALSO IN Missiology; Innovation and Creativity

A book arguing that Christian ministry has been shaped by a 'dominant social paradigm' that separates sacred from secular, private from public and transcendent from immanent, and that missional imagination, a way of seeing and acting that refuses those separations, is where innovation in mission begins. Drawing on Moon's missionary work in Ghana and congregational ministry in the United States, it sets out practices for discipleship and mission as well as for evangelism, the subject of Moon and Simon's *Effective Intercultural Evangelism*.

MISSION FROM EVERYWHERE

Bolger, Ryan K., ed. *The Gospel after Christendom: New Voices, New Cultures, New Expressions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Missiology; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

An edited volume that widens the largely Anglo-American scope of Gibbs and Bolger's *Emerging Churches* (2005) to churches that have grown up after Christendom on several continents. Bolger put questions about the shifts facing the Western church to 137 scholar-practitioners and built the book from the 76 who replied, in five parts, with contributors commenting on one another's chapters in text boxes. Reviewing it, Kevin Book-Satterlee finds themes repeated, especially in the European material.

Escobar, Samuel. *The New Global Mission: The Gospel from Everywhere to Everyone*. Christian Doctrine in Global Perspective. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2003.

ALSO IN Latin America; Missiology

A short book by a Peruvian Baptist arguing that mission is no longer a Western enterprise but the task of a global church, now growing faster in Latin America, Africa and parts of Asia than in the West. Escobar sat on the drafting committee of the Lausanne Covenant (1974) and is credited, with René Padilla, with shaping integral mission; the book faults the paternalism of Western mission agencies. Three of its chapters follow the Trinity: the Father as sender, Christ as the model missionary, the Spirit as director of mission.

Jenkins, Philip. *The Next Christendom: The Coming of Global Christianity*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2002.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Sent Forth: African Missionary Work in the West*. American Society of Missiology Series 51. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Africa; Missiology; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church

A book by a Malawian scholar and pastor arguing that African Christianity has carried a missionary impulse since the early church and now brings it to the West. Its organising idea is the 'blessed reflex': that the continuing evangelisation of the world will need, and profit from, the energies of African churches, so that mission now runs towards the West as well as from it. Written for scholars, pastors and congregational leaders, and for African Christians engaged in mission in Western contexts.

Kwiyani, Harvey C. *Mission-Shaped Church in a Multicultural World*. Mission and Evangelism 118. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2017.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Missiology

A Grove booklet arguing that growing ethnic diversity in British Christianity will make race a central question for mission this century, and urging majority-culture congregations to build real relationships with the immigrant and majority-world Christians already worshipping among them. *Sent Forth* (2014) studies African mission to the West at large, and *Multicultural Kingdom* (2020) sets out a fuller multicultural missiology for Britain; this booklet compresses a similar argument into a short, parish-level statement, written for a general church readership rather than students.

Ramachandra, Vinoth. *The Recovery of Mission: Beyond the Pluralist Paradigm*. Carlisle: Paternoster, 1996.

ALSO IN Missiology; Asia and the Middle East

An evangelical critique, written from Sri Lanka, of religious pluralism as a theological programme, made through three Asian exponents, Stanley Samartha, Aloysius Pieris and Raimundo Panikkar, with a chapter on each. Drawing on Lesslie Newbigin's account of mission, Ramachandra argues from biblical, patristic and contemporary theology for the decisiveness of what God has done in Christ. It closes with proposals, addressed to pluralists and conservative Christians alike, for communicating the gospel in a multifaith world.

Sanneh, Lamin. *Whose Religion Is Christianity? The Gospel beyond the West*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Tennent, Timothy C. *Theology in the Context of World Christianity: How the Global Church Is Influencing the Way We Think about and Discuss Theology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2007.

ALSO IN Missiology

A textbook of systematic theology, with chapter bibliographies and a glossary, that pairs doctrines with non-Western contexts, setting the Western, chiefly evangelical, treatment beside majority-world readings and arguing that the faith is theologically as well as culturally translatable. J. Scott Horrell (*DTS Voice*) finds those readings filtered through Tennent's own lens rather than quoted from the theologians themselves. Chapter 5, on African Christology, which Joseph Greer singles out for its range of majority-world voices, would be a good place to start.

Walls, Andrew F. *The Missionary Movement in Christian History: Studies in the Transmission of Faith*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books; Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1996.

ALSO IN Missiology; Modality and Sodality

A collection of historical essays and lectures written between 1971 and 1994, arguing that Christianity crosses cultures by translation, and that its centre of gravity moves from one region to another, each era's periphery becoming the next era's heartland. 'The Gospel as the Prisoner and Liberator of Culture' is the essay usually credited with the indigenising principle, by which the faith is at home in every culture, and the pilgrim principle, by which it is at home in none. Chapter 18, 'Missionary Societies and the Fortunate Subversion of the Church', argues that the mission societies did what the churches could not.

PLANTING ACROSS THE WORLD

Allen, Roland. *Missionary Methods: St Paul's or Ours? A Study of the Church in the Four Provinces*. London: Robert Scott, 1912. <https://archive.org/details/missionarymethod00alle>.

ALSO IN Missiology; Acts of the Apostles; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Victorian Three Selves

A prophetic book from an early 20th-century missionary to China: its ideas were initially misunderstood and gained ground after Allen's death in 1947. Working from the Acts of the Apostles, he sketches how Paul reached whole regions by planting churches quickly, relying on the Holy Spirit and the training of local leaders rather than on missionary control. Much of the later literature argues either from it or with it; Caleb Greggson, in a 9Marks review, finds Allen's approach insufficient without firmer scriptural grounding but holds that readers must engage with him.

Allen, Roland. *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church and the Causes Which Hinder It*. London: World Dominion Press, 1927.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension; Victorian Three Selves; Modality and Sodality; Acts of the Apostles

A companion volume to Allen's *Missionary Methods* (1912), arguing that the church grows through the unorganised witness of ordinary members explaining the gospel they have found for themselves, and that the control missions keep over the churches they found is what hinders it. Its introduction starts from his missionary experience in China, and its instances come from Acts, among them Acts 11:19–21 and Paul's churches at Lystra and Thessalonica, left to govern, support and propagate themselves once planted. A review for Reaching and Teaching International Ministries calls the model 'reductionistic', judging that in resisting years of formal education for national pastors Allen gives up even basic theological discernment.

Aychi, B. R., with Dave Coles. *Living Fire: Advancing God's Kingdom in Challenging Places*. Beyond, 2024.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A systematic account of a family of disciple-making movements catalysed by Aychi, setting out 22 factors grouped as those that ignite a movement, those that accelerate it and those that sustain it. The settings are named only as challenging places among unreached peoples. More analytical than *Cabbages in the Desert*, which tells the story instead.

Bergquist, Linda, and Michael D. Crane. *City Shaped Churches: Planting Churches in a Global Era*. Skyforest, CA: Urban Loft Publishers, 2018.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Cities and Urban Areas

A book in 23 chapters arguing that planters should not carry suburban models into cities but shape each church to its city, drawing on demographic and ethnographic research and attending to populations churches overlook, such as night workers and undocumented immigrants. The authors' own failed plant in San Francisco in the 1990s is one case. Stephen Mark Davis's review finds it 'a patchwork of collected essays' with overlapping chapters. Bergquist has worked in church planting for over 30 years; Crane helped to launch the Gospel City Network in Southeast Asia.

Bevins, Winfield, ed. *Global Voices: Stories of Church Planting from Around the World*. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2019.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Introductions and Overviews

A collection of eight case studies of church planting, from Jerusalem, India, Canada, England, Colombia, China, Kenya and New Zealand, edited by the director of Asbury Theological Seminary's church planting initiative. Selvaratnam's chapter, 'Reclaiming the Missing Generation', tells of G2, the plant he led in York.

Bolger, Ryan K., ed. *The Gospel after Christendom: New Voices, New Cultures, New Expressions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2012.

ANNOTATED under Mission from Everywhere

Coles, Dave, ed. *God on the Move: Making Disciples Among the Nations*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2025.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

Coles was an associate editor of *Motus Dei* and wrote its third chapter, and this is the same movement research written for ordinary readers and working missionaries rather than for a symposium. Too recent to have gathered reviews.

Farah, Warrick, ed. *Motus Dei: The Movement of God to Disciple the Nations*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2021.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A collection from a 2020 research symposium of the Motus Dei network, in five parts, among them case studies and an agenda for further research. It carries more than 30 first-hand accounts, drawn from the Global North and South alike. Evidence rather than advocacy.

Garrison, David. *A Wind in the House of Islam: How God Is Drawing Muslims Around the World to Faith in Jesus Christ*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2014.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Church Planting Movements; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A survey of the Muslim world in which Garrison gathered the accounts of more than a thousand believers from Muslim backgrounds across a quarter of a million miles. He divides that world into nine geo-cultural 'rooms' and counts as a movement a thousand baptisms or a hundred new churches within two decades. The definition is what makes the count checkable, and where the argument about his figures begins.

Garrison, David. *Church Planting Movements: How God Is Redeeming a Lost World*. Midlothian, VA: WIGTake Resources, 2004.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Ecclesial Minimum

A study of church planting movements around the world and of what they have in common, such as prayer, abundant evangelism, deliberately planting churches able to plant others, local and lay leadership, and healthy churches. It expands, with case studies of more than two dozen movements, a booklet Garrison wrote for the International Mission Board in 1999, which had already defined such a movement and listed its universal elements. Ed Roberts (9Marks, 2009) records that it was once required reading for the Board's missionaries, and finds its ecclesiology thin. Its methodology depends on a low and portable definition of church, which is where it meets the argument about the ecclesial minimum.

Hesselgrave, David J. *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally: A Guide for Home and Foreign Missions*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1980.

ANNOTATED under Crossing Cultures

Hodges, Melvin L. *The Indigenous Church*. Springfield, MO: Gospel Publishing House, 1953.

ALSO IN Victorian Three Selves; Pentecostal

A short book written to prepare Assemblies of God missionaries, out of Hodges's own work in El Salvador and Nicaragua. It put indigenous-church principles into the hands of a Pentecostal mission agency, and went on to shape the missionary policy of the Assemblies of God and of other evangelical agencies. Roland Allen is the influence the sources name on Hodges's missiology. Reissued in 2009 together with *The Indigenous Church and the Missionary*.

Hope in Hard Places: Real Church Planting Stories from Around the World to Encourage You in God's Mission. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2022.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A collection of case studies of church plants around the world, one to each chapter, published by Asbury Theological Seminary from the Global Church Planting Summit it co-hosted in 2021. Each case is offered as evidence that every context needs new local churches. Winfield Bevins's *Global Voices* is an earlier collection of planters' stories from the same seminary.

Payne, J. D. *Discovering Church Planting: An Introduction to the Whats, Whys, and Hows of Global Church Planting*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009.

ALSO IN Baptist; Practical Guides; Introductions and Overviews

An introductory overview, written from the perspective of a North American Baptist. Its four sections run from the theology of planting to contemporary issues, and draw on history, with the Moravians, the Methodists and the Baptists among its examples. It is set out as a first textbook: each chapter carries summaries, review questions and short articles on practical issues in planting.

Schwarz, Christian A. *Natural Church Development: A Guide to Eight Essential Qualities of Healthy Churches*. Carol Stream, IL: ChurchSmart Resources, 1996.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A book setting out eight quality characteristics that Schwarz found in growing churches through a survey of about 1,000 churches on six continents, among them gift-oriented ministry and holistic small groups. It argues that growth follows health, 'quality is the root and quantity is the fruit', and that a church grows only as far as its weakest quality, the 'minimum factor', allows. Ellas and Yeakley (*Journal of the American Society for Church Growth*, 1999) call its research foundation 'pseudo-science'.

Selvaratnam, Christian. 'Reclaiming the Missing Generation'. In *Global Voices: Stories of Church Planting from Around the World*, edited by Winfield Bevins, 71-85. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2019.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Formation and Training

A case study of G2, the church plant Selvaratnam led in York, which reached the millennial generation largely by apprenticing new leaders; it is one of the eight case studies in Winfield Bevins's *Global Voices*. Short, and the practical account behind the argument he develops at length in *The Craft of Church Planting*.

Tasse, Aila, with Dave Coles. *Cabbages in the Desert: How God Transformed a Devout Muslim and Catalyzed Disciple Making Movements Among Unreached Peoples*. Beyond, 2024.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Africa

A Muslim teenager in Marsabit, in northern Kenya, meets a Christian teacher, is converted and, in his own words, thrown out of the house, and receives the vision of cabbages growing in desert sand that gives the book its title. What followed was decades of church planting and then disciple-making movements across more than a dozen countries in East, the Horn of, and Southern Africa. Told with Dave Coles, it is a first-hand account by the African leader who catalysed the movements.

Latin America

This list holds books by Latin American evangelicals, and books about mission in and from Latin America. A book is here for its subject or for where its author stands, not because its author once worked on the continent. Planting among Hispanic Americans in the United States is in Church Planting Movements. This list opens with Start Here, then Mission from Latin America.

START HERE

Costas, Orlando E. *The Church and Its Mission: A Shattering Critique from the Third World*. Wheaton, IL: Tyndale House, 1974.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality; Ecclesiology

A book published the same year as Ralph Winter's essay 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission' and answering it directly: there is no New Testament warrant for mission apart from the church, the two-structure model damages the historic and universal character of the church, and mission sodalities, the specialised bodies that send Christians in mission, ought to be church sodalities. It also evaluates the church growth movement at length. A contemporary objection, from a Latin American writing to North Americans about their own arrangements; *Christianity Today* (1975) found that Costas 'recognizes the strength and bares the weaknesses of North American missiology'.

Padilla, C. René. 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 6, no. 1 (January 1982): 23-30.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle; Ecclesiology

An article arguing that the homogeneous unit principle has no biblical foundation, since a church which will not cross the barriers Christ has abolished has misunderstood what it is. Padilla works from Ephesians and from the Gentile mission in Acts, judging a mission strategy by the church's unity, and writes as a Latin American evangelical from inside evangelical mission rather than against it; he took part in the 1977 Pasadena consultation on the principle. The article is reprinted in his *Mission Between the Times* (1985).

MISSION FROM LATIN AMERICA

Costas, Orlando E. *The Church and Its Mission: A Shattering Critique from the Third World*. Wheaton, IL: Tyndale House, 1974.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Escobar, Samuel. *The New Global Mission: The Gospel from Everywhere to Everyone*. Christian Doctrine in Global Perspective. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2003.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Missiology

A short book by a Peruvian Baptist arguing that mission is no longer a Western enterprise but the task of a global church, now growing faster in Latin America, Africa and parts of Asia than in the West. Escobar sat on the drafting committee of the Lausanne Covenant (1974) and is credited, with René Padilla, with shaping integral mission; the book faults the paternalism of Western mission agencies. Three of its chapters follow the Trinity: the Father as sender, Christ as the model missionary, the Spirit as director of mission.

Padilla, C. René. 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle'. *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* 6, no. 1 (January 1982): 23-30.

ANNOTATED under [Start Here](#)

Padilla, C. René. *Mission Between the Times: Essays on the Kingdom*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1985.

ALSO IN Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Missiology

A collection of essays by the Latin American evangelical who argued at Lausanne in 1974 for integral mission (*misión integral*): evangelism and social responsibility as one task. It is the source of the underlying objection to church growth theory, of which McGavran's three kinds of growth (biological, transfer and conversion) are part: that it begins with sociological observation and looks for biblical warrant afterwards. Its essay 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle' answers McGavran's *Understanding Church Growth* directly and would make a useful pair with it; the Langham revision (2010), where the essay is chapter 8, adds one on integral mission's later history.

The Planter and the Team

Selecting and Assessing Planters

See also the list on Formation and Training.

This reading list is on how churches and planting networks decide who should plant a church: the profiles of an effective planter, the interviews and assessment centres built on them, and the research on whether they select well. How those chosen are then trained has a list of its own.

The earliest profile here is Charles Ridley's manual, whose thirteen characteristics came from a study of North American planters. Later profiles followed: J. Allen Thompson's thesis of 1995 compiled eighteen competencies from what planters and assessors perceive, and the assessment system that Douglas McClintic describes, used in southern California in the 2000s, looks at calling, character, competence and chemistry.

Two questions run through what followed. The first is empirical: whether the profiles measure what they claim, and whether they predict how a plant will fare. Jason Walker's doctoral project evaluates the Southern Baptists' own instrument statistically, and Ed Stetzer's benchmarking of planting networks adds that the average network is organised around choosing planters rather than around churches that plant. The second is normative: what the profiles ought to look for at all. Lloyd Grant's thesis analyses them theologically, and Chuck DeGroat, a therapist, observes that narcissism is often mistaken for confidence, strong leadership and clear vision. Everything in this list is North American.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Does Assessment Work? and What Should Be Assessed.

START HERE

Ridley, Charles R. *How to Select Church Planters: A Self-Study Manual for Recruiting, Screening, Interviewing and Evaluating Qualified Church Planters*. Pasadena, CA: Charles E. Fuller Institute of Evangelism and Church Growth, 1988.

A self-study manual for those recruiting, screening, interviewing and evaluating church planters, built on a study Ridley made of planters in the United States and Canada. It sets out 13 characteristics of an effective planter, from visioning capacity and intrinsic motivation to spousal cooperation, resilience and the exercise of faith, and the 13 are still reproduced in material for assessing planters.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. 'The State of Church Planting in the United States: Research Overview and Qualitative Study of Primary Church Planting Entities'. *Journal of the American Society for Church Growth* 19, no. 2 (2008): 1-42.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Formation and Training

An article that reviews existing research on church planting in the United States and reports Leadership Network's study of 2007, which reviewed the contribution and impact of four kinds of planting body: denominations, networks, churches that plant churches, and house churches. It reports that around 68 per cent of plants still exist four years after starting, and that the assessment, preparation and coaching of the planter have 'a dramatic impact' on the planter's wellbeing and on the new church's vitality and survival. The same authors' *Viral Churches* (2010) asks what distinguishes the churches that go on to multiply.

DOES ASSESSMENT WORK?

McClintic, Douglas C. 'Assessing Missional Leaders: Evaluating the Effectiveness and Placement of Missional Church Planters'. Doctoral thesis, Bakke Graduate University, 2007.

ALSO IN Missiology

A doctoral thesis proposing a way of assessing church planters for a postmodern and increasingly complex urban context, around four categories: calling, character, competence and chemistry. McClintic grounds it in biblical and theological foundations for church multiplication movements, and documents an assessment system devised and run in southern California from 2004 to 2006, with a training manual for assessment consultants. It is concerned with where planters are placed as well as with who is selected.

Merritt, Andrew W. 'Maximizing Planter Potential: An Analysis of the Church Planter Assessment of the Wesleyan Church'. DMin thesis, Asbury Theological Seminary, 2024.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A DMin thesis of 2024 at Asbury Theological Seminary analysing how the Wesleyan Church assesses its church planters. Its catalogue record lists case studies, call, appointment, mentoring and evaluation among its subjects.

Stetzer, Ed, Jeff Christopherson, and Daniel Yang. *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems: With Particular Attention to Church Planting Churches*. Wheaton, IL: Send Institute and New Churches, 2018. <https://www.sendinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/SI-2018-BPCPS.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; Church Planting Strategy

Benchmarking research on North American planting networks, asking what the churches that reproduce well do differently. Of the 130 organisations that answered, nearly half had taken multiplication language into their mission or vision statements and 73 per cent trained for it, but 74 per cent reported that fewer than a quarter of their churches were actually planting; and the average organisation still optimises for selecting planters rather than for growing churches that plant. American throughout, and concerned with how a planting system is put together rather than how it should feel.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. 'The State of Church Planting in the United States: Research Overview and Qualitative Study of Primary Church Planting Entities'. *Journal of the American Society for Church Growth* 19, no. 2 (2008): 1-42.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Stetzer, Ed. 'Equipping Church Planters for Success'. *Enrichment Journal* 14, no. 4 (Fall 2009): 36-43.

ALSO IN Formation and Training

An article in the Assemblies of God's quarterly for ministers, in its issue on church multiplication, on church-planting systems: assessment, intensive training, mentoring or coaching and planter networks, who uses them, how effective they are and what has been learned. Stetzer reports that two-thirds of the denominations surveyed now assess planters, that assessed planters led churches at least a fifth larger in each of their first four years, and that training, coaching and peer groups each raise survival, drawing on his Leadership Network research on the state of church planting. It is the short, popular form of the case that *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems* later makes at length.

Walker, Jason Alexander. 'Statistical Evaluation of the North American Mission Board's Church Planter Initial Assessment Instrument and the Implications for the Broader Church Planting Community'. DMin thesis, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2023.

ALSO IN Baptist; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A DMin thesis of 2023 at the Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, giving a statistical evaluation of the Church Planter Initial Assessment, the instrument with which the North American Mission Board of the Southern Baptist Convention begins its assessment of candidates, and drawing out what the results mean for the wider church planting community.

WHAT SHOULD BE ASSESSED

DeGroat, Chuck. *When Narcissism Comes to Church: Healing Your Community from Emotional and Spiritual Abuse*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP, 2020.

ALSO IN Power and Its Abuse

A book on narcissism in church leaders and in the church systems around them, by a therapist and professor of pastoral care at Western Theological Seminary in Michigan. DeGroat writes that narcissistic traits are often taken for strengths, as 'confidence, strong leadership, clear vision, a thick skin', so that such leaders are 'deemed credible'. He treats narcissism as a property of whole church systems as well as of individuals, and writes for communities recovering from emotional and spiritual abuse.

Grant, Lloyd Walter. 'Theological Analysis of Church Planter Profiles'. PhD thesis, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2012.

ALSO IN Baptist

A PhD thesis of 2012 at the Southern Baptist Theological Seminary giving a theological analysis of church planter profiles, the lists of qualities by which denominations and networks judge whether a candidate is fit to plant. Where Walker's later doctoral project at the same seminary evaluates one assessment instrument statistically, Grant's analysis is theological.

McClintic, Douglas C. 'Assessing Missional Leaders: Evaluating the Effectiveness and Placement of Missional Church Planters'. Doctoral thesis, Bakke Graduate University, 2007.

ANNOTATED under Does Assessment Work?

Moore, Ralph. *21 Questions to Ask before Starting a New Church*. Exponential, 2025. <https://exponential.org/product/21-questions-to-ask-before-starting-a-new-church/>.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A discernment guide of 21 questions for someone weighing whether and how to start a new church, by the same author and in the same Hope Chapel and Exponential context as the shorter *How Nearly Anyone Can Start a Microchurch*. It states its wager on the church that will prevail in one sentence on page 9: it will be 'more relational, less of a spectacle, and more focused on equipping members for ministry'. Unlike the thesis-based planter-profile studies found elsewhere in this bibliography, its questions are for the prospective planter to put to themselves, before rather than during the work of starting.

Ridley, Charles R. *How to Select Church Planters: A Self-Study Manual for Recruiting, Screening, Interviewing and Evaluating Qualified Church Planters*. Pasadena, CA: Charles E. Fuller Institute of Evangelism and Church Growth, 1988.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Rogers, Cris. *Listening to the Voice of the Estates Planters: A Report on What Helps Estates Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/Listening-to-Estates-Planters-Report-final-1.pdf>.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Formation and Training

A report for CCX, designed and led by Cris Rogers, a Church of England priest who spent 16 years planting and leading a church on a social housing estate. It draws on 45 practitioners, about a third of them from outside the Church of England, and on 450 working-class people asked about training. Its findings favour slow, incarnational models of planting, commitment measured in years and local leadership, and a section asks what success means on an estate. On selection it concludes that the Church's system 'rewards the qualities least needed on estates and undervalues the ones most needed'.

Thompson, J. Allen. 'Church Planter Competencies as Perceived by Church Planters and Assessment Center Leaders: A Protestant North American Study'. PhD thesis, Trinity Evangelical Divinity School, 1995.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A PhD thesis at Trinity Evangelical Divinity School on the competencies a church planter needs, as church planters and the leaders of assessment centres perceive them. Thompson compiles 18 characteristics in three groups, from prayer, integrity and family life to preaching, training leaders and emotional stability, and gives positive and negative indicators for each, so that the profile can be used to assess a candidate.

Formation and Training

See also the lists on Selecting and Assessing Planters, and on Coaching.

This reading list is on how planters, and ministers and others in mission, are formed and trained: training schemes and apprenticeships, coaching, and the theological education of ministers. Much of the training described is not for planters alone: the books here also form evangelists, lay apprentices in parishes and disciples in cultures other than the trainer's, and one treats the minister's own character as the thing to be formed.

Three of its books argue for forming ministers in the practice of ministry as well as in the classroom, and differ over how. Robert Banks, who surveys the classical and vocational models of theological education before proposing his own, argues from the practice of Jesus and Paul for training in and for mission, much of it in the field; Christian Selvaratnam argues from the medieval craft guilds that planting is best taught as a craft, by apprenticeship; Perry Shaw would reorganise the curriculum round the integration of theory and practice. No book here makes the case for the classroom model that all three argue against.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Training for Mission, Coaching and Theological Education.

Valentine, John H. "'Theology That Actually Works': An Analysis of Those Aspects of Theological Formation Which Best Equip Church Planters for Their Work'. DMin thesis, Asbury Theological Seminary, 2020.

A Doctor of Ministry thesis asking which parts of theological formation best equip church planters, set in London and the Church of England after *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004). Valentine surveyed 86 planters and 36 trainers and interviewed three leaders of English planting movements. He finds that ecclesiology and missiology need integrating within a wider theology; that how training is delivered matters as much as its content, practitioner-led cohorts learning inside real missionary situations fitting best; and that the planter's personal formation is crucial. Where Banks and Selvaratnam argue for forming ministers in practice, Valentine reaches a similar conclusion from what planters and trainers report.

START HERE

Banks, Robert. *Reenvisioning Theological Education: Exploring a Missional Alternative to Current Models*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1999.

A major book on the state of theological education: it sets a missional model of training against the classical and vocational models that have governed it, and makes a forceful case for training for and in mission rather than for a settled ministry. Part One surveys the models that govern the debate, and Part Two turns to how Jesus and Paul formed people for ministry. In the model Banks proposes, training takes place wholly or partly in the field.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *The Craft of Church Planting: Exploring the Lost Wisdom of Apprenticeship*. London: SCM Press, 2022.

Drawing on doctoral research into the pedagogy of the English medieval craft guilds, the book offers a fresh account of apprenticeship as a model for training in the Church. Its argument is that church planting, requiring both theory and practical skill, is best understood and taught as a craft. Helen Wordsworth, reviewing it for the Baptist Union in 2023, calls it 'a deeply academic read'.

Tang, Len, and Charles E. Cotherman, eds. *Sent to Flourish: A Guide to Planting and Multiplying Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2019.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Practical Guides; Women in Church Planting

An edited volume from Fuller Theological Seminary's church planting programme, which its editors rest on three foundations: a biblical theology of planting, the spiritual formation of the planter, and intercultural competencies. The editors write of the need to form 'a new generation of women and men from a multitude of cultural backgrounds' as planters.

TRAINING FOR MISSION

Breen, Mike. *Building a Discipling Culture*. 3rd ed. Pawleys Island, SC: 3DM International, 2017.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Leadership in Church Planting

The book behind the huddle and the LifeShapes: eight diagrams — a circle of repentance and faith, a semi-circle of work and rest, a triangle of relationships, then the square, pentagon, hexagon, heptagon and octagon — each carrying one discipline to be learned and passed on. Breen developed the system while leading St Thomas' Church, Crookes, in Sheffield. This third edition adds the Five Capitals, the Three As and a new shape for the person of peace. Keith Schooley, writing on his blog in 2013, argues that the shapes are reductive and open to being used manipulatively.

Jolley, Andy, and Ian Jones. 'Formation for Mission in Urban Britain: The Birmingham Mission Apprentice Scheme'. *Journal of Adult Theological Education* 13, no. 1 (2016): 33-47.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

An article on the Birmingham Mission Apprentice Scheme, in which the Church of England in Birmingham employed lay apprentices for 20 hours a week to take responsibility, under their vicar's supervision, for growing one area of a parish's life. The seven parishes were all highly urbanised: three on outer estates, two multicultural inner-city parishes, and two where most people belonged to a faith other than Christianity.

Listening to the Voice of the Lay Planters. London: Myriad and CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2022. <https://ccx.org.uk/resource/listening-lay/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A report from Myriad, the Church of England's lay church-planting initiative, with CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, the first of the 'Listening to the Voice' series, its research by Alice Bruce and Wendy Brooks. It draws on interviews in late 2021 with 20 lay people from 13 dioceses who had planted a church community, and sets out 10 insights and 10 recommendations, the chief being that no systematic pathway exists to prepare and equip lay planters, and that new ones are needed at the scale of the 10,000 new communities the church envisages. Beside the series' later reports on estates and rural planters and on pioneers, it is the account of the lay ones.

Augland, Øivind, and Harald Giesebrecht, eds. *M4: New People, New Fellowships; From Dream to Reality*. 2 parts. Kristiansand: DAWN Norway, 2013.

ALSO IN Europe

A training book in two parts from Norway's national church planting network, edited by Øivind Augland and Harald Giesebrecht with nine contributing authors, Dietrich Schindler among them, and translated from the Norwegian. M4 is a process tool for the first phase of a plant in four stages, Master, Mission, Multiplication and Movement, Part 1 taking the first two and Part 2 the second, each chapter ending in exercises 'from word to action' and learning goals, at two levels. The foreword says it grew from practical experience rather than academic study, and it is the text behind the M4 Europe process that planting teams across the continent have followed.

Miller, Carolina G., ed. *What Church Planters Need: How Community, Training, and Intentional Relationships Fuel Church Growth*. Wilmore, KY: First Fruits Press, 2026. <https://place.asburyseminary.edu/academicbooks/64/>.

A book edited by Carolina G. Miller and published in 2026 by First Fruits Press, Asbury Theological Seminary's open-access imprint for academic material from the Wesleyan and Holiness traditions.

Moon, W. Jay. *Intercultural Discipleship: Learning from Global Approaches to Spiritual Formation*. Encountering Mission. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2017.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural; Discipleship

A textbook on disciple-making read across cultures rather than out of one. Moon, who spent 13 years with SIM among the Builsa of northern Ghana, argues that formation happens through the genres a culture already has, from proverb and story to song, ritual and dance, and that Western discipleship has narrowed itself to the printed word and the classroom. Eleven chapters, each closing with a case study and an exercise. Useful to a planter working in any community whose habits of learning are not their own.

Porterbrook Learning. *Missional Church and Church Planting*. Local Groups ed. Sheffield: Porterbrook Network, 2011.

ALSO IN Missiology

A course book from Porterbrook Learning, the Sheffield-based training programme run through local groups rather than a seminary, in the edition it printed through Lulu in October 2011. Its nine units move from ecclesiology to the practice of church planting, and it names no individual author. Written for a group working through it together, it stands as a British network's own course material rather than a treatise, and shows how one such network taught church planting.

Rogers, Cris. *Listening to the Voice of the Estates Planters: A Report on What Helps Estates Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/Listening-to-Estates-Planters-Report-final-1.pdf>.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Selecting and Assessing Planters

A report for CCX, designed and led by Cris Rogers, a Church of England priest who spent 16 years planting and leading a church on a social housing estate. It draws on 45 practitioners, about a third of them from outside the Church of England, and on 450 working-class people asked about training. Its findings favour slow, incarnational models of planting, commitment measured in years and local leadership, and a section asks what success means on an estate. On selection it concludes that the Church's system 'rewards the qualities least needed on estates and undervalues the ones most needed'.

Selvaratnam, Christian. 'Is Church Planting a Craft? Training Lessons from Medieval Guilds'. In *New Churches: A Theology*, edited by Will Foulger and Joshua Cockayne, 128-43. London: SCM Press, 2024.

Drawing on the medieval craft guilds, where an apprentice advanced by producing real work rather than by finishing a course, the chapter asks what that older way of forming people might offer the training of planters now. It is Selvaratnam's contribution to *New Churches: A Theology*, a collection of theological essays on starting new churches, listed under Key Theological and Scholarly Works.

Selvaratnam, Christian. 'Reclaiming the Missing Generation'. In *Global Voices: Stories of Church Planting from Around the World*, edited by Winfield Bevins, 71-85. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2019.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Global and Cross-Cultural

A case study of G2, the church plant Selvaratnam led in York, which reached the millennial generation largely by apprenticing new leaders; it is one of the eight case studies in Winfield Bevins's *Global Voices*. Short, and the practical account behind the argument he develops at length in *The Craft of Church Planting*.

Selvaratnam, Christian. *The Craft of Church Planting: Exploring the Lost Wisdom of Apprenticeship*. London: SCM Press, 2022.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Send Network. *Church Planting Pipeline: Moving Beyond Addition*. Alpharetta, GA: North American Mission Board, 2017.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Church Planting Strategy

A short booklet from Send Network, the North American Mission Board's church-planting arm, issued in August 2017 with a foreword by Jeff Christopherson, then its vice-president. It presents the Pipeline as a local church's own system for finding and forming planters: a pre-assessment, then three levels of 10 competencies each, up to three years of modules, on the argument that planting by addition, one recruited planter at a time, never becomes a movement. Among books on churches that send, it is the one that describes a denomination's ready-made programme, and would suit a church wanting to see what such a pathway contains.

Snow, Martyn, ed. *Anglican Evangelists: Identifying and Training a New Generation*. London: SPCK, 2019.

ALSO IN Anglican; Evangelism; Missiology

An edited collection by 13 contributors from different traditions in the Church of England, published for the twentieth anniversary of the Archbishops' College of Evangelists and its relaunch. It sets aside evangelistic method for the calling and gifts of the evangelist, asking what an evangelist is and how the church should recognise and train one, so that evangelists can equip all Christians for witness.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. 'The State of Church Planting in the United States: Research Overview and Qualitative Study of Primary Church Planting Entities'. *Journal of the American Society for Church Growth* 19, no. 2 (2008): 1-42.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Selecting and Assessing Planters

An article that reviews existing research on church planting in the United States and reports Leadership Network's study of 2007, which reviewed the contribution and impact of four kinds of planting body: denominations, networks, churches that plant churches, and house churches. It reports that around 68 per cent of plants still exist four years after starting, and that the assessment, preparation and coaching of the planter have 'a dramatic impact' on the planter's wellbeing and on the new church's vitality and survival. The same authors' *Viral Churches* (2010) asks what distinguishes the churches that go on to multiply.

Stetzer, Ed. 'Equipping Church Planters for Success'. *Enrichment Journal* 14, no. 4 (Fall 2009): 36–43.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters

An article in the Assemblies of God's quarterly for ministers, in its issue on church multiplication, on church-planting systems: assessment, intensive training, mentoring or coaching and planter networks, who uses them, how effective they are and what has been learned. Stetzer reports that two-thirds of the denominations surveyed now assess planters, that assessed planters led churches at least a fifth larger in each of their first four years, and that training, coaching and peer groups each raise survival, drawing on his Leadership Network research on the state of church planting. It is the short, popular form of the case that *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems* later makes at length.

Tang, Len, and Charles E. Cotherman, eds. *Sent to Flourish: A Guide to Planting and Multiplying Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2019.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

COACHING

Bevins, Winfield, and Mark Dunwoody. *Missional Formation Coaching: Healthy Rhythms for Thriving Leaders*. Self-published ebook, 2020. <https://plantanglican.org/missional-formation-coaching-ebook/>.

A short coaching guide for church leaders and planters, given away as a free ebook, setting out what its own description calls a reflective approach to coaching, organised around the healthy rhythms of its subtitle. Its authors, Winfield Bevins and Mark Dunwoody, built a coaching programme of the same name on it. It is a different work from their later book, *Healthy Rhythms for Leaders*, and would suit a coach or planter wanting a brief, practical frame rather than a theory of coaching.

Collins, Gary R. *Christian Coaching: Helping Others Turn Potential into Reality*. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2001.

ALSO IN Coaching

An introduction to coaching from a Christian standpoint, by a psychologist who came to it from counselling. Collins distinguishes the two: coaching is 'for relatively well-adjusted people to build vision and move forward toward the future', and 'does not involve making a diagnosis or giving advice'. A revised and expanded second edition followed in 2009.

Hopkins, Bob, and Freddy Hedley. *Coaching for Missional Leadership*. Sheffield: Fresh Expressions and ACPI, 2008.

ALSO IN Coaching; Fresh Expressions of Church; Leadership in Church Planting

A guide to coaching and mentoring missional leaders, produced jointly by Fresh Expressions and the Anglican Church Planting Initiatives (ACPI) as a follow-on from Fresh Expressions' own training courses. Its distinctive focus, within Christian coaching generally, is coaching for those planting churches and fresh expressions specifically, rather than pastoral or life coaching more broadly. Aimed at trainers and mentors working with pioneer ministers and planters, in a British Anglican setting, rather than at a general readership.

Nicholson, Steve, and Jeff Bailey. *Coaching Church Planters: A Manual for Church Planters and Those Who Coach Them*. Association of Vineyard Churches USA, 2001.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; New Churches and Networks; Coaching

A coaching manual from the Association of Vineyard Churches USA, addressed at once to the planter and to the coach. The manual comes out of Vineyard planting practice. It emphasises the planter's pursuit of intimacy with God, with Jesus's life as the model, and includes a guide for small groups.

Thompson, J. Allen. *Unique Challenges Facing Urban Church Planters*. Manuals and Papers AR 38. New York: Redeemer Presbyterian Church, 2009. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/unique-challenges-facing-urban-church-planters/>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A short paper, excerpted from Thompson's manual *Coaching Urban Church Planters* and written for coaches as well as planters, on the difficulties a city adds to planting, with New York as its case. It groups them under three heads, from the religious climate to the cost of living and ministry, and adds others, among them the turnover of city dwellers, which makes leaders hard to develop.

Webb, Keith E. *The COACH Model for Christian Leaders: Powerful Leadership Skills for Solving Problems, Reaching Goals and Developing Others*. Rev. and exp. ed. New York: Morgan James Faith, 2019.

ALSO IN Coaching

A handbook of the COACH model, a five-step conversation for Christian leaders: connect, outcome, awareness, course and highlights. Webb, who worked for 20 years in Japan, Indonesia and Singapore with Church Resource Ministries, presents it as a change 'from that of telling and expertise to questions and the shared discovery of new solutions'; his own summary of the model includes questions such as 'What has God been doing in your life since we last met?' This revised edition of a book first published in 2012 adds about a fifth more text and appendices on coaching agreements, training and certification.

THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION

Banks, Robert. *Reenvisioning Theological Education: Exploring a Missional Alternative to Current Models*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1999.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Bevins, Winfield. 'Think Like St. Patrick'. In 'What Is the Biggest Change Evangelical Seminaries Need to Make Right Now?' *Christianity Today*, November 2012. <https://www.christianitytoday.com/ct/2012/november/what-is-biggest-change-evangelical-seminaries-need-to-make.html>.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Leadership in Church Planting

A short opinion piece in which Winfield Bevins answers a symposium question on seminary reform by pointing to Saint Patrick and the later Celtic monastic centres at Iona and Lindisfarne, arguing that seminaries should require a church-planting internship alongside academic study. One of three proposals printed together, with Dan Kimball and Cheryl Sanders.

Collicutt, Joanna. *The Psychology of Christian Character Formation*. London: SCM Press, 2015.

A book on Christian character formation for clergy and those preparing for ministry, by a clinical psychologist and Anglican priest who taught psychology and spirituality at Ripon College Cuddesdon. It treats formation as a community and its members growing into the character of Christ through the Holy Spirit, and draws on contemporary psychology first for the reader's self-awareness and then, at greatest length, for the cultivation of Christ-like characteristics. It concerns the minister's own formation rather than the design of a college or course.

Croft, Steven J. L. *Ministry in Three Dimensions: Ordination and Leadership in the Local Church*. 2nd ed. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2008.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Leadership in Church Planting; Pastoral Ministry

A study of ordained ministry built around three New Testament words for it — diakonia, presbyteros and episcopo — treated as dimensions present in every ordained ministry rather than as separate orders, each minister needing to find their own balance of the three. Croft's case is that recovering this pattern matters because the inherited model of ministry no longer sustains a more mobile, declining society, and that secular management models are a false trail. First published in 1999, while Croft was Warden of Cranmer Hall, Durham, this 2008 edition adds some 90 pages and a final chapter, written once he had become Archbishops' Missioner and Team Leader of Fresh Expressions, connecting diakonia to the forming of new contextual communities.

Paas, Stefan. 'The Discipline of Missiology in 2016: Concerning the Place and Meaning of Missiology in the Theological Curriculum'. *Calvin Theological Journal* 51, no. 1 (April 2016): 37-54.

An article by a Dutch missiologist asking where missiology belongs in the theological curriculum and what it means there. Its subject is the curriculum as a whole, not the training of church planters in particular.

Shaw, Perry. *Transforming Theological Education: A Practical Handbook for Integrative Learning*. ICETE Series. Carlisle: Langham Global Library, 2014.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East

A handbook applying adult learning theory to the training of church leaders, written from outside the Western academy: it arises from Shaw's years as professor of education and academic dean at the Arab Baptist Theological Seminary in Beirut. It argues for a curriculum that integrates theory and practice, in place of the classic division into biblical, dogmatic and practical theology, and for teaching that depends less on the lecture. A reorganised second edition followed in 2022.

Leadership in Church Planting

See also the lists on Power and Its Abuse, on Modality and Sodality, and on Women in Church Planting.

This reading list is on leadership as it bears on planting and multiplying churches: the character of the planter who leads, the making of other leaders, and the kind of leader that a movement of churches is argued to need. Most of its books are written for planters or for churches that plant; some are on Christian leadership in general, and more of those are in Wider Reading, under Leading an Organisation and in Pastoral Ministry.

A recurring argument is that a planter's task is to make leaders rather than to remain the only one. The books divide over what kind of leader planting needs. At one pole it needs what Scripture asks of any minister, which is where Darrin Patrick begins. At the other it needs a kind of leader the settled church has neglected: Alan Hirsch, with Tim Catchim and on his own, and Neil Cole argue that the church has let some of the five ministries of Ephesians 4:11 lapse, the apostle's above all, and that movements need all five. The objection to the second, made in reviews rather than in any book here, is that the New Testament's qualifications for leaders concern character, and that the fivefold scheme is made to explain too much. Emanuel Prinz's study of 147 movements asks what the leaders who start them have in common.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then The Character of the Leader, Multiplying Leaders, Leading a Multiplying Church and Apostolic and Movement Leadership.

START HERE

Cole, Kadi. *Developing Female Leaders: Navigate the Minefields and Release the Potential of Women in Your Church*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2019.

ALSO IN Women in Church Planting; Developing Leaders

A practical guide to developing women as leaders in churches and Christian organisations, based on interviews with 30 senior leaders and surveys of over 1,200 female ministry leaders. Cole distils this research into eight practices for building a culture that grows women's leadership, addressed to the leaders who set that culture rather than to women themselves. It is a research-based practical guide rather than a first-hand narrative, the distinction this list draws between Start Here and First-Hand Accounts. Cole writes from experience in a large, multisite American church, and the leaders and networks behind her research are mainly American.

Parkinson, Ian. *Understanding Christian Leadership*. London: SCM Press, 2020.

A textbook for those training for ordained ministry, in two parts, Understanding Leadership and the Work of Leadership. It appraises secular theories of leadership against biblical and theological accounts, defines leadership as 'a relational process of social influence' directed towards 'the achievement of God's purposes', and argues for leadership that is widely dispersed and collaborative. Parkinson wrote it while teaching leadership for CPAS in more than half the theological colleges and courses of Britain and Ireland. It concerns leading a church rather than planting one.

Patrick, Darrin. *Church Planter: The Man, the Message, the Mission*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

A book on the church planter himself, by the vice-president of the Acts 29 network and founding pastor of The Journey in St Louis. Holding that strategies do not transfer between contexts, it asks what Scripture teaches about the planter's character, teaching and aim. It is written for men, and holds that the pastor must be a man. The Journey's elders removed Patrick from its pastorate in 2016; he later returned to ministry at Seacoast Church in South Carolina.

Steel, Dan. *Wise Church Planting: Twelve Pitfalls to Avoid in Starting New Churches*. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2024.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A book on 12 pitfalls, drawn from research into 80 church plants that struggled or failed, by a pastor in Oxford who had worked in market research. It groups the struggles under external opposition, character, practical barriers, disunity and lack of support, and works through them with stories, scripture and self-examination. Several pitfalls concern the leader, among them choosing workers for gifts rather than godliness, isolation, and burn-out from an unsustainable early pace, and these bear most directly on leading a plant.

THE CHARACTER OF THE LEADER

Arbuckle, Gerald A. *Refounding the Church: Dissent for Leadership*. London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1993.

ALSO IN Modality and Sodality

An anthropologist's account of why an institution in confusion reaches backwards, and why it discourages dissent exactly when it most needs it. Arbuckle, a Marist priest, writes about Catholic religious congregations after Vatican II and the pull to restore the model that preceded them; refounding is his word for renewal led from the margins by people the centre finds awkward. Scholarly rather than practical, and a position planters working inside an institution may recognise.

Bloye, Brian, and Amy Bloye. *It's Personal: Surviving and Thriving on the Journey of Church Planting*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Resilience and Burnout

A book written for planting couples by a husband and wife who started West Ridge Church in Georgia in 1997, on the personal side of planting: the marriage, the children and the balance of family and ministry, along with criticism, friendship and spiritual warfare. Each chapter carries interviews with other planting couples. Hoover's *The Church Planting Wife*, listed under Practical Guides, is by contrast written for the wife.

Cole, Neil. *Journeys to Significance: Charting a Leadership Course from the Life of Paul*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2011.

ALSO IN Acts of the Apostles

A study of Paul in the Acts of the Apostles and of how he changed his church planting methodology over time, traced through six phases of his formation as a leader, from Sovereign Foundations to the Fourth Journey and Beyond. Each phase pairs biblical observation with practical leadership application. Cole founded a church planting movement, Church Multiplication Associates. It would suit a reader inclined to treat Acts as a fixed template rather than a developing practice.

Croft, Steven J. L. *Ministry in Three Dimensions: Ordination and Leadership in the Local Church*. 2nd ed. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2008.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Pioneering; Pastoral Ministry

A study of ordained ministry built around three New Testament words for it — diakonia, presbyteros and episcopo — treated as dimensions present in every ordained ministry rather than as separate orders, each minister needing to find their own balance of the three. Croft's case is that recovering this pattern matters because the inherited model of ministry no longer sustains a more mobile, declining society, and that secular management models are a false trail. First published in 1999, while Croft was Warden of Cranmer Hall, Durham, this 2008 edition adds some 90 pages and a final chapter, written once he had become Archbishops' Missioner and Team Leader of Fresh Expressions, connecting diakonia to the forming of new contextual communities.

Male, Dave. *Pioneering Leadership: Disturbing the Status Quo?* Leadership 14. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2013.

ALSO IN Pioneering

A Grove booklet in the Leadership series, shorter than Male's other two titles in this list and addressed to church leaders generally rather than to pioneers themselves. Opening from a predicted 90 per cent fall in Anglican worship attendance by 2057, it helps a leader decide whether pioneering has any place in their own ministry, and sets out a spectrum of pioneering leadership styles rather than one model. Where *How to Pioneer* (2016) gives the practical steps once that decision is made and *Pioneers 4 Life* (2011) sustains those already committed to it, this booklet sits at the discernment stage before either.

Moore, Carolyn. 'At the Intersection of Acts and Galatians: New Strategies for Women Church Planters'. DMin thesis, Asbury Theological Seminary, 2018. <https://place.asburyseminary.edu/ecommonsatsdissertations/1229/>.

ALSO IN Women in Church Planting; Acts of the Apostles

A Doctor of Ministry thesis on how women plant churches, by the founding pastor of Mosaic Church in Evans, Georgia, drawing on her 20 years in ministry to name the barriers women planters meet and ways past them. Its title pairs Acts with Galatians; in 'Biblical Women and the Spread of the Gospel', an essay for the Wesleyan Covenant Association, Moore reads Lydia in Acts 16 as evidence of women's early leadership and weighs restrictive passages through Galatians 3:28. American and Wesleyan in setting, and written for practitioners.

Patrick, Darrin. *Church Planter: The Man, the Message, the Mission*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2010.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Payne, J. D. *The Barnabas Factors: Eight Essential Practices of Church Planting Team Members*. Missional Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Teams and Culture

A book for the members of a planting team, taking Barnabas as their model and giving each chapter to one of eight practices, 'walks with the Lord' first among them. It includes a guide by which leaders can assess prospective team members against the eight.

Seamands, Stephen. *Ministry in the Image of God: The Trinitarian Shape of Christian Service*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2005.

A book drawing a theology of ministry from the doctrine of the Trinity, by a professor of Christian doctrine at Asbury Theological Seminary, who defines Christian service as the ministry of the Son to the Father, through the Spirit, for the sake of the church and the world. Each of seven chapters draws one quality of ministry from the life of the Trinity, from relational personhood to passionate mission. It concerns ministry in general rather than planting.

Steel, Dan. *Wise Church Planting: Twelve Pitfalls to Avoid in Starting New Churches*. Fearn: Christian Focus, 2024.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Wakefield, Gavin. *The Wise Pastor: Learning from Gregory the Great's 'Pastoral Rule'*. Pastoral 140. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Pastoral Ministry; Rule of Life

A Grove booklet by Gavin Wakefield, drawing pastoral wisdom from Gregory the Great's sixth-century *Pastoral Rule*. It opens with an account of Gregory's own life before turning to the *Rule* itself, arguing that a text written for the unsettled conditions of its own day still has insight to offer leaders facing change now. It reaches back to a patristic primary text rather than to contemporary leadership literature, and assumes no previous acquaintance with Gregory or his period.

MULTIPLYING LEADERS

Addison, Steve. *Pioneering Movements: Leadership That Multiplies Disciples and Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

A book on the leadership that multiplies disciples and churches, with scriptural, historical and contemporary examples from around the world. Chapter 6 is especially valuable for its five levels of movement leadership, from seed sower and church planter to multiplication trainer and movement catalyst. It builds on two earlier books by Addison, *What Jesus Started* and *Movements That Change the World*, the second of them in Church Planting Movements.

Bevins, Winfield. 'Think Like St. Patrick'. In 'What Is the Biggest Change Evangelical Seminaries Need to Make Right Now?' *Christianity Today*, November 2012. <https://www.christianitytoday.com/ct/2012/november/what-is-biggest-change-evangelical-seminaries-need-to-make.html>.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Formation and Training

A short opinion piece in which Winfield Bevins answers a symposium question on seminary reform by pointing to Saint Patrick and the later Celtic monastic centres at Iona and Lindisfarne, arguing that seminaries should require a church-planting internship alongside academic study. One of three proposals printed together, with Dan Kimball and Cheryl Sanders.

Breen, Mike. *Building a Discipling Culture*. 3rd ed. Pawleys Island, SC: 3DM International, 2017.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Formation and Training

The book behind the huddle and the LifeShapes: eight diagrams — a circle of repentance and faith, a semi-circle of work and rest, a triangle of relationships, then the square, pentagon, hexagon, heptagon and octagon — each carrying one discipline to be learned and passed on. Breen developed the system while leading St Thomas' Church, Crookes, in Sheffield. This third edition adds the Five Capitals, the Three As and a new shape for the person of peace. Keith Schooley, writing on his blog in 2013, argues that the shapes are reductive and open to being used manipulatively.

Devenish, David. *Fathering Leaders, Motivating Mission: Restoring the Role of the Apostle in Today's Church*. Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2011.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; New Churches and Networks

A book written from inside Newfrontiers by a leader who has overseen churches across the Russian-speaking world and the 10/40 window, arguing that the New Testament apostle is best understood as a father to leaders rather than as an office. Its reviewers divide over the ecclesiology and agree on the usefulness.

Ferguson, Dave, and Warren Bird. *Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2018.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Developing Leaders

The argument that a leader's job is to make other leaders rather than to be one, with five practices and a tool for each, from multiplication thinking to kingdom building. Written out of Community Christian Church in Chicago and the Exponential network.

Ford, Lance, Rob Wegner and Alan Hirsch. *The Starfish and the Spirit: Unleashing the Leadership Potential of Churches and Organizations*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2021.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

Brafman's starfish — the decentralised organism that regrows from any limb — applied to the church, with a foreword by Ori Brafman himself. The argument is for leaders who release rather than run, and for multiplying leaders at every level rather than only at the top. It assumes *The Starfish and the Spider*, where the metaphor is set out. Nathan Knight, reviewing it for 9Marks, argues against it from the pastoral qualifications in 1 Timothy 3, Titus 1 and 1 Peter 5.

Hopkins, Bob, and Freddy Hedley. *Coaching for Missional Leadership*. Sheffield: Fresh Expressions and ACPI, 2008.

ALSO IN Coaching; Formation and Training; Fresh Expressions of Church

A guide to coaching and mentoring missional leaders, produced jointly by Fresh Expressions and the Anglican Church Planting Initiatives (ACPI) as a follow-on from Fresh Expressions' own training courses. Its distinctive focus, within Christian coaching generally, is coaching for those planting churches and fresh expressions specifically, rather than pastoral or life coaching more broadly. Aimed at trainers and mentors working with pioneer ministers and planters, in a British Anglican setting, rather than at a general readership.

Marshall, Colin, and Tony Payne. *The Trellis and the Vine: The Ministry Mind-Shift That Changes Everything*. Kingsford, NSW: Matthias Media, 2009.

ALSO IN Developing Leaders

A book on Christian ministry in general, distinguishing the trellis, the structures that support ministry, from the vine, the growth of people through the word of God. It argues that trellis work, being more visible and tangible, tends to take over, and calls for a shift from running programmes to training people, since every Christian is called to vine work. Walter Strickland, reviewing it for Baptist21, finds its practical guidance thin and cautions against putting it into effect in haste.

Walkemeyer, Larry, and John Teter. *The Making of a Multiplier: Four Seasons to Maximize Your Kingdom Legacy*. Exponential, 2026. <https://exponential.org/product/the-making-of-a-multiplier/>.

ALSO IN Developing Leaders

A leadership-formation guide by two pastors in the Exponential network, working from a four-stage 'seasons' framework adapted from Robert Clinton's leadership research and worked out through the biblical case of Barnabas. It measures a leader's legacy by the leaders they develop and send, not by quick results. Where Walkemeyer's other book, *The River Church*, addresses a congregation's whole culture, this one narrows to the individual leader's formation across a lifetime. Written for pastors, leaders and lay believers alike.

Yang, Daniel, Adelle M. Banks and Warren Bird. *Becoming a Future-Ready Church: 8 Shifts to Encourage and Empower the Next Generation of Leaders*. Exponential Next. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2024.

A book for American church leaders on raising leaders from younger generations, whose needs Exponential, in whose series it appears, describes as shaped by anxiety, scepticism and fragmentation. Drawing on published American research on disaffiliation and the rise of the 'nones', it proposes eight shifts by which a church might encourage and empower younger leaders. Its authors are a leader in church multiplication, a religion journalist and a researcher.

LEADING A MULTIPLYING CHURCH

Ferguson, Dave, and Patrick O'Connell. *Together: The Great Collaboration*. Chicago, IL: Exponential, 2019. <https://exponential.org/resource-ebooks/together/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

The argument that collaboration between churches and networks belongs beside the Great Commission and the Great Commandment as a third call, read out of John 17. Written from inside a reproducing network rather than about one: Ferguson co-founded Exponential and leads NewThing, and the examples come from churches they work with. Short and hortatory, and lighter on evidence than on conviction, which is where Gordon Showell-Rogers's review in *Christian Daily International* also lands.

Galanos, Chris. *From Megachurch to Multiplication: A Church's Journey Toward Movement*. Experience Life, 2018.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Multi-site Church

Galanos asked 12 people to join him in reaching 10,000 people in 10 years, and passed the mark in year eight, then concluded that the megachurch he had built was the wrong goal and turned it towards multiplication. The interest is in the turn: a pastor dismantling his own success in public. Published by the church itself, Experience Life in Lubbock, Texas.

Keller, Timothy. *Leadership and Church Size Dynamics: How Strategy Changes with Growth*. New York: Redeemer City to City, 2010. First published in *The Movement* newsletter, 2006; reprinted as 'Process Managing Church Growth: How Strategy Changes Over Time' in *Cutting Edge*, Spring 2008. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/leadership-and-church-size-dynamics/>.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A paper on how a church's size changes its leadership, in five bands from the house church of up to 40 to the very large church of over 800. It describes what changes inside a church as it grows rather than what makes it grow. Keller argues that size culture runs deeper than tradition: churches of 100 and 1,000 may differ more than a Presbyterian and a Baptist church of the same size. Mark Dever and Jonathan Leeman (9Marks, 2024) accept that insight but question several specifics, calling the paper descriptive sociology rather than prescriptive theology.

Vanderstelt, Jeff. *One Eighty: A Return to Disciple-Making*. Exponential, 2023. <https://exponential.org/product/one-eighty/>.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

Vanderstelt's book for Exponential, organised around five shifts: from reaching to making, informing to equipping, attending to attaching, striving to thriving, and accumulating people in buildings and programmes to deploying them. He leads the Soma family of churches, and the shifts assume a church that already has programmes and buildings to redirect — a book for an existing congregation rather than for a planter starting clean.

Walkemeyer, Larry. *The River Church: Unleashing a Culture of Multiplication in Your Church*. Exponential, 2025. <https://exponential.org/product/the-river-church/>.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan; Church Planting Movements

Ezekiel 47 as a diagnosis: a church can become a lake, gathering and holding what comes to it, or a river, carrying it somewhere else. Walkemeyer led Light and Life in Long Beach for 30 years and now works with Exponential and the Free Methodist Church, and the book is the account of turning the one into the other.

APOSTOLIC AND MOVEMENT LEADERSHIP

Addison, Steve. *Pioneering Movements: Leadership That Multiplies Disciples and Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2015.

ANNOTATED under Multiplying Leaders

Addison, Steve. *The Rise and Fall of Movements: A Roadmap for Leaders*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2019.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

The later companion to *Movements That Change the World*, and the more searching of the pair: a six-stage life cycle, birth, growth, maturity, decline, decay and rebirth, which asks why movements decline as well as how they begin, and what leadership each stage requires. A corrective to a literature preoccupied with beginnings. Stephen McAlpine's review finds it most useful to those already leading something established; Caleb Morell, for 9Marks, is sharply critical of its theology.

Arbuckle, Gerald A. *Refounding the Church: Dissent for Leadership*. London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1993.

ANNOTATED under The Character of the Leader

Cole, Neil. *Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale House, 2014.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements

Cole on the same fivefold gifts Hirsch works on in 5Q, arguing that several have been quietly retired and that the church's capacity depends on all five together. It sets out to recover, reinterpret and reimagine the gifts, and is written with four collaborators who each bring one of them: Dezi Baker, Ed Waken, Phil Helfer and Paul Kaak.

Devenish, David. *Fathering Leaders, Motivating Mission: Restoring the Role of the Apostle in Today's Church*. Milton Keynes: Authentic Media, 2011.

ANNOTATED under Multiplying Leaders

Ford, Lance, Rob Wegner and Alan Hirsch. *The Starfish and the Spirit: Unleashing the Leadership Potential of Churches and Organizations*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2021.

ANNOTATED under Multiplying Leaders

Hirsch, Alan, and Tim Catchim. *The Permanent Revolution: Apostolic Imagination and Practice for the 21st Century Church*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Modality and Sodality; Theory of Change

A book arguing that Western churches have narrowed the fivefold ministry of Ephesians 4:11 (apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd, teacher) to shepherd and teacher, and that recovering the apostolic function keeps a church a movement rather than a settled institution. It draws on organisational theory as well as theology. Darrell Guder contributes the foreword. Andy Johnson, in the *Englewood Review of Books*, finds it 'most certainly not easily accessible'.

Hirsch, Alan. *5Q: Reactivating the Original Intelligence and Capacity of the Body of Christ*. 100 Movements, 2017.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Church Planting Movements

A book on the fivefold typology of ministry in Ephesians 4, apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd and teacher (APEST), presented not as five offices to fill but as the church's DNA: traced through God's nature, creation and culture, embodied fully in Jesus, and what makes a community a church. Its first part, 'Mapping the Genome of the Body of Christ', sets out the theology, and the second turns to practice. Chris Schoon (*Englewood Review of Books*, 2017) judges that it claims too much for APEST as a lens on all of these at once.

Hirsch, Alan. *The Forgotten Ways: Reactivating Apostolic Movements*. 2nd ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Missiology; Theory of Change

A book asking why some Christian movements grew exponentially, and calling what they share Apostolic Genius: six elements of 'mDNA', one of them 'APEST culture', which Hirsch and Catchim's *The Permanent Revolution* develops. Hirsch calls it 'not a how-to book'. The preface new to this edition concedes that few Western churches show all six elements, and argues that a handful of exemplary churches would be enough to change the paradigm.

Nelson, Gary V. *Borderland Churches: A Congregation's Introduction to Missional Living*. St Louis, MO: Chalice Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Missiology

A book on leading congregations into missional change, by the General Secretary of Canadian Baptist Ministries, writing from Canada. It takes the borderland, church life lived beyond its own walls, as its image, and covers the changing challenges of mission in the West and how to identify and overcome the blockages in congregations as they try to meet them. Chapter 4, on leadership for change, is particularly good: Robert Cornwall's review singles out its four leadership roles for a congregation moving into mission — apprentice, pastor, missionary and theologian.

Prinz, Emanuel. *What Actually Starts Movements: Partnering with God for Kingdom Multiplication*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2025.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A study of movement catalysts resting on more than 15 years of Prinz's research, 147 movements and some 32,000 data points, asking which qualities separate catalysts who see breakthrough from those who do not. The empirical counterpart to a literature that usually argues from stories. Not to be confused with his earlier *Movement Catalysts* (2022), which studies 35 movements and is often cited in its place.

Power and Its Abuse

See also the list on Leadership in Church Planting.

This reading list is on the misuse of power in churches: the abuse of authority by leaders, the emotional and spiritual abuse of the people in their care, and the church cultures that conceal abuse or resist it. It is not a list on safeguarding practice or law, which none of its books addresses.

Two of the cases these books examine are churches their founders planted, Mars Hill Church in Seattle and Willow Creek near Chicago, and what happened to each after its founder's fall.

The books start from different places. Chuck DeGroat, a therapist, starts from the narcissistic personality, though he finds narcissism in whole church systems as well. Scot McKnight and Laura Barringer, who argue for forming a culture of goodness able to resist abuse, and Mike Cospers's podcast history of Mars Hill look to the culture a church forms round celebrity. J. R. Woodward gives a theology of the powers of domination and of the imitation through which leaders take them on. Diane Langberg begins with power itself, a gift from God that every person holds and that anyone who holds it can misuse.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Culture and Its Failure.

START HERE

DeGroat, Chuck. *When Narcissism Comes to Church: Healing Your Community from Emotional and Spiritual Abuse*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP, 2020.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters

A book on narcissism in church leaders and in the church systems around them, by a therapist and professor of pastoral care at Western Theological Seminary in Michigan. DeGroat writes that narcissistic traits are often taken for strengths, as 'confidence, strong leadership, clear vision, a thick skin', so that such leaders are 'deemed credible'. He treats narcissism as a property of whole church systems as well as of individuals, and writes for communities recovering from emotional and spiritual abuse.

Langberg, Diane. *Redeeming Power: Understanding Authority and Abuse in the Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2020.

A book on power in the church by a psychologist whose clinical work has been with survivors of trauma and with clergy. Langberg treats power as a gift that comes from God, so that using it to damage a person is a failure to handle the gift. The book moves from the source of power to its abuse, including systemic power in complicity with abuse and power between men and women, and ends with its redemption.

CULTURE AND ITS FAILURE

Cospers, Mike. *The Rise and Fall of Mars Hill*. Podcast series, 15 episodes. Christianity Today, 2021-22.

<https://www.christianitytoday.com/podcasts/the-rise-and-fall-of-mars-hill/>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Planting Movements; New Churches and Networks

The narrative history of Mars Hill Church in Seattle, which grew to 12,000 people across 12 sites and dissolved in 2014, and of Mark Driscoll, who founded it and co-founded Acts 29. Driscoll resigned in 2014 amid serious concerns about his leadership. Setting former staff and members beside historians and sociologists, Cospers makes the series about the conditions that produced Mars Hill — celebrity, and a theology of masculinity — rather than about one leader. Justin Dean, the church's former communications director, has disputed its accuracy. Driscoll's *Confessions of a Reformission Rev.* was written in 2006 from inside the church whose end this describes.

DeGroat, Chuck. *When Narcissism Comes to Church: Healing Your Community from Emotional and Spiritual Abuse*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP, 2020.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Langberg, Diane. *Redeeming Power: Understanding Authority and Abuse in the Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2020.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

McKnight, Scot, and Laura Barringer. *A Church Called Tov: Forming a Goodness Culture That Resists Abuses of Power and Promotes Healing*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale Momentum, 2020.

ALSO IN [Ecclesiology](#); [Teams and Culture](#)

A book on church culture rather than policy, whose introduction begins with the unravelling of Willow Creek after the allegations against its founding pastor, Bill Hybels, in 2018. McKnight, a New Testament scholar, and Barringer argue that goodness, *tov* in Hebrew, has to be formed in a church deliberately, because celebrity and self-protection will otherwise shape its culture. Mary Stahl (CBE International) found it useful for spotting warning signs in a healthy church and for putting 'words to feelings' in a toxic one. Part 1, on how a church's culture forms and deforms, bears most directly on what goes wrong.

Vanier, Jean. *Community and Growth*. Rev. ed. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1989.

ALSO IN [Rule of Life](#)

A book of reflections on the nature and meaning of community, written in short sections out of Vanier's life in L'Arche, the communities he founded; it appeared in French and in English in 1979 and was revised in 1989. Inquiries published by L'Arche after his death in 2019 found serious abuse on Vanier's part.

Woodward, J. R. *The Scandal of Leadership: Unmasking the Powers of Domination in the Church*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2023.

ALSO IN [Developing Leaders](#)

A theological account of why church leaders come to dominate, developed from Woodward's doctoral thesis at the University of Manchester. He argues that powers of domination are present in the church and must be unmasked if it is to be missional, drawing on Walter Wink on the powers embodied in systems, René Girard on imitation and desire, and William Stringfellow on resisting the powers. Woodward is a church planter and directs church planting for the V3 movement.

Women in Church Planting

See also the list on Leadership in Church Planting.

This reading list is on women who plant churches, and on what bears on the work because the planter is a woman: the obstacles she meets that a man does not, and what has helped women past them. It is a list about planters rather than about the theology of women's ministry, which belongs to ecclesiology, and the one book written for the wives of planters is among the Practical Guides.

That theology is where the principal fault line lies. Whether a woman may lead a congregation at all is settled differently by different traditions: one of the books on the planter in Leadership in Church Planting holds that the pastor must be a man, and every book in this list assumes that a woman may plant and lead a church. What this list holds is the practical question that follows. Among the obstacles Carolyn Moore names are theological objection, the way a woman planter is perceived, resources, biology and pastoral care.

The first-hand accounts are by women who led the work they describe, though neither is about being a woman who plants.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then First-Hand Accounts.

START HERE

Cole, Kadi. *Developing Female Leaders: Navigate the Minefields and Release the Potential of Women in Your Church*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2019.

ALSO IN Developing Leaders; Leadership in Church Planting

A practical guide to developing women as leaders in churches and Christian organisations, based on interviews with 30 senior leaders and surveys of over 1,200 female ministry leaders. Cole distils this research into eight practices for building a culture that grows women's leadership, addressed to the leaders who set that culture rather than to women themselves. It is a research-based practical guide rather than a first-hand narrative, the distinction this list draws between Start Here and First-Hand Accounts. Cole writes from experience in a large, multisite American church, and the leaders and networks behind her research are mainly American.

Eason, Andrew Mark. *Women in God's Army: Gender and Equality in the Early Salvation Army*. Waterloo, ON: Wilfrid Laurier University Press, 2003.

ALSO IN Salvation Army

A study of whether the early Salvation Army's promise of sexual equality in ministry matched its practice. Eason traces the gap between the founding constitution's claim that women could preach and hold any office and the gendered assignment of roles he finds in practice, underwritten by what he calls a male-defined theology. Diane Winston, reviewing it, calls the book 'a provocative counterpoint to recent Salvationist scholarship that credits the Army with providing new opportunities for women.' The chapter on the public and domestic service of female officers bears most directly on the women who did the work of planting corps.

Moore, Carolyn. 'At the Intersection of Acts and Galatians: New Strategies for Women Church Planters'. DMin thesis, Asbury Theological Seminary, 2018. <https://place.asburyseminary.edu/ecommonsatsdissertations/1229/>.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Acts of the Apostles

A Doctor of Ministry thesis on how women plant churches, by the founding pastor of Mosaic Church in Evans, Georgia, drawing on her 20 years in ministry to name the barriers women planters meet and ways past them. Its title pairs Acts with Galatians; in 'Biblical Women and the Spread of the Gospel', an essay for the Wesleyan Covenant Association, Moore reads Lydia in Acts 16 as evidence of women's early leadership and weighs restrictive passages through Galatians 3:28. American and Wesleyan in setting, and written for practitioners.

Tang, Len, and Charles E. Cotherman, eds. *Sent to Flourish: A Guide to Planting and Multiplying Churches*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2019.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews; Practical Guides; Formation and Training

An edited volume from Fuller Theological Seminary's church planting programme, which its editors rest on three foundations: a biblical theology of planting, the spiritual formation of the planter, and intercultural competencies. The editors write of the need to form 'a new generation of women and men from a multitude of cultural backgrounds' as planters.

FIRST-HAND ACCOUNTS

Kilpin, Juliet. *Urban to the Core: Motives for Incarnational Mission*. Kibworth Beauchamp: Matador, 2013.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Pioneering; Cities and Urban Areas

A multi-voiced book, compiled by Kilpin, of reflections from some of the hundred or so people who had joined Urban Expression teams in Britain's urban neighbourhoods, setting out the motives behind the network's first years. Kilpin, a Baptist minister, led its first team with Jim Kilpin, planting a congregation in Shadwell, east London, in 1997, and later coordinated Urban Expression in Britain. Much of the book is the team members' own account rather than hers.

Woofenden, Anna. *This Is God's Table: Finding Church Beyond the Walls*. Harrisonburg, VA: Herald Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Estates and Poorer Communities

A first-hand account, written as narrative rather than method, of the Garden Church on an empty lot in San Pedro, Los Angeles, where housed and unhoused people farmed together, worshipped and shared a weekly meal. Woofenden was its founding pastor until 2017. Sam Chamelin, reviewing it in the *Englewood Review of Books* (2020), finds the work shown as communal, 'not a celebration of one person's expertise'.

Missional Spirituality

See also the lists on Power and Its Abuse, and on Rule of Life.

This reading list is on the spiritual life of a church in mission: the practices, habits and shared life that make a congregation missionary and sustain its members in mission. It is on spirituality as it bears on mission, not on prayer and devotion in general, which have lists of their own in Wider Reading.

The books divide over where that life is to be found. For some it lies in each Christian's practice: Michael Frost proposes a handful of weekly habits that anyone can keep, alone or with a few others. For others it lies in the common life of a body: a congregation's shared life for Robert Warren, a community under a rule for the contributors to *Ancient Faith, Future Mission*, a band of three or four friends for Philip Meadows and Anthony Watts, and for Alan and Eleanor Kreider and Paulus Widjaja the habits of peace a whole church forms.

A second difference runs across the first: whether such practices are a means to growth, as they are for Alex Harris and Chrissy Remsberg, who draw their habits from churches seeing conversion growth, or a discipline rather than a technique, which is how Frost presents his.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Habits and Common Life.

START HERE

Frost, Michael. *Exiles: Living Missionally in a Post-Christian Culture*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2006.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A book arguing that Western Christians should see themselves as exiles under an empire no longer Christian, and take up the practices of biblical exiles. Frost wrote it without Hirsch. The second of its four parts, on authenticity, community, hospitality and work, bears most directly on a church's common life.

Lovelace, Richard F. *Dynamics of Spiritual Life: An Evangelical Theology of Renewal*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1979.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A study of spiritual renewal drawn from the history of revival since the Reformation, weighted towards Jonathan Edwards and written from a Reformed standpoint. It sets out the preconditions of continuous renewal and its primary and secondary elements before turning to practice, in chapters such as 'The Renewal of the Local Congregation' and 'How Revivals Go Wrong'. An expanded edition of 2020 has a foreword by Timothy Keller.

HABITS AND COMMON LIFE

Bevins, Winfield H., and Mark Dunwoody. *Healthy Rhythms for Leaders: Cultivating Soul Care in Uncertain Times*. Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/healthy-rhythms-leaders/>.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Resilience and Burnout; Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A short manual of soul care for Christian leaders, one of Exponential's ebooks. It builds an 'Ebb and Flow' rule of life for a leader and adds a 'Missional Design Thinking' process for carrying the same habits into a team. Among entries on writing a rule for today it is pitched at leaders under operational pressure rather than at students of the monastic tradition; a companion visual guide summarises its frameworks.

Cray, Graham, Ian Mobsby and Aaron Kennedy, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: New Monasticism as Fresh Expression of Church*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesiology; Rule of Life

An edited volume in which leaders of traditional religious communities and of new monastic ones write from their own communities on how an older form of religious life is shaping a new form of church. It was edited from within Fresh Expressions, which Graham Cray then led, and its subtitle states its claim: that new monasticism, which *Mission-Shaped Church* named among the new forms of church, is a fresh expression of church. The chapters are testimony and reflection rather than a single argument. Gladys Ganiel's review commends Shane Claiborne's 'Marks of a New Monasticism' for its vision of living alongside disadvantaged communities.

Frost, Michael. *Exiles: Living Missionally in a Post-Christian Culture*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2006.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Frost, Michael. *Surprise the World! The Five Habits of Highly Missional People*. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology; Rule of Life

A book setting out five weekly habits under the acronym BELLS (Bless, Eat, Listen, Learn, Sent), on the argument that Christians have replaced habits that surprise the world with habits that mimic it. Frost, writing from Australia, offers them as a discipline for individuals or small groups rather than a technique of evangelism. Frost and Hirsch's *The Shaping of Things to Come* argued for a change in the church's shape; this book turns to the habits of its members. The closing chapter, on small groups for discipleship, nurture and accountability, bears on practising them together.

Harris, Alex, and Chrissy Remsberg. *On This Rock: Simple Lessons and Achievable Habits for Church Growth*. FirestartersUK, 2023.

ALSO IN Baptist; Church Growth; Practical Guides

A booklet setting out seven habits held in common by British Baptist churches seeing conversion growth, from small plants to larger established congregations, drawn from the Firestarters Network's conversations. Among them are intensity of prayer and fasting, and reorganising more often than you think. Each chapter grounds one habit in scripture, tells the story of a church that has practised it and closes with questions and next steps. Written for the leaders of existing churches to work through together.

Kreider, Alan, Eleanor Kreider and Paulus Widjaja. *A Culture of Peace: God's Vision for the Church*. Intercourse, PA: Good Books, 2005.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book by Alan and Eleanor Kreider, who co-directed the London Mennonite Centre and helped found the Anabaptist Network, with the Indonesian Paulus Widjaja, prompted by his judgement that the church in Indonesia must address reconciliation with Muslims. It treats peace as part of the culture a church should have, within the congregation, at work and between the church and the world, and argues that peacemaking rests on 'reflexes', habits formed before conflict arrives rather than skills improvised once it has.

Meadows, Philip R., and Anthony Watts. *Fellowship Band: A Quick Guide*. Spiritual Formation for Mission 2. Inspire Movement, 2019.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting; Early Methodist Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan

A quick guide to the fellowship band — three or four friends meeting regularly for spiritual conversation — as practised in the Inspire Movement, the international and ecumenical network for mission-shaped discipleship in the Wesleyan spirit that Meadows co-founded in 2007.

Ross, Cathy, and Jonny Baker, eds. *Pioneering Spirituality: Resources for Reflection and Practice*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2015.

ALSO IN Pioneering

An edited collection on the spiritual life that sustains pioneer ministry, on the premise that prayer and contemplation lie at the heart of work that can look merely active. Its contributors consider the spirituality already present in British culture, and how practices from the Eucharist to pilgrimage might be offered to people outside the church. It followed *The Pioneer Gift* (2014), from the same editors.

Rutba House, ed. *School(s) for Conversion: 12 Marks of a New Monasticism*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2005.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A statement of the 12 marks of a new monasticism, agreed at a gathering of intentional communities in Durham, North Carolina, in June 2004, among them relocation to 'the abandoned places of Empire' and the sharing of economic resources. *Christianity Today* called the gathering the movement's birth and this book what introduces it. Its politics are more radical than many English readers will expect: a sympathetic writer calls the new monasticism the strongest voice for social justice among such movements, and a critical one objects to its 'jubilee economics'.

Warren, Robert. *Being Human, Being Church: Spirituality and Mission in the Local Church*. London: Marshall Pickering, 1995.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Missiology; Anglican

A book arguing that the inherited church's structure casts the congregation as clients of a provider and so keeps its members passive, and that a local church becomes missionary through its spirituality and shared life. Warren compares the emerging church he anticipates with the Celtic church of the past.

Wegner, Rob, and Brian Johnson. *Deeply Rooted: Planting Our Lives and Planting the Gospel*. Exponential, 2025. <https://exponential.org/product/deeply-rooted/>.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A short guide by two leaders of the Kansas City Underground, a network of microchurches, written as a companion to Exponential's Microchurch Next video series. It argues that gospel multiplication grows from an ordinary, rooted life — relationships and habits of everyday witness — rather than from a starting method, and addresses individual disciples rather than planters. Wegner's earlier book with Ford and Hirsch, *The Starfish and the Spirit*, addresses movement leaders; this one is written for those they lead.

Bivocational and Covocational Ministry

See also the list on Money and Funding.

This reading list is on planters and ministers who earn their living, or part of it, by work other than the church's, and on that work as a setting for mission. How churches and their planters are otherwise paid for has a list of its own.

Brad Brisco's distinction gives this list its heading. The bivocational planter takes other work to make up what the church can pay, and hopes in time to leave it; the covocational planter has a calling in the marketplace, never meant to be left, and is called to plant a church as well. The difference shapes a plant's planning, since a bivocational plan assumes that the church will one day pay a salary and a covocational plan does not. The practice is older than either word: Roland Allen was arguing for voluntary clergy in the 1920s.

No book here treats a salary from the church as the goal. They differ over what the other work is for. For Allen it lets the church have ministers it does not pay; for W. Jay Moon and Fredrick Long it is the mission itself, since their planters start businesses in which a new church can meet.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then What the Other Work Is For.

Stetzer, Ed. 'Why Lay People Can (and Should) Plant Churches'. *The Exchange*, Christianity Today, April 2018.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A short online article arguing that planting need not wait for ordained and salaried leaders: in Stetzer's words, 'Building and growing a church depends on competency, not certification.' It puts to North American churches the case Roland Allen made a century earlier for a voluntary ministry, and would be a quick way in for a lay team wondering whether it may start a church at all.

START HERE

Brisco, Brad. *Covocational Church Planting: Aligning Your Marketplace Calling and the Mission of God*. Send Network, 2018. <https://www.sendnetwork.com/book/ebook-covocational-church-planting/>.

ALSO IN Baptist

A book for church planters whose primary vocation is in the marketplace, written for the Send Network of the Southern Baptist Convention's North American Mission Board, where Brisco works on strategy, and reissued by Missional Press in 2021. He distinguishes the bivocational planter, who takes a second job to supplement what the church pays, from the covocational planter, for whom work and planting are 'interlinked and equal' callings, and draws on missional theology for the practices of a planter rooted in a place, among them exegeting the local culture and hospitality.

Halter, Hugh. *BiVo: A Modern-Day Guide for Bi-Vocational Saints*. Missio Publishing, 2013.

A book on bivocational ministry by the pastor of Adullam, a network of incarnational communities in Denver, who also directed Missio, an apprenticing network for missional churches. It holds that the gospel reached the West 'through fully paid, barely paid, and mostly non-paid saints', and offers 'a story and a framework', drawn from Halter's own practice at Adullam, for bringing paid work and ministry together into one calling.

Moore, Ralph. *How Nearly Anyone Can Start a Microchurch: Plant a Church without Leaving Your Job*.

Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/how-nearly-anyone-can-start-a-microchurch/>.

ALSO IN Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A short practical guide, from Ralph Moore's Hope Chapel practice, to leading a reproducing microchurch while keeping one's job and home church membership. It sets out relational practices — shared meals, ongoing questions, a stated priority of making disciples over building congregations — and addresses recurring tensions, among them members who leave or who resist multiplying. Shorter and more method-focused than Cole's *Organic Church*, and written for lay people rather than for planters weighing a vocational call, as Brisco's *Covocational Church Planting* is.

WHAT THE OTHER WORK IS FOR

Allen, Roland. *The Case for Voluntary Clergy*. London: Eyre and Spottiswoode, 1930.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

A book arguing that the stipendiary ministry, suited to some settled churches, is a hindrance to the founding of new ones, and that the Church should ordain men who, like those Paul appointed, can maintain themselves and their families without its support. It follows an article in *The Interpreter* (1922) and *Voluntary Clergy* (SPCK, 1923) on the same subject. His voluntary clergy are men already established in life and in their own occupations, not ministers who take a second job to pay for a ministry.

Brisco, Brad. *Covocational Church Planting: Aligning Your Marketplace Calling and the Mission of God*. Send Network, 2018. <https://www.sendnetwork.com/book/ebook-covocational-church-planting/>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Halter, Hugh. *BiVo: A Modern-Day Guide for Bi-Vocational Saints*. Missio Publishing, 2013.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Moon, W. Jay, and Fredrick J. Long. *Entrepreneurial Church Planting: Engaging Business and Mission for Marketplace Transformation*. Wilmore, KY: GlossaHouse, 2018.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Pioneering

A book on what Moon calls 'entrepreneurial church planting', in which planters start or find businesses that double as places where a church gathers, so that the work is the site of ministry rather than a job taken to fund it. Moon, who teaches church planting at Asbury Theological Seminary, writes with Fredrick J. Long, a New Testament scholar there. Its three parts move from the approach's biblical and theoretical foundations to historical and contemporary examples and suggested starting points. Moon's free Exponential booklet, *A Missional Approach to the Marketplace* (2019), introduces the same approach more briefly.

Moon, W. Jay. *A Missional Approach to the Marketplace: An Onramp to Entrepreneurial Church Planting*.

Exponential, 2019. <https://exponential.org/product/a-missional-approach-to-the-marketplace/>.

ALSO IN Pioneering

A 71-page booklet from Exponential, subtitled 'An Onramp to Entrepreneurial Church Planting': a shorter, free introduction by Moon to the approach he sets out at length, with Fredrick J. Long, in *Entrepreneurial Church Planting* (2018). Moon asks what it would mean for ordinary Christians to carry out their calling within the marketplace, treated as a mission field, and points to cafés, coffee shops and gyms as places to meet people who will not come to a church building.

Money and Funding

See also the lists on Bivocational and Covocational Ministry, and on Buildings, Venues and Space.

This reading list is on how churches, new churches above all, and the people who lead them are paid for: the support a planter raises, the finances of a young congregation, and income from sources other than giving. Planters who earn their own living in other work, and the cost of premises, have lists of their own.

This list holds one survey, of American planters in 2014, and the conclusions drawn from it were disputed when it appeared. The rest is argument and practical guidance, and all of it is American but one report from London.

The principal disagreement is over where a church's income should come from. Mark DeYmaz and Harry Li look beyond giving, to grants and to business; Tim Thorlby's report, the one from London, looks to the letting of church buildings. James Elrod expects giving to remain the main income of most churches, and warns against pursuing other sources. Scott Morton's guide comes from a third practice, the missionary's, in which a minister's salary is raised from personal supporters.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Funding a Church Differently.

START HERE

Barna Group. *Church Startups and Money: The Myths and Realities of Church Planters and Finances*. Ventura, CA: Barna Group, 2016.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A survey report, commissioned by Thrivent Financial, on the finances of 769 church planters in the United States, surveyed in 2014; most were from non-mainline denominations and were reached through networks such as Exponential and Converge. It reports their household incomes and places their circumstances on a five-point scale from surviving to surplus. Jared Siebert, writing for Missio Alliance in May 2016, questioned the conclusion that plants need more outside money: such funding, he argued, 'could just as easily mask our problems as solve them'.

Elrod, James L., Jr. *Creating Financially Sustainable Congregations*. New York: Church Publishing, 2021.

A primer on church finance for clergy and lay leaders with no training in accounting, by a finance professional who teaches nonprofit finance at Yale Divinity School. It covers budgets, reporting, reserves and the management of funds, and argues that most churches will remain reliant on household giving: developing other sources of income, Elrod writes, 'might send mixed signals about the church's mission'. His publisher addresses it particularly to newly formed and growing churches. It takes the other side from DeYmaz and Li, who argue that tithes and offerings are no longer enough.

Morton, Scott. *Funding Your Ministry: A Field Guide for Raising Personal Support*. 3rd ed. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2017.

A guide to raising personal financial support, for ministry workers whose income depends on the gifts of supporters, by a Navigator who led the Navigators' development ministry for 12 years. First published in 1999 by Dawson Media, the Navigators' own imprint, it is used by more than a hundred organisations and churches, by the Navigators' account. This third edition, cited here, adds material on social media, email and budgeting. It is written for anyone raising support, not for planters in particular.

FUNDING A CHURCH DIFFERENTLY

DeYmaz, Mark, and Harry Li. *The Coming Revolution in Church Economics: Why Tithes and Offerings Are No Longer Enough, and What You Can Do about It*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2019.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Buildings, Venues and Space; Estates and Poorer Communities

A funding argument rather than an ethnic one: tithes and offerings, DeYmaz and Li argue, are no longer enough to carry a church, which should add a nonprofit arm that can draw grants and a business arm that lets property and starts enterprises. Mosaic, in a low-income part of Little Rock, is the tested case. George Wood's review puts the objections: pastors running businesses they are not trained for, and the tax and employment law that follows.

Thorlby, Tim. *Assets Not Burdens: Using Church Property to Accelerate Mission*. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2017. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2017-Assets-not-Burdens.pdf>.

ALSO IN Buildings, Venues and Space; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report by the Centre for Theology and Community on how churches of almost every denomination use the buildings they own or rent. Its 2016 survey of over 40 churches in the London Borough of Islington found worship spaces empty for most of the week, and every renting church, most of them Pentecostal or independent, wanting premises of its own. It proposes a social enterprise to let church spaces on the churches' behalf. Ric Thorpe's afterword, as the bishop appointed in 2015 to lead planting in London, ties the income to mission.

Buildings, Venues and Space

See also the list on Money and Funding.

This reading list is on premises: the buildings in which churches meet, whether owned, rented or shared, and what they cost a congregation in money and permission. It treats buildings as a question of mission and money rather than of architecture or heritage, and most of its evidence comes from London.

An established congregation may own more space than it uses, and a building that is expensive to maintain and no longer fit for its purpose can hinder the work it was built for. A new congregation, often a migrant or Pentecostal one, may have no building at all: it rents, often moves, and finds that few of the buildings open to it count as places of worship under the planning system. The two meet when an older church lets its building to a younger one, or sells it.

The principal question, which the title of one report here states, is whether property is a burden to be carried or an asset for mission. Those who answer that it is an asset mean more than one thing by it: a building used through the week by the community and by other congregations, or a building let for income, whether through a social enterprise shared by several churches or a business run by one church itself.

DeYmaz, Mark, and Harry Li. *The Coming Revolution in Church Economics: Why Tithes and Offerings Are No Longer Enough, and What You Can Do about It*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2019.

ALSO IN Money and Funding; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Estates and Poorer Communities

A funding argument rather than an ethnic one: tithes and offerings, DeYmaz and Li argue, are no longer enough to carry a church, which should add a nonprofit arm that can draw grants and a business arm that lets property and starts enterprises. Mosaic, in a low-income part of Little Rock, is the tested case. George Wood's review puts the objections: pastors running businesses they are not trained for, and the tax and employment law that follows.

Rogers, Andrew. *Being Built Together: A Story of New Black Majority Churches in the London Borough of Southwark*. London: University of Roehampton, 2013. <https://www.roehampton.ac.uk/globalassets/documents/humanities/being20built20togethersb203-7-13.pdf>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Cities and Urban Areas; Africa

A report, written by Andrew Rogers of the University of Roehampton, on the new black majority churches of the London Borough of Southwark, from a partnership with Southwark for Jesus and Churches Together in South London. It identified 252 such churches and estimates more than 240 in operation, over twice as many as all the borough's other churches, with nearly half in one postcode. Its chief practical subject is premises: congregations unable to find buildings the planning system counts as suitable for worship, some meeting in industrial units without permission.

Thorlby, Tim. *Assets Not Burdens: Using Church Property to Accelerate Mission*. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2017. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2017-Assets-not-Burdens.pdf>.

ALSO IN Money and Funding; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report by the Centre for Theology and Community on how churches of almost every denomination use the buildings they own or rent. Its 2016 survey of over 40 churches in the London Borough of Islington found worship spaces empty for most of the week, and every renting church, most of them Pentecostal or independent, wanting premises of its own. It proposes a social enterprise to let church spaces on the churches' behalf. Ric Thorpe's afterword, as the bishop appointed in 2015 to lead planting in London, ties the income to mission.

Research

Studies and Reports on Church Planting

Research on new churches: counts and surveys of them, studies that follow a single church or place, and work on the people who start them. The Church of England's statements of policy are in the list on Church of England Papers and Reports, and research on the growth and decline of churches in general is in Church Growth; a few such studies are here too, where they bear on new churches. Whether a new church reaches people who belonged to none, or gathers Christians from elsewhere, is argued in the list on Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth.

The principal disagreement is over what should count as a new church's success. Much of this research measures it by number: how many congregations start, how many attend and how many last. By that measure Bob Jackson and Bev Botting, reporting on the northern province, find it 'hard to see how [fresh expressions] as a whole can drive church growth'. George Lings, whose own surveys counted more than a thousand fresh expressions, questioned the assumption that each should become a large church: his study of Crossnet, a network-based community in Bristol, records its members' discovery that 'remaining small can be a significant gift'.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then The Church of England's Own Research, Studies of Particular Places, What the Data Says About Planters, Why Churches Do Not Grow and Movements and Multiplication.

START HERE

Church Growth Research Programme. *From Anecdote to Evidence: Findings from the Church Growth Research Programme 2011-2013*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2014. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/from_anecdote_to_evidence_-_the_report.pdf.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church of England Papers and Reports

The summary report of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme: 18 months of research, commissioned for the Archbishops' Council and the Church Commissioners, into what is statistically associated with growth and decline. The University of Essex, under David Voas, analysed attendance statistics and surveyed growing, declining and stable churches, and a strand at Ripon College Cuddesdon studied church planting. The researchers found 'no single and simple recipe for growth', though some factors, such as employing a youth worker, are associated with it. Mark Hart's critique, 'From Delusion to Reality', argues that the report overstates what the data show, and its press release more so.

Lings, George. *Encountering The Day of Small Things*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/encounteringthedayofsmallthings-web.pdf>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesial Minimum

The published summary of *The Day of Small Things*, and the short way into it. For the criteria by which a gathering was counted as a church, and the argument about them, the full report is where they are set out.

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church; Anglican; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A survey of 1,109 fresh expressions in the Church of England, started between 1992 and 2014 in 21 dioceses and studied from 2012 to 2016 through interviews with their leaders. They make up on average 15 per cent of a diocese's church communities, with over 50,600 people attending, and four times as many were being started each year as in 2004. Section 2.6 sets the survey's indicators against the eight criteria of the 2012 Anglican-Methodist report, objecting that those criteria make practices rather than relationship determine what counts as a church; pages 43-44 set out whether attenders were churchd, de-churchd or non-churchd, each estimate of those new to church lower than the last.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. 'The State of Church Planting in the United States: Research Overview and Qualitative Study of Primary Church Planting Entities'. *Journal of the American Society for Church Growth* 19, no. 2 (2008): 1-42.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters; Formation and Training

An article that reviews existing research on church planting in the United States and reports Leadership Network's study of 2007, which reviewed the contribution and impact of four kinds of planting body: denominations, networks, churches that plant churches, and house churches. It reports that around 68 per cent of plants still exist four years after starting, and that the assessment, preparation and coaching of the planter have 'a dramatic impact' on the planter's wellbeing and on the new church's vitality and survival. The same authors' *Viral Churches* (2010) asks what distinguishes the churches that go on to multiply.

THE CHURCH OF ENGLAND'S OWN RESEARCH

Bell, James, and Jill Hopkinson. *Shaping Strategies for Mission and Growth in Rural Multi-Church Groups: A Summary of Key Findings and Implications of Recent Research*. Archbishops' Council, 2017. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2017-11/shaping-strategies-for-mission-and-growth-in-rural-multi-church-groups.pdf>.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns; Church Growth

A short report from the Church of England's Archbishops' Council, signed by James Bell, Bishop of Ripon, and Jill Hopkinson, its national rural officer, which draws together *Released for Mission* (2016), the Church Growth Research Programme's *Going Deeper* and George Lings's case for multiplying churches. It sets out six characteristics its sources associate with growth in rural multi-church groups, co-operation within and between groups among them, and names next steps for the groups and for the diocesan strategies that support them.

Church Army's Research Unit. *Church Growth Research Project: Report on Strand 3b, An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church and Church Plants Begun in the Period 1992–2012*. Sheffield: Church Army, 2013. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/church_growth_research_fresh_expressions_-_strand_3b_oct13_-_the_report.pdf.

ALSO IN Anglican; Fresh Expressions of Church

A report from the fresh expressions strand, Strand 3b, of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme, conducted by Church Army's Research Unit under George Lings within the consortium led by Cranmer Hall, Durham, and dated October 2013. It analyses fresh expressions of Church and church plants begun between 1992 and 2012. It precedes Lings's larger survey of 21 dioceses, *The Day of Small Things* (2016), and sits beside Dadswell and Ross's companion strand on church planting, Strand 4.

Church Growth Research Programme. *From Anecdote to Evidence: Findings from the Church Growth Research Programme 2011-2013*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2014. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/from_anecdote_to_evidence_-_the_report.pdf.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Cockayne, Joshua. *The Communion Dilemma: The Challenges of Leading Eucharistic New Things*. Durham: Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Communion+Dilemma+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Anglican; Ecclesiology; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments; Ecclesial Minimum

A report surveying the leaders of 63 new communities in 20 Church of England dioceses, and by its own account the only current data on their eucharistic practice. Cockayne sets out three responses — not celebrating, celebrating with authorised liturgy and an ordained president, or celebrating without authorisation — and concludes that 'the communion dilemma is a loser's game', urging that liturgical reform be joined to the Church's aim of 10,000 new worshipping communities. Only nine of the 63 never celebrated communion.

Dadswell, David, and Cathy Ross. *Church Growth Research Project: Church Planting*. Cuddesdon: Oxford Centre for Ecclesiology and Practical Theology, Ripon College Cuddesdon, 2013. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/cgrp_church_planting_from_cgrd_website.pdf.

ALSO IN Anglican; Church Growth

A report from the church-planting strand of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme, written by David Dadswell and Cathy Ross of the Oxford Centre for Ecclesiology and Practical Theology at Ripon College Cuddesdon and dated November 2013. A qualitative study built on visits to plants, it describes the models then current, from Holy Trinity Brompton and minster plants to network, cell and Anglo-Catholic ones, and reports on buildings, dioceses, leadership, finance and growth, opening with 20 recommendations. It found leaders reluctant to measure growth by numbers and little record of where growth came from, and called for a longitudinal study. It precedes the programme's summary report, *From Anecdote to Evidence*, by a year.

Foulger, Will, ed. *Shaping Place: Reflections on 4 SDF Projects in Durham Diocese*. Durham: Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research, 2023. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Final+Shaping+Place+Booklet.pdf>.

ALSO IN Anglican

A report from the Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research on four churches in Durham Diocese funded through the Church of England's Strategic Development Funding: St Paul's Stockton, Vine Church Wynyard, Oxclose Church and Hope For All in Pennywell. A four-person team spent November 2021 to June 2022 with one church each, attending services and activities and interviewing clergy and members. Each church has an account of its context and then of the theological themes that emerged, which the team presents as reflecting the questions it brought rather than as neutral findings. Close description of four churches, not conclusions that generalise.

Foulger, Will. *New Things: A Theological Investigation into the Work of Starting New Churches across 11 Dioceses in the Church of England*. Durham: Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research, 2024. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+New+Things+Final.pdf>.

ALSO IN Anglican; Resource Churches; Church Planting Strategy

A report built on interviews with a representative of each of 11 dioceses, with their strategy documents and funding bids, on what the Church of England has been starting and what it calls it. Around 900 new things across the 11, 89 per cent of them inside the parish system rather than standing alone, and 40 of them newly designated resource churches. None of the 11 dioceses used the language of 'church plant'. Foulger reads the descriptors as an ecclesiology already shaping practice, and calls the starting of new things essentially an evangelically driven project.

Gaze, Sally. *Listening to the Voice of Rural Church Planters and Pioneers: A Report on What Helps Rural Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/07/Listening-to-the-Voice-of-Rural-Church-Planters-and-Pioneers-report.pdf>.

ALSO IN Rural and Market Towns; Anglican

A report for CCX, with Rural Missions and Rural Ministries, on starting churches in rural England, led by Sally Gaze and drawn from 36 practitioners, 18 of them interviewed: 12 from the Church of England and six from free churches. It finds rural plants relational and small by choice, often with more young people than the churches around them, and asks overseers for trust rather than control and for funding matched to small and scattered places. Gaze's theological reflection answers the view that planting belongs where the population is dense.

Jackson, Bob, and Bev Botting. *New in the North: New Worshipping Communities in the Province of York 2023*. Faith in the North, 2024. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/optimized_new_in_the_north_2023_.pdf.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Anglican

A report on new worshipping communities across the northern province, drawing on the 2023 Statistics for Mission returns: 388 among 2,616 churches sampled, about one in seven, from which the authors extrapolate some 550 province-wide. It is unusually candid about what the data cannot bear — a 24 per cent attrition rate among fresh expressions, and likely under-reporting of those that have closed. Jackson is a church-growth writer and former archdeacon; Botting is a statistician.

Lings, George. *Encountering The Day of Small Things*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/encounteringthedayofsmallthings-web.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Listening to the Voice of the Pioneer. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2025. <https://ccx.org.uk/content/pioneer-research/>.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Anglican

A report from CCX, produced with the London Pioneer School and marking 20 years since *Mission-Shaped Church*, on what pioneers say of their own experience of the work. It sets out seven findings, with actions the wider Church might take in response.

Listening to the Voice of the Resource Church Leaders: Offering a Framework for Action. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2024. <https://ccx.org.uk/content/voice-resource-church-leader/>.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Anglican

A report commissioned by CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, with research by Alanna Harris and Wendy Brooks, drawing on interviews with 25 leaders of resource churches. It describes what they carry, the breadth of accountability in a senior role, leading amid ambiguity, scaling and transitions, the relationships that sustain them and their standing with bishop and diocese, and closes with a framework for action offered to dioceses and leaders together. Where Foulger's *New Things* surveys dioceses, this hears the leaders themselves. CCX's page carries only a summary; the report was not published for download.

Perrin, Ruth, and Ed Olsworth-Peter. *The Mixed Ecologists: Experiences of Mixed Ecology Ministry in the Church of England*. Living Ministry Focussed Study 2. London: Church of England Ministry Council, 2021. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2021-05/focussed-study-2-the-mixed-ecologists.pdf>.

ALSO IN Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Church of England Papers and Reports

A Church of England research report from the Living Ministry programme, based on interviews with 17 parish clergy about combining pioneering initiatives with inherited or gathered forms of church within a single post. It names time, team and tenacity as what a flourishing mixed ecology needs, and follows this through five themed sections: the culture that enables it, how old and new forms interact, releasing leaders, clergy wellbeing, and the effect of the Covid-19 pandemic. Mixed ecology, it notes, is now the Church of England's stated norm rather than an exception.

Rogers, Cris. *Listening to the Voice of the Estates Planters: A Report on What Helps Estates Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/Listening-to-Estates-Planters-Report-final-1.pdf>.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Anglican; Selecting and Assessing Planters; Formation and Training

A report for CCX, designed and led by Cris Rogers, a Church of England priest who spent 16 years planting and leading a church on a social housing estate. It draws on 45 practitioners, about a third of them from outside the Church of England, and on 450 working-class people asked about training. Its findings favour slow, incarnational models of planting, commitment measured in years and local leadership, and a section asks what success means on an estate. On selection it concludes that the Church's system 'rewards the qualities least needed on estates and undervalues the ones most needed'.

Thorlby, Tim. 'City Centre Resource Churches'. Church Growth Research and Development, February 2015. http://www.churchgrowthrd.org.uk/blog/sharedinsight/city_centre_resource_churches.

ALSO IN Resource Churches

A short piece of February 2015 on city-centre resource churches, written for the Church Growth Research and Development blog by Tim Thorlby, who went on to write *Love, Sweat and Tears* (2016), a study of five churches planted in east London through the Holy Trinity Brompton network.

Thorpe, Ric, Mark Powley and Ryan Gilfeather. *Resourcing the Church? Resource Churches in the Church of England*. Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, Faith in the North and the Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/CCX_012_Resourcing-the-Church-A5-Booklet_Digital.pdf.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Church of England Papers and Reports

A briefing paper on the resource church model as it stood in 2025, covering its definition, history, evidence and theology. It reports congregational growth and engagement with young people, and raises questions about the narrow range of church traditions among resource churches. Written to inform strategic planning and further theological reflection rather than to settle the argument.

STUDIES OF PARTICULAR PLACES

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila, Fiona Tweedie and Liam Jerrold Fraser. *Churches without People, and People without Churches*. Brendan Research, 2024. <https://www.brendanresearch.com/projects/ethnic-minority-christianity-in-scotland-nature-contribution-and-challenges>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Africa

The project report of Brendan Research's study of the diaspora churches of Scotland, whose peer-reviewed paper is 'A Future with Hope'. The project's own page counts over 200 diaspora congregations and says one has been planted every eight weeks since 2000; in Clive D. Field's reading of the report, the churches that answered its survey had 7,200 members between them.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila, Liam Jerrold Fraser and Fiona Tweedie. 'A Future with Hope: Diaspora Churches in Scotland'. *Theology in Scotland* 31, no. 2 (2024): 43-59. <https://ojs.st-andrews.ac.uk/index.php/TIS/article/view/2805>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Africa

An article, the peer-reviewed paper of Brendan Research's project on diaspora churches, reporting a survey of Scotland's diaspora and ethnic minority congregations, which it calls 'the first study of ethnic minority and diasporic congregations in Scotland'. Sixty-five congregations responded, about a third of those contacted. The lack of suitable places of worship 'emerged as a major challenge for nearly all ministries', only 28 per cent owning their building, and the authors recommend that established congregations offer shared or redundant buildings 'for free or at reduced rates'.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila. 'Out with the Old, in with the New? An Introduction to the Phenomenon of New Churches in Glasgow, Scotland'. *Ecclesial Futures* 2, no. 1 (2021): 50-74. <https://ecclesialfutures.org/article/view/11886>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000

An article on the new churches founded in Glasgow between 2000 and 2016, the subject of Akomiah-Conteh's doctoral thesis. It argues that while old institutions wane, 'many new groups are emerging', 'often hidden from other forms of research such as national church surveys', and it raises questions about them, 'not least around the homogeneity of the majority of them'.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila. 'The Changing Landscape of the Church in Post-Christendom Britain: New Churches in Glasgow, 2000–2016'. PhD thesis, University of Aberdeen, 2019.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A doctoral thesis by Sheila Akomiah-Conteh on the churches started in Glasgow from 2000 to 2016. Her later articles report that it identified 110 of them, and the Brendan Research study of diaspora churches across Scotland builds on it.

Brierley, Peter. *Capital Growth: What the 2012 London Church Census Reveals*. Tonbridge: ADBC Publishers, 2013.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A report of the London Church Census of 14 October 2012, commissioned by the London City Mission and carried out by Brierley Consultancy. Sunday churchgoing in Greater London rose by 16 per cent between 2005 and 2012, from 620,000 to 720,000, and places of worship by 17 per cent; the census is the source of the claim that London's churches buck the national trend. Commentary in *Thinking Anglicans* and from the Evangelical Alliance links the growth to black-majority and immigrant churches and, in part, to migration.

Millar, Caroline, and Laura Treneer. *National Church Planting Network Scoping Research*. Chalk Lab for the National Church Planting Network Steering Group, 2022. <https://cte.org.uk/app/uploads/2022/03/NCPN-Scoping-Project-Chalk-Lab-Feb-2022.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Strategy

A scoping report commissioned by the steering group of the National Church Planting Network, supported by the Church of England, Churches Together in England, the Evangelical Alliance and City to City UK, and written by Caroline Millar and Laura Treneer of the consultancy Chalk Lab. It synthesises 19 interviews in autumn 2021 with those leading national planting strategies for denominations and networks, from the Church of England to New Frontiers and the RCCG, under plans, process, funding, place, people and partnership, and reflects on collaboration and the network's role. It finds a national picture hard to draw, given differing theologies, vocabularies and metrics, beside a shared wish for more churches. An executive summary is published with it.

Dalpra, Claire. *Pioneering Pieces: An Evaluation of the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2020. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/pioneering-pieces-full-report.pdf>.

ALSO IN New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Pioneering; Presbyterian and Reformed

A report by Claire Dalpra of Church Army's Research Unit evaluating the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project, which funded five full-time pioneer posts from 2016 to 2021: among artists in Glasgow, on a new-build estate in Bonnyrigg, with students at Stirling, in Ferguslie Park in Paisley and among Ayrshire farming communities. It gathers the reflections of those involved, post by post, then gives the author's own assessment, and asks whether these places offer enough to sustain the planting of a new ecclesial community.

Dunlop, Andrew. 'Catholicity and Connection: An Ecclesiological Framework for the Mixed Ecology Discerned through Research in an Anglican Team Ministry'. PhD thesis, University of Roehampton, 2025. <https://pure.roehampton.ac.uk/portal/en/studentTheses/catholicity-and-connection>.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Rural and Market Towns; Ecclesiology; Parish Church

A doctoral thesis that builds an ecclesiological framework for the mixed ecology from theological action research with the Lordsbridge Team of Churches, an Anglican team ministry of 11 village parishes west of Cambridge. Its question is what holds a mixed ecology of inherited congregations and fresh expressions together, and Dunlop answers with five 'instincts': missio-ecclesiology, in line with Rowan Williams's theology; a missional understanding of pastoral care; interconnection between communities; catholicity, which values ecclesiastical diversity; and a Christ-centredness that unifies the whole.

Foulger, Will, ed. *Shaping Place: Reflections on 4 SDF Projects in Durham Diocese*. Durham: Centre for Church Planting Theology and Research, 2023. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Final+Shaping+Place+Booklet.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under The Church of England's Own Research

Goodhew, David, and Rob Barward-Symmons. *New Churches in the North East*. Durham: Centre for Church Growth Research, 2015. <https://csmc.webspace.durham.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/sites/144/2021/04/NCNereportFINAL.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A report counting the new churches founded in North East England between 1980 and 2015: 125, with a combined usual Sunday attendance of about 12,000. Only 18 were founded by the historic denominations, and 47 have a black and minority ethnic majority. It answers the assumption that the region is simply in decline. Where Brierley's *Capital Growth* counts all churchgoing in London, this counts only new churches.

Goodhew, David, ed. *Church Growth in Britain: 1980 to the Present*. Farnham: Ashgate, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Growth

An edited collection showing that the blanket description of decline misses significant growth in parts of the church and the country. The major essays are Goodhew's own opening chapter, John Wolffe and Bob Jackson on the Diocese of London, and George Lings on the history of church planting and fresh expressions. Where *From Anecdote to Evidence* reports commissioned statistical research, this argues largely from case studies, with one figure and two tables in the volume by the count of the review for British Religion in Numbers. Christopher Cotter, for the Religious Studies Project, reads it as evidence of growth amid overall decline rather than as disproof of decline.

Goodhew, David, ed. *Growth and Decline in the Anglican Communion: 1980 to the Present*. Routledge Contemporary Ecclesiology. Abingdon: Routledge, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Anglican

An edited volume from a five-year international research project based at Durham, testing the assumption that Western Anglican churches decline uniformly while non-Western ones grow. After an overview by Todd M. Johnson and Gina A. Zurlo, 12 case studies, among them Nigeria, India, Australia, the United States and England, show how differently one denomination behaves from place to place, even within a single region. Its frame is the worldwide Communion rather than Britain; the part on England bears most directly on British questions.

Green, Beth, Angus Ritchie and Tim Thorlby. *Church Growth in East London: A Grassroots View*. Theology for the Local Church 5. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2016. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2016-Church-Growth-in-East-London.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A report of interviews held in 2014 with 13 church leaders in five east London boroughs on what they mean by church growth. Eight lead Church of England congregations and five belong to other traditions, in churches of about 40 to 900 worshippers, and the authors state that 13 interviews are not statistically representative. The report sets growth as numbers and conversion against growth centred on worship and community, and argues that numerical growth and growth in faith and discipleship 'have to go hand in hand'. Stephen Cottrell, then Bishop of Chelmsford, responds by recasting the question as one of transformation.

Jackson, Bob, and Bev Botting. *New in the North: New Worshipping Communities in the Province of York* 2023. Faith in the North, 2024. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/optimized_new_in_the_north_2023_.pdf.

ANNOTATED under The Church of England's Own Research

James, Christopher B. *Church Planting in Post-Christian Soil: Theology and Practice*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2018.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

A mixed-method study of the churches founded in Seattle between 2001 and 2014, joining survey and interview data to theological assessment. James sorts most of them into four models — the Great Commission Team, the Household of the Spirit, the New Community and the Neighborhood Incarnation — and assesses each theologically with help from Avery Dulles, the move from sociology into theology that Justin Cober-Lake's review singles out. James Butler's review in *Anvil* doubts how far the findings travel to Britain, where the scale and the funding differ.

Jolley, Andy, and Ian Jones. 'Formation for Mission in Urban Britain: The Birmingham Mission Apprentice Scheme'. *Journal of Adult Theological Education* 13, no. 1 (2016): 33-47.

ALSO IN Estates and Poorer Communities; Formation and Training

An article on the Birmingham Mission Apprentice Scheme, in which the Church of England in Birmingham employed lay apprentices for 20 hours a week to take responsibility, under their vicar's supervision, for growing one area of a parish's life. The seven parishes were all highly urbanised: three on outer estates, two multicultural inner-city parishes, and two where most people belonged to a faith other than Christianity.

Kewley, Daniel, and Sven Östring. 'Can Church Planting Movements Emerge in the West? Case Studies of Three Church Planting Strategies in Western Australia.' *Journal of Adventist Mission Studies* 8, no. 1 (2012): 25-43.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Church Planting Strategy

An article in the *Journal of Adventist Mission Studies* asking whether church planting movements, a category developed in the majority world, can take hold in a secular Western setting, and testing the question against three church-planting strategies in Western Australia. Among the studies of movements in particular places it is the one Australian case, and the only entry here from the Adventist literature.

Lings, George, ed. *Encounters on the Edge*. 56 nos. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit (The Sheffield Centre), 1999-2012. <https://churcharmy.org/our-work/research/publications/encounters-on-the-edge/>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

Fifty-six quarterly booklets from the Church Army's research unit in Sheffield, running from 1999 to 2012, most of them a close study of one new church — mostly British, a few overseas — with strategic and theological commentary attached. Lings wrote or co-wrote 50 of them; six are Claire Dalpra's. Their particular value is that they were written while fresh expressions were being invented rather than afterwards.

Lings, George. *Crossnet: Do Not Despise the Day of Small Things*. Encounters on the Edge 53. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, 2012. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/encounters-53.pdf>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

A case study of Crossnet in Bristol, started by three couples in 2004 and down to about a dozen at the core by 2012, after some 130 people had passed through it. Number 53 of the Encounters on the Edge series. Lings ties the title's point to method: apprentice-style work with a few, one to one, achieving more than traditional approaches to the many.

Paas, Stefan, and Hans Schaeffer. 'Reconstructing Reformed Identity: Experiences from Church Planting in the Netherlands'. *Journal of Reformed Theology* 8, no. 4 (2014): 382-407. <https://doi.org/10.1163/15697312-00804004>.

ALSO IN Europe; Ecclesiology; Presbyterian and Reformed

A journal article, written for a specialist theological readership, by Stefan Paas, a missiologist, and Hans Schaeffer, a practical theologian whose research concerns changing forms of the church and practical ecclesiology. Its subject is Reformed identity, taken up through experiences of church planting in the Netherlands.

Selvaratnam, Christian. 'Reclaiming the Missing Generation'. In *Global Voices: Stories of Church Planting from Around the World*, edited by Winfield Bevins, 71-85. Wilmore, KY: Asbury Theological Seminary, 2019.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural; Formation and Training

A case study of G2, the church plant Selvaratnam led in York, which reached the millennial generation largely by apprenticing new leaders; it is one of the eight case studies in Winfield Bevins's *Global Voices*. Short, and the practical account behind the argument he develops at length in *The Craft of Church Planting*.

Thorlby, Tim. *A Time to Sow: Anglican Catholic Church Growth in London*. Research for the Local Church 9. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2017. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2017-Time-To-Sow.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Parish Church

A report by Tim Thorlby for the Centre for Theology and Community, the sequel to his *Love, Sweat and Tears* on evangelical church planting in east London. It tells the stories of seven Anglo-Catholic parishes in the dioceses of London and Southwark, most in poorer areas, that had grown over the previous five years, from both wings of that tradition, and draws from them habits of growth: welcome, accessible worship with depth, work with children, new service times, community ministry and clergy focused on growth. Its four closing challenges include the scarcity of Anglo-Catholic church planting. It documents growth in a tradition the planting literature seldom covers.

Thorlby, Tim. *Assets Not Burdens: Using Church Property to Accelerate Mission*. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2017. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2017-Assets-not-Burdens.pdf>.

ALSO IN Buildings, Venues and Space; Money and Funding

A report by the Centre for Theology and Community on how churches of almost every denomination use the buildings they own or rent. Its 2016 survey of over 40 churches in the London Borough of Islington found worship spaces empty for most of the week, and every renting church, most of them Pentecostal or independent, wanting premises of its own. It proposes a social enterprise to let church spaces on the churches' behalf. Ric Thorpe's afterword, as the bishop appointed in 2015 to lead planting in London, ties the income to mission.

Thorlby, Tim. *Love, Sweat and Tears: Church Planting in East London*. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2016. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2016-Love-Sweat-and-Tears.pdf>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas; Estates and Poorer Communities; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A report on the church planting from St Paul's Shadwell in east London over the 10 years from 2005 to 2015, with the stories of the five Holy Trinity Brompton network churches involved, all in deprived parishes. The data is very useful: typical Sunday attendance across the five grew tenfold in the decade (p. 86), though four in five regular members had come from other churches. Chapter 9 is excellent on myth-busting, answering nine common criticisms of the planting from a survey of over 500 worshippers and 14 interviews.

Walford, Rex. *The Growth of 'New London' in Suburban Middlesex, 1918-1945, and the Response of the Church of England*. Lampeter: Edwin Mellen Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension

A study of the Church of England's response as the Middlesex suburbs north of the Thames filled with new housing between 1918 and 1945. Walford tracks the church-building campaigns parish by parish, with 38 figures, 24 illustrations and 27 tables. The situation it describes, a church deciding how to follow new housing, would be familiar to anyone planting on a new estate.

Wier, Andy, and Edd Graham-Hyde. *Seeing the Shoots: A Report for the Scottish Church Planters Network*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, December 2024. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/Final-Report-Church-Planting-in-Scotland.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; New Churches in Scotland since 2000

A survey of church planting in Scotland, commissioned by the Scottish Church Planters Network from Church Army's Research Unit: interviews with 14 denominations and networks, and 104 responses from plant leaders. Its finding is that nobody knows the number, because many bodies keep no central record, and that a conservative floor is 200 plants since 2010. Median attendance has grown from 14 at launch to 45, with a median of one faith commitment a year.

WHAT THE DATA SAYS ABOUT PLANTERS

Barna Group. *Church Startups and Money: The Myths and Realities of Church Planters and Finances*. Ventura, CA: Barna Group, 2016.

ALSO IN Money and Funding

A survey report, commissioned by Thrivent Financial, on the finances of 769 church planters in the United States, surveyed in 2014; most were from non-mainline denominations and were reached through networks such as Exponential and Converge. It reports their household incomes and places their circumstances on a five-point scale from surviving to surplus. Jared Siebert, writing for Missio Alliance in May 2016, questioned the conclusion that plants need more outside money: such funding, he argued, 'could just as easily mask our problems as solve them'.

Cockayne, Joshua. *The Communion Dilemma: The Challenges of Leading Eucharistic New Things*. Durham: Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. <https://irp.cdn-website.com/bb7b1d3a/files/uploaded/1+Communion+Dilemma+Final.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under The Church of England's Own Research

Listening to the Voice of the Lay Planters. London: Myriad and CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2022. <https://ccx.org.uk/resource/listening-lay/>.

ALSO IN Anglican; Formation and Training

A report from Myriad, the Church of England's lay church-planting initiative, with CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, the first of the 'Listening to the Voice' series, its research by Alice Bruce and Wendy Brooks. It draws on interviews in late 2021 with 20 lay people from 13 dioceses who had planted a church community, and sets out 10 insights and 10 recommendations, the chief being that no systematic pathway exists to prepare and equip lay planters, and that new ones are needed at the scale of the 10,000 new communities the church envisages. Beside the series' later reports on estates and rural planters and on pioneers, it is the account of the lay ones.

Listening to the Voice of the Pioneer. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2025. <https://ccx.org.uk/content/pioneer-research/>.

ANNOTATED under The Church of England's Own Research

Merritt, Andrew W. 'Maximizing Planter Potential: An Analysis of the Church Planter Assessment of the Wesleyan Church'. DMin thesis, Asbury Theological Seminary, 2024.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan; Selecting and Assessing Planters

A DMin thesis of 2024 at Asbury Theological Seminary analysing how the Wesleyan Church assesses its church planters. Its catalogue record lists case studies, call, appointment, mentoring and evaluation among its subjects.

Rogers, Cris. *Listening to the Voice of the Estates Planters: A Report on What Helps Estates Church Plants Begin, Grow, and Flourish*. London: CCX, The Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, 2026. <https://churchsupporthub.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/Listening-to-Estates-Planters-Report-final-1.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under The Church of England's Own Research

Stetzer, Ed, Jeff Christopherson, and Daniel Yang. *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems: With Particular Attention to Church Planting Churches*. Wheaton, IL: Send Institute and New Churches, 2018. <https://www.sendinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/SI-2018-BPCPS.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Selecting and Assessing Planters; Church Planting Strategy

Benchmarking research on North American planting networks, asking what the churches that reproduce well do differently. Of the 130 organisations that answered, nearly half had taken multiplication language into their mission or vision statements and 73 per cent trained for it, but 74 per cent reported that fewer than a quarter of their churches were actually planting; and the average organisation still optimises for selecting planters rather than for growing churches that plant. American throughout, and concerned with how a planting system is put together rather than how it should feel.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. 'The State of Church Planting in the United States: Research Overview and Qualitative Study of Primary Church Planting Entities'. *Journal of the American Society for Church Growth* 19, no. 2 (2008): 1-42.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Thompson, J. Allen. 'Church Planter Competencies as Perceived by Church Planters and Assessment Center Leaders: A Protestant North American Study'. PhD thesis, Trinity Evangelical Divinity School, 1995.

ALSO IN Selecting and Assessing Planters

A PhD thesis at Trinity Evangelical Divinity School on the competencies a church planter needs, as church planters and the leaders of assessment centres perceive them. Thompson compiles 18 characteristics in three groups, from prayer, integrity and family life to preaching, training leaders and emotional stability, and gives positive and negative indicators for each, so that the profile can be used to assess a candidate.

Walker, Jason Alexander. 'Statistical Evaluation of the North American Mission Board's Church Planter Initial Assessment Instrument and the Implications for the Broader Church Planting Community'. DMin thesis, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2023.

ALSO IN Baptist; Selecting and Assessing Planters

A DMin thesis of 2023 at the Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, giving a statistical evaluation of the Church Planter Initial Assessment, the instrument with which the North American Mission Board of the Southern Baptist Convention begins its assessment of candidates, and drawing out what the results mean for the wider church planting community.

WHY CHURCHES DO NOT GROW

Bretherton, Roger, and R. I. M. Dunbar. 'Dunbar's Number Goes to Church: The Social Brain Hypothesis as a Third Strand in the Study of Church Growth'. *Archive for the Psychology of Religion* 42, no. 1 (2020): 63-76. <https://ora.ox.ac.uk/objects/uuid:447ef235-8ef6-4ee6-b91a-68a6a3d9316b>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Ecclesiology

A journal article proposing Robin Dunbar's social brain hypothesis, which ties the size of human social groups to the size of the brain, as a third strand in the study of church growth beside the Church Growth Movement and social science. It derives five predictions and tests each against the church growth literature: among them, that engagement falls as a congregation grows, that a congregation led by one person is limited to about 150, and that growth beyond that forces reorganisation and tension. The section on transitions in group size bears most directly on a church growing past 150.

Cosper, Mike. *The Rise and Fall of Mars Hill*. Podcast series, 15 episodes. Christianity Today, 2021-22. <https://www.christianitytoday.com/podcasts/the-rise-and-fall-of-mars-hill/>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Power and Its Abuse; New Churches and Networks

The narrative history of Mars Hill Church in Seattle, which grew to 12,000 people across 12 sites and dissolved in 2014, and of Mark Driscoll, who founded it and co-founded Acts 29. Driscoll resigned in 2014 amid serious concerns about his leadership. Setting former staff and members beside historians and sociologists, Cosper makes the series about the conditions that produced Mars Hill — celebrity, and a theology of masculinity — rather than about one leader. Justin Dean, the church's former communications director, has disputed its accuracy. Driscoll's *Confessions of a Reformission Rev.* was written in 2006 from inside the church whose end this describes.

Davis, Jim, and Michael Graham, with Ryan P. Burge. *The Great Dechurching: Who's Leaving, Why Are They Going, and What Will It Take to Bring Them Back?* Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2023.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A report of a survey of American adults who have stopped going to church, analysed by the political scientists Ryan Burge and Paul Djupe. The authors find that about 40 million adults who once attended monthly now attend less than once a year, which they call the largest and fastest religious shift in the country's history. Most are 'casually dechurched', leaving after a move or a change in family life; about 10 million left after conflict or abuse. The evidence is American throughout. The later chapters, on how congregations might respond, would be the place for a planter to look.

Gibbs, Eddie, and Ryan K. Bolger. *Emerging Churches: Creating Christian Community in Postmodern Cultures*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2005.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesiology

A study of emerging churches in the United States and the United Kingdom, built on interviews with about 50 of their leaders over three years, from which Gibbs and Bolger draw nine practices held in common, three of which, identifying with Jesus among them, they treat as core. The authors offer interpretation rather than theological critique, working, in Xochitl Alvizo's phrase, 'more like sociologists', so the book describes the practice of new churches rather than arguing an ecclesiology. A chapter is given to each practice, and an appendix sets out the research method with the leaders' own words.

Gill, Robin. *The 'Empty' Church Revisited*. Aldershot: Ashgate, 2003.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A study of British churchgoing, the revised edition of Gill's *The Myth of the Empty Church* (1993), which revisits its local case studies with new data and substantially rewrites chapters 8 and 10. Gill argues that the over-provision of church buildings, rather than secularisation alone, explains much of the decline in churchgoing: a supply-side account whose subject is why churches emptied rather than where they have grown. It appeared in Ashgate's academic series Explorations in Practical, Pastoral and Empirical Theology.

Hunter, Todd. *Autopsy Reports of Failed Churches*. Vineyard USA, 1986.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; New Churches and Networks

One of the earliest attempts to study church plants that failed rather than those that worked, written in 1986 from inside the Vineyard by Todd Hunter, then pastor of the Wheeling Vineyard in West Virginia and later the movement's national director. Nick Klinkenberg's account of it has Hunter examining 22 failed Vineyard plants and drawing out 10 common reasons for their failure, among them leader development, strategic planning and accountability. Stetzer and Bird's 2008 report on church planting in the United States summarises its conclusions: the lead planter's disposition mattered most, then the site and the training of planters and teams.

Lings, George. 'Learning from the Work of David Wasdell'. Slides for the Inter-Diocesan Learning Community. Sheffield: Church Army Research Unit, 2015.

ALSO IN Parish Church

The slides of a talk by George Lings of Church Army's Research Unit to the Inter-Diocesan Learning Community in 2015, returning to David Wasdell's reports of 1974 and 1975. They chart Wasdell's figures, in which a church with one priest levels off at an average congregation of about 175 whatever the parish's population, set the figures for 2011 beside them, and record the response: the first report 'was noted', and Wasdell's contract for the second part was terminated. They end with questions for dioceses about fresh expressions of church.

Olson, David T. *The American Church in Crisis: Groundbreaking Research Based on a National Database of over 200,000 Churches*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2008.

A statistical study of worship attendance from 1990 to 2006 in more than 200,000 American churches of many denominations, by the Evangelical Covenant Church's director of church planting. A reviewer reports its finding that young churches grow quickly, being more flexible and adaptable than older ones.

Taylor, Steve. *First Expressions: Innovation and the Mission of God*. London: SCM Press, 2019.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity; Fresh Expressions of Church

A longitudinal study, which is what makes it unusual: Taylor researched 11 emerging churches in 2001 and went back to them 11 years later, following their creativity and their conflict, their dreams and their despair. James Butler, reviewing it for *Anvil*, notes that only five of the 11 were still in existence. Four parts, 13 chapters.

Wasdell, David. *Divide and Conquer*. London: Urban Church Project, 1975.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Parish Church; Cities and Urban Areas

The Urban Church Project's second report, dated June 1975. George Lings records that Wasdell's contract for a second part had been terminated, and calls this report 'unauthorised'. In Lings's account it argues that growth by adding members to existing congregations is 'self-defeating', because a group loses the quality of life that sustains it as it grows, and that the alternative is 'growth by multiplication' of small units. Lings sums up the two reports' conclusion as 'The Parish System is fatally flawed'.

Wasdell, David. *Let My People Grow!* London: Urban Church Project, 1974.

ALSO IN Church of England Papers and Reports; Parish Church; Cities and Urban Areas

The first report of the Urban Church Project, which Wasdell founded and directed, taken to General Synod in November 1974. As George Lings's slides of 2015 present it, the report analyses Church of England parishes by population, attendance and 'penetration', the share of a parish attending, and argues that no redeployment of clergy can produce growth; Lings quotes from p. 7 its contrast between 'a gospel of grace available to all' and 'a structure which takes the form of a club with limited membership'.

MOVEMENTS AND MULTIPLICATION

Farah, Warrick, ed. *Motus Dei: The Movement of God to Disciple the Nations*. Littleton, CO: William Carey Publishing, 2021.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Global and Cross-Cultural

A collection from a 2020 research symposium of the Motus Dei network, in five parts, among them case studies and an agenda for further research. It carries more than 30 first-hand accounts, drawn from the Global North and South alike. Evidence rather than advocacy.

Garrison, David. *A Wind in the House of Islam: How God Is Drawing Muslims Around the World to Faith in Jesus Christ*. Monument, CO: WIGTake Resources, 2014.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East; Church Planting Movements; Global and Cross-Cultural

A survey of the Muslim world in which Garrison gathered the accounts of more than a thousand believers from Muslim backgrounds across a quarter of a million miles. He divides that world into nine geo-cultural 'rooms' and counts as a movement a thousand baptisms or a hundred new churches within two decades. The definition is what makes the count checkable, and where the argument about his figures begins.

Prinz, Emanuel. *What Actually Starts Movements: Partnering with God for Kingdom Multiplication*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2025.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting

A study of movement catalysts resting on more than 15 years of Prinz's research, 147 movements and some 32,000 data points, asking which qualities separate catalysts who see breakthrough from those who do not. The empirical counterpart to a literature that usually argues from stories. Not to be confused with his earlier *Movement Catalysts* (2022), which studies 35 movements and is often cited in its place.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. *Viral Churches: Helping Church Planters Become Movement Makers*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2010.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth; Church Planting Strategy

A book drawing on research commissioned by Leadership Network on what distinguishes churches that multiply from those that merely grow. Its definition of a multiplication movement requires half of each new church's attenders to be new converts. Richard Rymarz, reviewing it for *Catholic Books Review*, finds its research detail thin and points elsewhere for a more systematic and critical treatment.

Church of England Papers and Reports

See also the lists on Anglican, Parish Church, and Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy.

The reports and statements on planting new churches and on fresh expressions that the Church of England's national bodies, the House of Bishops and General Synod among them, have issued or received, with the essays and later research that took up the argument. Most of the research on the Church's new churches is in Studies and Reports on Church Planting.

The principal question is the standing of new churches beside the parish. *Breaking New Ground* saw planting as 'a supplementary strategy that enhances the essential thrust of the parish principle'. *Mission-Shaped Church* held instead that 'the existing parochial system alone is no longer able fully to deliver its underlying mission purpose', and proposed that parish churches and churches formed around networks work together across a wider area, and in 2018 the House of Bishops set new church plants 'alongside and of equal value to other forms of mission', asking plants and the churches around them to cooperate. Whether and how far the parish system should change to make room for them is argued in Steven Croft's collections on its future and on the questions the 2004 report raised.

This reading list opens with The Main Sequence, the reports and statements themselves; then Responses and Follow-Up, the essays, papers and research that took up the argument; and Before the Reports, two reports of the 1970s on why parish congregations stop growing.

THE MAIN SEQUENCE

Church of England Working Party on Church Planting. *Breaking New Ground: Church Planting in the Church of England*. London: Church House Publishing, 1994.

ALSO IN Anglican; Ecclesial Minimum

A report on church planting from a working party the House of Bishops set up in 1991, and the document the Church of England's later official material answers to. *Mission-Shaped Church* of 2004 differs from it on strategy rather than on diagnosis.

Church of England, General Synod. *Dioceses, Pastoral and Mission Measure 2007*. 2007 No. 1. London: Church of England, 2007. <https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukcm/2007/1/enacted>.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum

A Measure of the Church of England's General Synod, given royal assent in October 2007, amending the Pastoral Measure 1983 and standing as primary legislation rather than a report. Section 47 let a diocesan bishop, satisfied that a proposed initiative would 'promote or further the mission of the Church', endorse it by what the Measure calls 'a bishop's mission order', without requiring parish status. That section was repealed in 2012 and re-enacted, in near-identical words, as section 80 of the Mission and Pastoral Measure 2011, which now governs the order. It gave the proposals of *Breaking New Ground* and *Mission-Shaped Church* their statutory footing.

Cray, Graham, et al., eds. *Mission-Shaped Church: Church Planting and Fresh Expressions of Church in a Changing Context*. London: Church House Publishing, 2004. https://ccx.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/mission_shaped_church-1.pdf.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Modality and Sodality; Ecclesial Minimum; Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

The report that changed church planting in England, and in the Church of England especially. It sets out the changing missionary context, tells the story of planting up to 2004, and argues that new churches are needed to reconnect with a population increasingly distant from the church — with a strong theological chapter (chapter 5) and a serious treatment of the legal, structural and leadership obstacles. Its two enduring commitments are that mission concerns should precede church concerns, and that context should determine strategy.

General Synod of the Church of England. *GS 2142: A Mission-Shaped Church and Fresh Expressions 15 Years On*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2019. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/gs-2142-mission-shaped-church.pdf>.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

A five-page report put to General Synod in July 2019, 15 years after *Mission-Shaped Church*. It describes fresh expressions and pioneering as a new missionary movement affecting mission practices, ecclesiology, theology, leadership, resources and structures, and carries a motion about work in 10 dioceses. It quotes the more flattering of Church Army's two estimates of who attends a fresh expression, without the caveat Church Army itself attached to it. Of the 'mixed or blended economy' it says only that it 'is important and calls for different expressions of church to recognise and resource one another through an integrated approach'.

House of Bishops of the Church of England. *Church Planting and the Mission of the Church: A Statement by the House of Bishops*. HB(18)05. London: Church of England, 2018.

ALSO IN Anglican; Ecclesial Minimum

An important paper from the Church of England's House of Bishops in 2018, expressing support for church planting, and laying out the broad principles of how it should be done within an Anglican context.

RESPONSES AND FOLLOW-UP

Church Growth Research Programme. *From Anecdote to Evidence: Findings from the Church Growth Research Programme 2011-2013*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2014. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/from_anecdote_to_evidence_-_the_report.pdf.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

The summary report of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme: 18 months of research, commissioned for the Archbishops' Council and the Church Commissioners, into what is statistically associated with growth and decline. The University of Essex, under David Voas, analysed attendance statistics and surveyed growing, declining and stable churches, and a strand at Ripon College Cuddesdon studied church planting. The researchers found 'no single and simple recipe for growth', though some factors, such as employing a youth worker, are associated with it. Mark Hart's critique, 'From Delusion to Reality', argues that the report overstates what the data show, and its press release more so.

Croft, Steven, and Ian Mobsby, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: Fresh Expressions in the Sacramental Tradition*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2009. American edition, with Stephanie Spellers, New York: Seabury Books, 2010.

ALSO IN Anglo-Catholic; Fresh Expressions of Church; Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments; Ecclesial Minimum

An edited volume on what a mission-shaped church looks like when it is rooted in sacramental tradition rather than set against it, written by pioneers, leaders and theologians from Britain and the United States. Contributors include Rowan Williams, Brian McLaren, Stephen Cottrell, Richard Giles and Phyllis Tickle. The American edition of 2010 adds Stephanie Spellers as a third editor and a foreword by Katharine Jefferts Schori. In the argument over fresh expressions it takes the side opposite Davison and Milbank's *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions* (2010).

Croft, Steven, ed. *Mission-Shaped Questions: Defining Issues for Today's Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2008.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church

A collection of essays responding to *Mission-Shaped Church*. A mixed collection, but Croft's own two — opening and closing — are well worth reading; the first argues for loosening Anglican structures to make room for planting and fresh expressions, the last reflects on what it means to be church in a missionary context. John Drane's essay on what maturity looks like for emerging churches is the other one worth the time.

Croft, Steven, ed. *The Future of the Parish System: Shaping the Church of England for the Twenty-first Century*. London: Church House Publishing, 2006.

ALSO IN Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church

A collection of essays by 12 contributors on what church planting and fresh expressions of church mean for the parish system of the Church of England; its own description gives its aim as 'to resource debate and reflection on the development of the parish system alongside and together with fresh expressions of church life'. Rowan Williams writes on a theology of church and mission built around shared encounter with Jesus, George Lings on how fresh expressions sit within an Anglican framework, and Steven Croft, the editor, on training for mission and ministry.

Davison, Andrew, and Alison Milbank. *For the Parish: A Critique of Fresh Expressions*. London: SCM Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy; Parish Church; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Ecclesial Minimum

An influential critique of the fresh expressions movement, from two mainstream Anglicans who defend the parish as theologically necessary. It would be most useful to a reader already persuaded by the movement, since it contests the movement's premise from outside it. Chapter 1, on the relationship between the form of a church and its message, and chapter 3, on the place of the church in salvation, are the significant ones.

Hull, John M. *Mission-Shaped Church: A Theological Response*. London: SCM Press, 2006.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesiology; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Ecclesial Minimum

A book-length theological critique of *Mission-Shaped Church*, arguing that the report never consistently distinguishes the Kingdom of God from the church, and so turns a mission directed towards the world into a strategy for the church's own growth. Drawing on Barth, Hull treats the church as the fruit and agent of mission rather than its goal, and presses the report on its treatment of poverty, its neglect of consumerism and religious plurality, and its Anglican horizon. He writes as a supporter of fresh expressions, if a cautious one.

Nelstrop, Louise, and Martyn Percy, eds. *Evaluating Fresh Expressions: Explorations in Emerging Church*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church

An edited collection assessing the fresh expressions movement four years in, presented by its publisher as the successor to Hull's shorter critique. It asks what counts as a fresh expression at all, how postmodern accounts of truth and tradition bear on it, who actually attends, and what follows for clergy training and pioneer ministry. Peter Rollins contributes 'Biting the Hand That Feeds'.

Perrin, Ruth, and Ed Olsworth-Peter. *The Mixed Ecologists: Experiences of Mixed Ecology Ministry in the Church of England*. Living Ministry Focussed Study 2. London: Church of England Ministry Council, 2021. <https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2021-05/focussed-study-2-the-mixed-ecologists.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican; Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy

A Church of England research report from the Living Ministry programme, based on interviews with 17 parish clergy about combining pioneering initiatives with inherited or gathered forms of church within a single post. It names time, team and tenacity as what a flourishing mixed ecology needs, and follows this through five themed sections: the culture that enables it, how old and new forms interact, releasing leaders, clergy wellbeing, and the effect of the Covid-19 pandemic. Mixed ecology, it notes, is now the Church of England's stated norm rather than an exception.

Thorpe, Ric, Mark Powley and Ryan Gilfeather. *Resourcing the Church? Resource Churches in the Church of England*. Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, Faith in the North and the Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, 2025. https://faithinthenorth.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/CCX_012_Resourcing-the-Church-A5-Booklet_Digital.pdf.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A briefing paper on the resource church model as it stood in 2025, covering its definition, history, evidence and theology. It reports congregational growth and engagement with young people, and raises questions about the narrow range of church traditions among resource churches. Written to inform strategic planning and further theological reflection rather than to settle the argument.

Warren, Robert. *Building Missionary Congregations: Towards a Post-Modern Way of Being Church*. Board of Mission Occasional Paper 4. London: Church House Publishing, 1995.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology; Anglican; Missiology

A Board of Mission occasional paper by the Church of England's National Officer for Evangelism, on how the church could move from a pastoral to a missionary mode, arguing that this needs to be the main focus of the second half of the Decade of Evangelism. *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004) cites its account of church life as worship, community and mission, which Warren drew as three overlapping circles, and traces 'emerging church' to this paper and to his *Being Human, Being Church* (1995).

BEFORE THE REPORTS

Waddell, David. *Divide and Conquer*. London: Urban Church Project, 1975.

ALSO IN Parish Church; Cities and Urban Areas; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The Urban Church Project's second report, dated June 1975. George Lings records that Waddell's contract for a second part had been terminated, and calls this report 'unauthorised'. In Lings's account it argues that growth by adding members to existing congregations is 'self-defeating', because a group loses the quality of life that sustains it as it grows, and that the alternative is 'growth by multiplication' of small units. Lings sums up the two reports' conclusion as 'The Parish System is fatally flawed'.

Waddell, David. *Let My People Grow!* London: Urban Church Project, 1974.

ALSO IN Parish Church; Cities and Urban Areas; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The first report of the Urban Church Project, which Waddell founded and directed, taken to General Synod in November 1974. As George Lings's slides of 2015 present it, the report analyses Church of England parishes by population, attendance and 'penetration', the share of a parish attending, and argues that no redeployment of clergy can produce growth; Lings quotes from p. 7 its contrast between 'a gospel of grace available to all' and 'a structure which takes the form of a club with limited membership'.

Wider Reading

Listed below are resources from additional topic areas that previous students have found useful in studying church planting. Although these topics are not directly about church planting, they connect with the subject by exploring related issues, offering different perspectives and approaches, and providing wider theological connections.

Wider Theological Topics

Focused topics of theological interest that bear on church planting indirectly. Each list takes a single idea, with its own vocabulary and its own body of writing, and gathers what has been said about it from every side. They sit here rather than in the first section because that section is for the subjects any theologian would put on a church planting syllabus, and these are a step behind it: a planter meets them through the decisions they force rather than as topics in their own right. Each is meant to be read whole rather than picked over.

C1-C6 and Insider Movements

A six-point scale, published by the pseudonymous John Travis in 1998, describing how far a community of believers from a Muslim background remains inside its birth culture and religious identity, from C1 (a foreign-language church using imported forms) to C6 (secret believers). The whole argument is about C5: followers of Jesus who remain legally, socially and self-descriptively Muslim, and whose neighbours still regard them as Muslims. 'Insider movement' is the wider term for that position, extended to Hindu and Buddhist contexts. For church planting the interest is not the Muslim world as such but the question the scale forces: whether a church has to be visible as a church, and who decides.

THE FOUNDING EXCHANGE

Parshall, Phil. 'Danger! New Directions in Contextualization'. *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* 34, no. 4 (1998): 404-6, 409-10.

An article warning that C5 goes too far, in the issue that introduced the C-scale. Parshall had worked among Muslims since 1962, and his *New Paths in Muslim Evangelism* (1980) had argued for contextualisation. As Travis restated them in 2000, his objections are to Christians posing as Muslims, to believers' continued attendance at a mosque 'pregnant with Islamic theology', and to their reciting the shahada, the creed that names Muhammad as prophet.

Travis, John. 'Must All Muslims Leave Islam to Follow Jesus?' *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* 34, no. 4 (1998): 411-15.

An article answering Parshall in the same issue, and the case for C5 in its own terms: 'much of our missiological energy should be devoted to seeking a path whereby Muslims can remain Muslims, yet live as true followers of the Lord Jesus'.

Travis, John. 'The C1 to C6 Spectrum: A Practical Tool for Defining Six Types of "Christ-Centered Communities" ("C") Found in the Muslim Context'. *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* 34, no. 4 (1998): 407-8.

A two-page chart, printed within Parshall's article, in which Travis set out the six types and gave the argument its vocabulary. He offered it to help church planters and believers from a Muslim background judge which kind of community would 'best fit in a given context'; in 2000 he wrote that C5 was 'never intended to be a "missionary approach"'. The chart's brevity shows how much later argument has rested on it.

THE CASE FOR

Higgins, Kevin. 'Acts 15 and Insider Movements among Muslims: Questions, Process, and Conclusions'. *International Journal of Frontier Missiology* 24, no. 1 (2007): 29-40. https://www.ijfm.org/PDFs_IJFM/24_1_PDFs/Higgins.pdf.

An article that takes the Jerusalem Council of Acts 15 as the precedent for insider movements: if Gentiles were not required to become Jews, why must Muslims become Christians? Written for a meeting of the International Society for Frontier Missiology, it draws from the passage the questions the council asked, the way it decided and its conclusions, and asks that believers from a Muslim background share in any such judgement now. Tennent had answered the argument from Acts 15 the year before.

Lewis, Rebecca. 'Promoting Movements to Christ within Natural Communities'. *International Journal of Frontier Missiology* 24, no. 2 (2007): 75-76. https://www.ijfm.org/PDFs_IJFM/24_2_PDFs/24_2_Lewis.pdf.

A two-page article defining 'insider movement', drafted after a consultation the journal held in April 2007. It moves the question from the individual believer to the community: the gospel flows through existing families and networks, and believing families remain inside their socioreligious community, which 'becomes the church'. Lewis distinguishes insider movements from the C-scale, holds that they can occur in any religious setting, and criticises church planting that forms 'aggregate churches' by extracting believers from their families.

Talman, Harley, and John Jay Travis, eds. *Understanding Insider Movements: Disciples of Jesus within Diverse Religious Communities*. Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 2015.

An anthology of 64 chapters, most of them previously published, in which advocates set out the case for insider movements. Reviewers find it one-sided: Fred Farrokh notes that none of its chapters gives a dissenting opinion, and L. D. Waterman remarks on the relative absence of Muslim-background voices, though he calls it a reference work for anyone wanting that case in one place.

Travis, John. 'Messianic Muslim Followers of Isa: A Closer Look at C5 Believers and Congregations'. *International Journal of Frontier Missions* 17, no. 1 (2000): 53-59. https://www.ijfm.org/PDFs_IJFM/17_1_PDFs/Followers_of_Isa.pdf.

An article describing C5 believers from inside, by a writer who had lived in a Muslim community for 13 years. Its four case studies are of individuals rather than congregations: believers who keep the fast, pray with verses from the Torah, the Psalms and the New Testament, or change the creed to honour Isa. Travis also answers Parshall's three objections, and allows that few C5 cases had been documented and that C5 may prove a transitional stage.

Travis, John. 'Must All Muslims Leave Islam to Follow Jesus?' *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* 34, no. 4 (1998): 411-15.

ANNOTATED under The Founding Exchange

THE CASE AGAINST

Coleman, Doug. *A Theological Analysis of the Insider Movement Paradigm from Four Perspectives: Theology of Religions, Revelation, Soteriology and Ecclesiology*. EMS Dissertation Series. Pasadena, CA: WCIU Press, 2011.

A book, published from the author's doctoral dissertation in the EMS Dissertation Series, that tests the published case for insider movements from four theological standpoints: the theology of religions, revelation, salvation and the church. Its chapter on the church bears most on planting: against Lewis's account, it argues that a church must know who its members are and guard baptism, the Lord's Supper and discipline. Bradford Greer, reviewing it, calls the analysis 'irenic and generously fair' but finds it confined to the advocates' articles, without field research.

Hicham, E. M. 'A Missiological Assessment of the Insider Movement'. *Foundations*, no. 83 (Winter 2022). <https://www.affinity.org.uk/foundations/issue-83-winter-2023/a-missiological-assessment-of-the-insider-movement/>.

An article assessing insider movements among Muslims, by E. M. Hicham, a minister at a French Reformed Baptist church. On the church, it criticises the practice of leaving converts to become the church within their existing communities, drawing on Phil Parshall's evaluation of a C5 experiment begun in 1983, and it concludes against the insider paradigm in favour of a believer who is a cultural insider but a theological outsider.

Parshall, Phil. 'Danger! New Directions in Contextualization'. *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* 34, no. 4 (1998): 404-6, 409-10.

ANNOTATED under The Founding Exchange

Tennent, Timothy C. 'Followers of Jesus (Isa) in Islamic Mosques: A Closer Examination of C-5 "High Spectrum" Contextualization'. *International Journal of Frontier Missions* 23, no. 3 (2006): 101-15. https://www.ijfm.org/PDFs_IJFM/23_3_PDFs/Tennent.pdf.

An article that asks whether a Muslim who follows Jesus can say 'yes' to Jesus and 'no' to the visible church, and answers in turn the texts most often cited for C5, among them Naaman in 2 Kings 5 and the Jerusalem Council. Kevin Higgins, replying in the same issue, calls it 'a careful biblical and theological assessment'; the issue also printed responses from Travis, Parshall, Hoefer and Lewis.

ASSESSMENT AND REVISION

Dyrness, William A. *Insider Jesus: Theological Reflections on New Christian Movements*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2016.

A book that sets out 'to provide a theological perspective for thinking about' movements to Jesus that stay inside their religious communities, rather than to describe or judge particular ones. Basil Grafas reads it as a theological defence of such movements. Walter McConnell recommends it, though he finds it too optimistic about culture and religion, and some of its arguments about insider movements illogical.

Williams, Mark S. 'Revisiting the C1-C6 Spectrum in Muslim Contextualization'. *Missiology: An International Review* 39, no. 3 (2011): 335-51.

An article arguing that the polarising effect of the scale owes less to the strategies it describes than to the assumptions and mechanics of the spectrum itself. Williams revisits those assumptions and proposes a change in how the scale works, especially over the tension between contextualisation and traditionalism. It would suit a student who wants to assess the tool rather than take a side.

BACKGROUND

Hoefer, Herbert E. *Churchless Christianity: A Report of Research among Non-Baptised Believers in Christ in Rural and Urban Tamilnadu, India, with Practical and Theological Reflections*. Rev. ed. Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 2001.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East

A study of people from Hindu families in Tamil Nadu who follow Jesus without being baptised or joining a church, based on research Hoefer carried out in the 1980s as a Lutheran missionary in India. First published in 1991; this edition adds five chapters and a new foreword. The Hindu-context parallel to the argument over believers from Muslim backgrounds who remain in their communities, it extends that question beyond Islam.

Parshall, Phil. *Muslim Evangelism: Contemporary Approaches to Contextualization*. Rev. ed. Waynesboro, GA: Gabriel Publications, 2003.

ALSO IN Asia and the Middle East

A book on the contextualisation of evangelism among Muslims, by a missionary who worked among them from 1962, first in Bangladesh and then in the Philippines. Parshall had argued for contextualisation for decades when, in 1998, he criticised as going too far the C5 position, in which believers in Jesus remain legally and socially Muslim; this book weighs which forms of Muslim life and worship a Christian witness may adopt without compromising the gospel.

Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

Donald McGavran's *Understanding Church Growth* (1970) distinguishes three sources of numerical increase: biological growth, from the children of existing members; transfer growth, from Christians arriving from other congregations; and conversion growth, from people coming to faith. The distinction is theological as well as statistical, because it exposes what a congregation is actually doing when it reports that it is growing. For church planting it sharpens a particular question: how much of the visible success of new churches is conversion, and how much is redistribution?

McGavran also proposes a separate fourfold taxonomy — internal, expansion, extension and bridging growth — which describes where growth happens rather than where the people come from. The two schemes are routinely confused in secondary literature, and readers should keep them distinct. McGavran offered the three types as a diagnostic, but in practice they are usually used as a scorecard. Later work in the Church Growth Movement, and its critics, has questioned whether the categories can be measured cleanly and whether a focus on numerical increase displaces other marks of ecclesial health.

START HERE

McGavran, Donald A. *Understanding Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970.

ALSO IN Homogeneous Unit Principle; Church Growth; Missiology

The fuller statement of the church growth theory Donald McGavran first argued in *The Bridges of God* (1955), resting on J. Waskom Pickett's research into the Indian mass movements. It is the source of the much-quoted sentence about people becoming Christians without crossing racial, linguistic or class barriers, and the book the debate over church growth and the homogeneous unit principle is about. The revised edition of 1980 adds three chapters on the principle; the third, of 1990, revised by C. Peter Wagner, turns church growth from a chief purpose of mission into the chief one.

Rainer, Thom S. *The Book of Church Growth: History, Theology, and Principles*. Nashville, TN: Broadman Press, 1993.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A survey of the Church Growth Movement in three parts, among them its history, from the forerunners to 'the Wagner era', and its principles, church planting among them. It summarises McGavran's taxonomy of growth and its variants, and with suggested reading at the close of each chapter it would be a convenient single reference for teaching. Rainer writes as an advocate aiming, in his publisher's words, at 'an objective view'; Carlus Gupton expects mainline and missional readers to disagree with much of it.

THE SOURCE

McGavran, Donald A. *Understanding Church Growth*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Wagner, C. Peter. *Strategies for Church Growth: Tools for Effective Mission and Evangelism*. Ventura, CA: Regal Books, 1987.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A strategy manual that works out the Church Growth Movement's measurement apparatus, in chapters that include the harvest principle and testing the soil. Wagner draws together the movement, the Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization and the US Center for World Mission, whose Ralph D. Winter writes the foreword, and argues that strategy is compatible with God's sovereignty and the Spirit's work. Where *Your Church Can Grow* diagnoses a congregation, this sets out tools for planning outreach.

Wagner, C. Peter. *Your Church Can Grow: Seven Vital Signs of a Healthy Church*. Glendale, CA: Regal Books, 1976.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A manual for pastors setting out seven signs of a growing congregation, among them a possibility-thinking pastor, a mobilised laity, the homogeneous unit principle and priority for evangelism. It is where McGavran's categories move from missiology into congregational practice. Ralph Elliott (*Christian Century*, 1981), who takes it as setting out the North American movement's methods and aims, objects to its authoritarian model of the pastor and to congregations segregated by the homogeneous unit principle.

THE CRITIQUE

Gibbs, Eddie. *I Believe in Church Growth*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1981.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A book offering a sympathetic British reception of the Church Growth Movement that is nonetheless alert to what McGavran's categories cannot measure, and a statement of the theological unease from inside the movement. Most of its reception concerns the revised edition of 1985, which Henry Schmidt (*Direction*, 1991) describes as a biblical foundation, on God's people, the church and the kingdom, and gospel and culture, followed by practical treatment of measurement, group dynamics, leadership and strategic planning.

Padilla, C. René. *Mission Between the Times: Essays on the Kingdom*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1985.

ALSO IN Missiology; Latin America

A collection of essays by the Latin American evangelical who argued at Lausanne in 1974 for integral mission (*misión integral*): evangelism and social responsibility as one task. It is the source of the underlying objection to church growth theory, of which McGavran's three kinds of growth (biological, transfer and conversion) are part: that it begins with sociological observation and looks for biblical warrant afterwards. Its essay 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle' answers McGavran's *Understanding Church Growth* directly and would make a useful pair with it; the Langham revision (2010), where the essay is chapter 8, adds one on integral mission's later history.

THE BRITISH EVIDENCE

Bullivant, Stephen. *The 'No Religion' Population of Britain: Recent Data from the British Social Attitudes Survey (2015) and the European Social Survey (2014)*. Catholic Research Forum Reports 3. Twickenham: Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society, St Mary's University, 2017. <https://research.stmarys.ac.uk/id/eprint/1525/1/FINAL%20NO%20RELIGION%20REPORT%20-%20embargo%2014%20May.pdf>.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Church Growth

A research report by Stephen Bullivant, the third in the Benedict XVI Centre for Religion and Society's Catholic Research Forum Reports series, drawing on the British Social Attitudes Survey (2015) and the European Social Survey (2014). It finds that 48.6 per cent of Britain's population now identify with no religion, and that the main driver is 'nonversion' rather than lifelong non-affiliation: for every person raised with no religion who becomes a Christian, 26 raised Christian now call themselves 'Nones'. Issued by a Catholic research centre at St Mary's University, Twickenham; a numbered, survey-based diagnosis beside the more general accounts of secularisation elsewhere in this list.

Church Growth Research Programme. *From Anecdote to Evidence: Findings from the Church Growth Research Programme 2011-2013*. London: Archbishops' Council, 2014. https://www.churchofengland.org/sites/default/files/2019-06/from_anecdote_to_evidence_-_the_report.pdf.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church of England Papers and Reports

The summary report of the Church of England's Church Growth Research Programme: 18 months of research, commissioned for the Archbishops' Council and the Church Commissioners, into what is statistically associated with growth and decline. The University of Essex, under David Voas, analysed attendance statistics and surveyed growing, declining and stable churches, and a strand at Ripon College Cuddesdon studied church planting. The researchers found 'no single and simple recipe for growth', though some factors, such as employing a youth worker, are associated with it. Mark Hart's critique, 'From Delusion to Reality', argues that the report overstates what the data show, and its press release more so.

Finney, John. *Finding Faith Today: How Does It Happen?* Swindon: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1992.

ALSO IN Engel Scale; Evangelism

A report of research into how adults in England come to faith, drawn from 511 questionnaires completed in Anglican, Roman Catholic, Free Church and New Church congregations. Finney found that for most it was a gradual process, taking about four years on average, though the share who recalled a definite time of not believing ranged from over three-quarters in New Churches to about a third in the United Reformed Church. Respondents were about two-thirds women and almost all white. The survey is reported in more detail in Pam Hanley's *Finding Faith Today: The Technical Report* (1992).

Francis, Leslie J., and Philip J. Richter. *Gone for Good?: Church-Leaving and Returning in the Twenty-First Century*. Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2007.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A monograph by Leslie J. Francis and Philip Richter, drawn from interviews and questionnaires with people who had left churches across British denominations, and a sequel to their *Gone but Not Forgotten* (1998). It sorts what leavers gave as reasons into 15 themes, from disillusionment and being let down by the church to problems with worship, leadership and belief, and asks which leavers are the more likely to return. Its evidence bears on the biological and transfer sides of British church growth rather than on new church plants, which this list treats separately under For Planting Specifically.

Hayward, John. 'Growth, Decline and Extinction of UK Churches'. Church Growth Modelling, 15 May 2022. <https://churchmodel.org.uk/2022/05/15/growth-decline-and-extinction-of-uk-churches/>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A web article by John Hayward, published on his own site, Church Growth Modelling, on 15 May 2022 and reprinted less than a week later by Anglican Ink. It applies his Limited Enthusiasm Model across the whole range of UK denominations rather than the Church of England alone, giving each an 'R number' modelled on epidemiological reproduction: below one, conversions fail to outpace losses and the church heads for extinction. Most historic UK denominations fall below one; only three, FIEC, Newfrontiers and the Elim Pentecostal Church, are above it. Complements Hayward's single-denomination model for the Church of England and Goodhew's survey-based *Church Growth in Britain*.

Jackson, Bob. *Hope for the Church: Contemporary Strategies for Growth*. London: Church House Publishing, 2002.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A study applying growth analysis to Church of England attendance data, written while Jackson, an economist by training, was a member of Springboard, Archbishop George Carey's evangelism initiative. It analyses the figures diocese by diocese, identifies where the church is growing as well as the causes of decline, and proposes strategic responses, with chapters on church planting and diocesan finance.

Jackson, Bob. *The Road to Growth: Towards a Thriving Church*. London: Church House Publishing, 2005.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Church Planting Strategy

The fuller and more strategic sequel to *Hope for the Church*, drawn from Jackson's consultancy with churches and dioceses. It argues that decline can be reversed in parishes, dioceses and the Church of England as a whole, and gives two of its four parts to strategies for deploying people and money to support growth.

Jackson, Bob. *What Makes Churches Grow? Vision and Practice in Effective Mission*. London: Church House Publishing, 2015.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Church Planting Strategy

A book on what makes Church of England congregations grow, which counts depth of faith and strength of ministry as growth alongside numbers. It joins strategy to prayer: its central part sets out strategies, from lay leadership to church planting and fresh expressions, on the principle that 'it is those who intend to grow the church who tend to grow the church', and its last part holds that strategy alone cannot produce growth. A congregation planning for growth might begin with the central part.

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ALSO IN Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Anglican

A survey of 1,109 fresh expressions in the Church of England, started between 1992 and 2014 in 21 dioceses and studied from 2012 to 2016 through interviews with their leaders. They make up on average 15 per cent of a diocese's church communities, with over 50,600 people attending, and four times as many were being started each year as in 2004. Section 2.6 sets the survey's indicators against the eight criteria of the 2012 Anglican-Methodist report, objecting that those criteria make practices rather than relationship determine what counts as a church; pages 43-44 set out whether attenders were churchd, de-churchd or non-churchd, each estimate of those new to church lower than the last.

FOR PLANTING SPECIFICALLY

Keller, Timothy. 'Why Plant Churches?' New York: Redeemer City to City, 2002. <https://gospelinlife.com/manual-paper/why-plant-churches/>.

ALSO IN Introductions and Overviews

A brief paper addressing the common objections to planting: that there are already many churches and they are not full, and that plants merely take Christians from elsewhere. Keller argues that new churches are the most effective way of reaching new people in new places, and that planting causes existing churches to grow too. Selvaratnam's Grove booklet of the same title is a slightly longer and more up-to-date equivalent.

Lings, George. *The Day of Small Things: An Analysis of Fresh Expressions of Church in 21 Dioceses of the Church of England*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, November 2016. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/the-day-of-small-things.pdf>.

ANNOTATED under The British Evidence

Paas, Stefan, and Alrik Vos. 'Church Planting and Church Growth in Western Europe: An Analysis'. *International Bulletin of Mission Research* 40, no. 3 (2016): 243–52.

ALSO IN Europe; Key Theological and Scholarly Works; Church Growth

An article testing, with data, whether planting churches grows the church numerically or only moves Christians between congregations. Paas and Vos compare older and younger churches in three small Reformed denominations in the Netherlands and find the younger ones gained about four times as many converts and five times as many returnees, which they credit to location, outreach and entrepreneurial leadership rather than to planting as such. Among the studies of biological, transfer and conversion growth it is one of the few to test the connection to planting empirically.

Stetzer, Ed, and Warren Bird. *Viral Churches: Helping Church Planters Become Movement Makers*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2010.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Church Planting Strategy; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A book drawing on research commissioned by Leadership Network on what distinguishes churches that multiply from those that merely grow. Its definition of a multiplication movement requires half of each new church's attenders to be new converts. Richard Rymarz, reviewing it for *Catholic Books Review*, finds its research detail thin and points elsewhere for a more systematic and critical treatment.

Thorlby, Tim. *Love, Sweat and Tears: Church Planting in East London*. London: Centre for Theology and Community, 2016. <https://www.ctcuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/2016-Love-Sweat-and-Tears.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Cities and Urban Areas; Estates and Poorer Communities

A report on the church planting from St Paul's Shadwell in east London over the 10 years from 2005 to 2015, with the stories of the five Holy Trinity Brompton network churches involved, all in deprived parishes. The data is very useful: typical Sunday attendance across the five grew tenfold in the decade (p. 86), though four in five regular members had come from other churches. Chapter 9 is excellent on myth-busting, answering nine common criticisms of the planting from a survey of over 500 worshippers and 14 interviews.

Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets

Bounded, centred and fuzzy sets are three ways of forming a category. The missionary anthropologist Paul Hiebert applied the first two to the word 'Christian' in 1978, and brought the third into his scheme in 1994. A bounded set is defined by the characteristics its members share, with a clear line between those inside and those outside. A centred set is defined by its centre, and its members are those moving towards it, however near or far they now stand. A fuzzy set has no sharp edge. For church planting the three give different answers to who belongs to a new church, and on what terms. This reading list is about that question; what makes a gathering a church at all is the subject of the list on Ecclesial Minimum.

The argument is over what a church does at its edge. Hiebert held that Western Christians, who think primarily in bounded sets, tend to define a Christian by tests of belief or conduct and to spend their effort maintaining the line, and that a centred set fits more closely what happens in mission. He kept a boundary, and named the difficulty himself: whether an institution such as the church, with its standards of membership, can be organised as a centred set.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Developing the Idea.

START HERE

Baker, Mark D. *Centered-Set Church: Discipleship and Community Without Judgmentalism*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2021.

A book working Hiebert's idea out for a congregation, which places the centred church between one that polices its boundaries and one that has given them up. Its later parts apply the idea to the life of a church, among them discipleship and leadership. Sherri Guenther Trautwein, reviewing it, finds it 'rooted in the nuts and bolts of church life', with examples from a range of churches.

Hiebert, Paul G. 'Conversion, Culture and Cognitive Categories'. *Gospel in Context* 1, no. 4 (1978): 24-29.

The article in which Hiebert set out the idea, through the case of Papayya, an illiterate Indian villager who prays to Jesus after hearing the gospel once: what must he know to be a Christian? Treated as a bounded set, 'Christian' makes evangelism a matter of getting people across a boundary and conversion a single event; a centred set counts those who have turned towards Christ. Fuzzy sets appear only in a footnote.

DEVELOPING THE IDEA

Baker, Mark D. *Centered-Set Church: Discipleship and Community Without Judgmentalism*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2021.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Frost, Michael, and Alan Hirsch. *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2003.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Introductions and Overviews; Missiology; Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Innovation and Creativity; Theory of Change

A book arguing that the attractional church shaped by Christendom cannot reach the post-Christendom West. Frost and Hirsch build on the Gospel and Our Culture Network's account of the missional church, which drew on Lesslie Newbigin, adding three shifts of their own: to incarnational ecclesiology, messianic spirituality and apostolic leadership. They set a centred-set church, defined by nearness to Jesus, against a bounded-set one. Chapter 11, 'Imagination and the Leadership Task', treats imagination as part of a leader's work. A revised edition followed from Baker in 2013.

Hiebert, Paul G. *Anthropological Reflections on Missiological Issues*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1994.

ALSO IN Global and Cross-Cultural

A book bringing anthropology to bear on mission, in which Hiebert sets out his method of critical contextualisation and treats spiritual power, miracles and healing. Its chapter on the category 'Christian' develops his 1978 distinction between bounded and centred sets into a scheme that distinguishes intrinsic from extrinsic and well-formed from fuzzy sets. For a planter working in another culture, the second part's chapters on relations between missionaries and national leaders, and on training leaders, bear most directly.

Shepherd, Jack. 'A Critical Realist Account of the Theological Values of Resource Churches in the Church of England'. PhD thesis, University of Manchester, 2026. <https://research.manchester.ac.uk/en/studentTheses/a-critical-realist-account-of-the-theological-values-of-resource-/>.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Anglican

Interviews at three resource churches with distinctive models, and six wider perspectives, read through a critical realist frame. Shepherd traces three theological lineages behind the form, a Pentecostal ecclesiology owing to Roland Allen, a pneumatological church growth owing to Wimber and Padilla, and a pneumatological missiology owing to Wright and Donovan, and finds no shared or normative understanding of liturgical tradition among them. In place of a definition by criteria he proposes a centred set of five values: centres of spirituality, processes of evangelism, contextual revitalisation, inaugurated eschatology and narrative testimony.

Engel Scale

The Engel Scale charts coming to faith as a series of steps, from an awareness of God without knowledge of the gospel, through understanding it, grasping what it means for oneself and feeling the need of it, to a decision, and in its fuller forms on into growth after conversion. It began as a student's suggestion, which James Engel revised and published in 1973; it is usually traced to *What's Gone Wrong with the Harvest?* (1975), where Engel and H. Wilbert Norton make it the basis of a strategy of communication, fitting the message to where each listener stands. Its versions differ even in their numbering, and in whether the scale stops at the decision or runs past it. This reading list is about the scale and the evidence it has been tested against; the theology and practice of evangelism are in the list on Evangelism.

The question is whether coming to faith can be charted as a single line. The scale orders the steps, so that knowledge of the gospel comes before a grasp of what it means, and that before a decision. Its critics object that the line is too straight and measures only what a person knows, and later models add a second dimension, a person's openness to the gospel. The scale's premise, that coming to faith is a journey rather than a moment, is what John Finney tested against the accounts of English adults who had come to faith: for most, it had been gradual.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Testing It Against the Evidence.

START HERE

Engel, James F., and H. Wilbert Norton. *What's Gone Wrong with the Harvest? A Communication Strategy for the Church and World Evangelism*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1975.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A book applying communication theory to evangelism, and the source usually given for the Engel Scale. Engel and Norton argue that churches often fail to produce spiritual results because they put programmes before effective communication, and propose a strategy of understanding the audience, adapting the message and measuring its effect. The scale sets out coming to faith as a sequence of stages, from no knowledge of the gospel to commitment and, in some versions, beyond it into growth as a believer; sources number the stages differently.

Evangelical Alliance. 'What Is the Engel Scale?' <https://www.eauk.org/great-commission/what-is-the-engel-scale>.

A web page, undated, setting out a form of the scale for evangelists, from 0, 'no interest and/or knowledge of the Christian faith', to 10, 'making a decision to follow Jesus', in three bands, each with the kind of conversation or tool suited to it. Where other forms of the scale continue past conversion into growth, this one ends at the decision, and it says that the gauge 'is only a guide'.

TESTING IT AGAINST THE EVIDENCE

Finney, John. *Emerging Evangelism*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2004.

ALSO IN Evangelism

A book on the thinking and practice of mission in a society where the churches' influence is declining. It came after Finney's survey of how adults come to faith, *Finding Faith Today* (1992), and his comparison of the Celtic and Roman missions to England, *Recovering the Past* (1996).

Finney, John. *Finding Faith Today: How Does It Happen?* Swindon: British and Foreign Bible Society, 1992.

ALSO IN Evangelism; Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth

A report of research into how adults in England come to faith, drawn from 511 questionnaires completed in Anglican, Roman Catholic, Free Church and New Church congregations. Finney found that for most it was a gradual process, taking about four years on average, though the share who recalled a definite time of not believing ranged from over three-quarters in New Churches to about a third in the United Reformed Church. Respondents were about two-thirds women and almost all white. The survey is reported in more detail in Pam Hanley's *Finding Faith Today: The Technical Report* (1992).

Søgaard, Viggo. *Media in Church and Mission: Communicating the Gospel*. Pasadena, CA: William Carey Library, 1993.

A book on Christian communication by the missiologist credited with first suggesting the scale, as a student at Wheaton, before Engel revised and published it. Søgaard faults Christian communicators for borrowing uncritically from secular marketing and treating the gospel as a product to be sold rather than a message to be understood, a critique from inside the scale's own tradition of the persuasion model it was often used to serve.

Theory of Change

A theory of change states how change is expected to come about: what has to change, why, and by what steps. The term is borrowed from the evaluation of social programmes, where it sets out why a programme's activities should lead to the outcomes it seeks. This list uses it more broadly, for how a church moves from one way of being church to another, and above all for how churches shaped by Christendom and inherited habits of ministry might become missional: turned outward, and attentive to the culture they now live in.

It treats that change as a question about what the church is for, not about how up to date or effective a church is: a church can be thoroughly contemporary and still not missional.

The church books agree that such churches must change and disagree about what is wrong. For Guder and his fellow authors, the church must learn to understand itself as sent by God. For Hirsch, it has lost what made the early church a movement, and needs refounding more than reform. For Bolsinger, change is a matter of leadership: a church meets an adaptive challenge by learning, not by applying what it already knows. A second question runs through them: whether theories of change from management and business belong in the church at all. Bolsinger draws on them; Root doubts that they do. Some of the books rest on the experience of one parish or network, whose success need not carry elsewhere.

The books are grouped as Start Here, Why the Church Must Change, What Has Changed, Church as Movement, Changing an Existing Church, Theories from Outside the Church, From Inherited Church to New Forms and The Case Against Business Models.

START HERE

Bolsinger, Tod. *Canoeing the Mountains: Christian Leadership in Uncharted Territory*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2015.

A book on leading a church through change, taking its image from Lewis and Clark's expedition, which expected a river route to the Pacific and met the Rocky Mountains. Bolsinger argues that church leaders were trained for a Christendom world that no longer exists, and translates for churches the distinction between technical and adaptive challenges in Heifetz, Grashow and Linsky's *The Practice of Adaptive Leadership*, drawing also on Friedman and Kotter. The distinction bears most directly on a church that keeps fixing its programmes when its assumptions about church and culture no longer hold.

Guder, Darrell L., ed. *Missional Church: A Vision for the Sending of the Church in North America*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

An edited volume by six members of the Gospel and Our Culture Network, asking what a theology of the church would look like that took seriously that North America is now a mission field. Steven Hovater notes that it gives no examples from actual congregations. George Hunsberger's chapter on the church as called and sent bears most directly on what the church is, and Alan Roxburgh's on missional leadership on how a church changes.

WHY THE CHURCH MUST CHANGE

Bosch, David J. *Transforming Mission: Paradigm Shifts in Theology of Mission*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1991.

ALSO IN Missiology; Key Theological and Scholarly Works

The classic textbook on mission: how mission has been understood from the New Testament through the historical paradigms of the church to the present, followed by the elements of an emerging ecumenical paradigm. It does not address church planting directly, but its analysis of church, mission and kingdom helps planters to think through their practice theologically. The sections on the developments in missionary thinking in the mid-20th century are particularly helpful: chapter 11 and the first two sections of chapter 12, whose 13 elements include mission as the church-with-others and as *missio Dei*. The twentieth-anniversary edition of 2011 adds a concluding chapter by Darrell Guder and Martin Reppen.

Bradbury, Paul. *Home by Another Route: Reimagining Today's Church*. Abingdon: BRF, 2019.

A book written from pioneer ministry in the Church of England, which reads Ezekiel's vision of the valley of dry bones as an image of a church Bradbury sees as marginalised and in exile, and argues that a fresh movement of the Holy Spirit is renewing and reforming it. Where Guder's *Called to Witness* makes the case for change from missional theology, Bradbury makes it from one biblical text.

Guder, Darrell L. *Called to Witness: Doing Missional Theology*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2015.

A collection of 11 essays carrying the premise of *Missional Church* (1998) into doctrine: if mission defines the essence of the church, it has consequences for every area of classical theology. Where the earlier volume drew them for leadership and structure, these essays draw them for theology, chiefly in conversation with Barth and Newbigin. Robert Cornwall places it after an introduction, for readers already grounded in missional theology. Its proposal to reread the Nicene marks of the church beginning with apostolicity would be a useful place to look.

Guder, Darrell L., ed. *Missional Church: A Vision for the Sending of the Church in North America*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998.

ANNOTATED under [Start Here](#)

WHAT HAS CHANGED

McNeal, Reggie. *The Present Future: Six Tough Questions for the Church*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2003.

A book organised as six 'new realities' for the church, from the collapse of church culture to the rise of apostolic leadership. Where Newbigin's *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society* analyses Western culture, McNeal names the changes the church must make in its own life, among them the shift from church growth to kingdom growth and the return to spiritual formation. It is written for church leaders rather than for an academic readership.

Newbigin, Lesslie. *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*. London: SPCK, 1989.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Missiology

A book on the gospel and Western culture by a missionary theologian who returned from long service in India to the English Midlands and found it the more challenging environment. Newbigin argues that splitting facts from values leaves Christian claims counted as private preference, and concludes that the local congregation is the ultimate hermeneutic of the gospel; chapter 18, 'The Congregation as Hermeneutic of the Gospel', would be a good place to meet the idea inside its own argument.

CHURCH AS MOVEMENT

Frost, Michael, and Alan Hirsch. *The Shaping of Things to Come: Innovation and Mission for the 21st-Century Church*. Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2003.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Introductions and Overviews; Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets; Missiology; Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Innovation and Creativity

A book arguing that the attractional church shaped by Christendom cannot reach the post-Christendom West. Frost and Hirsch build on the Gospel and Our Culture Network's account of the missional church, which drew on Lesslie Newbigin, adding three shifts of their own: to incarnational ecclesiology, messianic spirituality and apostolic leadership. They set a centred-set church, defined by nearness to Jesus, against a bounded-set one. Chapter 11, 'Imagination and the Leadership Task', treats imagination as part of a leader's work. A revised edition followed from Baker in 2013.

Hirsch, Alan, and Tim Catchim. *The Permanent Revolution: Apostolic Imagination and Practice for the 21st Century Church*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2012.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting; Modality and Sodality

A book arguing that Western churches have narrowed the fivefold ministry of Ephesians 4:11 (apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd, teacher) to shepherd and teacher, and that recovering the apostolic function keeps a church a movement rather than a settled institution. It draws on organisational theory as well as theology. Darrell Guder contributes the foreword. Andy Johnson, in the *Englewood Review of Books*, finds it 'most certainly not easily accessible'.

Hirsch, Alan. *The Forgotten Ways: Reactivating Apostolic Movements*. 2nd ed. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Missiology; Leadership in Church Planting

A book asking why some Christian movements grew exponentially, and calling what they share Apostolic Genius: six elements of 'mDNA', one of them 'APEST culture', which Hirsch and Catchim's *The Permanent Revolution* develops. Hirsch calls it 'not a how-to book'. The preface new to this edition concedes that few Western churches show all six elements, and argues that a handful of exemplary churches would be enough to change the paradigm.

Kreider, Alan. *The Patient Ferment of the Early Church: The Improbable Rise of Christianity in the Roman Empire*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Church Growth

A historical study of how the church grew across the Roman Empire in its first three centuries, drawing on Tertullian, Cyprian and the *Apostolic Tradition*. Kreider finds the engine of that growth in habitus, patience and formation: a way of life shaped by catechesis that often lasted up to three years before baptism. It would be of use to anyone arguing that discipleship and numerical growth belong together.

CHANGING AN EXISTING CHURCH

Arbuckle, Gerald A. 'Denial, Grieving and Leadership'. In *Refounding the Church: Dissent for Leadership*, 180-200. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1993.

A chapter arguing that any group, a church included, grieves its losses and stays 'haunted or entrapped by the past' until they are admitted and mourned. Case studies of two Catholic religious congregations show denial at work, and Arbuckle charges those in authority with refusing to be 'ritual leaders' of the grieving. Where Friedman's *A Failure of Nerve* reads resistance to change as anxiety, this reads it as unmourned loss. It closes with a ritual of group grieving.

Friedman, Edwin H. *A Failure of Nerve: Leadership in the Age of the Quick Fix*. Edited by Margaret M. Treadwell and Edward W. Beal. New York, NY: Seabury Books, 2007.

ALSO IN Leading Change

A book on leadership in chronically anxious institutions, by a rabbi and therapist. Friedman reads resistance to change as the reactivity of an anxious system rather than a dislike of change, and asks of the leader self-differentiation: a clear sense of self, held while staying connected. Its editors compiled it from Friedman's unpublished notes after his death, and Ray Befus's synopsis observes that not all the chapters are equally developed; the introduction and first two chapters set out the argument.

Mallon, James. *Divine Renovation: Bringing Your Parish from Maintenance to Mission*. New London, CT: Twenty-Third Publications, 2014.

ALSO IN Roman Catholic; Church Growth; Parish Church; Revitalisation and Replanting

A book by a Catholic parish priest in Halifax, Nova Scotia, drawn from the renewal he led in his own parish. It argues that a parish moves from maintenance to mission when it stops being a membership-based community and becomes an assembly of disciples who proclaim and share the good news.

Roxburgh, Alan J., and Fred Romanuk. *The Missional Leader: Equipping Your Church to Reach a Changing World*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2006.

A book on leading a congregation into mission, by Roxburgh with the organisational psychologist Fred Romanuk, for pastors and denominational leaders. It argues that new life comes less from a strategy for growth than from cultivating people, and pairs a five-stage Missional Change Model, running from awareness to commitment, with four functions of the leader, among them cultivating a listening community and engaging the local context. Part One sets out the model.

Roxburgh, Alan J., and M. Scott Boren. *Introducing the Missional Church: What It Is, Why It Matters, How to Become One*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2009.

An introduction to the missional church for local congregations: three theological 'conversations', on the Western context, the gospel as God's mission and a reimagined church, lead into a staged model of change. Where Roxburgh and Romanuk's *The Missional Leader* joins such a model to the leader's capacities, this grounds it in theology. Michael VandenEnden, reviewing it in *Direction*, notes that it names theological apathy as an obstacle without discussing its causes. The closing section puts the model into practice.

THEORIES FROM OUTSIDE THE CHURCH

Written for businesses and other organisations rather than for churches; Leading Change gathers more of this literature.

Friedman, Edwin H. *A Failure of Nerve: Leadership in the Age of the Quick Fix*. Edited by Margaret M. Treadwell and Edward W. Beal. New York, NY: Seabury Books, 2007.

ANNOTATED under Changing an Existing Church

Heifetz, Ronald A., Alexander Grashow and Marty Linsky. *The Practice of Adaptive Leadership: Tools and Tactics for Changing Your Organization and the World*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business Press, 2009.

ALSO IN Leading Change

A book written as a practical companion to Heifetz and Linsky's *Leadership on the Line*. In chapter 2 the authors hold that leadership most commonly fails by treating adaptive challenges, which only changes in people's priorities, beliefs, habits and loyalties can meet, as technical problems with known solutions. Thomas Gyuroka, in the *Journal of Applied Christian Leadership* (2010), finds a tension with Christian theology in the book's assumption that solutions lie within the organisation rather than in divine intervention.

Kotter, John P. *Leading Change*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press, 1996.

ALSO IN Leading Change

A book setting out eight stages for leading organisational change, from establishing a sense of urgency to anchoring new approaches in the culture, which grew out of Kotter's 1995 *Harvard Business Review* article 'Leading Change: Why Transformation Efforts Fail'. Where Heifetz, Grashow and Linsky's *The Practice of Adaptive Leadership* diagnoses the kind of challenge an organisation faces and Senge's *The Fifth Discipline* names the disciplines of a learning organisation, Kotter supplies a sequence.

Senge, Peter M. *The Fifth Discipline: The Art and Practice of the Learning Organization*. New York, NY: Doubleday/Currency, 1990.

ALSO IN Leading Change

A book on the five disciplines of a learning organisation: personal mastery, mental models, shared vision, team learning and systems thinking, which integrates the rest. Senge's systems thinking gives terms for why changing one practice may leave the wider system unchanged. Applying it to the local church, C. Christopher Smith (*Christian Scholar's Review*, 2018) finds language and imagery in it, not a theological model.

FROM INHERITED CHURCH TO NEW FORMS

Halter, Hugh, and Matt Smay. *The Tangible Kingdom: Creating Incarnational Community*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2008.

A practitioners' account of being the church in small pockets across a city rather than drawing people to worship services, drawn from Adullam, the authors' network of incarnational communities in Denver. It is a case study of missional theology put into a different form of church life: the incarnational ecclesiology for which Frost and Hirsch's *The Shaping of Things to Come* makes the case.

McNeal, Reggie. *Missional Renaissance: Changing the Scorecard for the Church*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2009.

A book on three 'missional shifts': from an internal to an external focus, from programme development to people development, and from church-based to kingdom-based leadership. It pairs each shift with a chapter on changing the church's scorecard, making what a congregation measures the lever of change, whereas McNeal's *The Present Future* diagnoses what must change. Brian W. Thomas, reviewing it in *Modern Reformation*, argues that McNeal undervalues Word and Sacrament.

THE CASE AGAINST BUSINESS MODELS

Drane, John. *The McDonaldization of the Church: Spirituality, Creativity and the Future of the Church*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2000.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West; Innovation and Creativity

A book applying George Ritzer's sociological thesis, that modern institutions are organised around efficiency, calculability, predictability and control, to the church. Drane argues that churches adopted this rationalised machinery, pre-packaged worship included, just as the wider culture was losing patience with it. Unusually among critics of consumer culture, he treats the postmodern turn as an opportunity and looks for renewal in creativity. A sequel, *After McDonaldization*, followed in 2008.

Root, Andrew. *The Church after Innovation: Questioning Our Obsession with Work, Creativity, and Entrepreneurship*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2022.

ALSO IN Innovation and Creativity

A theological critique of innovation and entrepreneurship as goals the church has taken over from the culture around it. Root traces this culture of innovation through the history of management, Protestantism and neoliberal economics, and in place of a better technique proposes a recovery of the mystical theology of Meister Eckhart and Johannes Tauler. Where Drane's *The McDonaldization of the Church* looks to creativity to free the church from rationalisation, Root questions the pursuit of creativity and innovation.

Leading an Organisation

Vision and Strategy

See also the list on Church Planting Strategy, in *Getting Started*, for planning where and how many churches to plant.

Vision, in writing on leadership, is a picture of the future an organisation works towards, and strategy the route by which it means to get there. For a church the questions are what it exists to do, where it believes God is leading it, and how its people, money and time are to be ordered to that end. This reading list is about how a church finds its direction and turns it into practice; how churches grow is the subject of the list on Church Growth.

Business writing gave vision this place first: a study of leaders published in 1985 made 'attention through vision' the first of a leader's four strategies. Books for church leaders followed in the 1990s, and church writers have often described vision as given by God to a leader, who then casts it before the congregation.

The books in this list differ over where a church's direction should come from. Rick Warren's *The Purpose Driven Church* offered other churches a pattern drawn from the church he founded; Will Mancini, against the church growth habit of copying what worked elsewhere, holds that each church must discover how it is unique. Critics of the megachurch movement object to its often uncritical use of management and marketing tools to induce growth.

This reading list opens with *Start Here*, then *From Vision to Practice*.

START HERE

Mancini, Will. *Church Unique: How Missional Leaders Cast Vision, Capture Culture, and Create Movement*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2008.

A book for church leaders on discovering and stating a church's vision, by a former pastor who founded the church consultancy Auxano. Mancini sets his method against classic strategic planning, treating vision as a way of life for a church rather than a document. His two tools are the Kingdom Concept, found where a church's local needs, the resources of its people and the energy of its leaders overlap, and the Vision Frame of mission, values, strategy, measures and vision; the first is set out at the end of Part II, the second in Part III.

Sinek, Simon. *Start with Why: How Great Leaders Inspire Everyone to Take Action*. New York: Portfolio, 2009.

A business book arguing that leaders and organisations that inspire begin with why they exist, then how they work, then what they do: the 'Golden Circle'. Sinek sets inspiration against manipulation and holds that it lasts longer; his examples include Martin Luther King and Apple, and he speculates that the pattern reflects the structure of the brain. Of the books in this list it alone was written for business rather than for churches.

FROM VISION TO PRACTICE

Browning, Dave. *Deliberate Simplicity: How the Church Does More by Doing Less*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2009.

A book on keeping a church organisationally simple, by the founding pastor of Christ the King Community Church, which grew from one site into a network of congregations in several countries. Its six principles run from minimality ('keep it simple') to scalability ('keep it expanding'). It is written from the experience of a multi-site church. Browning first published it himself in 2006; this Zondervan edition keeps the same six principles in the same order.

Jones, Laurie Beth. *The Path: Creating Your Mission Statement for Work and for Life*. New York: Hyperion, 1996.

A guide to writing a personal mission statement for work and for life, with exercises, meditations and case histories, by the author of *Jesus, CEO* (1995). Jones holds that a mission statement should be short enough to memorise and recite, and sets a longer vision statement beside it. She draws her examples from biblical and historical figures, among them Jesus, Ruth, Nehemiah and Joan of Arc. Its subject is a person's mission rather than an organisation's.

Leading Change

Leading change is the work of taking an organisation, and the people in it, from one way of working to another. The books in this reading list were written for businesses and other organisations, and treat change in any institution; how churches in particular must change, and whether this literature belongs in the church at all, are the concern of the list on Theory of Change.

Ronald Heifetz distinguishes technical problems, which expertise can solve, from adaptive challenges, which can be met only if the people involved change their priorities, beliefs or habits. Three of the books, by William Bridges, by Heifetz and Marty Linsky, and by Robert Kegan and Lisa Lahey, locate the difficulty of change in the people who must change rather than in the plan, and differ over what holds those people back.

A second divide is over how far an organisation's success depends on those at its head. Jim Collins credits the leaders at the top of the companies he studied; Ori Brafman and Rod Beckstrom describe organisations with no head at all. The evidence on failure is thinner than the literature's confidence suggests: the figure often repeated, that seven in ten change programmes fail, has no reliable study behind it.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then How Organisations Change.

START HERE

Bridges, William. *Managing Transitions: Making the Most of Change*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley, 1991.

A short practical book on the human side of organisational change, by a consultant on transition. Bridges distinguishes change, the external event, from transition, the inner process of coming to terms with it, which runs through an ending, a neutral zone and a new beginning. People react, on his account, less to a change than to the losses it brings, and the book sets out how to help them let go. Where most books in this list concern those who lead change, it concerns those who live through it.

Heifetz, Ronald A., and Marty Linsky. *Leadership on the Line: Staying Alive Through the Dangers of Leading*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press, 2002.

A book on the personal risks of leading adaptive change, the practical companion to Heifetz's *Leadership Without Easy Answers* (1994). People resist not change but loss, the authors argue, and organisations push back against whoever asks them to bear it, in four ways: they marginalise, divert, attack or seduce. The second part sets out the responses, among them getting on the balcony and holding steady. *The Practice of Adaptive Leadership* (2009) supplies the tools.

HOW ORGANISATIONS CHANGE

Brafman, Ori, and Rod A. Beckstrom. *The Starfish and the Spider: The Unstoppable Power of Leaderless Organizations*. New York: Portfolio, 2006.

A business book contrasting centralised organisations, which like a spider die when the head is cut off, with decentralised ones, which like a starfish regrow a lost leg, a leg that can itself grow into a new starfish. The authors also describe hybrids of the two, eBay among them. Church planting writers have used it to ask whether a church can survive the loss of its leader, and Lance Ford, Rob Wegner and Alan Hirsch apply it to the church in *The Starfish and the Spirit* (2021), to which Brafman wrote the foreword.

Collins, Jim. *Good to Great: Why Some Companies Make the Leap . . . and Others Don't*. New York: HarperBusiness, 2001.

A study, the product of five years' research, of 11 American companies that made a sustained leap from good results to great ones, chosen from 1,435 and set against comparison companies. Collins credits 'Level 5' leaders, who combine 'personal humility and indomitable will', and a habit of first getting 'the right people on the bus' and only then deciding where to drive it. The economist Steven Levitt noted in 2008 that the 11, taken together, appeared since to have underperformed the stock market, and that two of them, Circuit City and Fannie Mae, had lost most of their value.

Friedman, Edwin H. *A Failure of Nerve: Leadership in the Age of the Quick Fix*. Edited by Margaret M. Treadwell and Edward W. Beal. New York, NY: Seabury Books, 2007.

ALSO IN Theory of Change

A book on leadership in chronically anxious institutions, by a rabbi and therapist. Friedman reads resistance to change as the reactivity of an anxious system rather than a dislike of change, and asks of the leader self-differentiation: a clear sense of self, held while staying connected. Its editors compiled it from Friedman's unpublished notes after his death, and Ray Befus's synopsis observes that not all the chapters are equally developed; the introduction and first two chapters set out the argument.

Heifetz, Ronald A., Alexander Grashow and Marty Linsky. *The Practice of Adaptive Leadership: Tools and Tactics for Changing Your Organization and the World*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business Press, 2009.

ALSO IN Theory of Change

A book written as a practical companion to Heifetz and Linsky's *Leadership on the Line*. In chapter 2 the authors hold that leadership most commonly fails by treating adaptive challenges, which only changes in people's priorities, beliefs, habits and loyalties can meet, as technical problems with known solutions. Thomas Gyuroka, in the *Journal of Applied Christian Leadership* (2010), finds a tension with Christian theology in the book's assumption that solutions lie within the organisation rather than in divine intervention.

Heifetz, Ronald A., and Marty Linsky. *Leadership on the Line: Staying Alive Through the Dangers of Leading*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press, 2002.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Kegan, Robert, and Lisa Laskow Lahey. *Immunity to Change: How to Overcome It and Unlock the Potential in Yourself and Your Organization*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business Press, 2009.

A book on why people and organisations fail to make changes they sincerely intend. Kegan and Lahey hold that a self-defeating behaviour serves a hidden 'competing commitment', kept in place by a 'big assumption', so that what looks like resistance is self-protection. Their immunity map sets these out in four columns, from the improvement goal to the big assumption, as an exercise. The idea appears in short form in their article 'The Real Reason People Won't Change' (*Harvard Business Review*, 2001).

Kotter, John P. *Leading Change*. Boston, MA: Harvard Business School Press, 1996.

ALSO IN Theory of Change

A book setting out eight stages for leading organisational change, from establishing a sense of urgency to anchoring new approaches in the culture, which grew out of Kotter's 1995 *Harvard Business Review* article 'Leading Change: Why Transformation Efforts Fail'. Where Heifetz, Grashow and Linsky's *The Practice of Adaptive Leadership* diagnoses the kind of challenge an organisation faces and Senge's *The Fifth Discipline* names the disciplines of a learning organisation, Kotter supplies a sequence.

Senge, Peter M. *The Fifth Discipline: The Art and Practice of the Learning Organization*. New York, NY: Doubleday/Currency, 1990.

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A book on the five disciplines of a learning organisation: personal mastery, mental models, shared vision, team learning and systems thinking, which integrates the rest. Senge's systems thinking gives terms for why changing one practice may leave the wider system unchanged. Applying it to the local church, C. Christopher Smith (*Christian Scholar's Review*, 2018) finds language and imagery in it, not a theological model.

Teams and Culture

A team, in a definition from management writing of the early 1990s, is a small group committed to a common purpose for which its members hold themselves mutually accountable; an organisation's culture is the set of assumptions its members share, and teach to newcomers, about how to see and act. This reading list is about how teams work and how a culture forms, as they bear on a church and its leaders, and not about how a church is governed: whether a church should be led by a team of elders or by one senior pastor, a question on which church writers divide, lies outside it. Culture here means the life of an organisation, not the wider culture a church lives in, which is a question for the list on Missiology; and the team that plants a new church is treated in the list on Practical Guides.

Three of the four books were written for organisations of every kind, and church writers who use such books add that teamwork in a church also needs a theological account, which the business literature cannot supply. Patrick Lencioni and Brené Brown write for any organisation, Wayne Cordeiro from and for a church.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Building the Culture.

START HERE

Cordeiro, Wayne. *Doing Church as a Team*. Honolulu: New Hope Publishing, 1998.

A book arguing that every member of a church has a ministry, to be exercised in teams according to each member's gifts, by the founding pastor of New Hope Christian Fellowship in Honolulu. Its chapters move from spiritual gifts to the building of teams. Greg Gilbert, reviewing it for 9Marks in 2001, disputes its premise that people should serve where their gifts and desires lie, holding that 'the need of the church' should decide. It concerns the whole congregation, where the other books in this list concern leaders.

Lencioni, Patrick. *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team: A Leadership Fable*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2002.

A book written as a leadership fable, about a new chief executive and her team, with a handbook on the model it illustrates. Lencioni stacks five dysfunctions as a pyramid, each making the next possible: absence of trust, fear of conflict, lack of commitment, avoidance of accountability and inattention to results. A team that fears conflict settles, in his phrase, for 'artificial harmony'. The organisational psychologists Gordon Curphy and Robert Hogan note that it is not based on research. Alone in this list, it offers a model of how teams fail.

BUILDING THE CULTURE

Brown, Brené. *Dare to Lead: Brave Work. Tough Conversations. Whole Hearts*. New York: Random House, 2018.

A book on courage in leadership by a professor of social work at the University of Houston, who has studied courage, vulnerability, shame and empathy. Brown teaches courage as four skill sets, which she calls rumbling with vulnerability, living into our values, braving trust and learning to rise. Where Lencioni's book concerns how a team works, hers concerns the leader's own courage; its introduction is titled 'Brave Leaders and Courage Cultures'.

Lencioni, Patrick. *Death by Meeting: A Leadership Fable about Solving the Most Painful Problem in Business*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass, 2004.

A book in two parts, a business fable and the model it illustrates, on why meetings are dull and what can be done about it. Lencioni's answer is that one meeting is being asked to do four jobs, and he separates them: a daily check-in, a weekly tactical meeting, a monthly strategic one and a quarterly off-site review. Written for any organisation rather than for a church. It is the practical companion to his *Five Dysfunctions of a Team* in *Start Here*, taking the same argument down to the hour a team actually spends together.

McKnight, Scot, and Laura Barringer. *A Church Called Tov: Forming a Goodness Culture That Resists Abuses of Power and Promotes Healing*. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale Momentum, 2020.

ALSO IN Power and Its Abuse; Ecclesiology

A book on church culture rather than policy, whose introduction begins with the unravelling of Willow Creek after the allegations against its founding pastor, Bill Hybels, in 2018. McKnight, a New Testament scholar, and Barringer argue that goodness, *tov* in Hebrew, has to be formed in a church deliberately, because celebrity and self-protection will otherwise shape its culture. Mary Stahl (CBE International) found it useful for spotting warning signs in a healthy church and for putting 'words to feelings' in a toxic one. Part 1, on how a church's culture forms and deforms, bears most directly on what goes wrong.

Payne, J. D. *The Barnabas Factors: Eight Essential Practices of Church Planting Team Members*. Missional Press, 2008.

ALSO IN Practical Guides; Leadership in Church Planting

A book for the members of a planting team, taking Barnabas as their model and giving each chapter to one of eight practices, 'walks with the Lord' first among them. It includes a guide by which leaders can assess prospective team members against the eight.

Developing Leaders

Developing leaders is the deliberate work of finding people with the capacity to lead and training them, so that an organisation has leaders at every level rather than depending on a few. In the church it is often grounded in two texts: Ephesians 4, in which leaders are given to equip others for ministry, and 2 Timothy 2:2, in which what is taught is passed to others who will teach others in turn. This reading list is about raising leaders in an established church or other organisation; multiplying leaders for new churches is the concern of the list on Leadership in Church Planting, and the training of planters of the list on Formation and Training.

The books in this list treat leadership as a set of skills and habits that can be learned and passed on. John Maxwell, two of whose books are here, defines it as influence.

The premise has critics on two sides. Within the church, the objection is less to training leaders than to learning leadership from business: critics warn that the entrepreneur's strategy displaces the pastor's vocation, and that corporate, top-down models bring the dangers of power into the church. From outside the church comes a further doubt, whether leadership can be taught at all, by an industry one critic calls poorly policed.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Guides and Handbooks and The Objection.

START HERE

Malphurs, Aubrey, and Will Mancini. *Building Leaders: Blueprints for Developing Leadership at Every Level of Your Church*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2004.

A book on designing a church's own process for developing leaders at every level, laypeople and staff alike, by two church consultants. It starts from the observation that most churches have no formal way of training leaders, for want of money, staff and know-how. It includes a chart, devised by Mancini, comparing 16 settings in which leaders can be trained. It is the book in this list concerned with a church's system for developing leaders rather than with a leader's own practice.

Maxwell, John C. *Developing the Leaders Around You: How to Help Others Reach Their Full Potential*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 1995.

A book on developing other leaders, following Maxwell's *Developing the Leader Within You* (1993) on the reader's own leadership. Its premise is Maxwell's principle that those closest to a leader determine how far the leader succeeds, so that finding and growing the people around them is part of a leader's own work.

GUIDES AND HANDBOOKS

Cole, Kadi. *Developing Female Leaders: Navigate the Minefields and Release the Potential of Women in Your Church*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2019.

ALSO IN Women in Church Planting; Leadership in Church Planting

A practical guide to developing women as leaders in churches and Christian organisations, based on interviews with 30 senior leaders and surveys of over 1,200 female ministry leaders. Cole distils this research into eight practices for building a culture that grows women's leadership, addressed to the leaders who set that culture rather than to women themselves. It is a research-based practical guide rather than a first-hand narrative, the distinction this list draws between Start Here and First-Hand Accounts. Cole writes from experience in a large, multisite American church, and the leaders and networks behind her research are mainly American.

Ferguson, Dave, and Warren Bird. *Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2018.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Leadership in Church Planting

The argument that a leader's job is to make other leaders rather than to be one, with five practices and a tool for each, from multiplication thinking to kingdom building. Written out of Community Christian Church in Chicago and the Exponential network.

Greenway, John, Andy Blacknell, and Andy Coombe. *LEAD: 50 Models for Success in Work and Life*. Chichester: Capstone, 2018.

A business book of 50 leadership models, 30 of them classic and 20 the authors' own, presented under the three priorities of a leader the book names: to map, to navigate and to grow. All three authors are Christians involved in church leadership, and Andy Blacknell founded the Church Planting Course with Ric Thorpe; much of the teaching applies directly to church planting. Its particular features are its many leadership exercises and its diagrams.

Marshall, Colin, and Tony Payne. *The Trellis and the Vine: The Ministry Mind-Shift That Changes Everything*. Kingsford, NSW: Matthias Media, 2009.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A book on Christian ministry in general, distinguishing the trellis, the structures that support ministry, from the vine, the growth of people through the word of God. It argues that trellis work, being more visible and tangible, tends to take over, and calls for a shift from running programmes to training people, since every Christian is called to vine work. Walter Strickland, reviewing it for Baptist21, finds its practical guidance thin and cautions against putting it into effect in haste.

Maxwell, John C. *The Leadership Handbook: 26 Critical Lessons Every Leader Needs*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 2015.

A book of 26 short lessons on leadership, each titled as a maxim, among them 'The Best Leaders Are Listeners' and 'People Quit People, Not Companies', and each followed by application exercises and a 'Mentoring Moment'. Where Maxwell's *Developing the Leaders Around You* concerns the people a leader develops, it begins from the question of how leaders lead themselves. It is *Leadership Gold* (2008) under a new title, which the book acknowledges only in its front matter.

Walkemeyer, Larry, and John Teter. *The Making of a Multiplier: Four Seasons to Maximize Your Kingdom Legacy*. Exponential, 2026. <https://exponential.org/product/the-making-of-a-multiplier/>.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting

A leadership-formation guide by two pastors in the Exponential network, working from a four-stage 'seasons' framework adapted from Robert Clinton's leadership research and worked out through the biblical case of Barnabas. It measures a leader's legacy by the leaders they develop and send, not by quick results. Where Walkemeyer's other book, *The River Church*, addresses a congregation's whole culture, this one narrows to the individual leader's formation across a lifetime. Written for pastors, leaders and lay believers alike.

THE OBJECTION

Nouwen, Henri J. M. *In the Name of Jesus: Reflections on Christian Leadership*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1989.

ALSO IN Pastoral Ministry

A short book of reflections on Christian leadership, first given as an address and written after Nouwen had left Harvard to live in a L'Arche community. Taking Jesus's three temptations in the wilderness as its frame, it describes three movements asked of a Christian leader: from relevance to prayer, from popularity to ministry, and from leading to being led.

Woodward, J. R. *The Scandal of Leadership: Unmasking the Powers of Domination in the Church*. 100 Movements Publishing, 2023.

ALSO IN Power and Its Abuse

A theological account of why church leaders come to dominate, developed from Woodward's doctoral thesis at the University of Manchester. He argues that powers of domination are present in the church and must be unmasked if it is to be missional, drawing on Walter Wink on the powers embodied in systems, René Girard on imitation and desire, and William Stringfellow on resisting the powers. Woodward is a church planter and directs church planting for the V3 movement.

Coaching

Coaching is a conversation in which one person helps another towards a goal by asking rather than telling, drawing out the other's own thinking instead of supplying answers. It is distinguished from counselling, which looks back to past hurts and seeks healing, and from mentoring, in which someone more experienced passes on what they know, though in practice the words are often used interchangeably. This reading list is about coaching as a practice for leaders; the coaching of church planters is in the list on Formation and Training.

Business coaching, on John Whitmore's account, grew out of sport, from a tennis coach's discovery in the 1970s that telling players what they were doing wrong did not bring lasting change, while helping them to learn for themselves did; Whitmore, trained in that method, carried it into business. Christian coaching took shape around the turn of the century: a network of Christian coaches was founded in 1998, and Gary Collins published his introduction in 2001.

Many Christian coaches work to the professional standards of secular coaching and add a spiritual dimension, such as listening for God in the conversation. A question that follows is how coaching relates to discipleship: in coaching the person coached sets the agenda, while in discipleship, as one writer puts it, becoming like Jesus is the agenda. The two Christian books in this list stand at different points: Collins presents Christian coaching as helping people to find God's vision for their lives, and Keith Webb's model leaves the agenda of each conversation with the person coached.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then Coaching in a Christian Setting.

START HERE

Collins, Gary R. *Christian Coaching: Helping Others Turn Potential into Reality*. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2001.

ALSO IN Formation and Training

An introduction to coaching from a Christian standpoint, by a psychologist who came to it from counselling. Collins distinguishes the two: coaching is 'for relatively well-adjusted people to build vision and move forward toward the future', and 'does not involve making a diagnosis or giving advice'. A revised and expanded second edition followed in 2009.

Whitmore, John. *Coaching for Performance: A Practical Guide to Growing Your Own Skills*. London: Nicholas Brealey, 1992.

A practical guide to coaching at work and, on Whitmore's own account, the first book to publish the GROW model, which orders a coaching conversation by goal, reality, options and will. Whitmore credited others with the model's name, and who devised it is disputed. It is the one secular book in this list. The book grew through five later editions, which added chapters on purpose, meaning and leadership.

COACHING IN A CHRISTIAN SETTING

Collins, Gary R. *Christian Coaching: Helping Others Turn Potential into Reality*. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2001.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Hopkins, Bob, and Freddy Hedley. *Coaching for Missional Leadership*. Sheffield: Fresh Expressions and ACPI, 2008.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Fresh Expressions of Church; Leadership in Church Planting

A guide to coaching and mentoring missional leaders, produced jointly by Fresh Expressions and the Anglican Church Planting Initiatives (ACPI) as a follow-on from Fresh Expressions' own training courses. Its distinctive focus, within Christian coaching generally, is coaching for those planting churches and fresh expressions specifically, rather than pastoral or life coaching more broadly. Aimed at trainers and mentors working with pioneer ministers and planters, in a British Anglican setting, rather than at a general readership.

Nicholson, Steve, and Jeff Bailey. *Coaching Church Planters: A Manual for Church Planters and Those Who Coach Them*. Association of Vineyard Churches USA, 2001.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Practical Guides; New Churches and Networks

A coaching manual from the Association of Vineyard Churches USA, addressed at once to the planter and to the coach. The manual comes out of Vineyard planting practice. It emphasises the planter's pursuit of intimacy with God, with Jesus's life as the model, and includes a guide for small groups.

Webb, Keith E. *The COACH Model for Christian Leaders: Powerful Leadership Skills for Solving Problems, Reaching Goals and Developing Others*. Rev. and exp. ed. New York: Morgan James Faith, 2019.

ALSO IN Formation and Training

A handbook of the COACH model, a five-step conversation for Christian leaders: connect, outcome, awareness, course and highlights. Webb, who worked for 20 years in Japan, Indonesia and Singapore with Church Resource Ministries, presents it as a change 'from that of telling and expertise to questions and the shared discovery of new solutions'; his own summary of the model includes questions such as 'What has God been doing in your life since we last met?' This revised edition of a book first published in 2012 adds about a fifth more text and appendices on coaching agreements, training and certification.

Ministry and the Leader's Own Life

Pastoral Ministry

Pastoral ministry is the care of a congregation by those called to lead it: preaching and teaching, prayer and the sacraments, visiting, counsel and discipline, the work an older tradition called the cure of souls. This reading list is about that calling and the character it asks for. How an organisation is led is the concern of the lists in the group Leading an Organisation, preaching is the subject of the list on Preaching, and the leader's own inner life is treated in Rule of Life, Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines, and Resilience and Burnout.

The calling is the planter's too. When the Gospel Coalition asked twenty pastors in 2016 to name three books every church planter should read, only a minority of the books they chose were on church planting, and one of the pastors wrote that a planter is a pastor.

The debate is over what kind of leader a pastor is. Since the 1980s critics have objected that the pastor has been remodelled as a shopkeeper, a manager or a chief executive, after the management thinking that shaped the fast-growing American churches of the period, and that a shepherd answers for the people in their care rather than for the size of the congregation. Henri Nouwen and John Stott, whose books open this list, write from the shepherd's side. A second concern is the pastor's own character, and the ways in which the calling can corrupt it.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then The Dangers of the Calling.

START HERE

Croft, Steven J. L. *Ministry in Three Dimensions: Ordination and Leadership in the Local Church*. 2nd ed. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 2008.

ALSO IN Formation and Training; Pioneering; Leadership in Church Planting

A study of ordained ministry built around three New Testament words for it — diakonia, presbyteros and episcopo — treated as dimensions present in every ordained ministry rather than as separate orders, each minister needing to find their own balance of the three. Croft's case is that recovering this pattern matters because the inherited model of ministry no longer sustains a more mobile, declining society, and that secular management models are a false trail. First published in 1999, while Croft was Warden of Cranmer Hall, Durham, this 2008 edition adds some 90 pages and a final chapter, written once he had become Archbishop's Missioner and Team Leader of Fresh Expressions, connecting diakonia to the forming of new contextual communities.

Knight, Nathan. *Planting by Pastoring: A Vision for Starting a Healthy Church*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2023.

ALSO IN Practical Guides

A book in the 9Marks Building Healthy Churches series, arguing that a church plant is a church and a planter a pastor, so that a plant's health is measured by pastoring that produces faith, fruit and a flourishing community, not by size or speed. Knight, who planted and leads Restoration Church in Washington DC, sets this against the entrepreneurial mindset that, in its publisher's words, planters often adopt, in chapters mostly titled as contrasts, such as 'Pastors, Not Entrepreneurs' and 'The Team, Not the Man'.

Nouwen, Henri J. M. *In the Name of Jesus: Reflections on Christian Leadership*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1989.

ALSO IN Developing Leaders

A short book of reflections on Christian leadership, first given as an address and written after Nouwen had left Harvard to live in a L'Arche community. Taking Jesus's three temptations in the wilderness as its frame, it describes three movements asked of a Christian leader: from relevance to prayer, from popularity to ministry, and from leading to being led.

Stott, John. *Basic Christian Leadership: Biblical Models of Church, Gospel and Ministry*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2002.

An exposition of 1 Corinthians 1–4 in five short chapters, published in Britain as *Calling Christian Leaders*. Stott argues that what the church is must decide what its leaders are to be, and that the power of the gospel is shown in weakness, and he draws from Paul's letter models of ministry marked by humility. Its target is leadership modelled on the surrounding culture; a review on the Word and Spirit blog (2007) reads it as a case against autocratic leadership in churches.

Wakefield, Gavin. *The Wise Pastor: Learning from Gregory the Great's 'Pastoral Rule'*. Pastoral 140. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Rule of Life

A Grove booklet by Gavin Wakefield, drawing pastoral wisdom from Gregory the Great's sixth-century *Pastoral Rule*. It opens with an account of Gregory's own life before turning to the *Rule* itself, arguing that a text written for the unsettled conditions of its own day still has insight to offer leaders facing change now. It reaches back to a patristic primary text rather than to contemporary leadership literature, and assumes no previous acquaintance with Gregory or his period.

THE DANGERS OF THE CALLING

Bridges, Charles. *The Christian Ministry: With an Inquiry into the Causes of Its Inefficiency*. London: Seeley and Burnside, 1830.

A treatise on the Christian ministry by the vicar of Old Newton in Suffolk, first published in 1830, reprinted by Banner of Truth in 1959 and in print from them today: the oldest book in this list, and one of a long line of manuals written for pastors. Two of its seven parts ask why ministry fails: one finds the main cause in the withholding of divine influence, and the other finds further causes in the minister himself, among them conformity to the world, the fear of man, covetousness and spiritual pride.

Nouwen, Henri J. M. *In the Name of Jesus: Reflections on Christian Leadership*. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1989.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Packiam, Glenn, with David Kinnaman. *The Resilient Pastor: Leading Your Church in a Rapidly Changing World*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2022.

ALSO IN Resilience and Burnout

A book on pastoral resilience amid what Packiam calls a convergence of cultural upheaval, vocational confusion, spiritual depletion, relational loneliness and collapsing credibility, rather than simple burnout. It argues that disorder in a pastor's calling, spirituality, relationships and use of authority produces disorder in the church's worship, formation, unity and mission, and organises its chapters around those four pastoral and four congregational challenges in turn. Its distinguishing feature is a base of fresh Barna Group survey research, presented through data and infographics alongside Packiam's own argument; David Kinnaman, Barna's president, contributes the foreword. Written for working pastors rather than for students of leadership theory.

Tripp, Paul David. *Dangerous Calling: Confronting the Unique Challenges of Pastoral Ministry*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2012.

A book on the temptations that pastoral ministry creates or intensifies, written for pastors. Its second and third parts name its two dangers: losing one's awe of God, and 'arrival', forgetting who one is. A reviewer for Wisconsin Lutheran Seminary, Alan Gumm, finds three threads running through it: ministry taken for identity, theological knowledge taken for maturity, and success taken for God's approval of a pastor's life.

Preaching

Preaching is the explanation and application of Scripture in the gathered church, and the proclamation of the gospel to those outside it. This reading list is about the sermon and the preacher; the wider work of sharing the faith is the subject of the list on Evangelism, and the pastor's other work of the list on Pastoral Ministry.

Some writers on church planting give preaching a founding place. A new church, they argue, should be gathered and held by the word preached, not by gimmicks, entertainment or eloquence, nor by the momentum lent by the members of a sending church, which fades.

The question on which this list turns is whether a secular culture changes the preacher's task. Some hold that it does not: the preacher's work is not to make the gospel palatable to the modern mind but to preach it clearly and with authority, whatever the hearers now assume. Others argue that a sermon must reckon with hearers who no longer share its premises. Timothy Keller holds that the preacher should anticipate the objections a sceptical hearer would raise and answer them within the sermon, so that the gospel is heard as 'not only comprehensible but also convincing', resonating with the culture of its hearers and yet defying it.

Keller, Timothy. *Preaching: Communicating Faith in an Age of Skepticism*. New York: Viking, 2015.

A book on preaching by the founding pastor of Redeemer Presbyterian Church in Manhattan, written for preachers in a secular culture. Its second and third parts take, in Keller's terms, the context of the hearers and the subtext of the preacher's own heart, and it argues that a sermon must make the truth real to the heart as well as clear to the mind. One reviewer, Jeff Hunt, found the third part's counsel to preach from the heart 'overly simplistic', and thought the book of little help to a beginner without a firmer grounding in sermon preparation.

Discipleship

Discipleship is following Jesus as his learner, and disciple-making is the work the risen Jesus gave his followers at the end of Matthew's Gospel, to make disciples of all nations. This reading list is about how a church forms disciples. The disciple-making movements used to multiply churches are the subject of the list on Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting, the practices of prayer are in Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines, and the ordering of a life by a rule is in Rule of Life.

A study of 1963 by Robert E. Coleman of how Jesus trained the Twelve read the Great Commission as a call to make disciples who would lead others in turn, and critics since have charged the churches with making converts and members rather than disciples. Several writers therefore treat discipleship as a matter of a church's whole culture rather than of one of its programmes: a church that makes disciples, one argues, will always get a church, where a church that sets out to make a church rarely gets disciples.

The books differ over how people are formed. Jim Putman and Bobby Harrington, writing with Coleman, look to relationship, a disciple being made by another disciple who walks alongside. James K. A. Smith looks to worship and habit.

This reading list opens with Start Here, then How People Are Formed.

START HERE

Comer, John Mark. *Practicing the Way: Be with Jesus. Become like Him. Do as He Did.* London: Form, 2024.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book on discipleship as apprenticeship to Jesus, by the founding pastor of Bridgetown Church in Portland, Oregon, built on the three goals of its subtitle. It ends in a rule of life of nine practices, and a free eight-session course for churches accompanies it. A bestseller, it had appeared 23 times on the *New York Times* list by May 2025. Two reviewers, in 9Marks and Christ Over All, find it thin on sin and on the cross.

Williams, Rowan. *Being Disciples: Essentials of the Christian Life.* London: SPCK, 2016.

ALSO IN Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A short collection of six addresses on Christian discipleship by Rowan Williams, given to lay audiences while he was Archbishop of Canterbury and published as a sequel to his *Being Christian*. It runs from faith, hope and love to life in the Spirit, and is written for the general reader rather than the specialist. Among introductions to discipleship here it is the most compact; Geoff Thompson's review of 2017 finds the separate addresses read as one whole.

HOW PEOPLE ARE FORMED

Bevins, Winfield. *Multiplying Disciples: What Movements Can Teach Us About Discipleship.* Exponential, 2019.

<https://exponential.org/product/multiplying-disciples/>.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission; Church Planting Movements

A booklet drawing on three disciple-making movements from church history, the Celtic, the Moravian and the Methodist, for what each can teach the church now. Where Hunter's *The Celtic Way of Evangelism* takes the Celtic mission alone as a model for evangelism, Bevins sets it beside two later movements. His *Marks of a Movement* gives early Methodism a book to itself; this booklet would be a shorter first reading across all three.

Coleman, Robert E. *The Master Plan of Evangelism*. Westwood, NJ: Fleming H. Revell, 1963.

ALSO IN Evangelism; Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting

A short book deriving a method of evangelism from Jesus's training of his disciples, in eight principles, from selection to reproduction. Coleman argues that Jesus invested in a few rather than the crowd, and reads the Great Commission's main verb as 'make disciples', grounding the last principle: those trained train others. Nik Lingle (9Marks, 2013) notes that it rules out treating the point of decision as the main goal; Jared Longshore (Founders Ministries) finds that it underplays the local church's part in discipleship.

Comer, John Mark. *Practicing the Way: Be with Jesus. Become like Him. Do as He Did*. London: Form, 2024.

ANNOTATED under Start Here

Henderson, D. Michael. *John Wesley's Class Meeting: A Model for Making Disciples*. Nappanee, IN: Evangel Publishing House, 1997.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Early Methodist Church Planting

A study of Wesley's methods of forming disciples in small groups, and of the class meeting as a model for making disciples today. Like Kevin Watson's *The Class Meeting*, it is on the small-group machinery behind the General Rules, but it describes every part of the system — society, class, band and select society — where Watson keeps to the class. Charles Yrigoyen, reviewing it in *Methodist History* (1998), notes errors of fact, among them the year of Wesley's death.

Moon, W. Jay. *Intercultural Discipleship: Learning from Global Approaches to Spiritual Formation*. Encountering Mission. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2017.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural; Formation and Training

A textbook on disciple-making read across cultures rather than out of one. Moon, who spent 13 years with SIM among the Builsa of northern Ghana, argues that formation happens through the genres a culture already has, from proverb and story to song, ritual and dance, and that Western discipleship has narrowed itself to the printed word and the classroom. Eleven chapters, each closing with a case study and an exercise. Useful to a planter working in any community whose habits of learning are not their own.

Mulholland, M. Robert, Jr. *Invitation to a Journey: A Road Map for Spiritual Formation*. Rev. and expanded ed. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

An American book on spiritual formation, first published in 1993 and revised in 2016, by a professor of New Testament at Asbury Theological Seminary. It defines formation as 'a process of being formed in the image of Christ for the sake of others', and combines practical teaching on the spiritual disciplines with insights from personality types, on the view that formation happens within a person's given temperament, so that no one practice suits every temperament. The Transforming Center makes it a required text.

Putman, Jim, and Bobby Harrington, with Robert E. Coleman. *DiscipleShift: Five Steps That Help Your Church to Make Disciples Who Make Disciples*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2013.

A book in the Exponential series which argues that neither the attractional church nor the missional one makes disciples of itself: something more basic is missing. It asks a church to make five shifts, among them from programme to purpose and from activity to relationship, on the premise that discipleship is first of all relational.

Rogers, Cris. *Making Disciples: Elevating the Conversation around Discipleship and Spiritual Formation*. Uckfield: Essential Christian, 2018.

A short book that sets out discipleship in three dimensions, head, heart and hands, and serves as an assessment tool with a seven-week course, for a church, a small group or an individual. Rogers wrote it as rector of All Hallows Bow in east London; of the books in this list it is the only one from Britain.

Smith, James K. A. *You Are What You Love: The Spiritual Power of Habit*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book on why people are formed by liturgies they did not choose, and what to do about it: it argues that what people love, more than what they think, makes them who they are, and that love is trained by habit and worship. Written at pastors' request as a more accessible version of the argument of Smith's *Desiring the Kingdom* (2009), it is a short statement of the anthropology a rule of life assumes. Derek Rishmawy, reviewing it, asks whether it overstates the power of habit against the preached word.

Rule of Life

A rule of life is an ordered pattern of prayer, work and relationships by which a community or a person means to live. The Latin *regula* meant a straight rod or ruler, and so a measure; writers on the practice describe a rule rather as a support: a signpost, a railing, a trellis for a growing vine. This reading list is about the rule itself; the practices a rule orders are the subject of Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines, and the formation of disciples in a church the subject of Discipleship.

Three kinds of text go by the name. The oldest are the rules by which communities order their common life, written from the fourth century to the twentieth, a Protestant line among them, and the new monasticism of the last twenty years has produced communities, some of them dispersed, that keep a rule together. Beside these stand personal rules, written for a life in the world, and sets of missional habits, which do a rule's work without the word. Beneath all three lies an argument about people, that they are formed by what they repeatedly do, which is why books on habit and on the disciplines stand here as well as in their own lists.

The principal debate is between the communal rule and the personal one: one critic argues that most rules written now are individual, where the older rules began from a community's shared life. A further question is whether a rule is a return to law, a charge Stephen Macchia anticipates by presenting it as an invitation to grow in grace.

This reading list is arranged by function rather than by date. It opens with Start Here, then The Rules Themselves, Understanding the Tradition, Reading Benedict Now, The Protestant and Wesleyan Strand, Writing a Rule for Today, Community and New Monasticism, Habit and Formation, and Handle with Care.

START HERE

Barnett, James. *Crafting a Community Rule of Life: The Slow Ferment*. Discipleship 21. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2026.

A Grove booklet on a rule of life agreed by a group, rather than written by one person for their own growth: how members who share a rule encourage one another and hold one another to account, with examples and suggestions for practice. Barnett is vicar of St Matts, Leeds.

Benedict. *RB 1980: The Rule of St. Benedict in English*. Edited by Timothy Fry. Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1982.

The primary text: Benedict's Rule, written about 530, in a prologue and 73 chapters on the life of a monastic community, from the qualities of an abbot to daily practice and the governance of the community. This paperback prints, in about a hundred pages, the English of RB 1980, the scholarly translation first published with the Latin text and notes in 1981, to mark the 1,500th anniversary of Benedict's traditional birth date. The Catholic Encyclopedia of 1913 named 'its wonderful discretion and moderation' as the first thing to strike a reader.

Macchia, Stephen A. *Crafting a Rule of Life: An Invitation to the Well-Ordered Way*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2012.

A workbook for writing a personal rule of life, arranged in 12 sessions for a group or an individual. It defines a rule as a description of the 'Spirit-empowered rhythms and relationships' of a life. Two reviewers thought it suited to newer Christians; one, Jennifer Burns Lewis, found that it makes only passing reference to Benedict.

Peters, Greg. *The Story of Monasticism: Retrieving an Ancient Tradition for Contemporary Spirituality*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2015.

A single-volume history of Christian monasticism from Antony to the present, Eastern and Western, Catholic and Protestant, written by an Anglican priest for evangelical and Protestant readers taught to regard monasticism as an aberration. Each chapter ends with a reflection on what the tradition offers now. John Gavin, reviewing it, found that it breaks no new ground but reads well enough for courses on spirituality and for churches.

THE RULES THEMSELVES

Augustine of Hippo. *The Monastic Rules*. Edited by Boniface Ramsey. Hyde Park, NY: New City Press, 2004.

A volume of Augustine's monastic writings: his Rule, written about 396 for the community he left when he became a bishop, and the related texts, in Sister Agatha Mary's translation, with essays on its background and spirit. The Rule is shorter than Benedict's and less concerned with a timetable than with the interior life: with charity, and a common life of 'one heart and one soul'. It turns a quarrel over clothes into a lesson about the heart's inner garment.

Basil of Caesarea. *The Asketikon of St Basil the Great*. Translated by Anna M. Silvas. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005.

A scholarly translation, in the Oxford Early Christian Studies series, of Basil's ascetic writings, the Longer and Shorter Responses often called his Long and Short Rules, with studies of their text and of the rise of monasticism in fourth-century Anatolia. The Longer Responses begin with the commandments and their order, and with the love of God, and work outwards to the love of neighbour.

Columbanus. *Saint Columbanus: Selected Writings*. Edited by Alexander O'Hara. Dublin: Veritas, 2015.

ALSO IN Celtic and Early British Mission

A book of selected writings by Columbanus, edited by Alexander O'Hara for the 1,400th anniversary of his death in 615. Columbanus, the Irish counterweight to Benedict and much sterner, worked on the Continent rather than in Britain; the book shows Irish monastic mission abroad in a missionary's own words. Peter Costello, reviewing it in *The Irish Catholic*, describes it as a brief survey 'immediately accessible to the general reader'. It would be useful for seeing that the monastic tradition was never monolithic.

Francis of Assisi. *Francis of Assisi: Early Documents, Volume 1: The Saint*. Edited by Regis J. Armstrong, J. A. Wayne Hellmann and William J. Short. New York: New City Press, 1999.

The first volume of an English edition of the early Franciscan sources, holding Francis's own writings, among them the Earlier and Later Rules for his brothers and the Rule for Hermitages. It also holds his exhortations to the lay penitents from whom the Franciscan Third Order grew: a dispersed community living by a rule in the world, of which Anglican Franciscans now have a counterpart of their own.

Kardong, Terrence G. *Pillars of Community: Four Rules of Pre-Benedictine Monastic Life*. Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 2010.

A volume of four rules written before Benedict's, those of Pachomius, Basil and Augustine and the rules of Lérins, each with commentary, by a Benedictine monk and scholar of the Rule. It gathers in one volume older rules on which Benedict's own Rule drew.

Roger of Taizé. *The Rule of Taizé*. London: SPCK, 2012.

The document in which Brother Roger set down the common life of the Taizé Community, written during a long retreat in the winter of 1952–53 and first published in French in 1954; this edition prints the French and English texts together. It is a modern, brief and ecumenical rule, and the community that lives by it now welcomes tens of thousands of young adults a year.

Wesley, John. 'The Nature, Design, and General Rules of the United Societies'. In *The Works of John Wesley, Volume 9: The Methodist Societies; History, Nature, and Design*, edited by Rupert E. Davies, 69–73. Nashville, TN: Abingdon Press, 1989.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting

A pamphlet of 1743 in which Wesley defines the United Societies as companies meeting to pray together, receive exhortation and watch over one another in love. It asks of those joining only a desire to flee from the wrath to come, and gives three rules, to do no harm, to do good and to attend the ordinances of God, which class leaders enforced, if need be by exclusion. It would be worth reading in the original rather than through commentators.

UNDERSTANDING THE TRADITION

Cassian, John. *The Conferences*. Translated by Boniface Ramsey. New York: Paulist Press, 1997.

The first complete English translation of Cassian's *Conferences*, his record of conversations with the monks of the Egyptian desert, with Ramsey's introduction and notes. The Rule of Benedict prescribes the *Conferences* for reading in community (chapter 42) and commends them, with Cassian's *Institutes*, to those who would go beyond its own beginnings (chapter 73). Columba Stewart's study of Cassian presents him as the synthesiser of Egyptian monastic tradition for Latin readers and the major spiritual influence on the Rule of Benedict.

Chitty, Derwas J. *The Desert a City: An Introduction to the Study of Egyptian and Palestinian Monasticism under the Christian Empire*. [1966] Crestwood, NY: St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1995.

A history of the beginnings of monasticism, from the founders of Egyptian monasticism to the movement's spread into Palestine and the controversies that divided it. Where Ward's sayings and Cassian's conferences give the desert monks' own words, Chitty tells their history.

Peters, Greg. *The Monkhood of All Believers: The Monastic Foundation of Christian Spirituality*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2018.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book arguing that baptism makes every Christian a monk in the original sense of single-mindedness towards God. Peters holds that the vowed monasticism of the fourth century onwards modified an earlier and more universal monastic life, rooted in baptism and the priesthood of all believers, and draws on early monks, Russian Orthodox thinkers, the Reformers and Anglican writers. Ed Smither (2018) notes that it does not address parish or mission contexts. The chapter on the priesthood of all believers bears most directly on the doctrine of the church.

Sittser, Gerald L. *Water from a Deep Well: Christian Spirituality from Early Martyrs to Modern Missionaries*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2007.

A survey of Christian spirituality across 2,000 years, in 11 chapters, each a strand of the tradition under a single word; monasticism is 'Rhythm', set within the whole sweep of the tradition after a chapter on the desert saints. Richard Steele found it 'exceptionally accessible', and reports a colleague's use of it in an undergraduate course on the history of Christian spirituality.

Stewart, Columba. *Prayer and Community: The Benedictine Tradition*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1998.

A short introduction to Benedict and his Rule, in a series on the traditions of Christian spirituality, by a monk of Saint John's Abbey, Collegeville, and scholar of early monasticism. It sets the Rule among the early monastic writings, then turns from history to practice, to prayer, reading, obedience and community, and to what they are for, in monasteries and outside them.

Swan, Laura. *The Wisdom of the Beguines: The Forgotten Story of a Medieval Women's Movement*. Katonah, NY: BlueBridge, 2014.

A history of the beguines, laywomen who from about 1200 lived a religious life without vows or an approved rule, across Europe until the death of the last of them in 2013, by a Benedictine sister and former prioress; it has a chapter on whether they were heretics. In their earliest form beguines lived alone or in small households, as members of dispersed communities do now; later most moved into walled beguinages.

Wakefield, Gavin. *The Wise Pastor: Learning from Gregory the Great's 'Pastoral Rule'*. Pastoral 140. Cambridge: Grove Books, 2014.

ALSO IN Pastoral Ministry; Leadership in Church Planting

A Grove booklet by Gavin Wakefield, drawing pastoral wisdom from Gregory the Great's sixth-century *Pastoral Rule*. It opens with an account of Gregory's own life before turning to the *Rule* itself, arguing that a text written for the unsettled conditions of its own day still has insight to offer leaders facing change now. It reaches back to a patristic primary text rather than to contemporary leadership literature, and assumes no previous acquaintance with Gregory or his period.

Ward, Benedicta, trans. *The Sayings of the Desert Fathers: The Alphabetical Collection*. Kalamazoo, MI: Cistercian Publications, 1975.

A translation of the alphabetical collection of the *Apophthegmata Patrum*, the sayings of the desert monks of fourth- and fifth-century Egypt, arranged by the monk to whom each is attributed, by a member of the Sisters of the Love of God, an Anglican community in Oxford. The sayings are short and pointed, stating a principle of the spiritual life without argument, and the formal monastic rules grew out of the tradition they record.

READING BENEDICT NOW

Casey, Michael. *Strangers to the City: Reflections on the Beliefs and Values of the Rule of Saint Benedict*. Brewster, MA: Paraclete Press, 2005. Reprinted 2013.

A Cistercian monk's interpretation of the Rule of Benedict, written for Christians today from Tarrawarra Abbey in Australia. It asks for the hard disciplines the Rule sets: *Publishers Weekly*, otherwise unimpressed, allowed that 'this is not feel-good spirituality'. It is sharper in tone than de Waal's *Seeking God*.

Chittister, Joan. *The Rule of Benedict: A Spirituality for the 21st Century*. Rev. ed. New York: Crossroad, 2010.

A passage-by-passage commentary on the Rule of Benedict by a former prioress of the Benedictine Sisters of Erie, Pennsylvania, whose books are written for a general readership. This revised edition, retitled, nearly doubles the first, *The Rule of Benedict: Insights for the Ages* (1992).

De Waal, Esther. *Seeking God: The Way of St Benedict*. 3rd ed. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2017.

A reading of the Rule of Benedict for lay people, written, in its author's words, 'from the lived experience of a housewife and mother', in 10 chapters, among them 'Stability' and 'Balance'. It was the Archbishop of Canterbury's Lent Book for 1984, with forewords by Robert Runcie and by Cardinal Basil Hume, a Benedictine, and has been widely read since; de Waal calls it 'this very simple introduction to the Rule'.

Williams, Rowan. *The Way of St Benedict*. London: Bloomsbury Continuum, 2020.

A hundred and sixty pages of essays on what the Rule of Benedict has to say to contemporary questions, stability among them, in two parts, the second holding two more academic essays, on Abbot Cuthbert Butler's account of mysticism and on Benedict and the future of Europe. A reviewer in the *American Benedictine Review* thought it of use to those beginning to read the Rule and to those long under it alike; one blogger, William Connolley, found it weakest where it turns from contemplation to the practical world.

THE PROTESTANT AND WESLEYAN STRAND

Bonhoeffer, Dietrich. *Life Together*. Translated by John W. Doberstein. [1954] London: SCM Press, 2015.

Bonhoeffer's account of Christian community, written in 1938 out of the common life of the Confessing Church's illegal seminary at Finkenwalde, which the Gestapo had closed the year before; its chapters include 'The Day with Others' and 'The Day Alone'. Before Finkenwalde he had written that the church's renewal would come from 'a new kind of monasticism, which has nothing in common with the old but a life of uncompromising discipleship, following Christ according to the Sermon on the Mount'; the book is his account of such a common life, from within a Protestant church.

Cartwright, Michael G., and Andrew D. Kinsey. *Watching over One Another in Love: Reclaiming the Wesleyan Rule of Life for the Church's Mission*. Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2011.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan

A spiritual formation resource 'for United Methodists and other heirs of the Wesleyan tradition', in its retailers' description, by two elders of the United Methodist Church's Indiana Conference, a university teacher and a parish pastor. It connects the Wesleyan rule of life directly to the church's mission, the link its subtitle names. Where Heath and Kisker's *Longing for Spring* takes the Wesleyan tradition towards new monastic communities, this book takes up the rule itself.

Heath, Elaine A., and Scott T. Kisker. *Longing for Spring: A New Vision for Wesleyan Community*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2010.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan

A proposal, in its own description's words, for 'planting neo-monastic communities as a new model of the church', by Elaine Heath, a co-founder of the Missional Wisdom Foundation, and the historian of Christianity Scott Kisker. It sets new monasticism in a Wesleyan key and is addressed to the United Methodist Church in the United States. James Pedlar's review calls it 'very accessible' and notes that it avoids 'rigorous scholarship'. Chapter 5, with its concrete suggestions on rules of life and ministry appointments, would be a useful place to start.

Henderson, D. Michael. *John Wesley's Class Meeting: A Model for Making Disciples*. Nappanee, IN: Evangel Publishing House, 1997.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting; Discipleship

A study of Wesley's methods of forming disciples in small groups, and of the class meeting as a model for making disciples today. Like Kevin Watson's *The Class Meeting*, it is on the small-group machinery behind the General Rules, but it describes every part of the system — society, class, band and select society — where Watson keeps to the class. Charles Yrigoyen, reviewing it in *Methodist History* (1998), notes errors of fact, among them the year of Wesley's death.

Watson, Kevin M. *A Blueprint for Discipleship: Wesley's General Rules as a Guide for Christian Living*. Nashville, TN: Discipleship Resources, 2009.

ALSO IN Methodist and Wesleyan; Early Methodist Church Planting

A book for lay readers that takes the General Rules seriously as a rule of life rather than as a historical curiosity. Watson builds a pattern of discipleship on Wesley's three rules, which he renders as do no harm, do good and practise the spiritual disciplines, and on members watching over one another in love in accountable small groups. George King's review notes that the charge of legalism, which a reader may raise early, is answered only in chapter seven.

Watson, Kevin M. *The Class Meeting: Reclaiming a Forgotten (and Essential) Small Group Experience*. Franklin, TN: Seedbed, 2013.

ALSO IN Early Methodist Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan

A guide to the small-group machinery that made the General Rules workable, written for groups starting a class meeting. Watson argues that early Methodists met in small groups to talk together about their souls, not only to study the Bible, and gives a group a shared language for the work of the Holy Spirit and a structure for its meetings. It is an eight-week study, after which the group sets the book aside and carries on as a class meeting.

WRITING A RULE FOR TODAY

Barton, Ruth Haley. *Sacred Rhythms: Arranging Our Lives for Spiritual Transformation*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2006.

ALSO IN Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A book of spiritual practices taken one at a time, from solitude and the reading of Scripture to self-examination and Sabbath, ending with a chapter on assembling them into a personal rule of life, by the founder of the Transforming Center and a spiritual director trained at the Shalem Institute. One reviewer, Carrie Myers, commends it to individuals, and to use by a small group, a couple, or a spiritual director and directee.

Bevins, Winfield H., and Mark Dunwoody. *Healthy Rhythms for Leaders: Cultivating Soul Care in Uncertain Times*. Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/healthy-rhythms-leaders/>.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality; Resilience and Burnout; Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A short manual of soul care for Christian leaders, one of Exponential's ebooks. It builds an 'Ebb and Flow' rule of life for a leader and adds a 'Missional Design Thinking' process for carrying the same habits into a team. Among entries on writing a rule for today it is pitched at leaders under operational pressure rather than at students of the monastic tradition; a companion visual guide summarises its frameworks.

Comer, John Mark. *Practicing the Way: Be with Jesus. Become like Him. Do as He Did*. London: Form, 2024.

ALSO IN Discipleship

A book on discipleship as apprenticeship to Jesus, by the founding pastor of Bridgetown Church in Portland, Oregon, built on the three goals of its subtitle. It ends in a rule of life of nine practices, and a free eight-session course for churches accompanies it. A bestseller, it had appeared 23 times on the *New York Times* list by May 2025. Two reviewers, in 9Marks and Christ Over All, find it thin on sin and on the cross.

Comer, John Mark. *The Ruthless Elimination of Hurry: How to Stay Emotionally Healthy and Spiritually Alive in the Chaos of the Modern World*. Colorado Springs, CO: WaterBrook, 2019.

ALSO IN Resilience and Burnout

A book on hurry as the great enemy of the spiritual life, written after Comer had burned out at 33 while leading a multi-site church in Portland, Oregon; its title is Dallas Willard's advice, as John Ortberg told it to Comer, to 'ruthlessly eliminate hurry'. Its remedy is a rule of life, and its third part sets out four practices for an unhurried life: silence and solitude, Sabbath, simplicity and slowing.

Earley, Justin Whitmel. *The Common Rule: Habits of Purpose for an Age of Distraction*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2019.

A book setting out four daily and four weekly habits, among them kneeling prayer three times a day, an hour with the phone off and a weekly Sabbath, by a business lawyer. It is framed against the formative power of technology and work, and Earley presents it as a communal pattern, to be kept with others against the individualism of the culture, though one person can take it up.

Frost, Michael. *Surprise the World! The Five Habits of Highly Missional People*. Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2016.

ALSO IN Missiology; Missional Spirituality

A book setting out five weekly habits under the acronym BELLS (Bless, Eat, Listen, Learn, Sent), on the argument that Christians have replaced habits that surprise the world with habits that mimic it. Frost, writing from Australia, offers them as a discipline for individuals or small groups rather than a technique of evangelism. Frost and Hirsch's *The Shaping of Things to Come* argued for a change in the church's shape; this book turns to the habits of its members. The closing chapter, on small groups for discipleship, nurture and accountability, bears on practising them together.

Harrison Warren, Tish. *Liturgy of the Ordinary: Sacred Practices in Everyday Life*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2016.

A book that follows one ordinary day, from waking and making the bed to losing one's keys, linking each act to a spiritual practice and to a part of Sunday worship, by a priest of the Anglican Church in North America. It is not framed as a rule of life, but its thesis is the one a rule assumes: 'our hearts and our loves are shaped by what we do again and again and again'. It was *Christianity Today's* Book of the Year for 2018.

Pierlot, Holly. *A Mother's Rule of Life: How to Bring Order to Your Home and Peace to Your Soul*. Manchester, NH: Sophia Institute Press, 2004.

A book setting out a rule of life for a mother at home, by a mother of five who had homeschooled them, and who found that most of the rules she read were written for religious orders and none by a layperson. It orders the day by five priorities of the married vocation, in order prayer, person, partner, parent and provider, and so answers the assumption that a rule belongs to those with unusual amounts of solitude.

Runcorn, David. *Spirituality Workbook: A Guide for Explorers, Pilgrims and Seekers*. London: SPCK, 2006.

A workbook on the Christian spiritual life in five parts, among them 'Life together' and 'When you pray', by a Church of England priest who has trained ordinands and taught spirituality at Trinity College, Bristol. Among the guides to writing a rule in this list, most of them American, it is an English Anglican voice.

Shigematsu, Ken. *God in My Everything: How an Ancient Rhythm Helps Busy People Enjoy God*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2013.

A book on keeping a rule of life amid a busy working life, by the senior pastor of Tenth Church, Vancouver, written for busy people rather than for those already drawn to monasticism. Built around the image of a trellis, it moves from Sabbath, prayer and sacred reading to friendship, health and outreach, and each chapter ends with questions and space to outline a rule. One reviewer found it adaptable to 'a variety of life situations'.

Thompson, Marjorie J. *Soul Feast: An Invitation to the Christian Spiritual Life*. Rev. ed. Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A book on the practices of the Christian spiritual life, from spiritual reading and prayer to fasting and hospitality, first published in 1995 with a foreword by Henri Nouwen. This revised edition adds a chapter on the Sabbath and closes with a chapter on developing a rule of life, much expanded at readers' request, in which Thompson compares a rule to the ropes that hold window-cleaners to a building.

COMMUNITY AND NEW MONASTICISM

Adams, Ian. *Cave, Refectory, Road: Monastic Rhythms for Contemporary Living*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2010.

A book offering three places as the shape of a life: the cave, of stillness, withdrawal and prayer; the refectory, of hospitality and community; and the road, of engagement with public life on the pattern of the friars. Adams is an Anglican priest who founded mayBe, a new monastic community in Oxford.

Cray, Graham, Ian Mobsby and Aaron Kennedy, eds. *Ancient Faith, Future Mission: New Monasticism as Fresh Expression of Church*. Norwich: Canterbury Press, 2010.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Missional Spirituality; Ecclesiology

An edited volume in which leaders of traditional religious communities and of new monastic ones write from their own communities on how an older form of religious life is shaping a new form of church. It was edited from within Fresh Expressions, which Graham Cray then led, and its subtitle states its claim: that new monasticism, which *Mission-Shaped Church* named among the new forms of church, is a fresh expression of church. The chapters are testimony and reflection rather than a single argument. Gladys Ganiel's review commends Shane Claiborne's 'Marks of a New Monasticism' for its vision of living alongside disadvantaged communities.

Greig, Pete. *The Vision and the Vow: Rediscovering Life and Grace*. Orlando, FL: Relevant Books, 2004.

ALSO IN Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A book in two parts: 'The Vision', Greig's manifesto of 1999 for the 24-7 Prayer movement, and 'The Vow', a rule of life with a 40-day devotional, drawn from the vow of Count Zinzendorf's Order of the Mustard Seed, which 24-7 Prayer relaunched in 2005. It comes from the charismatic evangelical tradition, and reaches readers whom the older monastic literature may not.

McEntee, Rory, and Adam Bucko. *The New Monasticism: An Interspiritual Manifesto for Contemplative Living*. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 2015.

An interspiritual book, drawing on many religious traditions: a manifesto by two leaders of the interspiritual new monastic movement, setting out nine vows for a contemplative life open to seekers of any tradition or none. It rests on Wayne Teasdale's 'interspirituality', the sharing of spiritual experience across religions, and on Panikkar and Teilhard de Chardin, not on Christian doctrine or a Christian rule of life, and it is not an account of the Christian new-monastic communities beside it in this list. A review in *Horizons* found it thin on concrete practice, better read as an object of study in emergent spirituality than as a guide to it.

Pohl, Christine D. *Living into Community: Cultivating Practices That Sustain Us*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2011.

ALSO IN Ecclesiology

A book on four practices that sustain a community — gratitude, promise-keeping, truthfulness and hospitality — set against the betrayal, deception, grumbling, envy and exclusion that damage one. Gratitude, promising and truthfulness each have three chapters, on the practice, its complications and what weakens or strengthens it; hospitality, the subject of Pohl's *Making Room*, has one chapter drawing the practices together. Written from Christian social ethics for communities and families, it includes discussion questions.

Rutba House, ed. *School(s) for Conversion: 12 Marks of a New Monasticism*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2005.

ALSO IN Missional Spirituality

A statement of the 12 marks of a new monasticism, agreed at a gathering of intentional communities in Durham, North Carolina, in June 2004, among them relocation to 'the abandoned places of Empire' and the sharing of economic resources. *Christianity Today* called the gathering the movement's birth and this book what introduces it. Its politics are more radical than many English readers will expect: a sympathetic writer calls the new monasticism the strongest voice for social justice among such movements, and a critical one objects to its 'jubilee economics'.

Santos, Jason Brian. *A Community Called Taizé: A Story of Prayer, Worship and Reconciliation*. Downers Grove, IL: IVP Books, 2008.

An account of the Taizé Community, its history under Brother Roger, its brothers, its prayer and the pilgrims who come to it, by a practical theologian whose doctoral research was on what becomes of Taizé's pilgrims after they leave, with a foreword by Desmond Tutu; its last chapter turns to taking Taizé's ways elsewhere. It is a companion to *The Rule of Taizé*, and gives particular attention to the young people who make up most of the community's pilgrims.

HABIT AND FORMATION

Foster, Richard J. *Celebration of Discipline: The Path to Spiritual Growth*. [1978] London: Hodder and Stoughton, 2008.

ALSO IN Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A book on 12 spiritual disciplines in three groups, inward (meditation, prayer, fasting, study), outward (simplicity, solitude, submission, service) and corporate (confession, worship, guidance, celebration), revised since it first appeared. *Christianity Today* in 2000 placed it eighth among its books of the 20th century, Mark Buchanan observing that after each discipline 'you want to do it'. It is a single inventory of the practices a rule might contain.

Kreider, Alan. *The Patient Ferment of the Early Church: The Improbable Rise of Christianity in the Roman Empire*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Theory of Change

A historical study of how the church grew across the Roman Empire in its first three centuries, drawing on Tertullian, Cyprian and the *Apostolic Tradition*. Kreider finds the engine of that growth in habitus, patience and formation: a way of life shaped by catechesis that often lasted up to three years before baptism. It would be of use to anyone arguing that discipleship and numerical growth belong together.

Smith, James K. A. *You Are What You Love: The Spiritual Power of Habit*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Discipleship

A book on why people are formed by liturgies they did not choose, and what to do about it: it argues that what people love, more than what they think, makes them who they are, and that love is trained by habit and worship. Written at pastors' request as a more accessible version of the argument of Smith's *Desiring the Kingdom* (2009), it is a short statement of the anthropology a rule of life assumes. Derek Rishmawy, reviewing it, asks whether it overstates the power of habit against the preached word.

Willard, Dallas. *The Spirit of the Disciplines: Understanding How God Changes Lives*. San Francisco: Harper and Row, 1988.

ALSO IN Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A theological account of the spiritual disciplines by a philosopher at the University of Southern California, arguing that grace and human effort are not opposites: the disciplines are the practices, undertaken in the body, through which grace changes a life. It surveys their history, monastic and Protestant, and divides them into disciplines of abstinence, such as solitude and fasting, and of engagement, such as study, worship and prayer. One reviewer, Bob Trube, treats it with Foster's *Celebration of Discipline* as a foundation of the later practical writing on the disciplines.

HANDLE WITH CARE

Agamben, Giorgio. *The Highest Poverty: Monastic Rules and Form-of-Life*. Translated by Adam Kotsko. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2013.

A philosopher's study of the monastic rules, published in the Meridian series of Stanford University Press as part of his *Homo Sacer* project. It asks at what point a rule stops being a text to obey and becomes a form of life, one that can no longer be told apart from the life lived under it. It is hard going, and suits postgraduate work better than a first-year reading list.

Dreher, Rod. *The Benedict Option: A Strategy for Christians in a Post-Christian Nation*. New York: Sentinel, 2017.

ALSO IN Post-Christendom and the Secular West

A book of cultural polemic that borrows Benedict's name from a sentence at the end of Alasdair MacIntyre's *After Virtue*; it is not a study of the Rule. Dreher argues that Christians in the West should rely less on politics than on building resilient local communities, churches, schools and neighbourhoods, on a loosely Benedictine discipline. Its withdrawal strategy sits awkwardly with any missional reading, and R. R. Reno (*First Things*, 2017) faults its 'rhetoric of crisis'. It would serve students wanting to understand an argument they may meet in their own congregations better than those wanting to learn about Benedict.

Vanier, Jean. *Community and Growth*. Rev. ed. London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1989.

ALSO IN Power and Its Abuse

A book of reflections on the nature and meaning of community, written in short sections out of Vanier's life in L'Arche, the communities he founded; it appeared in French and in English in 1979 and was revised in 1989. Inquiries published by L'Arche after his death in 2019 found serious abuse on Vanier's part.

Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

See also the list on Missional Spirituality.

The spiritual disciplines are practices by which Christians put themselves in the way of God's grace: prayer and fasting, solitude and silence, study, worship, confession and service among them. This reading list is about those practices and about the leader's own prayer; how practices are gathered into a pattern for a whole life is the subject of *Rule of Life*, and the strain of ministry the subject of *Resilience and Burnout*.

The disciplines came back into evangelical and Protestant practice from the late 1970s. Evangelicals who had found little in their own heritage to satisfy them began to go on retreat to monasteries, and Richard Foster's account of the classical disciplines, published in 1978, found a large readership among them.

Three questions run through the debate. One Protestant critic holds that teaching disciplines as a path to growth puts a person's faith in their own faithfulness, and so brings a Catholic theology of works into Protestant churches; Dallas Willard's answer is that the disciplines are matters of wisdom, not of merit. Others distrust contemplative practices drawn from Catholic and mystical traditions, and one critic calls Henri Nouwen a heretic on that account. The third question, which Ruth Haley Barton addresses from within leadership, is how a leader's own prayer survives the work of leading.

This reading list opens with *Start Here*, then *The Practices and Prayer and the Leader's Own Life*.

START HERE

Foster, Richard J. *Celebration of Discipline: The Path to Spiritual Growth*. [1978] London: Hodder and Stoughton, 2008.

ALSO IN *Rule of Life*

A book on 12 spiritual disciplines in three groups, inward (meditation, prayer, fasting, study), outward (simplicity, solitude, submission, service) and corporate (confession, worship, guidance, celebration), revised since it first appeared. *Christianity Today* in 2000 placed it eighth among its books of the 20th century, Mark Buchanan observing that after each discipline 'you want to do it'. It is a single inventory of the practices a rule might contain.

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A theological account of the spiritual disciplines by a philosopher at the University of Southern California, arguing that grace and human effort are not opposites: the disciplines are the practices, undertaken in the body, through which grace changes a life. It surveys their history, monastic and Protestant, and divides them into disciplines of abstinence, such as solitude and fasting, and of engagement, such as study, worship and prayer. One reviewer, Bob Trube, treats it with Foster's *Celebration of Discipline* as a foundation of the later practical writing on the disciplines.

Williams, Rowan. *Being Disciples: Essentials of the Christian Life*. London: SPCK, 2016.

ALSO IN *Discipleship*

A short collection of six addresses on Christian discipleship by Rowan Williams, given to lay audiences while he was Archbishop of Canterbury and published as a sequel to his *Being Christian*. It runs from faith, hope and love to life in the Spirit, and is written for the general reader rather than the specialist. Among introductions to discipleship here it is the most compact; Geoff Thompson's review of 2017 finds the separate addresses read as one whole.

THE PRACTICES

Barton, Ruth Haley. *Invitation to Solitude and Silence: Experiencing God's Transforming Presence*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2004.

A short book on the disciplines of solitude and silence, built on the story of Elijah in 1 Kings 19, with a foreword by Dallas Willard; each chapter closes with a practice, so that it can be worked through as well as read. An expanded edition followed in 2010. One critic of contemplative practice, Tim Challies, would 'not recommend this book for any reason'.

Barton, Ruth Haley. *Sacred Rhythms: Arranging Our Lives for Spiritual Transformation*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2006.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book of spiritual practices taken one at a time, from solitude and the reading of Scripture to self-examination and Sabbath, ending with a chapter on assembling them into a personal rule of life, by the founder of the Transforming Center and a spiritual director trained at the Shalem Institute. One reviewer, Carrie Myers, commends it to individuals, and to use by a small group, a couple, or a spiritual director and directee.

Batterson, Mark. *The Circle Maker: Praying Circles Around Your Biggest Dreams and Greatest Fears*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2011.

A popular book of devotional teaching on bold and persistent prayer, built on the legend of Honi the circle maker, a Jewish figure said to have drawn a circle in the sand and refused to leave it until God sent rain. Batterson turns that story into a method of praying round a dream or a fear until it is answered. It is the one entry here from the American popular prayer market rather than from the classical disciplines, and it is contested: Tim Challies holds that it reads Scripture through Honi rather than the other way about.

Foster, Richard J. *Streams of Living Water: Celebrating the Great Traditions of Christian Faith*. San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 1998.

A survey of six streams of Christian spirituality, contemplative, holiness, charismatic, social justice, evangelical and incarnational, each shown through one figure from church history, one from Scripture and one from the present, with its strengths and its perils. Rosa Hunt, reviewing it in the Baptist Times, reads it as an encouragement to try a tradition other than one's own; Lin Cook, in Modern Reformation, found it anecdotal rather than argued.

Mulholland, M. Robert, Jr. *Invitation to a Journey: A Road Map for Spiritual Formation*. Rev. and expanded ed. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Discipleship

An American book on spiritual formation, first published in 1993 and revised in 2016, by a professor of New Testament at Asbury Theological Seminary. It defines formation as 'a process of being formed in the image of Christ for the sake of others', and combines practical teaching on the spiritual disciplines with insights from personality types, on the view that formation happens within a person's given temperament, so that no one practice suits every temperament. The Transforming Center makes it a required text.

Nouwen, Henri J. M. *Reaching Out: The Three Movements of the Spiritual Life*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1975.

A short book describing the spiritual life as three movements: from loneliness to solitude, from hostility to hospitality, and from illusion to prayer. Its second part, on hospitality, bears most directly on a planter's work: 'Hospitality is not to change people, but to offer them space where change can take place.' *Kirkus Reviews* found the whole 'disappointingly less than the sum of its many worthwhile parts'.

Rohr, Richard. *Breathing Under Water: Spirituality and the Twelve Steps*. Cincinnati, OH: St Anthony Messenger Press, 2011.

A book reading the Twelve Steps of Alcoholics Anonymous as a practical form of the gospel, and a spiritual practice for anyone rather than only for addicts, by a Franciscan priest who founded the Center for Action and Contemplation in New Mexico. It treats addiction as a description of the human condition rather than a special case, the primary addiction being, Rohr argues, to one's own power.

Thompson, Marjorie J. *Soul Feast: An Invitation to the Christian Spiritual Life*. Rev. ed. Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2014.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book on the practices of the Christian spiritual life, from spiritual reading and prayer to fasting and hospitality, first published in 1995 with a foreword by Henri Nouwen. This revised edition adds a chapter on the Sabbath and closes with a chapter on developing a rule of life, much expanded at readers' request, in which Thompson compares a rule to the ropes that hold window-cleaners to a building.

PRAYER AND THE LEADER'S OWN LIFE

Barton, Ruth Haley. *Strengthening the Soul of Your Leadership: Seeking God in the Crucible of Ministry*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2008.

A book on the leader's own spiritual life, taking Moses as its case study, with chapters on the loneliness of leadership and on finding God's will together; each chapter ends with a practice. An expanded edition followed in 2018. Richard Blackaby found its reading of Moses forced in places.

Bevins, Winfield H., and Mark Dunwoody. *Healthy Rhythms for Leaders: Cultivating Soul Care in Uncertain Times*. Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/healthy-rhythms-leaders/>.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Missional Spirituality; Resilience and Burnout

A short manual of soul care for Christian leaders, one of Exponential's ebooks. It builds an 'Ebb and Flow' rule of life for a leader and adds a 'Missional Design Thinking' process for carrying the same habits into a team. Among entries on writing a rule for today it is pitched at leaders under operational pressure rather than at students of the monastic tradition; a companion visual guide summarises its frameworks.

Greig, Pete. *Dirty Glory: Go Where Your Best Prayers Take You*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 2016.

A book by one of the founders of 24-7 Prayer, telling the movement's story after the first five years recounted in *Red Moon Rising*: a movement of continuous prayer that began in 1999 and has spread to national teams on six continents. Its stories come from 24-7's work in places as far apart as a red-light district in Mexico and the clubs of Ibiza, and it keeps prayer and action together. Jon Kuhrt, reviewing it, found it inspiring but thought some of its stories inflated beyond what they can bear.

Greig, Pete. *God on Mute: Engaging the Silence of Unanswered Prayer*. Eastbourne: Kingsway Publications, 2007.

Greig's book on unanswered prayer, written while his wife was being treated for a brain tumour and went on suffering severe epilepsy despite prayer for her healing. It works through 15 reasons a prayer may seem to go unanswered, and is the only entry in this list on prayer that appears to fail, where the others treat prayer that is being sustained or deepened. The revised edition of 2020 adds a foreword by Justin Welby and a 40-day devotional.

Greig, Pete. *The Vision and the Vow: Rediscovering Life and Grace*. Orlando, FL: Relevant Books, 2004.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book in two parts: 'The Vision', Greig's manifesto of 1999 for the 24-7 Prayer movement, and 'The Vow', a rule of life with a 40-day devotional, drawn from the vow of Count Zinzendorf's Order of the Mustard Seed, which 24-7 Prayer relaunched in 2005. It comes from the charismatic evangelical tradition, and reaches readers whom the older monastic literature may not.

Self-Knowledge and Personality

This reading list is about self-knowledge as a Christian leader needs it: knowing one's own temperament, habits and blind spots, and the effect they have on others. The Christian tradition has long joined the knowledge of oneself to the knowledge of God. In churches today that knowledge is often sought through personality typologies, and above all through the Enneagram, a scheme of nine types that reached the United States from South America in the early 1970s and passed through a Jesuit teacher into Catholic seminaries and retreat houses, and from them into Protestant churches and their leadership teams. The leader's inner life more broadly is treated in the other lists of this group, and the working of a team in Teams and Culture.

The question the Enneagram raises is whether it describes people truly. Psychologists who study personality judge it unfounded: its nine types were set down in advance rather than derived from evidence, and one calls it pseudoscientific at best. Its Christian teachers, Ian Morgan Cron and Suzanne Stabile among them, answer that it is a map for self-examination and spiritual growth rather than a scientific measure, a way of seeing the patterns in which a person repeatedly stumbles. Some Christian critics object besides to its origins in esoteric teaching.

Cron, Ian Morgan, and Suzanne Stabile. *The Road Back to You: An Enneagram Journey to Self-Discovery*. Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2016.

A book introducing the Enneagram as a tool of Christian self-knowledge and spiritual formation, by an Episcopal priest, once the founding pastor of a church in Connecticut, and an Enneagram teacher. Each of the nine types is described through stories, with the changes a person of that type might begin to make. The authors state the objections themselves: the system's origins are uncertain, and there is no scientific evidence that it measures personality reliably.

Resilience and Burnout

Burnout, in the World Health Organization's definition, results from chronic workplace stress that has not been managed, and is marked by exhaustion, by distance from or cynicism about one's work, and by a loss of effectiveness. Resilience is the capacity to meet such pressure and recover from it. This reading list is about both in the life of a minister and a church planter; the leader's inner life more broadly is treated in *Rule of Life* and in *Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines*.

Studies of clergy measure burnout on the same three dimensions, and have looked for what relieves it. A study of Church of England clergy found stress lower where they felt supported by professional advisers, and one British model of clergy burnout sets the satisfactions of ministry against its exhaustion. A study of church planters in Europe traces both the crises they meet and the sources of their resilience.

The principal question is where the remedy lies. Some writers treat resilience as a capacity to be built, by ordering the inner life or the pace of work: Peter Scazzero, John Mark Comer and Jenny Campbell among them. Against this, the psychologist whose inventory measures those three dimensions argues that burnout signals a failing workplace, which should be changed before the person is asked to become tougher.

This reading list opens with *Start Here*, then *Pace and Capacity*.

START HERE

Bloye, Brian, and Amy Bloye. *It's Personal: Surviving and Thriving on the Journey of Church Planting*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2012.

ALSO IN Leadership in Church Planting; Practical Guides

A book written for planting couples by a husband and wife who started West Ridge Church in Georgia in 1997, on the personal side of planting: the marriage, the children and the balance of family and ministry, along with criticism, friendship and spiritual warfare. Each chapter carries interviews with other planting couples. Hoover's *The Church Planting Wife*, listed under Practical Guides, is by contrast written for the wife.

Packiam, Glenn, with David Kinnaman. *The Resilient Pastor: Leading Your Church in a Rapidly Changing World*. Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2022.

ALSO IN Pastoral Ministry

A book on pastoral resilience amid what Packiam calls a convergence of cultural upheaval, vocational confusion, spiritual depletion, relational loneliness and collapsing credibility, rather than simple burnout. It argues that disorder in a pastor's calling, spirituality, relationships and use of authority produces disorder in the church's worship, formation, unity and mission, and organises its chapters around those four pastoral and four congregational challenges in turn. Its distinguishing feature is a base of fresh Barna Group survey research, presented through data and infographics alongside Packiam's own argument; David Kinnaman, Barna's president, contributes the foreword. Written for working pastors rather than for students of leadership theory.

Scazzero, Peter. *The Emotionally Healthy Leader: How Transforming Your Inner Life Will Deeply Transform Your Church, Team, and the World*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2015.

A book on the inner life of Christian leaders and its effect on the churches and teams they lead, written out of Scazzero's burnout in 1996, eight years after he planted New Life Fellowship in Queens, New York, when part of the church split away and his marriage was under strain. Its first part takes the inner life (facing one's shadow, marriage or singleness, slowing down and Sabbath), its second the outer work of leading (planning, team and culture, power and boundaries, endings and new beginnings). One reviewer, Christine Fox Parker, finds it 'a bit heavy-handed' in tracing all unhealthy patterns to the family of origin.

Selvaratnam, Christian. 'Resilience in Ministry'. Keynote address, New Wine Leadership Conference, Harrogate, February 2024. Video. New Wine Online.

A keynote on the hidden pressures of ministry, and of church planting in particular: what they do to the people who carry them, how devastating the effect can be, and what might be done to guard against it. The recording is available only to paying members of New Wine Online.

PACE AND CAPACITY

Bevins, Winfield H., and Mark Dunwoody. *Healthy Rhythms for Leaders: Cultivating Soul Care in Uncertain Times*. Exponential, 2021. <https://exponential.org/product/healthy-rhythms-leaders/>.

ALSO IN Rule of Life; Missional Spirituality; Prayer and Spiritual Disciplines

A short manual of soul care for Christian leaders, one of Exponential's ebooks. It builds an 'Ebb and Flow' rule of life for a leader and adds a 'Missional Design Thinking' process for carrying the same habits into a team. Among entries on writing a rule for today it is pitched at leaders under operational pressure rather than at students of the monastic tradition; a companion visual guide summarises its frameworks.

Campbell, Jenny. *The Resilience Dynamic: The Simple, Proven Approach to High Performance and Wellbeing*. Northwich: Practical Inspiration Publishing, 2019.

A book for leaders and organisations that presents resilience as something developed rather than a fixed trait, and its model as a buffer against stress that lets high performance and wellbeing go together. It is the only book in this list written neither by nor for church leaders.

Comer, John Mark. *The Ruthless Elimination of Hurry: How to Stay Emotionally Healthy and Spiritually Alive in the Chaos of the Modern World*. Colorado Springs, CO: WaterBrook, 2019.

ALSO IN Rule of Life

A book on hurry as the great enemy of the spiritual life, written after Comer had burned out at 33 while leading a multi-site church in Portland, Oregon; its title is Dallas Willard's advice, as John Ortberg told it to Comer, to 'ruthlessly eliminate hurry'. Its remedy is a rule of life, and its third part sets out four practices for an unhurried life: silence and solitude, Sabbath, simplicity and slowing.

Scazzero, Peter. *The Emotionally Healthy Leader: How Transforming Your Inner Life Will Deeply Transform Your Church, Team, and the World*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2015.

ANNOTATED [under Start Here](#)

Particular Subjects

Lausanne Movement

The Lausanne Movement grew from the International Congress on World Evangelization, held at Lausanne in July 1974, whose covenant, drafted by an international committee, set out the necessity and the goals of evangelism and drew evangelicals of many backgrounds together; the movement has met in congress three times since. Its subject is world evangelisation, and church planting appears in its work as one part of that aim. This reading list holds the movement's papers that bear on planting and its present network for it; the wider theology of mission is the subject of Missiology, and the homogeneous unit principle, the subject of the first paper here, has a list of its own.

The papers are the Lausanne Occasional Papers, reports of consultations and issue groups, most of those here from meetings at Pattaya, in Thailand, in 1980 and 2004. The question running through them is how evangelism relates to the wider life of a society. A consultation at Grand Rapids in 1982 called evangelism and social responsibility distinct but 'integrally related', and the two papers here on cities, of 1980 and 2004, stand on either side of it.

This reading list opens with The Occasional Papers, then Church Planting at Lausanne.

THE OCCASIONAL PAPERS

Christian Witness to Large Cities. Lausanne Occasional Paper 9. Mini-consultation on Reaching Large Cities, Consultation on World Evangelization, Pattaya, 16-27 June 1980. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 1980. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/lop-9>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

The report of Lausanne's mini-consultation on reaching large cities, held at Pattaya in June 1980 and chaired by Raymond Bakke. Its recommendations for Latin America included a manual on 'the varied alternative church planting methods', a good indication of where the evangelical conversation about cities stood in 1980. LOP 37 superseded it as a statement, but the earlier paper is the one that set the terms: LOP 37 itself dates 'a fresh missiological movement with the large cities of the world' to Pattaya in 1980.

The Pasadena Consultation: Homogeneous Unit Principle. Lausanne Occasional Paper 1. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 1978. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/lop-1>.

ALSO IN Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Church Growth; Homogeneous Unit Principle

The report of the Pasadena colloquium of 1977, held under the Lausanne Theology and Education Group and published as the first Lausanne Occasional Paper: 10 primary contributors, Donald McGavran and C. Peter Wagner among them, some 25 further consultants and John Stott as moderator. Proponents and critics of the homogeneous unit principle agreed that a homogeneous unit church 'can be a legitimate and authentic church' but 'can never be complete in itself', since the 'dividing wall' Christ abolished 'was enmity or hostility'. It would be a useful place to begin on the ecclesiological objection to church-growth planting strategy, before taking either side.

Lausanne Church Planting Issue Network. *Saturation Church Planting: A Call to Collaboration*. Edited by Juan Wagenveld. Lausanne Occasional Paper 79. Lausanne Movement, 2024. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/saturation-church-planting-a-call-to-collaboration>.

ALSO IN Church Planting Movements; Church Planting Strategy

A Lausanne report tracing the DAWN saturation approach that Jim Montgomery and others promoted through the 1980s and 1990s, and arguing for its continuation in new forms. It grew out of a gathering of 250 leaders from 65 countries at Batam, Indonesia, in February 2024, convened with GACX, the Global Church Planting Network and Vision 5:9, and carries contributions from Chuck Van Engen, Murray Moerman, Raphael Anzenberger, Todd Benkert, Matt Fretwell and Ron Anderson, with a final review by Craig Van Gelder.

Shenk, Wilbert R., and David Parker. *The Realities of the Changing Expressions of the Church*. Lausanne Occasional Paper 43. Issue Group 14, 2004 Forum for World Evangelization, Pattaya. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 2005. https://lausanne.org/wp-content/uploads/2007/06/LOP43_IG14.pdf.

ALSO IN Fresh Expressions of Church; Ecclesiology

A committee report on its issue group's brief: the different patterns of church planting aimed at different sections of a community, and how effective each is at reaching the unreached. It works from cases in Africa, Asia, Europe, Latin America and North America, and on new varieties of church that had emerged over the preceding 30 years. Its theological reflection argues that these raise questions the classic notes of the church do not fully cover, and cautions both against dismissing new forms and against granting older ones a monopoly on truth. The closest thing Lausanne has to a theological treatment of new and emerging forms of church, and, with its cases, a useful paper for students.

Smith, Glenn. *Towards the Transformation of Our Cities/Regions*. Lausanne Occasional Paper 37. Issue Group 8, 2004 Forum for World Evangelization, Pattaya. Lausanne Committee for World Evangelization, 2005. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/towards-transformation-citiesregions-lop-37>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas

A paper from Lausanne's 2004 Forum at Pattaya, the successor to LOP 9 and a much larger undertaking: some 30 urban practitioners from 25 cities on six continents, with case studies from Melbourne, the Philippines, Hyderabad, central Java and Seattle. Where LOP 9 spoke of evangelising large cities, this speaks of transforming them, and the two together show how far the evangelical account of the city moved in a quarter of a century.

CHURCH PLANTING AT LAUSANNE

Lausanne Church Planting Issue Network. *Saturation Church Planting: A Call to Collaboration*. Edited by Juan Wagenveld. Lausanne Occasional Paper 79. Lausanne Movement, 2024. <https://lausanne.org/occasional-paper/saturation-church-planting-a-call-to-collaboration>.

ANNOTATED under The Occasional Papers

Lausanne Movement. *Church Planting Issue Network*. <https://lausanne.org/network/church-planting>.

ALSO IN Other Places to Look

The web page of the Lausanne Movement's Church Planting Issue Network, setting out its 'collaborate 2 Saturate' strategy, a disciple-making and church planting roundtable in every nation, supported by regional gatherings, and linking on to Multiplication Network, Saturation Church Planting and the Global Church Planting Network. It is a way in to those three partner bodies, and a place to look for what Lausanne is doing now rather than what it has said.

Asbury Outpouring 2023

The Asbury Outpouring began on 8 February 2023, when students at Asbury University, in Wilmore, Kentucky, stayed on in Hughes Auditorium after a routine chapel service to pray and worship. It ran for 16 days and drew tens of thousands of visitors, by the reports of the time; the university set an end date for the public meetings on 16 February and, as the crowds grew, moved services off campus. The university's own page is headed 'Outpouring', and others have called it a revival or an awakening. Asbury had known such seasons before, most notably in 1970. This reading list is about 2023; the planting of churches in an earlier revival is the subject of the list on Early Methodist Church Planting.

The principal question is whether the outpouring was a revival, and how its fruit should be judged. One critic doubted it, pointing to little preaching of the gospel, to women leading, to disorder and to what he called spiritual tourism; others set a test, whether it was centred on Jesus, and looked for its fruit over time, in witness, in love of neighbour and in justice. Every book in this list is by people who took part, from the university and from Asbury Theological Seminary, and every film is built on their testimony; none is by a critic.

This reading list opens with What Happened, then Making Sense of It.

WHAT HAPPENED

The Asbury Awakening. Documentary film. CBN Films, 2023. <https://www.cbnfilms.com/asburyawakening.php>.

A documentary video from CBN Films telling how a chapel service at Asbury University on 8 February 2023 turned into days of continuous worship and prayer, through eyewitness interviews and what its maker calls 'never-before-seen footage', presenting it, in the maker's words, as a 'historic move of God'.

Asbury Outpouring. Documentary film, 8 min. Directed by Jon Snyder. Sojourner Films, 2023. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fjwQSEihmhQ>.

A short documentary video, eight minutes long, filmed on campus by Jon Snyder while the outpouring was happening: the queues, the worship, and students and faculty saying what they thought was going on. Resting mostly on student testimony, it records the experience rather than assessing it, as most of the books in this list do, and would serve as a first introduction for someone who was not there.

Asbury Revival: Desperate for More. Documentary film. Christian History Institute, 2023. <https://watch.redeemtv.com/asbury-revival-desperate-for-more>.

A documentary video of 55 minutes, made for the Christian History Institute's streaming service by 1 Voice Films, whose team filmed during the outpouring and released the film at Passover 2023. It offers, in the maker's words, a 'behind-the-scenes view', reported by students, staff, university administrators and participants.

Baldwin, Sarah Thomas. *Generation Awakened: An Eyewitness Account of the Powerful Outpouring of God at Asbury*. Plano, TX [?]: Invite Press, 2024.

A day-by-day account of the outpouring, in the form of a memoir, by Asbury University's vice-president for student life, written from among those who decided how the university should steward it; its publisher calls it not an explanation but 'an invitation'. Nadya Williams, in *Mere Orthodoxy*, notes her 'firsthand, ground-level vantage point managing the revival's practical logistics and community response'.

MAKING SENSE OF IT

The Asbury Outpouring Unpacked. Video series, 10 episodes. Franklin, TN: Seedbed, 2024. <https://awakeninglibrary.com/>.

A documentary series of 10 short episodes, arranged by theme rather than by day, among them 'Consecration' and 'What Now?', built on the testimony of those who were there, made by Seedbed and New Room and released on the first anniversary as part of their Awakening Library, which also offers a study guide. It is meant, in the makers' words, 'to stir faith and hope' that 'the Spirit of God is at work in our generation'.

McClymond, Michael. 'What Revivals Can Teach Us'. *Christianity Today*, 24 February 2023. <https://www.christianitytoday.com/2023/02/what-revival-history-christian-movements-asbury-university/>.

A magazine article by a historian of American revivals, written while the Asbury outpouring was still under way. McClymond neither calls it a revival nor dismisses it: citing Jonathan Edwards, he holds that no revival can be judged from inside its own moment and that any verdict waits on fruit seen over years, a caution addressed as much to hasty defenders as to hasty critics.

Meerkreebs, Zach. *Lower: Igniting Spiritual Awakening Through Radical Humility*. New York: FaithWords, 2025.

A book arguing that radical humility is the posture from which spiritual awakening comes, a teaching rather than a chronicle of the events, by the preacher at the chapel service of 8 February 2023, after which students stayed to pray; he was then a friend of the university and a guest speaker, and afterwards joined its spiritual life staff.

Nicholson, Suzanne, ed. *Cooperating with the Holy Spirit: Theological and Practical Reflections on the Asbury Outpouring*. Abilene, TX: ACU Press, 2025.

A collection of 18 chapters by 23 members of the Asbury University community, faculty, staff and administrators, edited by its professor of New Testament, in sections on what happened, on the theology of revival, and on practical matters from the design of worship to the management of the media. It is the only book in this list that gathers many voices from among those who stewarded the outpouring.

Sey, Samuel. 'Is the Asbury "Revival" a Real Revival?' *Christian Post*, 20 February 2023. <https://www.christianpost.com/voices/is-the-asbury-revival-a-real-revival.html>.

An opinion piece for a Christian news website, published while the outpouring was still running. Sey argues against calling it a revival, pointing to what he judged too little gospel preaching and too much disorder, and holds that revival should be judged by preaching and lasting transformation rather than by emotional experience. His objections, including to women leading worship, are made from a complementarian position.

Vickers, Jason E., and Thomas H. McCall. *Outpouring: A Theological Witness*. Eugene, OR: Cascade Books, 2023.

A short theological account by two theologians of Asbury Theological Seminary who were present, which asks whether the outpouring was a work of God and answers by returning, in their words, to 'the sites of Holy Scripture and classical Christian doctrine and theology'; if it was, they argue, it is 'among the means by which God is drawing all people to himself'. Brian Roden, in *The Pneuma Review*, found it written 'at a level that any student of the Bible can understand'.

New Churches in Scotland since 2000

The research evidence on the churches started in Scotland since 2000, and on the Church of Scotland's own turn towards planting, from a pilot of pioneer posts in 2016 to a resource church planned for Glasgow. Among the new churches are the plants and pioneer projects of denominations and networks, and the congregations of Scotland's diaspora communities, which Sheila Akomiah-Conteh and her colleagues have studied first in Glasgow and then across the country. Recent books on mission and the church in Scotland are included as context, and two English studies for comparison: a count of the new churches in the north-east of England, and a study of the black majority churches started in one London borough.

The principal question is what the counts can see. Akomiah-Conteh argues that the new churches she found in Glasgow are often hidden from national church surveys; *Seeing the Shoots* found that many denominations and networks keep no central record of their plants; and Clive D. Field's history of Glasgow's church censuses shows how far their changing methods limit comparison from one to the next. The counts also cover different groups, periods and definitions of a new church, so they cannot be added together or set against one another.

This reading list opens with Overview Reports; then Diaspora and Ethnic Minority Churches; Denominational, Census and Statistical Sources; Mission and Ecclesiology in the Scottish Context; and English Comparators.

OVERVIEW REPORTS

Dalpra, Claire. *Pioneering Pieces: An Evaluation of the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, 2020. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/04/pioneering-pieces-full-report.pdf>.

ALSO IN Pioneering; Presbyterian and Reformed; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report by Claire Dalpra of Church Army's Research Unit evaluating the Church of Scotland's Pioneer Pilot Project, which funded five full-time pioneer posts from 2016 to 2021: among artists in Glasgow, on a new-build estate in Bonnyrigg, with students at Stirling, in Ferguslie Park in Paisley and among Ayrshire farming communities. It gathers the reflections of those involved, post by post, then gives the author's own assessment, and asks whether these places offer enough to sustain the planting of a new ecclesial community.

Wier, Andy, and Edd Graham-Hyde. *Seeing the Shoots: A Report for the Scottish Church Planters Network*. Sheffield: Church Army's Research Unit, December 2024. <https://churcharmy.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/Final-Report-Church-Planting-in-Scotland.pdf>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Church Growth

A survey of church planting in Scotland, commissioned by the Scottish Church Planters Network from Church Army's Research Unit: interviews with 14 denominations and networks, and 104 responses from plant leaders. Its finding is that nobody knows the number, because many bodies keep no central record, and that a conservative floor is 200 plants since 2010. Median attendance has grown from 14 at launch to 45, with a median of one faith commitment a year.

DIASPORA AND ETHNIC MINORITY CHURCHES

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila, Fiona Tweedie and Liam Jerrold Fraser. *Churches without People, and People without Churches*. Brendan Research, 2024. <https://www.brendanresearch.com/projects/ethnic-minority-christianity-in-scotland-nature-contribution-and-challenges>.

ALSO IN Africa; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

The project report of Brendan Research's study of the diaspora churches of Scotland, whose peer-reviewed paper is 'A Future with Hope'. The project's own page counts over 200 diaspora congregations and says one has been planted every eight weeks since 2000; in Clive D. Field's reading of the report, the churches that answered its survey had 7,200 members between them.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila, Liam Jerrold Fraser and Fiona Tweedie. 'A Future with Hope: Diaspora Churches in Scotland'. *Theology in Scotland* 31, no. 2 (2024): 43-59. <https://ojs.st-andrews.ac.uk/index.php/TIS/article/view/2805>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Africa

An article, the peer-reviewed paper of Brendan Research's project on diaspora churches, reporting a survey of Scotland's diaspora and ethnic minority congregations, which it calls 'the first study of ethnic minority and diasporic congregations in Scotland'. Sixty-five congregations responded, about a third of those contacted. The lack of suitable places of worship 'emerged as a major challenge for nearly all ministries', only 28 per cent owning their building, and the authors recommend that established congregations offer shared or redundant buildings 'for free or at reduced rates'.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila. 'Out with the Old, in with the New? An Introduction to the Phenomenon of New Churches in Glasgow, Scotland'. *Ecclesial Futures* 2, no. 1 (2021): 50-74. <https://ecclesialfutures.org/article/view/11886>.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

An article on the new churches founded in Glasgow between 2000 and 2016, the subject of Akomiah-Conteh's doctoral thesis. It argues that while old institutions wane, 'many new groups are emerging', 'often hidden from other forms of research such as national church surveys', and it raises questions about them, 'not least around the homogeneity of the majority of them'.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila. 'Rivers in the Desert: The Story of African Christianity in Britain'. *Anvil* 37, no. 3 (2021). <https://churchmissionsociety.org/anvil/rivers-in-the-desert-the-story-of-african-christianity-in-britain-sheila-akomiah-conteh-anvil-vol-37-issue-3/>.

ALSO IN Africa

An article on the growth of Black Majority Churches in Britain, and of African churches in particular, which it calls 'one of the most notable developments in contemporary British Christian history'. It traces their origins, then argues for their significance under four heads, from the resacralising of sacred places to the diversifying of British theology. Written for Church Mission Society's journal of mission by a Ghanaian scholar based in Scotland, it covers Britain as a whole.

Akomiah-Conteh, Sheila. 'The Changing Landscape of the Church in Post-Christendom Britain: New Churches in Glasgow, 2000–2016'. PhD thesis, University of Aberdeen, 2019.

ALSO IN Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A doctoral thesis by Sheila Akomiah-Conteh on the churches started in Glasgow from 2000 to 2016. Her later articles report that it identified 110 of them, and the Brendan Research study of diaspora churches across Scotland builds on it.

DENOMINATIONAL, CENSUS AND STATISTICAL SOURCES

Brierley, Peter. *The Fourth Scottish Church Census: The Results Unveiled*. Tonbridge: Brierley Consultancy, 2017.

The report of the fourth Scottish Church Census, taken in 2016, by Peter Brierley, who conducted it. Its 10 chapters cover the number attending church; the age, gender and ethnicity of churchgoers; churchmanship; geography; leadership; midweek attendance; and the age of Scotland's churches, the chapter that bears most directly on new churches. *Seeing the Shoots* takes from it the figure of 277 new churches begun since 2002. The findings were also sold as a book, *Growth Amidst Decline: What the 2016 Scottish Church Census Reveals*.

Church of Scotland Faith Action Programme Leadership Team. *Report of the Faith Action Programme Leadership Team*. Reports to the General Assembly 2026. Church of Scotland, 2026. https://www.churchofscotland.org.uk/__data/assets/pdf_file/0006/154653/Faith-Action-Programme-Leadership-Team1.pdf.

ALSO IN Resource Churches; Church Planting Strategy; Presbyterian and Reformed

A report to the Church of Scotland's General Assembly of May 2026, which asked the Assembly to note the progress of plans for a resource church in the Presbytery of Glasgow. It defines a resource church as a hub for mission, planting, revitalisation and developing leaders, proposes siting one near universities to reach students and young adults, and affirms three levels of planting: local, presbytery and national. It also records that the planting strategy the 2025 Assembly asked for is not ready, central staff having been cut.

Field, Clive D. 'Churchgoing in Glasgow, 1836–2016: The Statistical Record'. *Scottish Church History* 53, no. 1 (2024): 1–28.

An article by Clive D. Field setting out 14 censuses of churchgoing in Glasgow, from 1836 to 2016, as one measure of secularisation: the long view behind the recent counts of new churches in the city. It finds that churchgoing has declined relative to population since the later 19th century, first among Protestants.

Vint, Allan Scott. 'Statistics, Planning and the Mission of the Church of Scotland: A Critical Examination of Quantitative Data as a Resource for National, Regional and Local Engagement'. PhD thesis, University of Glasgow, 2018. <https://theses.gla.ac.uk/id/eprint/9113>.

A doctoral thesis on how the Church of Scotland has used its own figures for mission and planning through its decline in membership and attendance, by Allan Vint, earlier a presbytery mission development officer. It surveys ministers on their use of the 2011 national census and of early data from the Scottish Church Census of 2016, and studies one presbytery's attempt to allocate ministry by the numbers.

MISSION AND ECCLESIOLOGY IN THE SCOTTISH CONTEXT

Aisthorpe, Steve. *Rewilding the Church*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2020.

ALSO IN Presbyterian and Reformed

A book by Steve Aisthorpe, a mission development worker for the Church of Scotland, that takes rewilding, the ecological practice of letting land return to its own growth, as a picture of a church less dependent on its own strategies. It follows his study of churchless Christians, *The Invisible Church*.

Aisthorpe, Steve. *The Invisible Church: Learning from the Experiences of Churchless Christians*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2016.

ALSO IN Church Growth

A study of 'churchless Christians' in Scotland, people who no longer attend a congregation but still identify as Christian. Aisthorpe finds that leaving a congregation is 'more of a "wrench" than a "flit"', and that many who leave keep up informal Christian fellowship. Attendance figures do not count such believers, which bears on any measure of growth or decline made from attendance.

Fraser, Liam Jerrold. *Mission in Contemporary Scotland*. Edinburgh: Saint Andrew Press, 2021.

ALSO IN Missiology

A study of Christian mission in Scotland by Liam Jerrold Fraser, then minister of St Michael's, Linlithgow. Its publisher presents it as 'practical guidance to church leaders engaged in Fresh Expressions and church planting in a Scottish context'; the reviewer in *Life and Work* read it as 'a two-way dialogue' rather than a guide to method.

ENGLISH COMPARATORS

Goodhew, David, and Rob Barward-Symmons. *New Churches in the North East*. Durham: Centre for Church Growth Research, 2015. <https://csmc.webspace.durham.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/sites/144/2021/04/NCNereportFINAL.pdf>.

ALSO IN Church Growth; Studies and Reports on Church Planting

A report counting the new churches founded in North East England between 1980 and 2015: 125, with a combined usual Sunday attendance of about 12,000. Only 18 were founded by the historic denominations, and 47 have a black and minority ethnic majority. It answers the assumption that the region is simply in decline. Where Brierley's *Capital Growth* counts all churchgoing in London, this counts only new churches.

Rogers, Andrew. *Being Built Together: A Story of New Black Majority Churches in the London Borough of Southwark*. London: University of Roehampton, 2013. <https://www.roehampton.ac.uk/globalassets/documents/humanities/being20built20togethersb203-7-13.pdf>.

ALSO IN Cities and Urban Areas; Buildings, Venues and Space; Africa

A report, written by Andrew Rogers of the University of Roehampton, on the new black majority churches of the London Borough of Southwark, from a partnership with Southwark for Jesus and Churches Together in South London. It identified 252 such churches and estimates more than 240 in operation, over twice as many as all the borough's other churches, with nearly half in one postcode. Its chief practical subject is premises: congregations unable to find buildings the planning system counts as suitable for worship, some meeting in industrial units without permission.

Further Sources

Other Places to Look

This reading list gathers websites: collections of material on church planting, and the networks and organisations that plant churches or support those who do. The books and reports from these sites that this bibliography holds are listed under their subjects; a website or page appears here as a place to look. Each description is of the site as it stood in September 2026, and any of them may since have changed, moved or closed.

Most of the sites are American or British, and most belong to a tradition and write from within it. Among them are Reformed networks, Pentecostal and charismatic ones, and the church planting programmes of particular denominations, from the Methodist Church in Britain to the Presbyterian Church in America; others name no denomination at all.

This reading list opens with Resource Collections, sites whose chief offer is material; then Directories and Gateways, routes to other people and resources; Church Planting Networks, which churches and planters belong to; and Centres and Support Organisations, bodies that train, assess, coach, research or fund church planting.

RESOURCE COLLECTIONS

Antioch Network. *Resource Library*. <https://www.antiochnetwork.org.uk/resource-library>.

The resource library of the Antioch Network, a network of new churches in and around Manchester constituted as a Bishop's Mission Order in the Church of England's Diocese of Manchester. The library gathers material from partners, among them the Joshua Centre, Redeemer City to City, M4 and 24-7 Prayer, for planters and their launch and core teams.

The Broadcast Network. *Church Planting*. <https://thebroadcastnetwork.org/church-planting/>.

The church planting collection of Broadcast, an online library that names no denomination and calls itself 'a conversation partner for front-line ministry'; Broadcast was begun in 2013 by Colin Baron, Tom O'Toole and others at Christ Church Manchester. The collection holds seven courses and more than 80 recorded broadcasts, 80 articles and 50 podcast episodes on planting, reached by creating an account.

Church Army. *Research*. <https://churcharmy.org/our-work/research/>.

The research collection on the website of Church Army, a Church of England mission agency that trains evangelists. Its Research Unit, which studied fresh expressions of church and pioneer ministry, closed in June 2025, but its reports, among them evaluations of pioneer ministry and the *Encounters on the Edge* and *Snapshots* series, remain free to download. The page says that Church Army is looking for a secure long-term home for the archive, so its address may change.

Church Mission Society. *Pioneer Mission: Estates and New Housing Developments*. <https://churchmissionsociety.org/resources/pioneer-mission-estates-and-new-housing-developments/>.

A web page from the Church Mission Society that now opens onto the Society's general collection of resources: videos, webinar recordings, blog posts, prayer material and its journal *Anvil*. It is a place to look rather than a work to cite. Its one item found on estates and new housing is Ali Boulton's 'How to... pioneer mission on a new housing estate', from a Baptist pioneer's work in Swindon.

Exponential. *Multiplier Resource Library*. <https://exponential.org/multiplier-resource-library/>.

A resource library from Exponential, an American organisation that names no denomination. It holds articles, books, resource kits, assessments, webinars and podcasts: some free, among them a church planting resource kit, some paid, and some needing an account. Exponential also runs conferences; Exponential Australia and Exponential Europe have resource pages of their own. NewThing, the church multiplication network begun at Community Christian Church in Chicago, joined Exponential in April 2025.

Exponential Australia. *Resources*. <https://exponential.org.au/resources/>.

The resource page of Exponential Australia, 'a community of leaders and partners' working 'across all denominations and movements' for 'healthy church planting, disciple-making and multiplication' in Australia. It carries articles, stories of church planters, books, research reports, podcasts and videos; some material needs a free sign-up, or a digital pass to past conferences. Exponential Australia also holds a national conference.

Exponential Europe. *Resources*. <https://exponential.eu/resources/>.

The resource page of Exponential Europe, which describes its aim as 'fueling multiplication as the heartbeat of the church in Europe'. It offers workbooks free to download, among them Spirit-Filled, Together and Gospel X, with Bible reading plans, books and e-books, some sold through its shop, and the Movement System, a planning process for leadership teams. It also runs Roundtables, gatherings held in many European cities at once and in many languages.

Mission Frontiers. <https://connect.frontierventures.org/mission-frontiers>.

The website of *Mission Frontiers*, a bi-monthly magazine of mission published since 1979 by Frontier Ventures, an evangelical mission agency formerly the U.S. Center for World Mission. It returns often to church planting movements among unreached people groups. The free online archive, arranged by issue rather than by subject, runs from 2007, and part of it is also kept by the Ralph D. Winter Research Center.

Jones, Peyton. *Fifty Books Every Church Planter Should Read*. NewBreed Training, 2021. <https://newbreedtraining.com/50-books-church-planting/>.

A reading list of 50 titles, each with a paragraph of comment and a reason for reading it, compiled by Peyton Jones for NewBreed Training, the collective he co-founded. His own *Church Plantology* is among the 50 and *Church Zero* is added as a bonus, 'a manifesto for what we believe at Newbreed', so the choices show one trainer's priorities rather than a neutral survey. It sits among the resource collections here as a planter's way into further reading, and several of its titles are annotated in this bibliography.

NewChurches. <https://newchurches.com>.

The resource site of Send Network, whose statement of faith is the Southern Baptist Convention's Baptist Faith and Message 2000: courses, podcast episodes, articles, ebooks and ready-to-use resources for planters, reached through a free membership.

Verge Network. <https://vergenetwork.org/>.

A resource site for leaders in mission, begun in 2010 at The Austin Stone Community Church in Texas and merged in 2014 with the For The City Network; it names no denomination. A free library of some 20 ebooks and reports on discipleship is reached by registering, and its masterclasses, courses and coaching are paid. The newest dated material seen was from December 2024.

DIRECTORIES AND GATEWAYS

Congregational Resource Guide. *Church Planting Resources*. https://thecrg.org/collections/Church_Planting_Resources.

A small collection of links on church planting in the Congregational Resource Guide, which the Center for Congregations runs, with funding from Lilly Endowment, for congregations of every tradition. It held four items, among them an article on models of church plant and a listing of the Converge network.

PlanterMatch. <https://plantermatch.org/>.

An online directory, hosted by the Fuller Church Planting Initiative, that matches planters with church planting networks and coaches, filtered by context, theology and method, on the conviction that no one should plant alone. It lists some 170 networks across 110 denominations and offers a free e-book on discerning a call to planting.

Van Rheen, Gailyn. 'Bibliography: Resources for Church Planting'. Missiology.com, 2011. <https://missiology.com/blog/GVR-Bibliography-Resources-for-Church-Planting>.

A bibliography of some 40 works compiled by Gailyn Van Rheen, arranged in four parts, among them the practice of church planting and church planting among the poor. It is dated 2011, and sits on Missiology.com, now kept by the Missio Dei Foundation.

CHURCH PLANTING NETWORKS

24:14 Coalition. <https://2414now.net/>.

The website of the 24:14 Coalition, an evangelical coalition that calls itself 'a collaborative community catalyzing, multiplying and supporting church planting movements' among unreached peoples and takes its name from Matthew 24:14. The site, in 13 languages, has foundational teaching on movements, training materials and videos, prayer resources and a blog.

ARC Churches. <https://www.arcchurches.com>.

The website of the Association of Related Churches, 'a cooperative of independent churches from different denominations', each self-governed. ARC supports church planting and leadership development, and by its own figures has put more than \$100 million into planting; the site gives such figures and aims rather than a library of resources.

Acts 29. <https://www.acts29.com>.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

The website of Acts 29, a global church planting network that 'stands in the tradition of historic evangelical confessionalism', and works in six regions, from North America to Asia Pacific. Acts 29 plants churches and supports their pastors; the site carries stories, books, podcasts, videos and training material under some 40 topics.

Church Planting Canada. <http://www.churchplantingcanada.ca/home>.

The website of Church Planting Canada, a cross-denominational gathering of church planting catalysts and of denominational and network leaders, administered by the Pentecostal Assemblies of Canada, with the Lausanne Covenant as its statement of faith. Its main work is an annual national conference, Intersession; the site publishes little else.

Co-Mission. <https://co-mission.org/>.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

The website of Co-Mission, a network of churches in London, varied in culture, that 'teach the reformed evangelical faith of the scriptures'. The network exists 'to plant churches to reach London for Christ'. The site is chiefly about the network itself, which also keeps a video channel on YouTube.

Crossway Network. <https://crosswaynetwork.org/>.

The website of Crossway Network, a church planting network not connected with the publisher Crossway, which exists 'to plant and support healthy, reproducing churches and regional networks'. It has a statement of faith but names no denomination; its resource library holds huddle material, key documents and regional training sessions.

Global Church Planting Network. <https://www.gcpn.info/>.

The website of the Global Church Planting Network, a voluntary association registered in the United States that names no denomination and 'is not a funding agency but seeks to link people of shared vision'. Its regional teams, in eight clusters from Africa and the Arab World to the Western World, work at prayer mobilisation, strategic information, training and church planting; the pages on the regions carry older material.

Lausanne Movement. *Church Planting Issue Network*. <https://lausanne.org/network/church-planting>.

ALSO IN Lausanne Movement

The web page of the Lausanne Movement's Church Planting Issue Network, setting out its 'collaborate 2 Saturate' strategy, a disciple-making and church planting roundtable in every nation, supported by regional gatherings, and linking on to Multiplication Network, Saturation Church Planting and the Global Church Planting Network. It is a way in to those three partner bodies, and a place to look for what Lausanne is doing now rather than what it has said.

M4 Europe. <https://m4europe.org/>.

The website of M4 Europe, a multi-denominational church planting movement registered in Estonia and working in 13 European countries, which trains and coaches planting teams through its own programmes, M4 Ready and the M4 Team Process. Its work in the United Kingdom and Ireland is a section of the same site.

NCMI. <https://ncmi.net/>.

The website of NCMI, an international network of churches working by partnership in more than 100 countries, on what it calls an 'apostolic-prophetic model' and on the principle that 'local churches plant churches'. The site has a small set of videos and podcasts, two books and a blog on planting and leading churches.

Plant Anglican. <https://plantanglican.org/>.

The website of Plant Anglican, a global network of men and women planting 'within, or associated with the Anglican Communion', led by a steering group of bishops, clergy and lay leaders. The site offers stories, resources, training and strategies for church planting and a programme of webinars; a coaching portal was announced as coming soon.

Reach Australia (formerly Geneva Push). <https://reachaustralia.com.au>.

The website of Reach Australia, begun as Geneva Push: a network of more than 450 churches, Anglican, Presbyterian, Baptist and others, in the Reformed evangelical tradition, 'committed to launching new congregations and equipping church leaders'. It offers leadership development, church health reviews, consulting and coaching for planters.

Send Network. <https://www.sendnetwork.com/>.

The website of Send Network, the Southern Baptist Convention's network for church planting, run by its North American Mission Board, which trains and supports planters and sending churches; its courses and other material are delivered through the NewChurches site, listed separately here.

Vineyard Churches UK and Ireland. *Multiply: Resources*. <https://www.vineyardchurches.org.uk/multiply/resources/>.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

The church planting resources of Vineyard Churches UK and Ireland, a charismatic evangelical movement that describes itself as a church planting movement with a mandate to plant churches worldwide, rooted in Jesus's proclamation and demonstration of the Kingdom of God. A free church planting manual, two podcasts, Multiply and Planted, training modules and a staged coaching pathway serve those planting within the movement.

CENTRES AND SUPPORT ORGANISATIONS

20schemes. <https://20schemes.com/>.

The website of 20schemes, an evangelical charity that plants and revitalises churches on Scotland's poorest housing estates, the schemes of its name. It trains local leaders, among other ways through its Ragged School of Theology; a companion site, 20schemes Equip, has articles, courses, sermons, videos and a podcast, some free and some behind registration.

Always Forward. <https://www.always-forward.com/>.

The website of Always Forward, the Office of Church Planting of the Anglican Church in North America, which exists to 'train, mobilize, resource and support' the province's dioceses and church planters in starting new Anglican congregations. It offers training intensives, coaching, an assessment programme, online courses, a podcast and a resource on the health of planted churches, chiefly for planters and dioceses within the province.

Asbury Theological Seminary. *Center for Church Multiplication*. <https://asburychurchplanting.com/>.

The website of the Center for Church Multiplication at Asbury Theological Seminary, an evangelical seminary in the Wesleyan tradition. The centre exists to 'recruit, support, train, and connect Spirit-filled church planters' and, while it works with many networks and denominations, gives priority to those in the Wesleyan tradition. It offers workshops, a Certificate in Church Multiplication and degree courses, which are paid, with coaching, grants, a podcast and a resource library.

Baptists Together. *Pioneering*. <https://www.baptist.org.uk/Groups/310262/Pioneering.aspx>.

The pioneering pages on the website of the Baptist Union of Great Britain, known as Baptists Together, which grounds pioneering in the ministries of Ephesians 4 and describes it as a readiness to be sent beyond the edges of the church. Three Pioneer Ambassadors work with the Baptist associations and colleges, and the pages offer a video series, Snapshots of Baptist Pioneering, and training for pioneers; enquiries about church planting go to the local association.

CCX, the Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication. <https://ccx.org.uk/>.

The website of CCX, the Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication, begun in 2004 by the Diocese of London, after *Mission-Shaped Church*, as the Centre for Church Planting and Growth, and now working 'across all denominations and traditions'. CCX supports church planting, church growth and pioneering, and its site holds free articles, videos and research reports under some two dozen themes, among them estates, rural church and sacramental church.

Christian Reformed Church in North America. *Classis Resource: Church Planting*. <https://network.crcna.org/topic/church-strategy-mission/church-planting/classis-resource-church-planting>.

A page of the Christian Reformed Church in North America's online network carrying 'A Classis Resource for Church Planting', compiled by Resonate Global Mission and Pastor Church Resources for regional bodies, parent churches and planters. The downloadable guide gathers assessments, grants, training and coaching, the church order on forming a new church, and sample documents such as an agreement between a plant and its parent church.

Centre for European Church Planting. <https://www.cecp.eu/>.

The website of the Centre for European Church Planting, an organisation founded in 2004 by Tom Jackson, who had planted churches in Ukraine, to fund and support church planters and missionaries across Europe. Its history page carries the logo of Every Nation Europe without explaining the connection. The site publishes little by way of resources.

Church Multiplication Network. <https://www.churchmultiplication.net/>.

The website of the Church Multiplication Network, established in 2008 by the Assemblies of God in the United States, a Pentecostal denomination, to 'develop leaders and build the church'. It trains, funds and charters new churches, with training modules, cohorts, assessment, planting guides, a video library and an annual conference; its matching funds and credentials are for Assemblies of God planters.

City to City Australia. <https://citytocityaustralia.org.au/>.

The website of City to City Australia, the Australian arm of Redeemer City to City, based in Sydney, which 'exists to equip churches in contextualised mission'. It offers church planting cohorts and intensives, leadership and gospel coaching, and training in evangelism and preaching, rather than a library of materials.

Dynamic Church Planting International. <http://www.dcp.org>.

The website of Dynamic Church Planting International, an evangelical, non-denominational organisation founded in 1994 by Paul Becker, whose training in church planting, in four strands (planting, thriving, cultivating and multiplying), is donor-funded and free to participants; the site also offers free books and material for trainers.

European Mission Fellowship. <https://www.europeanmission.org/>.

The website of the European Mission Fellowship, a mission agency based in Market Harborough, 'evangelical and reformed' in its own description, which traces its history to revival in Eastern Europe in the 1930s and has had a British branch since 1959. It supports churches, missionaries, church planting, publishing and theological education, with more than 100 workers in 20 countries.

FIEC. *Church Planting*. <https://fiec.org.uk/who-we-are/what-we-do/church-planting>.

ALSO IN New Churches and Networks

The church planting section of the FIEC's website; the Fellowship of Independent Evangelical Churches is a body of self-governing churches working together in Britain. It advises on three ways of planting (a small team sent to a new area, a daughter church, and the replanting of a struggling congregation), gives grants and pastoral support, and holds an annual conference for planters.

Fresh Expressions. <https://freshexpressions.org.uk/>.

The website of Fresh Expressions, a body that grew from collaboration between several denominations and mission agencies and names no single tradition, whose concern is 'new forms of church that emerge within contemporary culture and engage primarily with those who don't "go to church"'. It offers training, coaching and a model it calls the Fresh Expressions Journey, and its site has stories, worship resources, articles, a reading list and a podcast, mostly free, with books for sale.

Methodist Church in Britain. *New Places for New People*. <https://www.methodist.org.uk/for-churches/evangelism-growth/new-places-for-new-people/>.

The web pages of New Places for New People, the Methodist Church in Britain's programme for starting new Christian communities among people its churches do not reach, run alongside Church at the Margins and supported by Methodist Pioneering Pathways for those who lead the work. The pages offer guides to beginning a new place and to circuit funding, with training, coaching and safeguarding guidance for pioneering settings.

Mission to North America (Presbyterian Church in America). <https://pcamna.org/>.

The website of Mission to North America, the church planting and renewal agency of the Presbyterian Church in America, which exists to serve 'the PCA to plant, mobilize, and restore churches'. It supports planting among several ethnic communities and in rural areas, and its resources site is chiefly a directory of partner organisations offering training, coaching and consulting.

Multiplication Network. <https://www.multiplicationnetwork.org/>.

The website of Multiplication Network, a training organisation whose mission is 'to equip leaders with the tools to strengthen and multiply healthy churches', working through seven regional hubs in more than 55 countries; the site carries the logo of the Evangelical Free Church of America. Its two programmes are More Churches, a course in church planting with mentoring, and Stronger Churches, an evaluation of church health, and it also offers videos, a podcast, a ministry toolbox and an assessment tool.

Redeemer City to City. <https://redeemercitytocity.com>.

The website of Redeemer City to City, a leadership development organisation founded in 2001 by Timothy Keller and Redeemer Presbyterian Church in New York, which exists 'to prayerfully help leaders start and strengthen churches to advance the gospel together in their cities' and works in more than 75 cities. It trains and coaches leaders, supports church planting and links churches together; its guide *Gospel-Centered City Ministry* can be downloaded from the site.

Revitalise Trust. <https://revitalisetrust.org/>.

The website of the Revitalise Trust, set up by Holy Trinity Brompton in 2017 as the Church Revitalisation Trust, which plants and revitalises churches in partnership with dioceses, from city resource churches to neighbourhood churches on estates and in towns. It also trains leaders and supports a network of churches, and its films and news stories give short accounts of particular plants and revitalisations.

St Hild Centre for Church Planting. <https://sthildplanting.org/>.

The website of the St Hild Centre for Church Planting, part of St Hild College, a theological college with Church of England roots, which works with denominations across the North of England to train leaders and teams for church planting and revitalisation. It runs a church planting track at the college, the seven-session Plant Course, an introductory course, Explore Church Planting, and an online programme, Seedbed, with webinars, articles and a small research page.

Stadia. <https://stadia.org/>.

The website of Stadia, an interdenominational church planting organisation which, by its own count, has helped launch more than 2,200 churches since 2003, holding that new churches should reflect 'a Kingdom of diversity'. It offers assessment through its Discovery Center, coaching, training and support for new churches, with podcasts and articles; one service, bookkeeping, is charged for.

The Unstuck Group. Multisite consulting. <https://theunstuckgroup.com/consulting/multisite>.

The web page of the Unstuck Group's multisite consulting, a commercial service for churches across denominations that assesses a church's ministry health and plans, staffs and launches new campuses, for churches already multisite and for those preparing to be. The address of MultiSite Solutions now leads to this page, and neither site explains the connection.

Glossary of Church Planting Terms

A glossary of the words a student meets in the literature of church planting and in the Church of England's own papers, in eleven sections under two headings, each section opening with a note on where its vocabulary comes from. An entry gives the word's meaning, its origin where one is known, and how it differs from its neighbours; its sources are cited and its reading lists named, so that a definition can be followed back into the book. A term that belongs to two sections is defined in the earlier one and pointed to from the later.

Church Planting, Renewal and Growth

Basic Church Planting Terms

The words in ordinary use for the work itself, for the people, churches and teams that do it, for how planters are chosen, and for the churches it produces. Most are plain English that settled into use rather than coined terms. Their edges are soft: the same writer may use two of them for one thing, and one may mean different things in different traditions. The sections that follow narrow the focus, and assume the terms here.

Church plant

A congregation started from scratch in a particular place by an existing church or a planting organisation, even where a [parish](#) church already stands nearby. Church of England material treats plants and [fresh expressions of church](#) as complementary, and puts the difference between a [resource church](#), which is one form a plant takes, and a fresh expression in where each begins: the first from a settled idea of the church to be formed and the staff and money to form it, the second from listening to the context it will belong to.

SOURCES Religion Media Centre, 'Church of England Glossary' (2019); Church of England, 'Resource Churches and Fresh Expressions' (2020). **SEE ALSO** Church planting; Daughter church; Fresh expression of church; New worshipping community; Resource church. **READING LIST** Introductions and Overviews.

Church planter

Whoever leads the starting of a new church. The title is not in the New Testament, and writers such as Brandon Langley resolve it into an existing ministry doing missionary work rather than an office of its own. In North America a candidate often goes through [church planter assessment](#) before being sent. The Church of England's formal vocational category is the [pioneer](#), of whose work planting is one kind.

SOURCE Langley, 'What Is a Church Planter?' (2023). **SEE ALSO** Church planter assessment; Pioneer ministry; Planting team; Bivocational. **READING LIST** Selecting and Assessing Planters. **ALSO IN** The Planter and the Team.

Church planter assessment

The practice, in North American denominations and [planting networks](#), of examining candidates before they are sent to plant: questionnaires and interviews, then an assessment centre of several days, ending in a verdict on whether they are ready. The assessment centre is traced to AT&T's choosing of managers in 1956; Thomas Graham, an organisational psychologist, is credited with the first for [church planters](#), in 1983, for the Presbyterian Church in America. Charles Ridley's 13 behavioural characteristics, from his study of 1984 across 13 denominations, became the standard most instruments rest on. In the Church of England the process is called discernment, though the Gregory Centre's 'Attributes of a Church Planter' repeats several of Ridley's.

SOURCES Ridley, *How to Select Church Planters* (1988); Ott and Wilson, *Global Church Planting* (2011); Stetzer, Christopherson and Yang, *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems* (2018); Church of England, *The Shared Discernment Process for Ordained Ministry* (2024); Hoare, 'Attributes of a Church Planter' (2022). **SEE ALSO** Church planter; Church planting residency; Pioneer ministry. **READING LIST** Selecting and Assessing Planters. **ALSO IN** The Planter and the Team.

Church planting

The work of starting new congregations, and the body of practice, training and argument that has grown up around it. The figure behind the phrase is Paul's, in 1 Corinthians 3. [Church extension](#) was the Victorian term for planting, though it also covered the formal carving-out of new [parishes](#); [church multiplication](#) is not a synonym but the planting of churches that go on to plant in their turn. John McGinley would plant the gospel instead: scripture, he argues, does not teach the church to plant churches, and a church is God's people gathered with Jesus at their centre.

SOURCES Paul, 'Can the C of E Plant New Churches and Retain the Parish System?' (2021); Dunthorne, 'The Priority of the Gospel' (1997). **SEE ALSO** Church plant; Church extension; *Plantatio ecclesiae*; Church multiplication. **READING LIST** Introductions and Overviews.

Daughter church

A congregation started by an existing church, its [mother church](#), which sends some of its members to form the new church's core and supports it at the start; the name marks a [plant](#) by its relation to the church that started it. Craig Ott and Gene Wilson call mother-daughter planting the commonest approach to [church multiplication](#). The phrase has an older English sense as well, which need not involve planting: a subsidiary church or chapelry within a [parish](#), dependent on the minster or parish church.

SOURCE Ott and Wilson, *Global Church Planting* (2011). **SEE ALSO** Mother church; Church plant.

Mother church

A church from which another has been planted, and the counterpart of a [daughter church](#); in this sense it is sometimes referred to as a sending church, the church that sends the team and supports it. Two older senses are separate. In older Roman Catholic canon law the mother church is the cathedral, from Innocent III's ruling that 'by the mother church we understand the cathedral'. In English history a mother parish or minster is the senior church from whose territory later [parishes](#) and chapels were formed.

SOURCES Herbermann, *The Catholic Encyclopedia* (1908); Stutz, 'A Mother Church's Importance in Planting' (2019). **SEE ALSO** Daughter church; Church plant; Parish.

Parachute plant

A church started by a planter sent into a community where, in the Baptist Convention of Iowa's words, 'he doesn't really know anyone and no one really knows him', with a small core group from a sending church or none. It differs from a [daughter church](#) in that no body of members goes with the planter from a [mother church](#). Acts 29, which calls it the parachute drop, counts it probably the hardest way to plant: the planter relocates, often works bivocationally and can expect slower growth.

SOURCES Baptist Convention of Iowa, 'The Parachute Church Planting Strategy'; Acts 29, '4 Questions for Becoming a Church Planting Church, Part 3'. **SEE ALSO** Daughter church; Mother church; Planting team. **READING LISTS** Church Planting Strategy; Practical Guides.

Planting network

A voluntary association of churches formed to plant churches, which recruits, assesses, trains, coaches and often funds planters; the Holy Trinity Brompton network, within the Church of England and the Church in Wales, is one. Ed Stetzer, Jeff Christopherson and Daniel Yang's study of church planting systems (2018) sets networks beside denominations as the two kinds of body that plant in North America. It differs from a [network church](#), a single church gathered around relationships rather than a place.

SOURCE Stetzer, Christopherson and Yang, *Best Practices in Church Planting Systems* (2018). **SEE ALSO** Network church; Church planting; Church planter assessment. **READING LISTS** New Churches and Networks; Church Planting Strategy; Other Places to Look.

Planting team

The group gathered to start a new church, which provides its first members and its early leadership; core team and core group are names for the same people. It is not the launch team, which Nelson Searcy describes as larger and temporary, though Paul Whaley of Acts 29 appears to use both names of the same people. Myriad, an initiative for [lay-led churches](#) within the Church of England, from the Gregory Centre, speaks of a team without settling on a word for it. The Anglican Mission in England's Planting Team is something else: its own supporting staff.

SOURCES Searcy, 'Church Planting'; Myriad, 'Introductory Resources'. **SEE ALSO** Church planter; Resource church; Apostolic team. **READING LIST** Teams and Culture. **ALSO IN** The Planter and the Team.

Kinds of Church and Plant

Names for the shapes a church can take, including the Church of England's and Fresh Expressions' own forms, defined here and listed again in their sections. Most come from four streams: the small-church literature, which argues how little a gathering can have and still be a church; the American and British vocabulary of ethnicity and migration; the digital vocabulary of the pandemic; and the history of British church movements. Others name churches by size, spread across several sites, gathered by network, dying, or set against the parish. In the Church of England's counting, new worshipping community is the umbrella term under which plants and fresh expressions alike are recorded.

Black majority church

A church led by black Christians or with a mainly black congregation; in Britain, chiefly of Caribbean and African heritage. The older name, 'black-led', divides churches by leadership rather than membership, and Arlington Trotman argued in 1992, as Israel Olofinjana reports, that it was imposed by outsiders and did not describe the churches. Olofinjana dates Britain's black Pentecostal churches from 1906, when Brem-Wilson, a Ghanaian, started Sumner Road Chapel in Peckham. It overlaps a [diaspora church](#) without being a kind of one, since its members may be British-born; and by Michael Emerson's measure a church can also be [multi-ethnic](#) so long as no group makes up 80 per cent or more.

SOURCES Olofinjana, 'What Are Black Majority Churches?' (2023); Olofinjana, 'Historical Development of Black Pentecostal Churches in Britain'. **SEE ALSO** Diaspora church; Multi-ethnic church; Reverse mission. **READING LISTS** Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Pentecostal; Cities and Urban Areas.

Cell church

A church built on small groups treated as the basic unit of its life rather than as one activity among many, which still gather as one larger body: its advocates put cell and celebration on an equal basis. Ralph Neighbour's *Where Do We Go From Here?* (1990) claims that the cell 'is church life'; the structure is older, and David Yonggi Cho's congregation in Seoul was organised in cells by 1974. Joel Comiskey makes evangelism, leadership development and multiplication the cell's own priorities, which marks a cell church off from a church that happens to run small groups.

SOURCE Neighbour, *Where Do We Go From Here?* (1990). **SEE ALSO** House church; Missional community; Microchurch.

Class meeting

The weekly meeting of about 12 members of an early Methodist society under a class leader, who in time gave its members pastoral oversight. It began at Bristol as a way of collecting a penny a week from every member to clear the debt on the New Room, and John Wesley saw that the collectors' weekly visits were a means of pastoral care. It differs from the band, a smaller, voluntary group for mutual confession, and from the society, the whole local Methodist body the classes made up. Kevin Watson's *The Class Meeting* (2013) argues for its recovery by small groups now.

SOURCES Wesley, *A Plain Account of the People Called Methodists, in a Letter to the Revd Mr Perronet* (1749); Watson, *The Class Meeting* (2013). **SEE ALSO** Cell church. **READING LISTS** Early Methodist Church Planting; Methodist and Wesleyan; Discipleship.

Diaspora church

A congregation formed by and largely for people who have migrated, of any national or linguistic origin, often worshipping in their own language. The academic frame is diaspora missiology, which the Lausanne Movement's Seoul Declaration of 2009 defines as a framework for God's mission 'among people living outside their place of origin'. It measures something different from a **black majority church**: migration rather than ethnicity, so that a church can be either without being the other.

SOURCE Lausanne Movement, 'The Seoul Declaration on Diaspora Missiology' (2009). **SEE ALSO** Black majority church; Reverse mission; People group. **READING LISTS** New Churches in Scotland since 2000; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church; Global and Cross-Cultural.

Emerging church

The conversation, from the late 1980s, among Christians who held that church had to be remade for a postmodern culture, and who gathered in alternative worship, **house churches** and new congregations across the denominations. It began in New Zealand from about 1989 and in Britain from about 1992, before the American organisation that gave it its public face. Some of those inside it distinguish emerging, the movement, from Emergent Village, which Doug Pagitt and Brian McLaren founded in 1999; McLaren himself, and D. A. Carson, who wrote against the movement, use emerging and emergent as synonyms.

SOURCES Gibbs and Bolger, *Emerging Churches* (2005); Carson, *Becoming Conversant with the Emerging Church* (2005). **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church; Missional; Post-Christendom. **READING LIST** Post-Christendom and the Secular West. **ALSO IN** The Missional Church.

Gathered church

A church constituted by the covenanting together of believers who choose it, as against the **parish**, to which everyone living in a place belongs. The principle is English Separatist and Congregational, set out in Robert Browne's treatise of 1582 on congregational independency, and the Baptist tradition took the same view of a disciplined congregation of the baptised. In Church of England writing the word also has a plainer sense: Will Foulger, who sets parochial against membership-defined churches, uses gathered of the worshipping congregation itself.

SOURCE Foulger, *New Things* (2024). **SEE ALSO** Parish; Network church; Resource church. **READING LIST** Parish Church. **ALSO IN** Ecclesiology.

House church

A church that meets in a home, or the British movement of the 1970s and 1980s that took the name. The first runs from the New Testament households of Lydia, Prisca and Aquila to the house churches of China, a name there for congregations that are unregistered wherever they meet, many of them now large and meeting openly, and to the **missional** house churches of recent planting writing. The second, the House Church movement, was charismatic and restorationist, left houses behind as it grew, and renamed itself the **New Churches** in 1988.

SOURCES Payne, *Missional House Churches* (2008); Walker, *Restoring the Kingdom* (1998); Silliman, 'Died' (2022). **SEE ALSO** Microchurch; Cell church. **READING LIST** Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting.

Hybrid church

A congregation that gathers both in person and online, in everything it does or in part of it, where an [online church](#) gathers wholly or mainly online. Blended is used for the same thing, but carries two other senses that are not this one: in liturgical writing it means a service mixing traditional and contemporary music, and in Fresh Expressions a blended economy is what is elsewhere called a [mixed economy](#). The phrase itself predates the pandemic: Dave Browning's *Hybrid Church* (2010) used it for a church combining the intimacy of small groups with the reach of a large one.

SOURCES Phillips, *Hybrid Church* (2020); 'What Do We Mean by Hybrid Church?'. **SEE ALSO** Online church; Fresh expression of church; Mixed economy. **READING LIST** Digital and Hybrid Church.

Inherited church

The church that was already there, named from the side of what is new: the [parishes](#), the congregations and the patterns received rather than started. Rowan Williams, as Archbishop of Wales, had written of ways of being church alongside 'the inherited parochial pattern'; *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004) speaks of inherited models of church, and its second edition pairs inherited with fresh, judging both by the disciples they make. Fresh Expressions material uses the word without defining it.

SOURCES Cray et al., *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004); Müller, 'Towards the Acceptance of Diversity' (2020). **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church; Mixed ecology; Parish. **READING LIST** Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy. **ALSO IN** Fresh Expressions of Church.

Intercultural church

A congregation that sets out to have its cultures shape one another and share its leadership, rather than hold them side by side. Harvey Kwiyan and Nigel Rooms describe it as a church where 'everyone is changed by the encounter in worship and mission across cultures', each keeping their own identity, and set it against a one-way street of assimilation. British church bodies have taken the word up, among them the Anglican Network for Intercultural Churches, launched in April 2023. A student meets a second and unrelated sense in W. Jay Moon and W. Bud Simon's *Effective Intercultural Evangelism* (2021), where intercultural means presenting the gospel across frames such as guilt, shame and fear.

SOURCES Kwiyan and Rooms, *Two-Way Street*; 'First Intercultural Mission Conference in the Church of England' (2023). **SEE ALSO** Multicultural church; Multi-ethnic church; Contextualisation. **READING LIST** Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church.

Legacy church

A congregation near the end of its life, or the planting that builds on what it leaves. In Southern Baptist use the phrase is 'legacy church planting', and Mark Clifton's 2015 article for the North American Mission Board gives a dying church three paths: a legacy plant, in which the church [replants](#) itself; a legacy partnership, in which it closes and another church takes over its buildings and ministry; and a legacy provision, in which it closes and gives what remains to [church planting](#). In the United Church of Christ's Southern New England Conference, becoming a legacy church means concluding a congregation's ministry after discernment.

SOURCES Clifton, 'Introducing Legacy Church Planting' (2015); Southern New England Conference, 'Building a Legacy and Completing a Ministry'. **SEE ALSO** Replant; Revitalisation; Pastoral reorganisation. **READING LIST** Revitalisation and Replanting. **ALSO IN** Revitalisation and Replanting.

Megachurch

A very large Protestant congregation, usually defined, after the Hartford Institute for Religion Research, as one with an average weekly attendance of 2,000 or more, adults and children at all its sites counted together. Its defining measure is size: a megachurch may meet on one campus or be a [multisite church](#), and a multisite church need not be large. Jack Shepherd separates it from the [resource church](#), with which, he writes, it is regularly conflated.

SOURCES Shepherd, 'What's in a Name?' (2024); Hartford Institute for Religion Research, 'Megachurch Definition'. **SEE ALSO** Resource church; Multisite church. **READING LISTS** Multi-site Church; Resource Churches; Church Growth.

Messy Church

An all-age gathering at which people eat, play and worship together, which began at St Wilfrid's, Cowplain, near Portsmouth, in 2004 and is supported internationally by the Bible Reading Fellowship. Its five values are that it is Christ-centred, all-age, creative, hospitable and celebratory. Its own material says it is a congregation rather than a feeder programme for a Sunday service; Oliver Gross, reviewing *Messy Church Theology* in 2015, holds instead that it should be kept as an outreach of a more traditional church, preparing people for the move into one. In Church Army's survey of 21 dioceses it was the commonest kind of [fresh expression](#), about a third of those counted.

SOURCES Bible Reading Fellowship, 'What Is Messy Church?'; Gross, 'Review Article' (2015); Lings, *The Day of Small Things* (2016). **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church; Inherited church. **READING LIST** Fresh Expressions of Church. **ALSO IN** Fresh Expressions of Church.

Microchurch

A church deliberately kept small, and understood by its advocates as a church in full rather than a part of one. Brian Sanders and the Underground Network in Tampa make the test functional rather than numerical: where worship, community and mission coincide, a church is present. Brad Brisco separates the microchurch from a [missional community](#), which is normally tethered to a parent congregation as its outreach, where a microchurch holds its own leadership and the network exists to serve it. Warren Bird gives five to 35 people as the usual range, and notes that none of the small forms, microchurch, simple church and [house church](#) among them, has a universally accepted definition.

SOURCE Sanders, *Microchurches* (2019). **SEE ALSO** House church; Missional community. **READING LIST** Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting.

Minster model

A pattern of church life named after the Anglo-Saxon minster, a superior church with pastoral and financial reach across a wide area, and used in two ways. The Diocese of Leicester's Minster Communities are groups of churches and [fresh expressions](#) working collaboratively and sharing resources, much like a [mission community](#). Alan Bing's minster model is a single church at the centre, gathering resources in order to share them more widely; Jack Shepherd holds that not every minster church is a [resource church](#) and that the two should not be conflated.

SOURCES Diocese of Leicester, 'Minster Communities'; Shepherd, 'What's in a Name?' (2024). **SEE ALSO** Resource church; Mission community; Parish; Revitalisation. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Missional community

A group gathered around mission to a neighbourhood or a network as well as around one another. Mike Breen, who dates his own first ones to the 1980s and carried the form on through the 3DM network, places it between a small group and a congregation, ordered by the pattern he calls up, in and out; David Lloyd's survey of Anglican practice found them ranging from fewer than five members to more than a hundred. Whether such a group is a church in its own right is unsettled: Jeff Vanderstelt holds that it is, and in Lloyd's survey most leaders call it their members' main expression of church while most members keep a tie to a Sunday congregation.

SOURCES Lloyd, 'Back to the Garden' (2024); Breen and Absalom, *Launching Missional Communities* (2010). **SEE ALSO** Mission community; Missional; Microchurch; Cell church. **READING LIST** Fresh Expressions of Church. **ALSO IN** The Missional Church.

Multi-ethnic church

A congregation of more than one racial or ethnic group. The measure quoted with it is Michael Emerson's, from the sociology of the multiracial congregation: in *United by Faith* (2003) no one group makes up 80 per cent or more, on the reasoning that a group smaller than a fifth cannot make itself heard, and a church 79 per cent white, and white throughout its leadership, still counts. Mark DeYmaz, in *Building a Healthy Multi-Ethnic Church* (2007), defines it without a number: 'an authentic, visible community of faith where people of diverse backgrounds worship together as one'. [Intercultural](#), and [multicultural](#) in its narrower use, describe how the groups present share a life; neither is another name for this.

SOURCES DeYmaz, *Building a Healthy Multi-Ethnic Church* (2007); DeYoung et al., *United by Faith* (2003). **SEE ALSO** Homogeneous Unit Principle; People group; Intercultural church; Multicultural church. **READING LIST** Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church.

Multicultural church

A congregation with several cultures in it. Some British church material uses the word more narrowly, for a congregation whose groups keep their own services, ministries and programmes, and British and Australian material sets it against [intercultural](#), the practice of having those cultures shape one another; no one is credited with the distinction, and it is not settled. Harvey Kwiyani, whose *Multicultural Kingdom* (2020) is subtitled *Ethnic Diversity, Mission and the Church*, uses multicultural in the plain sense, and in his course booklet with Nigel Rooms even for cultures shaping one another.

SOURCES Kwiyani, *Multicultural Kingdom* (2020); Kwiyani and Rooms, *Two-Way Street*. **SEE ALSO** Intercultural church; Multi-ethnic church; Homogeneous Unit Principle. **READING LIST** Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church.

Multisite church

One church meeting in several places, which Geoff Surratt, Greg Ligon and Warren Bird define as sharing a common vision, budget, leadership and board across its sites. A Leadership Network gathering in 2001 is credited with starting the modern movement. Whether it is one church at all is argued: Gregg Allison holds that multisite can be biblically justified when properly structured, and John Hammett that a church which never gathers in one place is not one church; Andy Paterson, comparing it with a [church plant](#), holds that a site should in time be released to govern itself.

SOURCES Surratt, Ligon and Bird, *The Multi-Site Church Revolution* (2006); Paterson, 'Multi-Site Church' (2017). **SEE ALSO** Church plant; Resource church. **READING LIST** Multi-site Church.

Network church

A church gathered around a network of relationships — work, study, interest, culture — rather than around a place, and set against the neighbourhood or [parish](#) church. The distinction is usually credited to *Mission-shaped Church* (2004). The [planting networks](#) use the word differently: the Holy Trinity Brompton network and Acts 29 are networks of churches, and a congregation inside one is a [plant](#) rather than a network church.

SOURCE Cray et al., *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004). **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church; Parish; Church plant. **READING LIST** Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy.

New Churches

The British charismatic churches that grew out of the [house church](#) movement, restorationist in outlook, many of them in networks under [Apostolic](#) leaders; and the name they took from 1988, when Gerald Coates of Pioneer proposed it at a conference in Sheffield for them all. Used without capitals, the same words mean simply churches recently started, of any tradition, which is a different thing.

SOURCE 'Died' (2022). **SEE ALSO** House church; Apostolic; Planting network. **READING LISTS** New Churches and Networks; Pentecostal.

New monasticism

A movement of communities that order their common life by a rule taken from the monastic tradition, including married couples and families as well as single members. Jonathan Wilson, answering Alasdair MacIntyre in 1997, made it the way the church would recover its true end in a fragmented world. A gathering at Rutba House in Durham, North Carolina, in 2004 produced the twelve marks published as *School(s) for Conversion* (2005); the British form reached the Church of England through Fresh Expressions and *Ancient Faith, Future Mission* (2010). A sentence from Dietrich Bonhoeffer's letter to his brother Karl-Friedrich in 1935, calling for a new kind of monasticism, is widely quoted as the movement's charter.

SOURCES Cray, Mobsby and Kennedy, *Ancient Faith, Future Mission* (2010); Rutba House, *School(s) for Conversion* (2005); Huyser, 'The New Monastic Movement' (2008). **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church; Rule of life; Missional community.

READING LIST Rule of Life.

New worshipping community (NWC)

A new congregation in the Church of England's own terms, which dioceses count towards their targets for new communities. The Diocese of Worcester, for example, defines one administratively rather than doctrinally: it meets in person or online at least once a month, and it aims to reach people who have not been to church in the past two years.

SOURCE Diocese of Worcester, 'New Worshipping Communities'. **SEE ALSO** Church plant; Fresh expression of church; Vision and Strategy for the 2020s. **READING LIST** Church of England Papers and Reports. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Online church

A congregation whose gathering is itself wholly or mainly online, rather than a physical congregation broadcasting what it does. Where the line falls is contested: the Vatican's *The Church and Internet* (2002) held that 'there are no sacraments on the Internet', while the Methodist Conference affirmed in 2023 the possibility of predominantly online churches. A [hybrid church](#) meets both in person and online.

SOURCES Hutchings, *Creating Church Online* (2017); Pontifical Council for Social Communications, *The Church and Internet* (2002). **SEE ALSO** Ecclesial minimum; Fresh expression of church; Hybrid church. **READING LIST** Digital and Hybrid Church.

Resource church

A church designated by its diocesan bishop to plant churches and to resource mission across a city or town. The five-element definition is credited to Ric Thorpe: designation by the bishop, a place in a diocesan strategy, resourcing to plant and to revitalise, a pipeline of leaders, and other resources for mission across the area. *Resourcing the Church?* (2025) softens the first element to partnership with the bishop and dates the first formal description of one to 2011. Jack Shepherd finds Thorpe's definition tied to the Church of England's legal practice, and sets resource churches apart from hub, [minster](#) and [mega churches](#); Alison Milbank and the Save the Parish campaign question their effect on the [parishes](#) around them.

SOURCES Thorpe, 'City-Centre Resource Churches' (2020); Shepherd, 'What's in a Name?' (2024); Thorpe, Powley and Gilfeather, *Resourcing the Church?* (2025). **SEE ALSO** Graft; Revitalisation; Minster model; Planting team. **READING LIST** Resource Churches. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Revitalisation and Replanting

What is done with a church that is declining or dying. The replanting vocabulary is mostly American, much of it from Southern Baptist writing of the 2010s, and turns on a single question: whether the congregation that is there continues. Revitalisation is the looser word, and is used on both sides of the Atlantic. The Church of England has taken the two up unevenly — revitalisation is in current use, replant is rare — and its own mechanism is the graft, defined here; the legal process for closing a church is among its own words.

Graft

A team with a leader joined to a congregation that is already there, to renew it rather than to start something new; where a [revitalisation](#) may be worked from within, a graft brings its leadership, people and resources from another church. The Diocese of Oxford's wording is that church grafts or revitalisations 'seek to renew an existing church by grafting leadership, people and resources' into it. *Resourcing the Church?* (2025) sets grafting into a church that is struggling against planting into one that is closed or in a new location.

SOURCES Diocese of Oxford, 'Resourcing Hubs and Church Planting'; Thorpe, Powley and Gilfeather, *Resourcing the Church?* (2025). **SEE ALSO** Revitalisation; Resource church; Replant. **READING LIST** Revitalisation and Replanting. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Legacy church

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Replant

The closing of a congregation and the starting of a new one in its place, with a new leader, a new name and new governance. In Thom Rainer's terms the line between it and [revitalisation](#) is that revitalising works from within while a replant brings in new leadership and ends the congregation's continuity. Whether the two differ in kind or in degree is argued: Rainer records writers who treat it as a matter of degree and offers 'relaunch' for the middle ground, while Mark Clifton will call a case an internal replant where others would call it revitalisation. In replanting, Mark Hallock calls the congregation that comes alongside the dying church 'for the long haul' its sending church.

SOURCES Rainer, 'Revitalize and Replant' (2018); Hallock, 'Revitalization vs Replanting' (2017); Hallock, 'In Church Replanting, What Exactly Is a Sending Church?' (2024). **SEE ALSO** Revitalisation; Legacy church; Graft. **READING LIST** Revitalisation and Replanting.

Revitalisation

The work of bringing a declining congregation back to health without ending it, a work expected to take years. It is the other half of the pair with [replant](#): revitalising keeps the congregation and its governance, where a replant ends them and begins again. The Church of England's usual form brings a leader and team from another church by [graft](#): the Diocese of Liverpool defines revitalising as a transfusion of energy by one [parish](#) church into another, aiming to grow the congregation to an independently sustainable size.

SOURCES Rainer, 'Revitalize and Replant' (2018); Diocese of Liverpool, *Church Revitalising Protocol* (2024). **SEE ALSO** Replant; Resource church; Graft. **READING LIST** Revitalisation and Replanting.

The Planter and the Team

Who does the work, under what name, and how they are trained. The words come from three places that do not line up: the ministries listed in Ephesians 4, read by missional writers as a typology and by restorationists as offices; American assessment and training schemes, among them the words for earning a living alongside ministry; and the Church of England's own designations. The mission-structures literature adds the apostolic team. The planter is among the basic terms, and the Church of England's structures have their own section.

APEST

The five ministries of Ephesians 4:11 — apostle, prophet, evangelist, shepherd and teacher — read as a typology. Alan Hirsch made the acronym current in *The Permanent Revolution* (2012, with Tim Catchim) and 5Q (2017), reading the five as functions rather than offices and holding that Western churches narrowed them to the last two; *The Shaping of Things to Come* (2003), with Michael Frost, is reported as having APEPT, with pastor. Fivefold ministry is the older name, but in Pentecostal use since the Latter Rain movement of 1948 it carries a further claim: apostle and prophet are offices lost since the first century and now restored. Bob Robinson objects that Granville Sharp's rule joins shepherds and teachers, leaving four.

SOURCES Hirsch, 5Q (2017); Hirsch and Catchim, *The Permanent Revolution* (2012); Robinson, 'A Caring Critique of Alan Hirsch's APEST Paradigm for Churches' (2017); Frost and Hirsch, *The Shaping of Things to Come* (2003). **SEE ALSO** Apostolic; Apostolic Genius; Missional. **READING LIST** Leadership in Church Planting.

Apostolic

What belongs to the apostles, and to the pioneering work that the planting literature takes from them. In Alan Hirsch's **APEST** reading of Ephesians 4 it names one of the five ministries a church needs, the one that starts things. In the New Churches that came out of British restorationism it names a present office: Newfrontiers calls its senior figures apostolic leaders, and looks to local elders to invite the apostolic leaders' input and authority. Applied to the whole church, as when *Lumen Gentium* grounds the church's mission in the sending of the apostles, the word belongs with **apostolicity**, the creedal mark.

SOURCES Hirsch, 5Q (2017); Second Vatican Council, *Lumen Gentium* (1964); Walker, *Restoring the Kingdom* (1998). **SEE ALSO** APEST; Apostolicity; Apostolic team. **READING LIST** Leadership in Church Planting.

Apostolic team

A mobile team that plants churches and moves on, on the pattern of Paul and his companions, as against the **planting team** that stays to become the new church's core. The phrase has no settled definition. Don Dent argues in *The Ongoing Role of Apostles in Missions* (2019) that such a team is a significant entity alongside the church, under no local church's oversight, and independent teaching pages, Craig Kirkby's and Logan Leadership's, use the phrase for what Ralph Winter called a **sodality**. Newfrontiers' own word is the apostolic leader, not the team.

SOURCES Dent, *The Ongoing Role of Apostles in Missions* (2019); Kirkby, 'How Does an Apostolic Team Work?'; 'Sodality and Modality'. **SEE ALSO** Apostolic; Planting team; Sodality; APEST. **READING LIST** Church Planting Movements.

Bivocational

A minister who also earns a living outside the church. Brad Brisco separates bivocational from **covocational**: a bivocational **planter** takes a second job to supplement what the church can pay, hoping it will be temporary, while a covocational one has a calling in the marketplace they never intend to leave. Both are current in American Southern Baptist planting. The Church of England's own are different: self-supporting minister, also called non-stipendiary minister, and, for those whose workplace is the main arena of their ministry, minister in secular employment. Tentmaking, from Acts 18:3, is a word for supporting oneself in ministry, used especially in cross-cultural mission, where the work may give access to a country closed to missionaries.

SOURCES Brisco, *Covocational Church Planting* (2018); Holcomb, 'Called By Whom, To What, To Where?' (2026); 'Self-Supporting Ministry'. **SEE ALSO** Covocational; Church planter. **READING LIST** Bivocational and Covocational Ministry.

Church planter

DEFINED UNDER Basic Church Planting Terms.

Church planter assessment

DEFINED UNDER Basic Church Planting Terms.

Church planting residency

A fixed period inside a sending or host church in which a would-be **planter** is formed and given the work to do before being sent out; in the American networks it follows a pass at **church planter assessment**. Acts 29 speaks of 'apprenticeship and residency' together. The word names a family of programmes that vary widely in length and hours. The Holy Trinity Brompton network runs its leadership training alongside curacy rather than calling it a residency. It is not a curacy, which every ordained minister of the Church of England serves, which lasts at least three years, and which follows theological college.

SOURCES Redeemer Church NW, 'Residency'; Revitalise Trust, 'Developing Leaders'; Church of England, 'Curacy'. **SEE ALSO** Church planter assessment; Church planter; Planting curacy. **READING LIST** Formation and Training.

Covocational

A **planter** whose calling in the marketplace runs alongside the call to start a church, and who does not intend to leave the marketplace. Brad Brisco, who directs bivocational planting for the Southern Baptists, is credited with the word and set it out in *Covocational Church Planting* (2018), against **bivocational** ministry, where outside work makes up what the church cannot yet pay. His further argument is that the older word encourages the split between spiritual and ordinary work. Austin Holcomb's criticism of 2026 asks which New Testament ministry the covocational planter stands in.

SOURCES Brisco, *Covocational Church Planting* (2018); Holcomb, 'Called By Whom, To What, To Where?' (2026). **SEE ALSO** Bivocational; Church planter. **READING LIST** Bivocational and Covocational Ministry.

Focal minister

The leader, lay or ordained, of one church within a multi-parish benefice or group of churches, so that each congregation has its own focal person while oversight is held by an incumbent or oversight minister. Bob Jackson gave the role its name in *Leading One Church at a Time* (2018), for 'the focal person embedded at the centre of just one church'. Dioceses have since made it an authorised role, Sheffield pairing each focal minister with an oversight minister and Chichester defining it under an incumbent who gives oversight. Where a **pioneer** begins a new community, a focal minister leads an existing one, and Chichester describes it as a role rather than an office.

SOURCES Jackson, *Leading One Church at a Time* (2018); Diocese of Sheffield, 'Focal Ministry'; Diocese of Chichester, 'Focal Ministry'. **SEE ALSO** Pioneer ministry; Ordained Pioneer Minister; Parish; Pastoral reorganisation. **READING LIST** Parish Church. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Ordained Pioneer Minister (OPM)

A Church of England minister ordained deacon or priest and designated for [pioneer ministry](#). The Church's stocktake of 2019 for General Synod spoke of exploring pioneer designation for those already in an ordained or licensed lay role; candidates are discerned through the ordinary process, with each of the qualities given a pioneering inflection. Because they are expected to start and shape new communities, ordained pioneers are formed as incumbents, and the qualities document makes no reference to assistant priestly ministry. Ministry Division hoped for about 6,000 pioneers by 2027, a fifth of them ordained and the rest lay.

SOURCES General Synod of the Church of England, GS 2142 (2019); Church of England, *Qualities for Formation IME1 Ordained Pioneer* (2025); Diocese of Ely, *Ordained Pioneer Ministry* (2024). **SEE ALSO** Pioneer ministry; Church planter.

READING LIST Pioneering. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Pioneer ministry

The Church of England's category for those who begin new Christian communities among people outside the church, in ordained and in lay forms. A definition the Church's formation papers date to its Ministry Council in 2017 turns on being first: pioneers are 'the first to see and creatively respond to the Holy Spirit's initiatives' with those outside the church, gathering others to establish new contextual Christian community. *Mission-shaped Church* (2004) had recommended that lay and ordained pioneers be identified, trained and deployed, and called planting pioneer where known Christians are few. Ben Aldous and colleagues argue that the word carries a settler's frame and propose pilgrim instead.

SOURCES General Synod of the Church of England, GS 2142 (2019); Aldous et al., 'Problems with "Pioneering" Mission' (2022); Church of England, *Qualities for Formation IME1 Ordained Pioneer* (2025). **SEE ALSO** Ordained Pioneer Minister; Fresh expression of church; Church planter; Focal minister. **READING LIST** Pioneering. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Planting curacy

A curacy, the title post every newly ordained Church of England minister serves, designed to train the curate to plant: the curate spends one to three years in a [resource church](#) and then plants out, to start a new worshipping community or revitalise a parish church. The Diocese of London announced that each of its first designated resource churches would receive a planting curate, in a three-year post, and that the Strategic Development Fund would pay for 15 of the posts. It differs from a [church planting residency](#), which is not a title post, is not confined to the ordained, and is the usual term outside the Church of England.

SOURCE Bishop of London, 'London Diocese Announces First Resource Churches'. **SEE ALSO** Church planting residency; Resource church; Church planter. **READING LISTS** Formation and Training; Resource Churches. **ALSO IN** The Church of England's Vocabulary.

Planting team

DEFINED UNDER Basic Church Planting Terms.

Growth and Multiplication

How churches grow, how the growth is counted, and what the counting is for. The vocabulary comes from an older missionary literature and the evangelical revival tradition, from the Church Growth school that Donald McGavran began in the 1950s, from the American multiplication networks that followed it, and from international saturation strategies, hence its categories, ratios and generations; theory of change, which funders now ask for, comes from evaluation practice. Its habit is to prefer reproduction to accumulation. The movements section carries the argument further; People group and the Engel scale are in Missiology.

Church Growth movement

The school of missiology founded by Donald McGavran, which studies why churches grow and treats growth as a subject for research; in lower case the phrase is also ordinary English for a church getting bigger. McGavran, a missionary in India, argued the case in *The Bridges of God* (1955) and *Understanding Church Growth* (1970), and moved to Fuller Theological Seminary in 1965, where he founded the School of World Mission; C. Peter Wagner applied its categories to congregations in America. Its critics say it puts sociology before theology — Glen Huebel's phrase is 'long on sociology and short on theology' — and William Abraham that its method moves between rival and even opposed traditions without cost.

SOURCES McGavran, *Understanding Church Growth* (1970); Wagner, *Our Kind of People* (1979). **SEE ALSO** Homogeneous Unit Principle; Conversion growth; People group. **READING LIST** Church Growth.

Church multiplication

The planting of churches that themselves plant, as against a church adding congregations that depend on it. Todd Wilson, chief executive of the Exponential network, puts the difference in the capacity to reproduce: what has been added cannot reproduce itself, because it relies on the parent to act. How many generations count is not agreed: Dave Ferguson asks for churches that plant to the fourth generation, while Ed Stetzer and Warren Bird are reported to set the mark at 50 per cent reproduction through the third.

SOURCE 'The Church Multiplication Challenge'. **SEE ALSO** Church planting movement; Spontaneous expansion; Saturation church planting. **READING LIST** Church Planting Movements.

Conversion growth

Growth in a congregation from people newly coming to faith, as against biological growth from the children of members and transfer growth from Christians arriving from other churches. The three categories are Donald McGavran's, and Thom Rainer restated them in *The Book of Church Growth* (1993); the point of separating them is that a congregation whose numbers are rising may be doing any of the three. Thom Rainer now says he cannot get data good enough to tell transfer growth from conversion growth, and Sam Rainer's 25-year analysis for Church Answers counts four ways a church grows rather than three.

SOURCES Rainer, *The Book of Church Growth* (1993); McGavran, *Understanding Church Growth* (1970); Rainer, 'The Real Story Behind Transfer Growth and Churches'; Rainer, 'It Is Time to Stop Celebrating Church Transfer Growth' (2024). **SEE ALSO** Church Growth movement; Church multiplication. **READING LIST** Biological, Transfer and Conversion Growth.

Homogeneous Unit Principle (HUP)

Donald McGavran's claim that people prefer to become Christians without crossing barriers of race, language or class; a homogeneous unit is 'a section of society in which all the members have some characteristic in common'. He set the principle out in *Understanding Church Growth* (1970), and C. Peter Wagner defended it for American congregations as an ethical position. C. René Padilla objected at the Lausanne consultation at Pasadena in 1977, in a paper he revised in 1982, that using it to grow churches lacks biblical grounds, because the church is a reconciling community. The consultation agreed that such a church can often be legitimate, but can never be whole on its own.

SOURCES McGavran, *Understanding Church Growth* (1970); Wagner, *Our Kind of People* (1979); Padilla, 'The Unity of the Church and the Homogeneous Unit Principle' (1982); *The Pasadena Consultation* (1978); McIntosh, 'Revisiting the Homogeneous Unit Principle' (2023). **SEE ALSO** Church Growth movement; People group; Multi-ethnic church. **READING LIST** Homogeneous Unit Principle. **ALSO IN** Ecclesiology.

People movement

The turning of a group within one people to Christ together, so that its members become Christians as a group without leaving their community. J. Waskom Pickett studied such cases in India, then called mass movements, in *Christian Mass Movements in India* (1933), and Donald McGavran, building on his work, called them people movements in *The Bridges of God* (1955). It differs from an **insider movement**: a people movement concerns how a decision to follow Christ spreads through a group, an insider movement whether believers keep their former religious identity. It is older than the **church planting movement**, which is defined by churches multiplying rather than by a group's joint decision.

SOURCES McGavran, *The Bridges of God* (1955); Pickett, *Christian Mass Movements in India* (1933); Daggett, 'Donald McGavran's *Bridges of God* [1955]' (1955). **SEE ALSO** Homogeneous Unit Principle; Church planting movement; People group; Movement. **READING LISTS** Church Growth; Homogeneous Unit Principle; Church Planting Movements. **ALSO IN** Church Planting Movements.

Revival

A season in which a Christian community's faith and devotion intensify, often with many conversions, seen in the tradition of Jonathan Edwards as a surprising work of God. Charles Finney's *Lectures on Revivals of Religion* (1835) held that a revival follows the right use of means, as a crop follows good husbandry. Iain Murray, in *Revival and Revivalism* (1994), sets revival, which God sends, against revivalism, which can be manufactured and worked up by method. Michael McClymond distinguishes revival from renewal, the return of zeal to a community that has declined. Whether the Asbury outpouring of 2023 was a revival is argued in the literature on it.

SOURCES McClymond, 'What Revivals Can Teach Us' (2023); Finney, *Lectures on Revivals of Religion* (1835); 'Revival and Revivalism'. **SEE ALSO** Revitalisation; Conversion growth. **READING LISTS** Asbury Outpouring 2023; Early Methodist Church Planting.

Saturation church planting

Planting until every community in a country has a church within reach. Jim Montgomery promoted it through the 1980s and 1990s under the name DAWN, and the method was to set a national target and mobilise every willing denomination towards it. Targets were set as ratios: the Ghana Evangelism Committee proposed a church for every 300 to 1,000 people. Successor networks carry the strategy on, one of them as Saturation Church Planting Global, and the Lausanne paper of 2024 reports leaders who hold that a place with many churches is not saturated with the gospel while violence persists there.

SOURCE Lausanne Church Planting Issue Network, *Saturation Church Planting* (2024). **SEE ALSO** Church multiplication; Church planting movement. **READING LIST** Lausanne Movement.

Spontaneous expansion

Roland Allen's name, from his book of that title published in 1927, for the church's growth through the unorganised activity of its own members. His definition joins three things: members explaining to others the gospel they have found, the attraction of the church's ordered life, and the founding of new churches. He named what prevents it: foreign control of ordination, dependence on outside money, and a paid clergy, since knowing that the speaker is paid changes how speaker and hearer alike regard what is said. Allen also held that the **three selves** cannot be pursued separately: a church spreads only as it also supports and governs itself.

SOURCE Allen, *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church and the Causes Which Hinder It* (1927). **SEE ALSO** Church multiplication; Three-self principle; Movement. **READING LIST** Missiology.

Theory of change

A statement of what must change, why, and by what steps, for a programme's activities to produce the outcomes it intends; unlike a plan's statement of goals, it explains why the steps should work. The term came out of the Aspen Institute's roundtable on community change in the 1990s, and Carol Weiss is credited with popularising it, on the ground that complex programmes are hard to evaluate because the assumptions behind them are poorly articulated. Maoz Brown argues that it suffers from real polysemy, meaning different things to different practitioners. The Diocese of Oxford, preparing a bid for Strategic Development Funding, developed one and described the work as demystifying the concept.

SOURCES Weiss, Carol H., in *New Approaches to Evaluating Comprehensive Community Initiatives*. Washington, DC: Aspen Institute, 1995; Brown, 'Unpacking the Theory of Change'. **SEE ALSO** Mission Action Planning; Vision and Strategy for the 2020s. **READING LIST** Theory of Change.

Mission, Theology and the Church

Church Planting Movements

The vocabulary of two related traditions of mission practice, church planting movements and disciple making movements, which came out of fieldwork in Latin America and Asia in the 1990s and spread through training networks. Much of it is method, in fixed processes with names and acronyms that are learned by being trained in them. The general vocabulary of multiplication and counting is in Growth and Multiplication, the mission theory the movements draw on is in Missiology and The Missional Church, and the small churches they produce are among the kinds of church.

Church planting movement (CPM)

Indigenous churches planting churches, and multiplying fast, within one **people group** or population segment. David Garrison's booklet of 1999 for the Southern Baptist International Mission Board, which had adopted the phrase as its vision the year before, calls it 'a rapid and exponential increase'; a later wording has the churches sweeping through a people group. Whether it differs from a **disciple making movement** is argued: Discipleship.org sees disciple making as the process that produces it, and Dare to Multiply treats the two names as interchangeable. Ed Roberts, reviewing Garrison's book of 2004 for 9Marks, objects that Garrison never clearly defines 'rapid', and Jackson Wu that measuring a **movement** by numbers is arbitrary rather than biblical.

SOURCES Garrison, *Church Planting Movements* (1999); Garrison, *Church Planting Movements* (2004). **SEE ALSO** Movement; Disciple making movement. **READING LIST** Church Planting Movements.

Disciple making movement (DMM)

A [movement](#) in which disciples make disciples and churches form as the outcome rather than the starting point, worked out through [Discovery Bible Study](#), the [person of peace](#) and obedience-based discipleship. The approach goes back to David Watson's work with Victor John among the Bhojpuri of northern India from 1994, and the name was coined by the team at CityTeam in December 2010 to replace the more general '[church planting movement](#)'. How far the two terms differ is argued: Discipleship.org treats disciple making as the process and [church multiplication](#) as its result, while Dare to Multiply treats the names as interchangeable.

SOURCES Watson and Watson, *Contagious Disciple Making* (2014); New Generations, 'Our History'. **SEE ALSO** Church planting movement; Discovery Bible Study. **READING LIST** Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting.

Discovery Bible Study (DBS)

A group's study of one passage of Scripture in a fixed shape. The passage is read aloud, retold from memory, and asked what it says about God and about people; then each person says what they will do about it and whom they will tell. David Watson devised it, and it starts among people who are not yet believers, where the groups of [Training for Trainers \(T4T\)](#) begin after conversion. The rule practitioners state most often is that the facilitator is a fellow learner who teaches nothing. The wording of the questions varies between networks; the shape does not.

SOURCE Watson and Watson, *Contagious Disciple Making* (2014). **SEE ALSO** Disciple making movement; Person of peace. **READING LIST** Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting.

Four Fields

A diagram of a [church planting](#) work in four stages, taken from the parable of the growing seed in Mark 4 and set out in Nathan and Kari Shank's manual. The empty field is where nothing has been sown, the seeded field where the gospel has been shared, the third where disciples grow, and the harvested field where a church is formed. A fifth element, leadership multiplication, is drawn by some as a fifth field and by others as running through all four. Compiled in 2007 and revised in 2014, the manual circulates free rather than as a published book, and networks beyond the Shanks' own South Asia name the third field differently: sprouted for NoPlaceLeft, growing for Zúme.

SOURCE Shank and Shank, *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth* (2014). **SEE ALSO** Church planting movement; Disciple making movement. **READING LIST** Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting.

Movement

Disciples making disciples and churches planting churches, generation after generation, so that the growth carries on beyond the team that began it. Steve Addison's *Movements That Change the World* (2011) sets out five keys common to such movements: white-hot faith, commitment to the cause, contagious relationships, rapid mobilisation and adaptive methods. Within [church planting](#) the two named traditions are the [church planting movement](#) and the [disciple making movement](#), and both are counted in spiritual generations.

SOURCE Addison, *Movements That Change the World* (2011). **SEE ALSO** Church planting movement; Disciple making movement; Church multiplication. **READING LIST** Church Planting Movements.

People movement

DEFINED UNDER Growth and Multiplication.

Person of peace

Someone in a community a team is trying to reach who welcomes the messengers, listens to them, and opens a household or a network to them. The phrase comes from Luke 10:6, where some translations have 'son of peace', and [disciple making movements](#) make finding such a person the first step, with a [Discovery Bible Study](#) begun in the household they open. Practitioners reserve it for a gatekeeper who gathers others, not a friendly or interested contact. Alex Kocman, writing for ABWE, objects that Luke is describing one time-limited mission, and that his phrase means someone who has visibly responded in faith, not someone picked out beforehand as receptive.

SOURCE Watson and Watson, *Contagious Disciple Making* (2014). **SEE ALSO** Disciple making movement; Discovery Bible Study. **READING LIST** Disciple Making Movements (DMM) / Micro-Church Planting.

Training for Trainers (T4T)

A process for starting churches, developed in East Asia by Ying and Grace Kai, missionaries with the International Mission Board, in which every disciple is trained to train others and every group to start further groups. Every meeting runs in three thirds: looking back over the past week's obedience and witness, looking up at a new passage, looking ahead to what will be practised and with whom. Steve Smith wrote it up with Ying Kai as *T4T: A Discipleship Re-Revolution* (2011). It differs from [Discovery Bible Study](#) in where conversion sits: T4T presents the gospel and asks for commitment before its groups begin, where a Discovery group starts before its members believe.

SOURCE Smith and Kai, *T4T* (2011). **SEE ALSO** Church planting movement; Disciple making movement. **READING LIST** Church Planting Movements.

Missiology

The vocabulary of the cross-cultural mission literature that church planting borrows from. Most of it describes what happens when the gospel crosses a cultural boundary: how a church takes root in a new culture, who its people are, and how much of that culture a believer keeps. The rest names the structures mission works through, and pictures of belonging and of coming to faith borrowed from set theory and communication studies. Most of it was formed for mission abroad and is now applied to Britain. The Western conversation about the church's own missionary nature is in *The Missional Church*.

Belonging before believing

The claim that people often come to faith by belonging to a Christian community before they believe, so that a church welcomes them into its life before asking for commitment. It sums up the sequence George Hunter calls Celtic in *The Celtic Way of Evangelism* (2000; revised 2010): fellowship, then ministry and conversation, then belief and an invitation to commit, against a Roman sequence of presentation, decision and fellowship. Michael Lawrence of 9Marks argues that it redefines the church, which he holds consists of believers. It is not Grace Davie's 'believing without belonging' (1994), a description of Britons who keep some belief but do not attend.

SOURCES Hunter, *The Celtic Way of Evangelism* (2010); Lawrence, 'How "Belonging Before Believing" Redefines the Church' (2012). **SEE ALSO** Missional community; Conversion growth. **READING LISTS** Evangelism; Celtic and Early British Mission.

C1 to C6 spectrum

John Travis's scale of six kinds of Christ-centred community in Muslim settings, published in the *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* in 1998. C1 is a church worshipping in a foreign language and in Western forms and C2 the same in the local language; C3 uses local cultural forms but filters out Islamic religious ones; C4 uses Islamic forms that scripture permits, its members calling themselves followers of Isa; C5 believers remain legally and socially Muslim; C6 are secret believers. The C stands for Christ-centred communities rather than **contextualisation**. Almost all the argument is about C5: Timothy Tennent holds that what separates it from C4 is identity and that it can be no more than a transitional bridge, whereas Joshua Massey defends it.

SOURCES Travis, 'The C1 to C6 Spectrum' (1998); Tennent, 'Followers of Jesus (Isa) in Islamic Mosques' (2006). **SEE ALSO** Insider movement; Contextualisation. **READING LIST** C1-C6 and Insider Movements.

Centred set

A way of describing a group by its centre rather than its edge: belonging means facing the centre and moving towards it, where in a bounded set belonging means being inside a boundary; Hiebert kept a boundary between being a Christian and not, with less stress on maintaining it. The pair is Paul Hiebert's, borrowed from set theory into missiology in 'Conversion, Culture and Cognitive Categories' (1978). Jonathan Leeman objects that the borrowing is a category mistake, since belief is not a matter of direction, and that a church which avoids stating its boundaries is being disingenuous.

SOURCE Hiebert, 'Conversion, Culture and Cognitive Categories' (1978). **SEE ALSO** Fuzzy set; Contextualisation; Conversion growth. **READING LIST** Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets.

Contextualisation

The work of putting the gospel and the church's life into the terms of a particular culture, so that what is said is faithful and intelligible where it is said. The word entered missiology through the World Council of Churches' Theological Education Fund in 1972 and is credited to its director, Shoki Coe, working with Aharon Sapsejian. Stephen Bevans's *Models of Contextual Theology* sorts the ways it is done, five models in 1992 and a sixth, the countercultural, added in 2002. The Lausanne movement's Willowbank Report of 1978 set the irrelevance of beginning where people are not against the danger of a truncated gospel, and warned separately against syncretism.

SOURCES Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology* (2002); *The Willowbank Report* (1978); De Vries, 'Towards a Global Theology' (1536). **SEE ALSO** Inculturation; Indigenisation; Three-self principle; Incarnational; Contextual church. **READING LIST** Missiology.

Engel scale

James Engel and Wilbert Norton's scale, from *What's Gone Wrong with the Harvest?* (1975), setting out what a person knows and believes at each step on the way to faith and beyond it into discipleship. Negative numbers run down through ignorance of the gospel, zero is the point of repentance and faith, and a shorter positive run covers growth as a disciple. Published versions of the scale differ in their range, and later ones extend it: Paul Hazelden's modified scale starts at minus 12.

SOURCE Engel and Norton, *What's Gone Wrong with the Harvest?* (1975). **SEE ALSO** Conversion growth; Centred set. **READING LIST** Engel Scale.

Fuzzy set

A group with neither a boundary nor a centre, so that the grounds for saying who belongs are vague: the third category, in Mark Baker's account of Paul Hiebert's scheme, beside the bounded set and the **centred set**. The word itself comes from mathematics, from Lotfi Zadeh's paper of 1965 in *Information and Control*. Baker, in *Centered-Set Church* (2021), holds that a fuzzy church has given up its boundary without putting a direction of travel in its place, so that it finds it hard to call for movement or change.

SOURCES Baker, *Centered-Set Church* (2021); Hiebert, 'Conversion, Culture and Cognitive Categories' (1978); Zadeh, 'Fuzzy Sets' (1965). **SEE ALSO** Centred set; Ecclesial minimum. **READING LIST** Bounded, Centred and Fuzzy Sets.

Inculturation

The Roman Catholic word for the work Protestants call [contextualisation](#): the gospel taking flesh in a culture, and that culture being taken into the life of the church. The Second Vatican Council, in *Ad Gentes* (1965), speaks of adaptation and accommodation rather than inculturation; the encyclical usually cited for the word is *Redemptoris Missio* (1990). Which word is used is largely a matter of confession: Protestant writers, and the World Council of Churches, prefer contextual theology.

SOURCES John Paul II, *Redemptoris Missio* (1990); Second Vatican Council, *Ad Gentes* (1965). **SEE ALSO** Contextualisation; Indigenisation; *Plantatio ecclesiae*. **READING LIST** Roman Catholic.

Indigenisation

The older name for making a church belong to its own culture rather than to the missionaries who brought it: the wider programme of which the [three-self formula](#) is the working test. Charles Kraft argued in 1973 that the formula measured indigeneity by a few forms without asking how they function or what they mean, and proposed the dynamic equivalence church instead. [Contextualisation](#) was coined in 1972, when, as Kraft later put it, many wanted a more dynamic approach. It is still used in Catholic and Anglican African missiological writing, paired with [inculturation](#).

SOURCES Kraft, 'Dynamic Equivalence Churches' (1973); Kraft, 'Contextualisation Theory in Euro-American Missiology' (1997); De Vries, 'Towards a Global Theology' (1936). **SEE ALSO** Three-self principle; Contextualisation; Inculturation. **READING LIST** Victorian Three Selves.

Insider movement

A movement to faith in Christ in which the gospel travels along existing family and social networks and believing households stay inside their socioreligious community, keeping their identity as members of it while living under the lordship of Christ. Rebecca Lewis wrote the definition in 2007, after a discussion convened by the *International Journal of Frontier Missiology*; the term was already in use. It differs from a [church planting movement](#), whose members, as Lewis quotes Garrison, 'make a clean break with their former religion', where insider believers do not. It is not the same as C5, which places one congregation on a scale of religious identity, since a C5 church need not belong to a movement at all. The practice is contested: Timothy Tennent and Gary Corwin argue against it, and Lewis and Kevin Higgins are among those who answer them.

SOURCE Lewis, 'Promoting Movements to Christ within Natural Communities' (2007). **SEE ALSO** C1 to C6 spectrum; Contextualisation. **READING LIST** C1-C6 and Insider Movements.

Modality

The church's ordinary structure, the congregation, [parish](#) or diocese: in Ralph Winter's words 'a structured fellowship in which there is no distinction of sex or age', which a person belongs to without the further, adult decision that joining a [sodality](#) requires. Winter set the pair out in an address in Seoul in August 1973, published in *Missiology* the next year, and traced it from the synagogue and the missionary band of the New Testament to the diocese and the monastery of the fourth century. Steve Hollinghurst of Church Army notes that both words were already in Roman Catholic use. The everyday sense of modality, a mode or manner, is no guide to this one.

SOURCES Winter, 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission' (1974); Hollinghurst, 'From Modality to Metaphor' (2012). **SEE ALSO** Sodality; Parish. **READING LIST** Modality and Sodality. **ALSO IN** Ecclesiology.

Parachurch

An organisation doing Christian work alongside the churches without being under the authority of any of them, such as a student body or a training network. The word marks standing outside church authority, where [sodality](#) marks the second decision by which a person joins, so that a religious order is a sodality and not a parachurch body. Whether the arrangement is a fault is argued: Carl Trueman holds that influence without accountability to a church is unknown in the New Testament, and Howard Snyder is reported as holding that denominations are themselves human structures standing alongside the people of God.

SOURCES Trueman, 'Parachurch Groups and the Issues of Influence and Accountability' (2014); Hollinghurst, 'From Modality to Metaphor' (2012). **SEE ALSO** Sodality; Ecclesial minimum. **READING LIST** Modality and Sodality.

Pauline Cycle

David Hesselgrave's 10-stage pattern of cross-cultural [church planting](#), drawn from Paul's mission in Acts 13 to 16 and set out in *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally* (1980): missionaries commissioned, audience contacted, gospel communicated, hearers converted, believers congregated, faith confirmed, leadership consecrated, believers commended, relationships continued, sending churches convened. It follows one church from first contact to its release, the last stage leading on to new areas. It is the older evangelical counterpart of [Four Fields](#), the movements' diagram of planting in four stages drawn from Mark 4.

SOURCE Hesselgrave, *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally* (1980). **SEE ALSO** Four Fields; Church planting. **READING LISTS** Acts of the Apostles; Global and Cross-Cultural; Missiology.

People group

The largest group within which the gospel can spread as a church planting movement without meeting barriers of understanding or acceptance, which is the definition the Lausanne Committee settled at Chicago in 1982. The framework came out of the [Church Growth](#) school at Fuller, and Ralph Winter's address to the Lausanne congress of 1974 turned mission strategy from countries towards peoples and introduced hidden peoples, later called unreached. The Joshua Project counts a people group unreached when evangelicals are 2 per cent of it or fewer and Christians of any kind 5 per cent or fewer. The congress's own covenant did not take up the language.

SOURCE Joshua Project, 'Definitions'. **SEE ALSO** Homogeneous Unit Principle; Church Growth movement. **READING LIST** Global and Cross-Cultural.

Reverse mission

Mission to Britain and the wider West by churches and missionaries from the majority world, reversing the direction of the modern missionary movement. The Evangelical Alliance traces it to gratitude for the missionaries Europe once sent, joined to a sense that Europe now needs missionaries itself. The term is contested: some African missionaries reject it, Israel Olofinjana reports, for implying that Western mission was the original, and Babatunde Adedibu's title asks whether Britain's [black majority churches](#) are reverse mission or migrant sanctuaries. Reverse mission names a claim to be sent to the host society, which a [diaspora church](#) serving its own community need not make.

SOURCES Evangelical Alliance, 'A Dummies Guide to Reverse Mission'; Olofinjana, 'Contextual Mission Theology and Migration Theologies' (2024). **SEE ALSO** Diaspora church; Black majority church; *Missio Dei*. **READING LISTS** Africa; Global and Cross-Cultural; Multi-ethnic and Intercultural Church.

Sodality

A voluntary, purpose-formed Christian structure, such as a religious order or a mission agency, which people join by what Ralph Winter calls 'an adult second decision beyond modality membership'. Winter set it against the [modality](#) in his address of 1973, and held that the Reformation's failure to readopt the sodalities was its greatest error, leaving Protestants without a mechanism for missions until William Carey's *Enquiry*. Steve Hollinghurst sets the Protestant [parachurch](#) beside the sodality as its rough equivalent, and reads Winter as arguing that such bodies are themselves church.

SOURCES Winter, 'The Two Structures of God's Redemptive Mission' (1974); Hollinghurst, 'From Modality to Metaphor' (2012).

SEE ALSO Modality; Apostolic; Parachurch. **READING LIST** Modality and Sodality. **ALSO IN** Ecclesiology.

Three-self principle

The formula that a church should become self-governing, self-supporting and self-propagating. Henry Venn of the Church Missionary Society and Rufus Anderson of the American Board reached it at about the same time, in the middle of the nineteenth century; Venn's image was of the mission as scaffolding, taken down once the building stands, and his phrase for the goal was 'the euthanasia of a mission'. John Nevius built a working method on it. Paul Hiebert and David Bosch have argued for a fourth self, self-theologising. China's Three-Self Patriotic Movement took the same three words for a church under state control.

SOURCES 'Venn, Henry'; Hiebert, *Anthropological Insights for Missionaries* (1985). **SEE ALSO** Spontaneous expansion; Contextualisation; Indigenisation. **READING LIST** Victorian Three Selves. **ALSO IN** Ecclesiology.

The Missional Church

The vocabulary of the missional church conversation in the West, mostly of the 1990s and after, though its premise was formed in mid-century ecumenical missiology. Its words are mostly adjectives and slogans from a few books, Guder's *Missional Church* (1998), Frost and Hirsch's *The Shaping of Things to Come* (2003) and Murray's *Post-Christendom* (2004), spread through networks; some name practices and places a missional church keeps. Missiology holds the cross-cultural vocabulary it drew on; the movements that made a method of these ideas have their own section, as do fresh expressions of church.

Apostolic Genius

Alan Hirsch's name, in *The Forgotten Ways*, for what makes a [movement](#) multiply: the whole of what a church is and does when a latent capacity in it becomes active. That capacity he calls mDNA, which his own site expands as movement DNA and others read as missional DNA, with six elements in the first edition of 2006: Jesus is Lord, disciple making, the missional-incarnational impulse, apostolic environment, organic systems, and *communitas*, not community. His two cases are the early church and the underground church in China, each of which he presents as having grown by orders of magnitude. The second edition of 2016 renamed apostolic environment as [APEST](#) culture, and *communitas* as liminality and *communitas*.

SOURCE Hirsch, *The Forgotten Ways* (2016). **SEE ALSO** Apostolic; Movement; Missional; Church multiplication. **READING LIST** Church Planting Movements.

Attractional

A church that grows chiefly by drawing people to its services, buildings and programmes rather than by being sent out to them. Michael Frost and Alan Hirsch set it against [incarnational](#) in *The Shaping of Things to Come* (2003), where such a church invites people in to hear the gospel on its own ground. In the missional literature the word is mostly pejorative; the American church-growth and planting literature uses it more neutrally.

SOURCE Frost and Hirsch, *The Shaping of Things to Come* (2003). **SEE ALSO** Incarnational; Missional. **READING LIST** Missiology.

Emerging church

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Incarnational

Mission patterned on the incarnation: entering a culture and remaining inside it rather than calling people out of it into the church. The adjective has no traceable coinage. Michael Frost and Alan Hirsch's *The Shaping of Things to Come* (2003) makes incarnational ecclesiology one of three shifts asked of the church, sets the word directly against **attractional**, and calls incarnational mission a prism through which to view the whole **missional** task. J. Todd Billings objects to the wider language of incarnational ministry that it turns the Word's becoming flesh, a uniquely divine act, into a method of ministry for Christians to repeat.

SOURCES Frost and Hirsch, *The Shaping of Things to Come* (2003); Billings, 'The Problem with "Incarnational Ministry"' (2012).

SEE ALSO Attractional; Missional; Contextualisation. **READING LIST** Missiology.

Missio Dei

The claim that mission belongs to God before it belongs to the church, which takes part in a sending that is not its own. Karl Barth made the theological move in 1932 and Karl Hartenstein coined the Latin phrase two years later; the idea was worked out at the International Missionary Council's Willingen conference of 1952, which did not use the words, and the phrase spread through Georg Vicedom's book of 1958. David Bosch's formulation is that mission is an attribute of God rather than primarily an activity of the church. Willingen left a division, Barth and Hartenstein holding that God's work in the world runs through the church and J. C. Hoekendijk that it largely passes it by.

SOURCES Bosch, *Transforming Mission* (1991); Vicedom, *Missio Dei* (1958); 'Missio Dei'. **SEE ALSO** Missional; Incarnational.

READING LIST Missiology.

Missional

A church that understands itself as sent rather than as a place people come to, and orders its life accordingly. The word became current with *Missional Church* (1998), edited by Darrell Guder, in a movement whose foundations Lesslie Newbigin's work had laid, and it rests on **missio Dei**. An earlier and separate use exists — the United Methodist Church's 'missional priority' of the 1980s was denominational planning language. Anthony Brown, writing from inside the conversation, complains that the word has become an adjective of uncertain meaning added to programmes that were running anyway.

SOURCE Guder, *Missional Church* (1998). **SEE ALSO** *Missio Dei*; Incarnational; Attractional; Missional community. **READING LIST** Missiology.

Missional community

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Post-Christendom

The condition of a society that was shaped by the Christian story and in which the faith and its institutions have lost their hold. Stuart Murray, the author of *Post-Christendom* (2004), treats it as a period of transition rather than whatever will follow Christendom, and separates it from postmodernity. Lesslie Newbigin had described the post-Christian West earlier, and differently, as a pagan society with false gods. Ron Adams and Isaac Villegas answer that Christendom has mutated rather than ended.

SOURCES Murray, *Post-Christendom* (2018); Murray, 'What Comes After Post-Christendom?' (2019). **SEE ALSO** Missional; Emerging church; Parish. **READING LIST** Post-Christendom and the Secular West.

Rule of life

A settled pattern of prayer, work and common life that a person or a community binds itself to. Three different things go by the name: a community's constitutional rule, as in Benedict's Rule; a personal framework of practices; and the shared habits taken on by [missional communities](#) and [new monastic groups](#). The claim, met in some of the literature, that the Latin *regula* means a trellis rather than a rulebook is not borne out by Lewis and Short's Latin dictionary.

SOURCES Macchia, *Crafting a Rule of Life* (2012); Benedict, *RB 1980* (1982); Lewis and Short, *A Latin Dictionary* (1879). **SEE ALSO** New monasticism; Missional community; Sodality. **READING LIST** Rule of Life.

Third place

A place beyond home and work, the first and second places, where people gather informally, voluntarily and regularly: the café, the pub, the hairdresser's, the community centre. Ray Oldenburg gave the term its currency in *The Great Good Place* (1989). American writers on fresh expressions have borrowed it for the settings in which a [fresh expression](#) can begin, and third place ministry, a phrase in use since at least 2013, names a church taking on the ways of such places, building relationships and welcoming strangers.

SOURCES Oldenburg, *The Great Good Place* (1989); Carter and Warren, *Fresh Expressions* (2017). **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church.

Ecclesiology

The words a student meets when the literature of church planting asks theological questions: what a church is, how one begins and what counts as one. They come from the creeds, the Reformation confessions and Anglican and Roman Catholic teaching on the church, from English Separatism and seventeenth-century Protestant missiology, and from recent research on what the Church of England is starting. The churches and instruments these words are applied to have sections of their own, as do the two sections on mission.

Apostolicity

The creedal mark of the church's continuity with the apostles, one of the four in the Nicene Creed. Three accounts are given of it. One is continuity of teaching, so that a church is apostolic as it holds to the authority of the apostolic scriptures. Another is continuity of ministry, held by Roman Catholics and Orthodox; for Anglicans the historic episcopate is the fourth point of the Lambeth Quadrilateral, though they have been reluctant to unchurch bodies without it. The third is that a church is apostolic in being sent: *Lumen Gentium* roots its mission in the apostles' sending. It is an attribute of the whole church, where the planting literature's [apostolic](#) names a ministry or an office.

SOURCES 'Lambeth Quadrilateral' (1888); Bosch, *Transforming Mission* (1991); Second Vatican Council, *Lumen Gentium* (1964). **SEE ALSO** Apostolic; Ecclesial minimum. **READING LIST** Ecclesiology.

Ecclesial

What belongs to the church itself: its life as communion and body of Christ, and also, as Will Foulger uses it, its system and structures. In Roman Catholic ecumenical teaching an ecclesial community is a body separated at the Reformation, with real Christian life, that is not given the name of church for want of apostolic succession and a valid Eucharist. In [church planting](#) it is the last of the four marks of a [fresh expression](#), [missional](#), contextual, formational and ecclesial, since one 'intends to become church', and the threshold it asks after is the [ecclesial minimum](#).

SOURCES Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Dominus Iesus* (2000); Second Vatican Council, *Unitatis Redintegratio* (1964); Lings, *The Day of Small Things* (2016); Foulger, *New Things* (2024). **SEE ALSO** Ecclesial minimum; Fresh expression of church. **READING LIST** Ecclesiology.

Ecclesial minimum

What must be present before a gathering counts as a church: Will Foulger's phrase, in *New Things* (2024), for the bare minimum that must be in place for something to be really a church. The classical Anglican answer is Article XIX, which finds the visible church in a congregation where 'the pure Word of God is preached, and the Sacraments be duly ministered'. Church Army's indicators ask instead whether a new community intends to be church and aspires to the four creedal relationships, up, in, out and of. George Lings sets them against the 2012 Anglican-Methodist criteria, a yet more demanding set.

SOURCES Church of England. Article XIX, Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion, 1563; Lings, *The Day of Small Things* (2016); Foulger, *New Things* (2024). **SEE ALSO** Ecclesial; Online church; Fresh expression of church; Parachurch. **READING LIST** Ecclesial Minimum.

Gathered church

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Homogeneous Unit Principle (HUP)

DEFINED UNDER Growth and Multiplication.

Lay presidency

The practice of presiding at the Lord's Supper, and so consecrating the bread and wine, by a lay person. The Church of England does not permit it: Canon B 12 allows only a priest to consecrate. The Diocese of Sydney's synod held in 2010 that lay and diaconal administration may be allowable, but lay presidency has never been authorised there. It differs from communion by extension, authorised by the House of Bishops in 2000, in which a lay person or deacon leads a service distributing bread and wine a priest consecrated at another service. Joshua Cockayne's survey of new churches (2025) found two of 63 celebrating with someone not ordained, and calls the question live in the Church of England.

SOURCES Cockayne, *The Communion Dilemma* (2025); Church of England. Canon B 12, 'Of the Ministry of the Holy Communion'. <https://www.churchofengland.org/about/governance/legal-resources/canons-church-england/section-b>; House of Bishops, *Public Worship with Communion by Extension* (2001). **SEE ALSO** Ecclesial minimum; Lay-led church. **READING LISTS** Worship, Liturgy and Sacraments; Ecclesial Minimum.

Marks of the church

The features by which the true church is recognised. The creedal marks are the four of the Nicene Creed: one, holy, catholic and **apostolic**. The Reformation confessions gave a working test instead: in the Augsburg Confession, the gospel purely taught and the sacraments rightly administered, and in the Church of England's Article XIX much the same. The **ecclesial minimum** is the question of what must be present; the marks are among the answers. The four values of a fresh expression, among them **Ecclesial**, are a different list, of what makes a fresh expression of church. Darrell Guder proposes reading the Nicene marks from apostolicity, so that the church is defined by being sent.

SOURCES Guder, *Called to Witness* (2015); Fresh Expressions, 'FX Values'. **SEE ALSO** Apostolicity; Ecclesial minimum; Fresh expression of church. **READING LISTS** Ecclesiology; Ecclesial Minimum; Fresh Expressions of Church.

Modality

DEFINED UNDER Missiology.

Plantatio ecclesiae

The planting of the church: the second goal in the threefold goal of mission that Gisbertus Voetius set out at Utrecht in the seventeenth century, between the conversion of the nations and the glory of God's grace. Voetius's missiology remained relatively unknown until a Dutch synod recovered it in 1896, and it reached English readers through Jan Jongeneel's work and David Bosch's *Transforming Mission* (1991). Bosch calls *plantatio ecclesiae* the medieval missionary policy, and holds that the Second Vatican Council's decree *Ad Gentes* still made it the overriding aim of mission.

SOURCES Bosch, *Transforming Mission* (1991); Second Vatican Council, *Ad Gentes* (1965). **SEE ALSO** Church planting; Inculturation. **READING LIST** Roman Catholic.

Sodality

DEFINED UNDER Missiology.

Three-self principle

DEFINED UNDER Missiology.

The Church of England's Vocabulary

The words the Church of England uses for its law, structures, policy and planning, and for planting, renewing and counting congregations. Many are ordinary words with a technical sense. A few are old, from the parish system and the building of churches in the nineteenth century; most date from the 1990s onwards, from Measures of the General Synod, national reports and diocesan practice. Several are defined diocese by diocese. The Church of England's licensed roles, its joint work with the Methodist Church in fresh expressions of church, and revitalisation and replanting each have a section of their own.

Bishop's Mission Order (BMO)

The bishop's instrument for authorising a mission initiative, created by the Dioceses, Pastoral and Mission Measure 2007 and now standing in Part 7 of the Mission and Pastoral Measure 2011. A bishop may make one where the initiative is likely to further the mission of the church by fostering a form of Christian community. The order names the objectives, the area, the leaders answerable to the bishop and a visitor who oversees it, and it may authorise ministry in a place without the consent of the incumbent whose cure of souls it is, though the incumbent must be consulted. It is a legal instrument rather than a kind of church, and not every new congregation has one.

SOURCES *Dioceses, Pastoral and Mission Measure 2007* (2007); *Mission and Pastoral Measure 2011* (2011). **SEE ALSO** Parish; Fresh expression of church; Pastoral reorganisation. **READING LIST** Church of England Papers and Reports.

Church extension

The Victorian name for what is now called **church planting**: building new churches, endowing them, and carving new **parishes** out of old ones to keep pace with industrial and suburban growth. It was official language by 1840, when the Commons debated a motion under that title; its engine was the Church Building Act of 1818, the Million Act, whose commission built more than 600 churches before being absorbed in 1857. Chapel of ease, one of its words, is still in current church law. Winfield Bevins, drawing on K. D. M. Snell, gives nearly 7,500 new parishes formed between 1835 and 1896.

SOURCES Bevins, 'Victorian Church Planting' (2020); 'Church Extension' (1840); Bevins, 'Nothing New under the Sun' (2019). **SEE ALSO** Church planting; Parish; Pastoral reorganisation. **READING LIST** Victorian and Edwardian Church Extension.

Estates church

A church, and the Church of England's ministry, on a social housing estate: in Britain, an area of public housing built by a local council, often called a council estate. The National Estate Churches Network was founded in the 1990s on the complaint that the attention given to the inner city after *Faith in the City* (1985) left the outer estates forgotten, and General Synod committed in February 2019 to a loving, serving, worshipping Christian community on every significant social housing estate in England. An estate parish is mapped as one with 500 or more social housing homes.

SOURCES National Estate Churches Network, 'History'; Church of England, 'Estates Evangelism'. **SEE ALSO** Parish; Vision and Strategy for the 2020s; Resource church. **READING LIST** Estates and Poorer Communities.

Five Marks of Mission

The Anglican Communion's summary of mission in five parts: to proclaim the good news of the kingdom; to teach, baptise and nurture new believers; to respond to human need by loving service; to seek to transform unjust structures of society, challenge violence of every kind and pursue peace and reconciliation; and to strive to safeguard the integrity of creation and sustain and renew the life of the earth. The Anglican Consultative Council developed them between 1984 and 1990, the fifth, on creation, coming last, and revised the fourth in 2012. They describe what the church does in mission, where the **marks of the church** say what makes it a church.

SOURCE Episcopal Church in Connecticut, 'Five Marks of Mission'. **SEE ALSO** Vision and Strategy for the 2020s; *Missio Dei*; Marks of the church. **READING LISTS** Missiology; Anglican.

Focal minister

DEFINED UNDER The Planter and the Team.

Graft

DEFINED UNDER Revitalisation and Replanting.

Lay-led church

A new church or worshipping community led by lay people rather than by a stipendiary priest. The phrase became contested in the Church of England in July 2021, when John McGinley said that lay-led churches 'release the Church from key limiting factors': a building, a stipend and college training for every leader. Save the Parish was founded in the same weeks to defend the parochial system, and McGinley later said that such churches rely on ordained leaders with theological and pastoral understanding. The Church's director of evangelism and discipleship said that a target of 10,000 lay-led churches was separate from its own **Vision and Strategy**.

SOURCES 'Do the Church of England's Bishops Want 10,000 New Churches or Not?' (2021); 'Plan for 10,000 New Churches Roils C of E' (2021). **SEE ALSO** Microchurch; New worshipping community; Vision and Strategy for the 2020s. **READING LISTS** Anglican; Formation and Training.

Minster model

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Mission Action Planning (MAP)

The discipline by which a **parish** or a diocese writes down what it intends to do in mission and how it will know whether it has done it. Mike Chew and Mark Ireland's handbook sets out the method, and plans are now common across dioceses. Alison Milbank objects that the SMART goals such plans set were devised to grow businesses rather than churches, and that what makes it managerialism is the calculability, with the laity carrying the strategy and answerable for it.

SOURCES Chew and Ireland, *How to Do Mission Action Planning* (2016); Milbank, 'Management and Mission' (2023). **SEE ALSO** Vision and Strategy for the 2020s; Theory of change.

Mission community

A diocesan grouping of [parishes](#) that plan and staff their mission together. Exeter, Carlisle and Manchester use the name; other dioceses have made broadly similar groupings under names of their own, among them the [minster communities](#) of Leicester. It is a different thing from a [missional community](#): a group gathered around mission, whose size varies widely.

SOURCE Diocese of Manchester, 'Mission Communities'. **SEE ALSO** Parish; Minster model; Missional community.

Mixed ecology

A church in which the [parish](#) and newer forms of church, from [plants](#) and [fresh expressions](#) to chaplaincies and online communities, are held together as normal: one of the three priorities of the Church's [Vision and Strategy](#). The phrase has largely replaced [mixed economy](#) in the Church's own language; Michael Moynagh gives the reason some prefer it, that it has a more organic ring. Will Foulger found mixed ecology or economy language ubiquitous in the 11 dioceses he surveyed, none of which used church plant as its main descriptor.

SOURCES Church of England, 'Our Priorities'; Foulger, *New Things* (2024); Müller, 'Towards the Acceptance of Diversity' (2020). **SEE ALSO** Mixed economy; Vision and Strategy for the 2020s; Inherited church. **READING LIST** Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy.

Mixed economy

A church in which [fresh expressions](#) and inherited [parish](#) churches exist alongside one another and are equally church. Rowan Williams said in 2011 that he had coined the phrase twelve or thirteen years earlier in south Wales, and occasionally regretted it, because what he meant was a flow of communication and challenge between different styles of church life rather than independent and self-serving groups. Fresh Expressions' own account instead has the language emerging around [Mission-Shaped Church](#) (2004). In current Church of England use the phrase has largely been replaced by [mixed ecology](#).

SOURCES Cray et al., *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004); Williams, 'Making the Mixed Economy Work' (2011); Müller, 'Towards the Acceptance of Diversity' (2020). **SEE ALSO** Mixed ecology; Fresh expression of church; Inherited church. **READING LIST** Mixed Ecology and Mixed Economy. **ALSO IN** Fresh Expressions of Church.

New worshipping community (NWC)

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Ordained Pioneer Minister (OPM)

DEFINED UNDER The Planter and the Team.

Parish

The Church of England's basic unit: a district committed to one incumbent who holds the cure of souls in it, which is a duty of care towards everyone who lives there and not only towards those who attend. Parishes sit within benefices, deaneries, archdeaconries and dioceses, and the words do not line up, since one benefice may hold several parishes. [Church planting](#) is argued out on this ground: Andrew Davison and Alison Milbank hold that a gathered congregation gives up something theological the parish claims, and Graham Cray answers that most [fresh expressions](#) are planted by parish churches.

SOURCES Halsbury's Laws of England, 's Laws of England. *Ecclesiastical Law*, §235, 'Meaning of "Parish"'; Davison and Milbank, *For the Parish* (2010); Cray, 'We Are All for the Parish'. **SEE ALSO** Bishop's Mission Order; Modality; Gathered church. **READING LIST** Parish Church.

Pastoral reorganisation

The legal process by which [parishes](#) are united or their boundaries changed, benefices are held in plurality and church buildings are closed for regular public worship, under the Mission and Pastoral Measure 2011. A scheme is made by the Church Commissioners, an order by the bishop, and the diocesan mission and pastoral committee does the work. The same Measure holds the [Bishop's Mission Order](#), which authorises something new. Whether it manages decline is disputed: Ian Paul holds that cuts to stipendiary clergy posts are made to balance diocesan books, and William Nye says that closures of consecrated churches have fallen decade by decade.

SOURCES *Mission and Pastoral Measure 2011* (2011); Davies, 'Fall in Church of England Parishes Prompts Questions on Pastoral Reorganisation' (2023). **SEE ALSO** Parish; Bishop's Mission Order; Church extension; Focal minister.

Pioneer ministry

DEFINED UNDER The Planter and the Team.

Planting curacy

DEFINED UNDER The Planter and the Team.

Resource church

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Vision and Strategy for the 2020s

The Church of England's programme for the 2020s, worked out under the Archbishop of York and put to General Synod in 2021: a church for the whole nation, centred on Jesus Christ and shaped by the [five marks of mission](#), and 'simpler, humbler, bolder'. It names three priorities — missionary disciples, [mixed ecology](#) as the norm, and a church younger and more diverse — and six outcomes, among them doubling the number of children and young active disciples by 2030 and creating 10,000 new Christian communities. Dave Male said that this figure and the Myriad initiative's figure for [lay-led churches](#) are different things that overlap a little; Heather Cracknell of Fresh Expressions acknowledged that the two are not independent.

SOURCES Church of England, 'Vision and Strategy'; Davies, 'Clarification' (2021). **SEE ALSO** Mixed ecology; Mission Action Planning. **READING LIST** Church of England Papers and Reports.

Fresh Expressions of Church

The vocabulary the Church of England and the Methodist Church have built since 2004 for new churches formed among people outside the existing congregations and shaped by the setting they grow in; other denominations have since joined them. One theological objection to the whole family is Andrew Davison and Alison Milbank's: in *For the Parish* (2010) they call it 'a wholesale reconfiguration of the identity of the Church of England'. The Church of England's own legal instruments and planning words have their own section, and those who lead this work are among the roles.

Contextual church

A church whose form has followed from the people and the place it is among, rather than being brought in ready-made. Contextual is the second of the four marks George Lings reports for a [fresh expression](#): 'it seeks to fit the context'. The singular is not a fixed phrase, but Michael Moynagh's *Church for Every Context* (2012) takes the plural, new contextual churches, as its own term for fresh expressions, defined by the same four marks. The wider missiological word for the instinct is [contextualisation](#).

SOURCES Lings, *The Day of Small Things* (2016); Moynagh and Harrold, *Church for Every Context* (2012); Ganiel, 'Michael Moynagh's *Church for Every Context*'. **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church; Contextualisation. **READING LIST** Fresh Expressions of Church.

De-churched

Someone who once attended church and no longer does. *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004), drawing on Philip Richter and Leslie Francis's study of church leavers, put the de-churched at 40 per cent of the English population and divided them into the open de-churched, who might return if contacted and invited, and the closed de-churched, 'damaged or disillusioned' and not intending to return. Leaders of *fresh expressions* estimated in 2019 that 27 per cent of those attending were de-churched. Davis and Graham's *The Great Dechurching* (2023), writing of the United States, spell it dechurched and count adults who once attended monthly and now go less than once a year. It differs from *non-churched*: the de-churched have a church history to react to.

SOURCES Cray et al., *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004); General Synod of the Church of England, *GS 2142* (2019); Davis, Graham and Burge, *The Great Dechurching* (2023). **SEE ALSO** Non-churched; Fresh expression of church; Inherited church.

READING LISTS Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Evangelism.

Fresh expression of church

A new form of church, established 'primarily for the benefit of people who are not yet members of any church'. That definition is the denominational partners', published in 2006. The phrase comes from the 2004 report *Mission-Shaped Church*, which turned the Declaration of Assent's call to proclaim the faith afresh in each generation into a noun for new communities. Church Army's research shortens the phrase to fxC and builds its ten indicators on four marks that the Church of England's research and statistics department uses: *missional*, contextual, formational and *ecclesial*. Whether a particular one has become a church is contested, Church Army and the 2012 Anglican-Methodist report applying different tests.

SOURCES Cray et al., *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004); Lings, *The Day of Small Things* (2016); Fresh Expressions, 'Our Story'.

SEE ALSO Mission-shaped church; Inherited church; Contextual church; Pioneer ministry; New worshipping community.

READING LIST Fresh Expressions of Church.

Inherited church

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Messy Church

DEFINED UNDER Kinds of Church and Plant.

Mission-shaped church

The Church of England report of 2004, written by a working party under Graham Cray for its Mission and Public Affairs Council, and the founding document of the Fresh Expressions movement. Its title carries its argument, that the church is the fruit of God's mission and exists to serve it, and it holds that church has to be planted rather than cloned. John Hull replied that the report does not distinguish the kingdom from the church clearly or consistently, and that a reader finds in it a church-shaped mission. Dioceses run a course called Mission-Shaped Ministry.

SOURCES Cray et al., *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004); Hull, *Mission-shaped Church* (2006). **SEE ALSO** Fresh expression of church; Mixed economy. **READING LIST** Church of England Papers and Reports.

Mixed economy

DEFINED UNDER The Church of England's Vocabulary.

New Places for New People (NPNP)

The Methodist Church in Britain's programme for starting new Christian communities among people not reached by existing churches. Its London district gives the aim as people not yet attending any church coming to faith and growing together into a [new worshipping community](#), which may meet on a housing development, online or in a community garden rather than in a Methodist building. It is not a Church of England scheme, though it shares the Church of England's words new worshipping community and new Christian community.

SOURCES Methodist Church in Britain, *New Places for New People*; London District of the Methodist Church, 'New Places for New People'; Church of England, 'Vision and Strategy'. **SEE ALSO** New worshipping community; Fresh expression of church.

READING LIST Methodist and Wesleyan.

Non-churched

Someone with no history of church attendance, perhaps for several generations, beyond the funeral or wedding of a friend or relation. *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004) put the non-churched at 40 per cent of the English population and held the difference from the [de-churched](#) important: the de-churched have had some exposure to the church, the non-churched have none, and inviting people back to church is not, the report argues, a coherent mission approach for the majority. Leaders of [fresh expressions](#) estimated in 2019 that 33 per cent of their attenders were non-churched. Thom Rainer's *The Unchurched Next Door* (2003) uses unchurched more broadly, for Americans outside the church, sorted by openness to the gospel.

SOURCES Gray et al., *Mission-Shaped Church* (2004); General Synod of the Church of England, *GS 2142* (2019). **SEE ALSO** De-churched; Fresh expression of church; Inherited church. **READING LISTS** Fresh Expressions of Church; Studies and Reports on Church Planting; Evangelism.

Serving-first journey

The pattern by which a [fresh expression](#) is expected to grow, in Michael Moynagh's account in *Church for Every Context* (2012): the founders listen to God and to the people they are called to serve, serve them in love and build community, before discipleship is explored and church takes shape. Moynagh favours it for reaching people with little or no church background and traces the pattern in Jesus' ministry, setting it against the [worship-first journey](#). Fresh Expressions in the United States teaches it as six stages, the last being to do it again.

SOURCES Moynagh and Harrold, *Church for Every Context* (2012); Fresh Expressions US, 'The Fresh Expressions Journey'.

SEE ALSO Worship-first journey; Fresh expression of church; Contextual church. **READING LIST** Fresh Expressions of Church.

Worship-first journey

The pattern of starting a church by offering worship, in the hope that a viable church forms around it, as Michael Moynagh describes it in *Church for Every Context* (2012). He finds that it may suit a new community where some of those moving in are already Christians, and sets it against the [serving-first journey](#), which he favours for people with little or no church background. In *Being Church, Doing Life* (2014) he adds a relationships-first journey between the two.

SOURCES Moynagh and Harrold, *Church for Every Context* (2012); Moynagh, *Being Church, Doing Life* (2014). **SEE ALSO** Serving-first journey; Daughter church; Resource church. **READING LISTS** Fresh Expressions of Church; Church Planting Strategy.

Key Church Planting Authors

It is helpful for students to know where to begin their reading and to understand some of the key authors in the field and what they have contributed. Selecting such a list is inevitably challenging, since the significance of an author's work depends to some extent on what you are studying. This section is therefore intended as an initial guide rather than a definitive account.

Steve Addison

An Australian missiologist and movement practitioner. His work asks why some movements spread while others stall, and argues from biblical, historical and contemporary cases rather than from theory. His account of what begins a movement, and what brings one to an end, has been widely drawn on by other writers. His books include *Movements That Change the World*, *Pioneering Movements* and *The Rise and Fall of Movements*.

Sheila Akomiah-Conteh

A Ghanaian scholar of African Christianity and of the new churches, working in Scotland. Her Aberdeen doctorate of 2019 counted and described the churches started in Glasgow between 2000 and 2016, and showed how much of that new church life is invisible to national surveys. With Liam Jerrold Fraser and Fiona Tweedie she made the first study of Scotland's diaspora and ethnic minority congregations, for Brendan Research in Edinburgh, and she has written on African Christianity in Britain for *Anvil*.

Roland Allen (1868–1947)

An Anglican priest and missionary whose years with the Society for the Propagation of the Gospel in north China convinced him that Western mission had substituted organisation for the work of the Holy Spirit. He argued for churches planted quickly, led and funded locally, and then left to find their own way. His work attracted little attention in his lifetime, but *Missionary Methods: St Paul's or Ours?* and *The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church* have since been widely read by those working in church planting.

Paul Avis

An Anglican priest and ecclesiologist, General Secretary of the Church of England's Council for Christian Unity from 1998 to 2011 and founding editor of the journal *Ecclesiology*. He now holds honorary chairs at Edinburgh and Exeter. His subject is what the church is and what the conditions for its unity are, which places him at the point where church planting meets questions of order and recognition. His books include *The Church in the Theology of the Reformers*, *The Identity of Anglicanism*, *Reshaping Ecclesiology* and *Anglicanism and the Christian Church*.

The Venerable Bede (c. 673–735)

A monk of Wearmouth-Jarrow in Northumbria, and no church planting author in the modern sense, but the first to tell how the church was planted in England. His *Ecclesiastical History of the English People* traces the missions from Rome and from Iona and the churches and monasteries they founded, and remains the main source for that story. He read the conversion of the English as a continuation of the mission in Acts, and held discipleship and pastoral care to be part of mission. He urged Bishop Egbert to provide more clergy for remote places and to teach the creed and the Lord's Prayer in English.

Winfield Bevins

An Anglican priest, formerly Director of Church Planting at Asbury Theological Seminary. His writing brings church planting into contact with the more sacramental aspects of church life — liturgy, the sacraments and the Christian year — and he has also written on church planting movements. His books include *Marks of a Movement*, *Church-Planting Revolution*, *Plant* and *Liturgical Mission*.

David Bosch (1929–1992)

A South African missiologist of the Dutch Reformed tradition who taught for many years at the University of South Africa, and whose opposition to apartheid was worked out theologically as well as politically. *Transforming Mission*, completed shortly before his death in a car accident, remains a standard account of how the church's understanding of mission has shifted across its history.

Mike Breen

An English Anglican, senior leader at St Thomas Crookes in Sheffield during the years it became one of the largest churches in England, and founder, with his wife Sally, of 3DM and of The Order of Mission. His contribution is a set of reproducible shapes and disciplines — huddles, the LifeShapes, the missional community of roughly twenty to fifty people — designed so that leaders are multiplied rather than recruited. His books include *Building a Discipling Culture*, *Launching Missional Communities*, *Covenant and Kingdom* and *Multiplying Missional Leaders*.

Joshua Cockayne

An Anglican priest, trained as a philosopher of religion, who directs mission and evangelism at Cranmer Hall, Durham, and its Bede Centre for Church Planting Theology, having earlier led Holy Trinity Boar Lane in Leeds and lectured at St Andrews. With Will Foulger he edited *New Churches: A Theology*, a collection of theological essays on the Church of England's new churches, and his own writing asks what liturgy and the sacraments do in a new congregation, in *What Does Liturgy Have to Do with Doctrine?* and *The Communion Dilemma*.

Neil Cole

An American church planter and founder of Church Multiplication Associates, and a consistent advocate of the small, reproducing, largely unstructured church. His argument is that anything requiring professional leadership or a building will not multiply, and that church should be simple enough for an ordinary disciple to start one. His books include *Organic Church*, *Church 3.0* and *Primal Fire*.

Joel Comiskey

An American, formerly a missionary with the Christian and Missionary Alliance in Quito and later a church planter in southern California, and founder of the Joel Comiskey Group. His doctoral research at Fuller was on cell churches, and his writing is among the most sustained bodies of work in English treating the cell as a unit of church rather than as a small group inside one. His books include *Home Cell Group Explosion*, *Biblical Foundations for the Cell-Based Church*, *Planting Churches That Reproduce* and *2000 Years of Small Groups*.

Graham Cray

An Anglican bishop who chaired the working party behind *Mission-Shaped Church* and then led the Fresh Expressions team as Archbishops' Missioner. Before that he was Principal of Ridley Hall, Cambridge, and a formative voice on the church and youth culture. He did much to shape the language the Church of England uses for new forms of church.

Andrew Davison and Alison Milbank

Anglican theologians, and the authors of one of the more substantial critiques the fresh expressions movement has received. Davison is Regius Professor of Divinity at Oxford; Milbank is Professor of Theology and Literature at Nottingham. *For the Parish* argues that the new forms rest on a thin ecclesiology and on a market model of the church, and that the parish is a theological commitment rather than an inherited inconvenience.

Vincent Donovan (1926–2000)

An American Catholic priest of the Holy Ghost Fathers who, after years of unproductive mission-station work among the Maasai of Tanzania, sought his bishop's permission to leave the schools and hospitals and speak with people about God directly. *Christianity Rediscovered* is his account of what followed, and many planters refer to it as a helpful introduction to pioneering thinking.

Dave Ferguson

An American, lead pastor of Community Christian Church in Chicago and co-founder of NewThing, a network of reproducing churches, and of the Exponential conference. His subject is the reproduction of leaders rather than of congregations, on the argument that a church multiplies only as fast as it can release the people to lead the next one. His books include *Exponential*, written with his brother Jon, and *Hero Maker*, with Warren Bird.

Michael Frost

An Australian Baptist minister and founding director of the Tinsley Institute at Morling College, Sydney. With Alan Hirsch he wrote *The Shaping of Things to Come*, which set out the incarnational, missional and apostolic pattern that a good deal of later missional writing assumes. Writing alone, his subject is Christian life in a culture the church no longer shapes: *Exiles* takes exile as its governing image, *Incarnate* argues against a disembodied Christian presence, and *Surprise the World* reduces the practice to five habits.

David Garrison

An American, a missionary and strategist with the Southern Baptist International Mission Board, where he worked in South Asia and later directed global strategy. *Church Planting Movements* named and defined the category from case studies of rapid multiplication in Asia, Africa and Latin America, and set out the elements he found common to them — abundant prayer, local leadership, lay-led churches, rapid reproduction. Much subsequent writing on movements works from his definition. *A Wind in the House of Islam* is his later survey of movements to Christ within Muslim communities.

David Goodhew

An Anglican priest, historian and academic, previously at Cranmer Hall, Durham. His research sets evidence against a general narrative of decline, through local studies — quantitative where the data allows — showing where churches in Britain have grown, and why. He edited *Church Growth in Britain, Towards a Theology of Church Growth* and, with Anthony-Paul Cooper, *The Desecularisation of the City*.

David J. Hesselgrave (1924–2018)

An American missiologist, twelve years a missionary in Japan after the Second World War and then Professor of Mission at Trinity Evangelical Divinity School from 1965 until 1991, where he built the missions programme. He founded the Evangelical Missiological Society with Donald McGavran. His concern was the cross-cultural communication of the gospel and what it asks of the person crossing: *Planting Churches Cross-Culturally* works from a Pauline cycle of planting stages, and *Communicating Christ Cross-Culturally* is the fuller treatment. With Edward Rommen he edited *Contextualization: Meanings, Methods and Models*.

Alan Hirsch

South African by birth and Australian by adoption, and among the most widely quoted writers on missional church. His argument is that the church carries a latent capacity for movement — what he calls Apostolic Genius — which Christendom suppressed and which can be reactivated. He founded Forge, 100Movements and the Movement Leaders Collective. His books include *The Shaping of Things to Come* (with Michael Frost), *The Forgotten Ways*, *The Permanent Revolution* and *5Q*.

Bob Jackson

An Anglican priest and economist, formerly Archdeacon of Walsall, who has spent thirty years analysing the Church of England's attendance figures and advising dioceses on growth, at first as a member of Springboard, Archbishop Carey's evangelism initiative. *Hope for the Church*, *The Road to Growth* and *What Makes Churches Grow?* set out what the data show and the strategies that follow, church planting among them; *Leading One Church at a Time* argues for focal ministers in place of multi-parish incumbents; and with Bev Botting he has counted the northern province's new worshipping communities in *New in the North*.

Timothy Keller (1950–2023)

A Presbyterian pastor and theologian who founded Redeemer Presbyterian Church in Manhattan and, through Redeemer City to City, shaped a generation's approach to urban ministry and church planting. His distinctive contribution was to hold Reformed theology, apologetics and cultural engagement together in a form that ordinary congregations could use. His books include *Center Church*, *The Reason for God* and *The Prodigal God*.

George Lings

An Anglican priest who founded and for twenty years led the Church Army's Research Unit in Sheffield. His *Encounters on the Edge* series examined individual new communities one at a time, describing each as it was rather than as the movement hoped it might be. *Encountering the Day of Small Things* analysed fresh expressions of church across twenty-one dioceses, and remains the largest body of evidence on the subject.

W. Jay Moon

Professor of Evangelism and Church Planting at Asbury Theological Seminary, after thirteen years with SIM, largely among the Builsa people of northern Ghana, where his work joined church planting to water development. That experience runs through his writing. *Intercultural Discipleship* argues that formation happens through the genres a culture already has, proverb and story and song, rather than only the printed word; and with Fredrick J. Long he wrote *Entrepreneurial Church Planting*, on planters who start businesses that become the place the church gathers.

Ralph Moore

An American, founder of the Hope Chapel movement, which began in California and grew through Hawaii, and which planted by sending out its own members rather than recruiting professionals. Hope Chapel traces something over two thousand churches to that practice, which makes it one of the few American movements with a multiplication record documented across several generations. His books include *Starting a New Church*, *How to Multiply Your Church* and *Making Disciples*.

Michael Moynagh

An Anglican writer and researcher, formerly Director of Research for Fresh Expressions, whose work gave the movement much of its academic grounding. *Church for Every Context* remains one of the fullest treatments of new forms of church in English, bringing theology, sociology and practice together in a single volume, and *Church in Life* extends the argument towards a theology of how new communities come into being. Both are substantial and closely argued.

Stuart Murray

An Anabaptist theologian and practitioner who founded Urban Expression and taught church planting at Spurgeon's College at a time when the subject was rarely taught in Britain. *Church Planting: Laying Foundations* remains among the more substantial British treatments, and his later work on post-Christendom considers what kind of church is possible once the establishment settlement has gone. He is also the author of *The Naked Anabaptist*.

Lesslie Newbigin (1909–1998)

A missionary in India for nearly forty years and a bishop of the Church of South India, who returned to Birmingham in his seventies and found the West a harder mission field than the one he had left. His question — what it would take for the gospel to meet Western culture as a genuinely missionary encounter — set the agenda for missional theology in Britain. Most students start with *The Gospel in a Pluralist Society*, *Foolishness to the Greeks* and *The Household of God*.

Craig Ott and Gene Wilson

Ott teaches mission and intercultural studies at Trinity Evangelical Divinity School; Wilson has planted churches and trained planters through ReachGlobal. Together they wrote *Global Church Planting*, a standard textbook in the field: biblical foundations, strategy, the stages of a plant, and an unusually full treatment of developing indigenous leadership. It is written for missionaries and requires some translation for a Western setting, but its range is wide.

Stefan Paas

Professor of missiology at the Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam and the Theological University Kampen, and among the most substantial scholarly voices on church planting in Europe. He is a critical voice within the field, unpersuaded by imported American models and by the growth expectations attached to them, and argues instead for planting as faithful presence in a secular society. *Church Planting in the Secular West* and *New Churches in the Old World* are his principal works on the subject.

George Patterson (1933–2022)

An American, twenty-one years in northern Honduras, where he abandoned residential Bible institute training after poor results and developed what he called Theological Education and Evangelism by Extension — training pastors where they already lived and worked. He is known for obedience-oriented discipleship: teaching new believers Christ's commands in an order they can act on, and treating obedience rather than knowledge as the measure of progress. Around a hundred churches were started in northern Honduras over twenty years. With Richard Scoggins he wrote *Church Multiplication Guide*.

J. D. Payne

An American Baptist missiologist and prolific writer on planting, notable for his range: theology, history, strategy and method in accessible form, and as ready to treat house churches as denominational programmes. *Discovering Church Planting* serves as a first textbook; *Apostolic Church Planting* is the more distinctive, arguing that new churches should be formed from new believers rather than gathered from existing Christians.

Christian Selvaratnam

Dean of Church Planting at St Hild College and founder of the St Hild Centre for Church Planting. An Anglican priest and theological educator, he has worked extensively in church planting, mission and the development of mixed-ecology approaches to church. He previously served as National Director of Alpha UK, and is an Adjunct Professor at Asbury Theological Seminary.

Nathan and Kari Shank

Americans, missionaries in South Asia with the International Mission Board. *Four Fields of Kingdom Growth* is a training manual rather than a book: a single diagram of empty, seeded, growing and harvest fields, with the practices belonging to each, compiled from the experience of South Asian practitioners and revised in use. It has become one of the standard tools of the disciple-making movement, and much of what is taught under that heading derives from it.

Howard Snyder

An American Wesleyan theologian who taught for many years at Asbury Theological Seminary, and among the earliest to argue that the church's structures are provisional while its life is not. *The Problem of Wineskins* framed the question in terms still in use: which parts of church life are the wine, and which the wineskin. *The Community of the King* sets out the fuller ecclesiology behind it, and many students start with *The Radical Wesley*.

Ed Stetzer

An American Baptist missiologist, church planter and researcher, now Dean of Talbot School of Theology at Biola University, and previously at Wheaton College and LifeWay Research. His contribution is largely empirical, establishing through research what happens to new churches in North America, and at what rate. *Planting Missional Churches* is a standard American textbook.

Ric Thorpe

An Anglican bishop who, as Bishop of Islington from 2015 to 2025, held the Church of England's first national brief for church planting, and who founded the Gregory Centre for Church Multiplication. He served previously at Holy Trinity Brompton and as vicar of St Paul's Shadwell, and was a key voice in establishing resource churches as an instrument of English church planting. He became Archbishop of Melbourne in November 2025.

C. Peter Wagner (1930–2016)

A missionary in Bolivia from 1956, then Professor of Church Growth at Fuller Theological Seminary's School of World Mission until 2001, where Donald McGavran passed him the leadership of the church growth movement. He is the figure who carried McGavran's categories from the mission field into American congregational life: *Your Church Can Grow* turned them into seven marks for a pastor, and *Our Kind of People* defended the homogeneous unit principle on ethical grounds. From 1982 he taught the Signs and Wonders course with John Wimber and named the Third Wave; from the 1990s he led what he called the New Apostolic Reformation.

Gavin Wakefield

An Anglican priest, a parish minister in Sheffield and Chelmsford before ten years as deputy warden and mission tutor at Cranmer Hall in Durham, and then director of training for missional ministry in the Diocese of York. He writes about the Christianity of the North East and about what can and cannot be said of Celtic Christianity: *Holy Places, Holy People* is a pilgrim's guide to its sites, his *Anvil* articles test the Celtic myth, and with Nigel Rooms he edited *Northern Gospel, Northern Church*.

Robert Warren

An English Anglican priest, Team Rector of St Thomas Crookes in Sheffield, then the Church of England's National Officer for Evangelism from 1993 in succession to John Finney, and afterwards a member of Springboard, the Archbishops' initiative for evangelism. His writing joins mission to the ordinary health of a congregation rather than treating it as a separate activity: *Being Human, Being Church* argues for the missionary congregation as a form, and *The Healthy Churches' Handbook* sets out seven marks that have been used widely in English parish reviews.

David Wasdell

A British researcher whose work in the 1970s and 1980s on the dynamics of congregational size and the limits of the single-leader parish anticipated later thinking about growth and multiplication. Working through the Unit for Research into Changing Institutions, he argued that congregations plateau for structural rather than spiritual reasons.

Christopher J. H. Wright

An English Anglican priest and Old Testament scholar, formerly principal of All Nations Christian College and now Global Ambassador and Ministry Director of the Langham Partnership, founded by John Stott. His argument is that mission is not a theme within Scripture but the framework of it: *The Mission of God* reads the whole canon as the account of God's purpose for the nations, and *The Mission of God's People* draws out what that means for the church. He also wrote *Old Testament Ethics for the People of God*.

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